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ORGANIZATIONAL COMMUNICATION THEORY AND RESEARCH

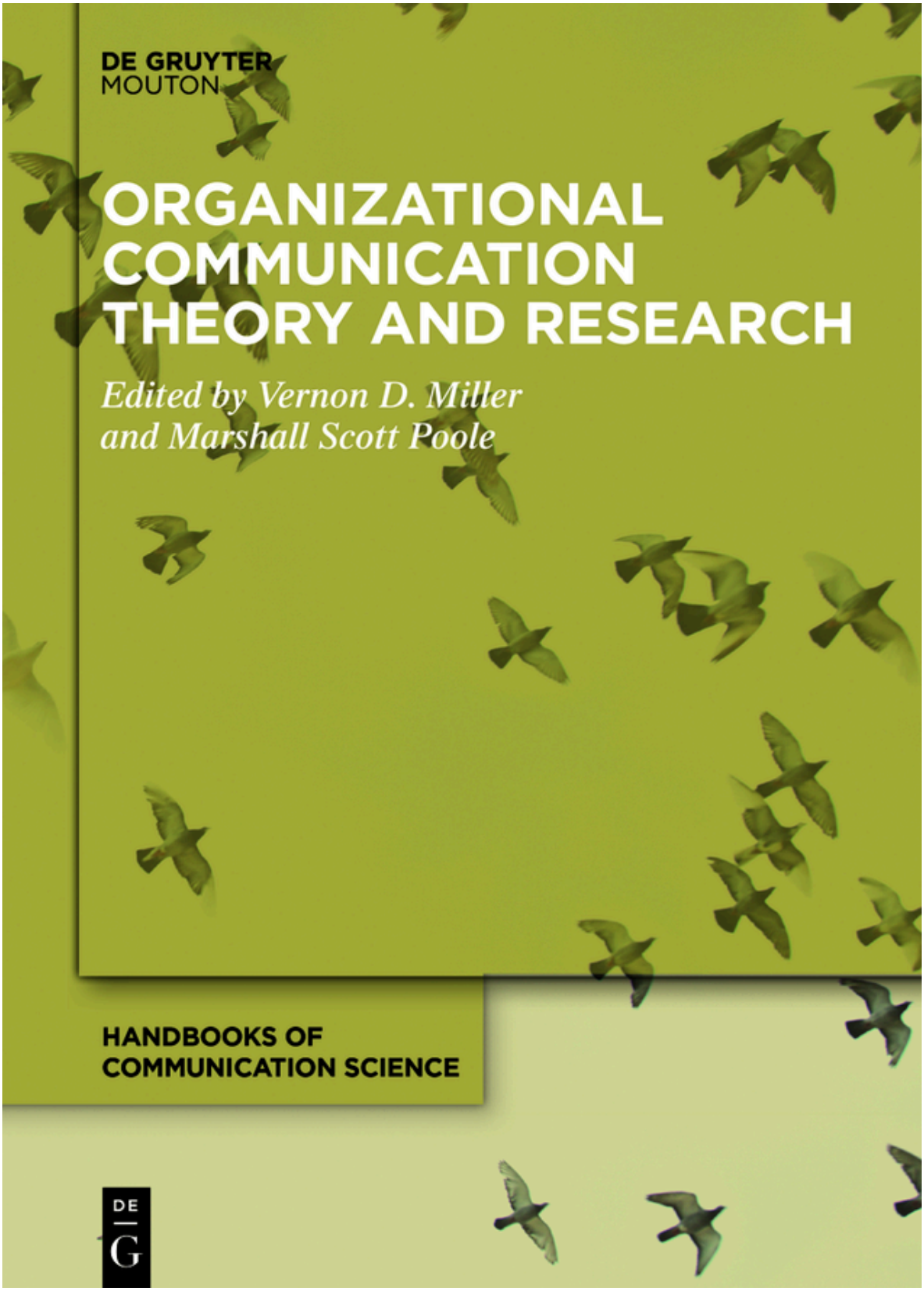
Edited by Vernon D. Miller and Marshall Scott Poole



HANDBOOKS OF COMMUNICATION SCIENCE



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Organizational Communication Theory and Research

Handbooks of Communication Science

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Organizational Communication Theory and Research

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Preface to *Handbooks of Communication Science* Series

This volume is part of the series *Handbooks of Communication Science*, published from 2012 onwards by de Gruyter Mouton. When our generation of scholars was in their undergraduate years, and one happened to be studying communication, a series like this one was hard to imagine. There was, in fact, such a dearth of basic and reference literature that trying to make one's way in communication studies as our generation did would be unimaginable to today's undergraduates in the field. In truth, there was simply nothing much to turn to when you needed to cast a first glance at the key objects in the field of communication. The situation in the United States was slightly different; nevertheless, it is only within the last generation that the basic literature has really proliferated there.

What one did when looking for an overview or just a quick reference was to turn to social science books in general, or to the handbooks or textbooks from the neighbouring disciplines such as psychology, sociology, political science, linguistics, and probably other fields. That situation has changed dramatically. There are more textbooks available on some subjects than even the most industrious undergraduate can read. The representative key multi-volume *International Encyclopedia of Communication* has now been available for some years.

Overviews of subfields of communication exist in abundance. There is no longer a dearth for the curious undergraduate, who might nevertheless overlook the abundance of printed material and Google whatever he or she wants to know, to find a suitable Wikipedia entry within seconds.

'Overview literature' in an academic discipline serves to draw a balance. There has been a demand and a necessity to draw that balance in the field of communication and it is an indicator of the maturing of the discipline. Our project of a multi-volume series of *Handbooks of Communication Science* is a part of this coming-of-age movement of the field. It is certainly one of the largest endeavours of its kind within communication sciences, with almost two dozen volumes already planned. But it is also unique in its combination of several things.

The series is a major publishing venture which aims to offer a portrait of the current state of the art in the study of communication. But it seeks to do more than just assemble our knowledge of communication structures and processes; it seeks to *integrate* this knowledge. It does so by offering comprehensive articles in all the volumes instead of small entries in the style of an encyclopedia. An extensive index in each *Handbook* in the series, serves the encyclopedic task of find relevant specific pieces of information. There are already several handbooks in sub-disciplines of communication sciences such as political communication, methodology, organizational communication – but none so far has tried to comprehensively cover the discipline as a whole.

For all that it is maturing, communication as a discipline is still young and one of its benefits is that it derives its theories and methods from a great variety of work in other, and often older, disciplines. One consequence of this is that there is a variety of approaches and traditions in the field. For the *Handbooks* in this series, this has created two necessities: commitment to a pluralism of approaches, and a commitment

to honour the scholarly traditions of current work and its intellectual roots in the knowledge in earlier times.

There is really no single object of communication sciences. However, if one were to posit one possible object it might be the human communicative act – often conceived as "someone communicates something to someone else." This is the departure point for much study of communication and, in consonance with such study, it is also the departure point for this series of *Handbooks*. As such, the series does not attempt to adopt the untenable position of understanding communication sciences as the study of everything that can be conceived as communicating. Rather, while acknowledging that the study of communication must be multifaceted or fragmented, it also recognizes two very general approaches to communication which can be distinguished as: a) the semiotic or linguistic approach associated particularly with the humanities and developed especially where the Romance languages have been dominant and b) a quantitative approach associated with the hard and the social sciences and developed, especially, within an Anglo-German tradition. Although the relationship between these two approaches and between theory and research has not always been straightforward, the series does not privilege one above the other. In being committed to a plurality of approaches it assumes that different camps have something to tell each other. In this way, the *Handbooks* aspire to be relevant for all approaches to communication. The specific designation "communication science" for the *Handbooks* should be taken to indicate this commitment to plurality; like "the study of communication", it merely designates the disciplined, methodologically informed, institutionalized study of (human) communication.

On an operational level, the series aims at meeting the needs of undergraduates, postgraduates, academics and researchers across the area of communication studies.

Integrating knowledge of communication structures and processes, it is dedicated to cultural and epistemological diversity, covering work originating from around the globe and applying very different scholarly approaches. To this end, the series is divided into 6 sections: “Theories and Models of Communication”, “Messages, Codes and Channels”, “Mode of Address, Communicative Situations and Contexts”, “Methodologies”, “Application areas” and “Futures”. As readers will see, the first four sections are fixed; yet it is in the nature of our field that the “Application areas” will expand. It is inevitable that the futures for the field promise to be intriguing with their proximity to the key concerns of human existence on this planet (and even beyond), with the continuing prospect in communication sciences that that future is increasingly susceptible of prediction.

Note: administration on this series has been funded by the Universita della Svizzera italiana – University of Lugano. Thanks go to the president of the university, Professor Piero Martinoli, as well as to the administration director, Albino Zgraggen.

Peter J. Schulz, Universita della Svizzera italiana, Lugano
Paul Cobley, Middlesex University, London

Preface

Vernon D. Miller

Marshall Scott Poole

The general purpose of a preface is to provide readers with an overview of a book's content and insight into the authors' approach, points of view, and biases. In this case, our orientation can be best offered to you in our answers to four questions: Why another handbook of organizational communication? What is the purpose and content in each section of the handbook? What instructions were given to chapter authors? Who deserves an extra word of gratitude in shaping the structure and content of the book?

Why Another Handbook of Organizational Communication?

In every decade, it is essential to offer a distillation of research advances in knowledge and methodologies to the well-informed as well as to those new to the field. There will always be a need for leading scholars to offer critical assessments and direct readers to both deficiencies and opportunities for scholarly advancement that will serve the field and the public.

For the unacquainted, "*Communication* is a complex, multifaceted process through which people and organizations exchange information; form and dispute understandings; organize and coordinate activities; influence one another; create communities; and generate, maintain, and undermine beliefs, values, perspectives, symbols, and ideologies, among other things" (→Poole 2011: 249). Recent major changes in societal structures, attitudes, and technology are reshaping how individuals organize, interact within organizational settings, and engage with and between organizations. Pressing environmental, civic, and disaster response issues would benefit from relevant linkages to established and emerging areas of organizational communication research.

Researchers in established areas will also benefit from the articulation of research opportunities within specialized fields (e.g., health professions) that are often outside the sphere of traditional organizational research. Finally, this handbook, like others before it, can offer introductions to organizational communication theory and its research. Distillations on established and emerging organizational communication areas can also enable scholars in other fields to harness insights from communication researchers and in turn make their own contributions to the commonweal.

At a minimum, handbooks extend a field's relevance by updating knowledge of key areas. At best, handbooks

challenge extant works and push scholars toward greater relevance and more powerful analyses. With the latter vision, we entitled this work, the *Handbook of Organizational Communication Theory and Research*.

What Is the Purpose and Content in Each Section of the Handbook?

This handbook has five sections: Theory and Methods; Processes; Contexts; Technology; and Emerging Areas. Materials in the "Theory and Methods" chapters provide an overview of the field's history, prominent theories, and methodologies. Chapters on *systems theory*, *communicative constitution of organizations theory*, *doing justice to/with organizational theories of difference and power*, *quantitative methods*, and *qualitative methods* build upon prior foundational works, but illuminate recent developments in their respective domains.

The section examining "Processes" depicts primal processual elements that beget meanings, attitudes, actions, and structures. Chapters herein feature *organizational communication design*, *leadership*, *organizational entry*, *conflict*, *diffusion*, *identity*, *coordination*, *organizational change*, *power and politics*, and *inclusion*.

The third section, "Contexts", explores how the embeddedness of organizational members shapes the goals of interaction and their meaning. Communication both emerges within and helps to constitute the context and in turn influences subsequent communicative actions and outcomes. These chapters examine communicative behaviors within *supervisor-employee*, *teams and workgroups*, *networks*, *organizational structure*, *globalization*, and *types of organizations*.

The fourth section, "Technology", considers the development and introduction of new media and intelligent technologies into organizations. The role of agency, materiality, and technology on organizing and organizational processes is of particular interest and features *AI and communication*, *social media*, and *distributed alliances*.

Finally, the section on “Emerging Areas” addresses communication issues associated with changing environmental, social, and political upheavals. Chapters focus on *wellness*, *organizing for social change and civic engagement*, *work-life issues*, *military exit and re-entry into family, society, and work*, *corporate social responsibility*, *and crisis response*. These are at the confluence of communication research, understanding structures, policies, macro and micro actions.

What Instructions Were Given to Chapter Authors?

Our instructions were rather standard. First, incorporate a range of theoretical perspectives and methodologies as they address pertinent issues within their domain. Second, make their materials accessible to those new to the organizational communication field, yet relevant to established scholars. Third, in addition to requesting concise, but thorough reviews of those materials, we encouraged authors to provide strongly written critiques and to extrapolate from related studies to direct future research.

From our point of view, our authors balanced these challenges exceptionally well. Each section and topic demanded a unique approach and organization. In general, research summaries are vital, but seem all too plentiful. However, experts' insights for where greater clarification is needed, areas to shore up, applications yet to be explored, and applications to be tested are rare and can offer vital links in advancing knowledge and helpful application. We hope these extrapolations of current theory and research will prompt others to envision new theory and research that will benefit others.

Who Deserves an Extra Word of Gratitude in Shaping the Structure and Content of the Book?

To begin, we noted popular topics presented at academic conferences and in journals publishing organizational communication research. As we formulated ideas, we chatted with colleagues at conferences and through phone calls. We next emailed a set of established scholars as well as those

who were newly publishing their research. In these emails, we asked, “What do you consider to be one area of emerging research (that is *outside of your area of research*) in organizational communication?” and “What is an example of a journal article, book chapter, or book that exemplifies this area of emerging research?” These individuals were very generous with their time and ideas, and we acknowledge their contributions here: Karen Ashcraft, Yannick Atouba, Josh Barbour, Jos Bartels, Ryan S. Bisel, Sarah Blithe, Patrice Buzzanell, Isabel Botero, Maggie Boyraz, Caleb Carr, Rebecca Chory, Francois Cooren, Lars Thoger Christensen, Stephanie Dailey, Debbie Dougherty, Mary Beth Deline, Marya Doerfel, Elizabeth Eger, Jessica Ford, Johny Garner, Jenn Gibbs, Rebecca Gill, Zach Hart, Guowei Jian, Jeffrey W. Kassing, Heewon Kim, Matt Koschmann, Michael Kramer, Kathy Krone, Tim Kuhn, John Lammers, Elizabeth Larson, Jaesub Lee, Irina Lock, Ken Levine, Jamie MacDonald, Rebecca Meisenbach, Rahul Mitra, Karen Myers, Anne Nicotera, Amy O’Connor, Andrew Pilny, Linda Putnam, Craig Scott, Dave Seibold, Claartje ter Hoeven, Bart van den Hooff, Martine van Selm, Patty Sias, Maureen Taylor, Matt Weber, Catherine Kingsley Westerman, Anna Wolfe, and Heather M. Zoller.

Finally, the field of organizational communication is a burgeoning one, with four handbooks over the past 32 years (→Jablin et al. 1987; →Goldhaber & Barnett 1988; →Jablin & Putnam 2001; →Putnam & Mumby 2014), one encyclopedia (→Lewis & Scott 2017), and one collection of formative readings (→Putnam & Krone 2006) to its credit. Each of these works has shaped the thinking of a new generation of scholars. They are the giants upon whose shoulders we stand as we offer this handbook.

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Section I: Theory and Methods

Chapter 1 Systems Theory and Ecosystems of Organizational Communication

Matthew S. Weber

Abstract

Concepts from systems theory continue to be prevalent across organizational communication research, with ideas from early work on systems theory found in research including studies of organizational change, communicative construction of organizations, public relations, and external organizational communication. With an eye towards emergent scholarship on ecosystems of communication and multilevel studies of organizational change, this chapter examines central mechanisms of systems theory and details the theory's roots and use within organizational communication research. The chapter provides a primer on the core tenets of systems theory and traces the development of systems thinking through research on sensemaking, adaptive systems, and organizational ecology, among others. The closing pages outline the potential application of systems theory as a means of understanding, examining, and analyzing modern communication challenges including as developing research in areas of data science and communication, public relations, and multilevel perspectives of communication scholarship.

Keywords: systems theory, organizational change, M. Scott Poole, Peter Monge, sensemaking, structuration, complexity, network analysis, health communication, public relations,

Concepts from systems theory, and the broad notion of organizations as systems of interaction and meaning, are

frequently utilized in organizational communication scholarship. While concepts and constructs from systems theory remain prevalent across organizational communication research, extant organizational communication research focused on systems theory has waned since the 1980s. Despite shifting tides within the field, systems theory remains foundational theory in organizational communication scholarship. The tenets of systems remain at the core of communication research in the 21st century, with aspects of systems theory represented across many veins of organizational communication. For instance, research as varied as studies of organizational change, communicative construction of organizations (CCO), as well as studies of public relations and external organizational communication each have roots in systems theory.

While systems theory is central to the foundation of organizational communication, it is also a critical framework for modern organizational communication research. Systems theory is one of the few frameworks that provides a lens for examining the full ecosystem of communication within and between organizations. An ecosystem of communication refers to the multiple levels of communicative interaction that occur within an organization, from communication within teams, up to interaction between different organizations within the broader environment. The different mechanisms of systems theory introduce potential research questions that can be asked across these levels.

This chapter provides an overview of the roots of systems theory, as well as the use of systems theory in organizational communication research. This work outlines the applicability of systems theory for examining different types of interactions within the broad context of ecosystems of organizational communication. This chapter examines the key postulates of system theory and how they have been interpreted and applied in organizational communication research, and

subsequently addresses systems theory's ongoing influence on a variety of organizational studies. Additional consideration is given to issues associated with application of the theory and methods for analysis.

1 Origins of Systems Theory

It is hard to find a textbook in organizational communication that doesn't mention systems theory as foundational to the field, from one of the first textbooks in the field (→Redding and Sanborn 1964) to more recent incarnations (→Conrad and Poole 2012). More broadly, systems theory in the social sciences has its roots in three separate streams of scholarship that originated in the 1950s. Systems theory draws on research from general systems theory and the biological sciences (→von Bertalanffy 1968), cybernetics (Wiener [1954] 2002) and structural functionalism (→Parsons 1951).

Systems theory's origins are rooted in the biological sciences. The theory was developed in the 1950s from a need to craft a systematic framing through which empirical studies could be discussed and analyzed (→Boulding 1956; →von Bertalanffy 1951). In describing the utility of a systems theory approach, von Bertalanffy wrote, "Since the fundamental character of the living thing is its organization, the customary investigation of the single parts and processes cannot provide a complete explanation of the vital phenomena" (→von Bertalanffy and Woodger 1938: 7), alluding to the importance of the biological metaphor but also the importance of understanding the interaction of individual parts within the complex framing of the system as a whole. Similarly, →Boulding (1956) argues that systems theory should be thought of as a framework for understanding how individual parts within a system interact to build a collective system that functions beyond the capacity of any single component.

Concurrently, cybernetics emerged as a popular domain of research focused on communication and control in machine systems (→Almaney 1974). Cybernetic systems theory materialized from the domain of mechanical engineering and was utilized as a way of understanding interactions within physical systems (→Ashby 1954; Wiener [1954] 2002). Cybernetics introduced the concept of feedback and control mechanisms that are used to maintain system stability. Research on cybernetics frequently emphasized the tendency of a system to maintain equilibrium, responding and adapting to disruptions to return to a state of balance. Analogous to machine systems, cybernetics draws on mechanisms of feedback and control to explain the processes by which systems maintain equilibrium.

The third foundational perspective, Parson's (1951) structural functionalism, emphasizes the mechanisms by which organizations respond to changes in the surrounding environment, and focused on the four primary functions of actions performed by organizations. These functions are: adaptation, pattern maintenance, integration, and goal attainment. In aggregate, these functions are critical to maintaining the effectiveness of a system, as well as keeping that system in a state of equilibrium.

This brief history demonstrates the interdisciplinary foundations of systems theory. As a macro-level framework, systems theory provides a philosophy for examining and understanding organizational interactions across levels.

2 Core Tenets of Systems Theory

In practice, systems theory is a broad class of theories that has been applied across domains, from the hard sciences to the social sciences. The transdisciplinary nature of systems theory is part of what has made this framework so popular within communication scholarship. A turn in systems theory

scholarship towards a sociological lens brought about a focus on the role of communication in systems (→Bavelas and Segal 1982), as well as the study of information systems and communication (→Krippendorff 1977). From this perspective, →Krippendorff (1977) and →Buckley (1967) advocated for a more modern view of systems theory that integrated a communication-based approach. They further argued for the role of communication as central to understanding modern societal systems.

Systems theory does not advocate for a single logic of understanding or framing of organizations; rather, systems theory advocates for a variety perspective for understanding the underlying mechanisms that explain interactions within a system (→Monge et al. 1984). A review of systems theory draws on cybernetics (→Etzioni 1975), structural functionalism (→Farace, Monge, and Russell 1977), information theory (→Krippendorff 1986, →1977), and network analysis (→Farace and Mabee 1980), and makes clear that there are certain guiding principles that set a foundation for systems theory. These early works, as well as →Barnett's (1997) work on organizational systems, set forth common terminology that has largely become taken for granted as foundational in the use of a systems theory approach.

2.1 Fundamental Concepts

The following provides a brief overview of the fundamental concepts of systems theory, framed in the context of organizational communication. This is not intended as a comprehensive discussion of the core tenets, but rather an introduction to the application of systems theory in the context of organizational communication.

Systems theory focuses on the structure and patterns of relationships that emerge as components interact within the system. A system is a set of independent components that in

aggregate form an organized whole. The organized whole works together in relation to the broader environment and interacts with other systems.

Components constitute the basic unit that comes together to constitute the system. In the context of organizations, examples of components could be individuals, groups, or entire organizations interacting with one another. As with many of the fundamental concepts of systems theory, the exact specification depends on the system being analyzed. Population ecology (→Hannan and Freeman 1977), for instance, focuses on the formation of populations of organizations, as well as sub-niches of common related organizations. The core component, from an ecological perspective, is the organization.

Systems operate at multiple *levels*. There are three primary levels of observation within a system: the environment, the social organization of the system, and the individual participants interacting within the system. Levels are nested within one another, with lower levels nested within higher levels. Generally, systems are thought to have a suprasystem that governs high-level functioning of the system, while subsystems are lower-level structures that govern core functions within the system.

Regardless of the level, all systems function to accomplish explicit goals. For instance, a system that produces automobiles may have an *explicit goal* of producing as many automobiles as possible. More broadly, all systems function with a higher-level *goal*, which could be as basic as survival or growth. Modern media organizations, such as social media companies, often function with the higher-level goal of sustaining growth or sustaining a user base, which drives lower-level activities.

The system does not function unless the components work together. The components of a single system are thus *interdependent*, either in one direction or in mutual

relationships. In organizations, examples of interdependencies in a system include workflow relationships in an organizational team and communication networks within an organization. For instance, teams within organizations may be interdependent on one another's work to accomplish the explicit goals of the organization.

Structure within systems is the configuration of the interdependent components within a system. Each system has its own structure, as seen in the way that various organizations develop their own communication structure or their own pattern of organizational relationships to manage workflow. The *interdependencies* that comprise the system can exist in different hierarchies such as the structure of leadership or the structure of work within the system. Within the system, there is a circular process of information flow. As a system functions, *feedback* occurs within a system when there is a closed loop as part of the chain of cause and effect – tradition amplifies or increases existing effects by reinforcing or adding to the behavior, whereas negative feedback counteracts a process and tends to move the system towards a state of equilibrium. Organizational systems are likely to have multiple types of feedback loops.

The *boundaries* of the system delineate what is a part of the system and what is not a part of the system. →Barnett (1997) references boundaries as critical to developing an analytical understanding of organizational communication systems. Barnett emphasizes the notion of spatial temporality: the need to understand the physical boundaries of a system as well as the temporal period captured by a given representation of a system. An organization as a component of analysis can be an explicit boundary for a system; the flow of knowledge within a group may be a more explicit type of boundary. For instance, looking with an organization, membership within project teams in a research laboratory could delineate a type of boundary. Boundary-spanning

behavior occurs when individuals in one team establish communication with individuals in another team, thereby sharing knowledge and information across boundaries (→Tushman and Scanlan 1981).

The environment within which a system operates is defined as everything outside the systems boundaries that is still relevant to the system. System environments can have multiple dimensions and are general conceptualized as the complex space outside of the boundaries of the system.

Inputs into a system are anything that moves from the environment into the system; on the other hand, *outputs* are anything that moves from the system into the broader environment. When a system is closed, the boundary is fixed and impermeable, whereas in open systems there is a flow of information across boundaries. Inputs and outputs develop as processes occur within the system. *Processes* are coordinated changes or activities within the system that are causally linked to one another (→Poole 2013). When a system reaches a state of balance it is said to be in a state of *equilibrium*, although this is not necessarily a single point in the evolution of a system.

2.2 Guiding Principles

There are certain guiding principles that govern the behavior of systems. These principles derive from general systems theory and serve to govern much of the modern thinking about systems of organizations. *Equifinality* is a principle that says system structures operate towards the same endpoint, meaning that while different components of a system function in different ways, they may still reach the same endpoint.

To be effective, systems have *requisite variety*. Control in a system can only occur if the structure for control matches the complexity of the behavior being controlled (→Ashby 1962). In the same vein, hierarchy is needed within a system to

maintain control and order. Further, *complex causality* puts forth that it is difficult to ascertain cause and effect relationships within a system. In part, cause and effect occurs in recurrent loops within a system; examining an organizational system at a given point in time may reveal a particular cause and effect relationship, but a subsequent time point may show the relationships to be reversed.

Emergence is the principle that a system will emerge because of the interactions of the components of the system. The collective system that emerges may, in fact, be greater than the individual components of the system. Self-organizing systems, for instance, embody the notion of emergence as order and pattern develop from seemingly random patterns of interaction.

The above captures some of the guiding principles that govern systems behavior, but there are far more complex interactions at the center of systems governance. Closed systems, for instance, will degrade over time as inputs from the surrounding environment are necessary to sustain the system (drawing from thermodynamics). Further, subsystems cannot be optimized without sacrificing the overall optimization of the system as a whole. Both principles have clear implications for the functioning of organizational systems and have been implemented in organizational theories such as population ecology's focus on scarce resources and declining survival rates when competition reaches too high a level (→Hannan and Freeman 1977).

Systems are complex and dynamic, and the flexibility of the systems theory framework can be advantageous as it affords organizational communication scholars a pathway to mapping and analyzing a wide range of organizational systems, from a variety of perspectives. This perspective gives way to an analysis of organizations that accounts for the variety of functions an organization may perform, as well as

an understanding of the variety of causal relationships that underlie a system's functioning.

One particularly useful framing to understanding existing systems research is through classification based on three dimensions (→Poole 2014): complexity of the system, degree of agency of component within a given system, and the degree of formality of representation within a given system. Complexity captures factors such as the number of components in a system. For instance, if one were to examine a complex organization such as Amazon Inc., the degree of complexity could be inferred based on the large number of subdivisions and subsidiaries within the organization. Degree of agency refers to the ability of an organization and its actors to respond and engage with other components of the system. This representation can be seen in the variation between organizations; complex organizations such as Amazon will often have a formal chain of command that restricts individual agency. Looser organizational structures, such as networked organizational forms, will often confer a greater sense of agency on individual actors. Degree of formality references the explicitness with which the organization and organizational phenomena can be defined and represented. Formal corporations such as Amazon will have a high degree of formality, but looser affiliation networks such as nonprofit advocacy networks may be harder to define in formal terms. Thus, this approach provides a succinct framing to capture much of the variation and complexity present across decades of systems theory scholarship.

3 The Modernization of Systems Theory in Organizational Communication

Systems theory's impact on organizational studies has been far reaching. Prior to integration into mainstream organizational communication research, systems theory was

used more broadly in business and management research to understand organizational systems. Early work in management research drew on systems foundations to understand the interactions of and within organizations (→March and Simon 1958). →Katz and Kahn (1966) built on the foundation of systems theory and characterized organizations as open systems. Their work presented a strong defense for a turn in organizational studies to framing research through a lens of systems theory. The abstractness of systems theory, however, has always proved challenging when implementing in an organizational context. In a study of large organizational systems, →Lawrence and Lorsch (1967) implemented Fiedler's contingency model as a more specific framing of systems theory, which focused on the subsystems of an organization and their interactions with the surrounding environment. The focus on a contingency model, which emphasized the relationships between subsystems of an organization, was a direct response to struggles with the abstractness of earlier conceptualizations of systems theory.

Despite abstractions, some of the foundational aspects of organizational studies have roots that lead directly back to systems theory; even the notion of organizational hierarchy has roots that connect back to early systems theory thinking about levels of a system (→Weiss 1977). The shift towards a systems perspective in organizational studies was driven, in part, by a recognition that complex organizational environments are prone to a rapid pace of change and new thinking was needed to capture the intricacies of those processes (→Ashmos and Huber 1987). Further, systems theory frames organizations as analogous or biological systems or organisms (→Morgan 1986), in much the same way that organizational ecology leans on the biological metaphor. The biological metaphor is a useful lens for framing the complexities of how organizational systems evolve over time and examining key mechanisms that drive that change

(as seen in studies such as Powell et al.'s [2005] examination of the evolution of an interorganizational network between life science firms).

Following in line with organizational studies, systems theory was utilized extensively by organizational communication scholars as the field emerged in the 1970s. Building the early wave of sociological and management work on systems theory, organizational communication scholars were quick to adopt systems theory as a means of capturing the complexity of organizational systems. Moreover, Buckley's (1976) framing of the role of communication provided a perspective that integrated prior systems theory scholarship with a more modern understanding of communication as central to organizing and organizational processes. Seminal work in organizational communication draws heavily on systems theory thinking (→Farace, Monge, and Russell 1977; →Goldhaber 1974; →Monge 1973). →Monge (1973), in particular, argued for the general applicability of systems theory as a framing for understanding communication in social systems. Broadly, Monge (1973: 16) noted that systems theory had the potential to guide the development of future communication theory, but more specifically wrote that the application of systems theory had the potential to guide scholars to, "focus on a new set of variables and employ a new set of analytic techniques which will significantly increase the ability of communication scientists to understand, predict, control, and explain the phenomenon of communication".

Management and communication scholars utilize systems theory in largely the same theoretical sense, although management scholars tend to focus more explicitly on interactions within teams and organizations, whereas organizational communication scholars tend to focus more broadly on ecosystems of organizational communication. Instances of the broader framing of organizational communication include the effects of external organizational

communication with the broader communication environment, as well as an internal focus on the way in which internal communication about organizational policies might help to shape the organizational structure. These types of questions and topics are more squarely situated within organizational communication.

Within organizational communication research, constructs extrapolated from systems theory are frequently used to examine a particular object of study central to organizations. Foundational work from systems theorists uses what can best be described as an "abstract calculus" to "[generate] expectations within a formal calculus and the transfer of those expectations, under suitable conditions, to the empirical world" (→Meehan 1968: 48). In organizational settings, this abstract calculus translates to a math that accounts for individuals, teams, organizations, and interactions with the competitive environment that organizations function within. This rich history reveals how systems theory has emerged as part of the "DNA of organizational communication research" (→Poole 2014: 50), which remains present in much of the current work within the field.

Following early theorizing in organizational communication in the 1970s, the history of systems theory in organizational communication is one of ebbs and flows; while systems theory is notably present in the foundations of the field, →Poole (2014) notes that the 1980s and the interpretive critical turn of the discipline saw systems theory fall out of fashion. But the 1990s brought a resurgence in systems theory thinking as seen in chaos theory, complex adaptive systems theory, and beyond.

4 Systems Theory Applications within Organizational Communication

As a foundational approach to studying organizations, organizing, and communication, systems theory emphasizes the processes by which individuals and groups use communication to engage with the broader environment, and in turn, how the broader environment exerts influence on those individuals and groups. In the context of organizational communication, aspects of systems theory can be seen in foundational theorizing such as work on structural functionalism, structuration theory, complex adaptive systems, social systems theory, adaptive and self-organizing systems, among others (→Poole 2014). More definitively, examining research from the past three decades in organizational communication research, systems theory can be seen in key veins of research such as work on adaptive systems, organizations and sensemaking, organizational ecology, and health research, each of which are discussed below as examples. While the reach of systems theory extends beyond this subset of scholarship, these domains demonstrate the clear impact of systems theory in shaping organizational communication research.

4.1 Adaptive Systems

Adaptive systems theory draws directly from systems theory thinking and examines the processes by which order emerges from chaos through self-organization (→Dooley 1997). More specifically, complex adaptive systems focus on complexity in organizing processes within open systems, and the role actors have on adapting to changing conditions to insure survival and successful adaptation. Self-organizing systems theory is directly related to adaptive systems, and the study of the formation of structure and process in organizations

(Contractor and Seibold 1993). Self-organizing systems theory focuses on mutual causality between components of a system, and more broadly considers mechanisms of self-generation resulting from interaction with the environment. Examples of self-organizing systems theory research include studies on team organization to drive innovation (→Carlisle and McMillan 2006), and to understand the core variables that impact adaptation in complex healthcare systems (→Tan, Wen, and Awad 2005).

Complex adaptive systems draw on systems theory, as well as population ecology and information processing, to account for the interwoven complexity of interactions within an organizational system. Related streams that focus on the construction of organizations from a systematic perspective include Giddens's structuration theory (1984), and more recently, →Latour's (1987) actor-network theory, which looks at the embedded complexity of organizational systems. This broad group of theories examines the levels within a system that help to create order out of chaos and bring organization to otherwise random and chaotic systems of interaction.

4.2 Organizations and Sensemaking

A systems perspective emphasizes both the interaction between organizations and their broader environment, as well as the role of organizations' efforts to respond to interaction with the organizational environment. Sensemaking frames the system as being constructed through individual actors' retrospective interpretations of actions that took place in the context of organizing (→Weick 1979). From this perspective, the environment is constructed through the communicative actions of those functioning within the system. Weick's sensemaking (1995), and his general theorizing of organizing processes, emphasizes individual agency. Sensemaking, as an extension of earlier systems thinking, looks at the creation of

systems of meaning. When those systems of meaning are replicated and retained through repeated action within an organization, those enactments give new meaning to an organizational system.

Unlike complex adaptive systems theory, sensemaking focuses on the adaptation of existing systems. This sensemaking approach centers communication within the organization and focuses on communication within subsystems as the central process for creating the constructed reality that is the organization (and for creating shared meaning). The process of enactment, selection, and retention that occurs is driven by the agency of individual organizational actors as they converge on a shared understanding of the organization. For instance, this type of approach has been used to study how officials in the US Coast Guard worked to engage with and respond to public concerns about maritime policy in the Midwest. While not explicitly framed from a systems theory perspective, the work explicates how the organizational environment shaped and limited the Coast Guard's ability to enact what is perceived to be the "correct" policy due to substantial concern and pushback from the public (→Weber, Thomas, and Stephens 2015).

4.3 Organizational Ecology

Leaning into the biological metaphor of organizations first introduced by systems theory, →Hannan and Freeman (1977) developed the population ecology model of organizations which examines how systems of organizations replicate one another and adapt for long-term survival based on interactions with the surrounding environment. Population ecology has an organizational level focus but recognizes multiple layers of organizing. For instance, organizations are built up through competition for resources from the

environment, as well as strategic decisions to develop as generalists or specialists (→Sutherland 1996).

Echoing the biological metaphor, success in population ecology emphasizes survival of a group of organizations, often at the cost of weaker, less suitable, organizations. Indeed, much of organizational ecology builds on the evolutionary approach of →Darwin's (1859) *Origin of the Species*, which at its very heart integrates life into a "system of nature". Organizational and population ecology borrow on this metaphor to conceptualize a system of organizations.

Similarly, resource dependency (→Pfeffer and Salancik 1978) focuses on the managerial processes by which organizations adapt to the surrounding environment and compete for scarce resources. Resource dependency is more about individual organizations' decisions to make strategic choices to gain access to resources. The notion that the system adapts and selects optimal routines for survival is central to both approaches. An ecological approach to systems theory aligns with the notion of multiple levels of analysis emphasized from a systems perspective. For instance, ecological research frames organizations at the macro, meso, and micro level, explicating the broader levels referenced from systems theory.

4.4 Health and Systems

Sensemaking and organizational ecology give examples of systems theory thinking applied to study a broad range of adaptive organizational processes. Topically, systems theory thinking has had a significant impact on certain domains of research more than others. For instance, systems theory has been applied in the context of health to bridge the connection between communication theory and health communication in practice (→Ruben 2016). Healthcare today represents an inherently complex and interwoven system across levels, from

individual private practice to large multinational conglomerates, and embedded within that complex system is a myriad of individual actors.

The increasing complexity of the nature of healthcare work, from advanced patient information systems to complex technology embedded into routine medical equipment has created multiple overlapping systems of expertise that must be navigated by doctors and other employees (Lai and Lin 2017). The intricacies of modern healthcare systems mean that adaptation can be difficult to fully comprehend. In a study of nurses and healthcare coordination, →Miller (1998) examined self-organizing systems in the context of healthcare management to examine the tensions between broad systems thinking and individual agency within organizations. In summary, systems theorizing provides an important framework for unpacking the networks of interaction that exist within modern healthcare systems.

5 Methodological Approaches

A variety of methods have been utilized over the years to implement a systems theory approach in the study of organizations. Much of the extant research in organizational communication that leverages a systems approach relies on a qualitative methodology to unpack the nuances of interactions within a system. General statistical methods, modeling methods, and network analysis have been used as approaches in organizational studies, although network analysis has emerged as an advantageous methodology because of the ability to capture multilevel interactions, including connections between actors and levels (see Chapter 18 in this volume on networks for details on networks and systems).

5.1 Qualitative Approaches

While emphasis has been placed on the ability to quantify systems, a qualitative perspective provides much needed context for understanding the nature of interactions within organizations (→Cash, Hodgkin, and Warburton 2019). For instance, critical discourse analysis provides an approach for understanding the key actors driving action within a system and allows the researcher to draw on textual analysis (→Cash, Hodgkin, and Warburton 2013). Thus, this type of qualitative approach, leveraging case studies or using textual records, can be useful to interrogate the individual actions of actors within an organizational system. A case study approach provides a lens for examining aspects of a system and can be useful for understanding a single organization's role within broader interactions (→Schneider, Wickert, and Marti 2017).

Qualitative approaches to systems can also be used to understand higher-order meaning as constructed by actors within a system. For instance, →Weick's (1993) work on sensemaking, as seen in his seminal study of the Mann Gulch fire disaster, builds on textual records, and interviews unpack how a system failure occurred in the context of a literal firestorm. While qualitative methods can be advantageous, they tend to focus on subsystems of an organization. Thus, a methodological challenge for systems theory from a qualitative perspective is the systems theory focus on systems of communicative interaction as opposed to individual actions of communication. The qualitative lens tends to build the macro perspective from the more micro communicative interactions, but larger-scale observational studies of interview projects can overcome this hurdle.

5.2 General Statistical Methods

General statistical methods are useful for characterizing the broad nature of organizational systems, and for quantifying

the structure of various levels of an organization. For instance, early quantitative work argued for mathematical approaches to summarizing the energy of a social system and using principals such as models of acceleration to capture momentum within such systems (→Woelfel 1997). →Lawrence and Lorsch (1967) demonstrate the utility of descriptive statistics as a way of capturing the distinct levels of organizational systems, as well as the difference between various system structures. Examples of the use of traditional statistical methods include the use of t-tests to assess the difference in outcomes and performance of organizational groups after an intervention testing the ability to impact behavior in self-organized work groups (→Appelbaum 1997). General statistical methods have a rich tradition in organizational research, but more recent work on systems theory has tended away from this approach.

5.3 Modeling Systems Theory

Deterministic models are useful for examining the evolution of systems. Deterministic models, such as economic models and linear programming, are models that use existing inputs to determine future behavior with a high degree of certainty. In cybernetics, for instance, deterministic equations are used to model the mechanics of systems (→Dent and Umpleby 1998). Similarly, empirical economic models, such as econometric models and time series analysis, use extant data to understand how an economic system functions (→Ramos-Martin 2003). Indeed, deterministic models are well-established as a means of understanding physical systems (→Fidler 2010), but have been utilized less frequently in organizational settings.

Probabilistic and agent-based models, on the other hand, provide a means for examining the likelihood of given outcomes in an organizational system. Modeling of complex

adaptive systems uses programming to model the complexity of interactions in a systems context (→Holland 2012). Recent advances in computing have aided the viability of agent-based modeling for complex systems. For instance, recent work used agent-based models to map complex interactions in air transportation networks (→Bouarfa et al. 2013). In contrast to deterministic models, agent-based models allow researchers to account for the uncertainty of human-based organizational systems.

5.4 Network Analysis and Systems Theory

Early work on systems theory pointed to the promise of social network analysis as a means of untangling interactions within an organizational system to better understand interactions at any single level of a system, as well as to understand interactions across levels of a system (→Roberts and O'Reilly 1978). Network analysis is a foundational method for studying organizational systems (→Rice and Richards 1985). Advancing this perspective, →Monge and Contractor (2003) explicate the important of social network analysis as a methodology for understanding multiple levels of an organizational system.

Analyzing communication structures within an organization, network research methodology is well suited to detecting micro-structures within organizations such as coalitions and cliques but can also be used to identify structures that connect level or subsystems, such as bridges and brokers between different subgroups (Sozen, Basım, and Hazır 2019). For instance, processes of self-organization can be examined using social network analysis to detect the emergence of organization from random noise (→Morel and Ramanujam 1999). Recent advantages in network analysis, paired with agent-based modeling, have allowed researchers to use social network analysis to model complex behavior in organizational networks (→McKelvey 1999; →Pentland et al.

2020), and to test the hypothetical impact of key variables based on prior observations.

Traditionally, network analysis has been used in systems theory research to analyze interactions within systems and to detect patters of organizing. Advances in the last two decades allow for the use of modeling of network systems to apply probabilistic techniques to social network analysis of organizational systems.

6 Future Directions

Systems theory is directly interwoven into the roots of the organizational communication scholarship. Despite the importance of systems theory to the field, in recent years traditional scholarship placing systems theory at the core has waned, but the core tenets of systems theory remain present throughout the field. Looking forward, the legacy of systems theory continues to carry sway within the field of organizational communication research and has the potential to contribute to future scholarship.

The modern world of organizational communication is increasingly complex. The acceleration of information communication technology in an ever more global environment means that communication within and between organizations is increasingly complex and interdependent. Systems theory provides a useful map for disentangling the various effects of communication with organizational communication ecosystems.

Variations of systems theory are present within sub-areas of the field, such as critical approaches to organizational studies and the rapidly growing domain of public relations scholarship. Further, methodological advances in areas such as large-scale data analysis promise to open new avenues of research that may advance the quantification of systems.

6.1 A Critical Lens on Systems

Scholars have advocated for a critical lens to be applied to systems theory (→Yerby 1995; →Graham 1999). Historically, systems theory research has been used in organizational communication to examine subsystems of interaction empirically and deterministically. A critical perspective on communication systems interrogates the valued logics of thought, and the meaning of language within systems of interaction (→Graham 1999). This approach to systems theory initially focused on a political economic view of technology and language in organizational systems and brought a critical lens to examining how organizations function.

Arguably, a critical lens has already been applied to systems theorizing; →Nicotera (2019) argues that the CCO view of organizational communications draws on systems theory, particularly as a path for mapping the complexity of communicative interactions in organizational systems. More robustly, a critical lens applied to systems theory would call into question the how and why of the functioning of an organizational system. Indeed, as the field moves forward, questions of hierarchy, colonialization, and post-colonialization (→Dutta and Pal 2020) should be interrogated across levels of organizational systems. A systems theory perspective gives a framing that would enable scholars to better understand the complex levers that have given rise to the current system and may further shed light on what a postcolonial system may evolve towards.

6.2 Systems Theory and Public Relations

Following the sociological turn in systems theory, →Luhmann (2006) critiqued systems theory as only focusing on the origin of communicative acts. The content of transmission is deemphasized as the systems approach tends to focus on the creation and sustenance of the system. Recent scholarship has

advocated for the use of systems theory to frame and analyze the complexity of organizational governance (→Valentinov, Roth, and Pies 2020); systems theory provides a framework for analyzing the multifunctional and multidimensional dynamics of governance aspects such as external public relations efforts. A Luhmannian view of systems theory, for instance, provides a systems theory perspective that emphasizes a social system view and accounts for the complexity of engaging in an open environment (→Roth 2019).

Looking forward, and extending from organizational communication, there is an argument for the ongoing relevance of systems theory as a means of understanding the individual as an actor in broader systems of interaction (→Hiscock 2019). →Ruben and Gigliotti (2021) argue that systems theory provides an approach for understanding the role of leaders in modern organizational settings. They argue that a systems perspective is important for understanding the connection between leaders and followers, as the communicative relationship is "mutually-defining, mutually-reinforcing and mutually-causal", echoing a core set of tenets of systems theory. For instance, a public relations scholar might want to look at how an organizational leader's external communication of social media is perceived by stakeholders in the broader environment, and how that perception then impacts management of the organization. This type of interdependent, interactive system could easily be framed in the context of systems theory.

6.3 Data Science and Systems

→Poole (1997) argues that the time has come for a renewed focus on systems theory in organizational communication scholarship. As Poole passionately wrote (1997: 47), "many will wonder why on earth we should bother with such an old bag of dead bones". Rather, Poole argues that systems theory

provides a clear framework for navigating the complexity of modern organizational systems, defining the precise levels of organizational interaction, and a framework for positing about the outcomes of system interactions. The rapid emergence of large-scale digital trace data tracking interactions within and across levels provides an opportunity to examine the complex interactions that occur within organizational systems. Large-scale data provides one lens for understanding the complexity of interactions within organizational systems (→Brosziewski 2018). One lingering challenge for the field at large, and specifically for analytical approaches utilizing systems theory, is a need to account for temporal dynamics (→Hilbert et al. 2018). The digital representation of human communication is apt for mapping the connections that exist within a system of interaction. Large-scale data, such as data from online games, offer insight into the nuances of multiple levels of organizing and organizational systems, at single points but also across temporal ranges.

6.4 The Relevance of Systems Theory Today

As noted in the opening sections, systems theory occupies a role in the foundation of organizational communication scholarship. As the preceding has argued, the ramifications of systems theory research extend through diverse areas of the discipline. Indeed, modern organizational communication has turned more towards structuration theories and network approaches to organizations, and shied away from traditional systems theory scholarship (→Keyton 2017). In many ways, these approaches embody aspects of systems theory, and may benefit from a clearer recognition of the relationship to systems and ecosystems of organizational communication. In Monge and Contractor's (2003) work on multilevel approaches to network analysis, they recognize the direction connection between multilevel studies of communication networks and

the interdependent component of an organizational system. Even structuration theory evolved in the formulation of adaptive structuration theory (→DeSanctis and Poole 1994) to recognize the complexities of team interactions within and across levels as a result of interaction with information communication technology. Organizations today operate in an increasingly complex environment, bringing a systems perspective back to the forefront. That complexity is seen in the internal dynamics of an organization, as well as in the complex network of relationships to build to an organization's broader environmental interactions (→Schneider, Wickert, and Marti 2017).

This line of reasoning echoes the importance of the broader notion of ecosystems of organizational communication. For example, systems theory could shed light on the complex and interdependent communicative actions that many organizations undertook to navigate the COVID-19 pandemic. Similarly, systems theory helps to frame the approach of modern organizations towards algorithms and artificial intelligence by framing the multiple levels at which this type of technology impacts organizations. Systems theory provides an important lens for mapping and analyzing the future of organizational communication systems, and the history of this approach is likely to impact the field for decades to come.

7 Conclusion

This chapter has provided a substantive review of the core tenets of systems theory. More broadly, this entry provides the reader with a framework for understanding how systems theory is interwoven in the foundational roots of organizational communication research. As Monge (1973: 13) noted, an "advantage of the system perspective is that it permits an increase in the level of complexity of analysis". It is

this focus on complexity that makes systems theory relevant as we looked towards the next generation of organizational communication research. Modern organizations – both formal and informal – operate in an increasingly complex communication ecosystem. Moreover, organizations themselves are increasingly complex and take on myriad different organizational structures. Systems theory provides a framework for conceptualizing the different research questions to interrogate these ecosystems but is also a pathway for future theorizing in organizational communication.

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Chapter 2 Emerging Trends and Topics in Research on the Communicative Constitution of Organizations

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Abstract

Research on the communicative constitution of organizations (CCO) is becoming institutionalized as an area of inquiry with its own identity. In the past decade, several overview texts have been published on this area of research. Hence, it is worthwhile to take stock of the current state of CCO scholarship and present a new outlook for the future. To accomplish these aims, the present chapter provides a meta-review of the main overview texts that have been published so far. Subsequently, we discuss emerging trends and topics in CCO research, which in turn serves as the basis for a discussion on the future of CCO research.

Keywords: affect, agency, capitalism, communicative constitution of organizations (CCO), critical theory, dis/organization, ethnography, extralinguistic, institutionalization, material, Montreal School,

organizationality, practice, relationality, ventriloquial approach,

Research on the communicative constitution of organizations (CCO) is increasingly becoming institutionalized as “an area of inquiry with its own identity” (→Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017: 345). In the past 10 years, several overview texts have been published on this budding area of research. Thus, the time is right to take stock of the current state of CCO scholarship and present a new outlook for the future. To accomplish these aims, we provide a meta-review of the main overview texts that have been published so far. After this, we discuss emerging trends and topics in CCO research, which in turn serves as the basis for a discussion on the future of CCO research in the final section of this chapter.

1 Meta-Review of Overview Publications on CCO Research

In this section, we examine how CCO research has evolved over the years by presenting some key questions that scholars associated with this area of inquiry have been exploring. For this part, we conducted a meta-review of nine overview texts on CCO research, published in reputable edited volumes and academic journals (i.e., →Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017; →Brummans et al. 2014; →Cooren et al. 2011; →Putnam and Nicotera 2010; →Putnam, Nicotera, and McPhee 2009; →Schoeneborn et al. 2014; →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman 2019; →Schoeneborn and Vásquez 2017; →Koschmann and Campbell 2019).

Proposing that organizations should not be reduced to containers of communicative activities, our meta-review reveals, was a stepping stone for what has become a rich and innovative line of inquiry. Following the works of pioneers such as →Barnard (1938), →Tompkins (1967), and →Redding (1985), CCO scholars have been vying for recognition, often

working in close partnership with scholars in the field of management and organization studies (→Cooren et al. 2011).

It is well-known that for the better part of the last century, the dominant approach to organizations was functionalism (→Putnam 1983). As this modernist paradigm started to be questioned by representatives of the interpretive (→Weick 1979) and critical (→Deetz 1992) paradigms, communication was progressively viewed as more than a mere factor of organizational performance (→Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017). Communication, in other words, came to be understood as constituting organizations, one of the key premises of CCO scholarship (→Cooren et al. 2011). One of the leading preoccupations of CCO scholars has thus been to reflect on what the concept of *communication* means, because this question has important consequences for how organizations are conceived (→Schoeneborn et al. 2014). The "communicative constitution of organization is a question", as →Putnam and Nicotera (2010: 158) suggested, "a collection of perspectives about grounding the role of communication in the ontology of an organization".

Since its inception during the "linguistic turn" in a number of disciplines (see →Taylor's [1999] translation model), CCO research has come a long way. Although the attention to language as an important means of communication, metacommunication, and reflexivity has been constant, new turns have emerged in the social sciences that many CCO scholars have eagerly embraced and contributed to (→Kuhn and Putnam 2014). For instance, the "material turn", understood in →Barad's (2003) and →Orlikowski's (2007) terms, challenged the premise that communication is only about human agents talking with or writing to each other. Accordingly, CCO scholars like →Cooren (2006) introduced the idea that many other types of other-than-human agents matter in the plena *of agencies* that constitute organizations. By highlighting this diversity of actors – technologies

(→Bencherki 2016), artifacts (→Caronia 2018), or architectural elements (→Kuhn and Burk 2014) – CCO research underlines the vital role of an expanded view of communication in *organizational becoming* (→Chia 1995) to the fore.

Hence, CCO research postulates that any kind of actor can participate in the way an organization is communicated into being (→Brummans et al. 2014). For example, the design of a building communicates a particular space or atmosphere into being that can be felt by organizational employees and visitors (take, for example, the design of the Apple headquarters in Cupertino, CA). Similarly, an organization like the Université de Montréal manages to remain relatively stable throughout the years because of its textualized procedures, protocols, charts, and so on that continuously remind employees what to do, and how to do what they have to do (of course, in the face of impermanence, this stability is always relative and precarious, and sometimes requires radical re-textualization, such as during the COVID-19 pandemic).

Especially the "practice turn" brought about a shift in the conception of how organizations are (re)produced (or (re)textualized) in the course of everyday communication. Consequently, the term "interaction" seems to have increasingly been subsumed by the term "communication practice". →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman (2019) define the latter as "*processes of meaning production and negotiation*" (p. 476, emphasis in original) that are susceptible to being appropriated, reproduced, or radically altered. A practice-based view of organizational action creates room for the inclusion of the structural (→Schatzki 2006) aspects of such action (power, culture, identity, etc.), without reducing the action-structure relationship to one of determination, since "practices are situated, materially mediated, pragmatic activities, not merely aggregations of individual actions" (→Kuhn and Putnam 2014: 415) (see also next section). In this respect, the focus on communication practices addresses

some important criticism according to which CCO research – especially the Montreal School approach – presents a "flat" picture of organizational life, bare of most (localized) struggles, apparatuses, and traditions (similar to →Latour's [2005] actor-network theory; see →Reed 2010; see also →Putnam and Nicotera 2010). This focus is increasingly leading CCO scholars to take *communication events and episodes* as their units of analysis (see →Cooren et al. 2011). →Vásquez, Schoeneborn, and Sergi (2016) define such an event as "a sequence of instances of communication (i.e., texts and conversations) that are performed in a distinct space-time" (p. 634). As →Schoeneborn and Vásquez (2017) explain, the focus on communication events allows for "grounding the analysis in situated local practices, yet also for considering the larger space-time framework in which the communication events are inscribed" (p. 4). And as →Blashke, Schoeneborn, and Seidl (2012) explain, "Sequences of communication events unfold into communication episodes, which in turn recursively interlock to form a self-sustaining network of communication that constitutes an organization" (p. 880).

These turns, as well as the more recent "affective turn" (see →Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren 2017), have led to the expansion of the kinds of phenomena that CCO scholars consider to be "organizational". To address this expansion, →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman (2019) proposed a new typology of CCO research, based on what is viewed as the other pole of the relation between communication as a constitutive process and (1) *organization* (the noun pole), (2) *organizing* (the verb pole), or (3) *organizationality* (the adjective pole) – the latter is defined by (1) the interconnection of instances of decision making taking place on behalf of the collective; (2) the collective's ability to act as an actor, which depends on the attribution of actorhood by other actors; and (3) the collective's ongoing demarcation and negotiation of its

(organizational) identity (→Dobusch and Schoeneborn 2015). What's important in →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman's (2019) typology is that it puts emphasis on the heuristically productive tensions between communication as a process, and the general idea of organization in all its substantial, processual, and modal incarnations or expressions. This shows that CCO researchers are typically more interested in the *how* than the *what* of organizations: How do an entity and a process coproduce each other? How do these mutual coproduction processes interweave, while keeping their specificities? How does one process modulate the other?

Although CCO scholarship's theoretical and methodological dispersion has been a recurrent object of criticism, →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman (2019) argue that this diversity is what allows this area of inquiry to offer such a "rich, complex set of interrelated theoretical inquiries" (p. 490). In the same vein, →Boivin, Brummans, and Barker (2017) write that current efforts to unify this area of research should "not suppress the diversity of methods that CCO scholars are mobilizing, which may be one of CCO scholarship's strengths; it should rather focus on clarifying the application of methods and on the synergies that may result from combining them" (p. 341). As we will show in the next section, the prospects are promising in this regard: CCO research, it seems, is moving away from being defined by one specific subject area toward being unified around a core premise that organizationality is an intrinsic aspect of social life. As →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman (2019: 490, emphasis in original) write, "With this expanded understanding of what an organization can be, organizational scholarship can be reinterpreted as a field united by a common theoretical impetus, rather than solely by a joint interest in a subject area; that is, by the study of social phenomena *as* organization, rather than by the study *of* organizations as social phenomena". This expanded

understanding thus creates possibilities for CCO scholars to "reciprocate" the flux of ideas they import into their work from other disciplines of the social sciences and humanities.

2 Six Emerging Trends and Topics in CCO Research

Having examined the development of CCO research, we now provide a discussion on the following six intersecting trends and topics that are emerging in this area of inquiry, based on an overview of CCO research that has been published between 2015 and 2020 in academic journals as well as edited volumes and books (e.g., →Blaschke and Schoeneborn 2017; →Brummans 2018; →Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren 2017; →Vásquez and Kuhn 2019): (1) rehabilitating the transmissive dimension of communication; (2) ongoing engagement with philosophical ideas; (3) emerging critical approaches; (4) interest in different forms of organizing; (5) new methodologies and methods; and (6) translating CCO research into practice.

2.1 Rehabilitating the Transmissive Dimension of Communication

While CCO scholars typically adopt an anti-transmissive view of communication (→Schoeneborn and Trittin 2013), some have started to call this view into question (see →Ashcraft 2021; →Bencherki 2017; →Cooren 2020; →Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren 2017). →Ashcraft (2021), for instance, introduces the concept of *affect* to show the limits of the linguistic turn that played a key role in the emergence of CCO research. CCO scholars initially concentrated on studying the discursive nature of organizations (→Fairhurst and Putnam 2004) while rejecting the conduit metaphor of communication (→Axley 1984) and its accompanying transmissive view. Affect can be defined as "a power to affect and be affected [that] governs a

transition, where a body passes from one state of capacitation to a diminished or augmented state of capacitation. This comes with the corollary that the transition is *felt*" (→Massumi 2015: 48, emphasis in original). The concept suggests that communication as affect-transmission is constitutive because it produces (brings forth) fields of relation with certain degrees of organizationality (see →Brummans and Vézy 2022).

As →Ashcraft (2021) notes, acknowledging the transmissive nature of communication leads to its reconceptualization. While communication is still often reduced to what *people* convey to each other (→Sanders 2021), the concept of affect suggests that communication also happens at the *pre-individual* level (→Bencherki 2017; →Bencherki and Snack 2016) and should be viewed in *relational* terms, since affect and relation go hand in hand (→Massumi 2015: 50). In other words, communication can be "both prepersonal (i.e., precedes, or exceeds, the self) and transpersonal (traverses bodies, forming interdependent selves)" (→Ashcraft 2021: 574). These ideas echo the writings of →Peters (1999), who notes that the field of communication has historically been divided into two opposite paradigms: (1) *the dissemination paradigm*, which focuses on diffusion and propagation while frequently overlooking the interactive dimension of communication; and (2) *the dialogue paradigm*, which highlights the bidirectional nature of communication while often neglecting its material dimensions.

The recent turn to affect and relationality (see →Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren 2017) positions CCO research well to reconcile these views by showing that one cannot exist without the other. It broadens how communication is conceptualized and its role in the production of organizations. As →Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren (2017) suggest, studying the communicative constitution of organizations does not entail neglecting effects of transmission and propagation. To the contrary, increased interest in the extralinguistic aspects of

communication should encourage CCO researchers to investigate how organizational fields of relation and all their human and other-than-human constituents are composed in the course of communication (see →Cooren 2018; →Cooren et al. 2015; see also →Brummans and Vézy 2022).

2.2 Ongoing Engagement with Philosophical Ideas

From its inception, CCO research, especially as practiced by the Montreal School, has been inspired by the works of continental philosophers (e.g., Derrida, Foucault, Latour), language philosophers (e.g., Austin, Ryle, Wittgenstein), and American pragmatists (e.g., Dewey, James, Peirce) (see →Taylor and Van Every 2000). CCO scholars are continuing this trend by exploring the heuristic character of these and other philosophers' ideas.

For instance, →Mease (2021) proposes a new conceptual framework for CCO research based on Deleuzian ontology, which she calls "Techniques and Forces (T&F)". As Mease notes, →Deleuze (1988) maintains that structures are always immanent and enacted; that is, they only exist in the course of (inter)action, a viewpoint that corresponds well with the premises of CCO scholarship (see →Cooren 2000), as well as with →Latour's (2005) "flat ontology". As Deleuze points out, the potential that is not (yet) actualized (the *virtual*) should be regarded as real. Echoing →Vásquez and Kuhn's (2019) work on dis/organization and dis/ordering, Mease consequently encourages CCO researchers to acknowledge that the stability of an organization is always precarious – an inevitable state of (in)stability – and is always emerging through the actualization of potentialities/virtualities. These potentialities/virtualities could, on other occasions, be left unexpressed, and they could be replaced by other potentialities/virtualities that are, for the moment, not yet actualized, yet still real.

The techniques in →Mease's (2021) framework reflect how *forces* (intensities, flows, affects, relations, etc.) that actualize specific entities (what Deleuze calls "machines") come together to produce a more or less stable (organizational) world. Communication, Mease (2021: 238, emphasis in original) suggests, may therefore be conceived as *"the processes by which force, in both material and meaning dimensions, comes together through particular techniques of articulation and emerges into (un)stable shared realities."* From this Deleuzian perspective, organizations may thus be seen as "collections of force (flows, lines, relations) arranged in (un)predictable patterns" (p. 240). These forces can compete with, complement, cancel, or correct each other, depending on the techniques that harness and articulate them, creating effects of stability and instability. In Mease's framework *power* becomes, in turn, the capacity to articulate forces in a particular way to stabilize certain configurations or assemblages, to the detriment of others. Hence, power is *always* at stake in communication processes.

Deleuze and Derrida didn't see eye-to-eye on many subjects: Derrida is usually associated with a philosophy of negation, while Deleuze is often portrayed as an affirmative philosopher (→Bearn 2000). Still, their writings resonate with each other, especially in terms of their focus on *repetition* and *difference*. Drawing inspiration from →Derrida (1982), →Del Fa and Vásquez (2019) mobilize his notion of différ*a*nce to study how organizations do not only attempt to affirm their identity, but also differentiate themselves from others. As Del Fa and Vásquez show, in order to position itself, an organization must affirm what it stands for (principles, values, goals, etc.) and what it differs from. This differ*a*ntiation often forces an organization to "presentify" (i.e., make present, see →Cooren 2006) what it would like to absentify (i.e., make absent). For example, many anti-capitalist organizations are constantly forced to talk about capitalism in order to affirm their

opposition to neoliberal values. These values *haunt* these organizations, meaning that their "foils" are part and parcel of their ongoing communicative constitution. However, this différ*a*nce is also at play in the differ*a*ntiation these organizations experience *from themselves*: given that they often need to reaffirm for and against what they position themselves, their identities are *defined by* this positioning, which evolves as the organization is confronted by the actual situations with which they have to deal. Thus, by being "thrown into the world", to use a Heideggerian expression, organizations experience both eventfulness and iterability, and navigating this interplay between difference and repetition is what they're faced with every day.

2.3 Emerging Critical Approaches

While constitutive explanations of power and discourse in and beyond organizations are not new (see →Deetz and Mumby 1990), CCO scholars have only recently started adopting a more critical stance, for example by focusing on branding (→Vásquez et al. 2017), authority (→Bencherki, Matte, and Cooren 2019; →Benoit-Barné and Cooren 2009; →Porter, Kuhn, and Nerlich 2018), and alternative organizations (→Del Fa and Vásquez 2019; →Wilhoit and Kisselburgh 2019). These studies focus less on organizations *per se*, but rather on the communicative organiz*ing* of people, goods, values, identities, and societies. Along the lines of →Foucault's (1981) notion of discourse (a contingent social system that produces and legitimates [a certain kind of] knowledge and meaning), this shift echoes what →Carlone and Taylor (1998: 361) call the "cultural experience of organizing" and what →Mumby (2014: 103) calls the "communicative politics of organizing" (see also →Kärreman 2010). Both expressions bring to the fore a communicative explanation of how power is organized in society.

According to these recent CCO studies, late capitalism (or neoliberal capitalism) is what organizes practices and action, and it does so through communication. As →Vásquez, Kuhn, and Plotnikof (2022: 128) write, “In contrast to the conventional image that capitalism is an organized system with stable rules that efficiently govern individual and organizational action, writers in [this] tradition show how the communicative character of contemporary capitalism fosters disruption and precarity as a relatively new logic of capital accumulation”. “[D]oing capitalism is”, in other words, “[the work of] communication” (→Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren 2017: 28). As a set of socioeconomic communicative practices, neoliberal capitalism therefore constitutes organizations.

This idea is also captured by the broad term of *communicative capitalism* (→Dean 2005), which suggests that our collective system of value production has gradually become more about making meaning(s), than about making things. Value is no longer produced “inside” the organization, but in our daily practices and lives (→Mumby 2016, →2019). Hence, struggles over meaning, along with the management of meaning, are at the heart of communicative processes that constitute subjectivities and societies (→Mumby and Plotnikof 2019). Taking branding as a symptom of communicative capitalism, →Mumby (2016) argues that brands act as floating signifiers of meaningfulness in our lifeworld, generating insecurity and precarity in the individuals who are impelled to brand themselves and their lives to exist. Yet, because brands are rooted in indeterminacies and struggles over meaning, they’re always subject to contestation and resistance.

→Del Fa and Kärreman (2022) extend these ideas by insisting that communication *is* doing capitalism. In other words, they view neoliberalism as an organizing principle that also constitutes communication. This communicative approach to the constitution of capitalist relations opens up breaches to undo neoliberal capitalism. Thus, Del Fa and

Kärreman underline the importance of theorizing resistance as a way of unmaking neoliberal capitalism through alternative forms of organizing (see also next section).

2.4 Interest in Different Forms of Organizing

Paying attention to communicative processes of organizing extends the object of study of CCO scholarship beyond established forms of organization to explore different types of social phenomena, such as networks, markets, social movements, communities, and so on. For example, recent CCO studies have focused on the organizationality of different social collectives, religious forms of organizing, alternative organizations, and forms of dis/organizing.

Studying the communicative constitution of organizationality entails exploring to what degree different types of social collectives become more or less "organizational" over time (→Dobusch and Schoeneborn 2015; →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman 2019). For example, →Wilhoit and Kisselburgh's (2015) study on bicycle commuting shows that collective action can be seen as a form of organizing, even when commuters don't see themselves as members of a formal organization. More specifically, their research shows that bikers form a social collective with a certain degree of organizationality when reclaiming places and infrastructures primarily designed to serve the purposes of car drivers and pedestrians. In a similar way, →Haug's (2013) study shows that decisional communications are key to constituting meetings as organizations, to the extent that they produce a partial and fragile order that allows for the creation of a social collective, even if temporary.

Another example is →Brummans, Hwang, and Cheong's (2020) study on the role of mantras in religious organizing. The authors develop a tripartite framework based on the notion of textualization, substantiation, and invocation to

explore how mantras, defined as a terse retelling of a key organizational story, contribute to the materialization of a Buddhist NGO's ethos and worldview. Their study shows that the act of recitation in face-to-face communication is vital for sustaining a religious NGO, and that this effect is amplified through mass and mass self-communication (→Castells 2009). This research provides insights into how particular forms of communication (here, mantras) constitute and legitimate new forms of organization.

More closely related to the emerging critical research discussed in the previous section, some CCO (or "CCO-friendly") scholars have engaged with the idea of different forms of organizing through the study of alternative organizations (cooperatives, worker-owned organizations, self-management, etc.) and organizing. Critical management scholars paved the way for investigating alternative organizations by defining their key features (autonomy, solidarity, and responsibility; see →Parker et al. 2014) and highlighting their ambiguous relationship with, against, and beyond capitalism. The contribution of CCO scholarship to these debates has been to explore communicative practices that bring forth the "alternativeness" of these organizations (→Del Fa and Vásquez 2019), as well as hidden communicative practices in alternative organizing (→Cruz 2017) and decolonial approaches of organizing (→Cruz and Sodeke 2021).

Finally, another set of CCO studies on different forms of organizing attends to the disordered, disruptive, and chaotic properties of communication (→Vásquez and Kuhn 2019). Focusing on the mutual constitution of organization and disorganization, these studies emphasize the key role communication plays in processes of dis/organization through the simultaneous opening (disordering) and closing (ordering) of meaning (→Vásquez, Schoeneborn, and Sergi 2016). This line of work challenges more traditional definitions of

(organizational) communication by recognizing that the indeterminate character of communication is a prerequisite for and a driver of organizing. The capacity of communication to dis/organize is thus central to understanding the mode of existence of social collectives and larger societies (→Vásquez, Kuhn, and Plotnikof 2022).

2.5 New Methodologies and Methods

CCO researchers have traditionally favored naturalistic or (quasi-)ethnographic data collection methods such as participant and non-participant observations, semi-structured interviews, and the collection of documents (e.g., from archives), or a combination of these techniques (→Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017). Especially Montreal School CCO scholars have used organizational shadowing, a data collection method that implies "following organizational actors during their everyday activities and interactions by using video/audio recording and/or taking fieldnotes" (→Vásquez, Brummans, and Groleau 2012: 145).

With regard to the latter, some innovative applications of shadowing have emerged in CCO scholarship (see →Cooren and Malbois 2019). For example, →Vásquez (2019) adapted this technique in her study of projects – temporary, anticipatory, and hybrid modes of dis/organizing. Based on her fieldwork, Vásquez proposed four methodological premises for shadowing a project: (1) *follow the action*; (2) *apply an equal analytical strategy to beings and things*; (3) *account for the reflexivity of action*; and (3) *cultivate methodological humility*. Moreover, →Martine, Brummans, and Cooren (2020) explained how an idea can be followed (shadowed) by acknowledging its agency and tracing the work through which it persists in the context of a specific social collective. This involves attending to two interrelated processes: (1) *subsistence* (how an idea is produced by passing

through new elements, such as gestures, words, etc.); and (2) *reference* (how rectified knowledge about the idea is produced by passing through inscriptions that corroborate its existence and make it scientifically verifiable). For →Martine and colleagues, a pragmatic stance that decenters the analysis of interactions through which a social collective is constituted from human subjects to the relations produced *in* interaction is needed to study both processes, and to account for the constitution and persistence of an idea.

In terms of data analysis, →Boivin et al. (2017) note that most CCO scholars favor a combination of conversation, discourse, and/or interaction analysis, and to a lesser extent thematic or narrative analysis. By focusing on acts of communication, these types of analyses enable insight into the constitutive dynamics of organizational communication while remaining at the level of communication events (→Schoeneborn and Vásquez 2017; see also →Cooren 2015). Except for Blaschke's network analytic work (→Blaschke 2015; →Blaschke, Schoeneborn, and Seidl 2012), the use of quantitative analyses is pretty much absent from CCO scholarship.

CCO researchers have only recently started to systematize their analytical approaches (e.g., see →Bencherki 2014) and develop their own analytical "toolboxes". For example, →Nathues, van Vuuren, and Cooren (2021; see also →Nathues and van Vuuren 2022) created a four-step analytical method to systematize →Cooren's (2010) ventriloquial approach to studying communication: (1) *identifying ventriloquial effects* by using three analytical questions to examine the data (What is a person invoking? What voice can be recognized? What appears to lead a person to say or do what they're saying or doing?); (2) *grouping the ventriloquial effects* through sorting voices into clusters and arranging clusters into overarching collections; (3) *relating separate bits of the analysis* into an integrated model by tracing chains of authorship, relations,

and workings of ventriloquations; and (4) *selecting vignettes* from the data and *showing ventriloquial voices* through detailed elaborations.

Furthermore, some CCO scholars are exploring adventurous new methodological ways to study the constitutive force of communication by drawing on the mentioned turn to affect and relationality. For instance, →Brummans and Vézy (2022) explain how CCO researchers can mobilize new ethnographic techniques based on →Massumi's (2011) and →Manning's (2013) process philosophy. These techniques are referred to as a "cartography of everyday life" (→Manning 2013: 191) and "thick co-composition" (→Brummans and Vézy 2022: 270). They consist of mappings, tracings, or drawings that "acknowledge that you (the ethnographer) are an integral (*feeling* and *felt*) constituent of the relational field-in-formation, not a mere (participant) observer *of* it; someone who affects its enactment and is at the same time affected by it" (→Brummans and Vézy 2022: 271, emphasis in original). In other words, Brummans and Vézy encourage CCO researchers to embrace the situational dimension of everyday life by not exclusively focusing on what is expressed discursively. CCO researchers – especially ethnographers – can thus record and retrace the linguistic and extralinguistic forms of expressions that constitute organizational worlds, worlds composed of what's said and especially of what's felt (by the interrelated humans and other-than-humans they observe, but also by the researchers themselves, who are part of this field of relation).

2.6 Translating CCO Research into Practice

To what extent can CCO research be(come) practically relevant? This question was the focus of two pre-conferences of the European Group for Organizational Studies in 2014 and 2017. According to →van Vuuren and Knoers (2022), even if

the theoretical jargon used by CCO scholars is often opaque to practitioners, "one of the strongest assets of CCO thinking *is the reduction of communication naiveté*" (439, emphasis in original). In other words, CCO research invites organizational members (especially leaders and managers) to stop reducing communication to what has to be communicated to others once everything has been planned and organized. As James →Taylor (1988), (arguably) the founding father of CCO scholarship, suggested more than 30 years ago, communication should, on the contrary, be viewed as the way by which things get planned and organized.

Van Vuuren and Knoers in turn identify the most helpful CCO insights for practitioners: (1) *seeing organizing as a process* (a performative turn they consider to be a liberating thought for professionals); (2) *thinking in terms of degrees of organizationality* (→Dobusch and Schoeneborn 2015), which "positions the structure as a consequence for which organizing takes place" (→van Vuuren and Knoers 2022: 441) and not the opposite; (3) *showing the analytical payoff of paying attention to the detail of conversations and communication in general* (e.g., by showing how specific metaphors [→Koschmann 2013] or *authoritative texts* [→Kuhn 2008] can make a difference in organizing); (4) *insisting on the role of aspirational talk* (→Christensen, Morsing, and Thyssen 2013) to inspire organizational members and help them address accusations of hypocrisy in case of discrepancies between corporate social responsibility (CSR) action and talk by formulating strategies that are realistic and achievable; and (5) "*providing a sophisticated language for communication processes*" (→van Vuuren and Knoers 2022: 442, emphasis in original), a language that will give managers the discursive resources to acknowledge the constitutive dimension of communication; that is, its capacity to make things work, not only technically, but also ethically and humanely (see also →Town et al., 2024).

In line with these insights, →Lambotte and Wathelet (2016) conducted an action-research study in a Belgian regional administration that mobilized →Taylor and Van Every's (2000) text-conversation dialectic as a conceptual device for accompanying a planned organizational change. They examined conversations between the different stakeholders implicated in the organizational change by co-writing the text (the change plan). Through this recursive cycle, conflicts became visible that had remained latent throughout the process. The CCO framework adopted in this study thus became a catalyst for productive tensions (see also →Morillon, Grosjean, and Lambotte 2018).

A second example is →Grosjean's (2014) collaborative research on sensory acuity in decision-making processes in a Canadian hospital. Inspired by CCO thinking, this research examined the narration of practices and the sharing of narratives between health professionals as means for supporting the sensorial construction of meanings and knowledge in clinical decision making. Grosjean's research design followed three steps: (1) *individually identifying a narrative of a clinical situation*; (2) *collectively constructing a narrative of a clinical situation*; and (3) *sharing other stories and reflecting on practice*. In this case, a CCO approach was mobilized as a resource for professional development and organizational learning. Thus, it was used in the design of training systems based on storytelling.

Examples like these show that to become practically relevant, CCO scholars must learn how to speak the language of practitioners; they must find ways to translate their ideas into actionable recommendations. For example, regarding CSR communication, →Schoeneborn and Trittin (2013) propose that organizations should treat CSR communication as a strategic and general endeavor focused on highlighting their contribution to societal sensemaking processes. Likewise, they suggest that a CSR communication manager should focus on

sensemaking and translation, as well as on “handling challenges that arise from the responsibility and agency not only of individual organizational members but also of non-human entities” (→Schoeneborn and Trittin 2013: 206). Inspired by this work, →Cooren (2020) suggests that an organization’s social responsibility isn’t something that has to be planned and organized, and then communicated to stakeholders. Planning and organizing in a responsible manner should rather involve (directly or indirectly) mobilizing stakeholders in these very activities. Hence, a CCO approach to CSR should invite practitioners to *attune* to stakeholder concerns, which means that these stakeholders should be included in the CSR conversation.

3 Conclusion

In 2017, Boivin and colleagues ended their review of CCO texts published between 2000 and 2015 with this concluding statement: “[B]y encouraging a ‘unified diversity’ (→Eisenberg 1984) that not only welcomes new approaches but also ensures that such approaches are sufficiently formalized so others can understand and appropriate them, CCO research can solidify its ‘place at the interdisciplinary table’ (→Kuhn 2005: 625), increase its social relevance, and gain strength as an institutional force” (→Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017: 348).

As mentioned in the introduction to this chapter, seven years later, CCO research seems to have become more established as “an area of inquiry with its own identity” (→Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017: 345; see also →Basque, Bencherki, and Kuhn 2022). Our chapter shows, however, that CCO scholarship is also resisting trends toward institutionalization, unification at the cost of diversification, and formalization at the cost of theoretical as well as methodological exploration and creativity. For example, while

CCO research was initially characterized by three main schools of thought (McPhee's Four-Flows, the Montreal School, and Luhmannian systems theory; see →Cooren et al. 2011; →Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017; →Brummans et al. 2014; →Schoeneborn et al. 2014; →Schoeneborn and Vásquez 2017), this categorization is absent in more recent overview texts (see →Schoeneborn, Kuhn, and Kärreman 2019), suggesting that leading CCO scholars are less concerned with thinking about the communicative constitution of organizations in terms of these schools or "pillars" (→Schoeneborn et al. 2014: 310).

Instead, CCO scholars now seem to be united by a shared interest in the fertility of different communication-based understandings of organizational phenomena. That is, scholars across the broad spectrum of different kinds of CCO research that has appeared in the past years have continued to translate (and betray, as in the Italian proverb, "*Tradurre è tradire*", see →Brummans et al. 2014: 177) each other's work in their own creative and innovative ways. This pluralization (and proliferation) of ideas, combined with a spirit for adventure and a desire to push envelopes, have defined CCO scholarship since its inception, starting with →Taylor and Van Every's (2000) book *The Emergent Organization*, which broke new ground in organizational communication as well as a number of other disciplines, particularly management and organization studies (see →Weick 2006; →Weick, Sutcliffe, and Obstfeld 2005). These characteristics enabled, in other words, what Taylor optimistically called "the constitution of a *collective* mind at work" (→Schoeneborn et al. 2014: 311, emphasis in original); that is, of a common space that fosters the productive circulation of thought about the constitutive role of communication in organizational life. To make this space even more expansive and inclusive, CCO scholarship must shift the locus of enunciation from the Global North to the Global South, and start listening to other voices that have not yet

been part of the conversation (see →Vásquez, Marroquín, and Guillén 2021).

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Chapter 3 Can We Meet at the Alter? Doing Justice through Organizational Communication

Karen Lee Ashcraft

Abstract

This chapter addresses a simmering rupture in organizational communication studies. My aim is to trace key arcs of contact fomenting this "crisis" and to explore how these trajectories might bend otherwise, away from both polarizing and harmonizing forces that tend to immobilize potentials for justice. I argue, specifically, that critical approaches to difference (e.g., critical race, feminist, queer, decolonial, disability, and environmental justice) are unsettling the field by challenging its foundational scholarly practices. I suggest a need to let go of one of those constitutive practices: "polite pluralism", which grants limited recognition to certain forms of difference provided they remain domesticated and orderly, *organized*. If the field seeks to "make a difference" otherwise, a new mode of field-making is in order. I propose "alter-organizational communication", a linguistic placeholder for approaches that abandon polite pluralism and *dis*organize difference, toward reconstitutions of the field wherein difference can flourish. Organizational communication scholars can begin to "meet at the alter" by fostering four communal literacies: sideline the self, train in self-conscious doing, grow Other-wise, and savor the sweat.

Keywords: critical approaches (feminist, queer, disability, environmental, post-/de-colonialization, racialization, indigenous, food, housing, animal justice), difference,

diversity, othering, intersectionality, onto-epistemology, handbooks *as* organizational communication, NCA 2019 OCD racial rupture, polite pluralism, academic civility, alter-organizational communication, organization and anti-blackness,

This is an unusual chapter, written by a usual suspect.

An opening sentence says more than it may seem. Unraveling it slowly, for the rest of this chapter, we might fumble toward a different way to learn (and do) our subject matter, which is "critical approaches to difference in organizational communication studies".

1 The Introduction You'd Expect: Learning *About* Critical Approaches to Difference

The usual way to teach this topic would have us delineate the domain in question. We could begin, for example, by saying that **critical** approaches care about power. They ask how regulation and resistance unfold in organizational life and what communication has to do with this. Critical approaches seek to transform power and maximize justice, a goal usually framed in emancipatory terms – like liberation, equality, equity, integrity, and dignity.

Next, we might clarify that **difference** is a cover term for operations of power that occur through social identities and alterities. Markers of sameness and difference – like race, sexuality, class, gender, and nation – activate entire regimes of control. For example, references to "civilized persons" or "average citizens" elevate some by demoting others. Bodies and activities associated with these "others" can be downgraded in many ways, cast as natural, primitive, exotic, foreign, racialized, feminized, sexualized, deviant, disabled, deficient, deprived, depraved, hypervisible, and/or disappeared. Like this, Others become the foil for "normal" (read: unmarked, generic, normat*ive*) human subjects. Critical

approaches to difference track how such categorizations materialize power, mainly by othering with a capital O.

Othering makes an "inside" based on a constitutive "outside". I say *constitutive* because the valuable thing inside depends, for existence, on the boundary between itself and Others. Absent their exclusion, the inside would cease to have the same character and worth. That's why subsequent projects of inclusion are intrinsically problematic for everyone, most of all those made Other. When exclusions are constitutive, Others cannot be incorporated en masse without fundamentally altering the inside. *By definition*, that is, few can cross the border, and those who do pay a hefty price of admission. Confined mostly to the margins, Others create and inhabit vivid worlds that those living inside cannot know. Not knowing is a privilege that takes a toll on the inside too.

If we zoom in on specific categories of Othering, distinct angles of critical approach come into view. **Feminist** and **queer theory** take up with gender and sexuality, for example. **Disability justice** confronts able-bodied regimes, while **environmental justice** counters the rule of "culture" over "nature" and the racial, gender, and geopolitics of land ownership, resource extraction, and ecological destruction. Critical accounts of **racialization**, **coloniality**, and **indigeneity** take on racial injustice and its entanglement with campaigns of civilization and empire, nation and citizenship, property and entitlement, economy, religion, and so on that carve the world into regions and populations that "have and have not", "the West and the rest", global North and South. **Food**, **housing**, and **animal justice** interrogate the line between human and non- or sub-human, unearthing the complex relations among race, capitalism, labor, environmental ruin, agriculture, gentrification, and the killing industries.

These are examples of critical approaches included in the widest web we might cast for organizational communication studies, and they point to something else we should notice.

Rather than acting as separate regimes, difference categories overlap and intermingle. Anti-blackness, for instance, is committed through gender and sexuality, which are caught up in claims to nation, which rest on hierarchies of ability, and so forth. We are thus called to investigate their **intersectionality**, a term that captures how difference-power systems work in tandem, through relation with one another.

Already we are learning about critical approaches to difference through this usual method, the operative word there being "about". When we only talk *about* something, as I just did, it becomes hard to see how we are also *doing* precisely what we are talking about.

For instance, Othering constitutes academic fields too. It values "hard" sciences like engineering over "soft" sciences like communication by masculinizing the former and feminizing the latter. Othering occurs in studies of Othering, as when feminisms aligned with white hetero ciswomen find traction by eclipsing or erasing BIPOC, queer, and trans folk. Othering like this defines the field of organizational communication, and I have contributed to it. Othering is happening in this handbook and in the authoring of this very chapter.

This is the other way of learning I hinted at the outset: knowing through self-conscious doing.

2 Starting Over, Self-Consciously: Learning *Through* as Well as *About*

In this atypical method of teaching, we would not only show-and-tell critical approaches but show *through* the telling. That is, we would explain how power works through difference and use the explanation itself to illustrate this. Knowing through doing demonstrates how difference and power work *while* we are speaking of them, in our talk *about* them. How communicative, or *meta*communicative, this would be! How

onto-epistemological, which is a fancy way of making a meaningful point: how we know (epistemology) isn't separate from what we know, or the nature of the thing we wish to learn about (ontology). Any effort to know something also produces that thing, brings it into being in a particular way (hence, onto-epistemology). This is what I mean by "self-conscious", a method of learning that stays aware of its implication in the object of study, its complicity in that which it seeks to know.

Knowing through self-conscious doing would have us read handbooks like this one differently. The difference-power relations that any academic field deems "normal" are executed in its handbooks. You are reading your way into these relations right now, becoming an "organizational communication scholar" through them. Said another way, handbooks engage in organizational communication; and in so doing, handbooks *of* organizational communication form the very field of which they speak.

This chapter makes the following wager: if organizational communication really wants to engage with critical approaches to difference, we will all need to get better at this onto-epistemological method – essentially, knowing through our own doing. At its simplest, the call of this chapter is *to learn how organizational communication (the practice) constitutes organizational communication (the field) by doing power through difference, and to collaborate in doing otherwise*. Yet, just like it sounds, there is nothing simple about it.

Back to the opening sentence. This chapter is unusual, first, for the self-conscious method of knowing it attempts. It uses its own activity (composing handbooks) to demonstrate the phenomenon at hand (critical approaches to difference). What I mean is that the chapter takes itself and the whole handbook enterprise as another instance of organizational communication (the field *and* the practice that makes the field) arranging power through difference.

Self-conscious learning is both awkward and well worth the discomfort, or so I will try to show. It proceeds with vulnerability and mercy because the only thing it knows for sure is that our practice is fallible. No reason to stop trying, imperfection becomes both a baseline we can relax into and a summons to keep at it. Shall we give it a try?

3 A Field-Making Practice: Handbooks Speak Volumes

This is the sole chapter dedicated to critical approaches in this volume (e.g., Chapters 14 and 15 engage with critical perspectives, but they are not the main focus), another feature that makes the chapter unusual. Those tracking the evolution of organizational communication handbooks may expect more by now, perhaps separate chapters on critical, postmodern, post- and de-colonial, feminist, and queer perspectives. It is not possible to cover all this – even if I cover up all "this" leaves out – in a single chapter, so allow me to reframe my charge:

- Not – How can I do justice to the rich array of critical approaches to difference in one chapter? (I can't.) How should I prioritize them so at least some claim territory, albeit at Others' expense? (I won't.)
- Instead – How does my authorship of the one critical chapter in this volume do power through difference? (Any way you cut it, unjustly. But hopefully, better than I've done it before.)

The opening sentence unravels one more turn. As before, let's take it slowly.

Handbooks have a way of recycling experts, thereby reproducing insular scholarly networks and the partialities that go along with them. This is one way such volumes draw the boundaries of a field without quite declaring them. Relying

on the same or adjacent authorities, drawn from the likely networks, retraces the borders until they become so deeply etched that “the field” revolves around a circle of people. Constitutive exclusions – racial and geopolitical walls, for instance – quietly persist like this.

My regular cameo in handbooks is the chapter on feminist approaches to gender and difference in organizational life. My official task is to represent a “marginal” area of inquiry such that “mainstream” readers can recognize and assess its case for inclusion. This is a second, more overt way that handbooks draw the boundaries of a field, by granting the space to put Others on the map (“Oh, feminist org comm is a thing?!”).

A third way is by keeping Others in their place. Containment is often a cost of inclusion. It happens through a volume’s structure – for example, by limiting the number of critical difference chapters and/or separating them as abstract theories, held apart from the mainstream issues they stand to utterly reframe, or by continuing to dub them new (“emerging”) or nonconforming (“alternative”) long after they make the map.

Containment also occurs in the writing of chapters. As a frequent handbook chapter author (18 at last count), I know my unofficial task to be this: legitimize a marginalized domain in a non-threatening manner. My job is to expand the available territory on the map of the field without disputing its basic contours. I suspect I am a usual suspect for both my acquired skill at performing this function and my geopolitical and racial advantage. These skills and advantages are intertwined.

As much as I hate to disappoint, the self-conscious method of learning attempted here requires me to fail at these official and unofficial tasks this time around. Why? Because succeeding would repeat once more these habitual ways that handbooks fail to do justice *to* difference and, thereby, do power unjustly *through* difference.

I'll say that again, pointedly. Organizational communication handbooks present a field where difference stays in its rightful place, which seems to be: a separate matter for occasional consideration ("Other" ways to think about …), best handled in "safe" hands, which are reliably "reasonable" (like mine).

If you wince at this revelation, know that I am squirming too. Few will emerge virtuous from this exercise, least of all me. But your or my virtue is entirely beside the point when the point is to learn how power operates through difference. To keep learning, let's press through the discomfort and bring one of the field's own theories – the communicative constitution of organizing (CCO) – to bear on its practice of composing handbooks.

Read through CCO, the handbook project is a bid to constitute the field as a legitimate entity by serving up its next "authoritative text" (→Kuhn 2008). If we listen beyond what they say outright, handbooks *really* begin to speak volumes. Namely, they map out the difference-power relations by which a narrow "we" becomes (and remains) "the field". One small example is my authorship of the sole chapter here devoted to critical approaches to difference in all its forms. Yet again, a regularly featured, white, native-English-speaking, US-born, hetero ciswoman (to name a few of my advantages) accepts the charge to represent – diplomatically – the entire field of critical difference studies in a single chapter. Inequities like this are enshrined in our authoritative texts. No minor oversights, they are foundational to field-making, in and beyond the handbook project.

It bears asking: If we cannot do justice *to* difference when we talk about organizational communication – in a handbook, for example – how can we do justice *through* organizational communication anywhere, or ask anyone else to?

This chapter makes the case that **difference in order** (i.e., well-kempt and safely contained) **defines the organizational**

communication practice by which the field of organizational communication is routinely made. **In effect, organizing = domesticating difference and organization = difference well-behaved. If we really want to make a difference otherwise, we need a new mode of field-making, one premised on difference out of order** (i.e., not working properly, unruly). Later, I will develop this alternative practice as "alter-organizational communication".

In playful terms, I write in hot pursuit of another kind of organizational communication. I try to relate with you in a way that *enacts* – and even makes catching – the spirit and promise of critical approaches to envisage better worlds. The immodest aim of this chapter is to leap off the page; to hit the reader oddly and provoke engagement with that experience; to strain against its separation from, and beckon to, other chapters and sections; to resist a tidy narrative and settle for unsettling. To put into practice – dare I say model (now *that's* immodest!) – the organizational communication for which it yearns. To show through telling.

In this light, my failure to organize difference as usual becomes a modest measure of the chapter's success. Strange as it may sound, a benchmark of failure meets the moment well. Increasingly, critical approaches to difference are neither content with the usual suspects nor inclined to stay in their place, resulting in a rupture described in the next section. Because I take this handbook to be another event in the evolving rupture, I write *as* the interruption I talk *about*.

The handbook project is not uniquely culpable. I use it to exemplify broader patterns because it's right in front of us, right now. The question is not who to blame or censure for these patterns. Whether you and I are right or wrong, good or bad, is mere distraction. Focus on our field-making practice. The question is can we do otherwise, and the answer is yes.

4 A Racial Rupture: Organizational Communication Is Perspiring

Ordinarily, academics write without disclosing what prompts them to. This habit of abstraction hinders my work here, so I'll start with the spark. There is a spreading sense that organizational communication is in "crisis" – facing an impasse, moment of truth, inflection point, you get the idea. The invitation to write this chapter asked me to weigh into this fracture.

Here's how I'd distill the divide. Critical approaches that are more radical and insistent (hereafter abbreviated as "2.0") have begun to refuse accustomed forms of restraint and challenge both the map of the field and its usual experts. This is happening to an extent that many folks, of diverse persuasions, wonder in what sense we even have *a* field, who *we* are to *have* one in the first place, if a more *expansive* "we" can share a field going forward, does expansive mean *inclusive* or *disruptive* or something else entirely, and whether even this initial row over the *terms* of an ideal future portend badly for one in common.

In other words, 2.0 is turning up the heat on long-simmering disagreement over (a) what counts as organizational communication, (b) how the field's knowledge processes and products relate to events in the world, and (c) how scholars should relate to one another and disciplinary institutions. 2.0 is calling the whole enterprise into question and not mincing words. Unaccustomed to such intense and sustained collective self-reflexivity, organizational communication is getting uncomfortable, sweating you might say.

The discomfort could prove productive. But, like any rising dynamic rattling durable norms, it is felt by many to be problematic in a range of ways. Some say the field and its traditions are the problem. Others say the critical challenges

and their escalating textures are at fault. Still others find credit and blame on “both sides”. Some disengage altogether.

What most appear to agree on (at the time of this writing, anyway) is that **race**[1] has become the hot spot. From the enduring forces that catalyzed #CommunicationSoWhite, to the Distinguished Scholar debacle that led up to the 2019 National Communication Association (NCA) conference, outcries over racism have reached a boiling point and spilled over, such that it is no longer viable to simply carry on by muting such concerns.

At the 2019 conference in Baltimore, Maryland, the NCA Organizational Communication Division (OCD) did something it had diligently avoided for years: jumped right into the scalding pot. During the annual ritual that is the OCD Top-Paper-Panel-plus-Business-Meeting, some long-lurking truths strode out into the open. Some of these were aired at the event, while others emerged in the continuing aftermath. This is no exhaustive list:

- Whereas organizational communication claims to oppose white supremacy, it is also emblematic of it, in that its field-making practice – including its inclusion fantasy – is based on the primacy of whiteness.
- 2.0 is not content to channel this critique toward organizational communication elsewhere (beyond the field). Real change requires continuous, not occasional, collective self-reflexivity.
- The reign of surface cohesion – that “polite” strain of academic civility long treasured by (some in) the field – is interrupted, if not over.
- This strain of “niceness” is not so nice after all, especially when invoked to discipline, deflect, and defend against demands that the field contend with its racism.
- Much of the field (many critical scholars included) is attached to its relative “goodness” – that is, to the virtue

of surface cohesion as a foundation for community. For those so attached, the decline of cohesion feels like a disconcerting loss.

- 2.0 says the loss is necessary because this cohesion comes at the expense of the Others it excludes and controls. "Niceness" of this sort tries to sanitize white supremacy, not dismantle it.
- Dueling visions of the field are thus in circulation:
    1. a fundamentally, intentionally, or at least ideally *non*-racist community, where – admittedly – white people and associated habits remain dominant; racism occurs; and both need remediation; but members are largely united against white supremacy and aspire to act accordingly;
    2. a fundamentally racist community, defined not by its good intentions or ideals, but by its longstanding complacency regarding the rule of whiteness and its refusal to address the ongoing practices that maintain this hegemony – a situation that amounts to white supremacy regardless of anyone's aversion to the term or rejection of related beliefs, and that can only be transformed through a concerted *anti*-racist overhaul.
- As the confrontation keeps recurring, these dual visions appear to be polarizing. Or, the rupture is growing and accelerating, such that many seem unsure what to do next.

In a nutshell, the field's primary mode of organizational communication seems to be failing. Going forward, I refer to this longstanding practice of field-making as "polite pluralism".

Polite pluralism is not just unequal to the moment, incapable of dealing with a racial flash point. 2.0 points to stronger claims. Polite pluralism is a major way that whiteness continues to constitute the field. It is an enabling practice that

can serve racist ends regardless of practitioner intention – indeed, even when intentions are opposed to racism. Let me try that again. Polite pluralism *is* whiteness in action, a form of white supremacy at work. There, that's closer. Too close for comfort, maybe?

If you recoil at these claims, the next section is especially for you. Perhaps you are wondering how common courtesy could ever be (mis)taken for white supremacy. Perhaps you lean toward the first of the dueling visions of the field described above. In any case, I freely admit that I am old enough, "inside" and profiting enough, white North American settler woman enough, cis-hetero-masculinized and otherwise conditioned and rehearsed enough (the list goes on) to (a) comprehend you, (b) have been there, (c) feel my own tinges of loss and uncertainty at the decline of cohesion, (d) know firsthand the frustration of hearing that your best intentions and values aren't the point, and (e) recognize your resistance in my own unchecked reflexes. But plain and simple, the field pays too high a price for polite pluralism to continue. Come walk with me for a minute? I think we can, and must, do better.

Before we take that stroll, I should note that some readers, especially those who are not so involved in NCA's OCD, may find the rupture described here to be a parochial drama over distinctively US race relations and "American" communication norms. They would certainly have a point. As I suggested above, the racial and geopolitics of the field, particularly its rootedness in white, English-speaking, North American networks and preoccupation with associated concerns and institutions, are one major way it does difference unjustly. Conversations about "diversity" in "the field" often reek with US-centrism.

That said, though the granular details are specific to the OCD, the dilemmas are widely shared. Beyond communication and organization studies, many academic fields, in many

cultural contexts, are struggling with intensified cultural politics and long overdue racial and related reckonings. Many disciplines find themselves perspiring at the same time, for good reason. Just maybe, we all stand to learn new field-making practices through self-conscious doing.

5 Polite Pluralism: An Imperative to Organize by Domesticating Difference

What's wrong with the field-making practice we have? **Polite pluralism**, as I define it, is *a mode of organizational communication that embraces difference provided all parties maintain a "good-natured" interactive surface*, by which I mean both (a) amiable or agreeable and (b) affirming the decency and virtue of colleagues, as if interpersonal affability and individual character are the main measures of good organizational communication. Put this way, doesn't polite pluralism sound "nice?" At least it allows conflicting perspectives to cohabitate peacefully and disagree reasonably, and isn't that better than the meltdown happening now? No, is the short answer, but retracing history might help us arrive there together.

Lest the current "crisis" be mistaken as new or sudden, we do well to remember two things. First, *organizational communication has long fretted over the breakdown of field relations*. The past 30 years have seen the ebb and flow of anxiety about "our" cohesion. My mentors in the 1990s shared relief that the field was entering a fertile and collaborative era after earlier struggles with insecurity ("Are we theoretically and methodologically rigorous enough?") and paradigmatic battles (as if to prove scholarly rigor). Intellectual possibilities were multiplying. Rhetorical, cultural, and critical turns appeared capable of co-existing, or at least staying in conversation with, conventional approaches. Born of legendary gatherings like those in Alta, Utah (see →Kuhn

2005), a sense of communal optimism – that friendly difference was possible and productive – became the order of the day. Polite pluralism would mature.

Yet undercurrents of anxiety persisted, resurfacing in handbook iterations and similar works of synthesis. I'm thinking here of →Mumby and Stohl's (1996) "shared problematics" that "discipline" organizational communication (i.e., make it a coherent and legitimate field of study). Or →Corman and Poole's (2000) volume, *Perspectives on Organizational Communication: Finding Common Ground*, which tried to ease the lingering threat of paradigm incommensurability. A kindred vibe inspired a conference I helped plan and host in Utah during the summer of 2008, called "Organizational Communication at Alta, Revisited: Reflection, Synthesis and Engagement". Specific to handbooks, successive iterations of Putnam and friends' chapter on "metaphors of communication and organization" generously expanded the tent to make room for more, exemplifying the dream of cohesion (e.g., →Putnam and Boys 2006; →Putnam, Phillips, and Chapman 1996). →Deetz and Eger (2014) diminished such unity as "ecumenical fragmentation", "a kind of food fair where we congregate as Teflon-coated cosmopolitans, stopping only to sample the parts of the field with which we identify and admire, ignoring or refuting the rest" (p. 27). In a more recent encyclopedia chapter, →Conrad and Sillitto (2017) pondered the "tone of these debates" and the still-elusive quest for "common ground", marking concern about a contemporary resurgence of fragmentation.

Suffice it to say, the field has long strained to maintain surface cohesion, fearing the kind of rupture now underway. "Our" common ground has always been shaky, an idealized state that is a delicate and ongoing negotiation, a fragile accomplishment if it occurs.

Recently, →Hanchey and Jensen (2021) re-read this quest for common ground, exposing it as a white settler fantasy "we" that depends on the racialized Others it produces and excludes. Before hastily rebuffing this claim, we'd do well to remember a second thing: *racial critique is not new to organizational communication, yet somehow it never seems to stick*. Now why is that?

→Nkomo's (1992) groundbreaking piece on race and organization started circulating among communication scholars not long after its publication. By the early aughts, a handful of folks – such as Brenda J. →Allen (e.g., 1998, →2000), →Pat Parker (e.g., 2001, →2003), and Diane →Grimes (2001) – observed that, while the field embraced critical approaches to power, it did not seem keen to address racialized power and its own foundational whiteness. Postcolonial approaches soon joined the fray to further challenge the "we" undergirding "*our* shared problematics" (→Broadfoot and Munshi 2007).

And yet, to this day, the field shows almost no racial attention span. For 20 years, race remained a torch carried by a small set of scholars, who issued call after call with little response, until the sheer volume of unanswered calls began to get cited – without apparent irony – as evidence of the very attention whose absence they bemoaned. ("Look, here's proof org comm addresses race!" You mean … by *not* addressing it?)

Where do these twin recollections lead? Right here: *organizational communication has long navigated common ground, and perched its flimsy cohesion, on the indefinite postponement of racial reckoning*. Despite ample bidding and opportunities, the field has consistently dropped the ball when it comes to race. Meanwhile, feminisms emerging around the same time – composed mostly by and for white, hetero, cisgender women – became a fixture in handbooks that barely mentioned race. By and large, this is still the case.

The disparity in uptake is striking but not surprising, because feminist organizational communication is largely

compatible with the field-making practice of polite pluralism. Both are premised on whiteness, in that they prioritize demonstrations of individual "goodness" through interpersonal "niceness" – a "respectful reasonableness" that strenuously avoids rupturing the social fabric, no matter how riddled with inequities it may be (see →Bramen 2017). Critique and provocation are fine, even thrilling, provided they shield that precious surface from permanent stain. As long as they don't linger too long, get too demanding, or make anyone feel overly incriminated or uneasy.

"Well-behaved women seldom make history" (see →Ulrich 2007), a well-worn phrase that can eclipse how the reverse is also true. Feminist organizational communication behaved by the code of whiteness and leapt right into the handbooks. I know because I did it.

Elsewhere, I detail the claim that polite pluralism is the mode of organizational communication by which whiteness constitutes the field (→Ashcraft 2022a). There, I play on the overlap between my given name and that now infamous name given to white women's role in maintaining white supremacy, "Karen". I show how I blunted the impact of my work with Brenda J. Allen on "The racial foundation of organizational communication" (→Ashcraft and Allen 2003) by acting as a structural Karen, hell-bent on fulfilling my duty to uphold polite pluralism. I took the wind out if its sails, sanitizing the racism I knew saturated the field and my own body, all in the name of "preserving relationships", which is to say – among other things – sustaining my good standing as a white daughter of the field.

Nearly two decades later, in stark contrast, →Harris's (2019) NCA OCD Top Paper presentation pulled no such punches and met the consequences. Shortly after she described organizational communication as a field in step with white supremacy and identified "tone policing" as a field-making practice of whiteness, the tone police seemed to step

right in. And there it was, her argument enacted in the moment for all to see – an opportunity for onto-epistemological learning (knowing through, not only about) if ever there were one. Will we take it?

Organizational communication as we have known it, polite pluralism, prevents us from doing so. It is an imperative to keep difference *organized* – in order, defanged and safely contained, non-threatening *to* and *for* the "good" of the community. When we make the field this way, Others can only be seen and heard when they don't rock the boat too hard. The price of inclusion is the imperative to "play nice". Affirm the goodness of a "community" premised on your exclusion. Consent to proceed as if racism is normal instead of an urgent priority.

Louder this time: polite pluralism asserts the fundamental decency of a field made by papering over racial hierarchy, then casts those who would tear the tablecloth as "bad", rudely disruptive. Boiled down, organizational communication is not only *willing* to put race on hold for its veneer of cohesion – a trade-off that's telling enough. Worse, organizational communication *depends* on the perpetual deferral of racism, because dismantling the constitutive whiteness of the field amounts to surrendering its "good" name. Now how "nice" does that sound?

In the end, the whole field pays a heavy toll for this not-so-nice niceness, which is its inability to *get real*. We study organizing and communicating while George Floyd, Breonna Taylor, and countless other Black and Brown people in our midst are regularly violated and slaughtered by legitimized institutional violence. While a viral pandemic ravages the earth, exacerbating enduring inequities, and creating new ones, across institutional fields. While environmental destruction does the same and brings the planet's demise to ever-nearer horizons. While white supremacy, anti-Semitism, Islamophobia, and more surge with new force in the globally

contagious form of aggrieved masculinity (→Ashcraft 2022b). While truths wither into optics. While the rapacious appetites of late, global, racial, patriarchal, necro-, techno-, communicative, neoliberal, [insert additional qualifiers here] capitalism sanction these activities and so much more, touching and enlisting every one of us, remaking the very universities and field-making activities through which we try to know *about* any of this … Deep breath. And yet.

Were we to take our cue from professional entities like the OCD, or from the many organizational communication handbooks and similar academic anthologies around, we wouldn't know much of the scenes just described. The field's "authoritative texts" are oddly quiet on this state of affairs and the urgent coalitional organizing and communicating it compels. Let me put it this way. Perhaps organizational communication is perspiring not due to 2.0, but because there's a serious inferno raging across the world, yet our dominant mode of field-making – polite pluralism – would have us carry on in courteous denial.

I've heard the rise of 2.0 framed in many ways – a conflict born of generational difference, a fissure between social justice activism and more traditional conceptions of scholarship, or a reflection of society's political polarization, to name a few. My concern is not to dispute these frames or the insights they garner. Nor is it to advocate for the rightness or righteousness of 2.0. We all have much to learn about how we participate in the systems of power we study. Everyone stands to grow from asking how we do power in the act of critiquing it. Claims to criticality are no shield from complicity (→Ahmed 2012).

My concern is only to clarify that 2.0 isn't lighting the fire; it's sounding the alarm. Whatever the complicities and troubles of 2.0, a field that would cling to an imaginary cohesion by "killing" this messenger – that would turn its back

on the message out of distaste for the form of delivery – does so at everyone's peril.

I take this to be the spirit of efforts like #ToneUpOrgComm: let's get real before it's too late. As someone who has long participated in toning it down, and who continues to see value in multiple orientations to (dis- and re-) organizing for meaningful change, I am both humbled and animated anew by this spirit. However hard it is to hear, it's past time I absorb it. "Karen's" brand of diplomacy – her tireless effort to organize difference, to make it (re)presentable in the hopes of inclusion – will do no more. That's why this usual suspect *must* fail to write her usual chapter. That's why difference must become *dis*organized, fall out of order.

At last, we return to the question that opened this section. Isn't polite pluralism preferable to the rupture happening now? My first response is preferable *for whom*? Polite pluralism may feel better to some of us because it shields "our" comfort. But it does so on Others' backs, at the expense of their perpetual pain, erasure, and death. Admitting this ought to make that "comfort" unbearably uncomfortable.

My second response is that even those of us who profit most from polite pluralism enjoy its short-term comforts at long-term cost. The urgencies of the world do not leave us with a choice. If organizational communication doesn't get real, it will become increasingly irrelevant *by* clinging to its wheezing fantasies of benevolent inclusion.

No, polite pluralism isn't nice, preferable, ethical, or effective; and it has reached its end. It flies in the face of the world we live in, and everything critical approaches have told us about how power operates systemically. It tries to sanitize and absolve systemic racism in our midst with individual and interpersonal "goodness". We know better *about* difference, so let's *do* difference better. Or to the point of this chapter, let's know-by-doing difference better. The very least the

(formerly) comfortable among us can do is to start sharing, even shouldering, the labor of discomfort. The final sections explore how.

6 Alter-Organizational Communication: An Imperative to Question the Very Project of Organization

For some time, I've been reflecting on how scholarly knowledge production (our own work) configures power through difference, in an effort to (a) facilitate a more equitable field and (b) enhance what that field offers to organizing and communicating elsewhere (→Ashcraft 2018). A few years ago, I took a seemingly unrelated detour to study disorganization, specifically "disorders of disorder" like hoarding (→Ashcraft 2019). This side trip impressed upon "Karen" a lesson I should've learned earlier from Black feminist and queer, Afropessimist, and decolonial scholarship, which suggests not only the constitutive whiteness of academic fields, but more deeply, the constitutive anti-blackness of organization itself.

That lesson: organizing, the field's beloved object of study, runs thick with anti-black thinking and practice. Despite continuing denial of this fact, modern management is premised on the structures and practices of Black chattel slavery (→Cooke 2003; →Rosenthal 2018). A major continuing vector of organizational history is that of an instrument which rationalizes racist violence – systematically Othering, colonizing, extracting, enslaving, archiving and erasing, controlling, brutalizing, and killing, profiting from and justifying the whole operation. Organization remains a civilizing guard against "chaos", which time after time is revealed as the disorder threatened by "dark", "inferior", "foreign" Others. The contemporary imperative to organize (everything) is animated by the production, fear, and

regulation of difference gone wild (→Ashcraft 2019). As Cruz (in preparation) powerfully argues, “Africa” is projected as a murky place of “no-organization”, the constitutive exclusion or “outside” that enables the “inside” of *organization* as we know it.

Organization arrives steeped in white supremacy. No wonder when we try to know it, and do so by *organizing* a field, that field is made in its image. Under this circumstance, where organization as a modern project is thoroughly compromised from the start, the sort of reflection I was engaged in – asking how the field can *reorganize* difference toward better *organization* – is grossly inadequate. For as long as we presume organization as a moral (or even neutral) good, we are attached to a white supremacist project whose best-case scenario is difference well-behaved.

Witness the endless quest for “diversity management”, “multicultural workplaces”, “inclusive excellence”, or whatever we call it now and next – one ill-fated project of inclusion after another, all failing to question the normative foundation of whiteness built upon anti-blackness. Return to the opening of this chapter and re-read the passage that introduces Othering. Realize, with me, that “organizational” communication *is* the Othering that critical approaches to difference in organizational communication are talking *about*.

So much for the subject-object split. Enter the subject-object relation, wherein “we” (scholars, the supposed knowers) are constituted by the object of our fascination (organization, the supposedly inert known). The entire enterprise – organization itself, “our” love affair with it, the making of a field to know it better, and the founding of that field upon orderly difference – drips with racist history while repeating it.

Coming to this realization *should* be deeply troubling, but it does *not* give cause to pack up our bags and go home, crying “damned if we do or don’t”. As signaled earlier, it is a

reason to keep trying with humility, generosity, and imagination. Of course field-making practice as we know it is unjust. Of course we cannot surrender to this inevitable future. Of course we are all imperfect and will not get it "right". *And* of course we must endeavor to do otherwise. Right?

I think we need to start over *from where we are*. This does not require an *anti*-organizational stance that opposes anything which smacks of order. Replacing the moral imperative to organize with one that valorizes *dis*organization for its own sake calls to mind Jo →Freeman's (1972) classic critique of ideological purity in radical feminist organizing. As a scholar of feminist organizing raised in the lap of religious fundamentalism, I am not interested in piety of *any* kind, from any side of the current OCD rupture.

What I am suggesting, instead, is an alternative field-making practice that is admittedly unholy and, for this reason, intentionally unsure of itself. I propose a vulnerable mode of engagement that commits to dis-ordering and re-doing difference without precisely knowing how or what that entails. Where this practice should lead is away from white supremacy and entangled regimes of difference, but the routes available to get there remain an open question, whose answer can only be known creatively and provisionally, through trial and error. Through self-conscious learning.

For ease, and simply as a placeholder for gathering interested parties across intellectual orientations and affiliations, I refer to this alternative as **alter-organizational communication**. Alter-OC = something other than OC as we know it. Neither a mandate for *organized* communication that staves off unruly difference, nor the opposite. No utopia here. Critical approaches to difference increasingly reach for an "otherwise", imaginaries that are tethered in yet transcend realities now lived, forms of prefiguration that inspire creative

world-making and promising futurities. This is the sense in which I speak of “the alter”.

7 Fumbling Toward the Alter: Four Organizational Communication Literacies

Alter-OC sounds lofty or grandiose, you may say, too elusive in any case. What can be done right now to unlearn polite pluralism and fashion a field no longer in fear of difference out of order? Plenty. For starters, here are four communal capacities to pursue. You can work to develop these on your own *as* we rehearse them together:

1. **Sideline the self: It’s not about you or me.** Alter-OC begins by refusing any participants’ claims to “goodness” – not in order to make them “bad”, but to render such binaries and one’s status in relation to them beside the point. Alter-OC puts the ego in check, especially for those close(r) to whiteness and related privileges. When participants strive to be right by making others wrong – when affirmation of personal rightness becomes a focal point or driving force – alter-OC would gently and firmly insist: this is not about any one of us, momentarily righteous or outcast. This is about practice – our *relational becoming*, the ongoing constitution of a field that better knows dis/organization by doing it better. If you and I are constituted by the practice through which we relate, we *become better* by improving that practice. I am not “good” at your expense, nor you at mine. Scapegoating gets “us” nowhere.

The first thing to be done, then, is whatever ongoing work with our selves it may take to acknowledge and curb the ego’s need for individual affirmation. Among academics, where perfectionism, impostor syndrome, and related insecurities are common occupational hazards, I suspect this will take constant reminding, and that’s OK.

2. **Train in self-conscious doing: Know through *as well as* about.** Alter-OC tries to notice what is happening from within the doing – in the middle of things, as they are unfolding. The task is to point out speculatively, to wonder aloud, while the paint is still drying and the outcome, uncertain. This is an onto-epistemological literacy that resists the separation of subject and object. Earlier, I described this as learning *about* difference by becoming more aware of how we *do* difference in the act of knowing it. Rather than splitting knowledge practices from their products – essentially, dividing how we know (epistemology) from what we know (ontology) – we can build capacity for ongoing reflexivity on our own world-making.

In basic communication theory terms, alter-OC makes space for both *content* and *relational* levels of field-making and asks us to toggle between them. It would have us get used to multitasking – on the one hand, composing handbooks, chapters, panels, papers, editorial reviews, journals, talks, syllabi, classes, and the like (doing our work, in other words), *while*, on the other hand, considering the relations getting made by knowledge production. What kind of "us" or field do our practices yield, or could they summon differently? In tune with #1, self-consciousness like this is not preoccupied with implications *for* the self but, rather, with becoming aware of the self's implication in, and complicity with, field-making practice.

To be sure, it takes more dexterity and patience than we currently show to juggle the awkward simultaneity of self-conscious doing. But we can acquire these skills through repetitive practice. As that suggests, my subtitle "knowing through *as well as* about" is both conjunction and equivalence. Alter-OC asks that we do both at once *and* on par with (i.e., as good as) one another. For most academics trained to know about – at the remove of arm's length or bird's eye – knowing through will be the harder lift.

3. **Grow Other-wise: *Actively* discern how Othering happens.** Once we presume imperfection and abandon claims to virtue (#1), we are freed to focus on honing communal awareness of the organizational communication by which we make the field (#2). In this chapter, I have tried to model how self-conscious learning like this invariably directs us to the ways in which Othering propels the very scenes we inhabit. It thus carries the potential to recondition our relational reflexes, such that critical approaches to difference become something we *all* do.

Regardless of our areas of study, we can start to notice together how Othering guides the activities and outcomes in which we participate. Like this, alter-OC stays curious and keeps learning about the ways power operates through difference in our midst. I refer to this literacy as "becoming Other-wise", a term with dual meaning.

First and foremost, we become Other-wise by seeking to know (a) how Othering happens in our immediate worlds and (b) how we serve as vessels of Othering, regardless of our intent. To be clear, this sense of becoming Other-wise does *not* mean gaining knowledge of or about Others and "their ways" (akin to so-called women's ways of leading), such that whiteness remains the unmarked and intact standard. When learning about difference = learning about Others (rather than Other*ing*), Othering is already afoot. Indeed, this is an all-too-common form of Othering endemic to diversity training, and becoming Other-*wise* would have us name and reject it. In short, becoming Other-wise means cultivating shared wisdom about how Othering works and our varied complicities in its operation. The point is not to ask how Others communicate differently, as if "us" and "them" are given categories in the world. The point is to ask how Others are produced *as* naturally existing categories to serve a dominant yet silent normativity, like whiteness.

By definition, this first sense of becoming Other-wise also does not rely on the voluntary labor or "goodwill" of Others to cultivate shared wisdom. Such reliance is another common form of Othering – hence, the emphasis in my subtitle here, "*actively* discern …". Take the initiative, for example, to read →Saad's (2020) *White Supremacy and Me* or similar titles widely available. Those of us close(r) to whiteness have the most work to do but are not alone. Folks who experience marginalization are also enticed to invest in Othering. "Karens" are a case in point: Experiencing subordination on one front (gender) hardly makes one immune from perpetrating oppression on that and other fronts (gendered racism). Othering is a ready way to scramble for relative power, and pitting Others against one another is an old trick in the white supremacist manual.

The *shared* part of becoming Other-wise is key. Cultivating knowledge of Othering is not a path to personal goodness (return to #1) but, rather, makes us all better partners in alter-OC. As communal awareness of complicity in Othering grows, so too can a shared capacity for spotting and attempting other ways of dis/organizing difference. This is the second sense of "becoming Other-wise" – trying out different modes of world-making, that is, incubating the sort of "otherwise" referred to earlier. Alter-OC might even run on this lively motto, which captures both meanings and their necessary relation: *Grow Other-wise toward other ways*.

4. **Savor the sweat: Discomfort can be gratifying.** To this point, some readers may be thinking, "This sounds like hard, uncomfortable work!" This I do not deny, and it's why I led into alter-OC by calling those of us nestled in polite pluralism to step up, share, and bear the labor of discomfort. "We" must surrender any ease, or sense of cohesive community, founded on the discomfort of Others; and we will perspire with each act of surrender, in every moment we push ourselves to let go

of old comforts. Though serious, this work need not be drudgery and, arguably, won't be the more we do it.

The trick is to reframe discomfort as more than a (small) debt to be paid for any hope of real community. For as much as it unsettles, discomfort can be a productive, generative feeling too – the beginning or seed of new and previously unknown relational pleasures. In other words, alter-OC does not simply *endure* the sweat but *relishes* it for making possible an "otherwise" we could not have known otherwise.

Alter-OC seeks play, humor, laughter, joy, even fulfillment in the awkward exposures of vulnerable engagement. I cannot underscore enough the significance of this shift: from discomfort as onerous – a compulsory change you'd prefer to avoid if possible – to discomfort as energizing, shaking off the old skin to reveal new growth. When we sweat, we are working it out, transforming into something else. Organizational communication is getting stimulated, invigorated, even as old energies are expiring. In this frame, what a gift it can be to become Other-wise.

Already, I look forward to you expanding this limited list of literacies toward a new practice of field-making. Whoever you are and whatever you study, from whatever orientation, can we meet at the alter? We've got some dis/organizing to do.

8 Back to the Beginning: A Handbook of Alter-Organizational Communication

This is an unusual chapter because it is authored by a usual suspect who seeks to *un*do what she does well, which is organize difference, or render it (re)presentable for the sake of inclusion.

Intentionally failing at this task, I wound up "modeling" what I do even better, which is imperfection. Starting with the field-making practice of handbooks *of/as* organizational communication, I tried to enact critical approaches to

difference while talking about them. Basically, I tried to show through the telling, to perform alter-OC in making a case for it. I thus used my own complicity, uncertainty, struggle to unlearn polite pluralism, and continuing effort to grow Other-wise to display the provisional path forward I described, in the act of describing it.

In this way, you could say the chapter demonstrates all four literacies above. That the demonstration is flawed is precisely the point. *Please* have at it, so "we" can know and do better. The chapter aims to instigate engagement just like this: How can organizational communication do justice to difference, such that justice can be done through organizational communication? Confronting this question, we are already cultivating the capacities named above.

Returning to the example of handbooks, a provocation arises. As sure as polite pluralism is enthroned in our handbooks, so it can be unseated; the question is *how*. How about we cease the separation of theories and perspectives from topics, methods, and contexts? Make space for self-conscious knowing-by-doing, periodically reflecting on questions like: To what sort of organizational communication does this handbook aspire, and how is it doing? Are there breaks between the organizational communication described and displayed, and what can be learned from these? What silences loom large? What if handbooks intentionally decenter the US and global North, Western intellectual traditions and appropriations, and white cis-hetero-masculinities, for instance, by starting with Othered knowledges and realities and asking dominant approaches to engage on their terms? Feature unusual suspects and/or stage exchange between familiar and unfamiliar voices, where the latter speak first and/or "get the last word". Foreground urgent problems of dis/organizing around the globe (self-conscious of who's defining these, for whom) and invite diverse authors to bring communication to bear on these challenges – with the goal of

fostering previously unforeseen coalitions *through* the handbook's production. Make intersectionality the common thread. Tell other histories of the field, bringing new imperatives and futures to the table. Request attention to difference like we do to theoretical or practical implications. Require new citational practices. Let difference roam and shout. Er, stop assuming a gatekeeping "we" that "lets" difference do anything, and admit how "we" do difference ourselves (c'mon, Karen!). I don't know. What do you think?

Alter-OC, take one: vulnerable engagement with the question, if handbooks speak volumes, what (and how) else might they say?

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Notes

1 I use “race” here expansively, to encapsulate a family of concerns regarding racism, racialization, coloniality, indigeneity, ethnicity, im/migration, citizenship, and so forth. The persistence of white supremacy and the normativity of whiteness are common threads across these concerns.

Chapter 4 Quantitative Methods in Organizational Communication

Brian Manata

Jiawei Sophia Fu

Abstract

As of late, the field of organizational communication has witnessed a steady rise in the use of quantitative methodologies. In this chapter, we acknowledge this rise by providing an overview of basic quantitative concepts (e.g., reliability, sampling, statistical power), discussing the use of common quantitative methods (e.g., survey methods, experiments, content analysis), and delineating two recent developments that we believe represent promising new frontiers in organizational communication scholarship. Specifically, we focus on the increased use of multilevel modeling (e.g., consensus models, hierarchical linear modeling) and computational methods, such as social network analysis, machine and deep learning, text mining and analytics, and agent-based modeling. Overall, our aim with this chapter is to demonstrate the value and diversity of quantitative approaches, both for the tyro and for the more experienced organizational communication scholar. We believe integrating quantitative methods with other methodologies (e.g., qualitative methods) will considerably enhance the rigor and vibrancy of organizational communication scholarship and theory.

Keywords: machine learning, agent-based modeling, computational social science, open science, mixed-methods, social network analysis, big data, content analysis, validity,

reliability, sampling, surveys, experiments, multilevel, hierarchical linear modeling,

In the past two decades, the field of organizational communication has witnessed a steady increase in research publications using quantitative methodologies (see →Stephens 2017). Over this time, organizational communication scholars have employed a variety of quantitative methods, such as surveys, experiments, content analyses, and social network analyses to investigate research questions and test hypotheses. Many organizational communication scholars have also relied on mixed-methods research as a new mode of inquiry to identify patterns, mechanisms, and also add richness and nuance to extant research findings (→Myers 2014). In this chapter, we discuss many of these quantitative methods. In doing so, we (1) provide an overview of quantitative methods that are common in organizational communication research and (2) point out recent developments in quantitative methodologies that we believe will be useful for future organizational communication research.

Before beginning, however, we take a brief moment to remark upon the utility of quantitative research. To be clear, we recognize the importance and utility of other research methodologies (e.g., qualitative methods), but we see several distinct advantages of quantitative research that we believe to be noteworthy. First, quantitative research is associated typically with a higher level of objectivity. Specifically, quantitative research promotes the "conscious distancing of the investigator from the object of the study through systematic development and validation of measures, study design, and statistical hypothesis testing" (→Miller et al. 2011: 6). Thus, if a researcher makes a theoretical prediction but finds that they are incorrect, then they must concede that they are incorrect and try again.

Secondly, quantitative research offers the ability to produce effect sizes that quantify the strength of a relationship between two variables (e.g., correlations). Importantly, this affords researchers the ability to determine which variables have stronger effects on outcomes of interest. For example, research to date has shown that group-level cohesion has a strong positive effect on group performance (e.g., →Manata 2020). Alternatively, gender diversity in groups has virtually no effect on task performance (→van Dijk, van Engen, and van Knippenberg. 2012). Thus, if one were interested in improving a team's performance, they would be well advised to care less about the group's gender composition and to care more about whether members liked one another.

Finally, because effect sizes can be accumulated, they can be used to identify general patterns by making meaningful comparisons between different investigations. For example, if 20 different researchers conduct 20 different studies on the same construct of interest, then information from those 20 studies can be used to determine the general pattern of results that should be expected to manifest for any one study that examines that construct. Importantly, this provides researchers with information about how they should expect different variables to behave on average, which allows them to offer practical recommendations to others that seek to understand how variables operate. For these reasons, we believe that quantitative research is of decided value. Consequently, we endeavor to devote a considerable amount of time to explicating different aspects of quantitative research.

We begin this chapter by providing an overview of basic concepts and issues in quantitative research, such as validity, reliability, and sampling. We then consider prominent quantitative research methods in organizational communication research, including surveys, experiments, and

content analysis. Finally, we conclude by suggesting recent developments in quantitative methodologies and how they can benefit future organizational communication research.

1 The Basics

Core concepts in quantitative research include validity, reliability, and sampling. Regardless of the method used, these fundamentals are important for ensuring that organizational communication scholars are measuring concepts effectively and can draw valid inferences from their studies. We discuss each concept below.

1.1 Validity

Quantitative researchers typically place considerable effort on ensuring that their measures constitute valid representations of their theoretical constructs, i.e., the extent to which a measure measures its intended construct and nothing else (→Boster 2012). This is because theoretical constructs are latent and cannot be observed directly.

In their seminal article, →Cronbach and Meehl (1955) defined three methods of establishing a measure's validity, which involves providing evidence for (1) content validity, (2) criterion validity, and (3) construct validity. *Content validity* is usually judged subjectively by evaluating the sampling adequacy of a measure's range of content. Thus, content validity would be evidenced if a measure provided a complete representation of a construct as defined theoretically. Such assessments are made typically by a panel of experts or judges from a particular field that are familiar with the construct or content in question (e.g., academics, business executives).

Alternatively, criterion and construct validity rely on methods that are more quantitative in nature (e.g.,

correlation). Specifically, a measure has *criterion validity* when it predicts outcomes in ways that are consonant with theoretical predictions. For example, to the extent that the graduate record examination (GRE) predicts graduate student success (e.g., higher GPAs), then the GRE is said to have criterion or predictive validity. Similarly, a measure is said to have *construct validity* when it behaves as expected when interacting with myriad other constructs. For example, one might show that a measure of relational conflict is associated negatively with group performance (e.g., →Manata 2016), positively with the intention to leave the group, and negatively with group cohesion. When combined, the modeling of all three effects creates a network of associations around the construct of interest, which →Cronbach and Meehl (1955) termed the *nomological network*. If the patterns of associations within a construct's nomological network are all in the anticipated direction, this provides strong evidence of construct validity.

→Campbell and Fiske (1959) distinguished further between two additional types of validity: *convergent* and *discriminant* validity. *Convergent validity* is evidenced when two measures thought to measure the same thing are correlated strongly and positively. Alternatively, evidence for *discriminant validity* is produced when measures purported to measure different constructs are not correlated too strongly (→Anderson and Gerbing 1988). →Campbell and Fiske (1959) specified the *multi-trait-multi-method matrix* as the primary way by which to investigate convergent and discriminant validity (see also →Henseler, Ringle, and Sarstedt 2015). However, others (e.g., →Anderson and Gerbing 1988) have recommended assessing validity using the more robust procedure of confirmatory factor analysis (CFA).

CFA. In what is perhaps the most comprehensive way to investigate validity, scholars use CFA to establish the validity of quantitative measures and factor structures. In brief, CFA is

used to infer a measure's validity based on the patterns of associations evident in the item-by-item correlation or covariance matrix. More specifically, the internal consistency and parallelism theorems are used to evaluate the extent to which item correlations are being driven by some unobserved factor and nothing else (for technical details, see →Hunter and Gerbing 1982), which provides the basis for assessing model fit. Ultimately, the more that observed correlations diverge from the predictions made by both theorems, the poorer the fit of the model. Popular fit indices used to document overall model misspecification include the standardized root mean square residual (SRMR), comparative fit index (CFI), and the root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA). For most situations, →Hu and Bentler (1999) recommend the combinational rule of a CFI that is close to or above. 95 and an SRMR that is close to or below. 09. →Hair et al. (2019), however, suggest that different rules of thumb be applied based on the model's complexity and overall sample size (see p. 642). In general, Hair et al. suggest that simpler models require stricter evaluations than more complex models. We emphasize that such recommendations are rules of thumb, not golden rules to which scholars should adhere blindly. Instead, it is in researchers' best interest to remove or modify the parameters that are producing large model residuals, with the added caveat that such modifications may be capitalizing on sampling error (→Anderson and Gerbing 1988).

1.2 Reliability

Once construct validity is established, researchers move on to estimating the reliability (i.e., consistency of measurement) of their tests or measures (e.g., →Cronbach 1951). Formally, reliability constitutes the percentage of total response variance that is due to true score variance. This can also be conceptualized as the squared correlation between a set of

observed measures and their respective, theoretical true scores. In practice, reliability is used primarily as an indicator of measurement error; all else being equal, the reliability of a measure decreases as error of measurement increases. Error of measurement is important to document because it attenuates correlations between population true scores (→Schmidt and Hunter 2015). That is, valid measures with lower reliabilities will produce lower observed correlations when compared to measures with higher reliabilities. Fortunately, the reliability of a measure can be improved by increasing the length of a test (i.e., adding more parallel items to a measure). In addition, measurement error can be corrected for statistically (for correction formulae, see →Schmidt and Hunter 2015: 113; see also →Boster 2012).

Coefficient Alpha. Although numerous methods have been developed to estimate reliability (see →Cho 2016), coefficient alpha (α) is most common. In brief, coefficient alpha estimates the average split-half reliability coefficient. →Cronbach (1951: 331) notes further that coefficient alpha can be interpreted as a lower-bound estimate of the proportion of variance that is attributed to some common factor. When calculating coefficient alpha, scholars assume that the items of interest are valid indicators of the same latent construct. Making this assumption explicit is important because the concepts of reliability and validity are confused commonly in social science. This confusion is most apparent when scholars treat a large coefficient alpha value as evidence of item homogeneity, used to justify averaging a set of items in a scale (→Schmidt and Hunter 2015). This procedure is incorrect because high coefficient alpha values can be produced even when items fail to load on a single factor, such as when there are many items in a test that do not belong in the same content domain (e.g., see →Cruz and Manata 2020: 6).

When calculating α, one is also assuming that the indicators used are tau-equivalent (i.e., the indicators evidence equal factor loadings; see →Cho 2016). When this assumption is violated, α tends to underestimate reliability. Under such conditions, some recommend the use of congeneric reliability (see →Cho 2016: 664), sometimes referred to as coefficient omega (ω; e.g., →Manata et al. 2023) or composite reliability (e.g., →Peterson and Kim 2013; see also →Cho 2016). As others have pointed out, however, the difference between the two coefficients is usually trivial in practice (see →Peterson and Kim 2013).

1.3 Sampling

When designing a study, organizational communication researchers also must consider the important issue of sampling, which substantially influences researchers' ability to make generalized inferences. Critical to this discussion is the distinction made between *probability sampling* – when each sample element has a known, nonzero probability of being sampled – and *non-probability sampling* – when each sample element has undetermined or unknown probabilities of being sampled. In its simplest form, probability sampling can be accomplished via simple random sampling, which occurs when sample elements (e.g., organizational members) are drawn randomly from a population of interest (e.g., the workforce). Another form of probability sampling is termed cluster sampling, which occurs when clusters (e.g., organizations) are drawn randomly from a population of interest, and then elements are sampled randomly from these clusters. Such forms of data collection are advantageous because they allow for inferences that are more likely to generalize to the population of interest. For other types, see →Visser, Krosnick, and Lavrakas (2000).

On the other hand, non-probability sampling can be accomplished with haphazard or convenience sampling. Haphazard sampling occurs when elements are sampled because they are available. For example, samples comprising students (e.g., →Manata 2019) or members of one organization (e.g., →Myers and McPhee 2006) are common types of convenience samples (→Landers and Behrend 2015). Other forms of non-probability sampling include snowball sampling (e.g., sampling members from one organization, and then requesting that they forward the survey instrument to other members) and quota sampling (e.g., ensuring that the sample is composed of 50% male organizational subjects). For other types, see →Visser, Krosnick, and Lavrakas (2000). Such methods are used because they are convenient. However, because the extent to which the generated sample is representative of the population of interest is unknown, non-probability sampling methods are not well-suited to making generalized inferences about the population of interest.

Student Samples. As mentioned previously, one common type of convenience sample is the college student sample. These samples have been criticized by organizational communication scholars because of concerns about their generalizability to the actual organizational workforce. Indeed, research has documented cases in which student samples produce different effect sizes from organizational workers (e.g., →Gordon, Slade, and Schmitt 1986; →Peterson 2001). However, other research has shown that student samples produce results consonant with a more tenured organizational population (e.g., →Miller and Manata 2023). Additionally, although →Peterson (2001) showed that there are cases in which student samples produced different effect sizes when compared to non-student samples, the effect sizes for both samples were correlated strongly (r = .75). Ultimately, asserting that student samples produce biased results is an empirical question and not a known certainty.

mTurk Samples. More recently, researchers often procure convenient samples using online paneling services (e.g., Amazon's Mechanical Turk, Qualtrics, Prolific). Of the available data collection platforms, Amazon's Mechanical Turk (mTurk) is perhaps the most widely used. mTurk is best described as a crowdsourcing platform whereby individuals (i.e., Turkers) are tasked with completing human intelligence tasks (e.g., organizational surveys). Ample evidence shows that mTurk samples produce adequate levels of data quality (e.g., →Buhrmester, Kwang, and Gosling 2011). This is advantageous because such samples are typically more diverse than the traditional college student samples (→Landers and Behrend 2015). mTurk samples are also easy to attain and relatively inexpensive. Nevertheless, some scholars continue to raise concerns about the purported data quality of such online samples (e.g., →Chmielewski and Kucker 2020). In general, validity checks are recommended (e.g., attention checks), so that scholars are better able to flag and remove subjects that are responding randomly or providing nonsensical results. Fortunately, validity checks are simple to implement and may provide some improvement to overall data quality. For an example of such measures, see →Chmielewski and Kucker (2020).

Statistical Power. The issue of statistical power is critical to any discussion of sampling. In brief, statistical power is defined formally as 1-β, where β is the probability of failing to reject the null hypothesis when it is false (i.e., a Type-2 error). Statistical power is determined by using the significance criterion (α), population effect size, and sample size. In general, larger samples yield greater statistical power, which increases the odds of producing results that are statistically significant. One barrier to determining statistical power is that it requires an *a priori* estimate of the population effect size. Although such information can be obtained from meta-analyses, these have not yet been performed in every area. In

these cases, scholars must choose another value to use, such as the average effect size in individual differences research (r ~ .20; →Gignac and Szodorai 2016). Scholars can then use power analyses to determine what sample size will be needed to detect the expected effect. For example, with an expected r = .20 and α set to the conventional level of .05, an N of 200 yields a power value of ~ .81, which is usually deemed sufficient for most purposes (→Cohen et al. 2003). Increasing the sample size will increase power (e.g., when N = 300, power = .94), whereas decreasing the sample size will decrease power (e.g., when N = 50, power = .29). It is important to note, however, that power will only affect the statistical significance of a finding, not its magnitude or practical importance.

2 Major Quantitative Research Methodologies

Next, we turn to a discussion of the most common quantitative research methods in organizational communication research: surveys, experiments, content analyses, and mixed methods.

2.1 Surveys

Surveys are one of the most common ways by which organizational communication researchers collect quantitative data. Survey research involves using questionnaires to collect data from a population of interest. Questions in a questionnaire can be divided broadly into open-ended and closed-ended questions. *Open-ended questions* allow the subject to respond freely, which allow for richer and more nuanced responses. However, data produced using such questions must be coded, which can be an arduous process. *Closed-ended questions* require respondents to select an option from a pre-specified set of answers. Likert-type (e.g., ranging from 1 = *strongly disagree* to 7 = *strongly agree*) and semantic

differential (e.g., ranging from 1 = *toxic* to 7 = *supportive*) questions constitute two common forms of closed-ended questions. In general, closed-ended questions are easier to code than open-ended responses. However, closed-ended questions are limited in that subjects are forced to respond in a certain manner. Thus, if the available options are incomplete or incorrect, the subject has no way to respond accurately.

As with most methods, there are many challenges associated with surveys. For one, creating both closed- and open-ended survey questions can be difficult (→Visser, Krosnick, and Lavrakas 2000). For another, collecting survey data from hard-to-reach populations can face substantial barriers. Organizational-level survey data collection, in particular, may face low response rates and require significant financial and human resources to invite participation and follow up via postcards, mailings, and emails. Furthermore, issues of nonresponse bias and sample representativeness may arise when some groups with certain characteristics are more responsive than others. Scholars can mitigate these issues by creating questions that are simple in content and meanings that are easy for participants to understand and respond to; following response-enhancing strategies; and conducting statistical tests to see whether responding participants are statistically different from nonrespondents or representative of the sample that researchers aimed to collect (e.g., →Fu 2020).

Common-Method Variance. An additional problem associated with survey research is common-method variance. Social scientists have long been concerned about the confounding effects of common- or shared-method variance in behavioral research, particularly survey research that employs various scales to measure latent factors and constructs (e.g., →Podsakoff et al. 2003). The general concern is that, when measuring different constructs with the same measurement instrument, at least some of the observed

covariation between different constructs or indicators may be due to some unwanted trait or method factor (e.g., response bias). In response to this problem, many have suggested employing a variety of procedural techniques, such as defining or providing clear examples for ambiguous or unfamiliar terms, emphasizing anonymity, or telling respondents that there are no right or wrong answers. Other techniques include obtaining data using hetero methods (i.e., subjective and objective measures), obtaining data at different points in time, or controlling for the shared method factor(s) by modeling it explicitly (see →Podsakoff et al. 2003). It is worth mentioning, however, that many have disputed the problem of common-method variance, stating that it is overstated and largely a myth (e.g., →Spector 2006). Others have also pointed out that many of the purported remedies for common-method variance produce inaccurate inferences and introduce other problems that would require further remediation (see →Conway and Lance 2010; →Lance et al. 2010; →Richardson, Simmering, and Sturman 2009).

2.2 Experiments

Experiments are another common quantitative method in organizational communication research. The value of experiments is that they offer researchers the ability to control for methodological confounds and possible threats to validity. Indeed, the primary concern with experimental research is *internal validity* – whether the experimental treatments make a difference in the outcomes of interest (→Campbell and Stanley 1963). In their classic text, Campbell and Stanley describe numerous threats to internal validity that could compromise one's ability to make causal inferences. The downside is that experiments are limited by their ability to establish *external validity* – the extent to which scenarios and results generalize to different populations, contexts, and so

on. Specifically, experimental designs often do not reflect realistic conditions, which means that any results produced in the laboratory may not replicate in more realistic settings (cf. →Mook 1983). Nevertheless, because strong experimental designs allow for causal inference, they present a decided advantage over most cross-sectional survey research.

2.3 Content Analysis

Content analysis is another common quantitative method in organizational communication research employed to study and code a variety of archival materials, such as organizational mission statements, corporate social responsibility reports, organizational social media policies, and social media posts. For instance, →Banghart, Etter, and Stohl (2018) conducted content analysis of social media policies of 112 corporations to understand organizational boundary regulation. →Albu and Etter (2016) performed content analysis of two organizations' tweets to investigate organizational identity configuration and negotiation.

When performing content analysis, researchers first develop a coding scheme to identify key concepts and categories that they are interested in studying. Then, they train at least two human coders (e.g., research assistants) in these coding categories and have them code a common subset of cases. During this process, differences are usually resolved through substantive discussions and coding categories may be refined. This procedure may be iterated several times until the coders' subjective interpretations converge and interrater reliability or agreement is satisfactory. Subsequently, coders are assigned the rest of the cases and code independently. Through content analysis, researchers can make inferences by identifying specific characteristics of messages and quantifying differences across cases and observations.

There are many distinct advantages associated with content analysis, such as flexibility and creativity in (re)analysis and (re)coding, as well as the ability to study things over time. Moreover, the target content for analysis is usually more objective (i.e., archived materials), which may not be subject to the same data collection biases common with other methods (e.g., social desirability bias). However, the coding scheme designed by researchers may not reveal nuances inherent in messages and the case selection process may not be representative.

2.4 Mixed Methods

The past two decades have witnessed a steady increase in mixed-methods organizational communication research that integrates different types of methods to triangulate, complement, support, or develop new insights (→Stephens 2017). Such studies most often rely on interviews, content analysis, surveys, and participant observation to identify patterns and mechanisms; provide context, nuance, and richness; and make sense of findings. Through integrating insights from multiple methods, mixed-methods research can help researchers improve the rigor of research (e.g., rejecting or validating claims made in one method based on data from another method), showcase intentionality, broaden and deepen scholarly discoveries, and develop normative best practices (→Carlson, Cooper, and Pilny 2016).

There are different types of mixed-methods research. *Multi-method research* is broader and refers to any study in which a researcher employs two or more types of data collection (qualitative, quantitative, or a mix of both). For instance, scholars could employ semi-structured interviews, participant observation, and archival analysis to triangulate findings. By contrast, *mixing-method research* is a type of multi-method research that employs both qualitative and

quantitative research methods. For instance, researchers may use semi-structured interviews to contextualize, make sense of exploratory survey findings, and provide a deeper meaning to study findings that have emerged from a pilot survey; alternatively, they might use preliminary findings from interviews to inform the design of a large-scale survey. More recently, scholars have also supplemented more traditional methods with computational methods (e.g., social network analysis, automated text analysis, and machine and deep learning) in mixed-methods research. However, as →Myers (2014) notes, multiple methods are best used not for their own sake, but "when more really is more" (p. 297).

3 Emerging Quantitative Methods

Although the previous discussion provides much for the average organizational communication researcher to consider, current research has pushed the field of organizational communication in new directions that require added consideration. Below, we offer brief discussions of two general areas of research that are beginning to take precedence in the field of organizational communication: (1) multilevel theory and analyses, and (2) computational social science.

3.1 Multilevel Theory and Analyses

The explicit use of multilevel theory and methods in organizational communication research is beginning to gain traction (e.g., →Miller et al. 2011). In general, organizations can be classified as systems comprising multiple, interdependent units of analysis. In addition, units can range from micro- to macro-levels of analysis, whereby one unit is nested within another. For example, individuals may be classified as more micro-level than teams. For a detailed

discussion of multilevel theory, see →Kozlowski and Klein (2000).

Consensus Models. One key issue when attempting to investigate multilevel phenomena concerns establishing macro-level constructs from micro-level data. In his seminal article, →Chan (1998) described five different types of group composition models that can be used for this purpose. Of these five, the two implemented most often are *direct consensus* and *referent-shift consensus* models, both of which assume that the construct of interest is isomorphic or equivalent across individuals and levels of analysis. Notably, →Chan (1998) distinguishes between both models by making a key distinction thought to occur at the item level. Specifically, referent-shift consensus models are manifest when items are focused at the higher- or global-level of analysis (e.g., "My team evidences efficacy"). Alternatively, direct consensus models are manifest when items focus specifically on the lower-level units that are nested within the contextual factor of interest (e.g., "I evidence efficacy"). Thus, whereas one model asks questions about global properties, the other raises queries about individual-level properties (i.e., other vs. self-referent). Such a distinction implies that two different constructs may emerge in the data, but the extent to which this is the case in practice remains unclear.

Because both models are consensus models, both models represent a compositional form of emergence, whereby higher-level constructs are assumed to emerge over time via members' interactions, which then subsequently constrain their thoughts and behaviors (→Kozlowski and Klein 2000). Under such circumstances, documenting within-unit agreement is usually a requirement (→Chan 1998). Moreover, according to →Chan (1998), higher-level constructs of this nature are best represented by the average or mean of their respective lower-level unit scores. As an exemplar, the construct of group cohesion is treated commonly in this

manner (e.g., →Manata 2016). That is, if members agree regarding the level of their group's cohesion, then group cohesion is said to be a property of the group that has emerged and constrained their perceptions to be equivalent. Moreover, the group-level cohesion mean is treated as the higher-level contextual variable of interest.

Within-Unit Agreement. There are numerous ways to document within-unit agreement and justify the aggregation of lower-level values (see →LeBreton and Senter 2008), the simplest of which is to compute the intra-class correlation coefficient (ICC). Two forms of the ICC that are of particular interest to multilevel scholars are the ICC(1) and ICC(1, *k*). The ICC(1) is used primarily as an index of non-independence or clustering within units (→Singer and Willet 2003). That is, a large ICC(1) would indicate that a large portion of variance in subject responses was due to between-group variance, suggesting that scores were clustered by group and thus dependent on a higher-level contextual factor. For example, an ICC(1) value of .30 would indicate that 30% of response variance was due to subjects' group-level affiliations (i.e., subject responses were dependent on their group-level affiliations; or, group-level affiliation had a substantial effect on subject responses). In consequence, the ICC(1) is used generally as a method of estimating either within-group agreement (i.e., clustering) or non-independence for the purposes of justifying the use of a multilevel model (→Singer and Willet 2003). Alternatively, the ICC(1, *k*), which is an extension of the ICC(1), has been used to estimate the reliability of unit-level means. →Bliese (1998) has shown that such reliability coefficients can be used to correct for the attenuation of unit-level correlations. This property of the ICC(1, *k*) will likely be of use to researchers interested in correcting for unreliability when meta-analyzing correlations between macro-level phenomena.

Dispersion Models. In addition to direct consensus and referent-shift models, →Chan (1998) describes *dispersion* models that do not necessitate within-unit agreement. Instead, dispersion models assume that the level of dispersion in within-unit values constitutes the unit-level factor of interest. →Manata and colleagues (2021), for example, used the standard deviation (*SD*), which is a measure of dispersion, to document the extent to which a team's commitment climate was strong or weak. That is, the *SD* of team members' commitment responses was calculated for each team, with higher team *SD*s indicating greater commitment disparities within a team. Such values can be correlated with other factors (e.g., communication behaviors) in the same manner as average or mean unit-level values. For another example of dispersion models, see →Schneider, Salvaggio, and Subirats (2002).

Hierarchical Linear Modeling. Once the researcher has established unit-level factors, the next challenge is data analysis. Specifically, if there are variables conceptualized at different levels of analyses (e.g., groups and individuals), then specialized methods are required. The most common of these methods is hierarchical linear modeling (HLM). HLM constitutes an extension of traditional regression methods, whereby different regression equations are stipulated at different levels of analysis (e.g., level 1 for individuals and level 2 for groups). For example, →Manata (2019) used HLM to investigate whether team-level phenomena (e.g., normative communication) impacted individual-level behaviors (e.g., performance). For a detailed discussion of this method, see →Raudenbush and Bryk (2002).

Of note, HLM is required primarily when there is substantial dependence in the data, as indicated, for example, by the ICC(1). As →Singer and Willet (2003: 97) note, large ICC(1) values indicate that within-group residuals are correlated strongly, which violates one of the critical

assumptions of ordinary least squares (OLS) regression analysis. When the assumption of residual independence is violated, OLS will yield imprecise inferences because the analysis will produce incorrect standard errors (see →Cohen et al. 2003: 120). In contrast, HLM is flexible enough to account for such dependence because it assumes that the within-unit residuals will in fact be correlated (for technical details, see →Singer and Willet 2003: 249).

Nevertheless, the utility of HLM is limited in that it is not well-suited to deal with the dynamics of emergence and other complex issues. For these types of questions, organizational communication researchers have recently turned to computational methods.

3.2 Computational Social Science

Social Network Analysis. Organizational communication researchers have long used social network analysis to study relationships within and among organizations, such as interpersonal advice-seeking networks (e.g., →Fu, Shumate, and Contractor 2020) and interorganizational cross-sector partnerships to tackle social challenges in the global civil society (e.g., →Saffer, Pilny, and Sommerfeldt 2021). In general, there are two types of social network analysis techniques: (1) ego network analysis and (2) the study of whole networks with relatively well-defined network boundaries and memberships. The former typically uses a name-generator approach, which invites research participants to indicate their network contacts. The latter typically uses *exponential random graph modeling* (ERGM) to model structure and dependency in the formation of social relationships.

Recent methodological advances have enabled researchers to take a step beyond binary relationships to understand networks and relationships at multiple levels and/or over time. For instance, *relational event modeling* can

help researchers study sequential relations and events as temporal, unfolding communicative processes and interactions (→Schecter et al. 2018). *Multilevel ERGM* allows researchers to study network relationships embedded at the micro-, meso-, and macro-levels of analyses. *Bipartite ERGM* allows the examination of network relationships among two different types of entities, such as individuals and organizations. *Valued ERGM* allows scholars to study the strength of ties among social actors and provides much nuance to extant networks, as opposed to the presence or absence of social relationships as binary (→Pilny and Atouba 2018). Finally, *Simulation Investigation for Empirical Network Analysis* allows researchers to model the evolution of and dynamic change in network relationships and provides a more nuanced understanding of the selection and dissolution of ties over time. Ultimately, utilizing varied network modeling techniques and theoretical frameworks answers →Monge and Contractor's (2003) general call to study social networks at multiple levels of analyses using multiple social network theories (i.e., the multi-theoretical multilevel framework).

Machine and Deep Learning. With recent advances in computational social science, researchers have begun employing computational approaches as new modes of inquiry, particularly in applying these techniques to analyze texts and detect social relationships. Common supervised (i.e., involving training data and examples) and unsupervised (i.e., not involving training data or examples) machine and deep learning techniques include recurrent neural networks (e.g., →Zhu and Fu 2019), topic modeling (e.g., →Ophir, Walter, and Marchant 2020), and random forest classifiers (e.g., →Kwon, Priniski, and Chadha 2018). For instance, →Su and colleagues (2018) used a supervised machine learning-based method of content analysis to examine the extent and patterns of incivility in the comment sections of US news outlets' Facebook pages. →Zhu and Fu (2019) used recurrent neutral

networks to understand the relationship between content interdisciplinarity and a journal's research impact among social science citation index communication journals.

There are several distinct advantages associated with using machine and deep learning techniques, such as reduced sampling bias in social media data (→Kwon, Priniski, and Chadha 2018) and the ability to process and analyze data on a large scale. These approaches can also be useful for triangulating insights from other sources of data, such as surveys and manual content analysis by human coders. For instance, →Pilny and colleagues (2019) combined surveys and manual content analysis with supervised machine learning in automated content analysis to examine complex interpretations of relational uncertainty in online forum posts.

Automated Content and Textual Analysis. Arguably, one of the most common applications of computational approaches is automated, computer-assisted content analysis. In particular, many communication researchers have adopted computer-aided content analysis techniques for automated textual analysis, such as sentiment analysis, topic modeling, and semantic network analysis. These advanced techniques help researchers analyze a large corpus of textual data. Researchers often use sentiment analysis to evaluate the public and key stakeholders' reactions to certain social events and organizational activities, such as sentiments in news coverage and social media posts (Su et al. 2018). →Ophir, Walter, and Marchant (2020) used topic modeling to identify latent themes, categories, and topics in a large text corpus in ethnographic field notes. Semantic network analysis allows researchers to understand the interrelationship and co-occurrence of words in texts to understand the dominant discourse on key social issues (e.g., →Fu and Zhang 2019).

However, several limitations have posed significant challenges in the use of computerized content analysis. First, much of the computer-aided content analysis is exploratory in

nature. As a result, many researchers struggle with the interpretation (e.g., the categories in topic modeling) and validity of the findings that emerge from textual analysis. Second, some studies (e.g., →van Atteveldt, van der Velden, and Boukes 2021) have revealed that human coding in content analysis is more reliable and accurate than computerized textual analysis. In light of these challenges, it is recommended to integrate human coding and computer-assisted textual analysis – *hybrid content analysis* – to gain a more complete picture of the phenomenon under study. In this regard, we agree with other scholars (e.g., →Baden, Kligler-Vilenchik, and Yarchi 2020) who suggest future research would benefit from integrating multiple modes of inquiry, such as unsupervised machine learning (e.g., topic model networks), supervised machine learning and dictionaries, survey data, and ethnographic field notes to understand communication dynamics more rigorously.

Agent-Based Modeling (ABM). Finally, ABM allows researchers to understand and simulate what and how global patterns can emerge from micro-level behaviors and assumptions. This technique is particularly helpful when researchers do not have empirical data, or for theory building and validation. For instance, →Foote and colleagues (2023) employed ABM to simulate and compare different conditions of enterprise social media use to understand "the relationship between individuals' propensity to engage in connective or communal activities, their visibility into the communication of others, and the likelihood an enterprise social media reaching critical mass" (p. 11). Relatedly, →Song and Boomgaarden (2017) used ABM to simulate the mechanisms and boundary conditions (e.g., interpersonal discussion networks and election contexts) that affect selective media exposure and influence on individual attitudes. In another example, →Garner (2016) used ABM to simulate organizational dissent and demonstrate potential connections between various

elements of the dissent process, such as how goal-directed behavior and dissent conversations from micro- and meso-levels lead to macro-level dialectics in organizational dissent. ABM, along with other simulation techniques, can help overcome the limitations of typical experimental and observational studies that require extensive data collection across multiple levels of analysis, leading to more robust causal inferences that can be used to improve and refine theory.

4 Conclusion

In this chapter, we have reviewed key concepts in quantitative research, several common quantitative methods in organizational communication research, and two recent developments that we believe represent promising new frontiers in communication scholarship. Choosing an appropriate quantitative method is driven by the theoretical question that a research project seeks to address, and we hope that greater awareness of the diversity of methodological tools available will empower researchers to ask more diverse, novel, and ambitious questions.

As new and experienced researchers employ these methods, we encourage them to remain mindful of systemic issues in quantitative research. Many fields have struggled with problems such as low replicability, questionable research practices, and publication biases, and communication is no different. Although there are no easy answers to these problems, we agree with other scholars (e.g., →Dienlin et al. 2021) that open science would promote transparency and be an important step in the right direction in advancing quantitative communication research. Useful practices include sharing published materials, sharing data and code, and promoting open collaboration between scholars. Abandoning or de-emphasizing the statistical significance test would also

curb many of these problems by reducing the incentive to engage in questionable research practices in the interest of attaining statistical significance (see also →Hunter 1997).

Overall, we believe that emphasizing these general practices will help facilitate ethical scientific practices and further promote the general mission of knowledge accumulation. One manner by which this may be accomplished is meta-analysis, which provides a valuable quantitative summary of the available literature (→Schmidt and Hunter 2015). The problem of knowledge accumulation, however, presents one of the largest challenges to the newer methods mentioned in this chapter, as many of them produce effect size information that cannot be meta-analyzed. As we move forward with increasingly sophisticated methods, researchers will need to think about how results produced using these newer methods can be synthesized. The increase in methodological sophistication may be of little value if results produced using these newer methods cannot be accumulated.

In conclusion, we hope that this chapter demonstrates the value and diversity of quantitative approaches for organizational communication researchers. For those who may be new to any of these quantitative approaches, we also hope that this discussion assists in using these techniques mindfully and productively. When combined with other methodologies (e.g., qualitative methods), we believe that the rigor and vibrancy of organizational communication scholarship will be enhanced considerably.

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Chapter 5 Qualitative Methods in Organizational Communication

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Abstract

This chapter identifies key characteristics in qualitative methods such as an abductive iterative logic, gestalt, and bricolage. The chapter highlights markers of quality for qualitative research, such as self-reflexivity, thick description, multi-vocality, and aesthetic representation. It reviews and provides organizational communication examples of primary qualitative genres including grounded theory, case study, ethnography, phenomenology, participatory action research, narrative, and arts-based approaches. Furthermore, it details key types of data gathering, such as interviews, fieldwork, textual analysis, photo/video elicitation, and diaries, as well as analysis methods such as phronetic iterative qualitative data analysis (PIQDA), narrative, metaphor, and discourse tracing analyses. Throughout the chapter, we provide an original analysis of organizational communication qualitative research published in *Management Communication Quarterly* between 2010 and 2020. Additionally, using this analysis, we overview the subject matters, processes, and behaviors examined in organizational communication qualitative research. The chapter closes by discussing a key challenge and opportunity for organizational communication qualitative research into the future.

Keywords: qualitative, methodology, ethnography, fieldwork, interview, grounded theory, phenomenology, narrative,

iterative, rigor, metaphor, discourse, ethics, ethnocentrism,

Organizational communication and qualitative research methods have been scholarly companions since the 1980s' interpretive turn in the discipline of communication (→Taylor and Trujillo 2001; →Tracy and Geist-Martin 2013). The 1981 Alta conference spurred disciplinary conversations regarding the promise of analyzing organizational rituals, scripts, performances, and stories. With critical work in the 1990s and 2000s, researchers increasingly used qualitative methods to understand resistance and ideology (e.g., →Ashcraft 2005) among other power-laden phenomena. Since then, organizational scholars continue to lead qualitative research methods, in part because they have questioned, expanded, and pushed back upon normative assumptions (→Gist-Mackey and Kingsford 2020; →Jensen et al. 2020). The latest published methodological meta-analysis of *Management Communication Quarterly* (MCQ) (→Stephens 2017) reveals that approximately two thirds of empirical articles published from 2001 to 2015 used some qualitative methods – becoming the dominant methodological approach in the area of organizational communication.

The goal of this chapter is to introduce key tenets, contexts, and trends of qualitative research that may be useful to organizational communication scholars. It opens by identifying and defining key characteristics of qualitative scholarship such as an abductive iterative logic, gestalt, and bricolage. The chapter also highlights markers of high-quality qualitative research, such as creating self-reflexivity, thick description, multi-vocality, and aesthetic representation. It reviews and provides examples of primary qualitative genres including grounded theory, case study, ethnography, phenomenology, participatory action research, narrative inquiry, and creative and arts-based approaches, as well as key types of data gathering and analytical approaches. Throughout the chapter, we draw from our original analysis of

qualitative organizational communication scholarship published in MCQ between 2010 and 2020 highlighting collective attributes of organizational communication qualitative research. The chapter closes by discussing a key opportunity for future organizational communication qualitative research.

Tracking trends in organizational communication qualitative research, we conducted an analysis of a decade of MCQ publications. We reference this analysis throughout the chapter providing insight into contemporary trends of qualitative organizational communication research. We downloaded and coded 363 files representing all publications in MCQ between 2010 and 2020. Using NVivo qualitative analysis software, we first ran a text query for the word "qualitative", its stem words, and synonyms. Based on this analysis, the data set revealed that 52.3% (n=190) of the published files downloaded from MCQ mention qualitative research. Each of the 190 manuscripts were coded for: (1) year published, (2) qualitative methodology, (3) type of data, (4) type of analysis, (5) type of verification, (6) theories used, and (7) subject matter. Of those 190 files, 142 incorporated some kind of qualitative data (i.e., interviews, field notes, etc.). The remaining 42 mentioned qualitative research as an opportunity for future research, for instance, but were typically either forum publications not incorporating data or quantitative studies. We use MCQ as a proxy for publications in organizational communication and realize this is only one outlet within which qualitative organizational communication scholarship is published, therefore it is an imperfect snapshot, yet remains the closest peer-reviewed journal that is a metaphorical home for organizational communication.

1 Unique Value of Qualitative Scholarship in

Organizational Communication

Qualitative research is uniquely valuable to the organizational communication discipline. Through narratives and thick description, qualitative research draws readers into first-person understanding and empathy. Additionally, fieldwork can reveal tacit knowledge participants might not explicitly articulate, yet is evident in patterns, practices, and ritualized behaviors. Qualitative research is excellent for revealing how processes unfold over time, for example, in terms of employee socialization (e.g., →Woo and Myers 2020) and leadership progression (→e.g. Dutta 2018). Further, qualitative research is appropriate for research questions asking “what kind”, “how”, and “why”, and for researchers who are drawn to answer questions with thick description, narrative, and rich explanations, that are constructed through texts, interviews, fieldwork, diaries, and arts-based research. Qualitative research is marked by key characteristics which we review below.

Qualitative research tends to be *inductive* or *iterative* in nature. Researchers begin studies with broad questions, such as “what is going on here?” in relation to a social phenomenon. Qualitative researchers also explore specific experiences to elucidate, such as decision-making (e.g., →Gist-Mackey and Guy 2019) or bullying (e.g., →Tye-Williams and Krone 2015). They do not assume that they know exactly what to be examining or the exact theoretical focus until they listen and learn from the context at hand. Then, over time, qualitative research narrows in focus, as researchers iteratively return to literature, from which they may gather *sensitizing concepts* – ideas and theories that serve as lenses sensitizing them to particular foci (→Charmaz 2014). Like a funnel, qualitative researchers begin broad, but after iteratively returning to emergent data, broad research

questions narrow and become more connected to theory, subsequently explanations of phenomena begin to emerge.

Qualitative researchers – especially ethnographers – often rely on naturalistic data: stories, behaviors, rituals, and performances that occur naturally during organizing. For example, through his fieldwork with pediatric personnel at a children's hospital, →Barley, Treem, and Leonardi (2020) explicated moment-by-moment choices that helped employees stage their work authoritatively – insights only available through naturalistic data and would have been hidden or conflated in post-hoc recollection via surveys or interviews.

These inductive, iterative, and naturalistic characteristics explain why qualitative research also is characterized by notions of *gestalt* and *bricolage*. Qualitative research is richly enmeshed within diverse contexts and provides meaningful explanations of phenomena. Qualitative research aims toward providing a *gestalt* picture of how phenomena occur in relationship to one another, as integrated into a form, shape, or story. *Gestalt* is a German phrase that is loosely translated into the word figure or form. Such a framework suggests that analysis of organizational issues includes attention to the broader context, landscape, or background. For instance, →Dougherty and colleagues (2018) examined the phenomenon of food insecurity as a gestalt in relation to the context of unemployment. Often, researchers cannot know from the beginning which aspects of the scene will be needed to create meaningful stories or explanations. As such, they become expert *bricoleurs*; like quilters, they stitch together various strands of data available, making do and interweaving to create useful synthesis and research-based knowledge.

Given these key characteristics of qualitative research – inductive, iterative, gestalt, bricolage – it is natural that sampling plans, data collection procedures, and research questions are emergent, and (re)developed along the way.

Foci of qualitative research are influenced by the scene, not just from a priori research interests or theories. Further, there are key markers of quality and meaningfulness in qualitative research.

Many different researchers have created typologies outlining criteria for quality while others have argued preoccupation with rigor is problematic (e.g., →Smith and McGannon 2017). Indeed, many seemingly objective guidelines for merit and excellence, when examined closely, privilege Eurocentric, positivist, patriarchal, and Western ways of accomplishing research (→Cruz and Sodeke 2021). That said, most researchers seem to agree that qualitative research can be powerful, influential, and trustworthy when scholars engage practices such as self-reflexivity, thick description, multi-vocality, and aesthetic representation.

As discussed in →Tracy's (2010) "big-tent" model for qualitative quality *self-reflexivity* asks researchers to carefully consider, thoughtfully engage, and share ways in which their past experiences, viewpoints, identities, and roles influence their research. *Thick description*, a concept developed by anthropologist Clifford Geertz, refers to the quality of rich contextual immersive description allowing readers to enter the scene. For example, in field notes researchers might demonstrate *thick description* by showing rather than telling, allowing readers to draw contextually relevant conclusions. →Cruz's (2016) rich fieldnotes bring post-conflict Liberia to life; just a short snippet illustrates: "Upon entering the main mud road leading to the market, several young men perched on motorcycles bearing American insignia, haggled passers, offering their taxi services" (p. 220). Such scholarship is also strengthened via hearing about the scene from multiple stakeholders offering viewpoints – a quality known as *multi-vocality*.

Qualitative research is enhanced through *aesthetic*, evocative, and beautiful writing. Indeed, qualitative

researchers do not “write up” research any more than artists “paint up” or “sculpt up” art. Rather, through writing, as a method of inquiry (via fieldnotes, analytic memos, and manuscript drafts) scholarship comes into being. Aesthetic writing may be as simple as writing in accessible ways for readers and may use specific literary styles, including evocative storytelling and poetry, helping readers tap into emotions, identities, experiences, and bodies (see →Herrmann 2020).

Many organizational communication qualitative researchers articulate methods of qualitative credibility (→Tracy 2010). Disclosing qualitative credibility conveys how the research can be deemed rigorous and trustworthy. In our analysis of MCQ publications between 2010 and 2020, we tracked types of verification scholars used to convey credibility in manuscripts. There were 55 manuscripts that named/described qualitative verification. The most popular verification, described in 20 manuscripts, was *peer debrief* when research teams negotiate findings either among themselves or by bringing in outside readers to vet findings. The second most common approach was *member checks*, also known as member reflections, mentioned in 18 publications, where researchers shared findings with small subsets of the participants asking them to confirm, provide feedback, or reject findings. The third most popular method was *triangulation*, where researchers corroborated more than one type of data to arrive at findings, described in 16 manuscripts. Other methods of verification included: *negative case analysis*, *thick description*, and *prolonged engagement* in the field. Please note that at times studies reported using multiple methods of verification indicating a desire to demonstrate trustworthiness of the research.

Qualitative research is typically marked by several features that characterize it as unique and meaningful. A number of these features are further exemplified when considering how

qualitative research unfolds via specific methodologies or qualitative genres.

2 Genres in Qualitative Research

Qualitative research is diverse, and most research cannot be neatly categorized. In this section, we'll discuss foundational qualitative genres (→Tracy 2020), sometimes referred to as qualitative methodologies or traditions (→Bhattacharya 2017; →Creswell and Poth 2018). Some scholars choose a specific genre first, and then design their research with that area's tenets, philosophical assumptions, and criteria. Others move forward with a general research question or topic and then turn to the genres as loose guiding heuristics. We review these genres roughly in the order of those that tend to be more realist and foundational to those more closely associated with interpretive paradigms to those that are more critical in nature. Genres have multiple manifestations, and so this overview should serve as a primer to engage in more focused study for genres that seem salient. Below we give a concise overview of case study, grounded theory, ethnography, phenomenology, participatory action research, narrative, and creative arts-based approaches.

Case studies are in-depth descriptive analyses of naturally occurring phenomena in a specific and bounded contextual scene. The boundaries of case study research can be made regarding, for instance, a specific incident, time period, organization, or group. Researchers turn to case study for four primary reasons: "(1) description, (2) hypothesis generation or theory development, (3) hypothesis and theory testing, and (4) development of normative theory" (→Schwandt and Gates 2018: 346). Various research methods can be used to accomplish any one of the goals, including interviews, observation, and even surveys. That said, case studies rely on strategic and carefully considered arguments about the value

of the specific boundaries of the case so that its analysis effectively contributes to larger theoretical concerns, a process called *casing* (→Ragin 1992). As noted by →Stake (2000), "case study is not a methodological *choice*, but a choice of what is to be studied" (p. 435). One quick way to see if case study tenets are useful is to ask what boundaries define the scope of the case.

Grounded theory, which aims toward rigorous theory building from the "ground up", is among the most often cited qualitative research methodologies. Indeed, many people cite grounded theory and →Glaser and Strauss (1967) without acknowledging its post-positivist leanings or without closely interrogating the largely impossible original tenet that researchers enter the scene as a *tabula rasa* (blank slate). When most organizational communication scholars today refer to grounded theory, they are actually using a more iterative constructivist approach (→Charmaz 2014), characterized by simultaneous data collection and analysis examining dynamic relationships between meaning and action. In our review of qualitative research published in MCQ between 2010 and 2020, grounded theory approaches were cited in 30.2% of qualitative studies that named a specific analytic technique.

Grounded theory is also guided by specific analytic techniques that are thought to lead to rigor such as the constant comparative method, theoretical sampling, saturation, and writing analytic memos. It is important to note that several of these analytic techniques have become so common across qualitative research in organizational communication that many scholars use them across different genres and often use constant comparative or analytic memos as signs of rigor even though they were developed and fit most precisely with grounded theory methodology. A good way of knowing whether grounded theory may be useful is to consider this heuristic: does this research study explain *why*

and *how* a phenomenon occurs? This is a good heuristic because it reminds scholars that grounded theory is about *explanation*, not solely description.

Ethnography, a third common genre of qualitative research, is typically characterized by immersive fieldwork and observation into a particular cultural context in which the researcher explores a range of cultural aspects, language use, rituals, norms, and artifacts. Organizational scholars have been leaders in this method within the communication discipline, with researchers pursuing ethnographic studies of gay bars, grassroots organizing, cruise ships, airlines, unemployment agencies, and automotive industries – contexts in which they also served as full or partial participants themselves (e.g., →Branton and Compton 2021; →Gist-Mackey 2018; →Jensen et al. 2020). There are also different types of ethnography, including organizational ethnography, digital ethnography, critical ethnography, and autoethnography among others. It is common to hear organizational researchers use the phrase "ethnographic methods" when employing methods like observation and interviews but focus on specific phenomena rather than entire cultures and may not be immersive participants themselves (e.g., →Zanin and Bisel 2018). The 1980s interpretive turn in organizational communication was largely based upon the power of studying organizational performances (→Pacanowsky and O'Donnell-Trujillo 1983) as part of organizational culture, such as →Treem's (2016) ethnographic fieldwork that demonstrates how knowledge workers perform organizational expertise.

A strand of ethnography, specific to the discipline of communication, is ethnography of communication, developed by →Hymes (1962) in which researchers study a culture's distinctive interactions, speech codes, and contextual decision-making norms for what can be said, not said, by whom, when, where, and how. Ethnography of communication typically

combines fieldwork with close analysis of discourse (→Tracy and Robles 2013). As such, researchers not only engage in fieldwork, but often record and closely analyze speech in meetings, phone calls, or doctor's appointments, for instance. In doing so, they emerge with descriptions and interpretations of cultural norms for speech, and explanations for how certain assumed phenomena are talked into being through interactions over time.

Phenomenology, another genre of qualitative research, focuses on richly describing the experiential essence of phenomena elucidating how phenomena are lived in situ. A quick heuristic for knowing if a phenomenological study is appropriate is if the study centralizes the essence or experience of a particular phenomenon, such as "shaking hands, illness, sexual arousal, bullying, or texting" (→Tracy 2020: 65). In typical everyday life, phenomenologists (e.g., →Heidegger [1927] 1962) would contend that most people experience these and other phenomena in a state of "tranquilized obviousness" or autopilot complacency. In contrast, phenomenological interviews help participants become self-aware. To do this well, researchers are encouraged to "bracket" their everyday assumptions and biases, and work to transcend their habits of seeing so that they may encounter an experience with wonder and child-like curiosity. →McAllum (2014) provides an excellent example of phenomenology, which examined the experience of volunteering. Her interviews allowed participants to encounter and make sense of volunteering experiences in explicit and intentional ways, which revealed how volunteering is laden with meanings of freedom and obligation.

As another qualitative genre, participatory action research moves qualitative research from describing phenomena to working collaboratively with research participants (also known as "co-researchers") to address local problems. Researchers in this tradition work toward transformation through activities

like: planning and executing strategic plans for change, observing and reflecting on the change process and consequences, and serving and laboring on behalf of participants (→Huffman 2013; →Kemmis and McTaggart 2005). Participatory action research in the communication discipline has blossomed at the intersections of organizational and health communication, as researchers work alongside participants moving toward practical solutions addressing, for instance, inequities among rural poor (→Dutta and Dutta 2013) or unsheltered populations (→Huffman 2013). The goal of this type of research is to honor community wisdom and make use of theoretical knowledge to create practical change and community action.

Narrative, personal narrative, and autoethnography – although all distinct in their own ways – cohere together in their commitment toward the power of storytelling and story-living to explore the texture of human experience. Narrative approaches capture curiosity, conflict, surprise, resolution, and sometimes indecision. Narratives are marked by three characteristics: (1) temporal sequence and plot; (2) an audience (real/imagined); and (3) a complicating action (→Goodall 2008). Similar to other qualitative genres, narratives may be based on data gathered through field notes, interviews, textual materials, diaries, or one's own personal memories via autoethnography (→Herrmann 2020). Narrative research pays close attention to the ways people talk about themselves and others as actors in scenes – each actor with agency, purpose, striving for coherence and sensemaking, but potentially also grappling with wrenching doubt. One powerful organizational communication narrative analysis revealed how whistleblowers in a Texas Public School System "experience 'the abyss', a dark and looming outer limit of experience characterized by chaos", which led to identifying whistle-blower identities: crusader, citizen, mom, and popularity seeker (→Gravley, Richardson, and Allison

2015). →Gravely, Richardson, and Allison's (2015) narrative analysis elucidated why whistle-bowers choose to disclose, retaliate, and constitute new identities. In doing so, this and other organizational narratives, especially those in autoethnographic forms, are written in aesthetic ways that often move the "heart and the belly", as well as the "head" (→Bochner 2000: 271). Narratives can be transformational and life-giving for the writer (→López and Tracy 2020) while leaving readers with increased empathy and identification, feeling like they have also experienced, known, and can better live because of the story told.

Finally, another genre of qualitative research is arts-based research (ABR) or creative approaches. One strand of this research is performance and ethnotheatre (→Saldaña 2011). ABR has often used actual theater and film as a method to represent qualitative research, such as the film *The Acoustics of Care* (→Harter, Quinlan, and Shaw 2016), which shows how performance artists transform hospital practices into healing spaces. Another strand of ABR occurs through data collection through asking participants to draw, sculpt, take photography, or engage in collage-making. For example, in her research on a transgender outreach center, →Eger (2021) led a focus group where participants made sense of their indigenous trans identities through collage-making. ABR emphasizes artistic practice as a way of exploring, knowing, and representing (→Barone and Eisner 2012). Artistic approaches of data collection are especially useful for those who are not able or willing to tell their story in a verbal and linear way (or conversely, are so over-rehearsed with practiced scripts that new meaning is unlikely to emerge without encouraging people to new imaginings through art) (→Tracy and Malvini Redden 2016).

The trends regarding most common methodologies used in MCQ publications between 2010 and 2020 provide insight into qualitative organizational communication research. Our

analysis revealed that qualitative articles in organizational communication are dominant; nearly 40% of all published manuscripts in MCQ between 2010 and 2020 contained at least some qualitative approaches. In regard to methodology, the majority of qualitative studies published in MCQ over the past decade did not identify a single specific qualitative genre or methodology. The top five methodologies mentioned were case study (n=15), ethnography (n=13), mixed methods (n=10), narrative (n=7), and content analysis (n=5). However, a number of other qualitative methodologies were also used less frequently, including, but not limited to: interpretive, discourse analysis, participatory research, phronetic iterative, language/message production, rhetorical, phenomenological, and grounded theory. Interestingly enough, these categories are not mutually exclusive. Often publications combine methodologies, like ethnographic case study (e.g., →Kopaneva and Cheney 2019).

Further, our analysis did point to compelling observations. For example, there were no narrative studies published between 2018 and 2020 in MCQ and no phenomenological studies published between 2015 and 2020. Further, our findings reveal that only 60 publications in MCQ (out of 142 qualitative manuscripts) identified their scholarship as aligned with a particular qualitative genre/methodology. This may demonstrate that the salience of naming a methodology may no longer be integral to contemporary qualitative training throughout the discipline of organizational communication, or that people increasingly use umbrella approaches such as phronetic iterative qualitative data analysis (Tracy, Gist-Mackey, and Dehnert, 2024). It certainly indicates that naming one's methodology is not required for publishing qualitative work. This diminishing trend however, in no way indicates a decline in the use of qualitative methods in organizational communication or in the quality of qualitative scholarship. Many manuscripts using the qualitative genres reviewed here,

often incorporate multiple types of qualitative data; next we review commonplace data gathering and analysis methods.

3 Common Data Gathering and Analysis Methods

Qualitative researchers gather and analyze data in a variety of manners. Each method reviewed below could be paired with many of the qualitative methodologies named above. Here we review dominant approaches, including interviews, fieldwork (also manifest as participation, observation, or witnessing), textual/artifact analysis, photo/video elicitation, and diaries. We then explore how researchers make meaning from qualitative data, through analysis practices including phronetic iterative, grounded, narrative, thematic, metaphor, and discourse tracing.

The trends regarding most common data type used in MCQ publications between 2010 and 2020 are highlighted in →Table 1. Interviews continue to be the most common form of data collection, followed by observation/fieldwork, then textual/artifact data, and open-ended written responses (see →Table 1). Of the manuscripts published in MCQ between 2010 and 2020, 39% (n=142) of publications in MCQ over the past decade incorporated qualitative data. The types of qualitative data included interviews (n=92), fieldwork/observation (n=46), textual/artifact data (e.g., documents, artifacts) (n=37), open-ended written responses (e.g., essays, message creation) (n=11), transcripts of public social interaction (n=5), photo/video data (n=4), social media content (n=4), personal autoethnographic narratives (n=2). Interview and fieldwork/observation data were the most consistently used across the decade being published every single year between 2010 and 2020. These trends point to potentially underused methods of data collection like diary/journal-based data collection, as well as more artistic data like photography, collage, or illustration/drawing.

Table 1: Qualitative Scholarship in *Management Communication Quarterly* between 2010 and 2020.

Methodological practice	**Number of papers 2010–2020 / Percentage of manuscripts published**
Manuscripts that incorporated some type of qualitative data out of all manuscripts published in MCQ from 2010 to 2020	142/363 39%
Of the qualitative scholarship published in MCQ, manuscripts that used **interviewing** (dyadic or group) data alone or in combination with other method(s)	96/142 67%
Of the qualitative scholarship published in MCQ, manuscripts that used some type of **fieldwork or observation** on own or in combination with other method(s)	46/142 32%
Of the qualitative scholarship published in MCQ, manuscripts that used some type of **textual/artifact analysis** on own or in combination with other method(s)	37/142 26%

Note: Numbers of published manuscripts that included some type of qualitative data in *Management Communication Quarterly* between 2010 and 2020.

Interviews are the most commonly used source of qualitative data across multiple disciplines, including organizational communication. According to our analysis, a range of six to thirteen publications using interviews were published annually over the last decade in MCQ. Interviews can be dyadic or groups – and are characterized by a guided conversation or "inter-change of views [...] conversing on a theme of mutual interest" (→Brinkmann and Kvale 2015: 4). Interviews are valuable for providing participant accounts, explanations, and stories in a targeted manner (→Tracy 2020). An example of an interview study in the field of organizational communication is titled, *The Mutual Constitution of Social Media Use and Status Hierarchies in Global Organizing*. In this study, →Kim (2018)

analyzed 32 interviews and over 1,000 enterprise social media posts to provide an account of the mutual constitution of technology use and status hierarchies in a global organization.

Organizational communication scholars have been disciplinary leaders in fieldwork methods, observing interaction in real time and witnessing daily organizational routines. Fieldworkers may have a number of roles, from being full members of the group they study to being complete observers. No matter the role, it is important to realize that fieldwork is an act of witnessing, complete with the powerful effects of watching and being watched (→Tracy 2020). Fieldwork is an effective method for ground-up research, elucidating actions and behaviors that organizational members may not otherwise discuss or purposefully reflect upon. For example, in →Cooper and Shumate's (2012) study, they used ethnographic observation in tandem with interviews and social network analysis to study an interorganizational collaboration among gender-based violence non-governmental organizations (NGO) in Zambia. Cooper served as an unpaid intern in the NGO observing employees, many of whom were interviewed, at events and meetings in real time.

Textual/artifact analysis is another popular method of data gathering. Texts such as speech transcripts, social media posts, news stories, newsletters, mission statements, corporate social responsibility web pages, websites, performance scripts, or advertisements as well as artifacts such as computer equipment, artwork, fashion, or furniture can be studied qualitatively. Textual/artifact analysis is often associated with rhetorical analysis and cultural studies; with the blossoming area of participatory critical rhetoric questioning how texts reify or resist ideologies in specific historical, political, and cultural moments (→McKinnon et al. 2016). For example, →Fredriksson and Edwards (2019) conducted a textual analysis of 357 policy and strategy documents from 188 Swedish national public agencies to

explore, “how transparency and consistency coexist, but are translated into local settings in divergent ways” (p. 548).

Earlier in this chapter we introduced arts-based research (ABR) as a key qualitative genre. Here we want to highlight visuals and arts as empirical materials. Working with artistic materials – whether those include clay, collage materials, paints, or LEGO blocks – provides participants with accessible ways to collaborate, share power, and co-create knowledge (→Tracy and Malvini Redden 2016). Asking participants to take photos or videos of their experience provides a first-hand (*verstehen*) understanding of organizational life. →Wilhoit Larson (2020), for example, combined photo-elicitation and interview methods to “allow for multiple meanings to exist and invite self-expression” (p. 305) in the study of workspaces.

Finally, diaries can be a powerful qualitative research method, especially when examining synchronous interaction via interviews or observation is impossible. Researchers can prompt participants with intermittent emails, text messages, and social media posts, and participants can respond with written entries, photographs, or video diaries. In a study of workplace gossip in healthcare organizations, →Waddington (2012) used diaries to explore gossip among nurses. However, a word of caution: crafting materials for asynchronous diaries requires significant participant motivation, which may be accomplished through material research incentives, intrinsic interest, or feelings of loyalty toward the research(er) (→Tracy 2020). Despite these important concerns, diaries can be a rich way to access experiences and are an underutilized method of data collection.

As we have discussed so far in this section, qualitative organizational communication researchers rely on a range of data types and analysis methods. If researchers know their qualitative genre from the outset, it can provide a good map for data analysis choices (→Creswell and Poth 2018). However, many people enter a qualitative study without knowing

immediately whether their study will be best poised to develop grounded theory, elucidate phenomenological experience, or tell a story.

The good news is that qualitative research design can be emergent and analytic choices can be made along the way. Phronetic iterative qualitative data analysis, also known as PIQDA, (→Tracy 2018, →2020; Tracy, Gist-Mackey, and Dehnert, 2024) provides an umbrella analytic technique that draws from, but is distinct from grounded analysis techniques (→Charmaz 2014). It can be used on its own or in combination with other qualitative genres and analytic approaches. *Phronesis* is focused on creating practical wisdom. *Iterative* is a concept that refers to an abductive approach, back and forth between emergent data and reflections on one hand, and consideration of a priori theories and research concerns on the other (→Srivastava and Hopwood 2009). PIQDA (see →Tracy 2018: 74–75) overlaps with and draws from grounded theory (→Charmaz 2014), thematic analysis (→Ryan and Bernard 2003), and coding (→Saldaña 2016). Between 2010 and 2020, 26 qualitative studies published in MCQ incorporated a phronetic iterative approach to analysis and this approach seems to be increasing in use over time (2010–2013 n=5; 2014–2017 n=7; 2018–2020 n=14). PIQDA serves as a good base for more specific analysis techniques, several of which we discuss next, such as narrative inquiry, metaphor analysis, and discourse tracing.

Narrative analysis examines stories – whether that be stories of a person or group, an organization, experience, or phenomenon. Using narrative inquiry typically includes techniques such as identifying the story's complicating factor, plot-line, purpose, characters, context/setting, moral, and resolution (→Labov and Waletzky 1997). →Tye-Williams and Krone (2015) analyzed the narratives of targets of workplace bullying and identified three different narrative types: chaos, report, and quest narratives. Their research provides insight

into how coworkers can better listen to and support targets of workplace bullying.

Metaphor analysis is an intrinsically communicative approach in which researchers examine how participants compare one thing (e.g., an organization) to another (e.g., a machine, a family). Most people regularly use metaphors without thinking about it, but in their identification and reflection, researchers can access the frames and lenses through which people are understanding or living through certain phenomena. →Malvini Redden and colleagues (2019), for example, examined the metaphors used by team members as they made sense of a planned organizational change process. By tracing how members likened the change to "lipstick on a pig" (p. 509) and "bureaucratic bullshit" (p. 516), researchers were able to identify how feelings of resiliency, success, and identification differed among various teams and how framings changed over time.

Discourse tracing is a complex analytic technique that draws from case study, critical theory, and discourse from the micro, meso, and macro levels. Discourse tracers choose a particular case in which a change process unfolds (e.g., a policy change, or organizational turning point), and then examine data chronologically, looking for ways different levels of discourse interact with and influence one another over time. Examples include →LeGreco's (2012) research where she studied how policy about a local school lunch program interacted with children's lunchroom behavior and media stories about healthy eating.

In our analysis of MCQ publications between 2010 and 2020, 35.5% (n=130) of the publications clearly identified a specific approach to qualitative analysis. It is important to note that a small number of manuscripts (n=12), which identified types of qualitative data collected, did not articulate how data was analyzed. Of the essays that named an analysis approach, the following analysis types were most common: constant

comparative/grounded analysis (n=39), computer-assisted analysis (n=30), thematic analysis (n=27), iterative analysis (n=26). Other types of analysis used with less frequency included: narrative, critical, discourse, textual, conversation analysis. Please note these frequencies are not mutually exclusive. For instance, computer-assisted analysis was used with various analytical approaches including, but not limited to content analysis, thematic analysis, and phronetic iterative analysis, among others. The most common computer-aided analysis programs named were Atlas.ti and NVivo.

In this section, we reviewed powerful ways to collect and analyze qualitative data. There is no one correct combination. Researchers must take inventory of personal proclivities (e.g., do they find fieldwork exhilarating/anxiety-laden?; should they tell stories and/or offer thick description?), assess availability of emergent data (e.g., what empirical materials are available for this topic?), and most importantly, consider which data and analysis processes are best poised to answer research question(s).

4 Contours of Current Organizational Communication Qualitative Research

Qualitative organizational communication research is robust, exploring an intellectually diverse array of communication subject matter, behaviors, and processes. The contours of contemporary qualitative organizational communication research are complicated given the breadth and depth of the field. We realize MCQ is but one outlet, but we do believe our analysis measures the metaphorical pulse of the contours of the organizational communication discipline and how scholars have conducted qualitative research within our academic community.

We coded 61 unique subject areas that were explored qualitatively in organizational communication research

between 2010 and 2020 in MCQ publications indicating that the discipline has a great amount of breadth in its subject matter. Please note that many manuscripts address more than one subject matter area, so the numbers reported here are not mutually exclusive, but do provide heuristic insight. Subject matter that only appeared in one manuscript includes topics such as temporality, spatiality, violence, memorable messages, mentoring, and organizational justice among others, indicating perhaps such subjects are published in other outlets or are understudied.

By far the most popular subject studied was related to identity/identification. Thirty different manuscripts engaged identity/identification as central to their research. These studies included exploring organizational identity (e.g., →Ban 2017), professional identities (e.g., →Garcia and Barbour 2018), underrepresented identities (→Shenoy-Packer 2015), and volunteer identities (→Meisenbach and Kramer 2014) among others. The second most popular subject matter studied was assimilation/socialization with nine manuscripts exploring, for instance, the experiences of organizational members in human service organizations (→Jensen and Meisenbach 2015) and zoos (→Kramer and Danielson 2016). The third most popular subject was emotions, a topic appearing in eight manuscripts examining, for instance, experiences of emotional taint (e.g., →Rivera 2015).

We also analyzed theories. Many qualitative manuscripts used more than one theoretical framework, so the numbers reported here are not mutually exclusive, but do provide heuristic insight. The most popular theoretical framework was the Communicative Constitution of Organizations (CCO) perspective, used in 18 unique manuscripts. CCO research incorporated the four flows model, sociomateriality, and ventriloquism among other CCO concepts. Identity/identification theories were the second most popular theoretical frameworks used in 17 manuscripts. These

included, but were not limited to: social identity theory, self-categorization theory, communication theory of identity, identity work/negotiation theories, and place identity theory among others. Coming in third with 13 manuscripts were critical theories, which we coded to include feminist and postcolonial theories. These theoretical foci are unsurprising given their interpretive and critical leanings, which lend themselves to qualitative research.

Analyzing types of organizational contexts studied in MCQ was challenging. Many studies simply recruited workers/employees as participants not specifying a particular profession/industry given the focus and scope of particular research studies. These studies were simply coded under 'workplaces' while specific types of workplaces studied were captured under subordinate codes, such as multinational corporations, consulting firms, and dirty work, which together accounted for 38 manuscripts. The second most popular context was non-profits, appearing in 22 manuscripts, for instance human service organizations (e.g., →McNamee and Petersen 2014) and policy non-profits (e.g., →Mitra 2018) among others. Educational contexts were third most popular with 15 manuscripts, including studies that exclusively recruited students as participants and those that studied educational enterprises (e.g., →Deline 2019) and institutions of higher education (e.g., →Dempsey 2010) among others. Other organizational contexts included governmental contexts, terrorist organizations, housing/residential communities, social organizations, and athletics/sports organizations, for example. Qualitative organizational communication scholars tend to gravitate toward work and non-profit contexts more than other contexts (perhaps due to access); workplace and non-profit contexts were published every year in MCQ between 2010 and 2020.

5 Looking toward the Future

Linking from the prior sections, key opportunities for future research include increased focus using data, theories or contexts that are currently underrepresented in the field, in general. That said, we want to especially highlight another key opportunity. Namely, our analysis of MCQ publications from 2010 to 2020 revealed a range of cultural contexts represented in the literature including, but not limited to, scholarship in African, Asian, Caribbean, European, and South American organizational contexts. However, the prevailing cultural context is still situated in North America, and predominantly in the United States. Thus, organizational communication research is still privileging Western and Eurocentric experiences. Organizational communication has much to offer in terms of "debunking eurocentrism" (→Cruz and Sodeke 2021) and in decolonial ways of knowing (→Pal et al. 2022). Focusing on decolonial approaches will mean breaking down epistemological strongholds. Given this opportunity, organizational communication is well-positioned to shift the paradigm since critical, feminist, and postcolonial theories were the third most used frameworks in our analysis of MCQ publications between 2010 and 2020. In fact, studies using critical qualitative studies were published nearly every year between 2010 and 2020, except 2014 and 2019. Leaning into this opportunity will also require organizational communication qualitative researchers to harness ethical sensitivity even more regarding procedural, situational, cultural, and relational ethics (→Tracy 2020). We will need to be more mindful about representation, voice, equity, and justice as we work to better understand and dismantle hegemonic systems and structures, as well as amplifying the voices and experiences of those who are marginalized. This will require a new era of training in qualitative methods seminars across the globe. Further, scholars will benefit from

studying a range of international contexts, which is an exciting opportunity on which to embark. This could also open up a host of collaborative opportunities where scholars across continents are co-authoring and collaborating with one another yielding global insights and community.

6 Conclusion

This chapter addressed key tenets, contexts, examples, and trends of qualitative research in organizational communication aiming to demonstrate where the field has been and where it can potentially be in the future. Throughout, we share an original analysis of qualitative organizational communication scholarship published over the last decade highlighting popular subject matter, theories, methodologies, and methods. In closing, we hope this chapter has provided a metaphorical map and identified key opportunities for future organizational communication qualitative research.

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Section II: Processes

Chapter 6 Organizational Communication Design

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Abstract

The study of organizational communication as design (CAD) offers metatheoretical resources that are particularly valuable for the cultivation of more effective organizational communication practice. Communication design is natural, undertaken by individuals and collectives, and focused on objects of design. CAD research aims to identify what might be possible in organizing through the analysis of objects of communication design and the choices communicators make and try to carry out. This chapter reviews organizational CAD scholarship, and forwards an agenda for future scholarship that argues that CAD needs to grapple with (a) difficulties of terminology, (b) the complexity of goals inherent to communication design, especially given the proliferation of automated communication and machine communicators, and (c) contextual influences in communication design work.

Keywords: design, collective communication design, applied communication, engaged research, organizational change, interaction design, meetings, facilitation, temporality, power, activity cycles, practice,

Organizations design communication.[1] In the last 50 years, the sheer number of occupations that focus on design, and especially the design of messages, interactive tools, and

communication formats, has grown dramatically (→Jackson and Aakhus 2014; →Julier 2017; →Nelson and Stolterman 2012). Information and interaction designers shape whom we talk to, what we say, the information we consume, the relationships that we build, sustain, and end, and the digital traces we leave behind at work and at play (→Rosner 2018; →Vasudevan 2020; →Zuboff 2019). Furthermore, in a fundamental sense, all organizational members make choices about how they will interact with each other, the messages they send to each other and stakeholders, how they share information and document organizational processes, and so forth.

In other words, communication design is an inherent feature of organizing (→Aakhus 2017; →Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018b). Preparing for disasters, facilitating public deliberation, responding to global pandemics, persuading stakeholders of the efficacy and legitimacy of organizational actions, navigating conflict, teamwork, and leadership all involve problems of communication design. For example, leaders frame organizational problems and solutions, create systems and strategies for listening and gathering information, plan how to communicate about organizational change, and set up systems of interaction for making sense and making decisions (e.g., →Fairhurst 2011; →Lewis 2019, →2020). Indeed, all of us are designers of communication in that producing communication is inherent to what it means to be human. Communication as design (CAD) is a metatheoretical framework that focuses on understanding the choices individuals and collectives make about communication, their efforts to realize them, and the effects they have (→Aakhus 2007; →Aakhus and Jackson 2005; →Jackson and Aakhus 2014).

CAD approaches hold particular value for organizational communication scholarship because CAD provides tools for intervening in and through communication (→Barbour, Gill,

and Barge 2018b; →Harrison 2014). Communication design "happens when there is an intervention into some ongoing activity through the invention of techniques, devices, and procedures that aim to redesign interactivity and thus shape the possibilities for communication" (→Aakhus 2007: 112). From its earliest days, organizational communication scholarship had a principal disciplinary concern for "real-life practice" (→Redding 1985: 15) and applied research (→Steimel 2014). This interest in improving communication and organizing, broadly conceived, holds across metatheoretical traditions (→Corman 2000), and designing organizational communication is a persistent challenge for applied, engaged, and practical organizational communication scholarship (→O'Hair et al. 2020).

Documenting the long-term importance of practical questions in organizational communication scholarship, →Tracy (2016) criticized the discipline for failing to develop "expertise in craft practice", referring to "the display, study, and training of practices that would create expert or masterful ways of organizing" (p. 3). Research aimed at making normative claims asks not just what is happening or what will happen, but "how people should behave if they wish to achieve desired outcomes and why" (→Goldsmith 2001: 515). CAD approaches address these commitments by focusing attention on communication choices. CAD scholarship includes research focused on what is, what ought to be, and what *might* be. That promise of what might be possible prompted →Jackson and Aakhus (2014) to argue that "the most important thing that can be learned from really creative design is *how else communication can be constituted*" (p. 3). CAD provides a framework for the study of communication through design, learning from the process of creating communication tools and formats as well as by studying the choices embodied in designs for communication and that unfold in design work (→Aakhus 2007). CAD approaches are

useful for cultivating the sort of masterful practice called for by Tracy, because by bringing analytical attention to the choices we make about communication, CAD generates insights for intervention, identifies theory and practice-based communication strategies, makes explicit taken-for-granted assumptions about why particular forms of communication work, or fail, and helps imagine new possibilities for communication.

This chapter reviews CAD scholarship with a focus on its relevance for organizational communication. We begin by defining communication design, explicating key concerns in CAD scholarship, and reviewing research examples to illustrate these concerns. The chapter concludes by highlighting important puzzles in CAD scholarship to offer an agenda for future research that focuses on solving problems of terminology, grappling with power, and accounting for importance of the context of communication design.

1 Communication as Design

We define communication design as making choices about communication to achieve goals in context (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018b). →Aakhus (2007) argued that communication design is "a natural, describable activity that is evident in ordinary communicators' creativity in language use and capacity to exploit mutual knowledge and principles of interaction" (p. 113). Communicators make choices that reflect design logics – their mental models of means-to-desired-ends relationships that connect particular communication choices and what they think those choices will produce (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018a; →O'Keefe 1988). Communication design logics are beliefs about how communication works (or should work) that reflect more and less sophisticated models of communication, and communicators draw on those logics to evaluate as well as produce communication (→Harrison 2014).

Communication design is “natural” in the sense that we make choices about communication all the time even though we may not be aware of them as such. Communication is inherently strategic and primarily automatic: communicators make choices that do not always involve elaborate deliberation or awareness of the choices as such, but they are goal-driven (→Kellermann 1992). In complex communication situations like interviewing for a job, making public remarks, or coordinating our communication with others, we tend to give communication choices more attention (→Barbour, Jacocks, and Wesner 2013; →Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018a; →O’Keefe 1988). Indeed, cultivating greater reflexivity is a principal intervention for becoming a more sophisticated communicator (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018b; →Schon 1984).

It is the focus on those choices and the processes of making those choices that distinguishes CAD research from communication research in general. CAD research focused on individuals might examine the cognitive, emotional, and communicative processes involved in communication design and how they relate to the effects of communication choices. For example, that might include research on the discrete messages produced to implement or respond to organizational change (→Barbour, Jacocks, and Wesner 2013; →Lewis 2019; →Malvini Redden et al. 2019) or worksite health promotion campaign messages (→Harrison et al. 2011; →James and Zoller 2018). For example, research on health campaigns tends to focus on campaign effects, and CAD would emphasize as well the processes of campaigning and how differences in campaigning can explain campaign outcomes (→Backer and Rogers 1993; →Harrison 2014). Research focused on communication processes and effects and research focused on design are related but distinct enterprises. CAD research is valuable for organizational

communication because it sheds light on the strategic efforts that may explain communication effects.

1.1 Collective Communication Design

Collective communication design (CCD) refers to communication choice-making undertaken by multiple actors at once, which should be of particular interest for organizational scholars (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018b). A team establishing a procedure for meetings, a group of students sorting out how they will tackle a question from an instructor in an online discussion forum, a pair of consultants disagreeing about how to organize the flow of a workshop, facilitators planning a public meeting, parents deciding how to talk to their children about a move across the country, and an organization crafting a public relations message or an organizational chart of who will report to whom, are all engaging in CCD (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018a). Organizational communication design logics are models of means-to-desired-ends relationships that connect specific communication choices and organizational expectations for what communication choices will produce. Examining CCD raises questions of how communicators coordinate multiple, potentially conflicting goals, and how choices are influenced by organizational power and authority negotiated in interaction about communication.

1.2 Objects of Communication Design

CAD research involves a focus on objects of communication design, such as messages, campaigns, processes, formats, tools, technologies, genres, workspaces, or career narratives (→Ballard, Inman-Ramgolam, and Solomon Gray 2017; →Eddington et al. 2020; →Orlikowski and Yates 1994). Objects of communication can be examined as specific, discrete

phenomena like specific campaign messages or communication platforms or by looking at broader, recognizable clusters of communication like campaigning or the features common across multiple platforms. For example, it can involve the study of the crafting of specific social support messages (→Caughlin et al. 2008) and also the collective negotiation of what counts as supportive communication (→Aakhus and Rumsey 2010). Likewise, organizational change may involve "structured implementation activities" in the sense that as "implementers make decisions about how to introduce change to stakeholders, they make basic and sometimes sophisticated choices of communication strategies" (→Lewis 2019: 156). Strategies can include specific messaging approaches aimed at persuading stakeholders or framing a change, and also communication techniques that aim to create capacity for change by building relationships among stakeholders. Looking at objects of communication design involves trying to understand the breadth and boundaries of choices inherent to communication and communicators' guesses about how communication works inherent to their choices (→Aakhus 2007).

1.3 Designable Features of Communication

The study of design objects also requires attending to the designable features of communication. They are the characteristics of design objects that people make communication choices about (see a discussion of designable features as key to design methods in →Aakhus and Jackson 2005: 423). The choices built into designs for communication can have profound implications. For example, civic engagement values can shape the sorts of choices made possible on deliberation platforms (→Brabham and Guth 2017). Replacing a "like" button with a "respect" button and

involving journalists in public conversations can have positive effects on public discourse (→Muddiman and Stroud 2017; →Stroud, Muddiman, and Scacco 2017), and efforts to make our engagement with social media "frictionless" can prey on our cognitive limitations to control and commodify us (→Vasudevan 2020; →Zuboff 2019). Even the oft-taken-for-granted practice of taking notes in public meetings can have implications for democracy (→Reinig and Sprain 2019). Indeed, human-computer interaction research places a central emphasis on "the creation and realization of interactive artifacts" that "include new systems, architectures, tools, toolkits, techniques, sketches, mockups, and envisionments that reveal new possibilities, enable new explorations, facilitate new insights, or compel us to consider new possible futures" (→Wobbrock and Kientz 2016: 40).

Designable features can be hard to identify, because empirical examples tend to focus on specific choices that have been made, not the range of options that might be possible. Once a feature is identified, practitioners and analysts alike can try to surface what other choices might be possible. For example, →Barbour and Gill (2014) enumerated the designable features of safety oversight meetings for nuclear power including "what to communicate; how much to communicate; and how to communicate, including expectations for turn-taking and timing; and for audience" (p. 177). They focused on a specific set of features, but the designable features of a given message, format, tool, or process are infinite in that they are limited only by the ability of communicators and analysts to see and describe communication and imagine what might be possible. Designable features are infinite in that messages, media content, and media technology are infinitely describable (→Jackson 1992; →Sundar 2020) and that language may be recombined to create an infinite number of communicative forms (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018a; →Jackson 1992).

Consider, for example, →Ramasubramanian, Sousa, and Gonlin's (2017) study of campus dialogues. They argued, "Specific communication design elements such as localized case studies, shared ground rules, expert facilitators, and role-play affect the nature and outcomes of dialogue sessions" (p. 15), which meant that describing those elements as part of a framework for such dialogues was of broad social importance. Although their list of the choices made about the campus dialogues was very detailed, it still captured only a fraction of the choices leaders, facilitators, and participants made or *might* have made before, during, and after the dialogue.

1.4 Design Work

CAD research also includes a focus on "design work" and what makes that design work more or less skillful or wise (→Aakhus 2007; →Jackson and Aakhus 2014). Design work can refer to the work of specific occupations such as journalists, platform designers, or meeting facilitators. For example, →Hedman-Phillips and Barge (2017) documented techniques used by facilitators to cultivate reflexivity about communication to support interventions into team interaction. Specific facilitation choices, such as framing the facilitation in terms of a shared responsibility for giving feedback about their communication and inquiring into the key issues of the team through systematic questioning guided by principles of critique and appreciative inquiry, improved team members' capacity for reflecting and intervening in their own communication practices. →Austin et al. (2020) found that the efficacy of instructors' and learning assistants' design work, making choices about communication to make the case for process change, depended on skills of adaptation, which allowed them to engage in "sensebreaking" and "sensegiving" (p. 307), or in other words, to articulate,

challenge, and reflect on existing processes and build on the communication choices that seemed to work.

2 CAD Research

With these concepts defined, the following section reviews CAD research exemplars by highlighting in them the objects of design, the designers making choices, the ostensible goals of designers, and the designable features or choices. The examples discussed are not comprehensive, but they highlight important domains and insights of CAD scholarship. The review illustrates the possibilities and challenges of CAD research for organizational communication.

The study of information, interaction, and communication technology design (→Aakhus and Jackson 2005; →Brabham and Guth 2017; →Rosner 2018; →Vasudevan 2020; →Wobbrock and Kientz 2016) including automated communication (→Bailey and Leonardi 2015; →Berkelaar 2017; →Darr 2018; →Leonardi 2012; →Shorey and Howard 2016) inspire questions of communication design, because the research focuses on choices for communication and what alternative choices might involve. The same holds for campaigns and ombuds processes (→Harrison 2014), organizational safety and reliability (→Barbour and Gill 2014), physical space and layout (→Dean, Gill, and Barbour 2016; →Kuhn and Burk 2014), the timing of work processes (→Ballard and McVey 2014; →Jensen, Rolison, and Barbour 2022), learning processes (→Austin et al. 2020; →Eddington et al. 2020; →Thompson, Steier, and Ostrinko 2014), community and family caregiving and social support (→Aakhus and Rumsey 2010; →Caughlin et al. 2008; →Donovan-Kicken, Tollison, and Goins 2012), and change implementation research (→Lewis 2019). Perhaps nowhere is the value of CAD clearer in organizational communication than in the study of

meetings and facilitation (consult Jahn and Khedekar, Chapter 17).

In general, CAD research involving meetings is focused on the ways in which meetings may be designed, how the design affects meeting dynamics, how those dynamics may modify design in process, and how facilitators make choices about communication in their interventions before, during, and after meetings. For example, →Reinig and Sprain (2019) defined them emphasizing that "meetings are designed contexts that use techniques, devices, and procedures to shape new possibilities for communication, making otherwise unlikely communication possible; democratic meetings are a design enterprise" (p. 648). →Poole (1991) reviewed "a wide array of meeting procedures designed to improve [decision making]" (p. 56), describing specific techniques such as Robert's Rules of Order, the Nominal Group Technique, Hall's Consensus Rules, Synectics, and the Delphi Technique. He then assessed each procedure in terms of its scope, restrictiveness, comprehensiveness, group control, and member involvement – designable features of meeting processes. →Wittenberg-Lyles et al. (2013) compared standard designs for interdisciplinary healthcare team meetings with one that included family caregivers, changing the makeup of the meeting. Including caregivers meant the meetings focused more on socioemotional talk, involved more relationship building, and lasted longer. In a similar way, →Sprain, Carcasson, and Merolla (2014) found that including experts in public deliberation may influence the extent to which participants engage in dialogue. Who gets included and how specific choices about communication are made shapes the form and nature of communication outcomes (→Ramasubramanian, Sousa, and Gonlin 2017). In contrast, →Lehmann-Willenbrock, Allen, and Kauffeld (2013) studied 59 teams across 19 organizations to examine the "functionality of procedural behaviors during team interaction processes in

organizational meetings" (p. 379). They found that procedural behaviors such as goal orientation, clarifying, procedural suggestions and questions, prioritizing, summarizing, and visualizing limited dysfunctional meeting behaviors like losing the train of thought, running a team member down, or complaining. This study compared with the previous exemplars is relevant for questions of design, but it is not concerned with a specific design for meetings or the design work of communicators who might try to cultivate more or less of them per se. Together, these studies illustrate how communication research can inform communication design while also illustrating that "Whereas communication research, broadly speaking, attends to the processes and effects of communicating, a concern for design is a concern for how and why actors make choices with the aim of creating particular processes and effects" (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018a: 90).

For example, CAD research focused on meetings also emphasizes the tensions that emerge when participants endeavor to cultivate forms of interaction. →Aakhus and Laureij (2012) examined a public agency that redesigned its meetings from an open dialogue structure to a more constricted structure wherein constituents' allotted time to ask questions was limited. The redesign occurred because agency facilitators found that open dialogue reduced clarity and led to more chaotic meetings. →Sprain, Carcasson, and Merolla (2014) examined "deliberative design", a set of procedures that establishes group norms, background materials, and turn-taking strategies to cultivate productive public dialogue. They found that when experts were invited to participate in deliberative discussion, they had the potential to pull groups away from deliberation when they interjected their "informed viewpoints", crowding out divergent ideas (p. 151). These studies point to the difficulty of balancing flexibility and structure in meetings and the importance of examining communication design in terms of its efforts to

balance competing goals and the tensions among them (→Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018b). Although ground rules may be created so that a variety of perspectives are heard, unforeseen tensions may emerge depending on participants' competing goals and agendas.

CAD research also investigates when and how practitioners intervene in facilitation processes (→Aakhus 2001). In a study of divorce mediations, →Aakhus (2003) found that facilitators intervened to encourage negotiation when agreements on existing conflicts could not be reached by proposing plausible lines of discussion rather than letting the couple focus on controversy (p. 283). These findings contradict theory that suggests dispute and conflict must and should be fully engaged in an environment of communicative openness to move stakeholders forward. Participants and facilitators make choices in the flow of interaction. For instance, →Reinig and Sprain (2019) analyzed practices of note-taking in public meetings. They defined notes as "a rhetorical genre constructed for particular audiences, and they circulate to do the work of more than the messages encoded within them" (p. 652). In that sense, they were focused on the design work of meeting facilitators, note-takers, and participants before and after the meeting. They considered choices such as format, which included "table notes typed or handwritten, easel notes, post-it note brainstorming, world café jottings, and graphic recordings" and the extent to which notes were detailed or abstract. Note-takers balanced adherence to existing processes and alternatives offered by participants during the meeting. CAD pushes past straightforward accounts of design to get at the mess of proposals and counterproposals in the making of choices about communication and underscores that looking for "best practices" may not necessarily aid practitioners because they ignore the ongoing, tensional, and fragmented nature of communication design (→Barbour and Gill 2014: 20).

2.1 Theory/Practice Building

Instead, CAD scholarship advances communication theory and practice by revealing how people conceptualize the mechanisms of communication effects. →Aakhus and Jackson (2005) argued that all design involves hypotheses and that all design is theoretical (→Aakhus 2007; →Jackson and Aakhus 2014). Communication design involves hypotheses in the sense that it embodies guesses about what will work in any given moment. For example, while planning a meeting, an organizer may make guesses about how long different topics will take to discuss, how sending an agenda ahead of the meeting may affect it, and what turn-taking order might help the meeting. To the extent the meeting fails or succeeds in their view, they will have evidence about the wisdom of their guesses. The hypothetical nature of communication design is fundamental to communication itself as a mechanism for learning what works and does not work across time, settings, topics, and people. It is also theoretical in the sense that communicators make those guesses based on the beliefs and models for how communication may be most successful. The ongoing success or failure of communication offers evidence that can refine these theories for designers.

As a metatheoretical framework, CAD works well with and often *needs* complementary descriptive, predictive, and normative theories of communication. For instance, research focused on communication design for reliable organizing advances the study of CAD *and* theories of reliability, resilience, and safety (→Harrison, Williams, and Reynolds 2020). CAD studies of online support groups advance knowledge of social support theory in community *and* the communication design involved in cultivating social support. CAD scholarship can orient theory-building, in →Tracy's (2016) terms, toward the development of masterful organizational communication practice, because it does both. Tracy recommended a stronger focus on how to make practice

available to others through experiential learning. It may not be enough to change practitioners' theories of what makes communication work. They also need to practice deploying and modifying choices so that they can experience the difference they make (e.g., →Thompson, Steier, and Ostrinko 2014).

2.2 Temporality

Hence, it is essential to understand how communication design happens over time. →Ballard and McVey (2014) developed a framework for understanding the temporal nature of CAD. They argued that attending to time is particularly important for CAD in that timing in designs and design work influences effects. Longer time intervals do not necessarily produce better communication, but a focus on time allows researchers to consider the variety of temporal differences important in communication design. Temporal intervals and orientations constrain and facilitate communication choices (→Barbour et al. 2017). CAD research can make contributions by taking into consideration the multiple and overlapping temporalities in organizing.

→Ballard and McVey (2014) suggested a focus on *activity cycles*, temporal "containers" of work processes that describe the rhythms of organizational life. An activity cycle may span a short time interval (e.g., hour-long team meetings at 8am every morning) or a long-time interval (e.g., the fiscal year) and can be thought of as objects of design. Choices about communication include the length of cycles; how often cycles occur; how long people speak or act; and the ways in which communicators end an activity. For example, →Jensen, Rolison, and Barbour (2022) examined activity cycles in their study of a health research organization where members were caught in cycles of *commotion*, "a blur of jarring, immediate tasks that require intense communication" (p. 30). Commotion

cycles had implications for visibility, technology, and power: Staff who worked in more visible areas of the building were more visible and more often interrupted; the automation of communication exacerbated temporal problems rather than alleviating them; and managers had more leverage to refuse and deprioritize tasks and accomplish tasks within traditional work hours, as well as dominion over schedules despite efforts to cultivate an egalitarian workplace. Seeing activity as cyclical draws attention to how actors make choices about communication and try to realize them in the flow of organizing (→Aakhus and Laureij 2012).

3 Opportunities for CAD Scholarship

Current CAD research also illustrates important difficulties that point to opportunities for future scholarship. For example, specifying the scope of CAD scholarship can be difficult but also clarifying. Communication offers means of intervention, but not all organizational problems are communication problems or problems of communication design. Likewise, not all design research focuses on communication even though it may still have important lessons for CAD scholarship. Making these distinctions clear can empower theoretical and practical contributions. Future scholarship needs to grapple with (a) difficulties of terminology, (b) the complexity of goals inherent to communication design, and (c) contextual influences on communication design work.

3.1 Problems of Terminology

A first challenge for CAD research is the word design itself. Burgeoning interest in design as focus, ethos, and method for research mirrored the proliferation of design occupations. The study of design broadly includes related topics such as design

thinking, design methods, the work of design in these emerging occupations, design science, and organizational design (→Aakhus 2017; →Barbour, Gill, and Barge 2018b; →Hevner et al. 2004; →Vasudevan 2020). This rich tradition can inform CAD scholarship. Organizational design research, for example, underscores the value of design for solving problems (→Romme 2003), and organizational design is no doubt tied up with communication (→Monge 1995). However, the varied meanings invested in the word design, its widespread usage across disciplines, and the hype surrounding it limit the utility of the term and encourage skepticism in audiences for design research. Just as scholars have lamented that if everything is communication then nothing is communication, researchers might have similar sentiments about design.

A related problem of terminology is that CAD involves communicating about communication. Talk about talk stretches the limits of language. Consider for example CAD research where the intervention into communication *is* design (→Aakhus 2001). →Eddington et al. (2020) examined the use of "design thinking" in helping engineers think about their future careers – career design. CAD was the perspective framing the inquiry, and design informed the intervention under study. →Thompson, Steier, and Ostrinko (2014) described the communication design of a participatory process aimed at designing a museum space. →Austin et al. (2020) focused on the communication design of processes for the skillful practice of communication design. These studies handle the complexity well, but they also make clear how difficult it can be to communicate about meta-communication – communication about communication about communication.

A pressing need in CAD research is the creation of vocabulary for naming and describing CAD phenomena. →Jensen, Rolison, and Barbour (2022), for example, drew on

concepts from music to describe choices about temporal communication design. Communicators made choices about the loudness, tempo, and reverberation of activity cycles, or in other words, the “amount of cognitive and emotional noise that accompanied their activities” and the “intensity of activities in the aggregate”, “the pace of activities; how quickly and often they may repeat”, and the “amount of space in time perceived within a given activity cycle” (p. 6). This language built on →Ballard and McVey’s (2014) metaphor of overlapping windows to describe temporal intervals and task complexity. Even with the development of new language, it is easy to get lost in the layers of description. Returning to the simple heuristic of asking what choices are being made by whom, for what reason, and about what, can be clarifying.

Another difficulty related to terminology, and one that makes translating communication research into designs for masterful communication practice especially difficult, is the level of detail required to describe design choices. Most CAD research does so at a high level without articulating all the specific communication choices being made. The infinite describability of communication compounds this difficulty. Analysts must make decisions about what gets included and excluded and make the case for how documenting a particular design for communication contributes to communication theory or practice. It can be difficult to provide a rationale for including designs for communication in research or convince readers of how these contributions advance communication scholarship. Research domains with a stronger design tradition may more readily recognize that specific designs for communication may themselves comprise a contribution to research (→Jackson and Aakhus 2014; →Wobbrock and Kientz 2016). →Ramasubramanian, Sousa, and Gonlin’s (2017) study of campus dialogues about race is an excellent exception that also demonstrates the difficulty. They dedicated extensive space to detailing the intricacies of the choices they made

about the dialogue sessions (about a quarter of the article), and they also made the case for the value of this design for communication as a contribution. They demonstrated the value of grounding dialogue in social identity by documenting effects of their sessions *and* by detailing *how* to organize the sessions. Their article offers a useful model for CAD research that documents specific designs, but a model that is not always a good fit, especially when the designs being documented fail or when evidence for their effects is difficult to obtain.

3.2 The Complexity of Goals in Communication Design

A second category of difficulties in CAD research center on the complexity of goals in communication. Our definition of communication design underscores that it is goal-driven; however, it can be difficult to identify the goals at stake. CAD research often refers to the ostensible goals for communication design while acknowledging others that exist or may exist. For example, in the mediation of divorce disputes, facilitators may dismiss topics to focus conversation. That choice may serve the facilitators' goals related to the success of the mediation, but their goals might include desired outcomes for mediation overall or a specific communication goal in that moment. Participants' goals are relevant and varied. They may wish to end the mediation, to subvert or support each other, or to walk away the winner. The facilitators' employers and the court system have goals that also complicate this interaction as can institutionalized goals for their interaction captured in relevant law and policy. Any given communication situation can involve multiple goals at multiple levels among multiple actors. These goals may align, magnify, conflict, or be indifferent with each other.

It may also be tempting to assume that the goals involved in communication design are just or wise. Design work can

also involve predatory manipulation (→Rosner 2018; →Zuboff 2019). For example, designers may seek to inculcate technologies and practices into our lives and sense of self that prey on our cognitive and social weaknesses. Surveillance-driven technologies allow "for the constant testing and shaping of peoples' behaviors through design", and "designed hooks are lurking throughout the social media ecosystem" (→Vasudevan 2020: 457). Crafting phishing and social engineering attacks or narratives that perpetuate social inequities are also problems of communication design. A focus on choices about communication can help shed light on the CAD phenomena that may otherwise be obscured (→Darr 2018).

The complexity of goals in CAD will magnify as automated technologies mediate interaction or engage in interaction themselves, introducing more inscrutability in the goals of communicators. The automation of communication tasks can mediate communicators' goals while transforming them (→Berkelaar 2017; →Darr 2018). Automated communicators may follow simple rules that produce chaotic patterns in the aggregate (→Shorey and Howard 2016; →Woolley, Shorey, and Howard 2018). The transformative power of automated communicators increases as more and more communication tasks are within reach of machines, but human communicators tend to see machine agents in overly simplistic, deterministic, and hyped terms (→Guzman and Lewis 2020; →Leonardi, Woo, and Barley 2021; →Sundar 2020). The tools that power modern automation operate in ways that are difficult to understand and explain and may therefore further obscure the communication choices being made and the ostensible goals of those involved. Future research must grapple with human design work that draws on automated communication tools, the communication design of automation, and the design work of automated communicators.

3.3 Context of Communication Design

A third category of difficulty in CAD research relates to the fact that communication effects involve interaction between *choices* about communication, *efforts* to realize those choices, the *effects* of those choices including the *reactions* of others, and communication *context*. Put another way, all communication design is unique in the sense that although patterns may be discernable across constellations of communication choices, efforts, and effects in context, "each communication context has specific circumstances that are unique" (→Harrison 2014: 11). Masterful communication practice depends on context and improvisation, not just the choices communicators make (→Tracy 2016).

From a research standpoint, that uniqueness can make specifying the designable features of communication difficult. CAD research typically focuses on specific choices rather than the general existence of a designable feature. For example, →Ramasubramanian, Sousa, and Gonlin (2017) highlighted the existence of ground rules and the substance of specific rules, but not all possible ground rules. The crux of the difficulty is that choices that can be identified empirically do not comprise all that are available to communicators across contexts, and it can be difficult to make the designable feature apparent by looking at only specific choices. Future research should cultivate strategies for surfacing the designable features of communication.

Context can also limit communicators' ability to imagine, let alone realize, possibilities for communication. It can be hard to see what might be possible. For example, confronting entrenched, multilevel problems like diversity and inclusion in engineering cultures, engineering trainees "described their culture as traditional, and rooted in a long history of practices and knowledge bases", and they responded to the invitation to imagine what structural change might be possible through design with hope and a sense of community but also

“confusion, uncertainty, and hesitation” (→Eddington et al. 2020: 270). To the extent that organizational communication researchers apply CAD to solve practical problems, they must also contend with the reality that choices exist within the confines of context. Research should consider how actors grapple with those constraints in practice to identify strategies that can be enacted by others without dismissing the constraints.

The limits of choices about communication are especially clear in contexts where the stakes are high. For example, →Donovan-Kicken, Tollison, and Goins (2012) argued for the reconceptualizing of caregiving as involving communication work. They explained that “The work that went into conversations about cancer was evident in how survivors packaged and delivered their messages” (p. 648), and through this analysis they identified strategies such as staying positive, practicing interaction ahead of time, and using email. Family caregiving is communication design work, and it is work of great importance given that it can alleviate suffering and improve health outcomes. But, cancer is still cancer.

In another relevant example, →Harrison, Williams, and Reynolds (2020) applied a CAD approach to high-reliability organizing to propose a research agenda aimed at developing normative and practical insights for researchers and practitioners (p. 279). Organizations seeking to become reliable do so by disciplining their communication. Nonetheless, a plan for how to communicate for safety and reliability does not guarantee success, and ignoring the realities of communication context can obscure the work that needs to be done to avoid the dangers in the first place.

4 Edge Questions

Responding to these opportunities surfaces key questions at the edge of CAD scholarship. Research needs to uncover

connections among communication choices, communication efforts, and communication effects, which are discrete but related phenomena that can be difficult to disentangle. Nonetheless, making sense of organizational communication design in context requires doing so. Providing more holistic accounts of communication choices may make it easier to make the case for sharing communication designs.

CAD scholarship must grapple with questions of power. A concern for power refers not just to the study of how power informs what designs for communication prevail, persist, and circulate but also how problems of managerial bias and systemic inequities may pervade communication design. For example, →Barbour, Gill, and Barge (2018b) defined the sophistication of communication design in terms of its efficacy for navigating the tensions and contradictions inherent to organizing. They argued that choices about communication persist and have effects because they fit the communication situation, depending on the ability and willingness of communicators to realize their choices and the circulation of alternative choices. Their theorizing sidestepped questions of power, which can include local and global inequities in control over the choices that get to be made about communication. CAD research concerns itself with the designers of communication, but in doing so, it may focus too much on powerful communicators, obscure or misunderstand other organizational members' choices, or fail to capture the strategies they may use to influence the choices that get made about communication.

Focusing on ongoing, overlapping, and competing processes of communication design can help reorient scholarship away from questions of fidelity or resistance with designs for communication or the intentions of powerful designers and toward the cultivation of more effective and just communication processes. Doing so can also help us consider questions of ethics in CAD scholarship where not all

design work has positive motives or ends. Researchers interested in the “interventions people make to realize preferred forms of interactivity and avoid nonpreferred forms” (→Aakhus 2007: 114) must also ask, preferred by who, for whom?

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Notes

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Chapter 7 Leadership Communication

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Abstract

This chapter reviews the history of leadership communication research from transmissional views of communication to post-truth. We adopt a meta-theoretical lens to analyze this wide and diverse literature based on how leadership has been studied. Specifically, normative approaches, with their post-positivist leanings, include trait theories, transformational leadership, leader-member exchange, moral and authentic leadership, and global leadership. Interpretive approaches emphasize performative and sociomaterial language games. They focus on leadership sensemaking/sensegiving, collective leadership, communicative constitution of organization approaches, and paradoxical leadership. Critical leadership infuses a power orientation into the performative aspects of leadership and followership; it includes poststructuralist approaches and leadership-followership dialectics that examine follower resistance. Finally, dialogical leadership approaches use leadership theory as a tool for praxis, focusing on leader-follower relationality and reflexivity, practical theory, and critical reflexivity. For each approach, we articulate its assumptions about communication, organizations, and leader-follower relations. We also undertake a selective review of the literature, highlighting important studies along the way, and point to important avenues for future research.

Keywords: leadership, management, leader traits, transformational leadership, leader-member exchange, global leadership, sensemaking/sensegiving, collective leadership, CCO approaches to leadership, paradoxical leadership, poststructuralist leadership research, dialectical leadership, relationality and reflexivity, practical theory and leadership, critical performativity and leadership,

Making the case for studying leadership communication since the inception of leadership studies has not always been easy. Early on, communication was a neglected topic, seen either as a simple act of transmission or epiphenomenal relative to leader cognition (e.g., →Carroll and Gillen 1987). However, communication scientists steadily made their case over the next several years by articulating the communication implications of leadership theories like leader-member exchange, neo-charisma approaches, and socialization (e.g., →Fairhurst 1993a, →1993b; →Miller and Jablin 1991). In more recent years, communication scholars grew bolder by suggesting that communication and psychology were equal lenses that can and should be alternated in figure-ground relationships when studying leadership (→Fairhurst 2007), while more discursive and dialogic views of leadership began to realize this promise (→Barge and Fairhurst 2008; →Holm and Fairhurst 2018; →Jian 2019, →2021). Still, making the case for leadership communication must address those who believe leadership is too commodified, lacks attention to power and materiality, or is disconnected from organizing practices and processes (→Collinson and Tourish 2015).

But has leadership communication ever been more important? The Trumpian era of post-truth leadership suggests that communication doesn't matter all that much; leaders can lie with impunity, remain indifferent to contradictions, and embrace "alternative facts" (→Deye and Fairhurst 2019). Moreover, the spectacular collapse of organizations like Enron and the banking crisis of 2008

showed the world that even before Trump, organizational leaders were quite adept at manufacturing realities, especially those aligned with neoliberal interests over the common good (→Collinson and Tourish 2015). Arguably, there has never been a time when leadership communication mattered so much and yet so little. Coming to terms with this paradox is a major challenge for leadership communication scholars today.

Convention dictates that we begin by defining leadership, although these are choppy waters. When leadership psychology dominated, leadership was defined in individual, cognitive, heroic, masculine, and goal-oriented terms (→Bass 1981; →Stogdill 1974). It was often equated with management, until scholars began to distinguish between leadership and management (→Zaleznik 1977). The former was centrally concerned with organizational visions of change and the longer time spans of morphing wicked problems, while the latter were the implementers of change dealing with tame "how to" problems of shorter durations (→Grint 2005). Although both roles are important, being a manager lacked the cachet of a leader. Predictably, we are now seeing a shift away from "manager" because of an over-valuing of "leader" (→Kniffen, Detert, and Leroy 2020), or a stance that is undecidable on those terms (→Koschmann and Sanders 2020). We are also seeing a shift toward the study of collective leadership, which directly targets the myth of the heroic leader (→Ospina et al. 2020), but struggles to distinguish itself from collaboration (→Denis, Langley, and Sergi 2012).

Given leadership's shape-shifting qualities, how should we define it? Following →Wittgenstein (1953), leadership qualifies it as a "blurred concept" and following →Gallie (1956), an essentially contested one. As such, we must acknowledge that leadership and followership have no right and final definitions, only definitions that are useful in some contexts for some purposes. As such, they are best regarded as a family resemblance among power- and influence-oriented language

games (→Kelly 2014), and our challenge as scholars is to interrogate the contexts of their use.

To assist us in this process, we borrow from →Deetz (2001) who suggests we view competing theoretical frameworks as discourses, or ways of thinking, doing, writing, and speaking about scientific efforts. Engrained through training, discipline, and ongoing practice, a discourse perspective encourages us to ask, *what do we see, think, and talk about with respect to leadership and followership when using one meta-theoretical or theoretical lens over another?* Following →Jian and Fairhurst (2017, →2019), we continue with the meta-theoretical approaches they selected: normative, interpretive, critical, and dialogical. For each approach, we articulate its assumptions about communication, organizations, and leader-follower relations. We also undertake a selective review of the literature, highlight important studies along the way, and point to avenues for future research.

1 Normative Theories and Research

Normative theories of leadership have a long and rich history. They are rooted in post-positivism, emulate the physical sciences, and view social phenomena as "naturally existing objects open to description, prediction, and control" thus waiting to be discovered (→Deetz 2001: 19). These objects are endemic to a natural reality external to the mind of the researcher. The goal of normative leadership research is to create theories with lawlike propositions that define and categorize an object's (e.g., leader, follower) properties and describe its relationalities with other objects. The praxis of a normative lens translates leadership theory into practices aimed at improving individual or organizational effectiveness. Indeed, theory and research from the normative lens dominate the practitioner market for leadership books and articles. Facilitating this theory-praxis combination is the

normative view of leadership as heavily cognitive, individualist, masculine, and goal-oriented. Several normative theories have also been critiqued for a bias towards heroic conceptions of leadership (→Yukl 1999) and ignoring power (→Collinson and Tourish 2015). Often, communication is conceived of as transmissional (evocative of the sender-message-receiver model), or if a meaning-centered view is adopted, the leader is the primary symbolizing agent.

Space does not permit a review of the many leader-centric theories, and relatively few follower-centric theories and leader-member theories (for a review, see →Jian and Fairhurst 2019). However, we pay particular attention to trait theories, neo-charisma theories, leader-member exchange, moral approaches, and global leadership communication.

1.1 Leader Trait Theories

Leader trait theories have been around since the inception of leadership studies but have gone in and out of fashion. Trait researchers are interested to know about the characteristics and qualities that distinguish leaders from nonleaders to predict leader effectiveness, group performance, and follower satisfaction (→DeRue et al. 2011). As such, most leader traits are divided into three categories: demographics (e.g., gender, age, education), task competence traits (e.g., intelligence, conscientiousness), and interpersonal attributes (e.g., agreeableness, extraversion), albeit independent effects are unlikely.

Gender has received the most attention. Notably, meta-analytic reviews found few significant differences in leadership effectiveness between women and men, despite some stylistic differences (→Eagly and Johnson 1990; →Eagly, Johannesen-Schmidt, and van Engen 2003). However, subsequent work by Eagly and colleagues (→Eagly and Karau 2002; →Eagly and Diekman 2005) suggests women may be subject to prejudice,

with less effective ratings in more male-dominated contexts. Sex-typing (think male, think leader) occurs when traditional leadership roles are congruent with masculine traits (assertiveness, decisiveness). Female leaders face double binds when displays of assertiveness are deemed not feminine enough while displays of traits like nurturing and relational are deemed too feminine.

Recent meta-analyses of leader traits assessed their contributions relative to leader behaviors across a range of leadership effectiveness criteria (→DeRue et al. 2011). Overall, leader behaviors like transformational leadership had a greater impact on leadership effectiveness than leader traits. However, DeRue et al. argued for an integrated model of the two, as traits related to task competence impacted leader task behaviors that, in turn, impacted performance related outcomes; the same was true for interpersonal attributes, relationship behaviors, and affective outcomes like follower satisfaction with the leader.

1.2 Transformational Leadership

During the latter part of the 20th century, the effects of globalization, shifting markets, and technological advance profoundly affected leadership in organizations. Neo-charisma approaches emerged, including visionary, charismatic, and transformational leadership, to entice employees to perform beyond the terms of their employment contract. Transformational leadership, specifically, focused on a vision for change rooted in idealized influence (charismatic appeal), inspirational motivation, intellectual stimulation, and individual consideration (→Bass and Avolio 1990). This model directly contrasts with transactional leadership, where leaders rely on rewards and incentives to persuade follower loyalty and behavior to meet their goals (→Bass and Avolio 1990).

Scholarship on transformational leadership links to several positive organizational outcomes, including higher job satisfaction and commitment (→Bycio, Hackett, and Allen 1995), more strategic organizational goals (→Berson and Avolio 2004), and vision creation and articulation (→Stam, van Knippenberg, and Wisse 2010). While transformational leadership remains well researched, theory and research in this area could do more to explain underlying communicative processes.

1.3 Leader-Member Exchange

Leader-Member Exchange (LMX) theory focuses on the quality of leader-follower relationships (→Graen and Uhl-Bien 1991, →1995). In high-quality relationships, followers enjoy greater support, challenging tasks, and more autonomy in return for performance beyond job expectations. In turn, high-quality LMXs have lower turnover, more job satisfaction, and mutual respect than medium or low-quality relationships.

LMX research has also focused on its development through the leadership-making model with role-finding, role-making, and role-routinization phases (→Graen and Uhl-Bien 1991). Recent work explores the emotional experiences of followers (→Tse and Troth 2013); narratives to determine follower trust (→Kelley and Bisel 2014); cooperative communication (→Bakar and Sheer 2013; →Sheer 2014); conflict management and shared tasks (→Madlock and Booth-Butterfield 2012; →Omilion-Hodges, Ptacek, and Zerilli 2015); and a tendency towards demographic and state and trait similarity (→Omilion-Hodges and Ptacek 2021).

Historically, LMX communication has been well researched (→Fairhurst 2007; →Lee 2001; →Olufowote, Miller, and Wilson 2005). More recent work has focused on emotions (→Gooty et al. 2019); upward influence (→Sparrowe 2020); empathy (→Jian 2021); performance (→Bakar, Jian, and Fairhurst 2014);

workgroup commitment (→Bakar and Connaughton 2010); and coworker exchange (→Omilion-Hodges and Baker 2013). →Jian, Shi, and Dalisay (2014) have also developed a leader-member conversational quality scale (LMCQ) to shift the focus to the conversation process that shapes the quality of LMX relationships.

1.4 Moral Approaches

From a seeming rise in corporate scandals in the past decade, there has been a turn to moral approaches to leadership including ethical, servant, and authentic leadership. *Ethical leadership* centers on normatively appropriate conduct through role modeling, interpersonal relationships, reinforcement, and transparent decision making (→Luthans and Avolio 2003). It emphasizes adherence to organizational norms, standards, and follower loyalty and compliance. *Servant leadership* acknowledges the moral responsibility of leaders to serve, empower, and develop followers (→Greenleaf 1997). More recently, servant leadership embraces multiple stakeholders, including customers, employees, and community members (→Schaubroeck, Lam, and Peng 2011).

Authentic leadership, a popular topic of late, emphasizes leader self-awareness, self-regulation, consistent self-expression, and modeling for followers (→Luthans and Avolio 2003; →Shamir and Eilam 2005). Authentic leaders know who they are (→Avolio et al. 2004); develop an orientation to "others and otherness" in and through dialogue (→Hanold 2017); and act with a sense of moral self-concordance (→Lemoine, Hartnell, and Leroy 2019).

We say more about the communication implications of moral approaches to leadership under dialogical leadership approaches.

1.5 Global Leadership Communication

Western views of leadership and management dominate leadership scholarship, yet critical approaches have long cited a serious lack of representation and understanding of non-Western global perspectives (→Hall 2010; →Said 1993). Global leadership focuses on the relationship between leadership and culture (→Triandis 1993), its impact on organizational performance, and what constitutes effective leadership communication (→Trompenaars 1993).

A comprehensive study of leadership culture in 62 cultures, known as the GLOBE project (→House et al. 2004), was designed to compare values and ideals for leaders across national borders. The project emphasized the significance of leadership variance found across cultures and the dynamic implications of misunderstandings between culture and leadership (→House et al. 2004). Building on the GLOBE project's foundation, →Hall (2010) examined Jamaican managing styles compared to those in the United States. →Bakar and Connaughton (2010) explored how national culture values in Malaysia inform supervisory communication and commitment, while →Bakar, Jian, and Fairhurst (2014) found that agreement on the quality of the LMX relationship was influenced by Malaysian cultural norms. Additional scholarship examines preferred leadership communication styles across cultures (→Cherfan and Allen 2021)

→Gibbs (2009) studied global software teams with multiple geographical and cultural challenges. Autonomy and connection, inclusion and exclusions, and empowerment and disempowerment were among the dialectical tensions they faced. While teams often selected one pole over another to manage the tensions, managers appeared more competent in transcending the dialectics. →Thomas (2006) described how a holistic conceptualization of intercultural competence can be thought of as "mindfulness", with major implications for improving communication.

In sum, a more globalized view of leadership considers different cultural elements that impact leadership communication while encouraging scholarship to move beyond ethnocentric and Western views. There is certainly space for much more scholarship on global leadership, given the attention paid to leader trait theories, LMX, and moral approaches. All orient to leadership and followership in ways to seek a more generalizable knowledge base.

2 Interpretive Leadership Research

With interpretive approaches, leadership is socially constructed and increasingly realized in material actants (objects, sites, and bodies). Contra the normative lens' essentializing of leadership in persons, situations, or some combination of the two (→Fairhurst 2007), interpretive approaches often see leadership as an attribution, which not all actors necessarily share. Interpretivists study how conflicting views of leadership come about and how they might coexist (→Fairhurst and Grant 2010). As such, views of human communication are meaning-centered, although leaders are not necessarily the sole or primary symbolizing agents. Leadership may shift and distribute itself among human and nonhuman actants, thus lending itself to understanding leadership in more collective or distributed forms (→Ospina et al. 2020). This marries well with efforts by global organizations to push controls downward in their systems into teams, making the distinction between "leadership" (advancing the task) and "authority" (hierarchical roles and responsibilities) increasingly necessary. Although issues of power are frequently glossed or ignored, an interpretive lens argues for a more relational view between leaders and followers, contra a heavy focus on leaders in the normative lens. As such, these perspectives range from sensemaking/sensegiving, collective leadership,

communicative constitution of organization approaches, and paradoxical leadership.

2.1 Sensemaking/Sensegiving

Sensemaking is often regarded as a psychological process of meaning-making, while sensegiving involves processes of communicating meaning, often the primary task of leaders (→Gioia and Chittipeddi 1991). However, others subvert this dualism either by emphasizing the linguistic and communicative foundations of sensemaking (→Cornelissen and Clarke 2010) or its origins in specific practice worlds (→Sandberg and Tsoukas 2020). Sensemaking and identity work ("Who am I?" "Who are we?") are often studied together, as leadership actors frequently envision themselves in cause-maps of the world (→Drazin, Glynn, and Kazanjian 1999). For example, several studies focus on middle managers' identity work in their sensemaking of organizational change (→Balogun and Johnson 2004; →Sharma and Good 2013), while others examine the sensemaking and identity work of employee resistors of management (→Sonenshein 2010). Finally, work by →Alvesson and Spicer (2011) explores the role of leadership metaphors and sensemaking.

2.2 Collective Leadership

Although casting leadership as a joint or communal endeavor is not exactly new (e.g., LMX), the study of collective leadership is relatively recent. It represents an umbrella of approaches (→Denis, Langley, and Sergi 2012; →Ospina et al. 2020), representing shared leadership in teams (→Pearce, Conger, and Locke 2008); distributed leadership across boundaries over time (→Gronn 2002, →2009); pooled configurations at the top of organizations (→Reid and Karambayya 2009); but

also, leadership as emergent, more communicative than role-oriented, and material (→Holm and Fairhurst 2018).

Collective leadership's commitment to relationality stands in sharp contrast to heroic and hierarchical leadership (→Uhl-Bien and Ospina 2012). However, knowledge workers, dispersed bases of authority, uncertain roles and responsibilities, valuable practices with a potential dark side, and the fluidity of decision making can make the distinction between hierarchical and collective leadership equivocal and diffuse (→Fairhurst et al. 2020). As such, →Gronn (2015) recommends studying leadership configurations, a constellation of parts emerging as wholes, with members who consciously act as a decision-making unit. A configurational analysis tracks how formal and informal roles blend, hierarchical levels cross, and influence shifts continuously over time (→Gronn 2015). It will see variety in different forms of collective leadership (→Denis, Langley, and Sergi 2012), but also the operations of power in and through role ambiguity, tension, contradiction, and paradox (→Endres and Weibler 2017; →Schnurr and Schroeder 2019)

Finally, leadership may be seen as irrelevant in collective leadership settings, deemed "collaboration" instead. Network analysts sidestep this issue by defining leadership as information brokerage (→Contractor et al. 2012; →DeRue, Nahrgang, and Ashford 2015) or an organizational role in team interactions (→Denis, Langley, and Sergi 2012). Yet, the same problems persist in collective leadership as with traditional leadership, namely, why those in formal roles may not be seen as leaders (→Bedeian and Hunt 2006), or why others not in those roles may well be (→Quinn and Spreitzer 2001). The same could be said for network centrality or whole networks putatively acting in a leadership capacity (→Gronn 2015).

2.3 CCO Approaches

Communicative constitution of organization (CCO) theory makes few claims about leadership (→Bisel, Fairhurst, and Sheep 2022). However, the Montreal School of CCO (→Cooren 2012; →Taylor and Van Every 2000, →2014) concerns itself with authority, which is often mistaken for leadership, and several draw from it to write about leadership. However, there is CCO work on charismatic leadership (→Fairhurst 2007); heroic versus failed political leadership during a crisis (→Fairhurst and Cooren 2009); routine building management (→Cooren, Fairhurst, and Huët 2012); shared versus hierarchical leadership (→Holm and Fairhurst 2018); ventriloquism in leadership (→Clifton 2017; →Clifton, Fachin, and Cooren 2021); and responsible management (→Schoeneborn, Trittin-Ulbrich, and Cooren 2020).

What is particularly unique about a CCO view of leadership is that it is viewed as a distributed phenomenon. In the Four Flows CCO model (→McPhee and Zaug 2000), leadership can be accomplished by management, but it can also occur wherever members' communication mixes four flows of activity (activity coordination, membership negotiation, reflexive self-structuring, and institutional positioning) (→Bisel, Fairhurst, and Sheep 2022). The Montreal School variously treats leadership as a series of "doings"; specifically, as hybrid human-nonhuman acting (→Cooren, Fairhurst, and Huët 2012; →Fairhurst and Cooren 2009); leaders (or followers or entities) as macro-actors, speaking for or on behalf of the organization (→Taylor and Van Every 2000, →2014); and, more recently, as a ventriloquized "figure" animated with a life of its own as it comes to "matter" in a situation (→Cooren et al. 2013). As such, leadership and management may prove to be different animating figures.

2.4 Paradoxical Leadership

The study of paradox in organizations (→Putnam, Fairhurst, and Banghart 2016) spawned interest in paradoxical leadership in which leaders move beyond the hard-edge of either-or decisional behavior to focus instead on both-and behavior, which is the ability to display competing yet interrelated actions that meet contextual demands simultaneously over time (→Waldman and Bowen 2016; →Zhang et al. 2015). In Zhang et al.'s study of Chinese leaders, paradoxical leadership was positively related to follower proficiency, adaptivity, and proactivity. →Zheng, Kark, and Meister (2018) proposed a model of paradoxical mindset (→Miron-Spektor et al. 2018) for women leaders, focused on psychological resilience, (multiple) identity coexistence, and leadership effectiveness. →Sparr (2018) explored the role of leader sensegiving for paradoxes of organizational change, as did →Pearce et al. (2019) who explored the organization's use of paradoxical thinking as it shifted to co-CEOs with very different styles.

Paradox work on hybrid organizations combining social and business missions (→Jay 2013; →Smith and Besharov 2019); ambidexterity in managing exploitation and exploration tensions in innovation (→Andriopoulos and Lewis 2009); and grand challenges confronting multiple paradoxical tensions portray paradoxical leadership at more senior levels (Jian and Fairhurst 2020). Finally, paradoxical leadership has been widely promoted amongst practitioners by focusing on common paradoxes that all leaders face (→Smith, Lewis, and Tushman 2016; →Waldman and Bowen 2016).

To summarize, three benefits of interpretive approaches are that, first, there is less of a leader bias than in normative approaches, which opens the door to followership and more collective forms of leadership. Second, it allows us to understand leadership more performatively – i.e., grounded in task accomplishment through influential acts of sociomaterial

organizing that engenders leadership attributions (or not). Third, the attributional focus of some interpretive approaches allows analysts to understand how diverging conceptualizations of leadership emerge and coexist.

3 Critical Approaches

Similar to interpretive approaches, critical leadership studies (CLS) also emphasizes the performative aspects of leadership, but it places a great deal more emphasis on the study of power and control (→Alvesson and Spicer 2012; →Collinson 2020). Interpretive approaches tend not to undertake such analyses unless actors make power an issue. CLS is a loose umbrella term for a diverse set of approaches, including labor process theory, critical management studies, relational dialectics, post-colonialism, feminism, poststructuralism, radical psychology, and psychoanalysis (Fairhurst and Collinson, 2023). For example, Marxist or neo-Marxist perspectives focus on forms of control that privilege elites (managers, owners, or shareholders). They might not use leadership terminology, or they might cast leadership as a form of domination, citing (normative lens) business books and consulting designed to commodify leadership for practitioners (e.g., →Hardy and Clegg 1996). Postcolonial leadership critiques the dominance of Western views of leadership in a global context, citing undue US influence in setting universal standards by which other countries measure themselves, sans localized concerns (→Said 1993).

Despite some tensions between these perspectives, they all critique situated power relations and identity constructions through which leadership and followership are rationalized, resisted, and transformed (→Fairhurst and Collinson 2023; →Ford and Harding 2011; →Spector 2019). Two of the largest categories of critical leadership studies stem from poststructuralism and dialectics.

3.1 Poststructuralist Leadership Research

A major influence on this genre is Michel →Foucault's (1977, →1983) sociological conception of power, which is more encompassing, relational, and both positive and negative. For example, power can discipline leadership actors to conform but also supply repertoires for relating to the world through sociomaterial practices. Both leaders and followers can be managers of meaning as much as they can be passive receptors (→Fairhurst 2007). Power and resistance follow on the heels of the other, and it is often the struggle between them to which CLS attends. Finally, poststructuralist CLS concerns itself with "denaturalization" i.e., unpacking how situations of leadership or followership may appear "natural" or "the way things are". As such, power is diffuse and often below radar, emphasizing systems of thought, sociomaterialities, structures, or techniques regulating what appears normal or natural.

For example, →Fairhurst (2007) critiqued executive coaching discourses for disciplining alpha male leaders to control their emotions at the same time coaching language normalizes (white) male bodies as senior leaders. On the heels of →Parker's (2005) work on race neutral leadership discourses, which marginalized executive black women through unquestioned assumptions of superiority and inferiority, →Smith et al. (2019) studied the paradoxical effects of intersectional invisibility, which also made them hypervisible. →Collinson (2012) wrote about "Prozac leadership" to describe leadership discourses of excessive positivity that suppress alternative voices, limit coping ability, and discourage followers from raising questions, while engendering their resistance in the process. However, the perils of excessive positivity discourses exist in (normative) leadership studies more broadly (→Alvesson 2020).

Poststructuralist scholars are increasingly turning to the body and bodily performances, including physical stature,

features, stance, gestures, voice, and athleticism, which have long been ignored in (normative) leadership research (→Sinclair 2005). →Ford et al. (2017) examined the unspoken assumptions underpinning lay theories of leadership as a material presence (read, looking the part) and how actors alter their appearance to fit the image of leader. Likewise, →Johansson, Tienari, and Valtonen (2017) examined gendered performances with respect to images of managerial athleticism.

3.2 Dialectical Leadership

Critical dialectical studies suggest rethinking leadership-followership power dynamics as dialectical processes that entwine in ways that are mutually reinforcing, oppositional and in tension, or both. Power can be productive as well as oppressive, covert as well as overt; thus, studies examine how different forms of control may produce unintended effects such as followers' resistance or their emergence as leaders themselves (→Fairhurst and Collinson 2023).

For example, several studies draw from →Giddens's (1984) dialectic of control, suggesting that followers retain a measure of autonomy and discretion amidst leaders' control (→Carroll and Nicholson 2014; →Gagnon and Collinson 2017). Other studies demonstrate the discursive practices through which leaders and followers hold (or fail to hold) together fragile coalitions or other power sharing arrangements by dialectically responding to tensional push-pulls (→Smith and Besharov 2019).

Performativity is an emerging focus of critical dialectical studies, specifically, how leadership/followership is performed via the material actants informing the relationalities involved. →Deye and Fairhurst (2019) compared the Twitter and public speaking performances of former President Donald Trump and Pope Francis, finding the seeds of democracy in a

historically autocratic organization and roots of authoritarianism in a historically democratic society. →Van De Mieroop, Clifton, and Verhelst (2020) found that the dialectical interplay of formal and informal leadership was mediated by materialities beyond talk, such as objects, gaze, and use of space.

In sum, CLS challenges dichotomous understandings of leader-led relations, arguing that power is performative, material, diffuse, and often misconstrued. Leadership and followership are ripe with the potential for conflict and dissent; control and resistance are thus inextricably linked as mutually reinforcing processes that are inherently ambiguous and potentially contradictory.

4 Dialogical Approaches

Unlike interpretive and critical approaches, a dialogical lens is theory-informed praxis. It seeks to enhance dialogue among leadership actors, but also impart a sense of relationality – i.e., being answerable and responsive to one another (→Bakhtin 1984). Relationality is an ontology that departs from individualist views of human existence, which have survived since the Enlightenment. Meaning, therefore, does not simply reside in the heads of actors, but is co-created in and through language, communication, and discourse. The praxis orientation of dialogic approaches derives from using leadership theory and research as a developmental tool, in turn, sensitizing actors to conversational moments that inspire change, renewal, and moral accountability. Over time, a commitment to reflexivity builds a critical and conscious awareness of what artful conversation and dialogue can yield vis-à-vis more morally responsive leadership actors and organizations (→Barge 2014; →Bisel 2018). In the section below, we review relationality and reflexivity, practical theory, and critical reflexivity.

4.1 Relationality and Reflexivity

Relationality is a term that gets passed around a lot. The term might simply be used to describe what occurs at the nexus of people, positions, processes, and outcomes, such as in nonprofit leadership (→Koschmann and Sanders 2020: 48), academic leadership (→Ruben, DeLisi, and Gigliotti, 2021), or leadership in interorganizational collaborations (→Kramer et al. 2019). Relationality might be an emergent property of relations such as in leadership as practice (→Carroll, Levy, and Richmond 2008) or relational control (→Fairhurst and Uhl-Bien 2012), although these approaches are not as inclined towards praxis as "nexus" approaches. Also, if relationships are abstracted from individual psychological states, as in LMX research, an individualist non-relational view of being still holds (→Jian and Fairhurst 2019).

From within a dialogic lens, leadership/followership is an everyday experience imbued with a sense of moral responsibility (→Cunliffe and Eriksen 2011), authentic moral dialogue, and ongoing reflexivity towards work practices (→Bisel 2018). It is also a commitment to empathy grounded in relational ethics, where empathic leadership practices recognize both leaders and followers as (moral) agents of empathy and coproducers of meaning (→Jian 2021).

Being relational responsive is thus essential to reflexivity (→Cunliffe 2002), in which actors *collectively* surface bias, local logics, layered meanings, and multiple interpretations with the goal of removing obstacles and co-creating new paths forward through morally guided conversations (→Bisel 2018). Being a relational leader or follower means being morally responsible and accountable to everyone who contributes to that relationship, a tenet that is also foundational to practical theory.

4.2 Practical Theory

Practical theory signals a decided shift from a dualistic, independent relationship between theory and practice to a reflexive one in which each informs the other (→Barge 2001). With origins in action science (→Argyris and Schön 1996) and the pragmatism of →Dewey (1938), practical theory evaluates research based on its utility for practice, while theory serves as a resource for practice, without dictating events or losing spontaneity or focus on context (→Barge 2001). As such, it depends heavily on relational responsiveness and reflexivity towards the conversational moments that theory may inspire.

For example, →Barge and Fairhurst's (2008) emphasis on collective sensemaking, positioning, and play through "systemic story-making" applies systems thinking to co-constructed narratives and stories. →Barge's (2014) notion of pivotal leadership extends his systemic constructionist focus to decipher how material realities and bodies factor into his reflexive analysis of a crisis. →Hedman-Phillips and Barge (2017) draw from the coordinated management of meaning to identify interactional moves that enhance team reflexivity, including framing the facilitation, positive storytelling, and reflecting on concrete communicative actions. →Mitra (2013) used transformational leadership theory as a springboard to contrast his critical dialogic perspective, which focuses on co-creating systems, material relations, and reflexive processes of interactional "trans-formations". Finally, combining the practical tradition with hermeneutic and rhetorical theories, →Jian (2019) casts leadership as artful orchestration and facilitation of conversation and collective narrativization through a hermeneutic circle.

4.3 Critical Performativity

Building on CLS's interest in the dialectic of control and resistance and the ideological aspects of leadership,

→Alvesson and Spicer (2012) expand their interest in performativity by advocating for critical performativity. It strives for a more affirmative performative engagement through: “circumspect care” (taking respondents’ views seriously, but also critically interrogating them), “progressive pragmatism” (pragmatically but also critically working with already accepted discourses), and “searching for present potentialities” (moving beyond a critique of existing practices of leadership to create a sense of what could be).

More recently, →Spicer, Alvesson, and Kärreman (2016) seek a return to a long-standing tradition of dialectics-based organizational interventions (→Fairhurst 2019), by introducing dialectical reasoning into their model of critical performativity for public engagement. Their point is not to try to resolve theory-practice tensions, but to find new ways of enacting leadership/followership with non-academic groups.

To summarize, dialogic approaches to leadership communication challenge leadership theory and research to “do more” i.e., be accessible, translatable, and actionable – and eschew knowledge for the sake of knowledge. The commitment to relationality, collective reflexivity, and moral accountability in these approaches is a paramount, as this genre ponders and seeks to remedy the leadership failures of the past.

5 Conclusion

In this final section, we look across the four lenses to draw several conclusions that speak to the future of leadership communication research and praxis. First, the very presence of the four lenses suggests scholars’ growing interest in studying leadership communication in increasingly complex terms. While divisions persist over different ways of doing science, each lens addresses different questions and ways of conceiving communication. Specifically, the study of

leadership actor performativity (interpretive), power (critical), and praxis (dialogic) are noteworthy additions to the historically dominant study of leader cognition (normative), which may relegate communication to a secondary status over a strong inner motor (→Fairhurst 2007). The study of communication, in turn, shifts from representationalist and transmissional (normative) to meaning-centered, material, and performative (interpretive), to power-laced and performative (critical), to relational, reflexive, improvisational, and interventionist (dialogic). This variety only benefits leadership research in the long run.

Second, regardless of the lens, an increasing number of actors are viewed as having the agency to win attributions of leadership. As organizations have pushed controls downward in their systems towards teams, the study of leadership beyond hierarchical role has seriously taken hold (→Denis, Langley, and Sergi 2012; →Ospina et al. 2020). This is even while the relationship between hierarchical and collective leadership remains an ambiguous leadership space whose diverse configurations require ongoing study (→Fairhurst et al. 2020; →Gronn 2015).

Third, the interest in studying leadership and followership performativity also marks an increasing interest in a material world. More than ever before, leadership actors' bodies and objects, like authoritative texts, are being conceived in spatiotemporal terms, although we are only at the beginning of this journey. The effects of race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, age, and social class remain unevenly studied, with gender continuing to dominate scholars' interests. More work is necessary, along with new technology's (e.g., social media) effects on voice and social influence and what they mean for conventional work design (→Jian and Fairhurst 2019).

Fourth, globalization remains an understudied area, especially in the production of leadership knowledge beyond Western societies. Although inroads have been made (→Bakar

and Connaughton 2010; →Hall 2010), there is still much to learn about leadership/followership in Africa, South America, and Asia.

Fifth, the study of moral leadership is of great importance given the challenges associated with post-truth leadership – i.e., the normalization of mendacity and the devaluing of communication. Historically, morality was underdeveloped in the normative lens, a matter of personal integrity or innate leader character traits. More recently, scholars seek measurement to distinguish between ethical, authentic, and servant leadership (→Lemoine, Hartnell, and Leroy 2019).

The interpretive lens shifts to the performative character of ethics, morality, authenticity, and servitude as language games. Authentic leadership, for example, must be regarded as a collective achievement (→Larsson, Clifton, and Schnurr 2021), while subject to paradox when truth-stretching leaders like Donald Trump appear highly authentic to followers (→Fairhurst and Sheep 2020).

From within a critical lens, scholars would study the systemic and sociohistorical influences on moral decision making, push back against excessive positivity in leadership theorizing (→Collinson 2020), and warn of leadership's dark side (→Tourish 2014). In a post-truth context, this would translate to the study of contradictions, leadership/followership responses, and deleterious effects on democratically organized societies.

Finally, a dialogical lens would ground moral decision making as a relationally responsive practice, eschewing abstract principles and charismatic personality traits. Instead, it would focus on problematizing praxis and using relational ethical theory to morally guide conversations in this post-truth era (→Barge 2014; →Bisel 2018; →Jian 2021). It might consider the call to dialogue from Thomas Merton, the Trappist monk, writer, and activist cited by Pope Francis in his 2015 speech to the US Congress.[1] "If I insist on giving you my truth, and never

stop to receive your truth in return, there can be no truth between us".

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Notes

1 →https://www.washingtonpost.com/local/social-issues/transcript-pope-franciss-speech-to-congress/2015/09/24/6d7d7ac8-62bf-11e5-8e9e-dce8a2a2a679_story.html?itid=lk_inline_manual_25.

Chapter 8 Organizational Entry Processes

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Abstract

This chapter overviews communication theory and research related to organizational newcomers' entry experiences. Following an introduction of select theories, we review scholarly work in the areas of vocational socialization, anticipatory organizational socialization including recruitment and interview processes, organizational entry and encounter, role-making processes, and entry experiences of nontraditional newcomers. Reviews of scholarly work in each of these areas are complemented by suggestions for future research.

Keywords: vocational socialization, recruitment, employment interviewing, newcomers, organizational socialization, information seeking, membership negotiation, role negotiation,

Organizational entry processes highlight communication's importance in developing "expectations and beliefs concerning how people communicate in particular occupations and in formal and informal work settings" (→Jablin 2001: 734). Socialization is the process of learning the ropes, being indoctrinated and trained, and being taught what is important in an organization or a subunit (→Schein [1968]

1988). Expectations for organizational roles and communication competencies begin developing in childhood, progress during organizational entry, and continue through role making where newcomers question and seek to modify tasks and interpersonal relations (→Graen 1976). Communication experiences throughout these processes are critical to newcomers' well-being and adjustment. They are essential for conveying organizational norms and values critical to its growth and survival (→Jablin 2001; →Van Maanen and Schein 1979).

Extensive overviews of organizational newcomers' communication experiences exist (e.g., →Jablin 2001; →Kramer 2010; →Kramer and Miller 2014). This chapter updates these reviews and emphasizes recent developments. Space limitations preclude reviewing organizational exit scholarship. (Chapter 28 in this volume selectively addresses exit processes from the military.) Nonetheless, the emphasis here on pre-entry and entry comes at a time when interest in vocational choices, changing jobs or careers, person-organization (PO) and person-job (PJ), and socializing newcomers are increasingly important.

This chapter examines five topics: (1) vocational or role anticipatory socialization, the process of selecting occupations or roles in some organization; (2) organizational anticipatory socialization, the process of selecting specific organizations in which to enact roles; (3) entry or encounter where individuals begin occupying and enacting roles; (4) negotiation processes, ongoing attempts to modify roles and expectations; and (5) nontraditional newcomers' experiences. Each section presents key concepts, research contributions, and directions for future research.

1 Theories and Theoretical Perspectives

Before explaining these topics, it is important to note that a number of theories offer insights into communication processes throughout onboarding during socialization or assimilation. →Kramer and Miller (2014) highlight four major theoretical approaches: uncertainty reduction theory (→Berger and Calabrese 1975) and uncertainty management theory (→Kramer 2010) posit newcomers use multiple strategies to achieve goals when facing task, relational, and organization uncertainty; sensemaking theory (→Louis 1980) explores how newcomers assign meaning to information and experiences they encounter; social exchange theory explains how individuals use cost-benefit analyses to make career decisions especially during hiring, entry, and leaving stages of organizational membership; and social identity theory (→Ashforth and Mael 1989) examines how individuals maintain or modify personal identities by affiliating or disassociating with groups and organizations.

As →Table 1 depicts, scholars appropriate many additional theories when examining communication directly or indirectly during onboarding processes. Exemplars include social learning, role, resource, expectancy violation, relationship development, congruence, normative influence, and impression management theories. Sometimes, theories are tested directly (e.g., uncertainty, →Ashford and Cummings 1983; value congruence, →Cable and Parsons 2001; sensemaking, →Zhou et al. 2022) whereas others are offered as frameworks to guide investigations (e.g., social exchange, →Korte 2009).

Table 1: Organizational Entry Research Theories.

Theory	Exemplars
Uncertainty reduction/management	
Uncertainty prompts newcomers to seek information to gain clarity or reduce concerns; newcomers also cope through internal cognitions or process scripts.	→Miller and Jablin 1991; →Kramer 2010
Sensemaking	
Newcomers retrospectively evaluate events, including communication, to assign meaning.	→Barge and Schlueter 2004; →Louis 1980
Social exchange	
Newcomers weigh benefits and costs of acquiring information or making requests.	→Miller and Jablin 1991
Social identity	
Newcomers' sense of belonging and emotional ties to vocations, roles, units, or organizations influence interaction patterns, role enactments, and inclusion or exclusion perceptions.	→Endacott and Myers 2019; →Ihm and Shumate 2022
Learning theory/social learning theory	
Newcomers attend to and emulate relevant stimuli and reinforcement from others.	→Cooper-Thomas et al. 2020; →Klein and Heuser 2008
Role theory	
Newcomers receive role expectations from incumbents and then seek to modify them.	→Graen 1976; →Katz and Kahn 1978
Resource theory	
Through structural connections or proactivity, newcomers access information and support to gain social integration.	→Fang, Duffy and Shaw 2011; →Saks and Gruman 2018
Expectancy violation	
Differences between onboarding expectations and experiences influence individuals' attitudes and behaviors.	→Meglino, Denisi and Ravlin 1993; →Wanous 1992
Relationship development	
Friendships grow based on newcomer competence or commonality, with increased sharing of insider knowledge.	→Jablin 2001; →Saks, Uggerslev, and Fassina 2007

Theory	Exemplars
Congruence	
Perceptions of fit to organizations, jobs, supervisors, or groups can be assuaged through entry processes.	→Kristof 1996; →Kristof-Brown, Zimmerman, and Johnson 2005
Normative influence	
Workgroup members, individually and collectively, may convey behavioral and performance expectations on newcomers.	→Manata 2019
Impression management	
Applicants and newcomers construct personas to shape organizational members' perceptions.	→Ellis et al. 2002; →Peck and Levashina 2017

2 Vocational Anticipatory Socialization

Vocational anticipatory socialization (VAS) includes the process of learning about occupations or roles and narrowing employment or volunteer choices to pursue (→Kramer 2010). Six communicative experiences influence individuals, beginning in infancy and throughout individuals' lives: family; education; peers; previous experience; media; and the Internet. Each experience influences perceptions of the nature of work and initial and ongoing career choices.

2.1 Family

Studies confirm family members socialize young people concerning work in general and specific roles. Children are primarily socialized by parents' messages, whether direct (e.g., "Dad told me …"), indirect (e.g., "I heard Mom talk about …"), or ambient (e.g., "I've seen Dad …") (→Buzzanell, Berkelaar, and Kisselburgh 2011). Household responsibilities and how family members interact influence individuals' development (→Jablin 2001). Children vicariously learn occupational and organizational norms from family if they

enter similar careers (→Gibson and Papa 2000). Additionally, omitting information, like not discussing education, socializes children away from certain paths (→Lucas 2011). Parents often promote self-actualization and self-sufficiency messages while encouraging careers related to children's talents (→Jahn and Myers 2014). College students report pressure to defend the economic viability of their major (→Lair and Wieland 2012), and women often receive gendered messages to select positions that will accommodate the "eventuality of family priorities" (→Medved et al. 2006: 172). Little is known concerning elderly parents' (perhaps retired) influence on adult children's later job or career changes, or how grown children shape parents' beliefs and choices about work or retirement.

2.2 Education

Educational institutions play a vital role in teaching children, adolescents, and adults the importance of responsibility, interpersonal skills, attention to details, and meeting deadlines, as well as introducing various occupations and their communication activities (→Jablin 2001). Curricula sometimes impart specific skills and nomenclature associated with occupations. Teachers' lessons, textbooks, and discussions present a range of occupational issues, but may fail to communicate the rewards associated with fulfilling jobs or careers (→Levine and Hoffner 2006). Adolescents' enjoyment of coursework stimulates or diminishes their interest in and expectations for STEM careers (→Jahn and Myers 2014). Science and math students felt they had to learn about STEM careers on their own, and often had difficulty connecting coursework to occupational practices. Yet, teachers and school counselors are critical sources of information and support for first-generation college students' vocational aspirations and adaption to college (→Gist-Mackey, Wiley, and Erba 2018).

Further research among engineering students suggests educational institutions might perpetuate work practices such as delaying project initiation or working alone that experienced engineers would find counterproductive (→Leonardi, Jackson, and Diwan 2009).

2.3 Peers

Peers concomitantly influence career choices and expectations. High schoolers report peers are the most influential source for discouraging career interests (→Powers and Myers 2017) and learning about negative aspects of working (→Levine and Hoffner 2006). Although most research focuses on adolescents' information sharing within friendships, an exception is an investigation showing peer relationships *at work* also serve career-enhancing functions (→Kram and Isabella 1985). Research into peer's role in anticipatory socialization among college-age or older adults changing careers could provide insights into the strength and continuity of peer influence.

2.4 Previous Organizational Experience

→Jablin (2001) referenced part-time work to examine how teens' after-school and weekend jobs helped them develop responsible work habits. The broader term, previous organizational experience (e.g., →Kramer 2010), describes the wide range of encounters, including part-time work (→Herrygers and Wieland 2017), past roles (→Dailey 2016a), internships (→Dailey 2016b), and volunteer experiences (→Kramer 2011) that shape individuals' understanding of their roles. Previous organizational experiences likely offer positive and negative models of leadership, team interaction, social dynamics, and daily organizing.

2.5 Media

Media depictions of organizational roles, member interactions, and social status influence VAS, even if depictions are often stereotypical, with excessive focus on personal relationships or the most interesting aspects of careers (→Jablin 2001; →Signorielli and Kahlenberg 2001). After parental influence, →Buzzanell, Berkelaar, and Kisselburgh (2012) found television and books as the second and third most frequently cited VAS agents by Chinese children. Favorite television characters' jobs shaped American college freshmen's occupational aspirations and work values (→Hoffner, Levine, and Toohey 2008). Though career depictions may have evolved past gendered lines, research suggests much programming presents stereotypical roles (→Sink and Mastro 2017).

2.6 Internet and Social Media

Internet-based sources have emerged recently as the "go to" repository for career information and information exchanges about careers, jobs, and organizations. Research indicates college students rely on the Internet significantly more than traditional media for VAS information, which includes (a) career (Indeed.com, LinkedIn) and organizational websites, (b) social media platforms (Facebook, Twitter), and (c) produced sources (podcasts, YouTube) (→Levine and Aley 2020). Although some work has explored how social media interactions shape first-generation students' college aspirations and expectations (e.g., →Gist-Mackey, Wiley, and Erba 2018), scholars understand less about how social media influence job perceptions and career choices.

2.7 Future Research Opportunities

Scholars could explore generational (e.g., Millennials, Gen Z) differences on values, job ideals, and role preferences, especially among underrepresented and non-Western groups as "distinctive values and perspectives can affect cohort members' workplace performance, relationships, and expectations" (→Kramer and Myers 2014: 259). However, scholars rarely track how job ideals evolve with workforce and life experiences. Individual differences (e.g., work-life balance preferences) could take precedence over general patterns.

Further, the COVID-19 pandemic, prompting at-home work and education via the Internet, may have inadvertently provided young people unique insight into parents' careers. Children may have gained occupational knowledge through observing zoom meetings, overhearing coworkers' conversations, and watching parents' work stress spillover at home. Research might explore what young people learned about "essential" versus "nonessential" work and health risks associated with certain occupations. The pandemic may have also shaped notions of meaningful work and career aspirations for young people and created enthusiasm or distaste for virtual learning or work.

Communication scholars could explore high dropout rates in STEM vocations, particularly among women. Although centered in other disciplines, communication researchers are well equipped to investigate the discursive dynamics of attrition in STEM. Investigations could examine nontraditional anticipatory socialization avenues, like living-learning communities (→Dean and Dailey 2020) or after-school programs (→Ashcraft Eger, and Scott 2017), to identify creative ideas for representation and matriculation.

3 Organizational Anticipatory Socialization

Vocational and job expectations continue developing as individuals investigate work (or volunteer) opportunities during anticipatory selection and onboarding processes. Individuals' understanding of vocations, recruitment processes, and organizations' hiring criteria shape how they tailor messages conveying their interest in positions and how they express experiences and abilities in application materials (→Jablin 2001).

Ideally, organizations perform job analyses, create job descriptions, and target specified populations who possess job-relevant knowledge and abilities (→Levashina et al. 2014). After filtering the applicant pool, organizations select job candidates. Candidates undergo screening, selection, and placement interviews, either sequentially over time or in a single setting. Successful candidates engage in pre-onboarding interactions with organizational representatives, possibly involving relocation discussions, completing pre-employment verification, and interactions with incumbents.

3.1 Recruitment and Job Seeking

Research into individuals' job seeking and organizations' recruitment practices is prolific. As extensive reviews exist elsewhere (e.g., →Levashina et al. 2014; →Posthuma, Morgeson, and Campion 2002; →Uggerslev, Fassina, and Kraichy 2012), this review focuses on research examining message sending or information exchanges between applicants and organizations or investigations with major implications for communication processes.

Because Internet sources provide new opportunities for organizational representatives and prospective employees, the recruitment and information-gathering landscape have changed dramatically. Scholars (e.g., →Carr 2016; →Ryan and

Delany 2017) note that websites provide rich information about organizations' goals, career opportunities, societal engagement, and work climates at initial recruiting stages. The Internet enables organizations to offer unique content to targeted prospects. Research-based recommendations for effective corporate branding for recruiting are common (e.g., →Murphy et al. 2018) since organizational image and websites influence job seekers' attitudes toward organizations, which predicts their employment intentions (e.g., →Allen, Mahto, and Otondo 2007). College students develop preferences for specific firms based on website representations (e.g., →Harrison and Stone 2018).

Job applicants' social media sites provide recruiters and potential coworkers intentional and unintentional candidate information. Recruiters seek information to verify impression of applicants' character on candidates' websites (→Carr 2016). Examining candidates' social media can morph into cybervetting and intrude into private lives (→Berkelaar 2014). Concurrently, applicants contact organizational representatives via social media for general career information and can examine third party websites such as Glassdoor to gain insider information on company policies and work climates (→Ryan and Delany 2017).

3.2 Interviews and Decision-Making

The most significant advance in selection processes over the last two decades may be the reinforcement of the importance of structured interviews, where candidates' responses to the same questions are scored on anchored rating scales (→Sackett et al. 2022). Structured interviews significantly predict new employees' job performance, reduce race, gender, and disability biases, and reduce applicants' impression management effects on interview ratings (e.g., →Huffcutt, Culbertson, and Goebl 2015; →Levashina et al.

2014; →Sackett et al. 2022). →Levashina et al. (2014: 279) proposed that “applicants with low job-related qualifications will have negative perceptions of structured interviews, whereas applicants with high levels of job-related qualifications will have positive perceptions of structured interviews”.

Better predictability is also associated with behavioral description interview questions, which provide information on candidates’ experience, followed by situational interviews, which reveal job knowledge (→Latham and Skarlicki 1995). Although individuals’ responses to interviewer questions are critical to assessing organization and job fit, the specific recruiter-candidate verbal exchanges that lead to determinations of PO and PJ fit remain unclear. Candidates’ levels of nonverbal communication, levels of vocal activity, and engaging in conversation during interviews (→Jablin 2001) may be prime areas for future research. For hiring decisions, meta-analytic findings show perceptions of candidates’ PO and PJ fit are highly predictive of organizations’ intent to hire (→Kristof-Brown, Zimmerman, and Johnson 2005).

Applicants’ interactions with organizational representatives and information quality remain important factors in applicants’ decision-making, consistent with prior research (e.g., →Jablin 2001). Applicants favor recruiters who provide job and organizational information not readily available (via online or corporate publications), yet consistent with third party sources. They also prefer personable recruiters (e.g., →Uggerslev, Fassina, and Kraichy 2012). Of note, recruiters’ interview training and job knowledge may be limited according to an investigation of over 1,000 recruiters to 11 college campuses that found 50% of interviewers were non-HR employees (sometimes representing non-hiring units) who volunteered or were directed to recruit. These campus recruiters reported considerably less interview training, suggesting variance in their ability to provide relevant job

information (e.g., nature of work, unit climate) to candidates or appropriately rate applicants (→Miller, Gardner, and Meiners 2001).

Job attributes prove most important in job applicants' decision to accept job offers (→Barber 1998; →Ryan and Delany 2017). Realistic job previews remain theoretically important, but rarely investigated. Instead, researchers tend to measure PO and PJ fit, likely due to difficulties creating valid realistic preview measures. →Meglino, Denisi, and Ravlin's (1993) study remains an exemplar for establishing validity of realistic previews by utilizing job analyses, in-depth interviews, and a 22-minute video that emphasized unpleasant aspects of correction officer positions. Of note, a recent experimental design with an online sample of Black and African-American adults finds that colorblind and implicit race-acknowledged realistic organizational previews are associated with higher intentions to accept job offers than explicit race-acknowledged realistic previews (→Austin and Bisel 2023).

3.3 Future Research Opportunities

With notable exceptions (→Allen, Mahto, and Otondo 2007; →Berkelaar 2014; →Carr 2016), communication scholars largely abandoned employment interview research. This development is unfortunate given the importance of job seeker-recruiter interactions in determining hiring decisions and creating newcomer and incumbent expectations (→Jablin 2001).

One fertile research area pertains to recruiter-candidate talk-time and probing of candidates' answers. Planned probing of candidates' answers likely strengthens interview validity and increases candidate talk-time. Planned probing may decrease candidate faking since recruiters can explore details of candidates' answers (→Levashina et al. 2014). At the same time, little is known about training recruiters in

question-asking, much less scripted or spontaneous probing (→Wegmeyer et al. 2022).

The use of restricted samples of undergraduate and MBA students limits research in this area. Recruitment practices targeting individuals with greater work experience and in non-collegiate settings are largely unexplored. The extent to which experienced individuals use third party websites like Glassdoor and what information has greater credibility might provide insights into realistic previews and perceptions of fit.

"Second", selection interviews remain largely unexplored despite →Miller and Buzzanell's (1996) theoretical exposition on communication's role in onsite interviews and how it differs from campus screening interviews. →Uggerslev, Fassina, and Kraichy's (2012) investigation of factors across →Barber's (1998) three stages of recruitment (e.g., generating applicants, maintaining applicant status, and influencing job choices) provides useful insights into the influence of job and organizational attributes and recruiter's behaviors across stages, but the study lacked longitudinal data.

Finally, organizations increasingly use automation to collect, process, and store large applicant pool data (→Landers, Fink, and Collmus 2017). Machine learning promises to identify patterns in biographical data that predict job performance and turnover (→Sajjadiani et al. 2019) or to assess relevant personality characteristics from video-submitted screening interviews (→Hickman et al. 2022). The validity of automated tools or the consequences accompanying reduced applicant-organizational representative interaction are unknown. Important communication issues regarding technology-enhanced selection include organizations' transparency in data collection and analyses, applicant reactions, and potential ethical issues related to adverse impact of underrepresented groups (→Tippins, Oswald, and McPhail 2021).

4 Encounter Experiences

Socialization is profoundly important for organizations and newcomers. Role-sending and role-taking are dominant processes during organizational entry where newcomers negotiate expectations with others for new positions (→Katz and Kahn 1978; →Kramer 2010). During organizational entry, newcomers learn job duties, organization culture and norms, and what is important to the organization or their subunit (→Schein [1968] 1988). Equally important, newcomers develop relationships with supervisors and coworkers, digest and prioritize information from multiple sources, and compare current and past experiences (→Jablin 2001). Newcomers encounter mild discrepancies (surprises) or severe ones (shocks) between work expectations and realities (→Louis 1980). More incongruous discrepancies hamper their adjustment, perceptions of PO/PJ fit, and role development.

4.1 Socialization Experiences

Newcomers' first days in organizations often include orientation and tours, meeting coworkers, and completing Human Resource forms. This period, known as onboarding, can be mere formality, or an intentional, strategic socialization step. →Klein, Polin, and Leigh Sutton's (2015) examination of 30 organizational onboarding practices reported two practices perceived as most helpful for newcomer acclimation: (a) offering "guides" (e.g., single point of contact or assigned coworker to answer questions) and (b) requiring incumbents' participation in onboarding practices within their units. →Smith et al. (2022) posit that "early, salient, positive [onboarding] events" (p. 535) can serve as anchoring points for employees with low organizational investment, create favorable attitudes toward the organization, and increase their work engagement. Orientations also provide opportunities for

newcomers to recast prior work experiences in ways to affirm attachment to their new employer (→Stephens and Dailey 2012).

Considering organizational entry holistically, →Manata et al. (2016) report three approaches to understanding socialization's communicative aspects: contextual, content, and memorable messages. Contextual approaches, derived from →Van Maanen and Schein's (1979) seminal work, suggest organizations consciously or incidentally chose among six pairs of socialization strategies or tactics – collective vs. individual, formal vs. informal, serial vs. disjunctive, sequential vs. random, fixed vs. variable, and investiture vs divestiture. Examples of communication within their tactics include formal (e.g., receiving prepared materials or training depicts a formal strategy) and serial (e.g., nearby job-knowledgeable incumbents who can answer questions or model behaviors).

Meta-analyses of socialization tactics conclude that the six tactics, aggregated together to reflect more formal, structured, and "institutionalized" experiences, are associated with reduced role ambiguity and role conflict while being positively associated with job satisfaction, commitment, fit, and performance (→Bauer et al. 2007). Further, "social or interpersonal aspects of socialization [from serial and investiture tactics] are most important for newcomers' adjustment" (→Saks, Uggerslev, and Fassina 2007: 440). A longitudinal study examining *changes* in newcomer acclimation showed developing peer relationships is the greatest contributor to newcomer's role clarity (→Zhou et al. 2022).

Content approaches in socialization research examine information conveyed to or discovered by newcomers (→Klein and Heuser 2008). →Chao et al. (1994) classified information content into history, language, politics, people, organizational goals and values, and performance proficiency. Their

longitudinal study found knowledge of organizational politics was most predictive of salary, knowledge of organizational goals and values were predictive of career involvement, and knowledge of goals and values and firm history were predictive of job satisfaction. Modifying Chao et al.'s scales to measure information received during entry, →Hart and Miller (2005) found receiving information on performing their jobs proficiently reduced manager-trainees' role ambiguity. By integrating over 20 conceptualizations and four measures of information content, →Cooper-Thomas et al. (2020) offered a parsimonious conceptualization and measure of content along three domains: role (e.g., "I know what my supervisor considers good performance"); relationships (e.g., "My coworkers are generally willing to offer assistance or advice"); and organization (e.g., "I am familiar with this organization's history").

Like anchoring events, memorable message approaches examine conversations and statements that have lasting impacts on newcomers (e.g., →Barge and Schlueter 2004). Likely occurring in the first months of employment, memorable messages serve work-related functions (e.g., professional behavior, work ethic) and interpersonal-related functions (e.g., promote personal aptitude and growth, expectation reinforcement) (→Barge and Schlueter 2004). For volunteers, memorable messages focused on work significance and benefits to others were associated with higher levels of identification (→Steimel 2013).

4.2 Information Seeking

Newcomers demonstrate agency by communicating directly and indirectly to acquire job-related information (e.g., →Miller and Jablin 1991; →Woo, Endacott, and Myers 2023). Uncertainty, competition, and self-evaluation motivate information seeking to cope with new settings, promote

learning, and decipher organizational norms and culture. Newcomers rely on direct inquiry with supervisors to learn performance expectations and receive feedback (→Ostroff and Kozlowski 1992). Credible coworkers serve as informational sources, yet social costs may prompt more discrete means of information acquisition from peers (→Sias and Wyers 2001). Characteristics of newcomers' information networks encourage or constrain access to organizational knowledge (e.g., →Fang, Duffy, and Shaw 2011). However, the extent to which socializing agents have adequate skills, have dedicated time, or sufficiently motivated to instruct newcomers appears quite variable (→Frögéli and Backström Eriksson 2023).

Despite nuanced lists for information acquisition tactics (e.g., overt inquiry, third parties, testing limits; →Miller and Jablin 1991), operationalizations commonly reduce information seeking to two dimensions, direct inquiry and indirect monitoring and focus on frequency of information seeking. Ignoring →Jablin's (2001) call, with few exceptions (e.g., →Morrison 1995), little research has examined the usefulness or relevance of the acquired information. →Bauer et al.'s (2007) meta-analysis suggests that gathering appraisal information (i.e., performance feedback) may be the most important information action for newcomers' learning "the ropes" and improving performance.

To date, evidence of the effectiveness of direct inquiry and monitoring on role learning and performance remains weak. Methodological factors such as early (e.g., 1–3 weeks) versus late (e.g., 6–9 months) data collection and newcomers' prior knowledge may lead to weaker relationships between information seeking and outcomes. Newcomer information seeking frequency declines rapidly across the first weeks of employment as newcomers' organizational knowledge increases (→Vancouver, Tamanini, and Yoder 2010) and social costs likely rise. Supervisors' relationship quality with

newcomers and motivation to share information may also confound findings on information seeking and adjustment (e.g., →Ellis et al. 2017; →Vancouver, Tamanini, and Yoder 2010). Possibly due to measurement challenges and interest in broader newcomer actions that contribute to acclimation (e.g., →Parker and Collins 2010), information seeking is often integrated into measures of newcomers' proactive behaviors.

Proactive behaviors refer to newcomers' attempts to accelerate and optimize their adjustment, which include changing work procedures, socializing, networking, seeking feedback, building relationships with supervisors, positive framing, and reading as well as direct inquiry and monitoring (e.g., →Cooper-Thomas et al. 2014). Newcomers who employ the full range of proactive behaviors likely benefit in their development, well-being, and work engagement (→Cooper-Thomas et al. 2020). Some proactive behaviors may complement socialization tactics or even substitute for them. For instance, institutionalized tactics promoted PO fit among South Korean newcomers who actively socialized and kept a positive mindset but were less important for those who developed close supervisor relationships (→Kim, Cable, and Kim 2005).

4.3 Future Research Opportunities

In the future, investigators must expand research designs to include broader conceptualizations of socialization content (→Klein and Heuser 2008) and longitudinal considerations (→Vancouver, Tamanini, and Yoder 2010). With notable exceptions (e.g., →Manata 2019; →Tornes and Kramer 2022), studies rarely use multi-level designs that separate unique individual, unit, and organizational influences on newcomers (→Kramer and Miller 2014; →Manata et al. 2016). Given the importance of integrating newcomers into units (e.g., →Saks, Uggerslev, and Fassina 2007), a greater understanding of unit

norms and social dynamics might provide insights into role learning and succeeding beyond initial entry experiences. As noted earlier in →Table 1, future studies should endeavor to test theories directly in addition to "building upon" theory when in search of pragmatic value.

In addition, e-socialization may restrict newcomers' proactive behaviors, reduce their learning of social and normative information, and decrease their social capital due to physical separation (→Gruman and Saks 2018; →Woo, Endacott, and Myers 2023). Yet, internal social media platforms, such as Slack, might foster more opportunities for proactive information seeking. The accelerated use of virtual technologies for workplace communication warrants greater attention as these changes impact newcomer adjustment.

Finally, examining broader entry outcomes beyond role ambiguity, identity, and commitment is vital. →Myers and Oetzel (2003) provide measures of supervisor familiarity, acculturation, recognition, involvement, job competency, and role negotiation. →Cooper-Thomas et al. (2020) integrate four socialization content scales and offer scales for newcomers' role, relationships, and organizational learning components.

5 Role-Making Processes

Employees engage in role making by attempting to alter others' expectations of their role's purpose, the manner in which it will be performed, and/or how it will be evaluated (→Graen 1976; →Jablin 2001). Individuals "not only conform to role expectations, [but also] interpret, organize, modify, and create them" (→Zurcher 1983: 13). Messages from others and self-interpretations of roles shape individuals' self-concepts and actions as they attempt to merge what they want to do with what is expected of them. Communication scholars have investigated role making in two related directions, membership negotiation and role negotiation.

5.1 Membership Negotiation

A critical issue from organizational entry until exit concerns individuals' relationships to others, their positions, and the organization. This concept of membership constitution involves individuals defining themselves and others in parlay with their and others' expectations (→McPhee and Zuag 2000). As →Scott and Myers (2010: 83) note, "individual attachment is always changing and requires ongoing reaccomplishment".

→Woo and Myers (2020: 85) define membership negotiation as "ongoing communication processes through which individuals develop meanings of their organizational participation". Investigations of membership negotiation reveal complexities of sensemaking and adjustment. Past work experiences are incorporated into individuals' self-concept and representation (→Stephens and Dailey 2012). Yet, organizations do not always value contributions from previous work experience, sometimes creating disconcerting and challenging adjustment transitions for newcomers (→Endacott and Myers 2019).

Identity issues often challenge boundary spanners, whose roles require developing relational ties to individuals in other units or organizations. To operate effectively, they likely acquire nuanced understandings of other stakeholders' needs and missions. Their own unit may question their loyalty and identity with their unit as a result (→Woo and Myers 2020). Key identity formation elements vary across organizational settings. Reciprocity, acceptance, and social influence appear paramount among professionals (→Rajamäki and Mikkola 2021), but elements of the physical environment, mobility, relationships, engagement, and the body dominate identity in involuntary settings (→Peterson and McNamee 2017).

5.2 Role Negotiation

Role negotiation "occurs when two or more persons consciously interact with the express purpose of altering the others' expectations about how a role should be enacted and evaluated" (→Miller et al. 1996: 296). Distinguishing characteristics of role negotiations involve overt discussions of proposed changes in task processes and/or assigned responsibilities. These interactions enable supervisors to access and discuss employee aims and needs (→Olufowote, Miller, and Wilson 2005), provide opportunities for a "human moment" (→Hallowell 1999: 58), and move parties closer to concurring on process and outcome expectations (→Graen 1976).

For example, high-quality communication relationships with managers increase employees' perceptions that they can negotiate their roles (→Miller et al. 1999). Manufacturing employees tend to use rational presentations to influence shift supervisors when the organization, not the individual, stands to gain the most from the change (→Olufowote, Miller, and Wilson 2005). For college students working part-time, positive relational tone between managers and employees was associated with conversational directness (→Meiners and Miller 2004). →Woo, Miller, and Lamsen (2021) illustrate how emergency workers quickly modify responsibilities through verbal and nonverbal signaling.

Considerable research examines conceptualizations of job crafting and iDeals. The former explicates the internal motivations and contextual factors for role development (→Wrzesniewski and Dutton 2001). The latter focuses on leveraging favorable social exchange or alternative employment (e.g., competitive job offer) factors (→Rousseau 2005). Each offers insights into role development, but generally glosses over the communication dynamics through which role making and work agreements are achieved. →Rudolph et al.'s (2017) meta-analysis indicates that job

crafting increases job engagement and decreases job strain. Job-crafting actions that remove performance-hindering stressors also reduce employee turnover intentions.

5.3 Future Research Opportunities

Role change proactivity can create more satisfactory and productive work conditions but can also affect others' workloads and efficiencies (e.g., →Berg, Wrzesniewski, and Dutton 2010; →Grant and Parker 2009). Investigations (e.g., →Zhang et al. 2021) have begun considering the impact of one person's role change on other unit members. Further, communicative and non-communicative forms of role change (e.g., job crafting, iDeals) likely involve discussions with supervisors to review changes and gain approval but have yet to be adequately investigated.

The nature of message exchanges in role negotiations is important to examine from a communication perspective. →Tims, Bakker, and Derks (2012) posit the content of these exchanges concerns increasing job resources (e.g., job variety, autonomy), increasing social job resources (e.g., social support, feedback), increasing challenging job demands (e.g., developing new knowledge, receiving more difficult goals), and decreasing hindering job demands (e.g., reducing negative emotional contexts). However, the formality of interactions, number of episodes, and timing likely influence negotiation processes and outcomes. Exploring micro-negotiations in work units, where subtle adjustments are made on a daily basis to cover a colleague's illness or work overload, may provide additional insights into newcomers' negotiation skill development.

6 Non-“Traditional” “Newcomers”

The prototypical organizational newcomers in research are first career job newcomers, ages 18 to 25, assuming entry- or low-level management positions following formal training or education. This tendency restricts the research’s generalizability to more experienced “newcomers”, who are likely to have different encounters than neophyte newcomers. The →US Bureau of Labor Statistics (2023) estimates individuals average 12 jobs during their working years, which may underestimate those switching jobs within an organization.

6.1 Experienced Individuals but Organizational Newcomers

Experienced newcomers bring diverse knowledge, work identities, and strategies that influence their adjustment (→Beyer and Hannah 2002). Some individuals, dissatisfied with their prior employment, follow a sense of calling to other careers, even if it involves lower status jobs (→Tan and Kramer 2012). Consequently, newcomers with considerable prior work history may feel like some combination of insiders, marginal members, or outsiders.

Experienced newcomers’ explanations of their motivations for leaving another position for the present one range from positive (seeking new opportunities) to neutral (move closer to family) to negative (negative peer/supervisor relationships). Like individuals exiting jobs or observing others’ departures (→Godager et al. 2022; →Klatzke 2016), experienced employees tailor explanations about job or career changes depending upon personal reflection and the audience. How these newcomers inform their new peers and supervisors of their expertise in a credible manner and without damaging newly formed relationships merits future investigation.

6.2 Newcomers to Jobs but Same Organizations

Employees who transfer to new locations within their same organization, including international transfers (expatriates) and domestic transfers (→Black, Mendenhall, and Oddou 1991; →Kramer 1993) or rotational program participants (→Dailey 2016a), are veteran company employees, but "newcomers" to locations and/or positions. Communication with their new supervisors and peers directly affects how quickly they reduce their uncertainty to become effective in their new positions.

In other cases, promoted individuals experience task and relational uncertainty as they become supervisors to former peers, while not experiencing uncertainty about the organizational norms and culture (e.g., →Ballinger and Schoorman 2007; →Kramer and Noland 1999). They must learn to manage communicating new information based on their new status. In mergers and acquisitions, experienced employees must learn the new combined culture, develop new relationships, and determine the new organization's verbal and nonverbal communication norms.

6.3 Future Research Opportunities

Many understudied newcomer populations remain. For example, many "retirees" work part-time or begin second careers typically supervised by younger, less experienced managers. Older employees in age-reversed dyads have lower expectations of supervisors (→Collins et al. 2009) and likely inadvertently communicate attitudes that affect relationships to younger supervisors and other employees. It would be valuable to examine retirees' work experiences in new places or even new positions within their previous companies.

Members of many underrepresented groups join organizations or occupations, such as members of racial or ethnic minorities, men or women entering occupations

traditionally held by the opposite gender, individuals of nontraditional gender status, or individuals raised in a different socio-economic status than their new position. It would be valuable to understand communication during these unique experiences more so than the sparse research available to date (e.g., →Gist-Mackey, Wiley, and Erba 2018).

Communication during new unit or organizational leaders' socialization likely differs from traditional samples. Those hired to produce change as visionary (→Bennis and Nanus 2007) or transformational leaders (→Bass 1990) likely have distinct entry experiences compared to those brought in as institutional leaders, who are expected to maintain the unit or organization's culture (e.g., →Trice and Beyer 1993). Research can explore communication surrounding those expectations and how new leaders accept, modify, or resist them. Additional insights into role making might also be forthcoming given resources associated with their leadership positions and ability to individualize their positions.

7 Conclusion

This chapter highlights important developments in research examining the experiences of organizational newcomers. Organizational entry remains a fruitful area for communication theory and research. The value of research on organizational entry processes is likely to grow in importance with advances in technologies, societal norms, new ways of working, and globalization.

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Chapter 9 Conflict and Negotiation

Linda L. Putnam

Marshall Scott Poole

Abstract

Organizations are ripe with opportunities for conflict and negotiation. Communication plays a pivotal role in managing disputes as well as constituting the very nature of conflict itself. This chapter reviews the role that communication plays in three arenas of workplace conflict: interpersonal, negotiation, and intergroup. In particular, it examines how communication functions as a structural or an interactional variable, as a process, or as meanings and symbols in conflict interactions. In interpersonal conflict, research has moved away from conflict styles to focus on metaphors, emotional expressions, communication skills, and expressions of gratitude and forgiveness. Interactional and process perspectives dominate negotiation in the workplace, particularly in examining sequences and patterns of interaction, turning points, linguistic style mapping, discourse, and relational paradoxes. Finally, in the intergroup arena, communication functions as both a structural and an interactional variable in accounting for social identity, categorization, projections of group differences, and self-reinforcing cycles.

Keywords: conflict styles, emotional expressions, integrative-distributive, negotiation sequences, turning points, framing, social identity, polarization, stereotyping,

In an era of rapid changes, conflict and conflict management in the workplace are critical topics. Conflict covers a vast array

of arenas and has expanded its terrain, particularly in embracing work-life conflict, bullying, and ethnic/diversity issues. Unresolved and poorly managed organizational conflict has detrimental consequences for organizations, including reduced decision quality, impaired relationships, employee turnover, and diminished health of workers (→Oetzel and Ting-Toomey 2013a). Yet, at the same time, effective conflict management promotes flexibility and adaptiveness, balances power relationships, guards against groupthink, and facilitates quality decision making (→Putnam 1997). In this way, conflict is not only beneficial to an organization but "it is essential to its very existence" (→Pondy 1989: 96). The key then is the management of it.

In this chapter, conflict is defined as the "interaction of interdependent people who perceive opposition in goals, aims, and values, and who see the other party as potentially interfering with the realization of these goals" (→Putnam and Poole 1987: 552). This definition parallels most communication scholars who focus on incompatibilities, expressed struggle, and interdependence of two or more parties in organizational conflicts (→Putnam 2013). Moreover, most scholars believe that conflict occurs through social interaction, exchanges of verbal and nonverbal messages, and symbolic meanings.

Communication, as the means by which conflict is enacted and managed, is a key element in the difference between beneficial and harmful conflict processes. As noted in →Putnam and Poole (1987), communication infuses the underlying sources, goals, strategies/tactics, relationships, and context of conflict management. It is not just an "add on" to conflict, but how the conflict is constituted (→Putnam 2013). In this way, communication is the motor or driving force of conflict and dispute management.

The literature on communication, conflict, and organizations has grown exponentially. It includes handbook chapters, edited volumes, and textbooks (→Eadie and Nelson

2001; →Folger and Jones 1994; →Geist and Hardesty 1992; →Jameson 2023; →Kellett and Matyók 2016; →Nicotera 1995; →Oetzel and Ting-Toomey 2006; →Putnam and Roloff 1992) in addition to a vast number of research articles. Moreover, it also encompasses a wide array of topics, including work-family conflicts, global workplaces, e-negotiations, social justice perspectives, organizational environmental conflicts, and ethnic-diversity conflicts (see Oetzel and Ting-Toomey 2013b). In effect, the types of conflict have changed, even moving away from rational models to highly volatile ones, such as workplace aggression (→Geddes and Baron 1997; →Geddes, Callister, and Gibson 2020).

Given the growth of studies, we have limited this review to parallel the →Putnam and Poole (1987) chapter, particularly in its focus on interpersonal conflict in the workplace, negotiation in organizations, and intergroup work conflict. As a narrow cast, it still cuts across micro and meso levels of analysis. Micro typically focuses on individual perceptions and dyadic relationships, such as supervisor-employee or coworker conflicts while negotiation focuses on buyer-seller, labor-management, contract and policy decisions, and multiparty interactions. Intergroup conflict also cuts across levels through examining intergroup differences, especially across societal-organizational levels.

We begin this chapter with a brief history of communication and conflict, particularly noting the theoretical orientations that guided early scholarship. We show how a shift from an implicit to an explicit focus on communication moved the field away from game theory and social exchange to process theories. Growing out of this overview, we delineate key assumptions that underlie our view of conflict – its normalcy, value-rooted status, and inevitability. This section concludes with examining how scholars cast the role of communication in conflict. In particular, we explore three overarching roles that communication plays in conflict;

namely, (1) as a structural or interactional variable that mediates antecedents and outcomes of disputes; (2) as an interactional process that shapes the nature of conflict and its development, for example, sequences, cycles, or stages; and (3) as struggles over meaning evident in interpretive symbols, reflexivity, and the dialectical interplay of opposites (→Putnam 2013). These three orientations serve as a framework to synthesize the literature in each arena.

1 Historical and Theoretical Approaches

The early research on communication and conflict typically adopted game theory, social exchange, systems theory, and interpretive/ critical theory approaches (→Putnam and Poole 1987). Game theory focused on payoffs and outcomes and cast communication primarily as a channel or a linear transmission of information flow. Residues of game theory surfaced in social exchange models of conflict as ways to maximize rewards and minimize costs (→Roloff and Campion 1985). Researchers embraced assumptions of reciprocity rooted in individual attributes, perceptions, and influence patterns (→Putnam 2013). Moving away from linear models of communication, systems theory approaches treated conflict as growing out of ongoing processes of interactions. Early work in this area focused on cooperative-competitive strategies as well as stages of escalation-de-escalation over time (→Putnam and Poole 1987) and scholars coded interactions to develop categories of message systems.

Three important assumptions about communication and conflict grew out of this history. First, researchers concluded that conflict in organizations was inevitable – a natural and normal process of organizing. Hence, it was not an aberration that disrupted harmony or blocked problem solving rather it facilitated creativity, change, and growth. Secondly, communication played an essential role in enacting conflict

management and shaping whether conflict would follow a constructive or destructive path. Moreover, scholars concluded that escalation and de-escalation were intertwined and often fed into each other as conflicts ebbed and flowed over time. Overall, researchers agreed that communication enacts conflict processes as it manages and produces conflict outcomes.

2 Role of Communication in Organizational Conflict

This historical picture also reveals how communication assumes a wide variety of roles in studying conflict – roles that range from information transmission to verbal-nonverbal strategies to surface and deep-level meanings. Focusing on the role of communication per se provides a lens or a framework to cluster the different studies in this review. Hence, we ask how do scholars cast communication and its role in organizational conflict? In effect, what role does conflict play in organizing and in organizational communication? Based on this historical overview, we set forth the following framework to organize each section of this chapter:

- *Communication as a structural or interaction variable*. In this approach, communication is one of many variables that moderate antecedent conditions and influence conflict outcomes. Examples of structural variables include choice of media, predispositions as communication strategies, and messages driven by gender or organizational role while examples of interactional variables include arguments, face management behaviors, and emotional expressions that shape conflict outcomes.

- *Communication as process*. In this category, communication shapes the very nature of conflict itself as an evolving process over time. This approach corresponds to a systems theory model, but it cast communication as

constituting conflict. This work emphasizes patterned relationships among messages and the evolution of conflict over time, particularly in sequences, patterns, cycles, spirals, phase development, episodes, and issue/conflict transformation (→Kellett and Matyók 2016).
- *Communication as interpretive symbols*. In this approach communication and conflict constitute each other in a reflexive way that alters each of them over time. This approach focuses on meanings, symbols, and discourses to examine what communication is doing in conflict and how talk and symbols surface in meanings that shape conflict processes.

Other orientations exist, but these three are prominent in the research literature, especially in the three areas included in this review, namely, interpersonal conflict in the workplace, negotiation in the workplace, and intergroup conflict.

3 Interpersonal Conflict in the Workplace

Historically, interpersonal conflict in the workplace focused on dyadic disputes, particularly conflict styles in superior-subordinate relationships (→Putnam and Poole 1987). Over the years, though, this work has broadened to include coworker relationships and norms for professional and organizational conduct in interpersonal conflicts.

Initially, the term conflict style referred to an individual's predisposition for handling disputes, but communication scholars have treated styles as message strategies (→Putnam and Poole 1987). The classic five-style inventory has remained similar over the years, but this line of research, while popular in the 1980s and 1990s, has diminished over time. The five-category scheme includes: (1) integrating or collaborating, such as raising issues directly and engaging in problem solving; (2) forcing or competing through the use of verbal dominance, assertiveness, and perseverance; (3) smoothing or

accommodating through glossing over differences, playing down disagreements, and treating conflict as trivial; (4) avoiding or withdrawing physically and/or psychologically, including removal from the conflict and failure to confront; and (5) compromising as reaching a middle ground, splitting the difference, or meeting the other party halfway (→Putnam and Poole 1987).

3.1 Communication as a Structural Variable

For the most part, scholars continue to use questionnaires to assess the five styles; hence, conflict styles research treats communication as a structural variable that moderates outcomes. In particular, researchers have focused on gender, cultural differences, and hierarchical role as influencing the choice of conflict styles (→Cai and Fink 2002; →Lee and Rogan 1991). Yet, after an extensive literature review, →Nicotera and Dorsey (2006) conclude that preference for conflict styles is not driven by gender (see also, →Brewer, Mitchell, and Weber 2002; →Sorenson, Hawkins, and Sorenson 1995). However, cultural differences differentiate choice of conflict styles, but importantly, self-image is a better predictor of style preference than is ethnicity (→Oetzel 1998). Even though early studies suggest that superiors and subordinates prefer different styles for managing conflicts with each other (→Putnam and Poole 1987), →Powell and Hickson (2000) report that anticipated success in reaching a settlement governs style preference more than hierarchical role. These studies follow the earlier work on conflict styles in treating communication as equivalent to predispositions for conflict strategies. However, preference for conflict style does not actually parallel enacted conflict behaviors (→Nicotera and Dorsey 2006).

Conflict style research has begun to focus on face concerns and identity goals. In this way style preference is

based on concerns for the other party. Specifically, choice of integrating, smoothing, and compromise styles reflect a desire to maintain the other party's face rather than one's own face (→De Dreu, Weingart, and Kwon 2000; →Oetzel et al. 2003). This finding also applies to members of cultural groups who place a premium on protecting the other party's face (→Oetzel and Ting-Toomey 2003). However, this pattern differs for younger as opposed to older adults (→Zhang, Harwood, and Hummert 2005). Overall, the number of studies that treat communication as a structural variable for predicting conflict styles has diminished over the years. Some research, however, focuses on the sequences and repertoires of styles that combine communicative strategies in interpersonal conflicts.

3.2 Moving toward an Interaction Variable

For the most part, conflict styles research relies on scales or measurement instruments to assess preferences for message strategies (see →Putnam and Poole 1987: 557). Some researchers, however, have moved away from individual assessment alone to focus on shifts in style preferences over time. These shifts typically hinge on whether the initial approach a person uses yields the desired outcomes. For example, if a disputant begins a conflict with a collaborative strategy, an individual might shift to forcing or smoothing if agreement is not reached (→Conrad 1991; →McCready and Roberts 1996; →Nicotera 1994). These shifts, based on the response to an initial strategy, also vary by gender composition of dyads (→Papa and Natalle 1989).

Researchers have also conceptualized the five styles as repertoires or aggregate behaviors that work in combination to maximize effectiveness. For example, the use of forcing followed by problem solving followed by smoothing often results in the best substantive and relational outcomes (→Van

de Vliert, Huismans, and Euwema 1995). Other studies have added emotional valence to the classic five styles, have challenged the two-dimensional origin of the styles, and have added new styles to the mix (→Nicotera 1993, →1994). In addition, workplace norms and climates influence preferences for conflict styles, hence, they are not just individual predispositions.

Treating communication as a conflict management style or strategy restricts its role primarily to being a variable. This approach also treats conflict as disagreements, misunderstandings, and ambiguity rather than as incongruent goals, practices, and values. Thus, scholars have turned to language and metaphors to investigate individual orientations to interpersonal conflict.

3.3 Embracing an Interpretive Approach

Disenchanted with conflict styles, scholars have adopted interpretative approaches to alter the direction of research. In particular, they have used metaphors, narratives, and discourse to investigate orientations to and meanings of conflict events. A metaphor is a linguistic term that refers to seeing a thing as if it were something else. To examine preferences for conflict metaphors, Burrell, Buzzanell, and McMillian (1992) conducted a study of images that organizational members held about conflict. Their analysis revealed three prototypes: (1) conflict as war/destruction, (2) conflict as impotence/inequality, and (3) conflict as resolution opportunity. Moreover, in images of interpersonal conflicts, negative metaphors surfaced more often than positive ones and women adopted impotence/inequality descriptions more often than men did (→Buzzanell and Burrell 1997). Interestingly, the war metaphor depicted coworker conflicts; resolution metaphors aligned with supervisor conflicts; and impotence/inequity images surfaced for departmental

conflicts. Further analysis revealed that metaphors symbolically shaped the underlying meanings of events and typified disputants' roles.

Unlike metaphors, narratives reveal characters, scenes, emotional expressions, and plots of interpersonal conflict interactions. →Gayle and Preiss (1998) collected stories of interpersonal conflicts at work and coded them into the categories of topic, partner status, emotional intensity, and communicative strategies. They found that lingering emotions from past conflicts infused current ones, particularly if the conflict was not managed effectively. Emotions surfaced as a powerful predictor of the communication strategies that disputants used. Drawing directly on discourse in disputes, →Roberts (1999) focused on identity creation in interpersonal conflicts during a crisis. Coding discursive and rhetorical strategies, she concluded that the ability to maintain a sense of self in the midst of a dispute facilitated effective management of interpersonal workplace conflict.

In summary, most research on conflict styles casts communication as a structural or an interactional variable. Style surfaces as an orientation to use particular message strategies, ones that moderate the effect of antecedents on conflict outcomes. Even though researchers have examined sequences and repertoires of style choice, communication remains in the role of a structural or interactional variable. Scholars who embrace the interpretive approach have broadened conceptions of communication to capture emotions, organizational context, and past conflicts as factors that shape approaches to interpersonal disputes.

3.4 New Directions in Interpersonal Work Conflict

Moving away from conflict styles, two new directions in interpersonal conflict have emerged: communication skills and forgiveness in the workplace. Research on *communication*

skills stemmed from interviews with healthcare professionals. Specifically, →Jameson (2003) tracked the communicative strategies that increased and/or decreased conflict escalation. Not surprisingly, power-based tactics escalated conflict while collaboration strategies transcended controversies. Communication skills that promoted transcendence in patient-provider conflicts included self-disclosure, active listening, perspective taking, reframing, and conveying empathic behavior (→Jameson and Albada 2013). In addition, the use of humor, asking questions, eliciting opinions, and clarifying understandings enhanced effective conflict management among co-workers as well as between patients and providers. Importantly, the professional/organizational context was a powerful force in shaping interpersonal conflict situations.

The second new research direction centers on two particular types of communication competencies – *expressing gratitude* and *offering forgiveness* in conflict situations. Expressing gratitude refers to showing appreciation in workplace conflict situations. It encompasses the skills of reinforcing, reflecting on, listening, explaining, and self-disclosure in addition to the communication skills of persuasion, negotiation, and assertiveness. Drawn from facework theories, expressing gratitude also entails switching from a negative to a positive conflict narrative. In a study of 35 cases, →Brinkert (2016) found that expressing gratitude during an interpersonal workplace conflict saved the other party's face, served as a turning point in the relationship, and made other colleagues feel less defensive. Importantly, making gratitude appropriate to the organizational context was pivotal to effective conflict management.

A related line of research, offering forgiveness, grew out of interest in emotional expressions in interpersonal conflicts (→Bodtker and Jameson 2001). This approach stood in contrast to responding with revenge or avoiding hurtful conflict situations (→Wang, Fink, and Cai 2012). In particular,

when an employee had empathy for the wrongdoer in a close work relationship, individuals chose to forgive (→Paul and Rigorgiate 2015). Conciliatory forgiveness also entailed apology as well as efforts to restore the relationship.

The use of forgiveness and relational restoration also stems from organizational norms, professional moral codes, and workplace climates. To illustrate, →Paul and Putnam (2016) conducted in-depth interviews with teachers and professional staff in four high schools. Their study uncovered four different types of forgiveness – moving on, not taking it personally, letting go, and conciliatory forgiveness. In professional situations, participants responded by moving on and not taking the conflict personally. They expressed frustrations to friends and colleagues outside of the organization rather than confront their colleagues. Individuals selected letting go when conflicts were less severe and relationships were distant. Thus, communicating forgiveness was not simply an individual's choice, but rather, it rested with norms, types of workplace relationships, and organizational cultures (→Paul and Putnam 2016).

This section centers on interpersonal conflict in the workplace. Although once the domain of conflict styles, research now includes face concerns, sequences and repertoires of message strategies, and interpretative work on metaphors, narratives and discourse in conflict situations. Thus, scholars are increasingly embracing process and interpretive approaches to interpersonal workplace conflicts. New directions focus on communication skills and competencies, namely, expressing emotions, gratitude, and forgiveness in workplace conflicts. These approaches also reveal how organizational norms and professional codes play a pivotal role in managing workplace conflicts.

4 Negotiation in the Workplace

The study of negotiation in the workplace has moved beyond dyadic interactions to focus on strikes, hostage situations, and environmental disputes. Unlike the work on interpersonal conflict, scholars focus less on styles and more on interaction patterns, yet, similar to the interpersonal arena, researchers center on message functions, emotional expressions, and language/discourse approaches.

Drawn from the formal bargaining context, negotiation research began with game theory and social exchange models that relied heavily on comparing channels of communication and using influence strategies. This work, however, shifted as scholars began to code interaction strategies and tactics, especially as negotiations developed over time (→Putnam 2013).

4.1 Coding Communication Behaviors as Interactional Variables

Inspired by theories of distributive (win-lose) and integrative (win-win) negotiation, communication scholars took the lead in coding what disputants said and how they responded to each other. Most negotiation coding schemes centered on message functions, for example, the use of attacking arguments, threats, put-down statements, and rejection remarks as distributive tactics, and the use of questions, acceptance statements, information exchange, and offers as exemplifying integrative strategies. Scholars tested the overall frequencies of types of strategies as they fit task, relational, and identity goals (→Liu and Wilson 2011; →Wilson and Putnam 1990). Other studies showed that frequent use of arguments and position statements resulted in low joint gains, unless disputants uncovered each other's underlying needs (→Olekalns et al. 2008; →Weingart and Olekalns 2004).

Bargainer role, for example, buyer versus seller or labor versus management, influenced the frequency of asking questions and conveying priorities (→Cai, Wilson, and Drake 2000). This research, however, relied on total amounts or frequencies of types of messages rather than sequences in the development of communication over time.

4.2 Sequential Interactions and Process Variables

Moving away from frequencies of messages, researchers tested for the evolution of communication through analyzing sequential interactions of negotiators over time. Using cue-response systems and clusters of strategies, scholars treated sequences of arguments, information sharing, and concession making as "negotiation dances" in which participants developed the rhythm and flow of conflict (→Adair and Brett 2005; →Young and Schlie 2011). The dance metaphor revealed that negotiators adapted to each other as they gradually moved in synchrony (→Putnam 2013). For example, labor and management negotiators balanced each other's offensive and defensive approaches in a complementary dance.

Three types of sequences marked different negotiation dances: reciprocal, transformational, and complementary sequences (→Olekalns et al. 2008). In reciprocal patterns, if negotiators matched each other's distributive messages, like threats and put-downs, they escalated conflict and promoted conflict spirals (→Putnam and Jones 1982). In contrast, matching supportive messages, especially in multi-issue offers, often led to productive conflict management. In an employment negotiation, the use of reciprocal patterns during the last half of interactions also predicted high joint gains for both parties (→Liu 2011). In addition, reciprocating integrative tactics (e.g., asking questions, prioritizing issues, sharing information) conveyed affiliation and fostered

interdependence in negotiator relationships (→Donohue 2001).

Transformational sequences or a mismatch in interaction between parties indicated that negotiators were out of sync, but this type of pattern broke up escalatory spirals by shifting back and forth between competitive and cooperative phases of negotiation (→Putnam 2013). As a combination of matching and mismatching of interaction patterns, complementary sequences demonstrated that negotiators used the same strategical focus, but altered their tactics (→Adair and Brett 2005; Adair and Lowenstein 2013). Overall, communication scholarship strongly supported the claim that patterns of interaction fundamentally altered the course of a negotiation.

In addition to sequential analysis, scholars also studied turning points and critical moments in negotiations. Turning points depicted dramatic shifts or changes, abrupt and non-abrupt departures, and radical stage transitions (→Druckman and Olekalns 2013). They often occurred after a crisis or a prolonged period of intense conflict, such as interruptions in stage movements (→Donohue and Roberto 1996). To illustrate, →Putnam and Fuller (2014) conducted a study of turning points in the 2007–2008 strike between the Writers Guild of America (WGA) and the Alliance of Motion Pictures and Television Producers (AMPTP). Based on the coding and tracking of press releases, web documents, and blogs, they found that messages about procedural precipitants acted as turning points to de-escalate the conflict. They also observed that abrupt departures were more frequent at the beginning and ending of the negotiation than in the middle stage. Thus, scholars have shifted away from doing phase analyses of negotiations (→Holmes 1992; →Putnam and Poole 1987) to examining turning points and transitional shifts in the process.

Another type of process analysis was linguistic style mapping of negotiation interactions. Linguistic style mapping

paralleled conversational mimicry in examining how negotiators matched each other in word choice, for example, similar prepositions, verbs, or pronouns. Based on automated textual analysis of negotiation transcripts, studies revealed that a high degree of linguistic style mapping fostered coordination, developed rapport, and led to successful outcomes between negotiators (→Taylor and Thomas 2008).

Also, using automated language analysis of buyer-seller negotiations, scholars advanced the work on emotional effects in dispute situations. →Brett et al. (2007) used an event history design and automated text analysis to show how the language of positive and negative facework evolved in e-negotiations that lasted over months. They found that expressions of negative emotions (e.g., anger, criticism, contempt, ridicule, and accusations) and the giving of commands (e.g., words such as *should*, *ought*, *need*, *must*) decreased the likelihood of resolving disputes while statements of firmness (e.g. “feel strongly about this”, “need a compensation”) and the offering of causal explanations (“I think UPS is responsible for the item being damaged”) increased the likelihood of a settlement. Surprisingly, expressions of positive emotion (e.g., “I respect you”, “I trust your judgment”) did not increase the likelihood of a settlement. This study then called into question research on emotional valence in negotiation (→Morris and Keltner 2000) and advocated examining the communication of appraisals over time (→Barry, Fulmer, and van Kleef 2004).

Drawing from this field-based data, →Friedman et al. (2004) investigated expressions of anger (e.g., words like “pissed”, “upset”, “hostile”) in filing and responding to dispute claims in e-negotiations. They found that anger triggered reciprocal expressions from the other party and reduced the likelihood of reaching a settlement. These patterns increased over time, unless anger helped the other party back off. In focusing on e-negotiations, this study added to the growing work on communication media and

negotiation (→Poole, Shannon, and DeSanctis 1992) and suggested that the findings on media, social awareness, negotiation processes, and conflict outcomes were "contradictory" and at best, "inconclusive" (→Friedman and Currell 2003; →McGinn and Croson 2004: 335).

In effect, most researchers concur that negotiation is a system of communicative interactions that combine distributive and integrative messages; reveal interaction sequences as types of dances; involve dramatic shifts and turning points; demonstrate linguistic style mapping; and incorporate emotional expressions and communication media. These developments in process analysis make communication the key building block of negotiation.

4.3 Interpretive and Discourse-Based Approaches

Analysis of language and message patterns over time also interfaces with interpretative approaches in negotiation research. Interpretive approaches, however, move away from tracking message systems over time to focusing on meanings, symbols, and discourse as forming understandings. Hence, it centers on what language does in organizational conflicts and how communication and conflict constitute each other. Unlike matching communication patterns over time, discourse focuses on meanings rather than on the frequencies and sequences of words and phrases. Studies in negotiation that embrace a discourse approach include verbal immediacy and language intensity, contradictions and mixed messages, and conflict framing.

Verbal immediacy refers to words that convey closeness versus distance between parties, with terms like, *you* and *us* rather than *they* and *them* as well as using long utterances and excessive numbers of verbs. Employing language that signals closeness, even when positions on issues are distant, helps negotiators develop relationships (→Donohue, Ramesh, and

Borchgrevink 1991). Similarly, drawing from conversational flow, disputants who develop turn-taking norms and balance topical flow enhance relationships, especially in deferring to the other party (→Maynard 2010). In contrast, employing excessive interruptions and emotional comments (both positive and negative) increases language intensity and strains negotiator relationships (→Donohue and Diez 1985).

These findings, however, hinge on whether negotiators move with or against each other over time and express congruent or mixed messages in verbal and nonverbal interactions. →Donohue (2001) posits that negotiators exist in a cooperative-competitive paradox with combinations of high affiliation, low interdependence or low affiliation, high interdependence. Thus, they simultaneously express integrative and distributive messages in which verbal and nonverbal communication contradict each other in relational paradoxes (→Beune et al. 2011).

The very definition of conflict then embodies contradictions in that disputants must cooperate with each other in order to compete as they work out the nature of their interdependence. Specifically, →Putnam (2004) demonstrated how teachers and administrators exerted both control and yielding to negotiate the meanings of money, policies, and contract issues. Engaging in a dialectical interplay between these opposites helped them discover a formula for reaching an agreement. In like manner, →Jameson (2004) examined how two healthcare professional groups embraced both autonomy and connection in negotiating project priorities and task procedures. Finally, →Real and Putnam (2005) showed how an airline pilot resistance group constructed a campaign that led to voting down a proposed contract. The campaign embraced opposite poles by advocating for unity while promoting division and upholding an elite image of pilots while promoting a classless system within the profession. In each of these cases, embracing and navigating contradictions

helped parties reach agreements and meet multiple negotiation goals.

One way to navigate the contradictions embedded in simultaneously cooperating and competing is to reframe disputes or to transcend opposites. Drawing on discourse patterns (i.e., use of descriptors) and on narratives of disputes, scholars have examined how actors shift the figure and ground of conflict features, reframe agenda items to embrace common goals, alter the naming and labeling of conflicts, and move issues from individual to collective ownership of problems (→Drake and Donohue 1996; →Putnam 2004, 2010). For example, in the →Putnam and Fuller (2014) previously reported Writers' Strike, both parties aimed to capture the moral high ground through characterizing the other as derailing the process and not taking the bargaining seriously. Only when disputants reframed the conflict through introducing new procedures did negotiators return to the table to reach a settlement. Media coverage also contributed to framing organizational conflicts as *wars*, *power struggles* among stakeholders, *feuds*, and *storms* (→Putnam and Shoemaker 2007). In this way, the media played a pivotal role in escalating conflicts among organizational actors who were struggling to determine which agency should regulate water distribution from an underground aquifer (→Brummans et al. 2008).

In the interpretive approaches, communication is not a variable, a set of strategies, interaction patterns, or frequencies of language use. Rather it constitutes the conflict itself as meanings emerge in an evolving context. Research in this approach examines how discourse conveys closeness-distance (verbal immediacy) and language intensity in relationships between negotiators. It also reveals how mixed messages, especially simultaneous cooperative and competitive goals, form the foundation of conflict as disputants embrace such opposites as control/yielding and

unity/division. Conflict framing is the naming or labeling of disputes through discourse patterns that characterize players, roles, and events. Scholars who examine framing focus on the figure-ground shifts in conflicts, ways that labels change as issues develop over time, and what is included or excluded in the frame of a dispute. Reframing becomes a way of transcending opposites and developing alternative approaches to conflict management.

4.4 New Directions in Communication and Negotiation

With a strong interest in natural language processing, negotiation scholars have begun to incorporate machine learning techniques and AI technology into linguistic modeling and to animate virtual negotiation agents. Hence, new directions in negotiation research are extending the work on linguistic mapping, conversational analysis, and emotional expressions.

In particular, natural language processing draws from politeness theory to detect communication styles and conversational receptiveness through calculating algorithms of language use. Specifically, Jeong and colleagues (2019) investigated warm and friendly versus tough and firm communication styles in distributed negotiations. Drawing on written messages, researchers employed a machine learning model to develop algorithms of linguistic markers of warm and tough styles, including word use, directness-indirectness phrases, self and other pronoun use, action phrases, commands, qualifiers, and speech tagging. Experiments in field and laboratory settings revealed that sellers reciprocated buyers' communication style; warm and friendly styles dissipated over time; and negotiators with tough styles elicited more favorable counteroffers and achieved better outcomes than did ones with warm and friendly ones. In similar research, →Yeomans et al. (2020) demonstrated that

conversational receptiveness at the beginning of policy discussions forestalled conflict escalation. Organizational members who followed the receptiveness recipes in text messages were seen as attractive conflict partners and received fewer personal attacks than did individuals who were less receptive.

Overall, the sophistication of natural language processing holds considerable promise to capture complex interactions in workplace conflicts. This research, while primarily centered on computerized written messages, is now being applied to transcripts of face-to-face interactions to model conversational flow. Also, drawing on advances in AI technology (e.g., Amazon's Polly, large language models), scholars have added spoken and nonverbal communication (e.g., facial expressions, gesturing, and verbal backchannels) to investigate human-agent negotiations, using an animated virtual agent. This research preserves the interdependence between negotiators and captures their emotional expressions better than computer scripted interactions in machine-based natural language processing (→Schweitzer et al. 2023).

This section focuses on communication and negotiation in the workplace. Importantly, the majority of the research no longer treats communication as a structural or interactional variable and instead centers on processes, such as depicting the negotiation dance, analyzing turning points in interactions, mapping linguistic style, and tracking emotional expressions over time. Interpretive approaches also focus on verbal immediacy and language intensity, the dialectical interplay that holds cooperation-competition together, and framing as shifting figure-ground elements of a conflict. New research directions in negotiation employ AI and machine learning to investigate communication styles, conversational receptiveness, and emotional expressions in natural language processing and in the use of animated virtual agents.

5 Intergroup Conflict in the Workplace

Intergroup conflict in the workplace focuses on social groups and organizational units rather than on dyads and interpersonal relationships. Differences between social groups are often presumed to be inevitable since they stem from disparate group characteristics, ones often tied to diversity. That conflict often arises between people of different nationalities, religions, races, ethnic groups, genders, or ages is not an original insight. In some organizations, white employees persecute African American workers because of their skin color, and management excludes women from the ranks of male executives because men control the reins of power. Treating these characteristics as “natural” or inevitable is one of the alleged causes of intergroup conflict.

However, two problems occur with this explanation. First, one or both groups typically have economic or political interests in the conflict and stand to gain from the other’s loss (→Billig 1976). Intergroup differences then justify the conflict, but are not the cause of it. Second, differences often exist among multiple groups, and theories of natural differences offer no valid explanation as to why some social groups are conflicted and others are not (→Billig 1976; →Oakes 2003). Thus, it is necessary to consider social identities and intergroup interactions as ways of triggering group differences.

Two approaches to communication offer some explanations for intergroup conflict. In the first one, communication surfaces as a structural variable to account for social identity and categorization, and in the second one, communication functions as an interactional variable that accounts for reactions and expectations between groups in intergroup conflict.

5.1 Communication as a Structural Variable

Communication plays an important role in social categorization. It is the medium through which people are taught categories. When children hear talk about general categories, such as “boys” and “girls” or “blacks” and “whites”, they are being taught social categories (→Hogg 2003). By the time they become adults, categorizations become the natural order of things, and they readily learn and create additional categories. Category work occurs in communication through comparing and contrasting one thing with another (→Boden 1994). Since categories have their own rationales for grouping things together, they are important barometers of *social identity*, that is, a sense of identity from belonging to a larger social group. This need fosters *social categorization* – a social process whereby people define themselves by identifying the groups that they and others belong to (→Hogg 2003; →Tajfel and Turner 1979). A major factor in the definition of social identity is an individual’s perception of the social groups or the categories that he or she belongs to (“I am an American”, “I am a Texan”, “I am a schoolteacher”). Labels of group categories then are communicative practices of identity formation.

Identity, however, is defined not only by the groups to which people belong to but also by the ones to which they do *not* belong (→Rothbart 2003). For example, many Americans define themselves both as Americans and as *not* Mexican or Japanese. Members of management draw on their identities as being opposed to the union. Every organization and society can be described as a network of complementary and opposing groups. For example, a typical American factory might comprise groups divided into multiple categories, including ones between labor and management, line workers and staff, male and female, and white collar and blue collar. Each group is defined by its reference to opposite groups as well as by its own group terms. Social categorization then is a

structural communication process in which people use labels or naming to classify and form social identities that create belonging and opposition to other groups.

What makes some categories salient in particular situations? →Garcia-Prieto, Bellard, and Schneider (2003) catalogue several factors that make social identities relevant. One factor is the *motivation* of the parties. Social identity is likely to be more salient if one of the parties has a need to enhance self-esteem, reduce uncertainty, or establish distinctiveness compared to others. In this case, membership in a social group can meet these needs. A second factor that can make social identity salient is *awareness of difference*. A Latino man in a group of white men is likely to be aware of his identity as a Latino because of his minority status.

A third factor that can raise awareness of social identities is *others' reactions and expectations* of individuals. Nurse Sue is likely to identify with her profession when others ask her for medical advice. A fourth factor is the *existence of previous conflicts* between social groups. For example, in Northern Ireland in the 1990s, it was difficult for anyone to not identify as either Protestant or Catholic. The parties had been in conflict for so long and the conflict was so intractable that taking sides was automatic. Each of these four factors makes it more likely that a social identity will be operative and provides clues as to which identities to look for.

With each social category comes a characterization of what people are like – their desires, needs, and how they act. Of course, the characterization of each group differs depending on who describes the category. A "woman" is likely to describe the characteristics of men differently from the way a "man" would. However, communication barriers often prevent people in different social categories from recognizing the differences among their stereotypes of others. Blacks and whites, for instance, sometimes keep their theories about the other group to themselves, only discussing them with other

blacks or whites, respectively. The process of group differentiation, discussed below, adds other communication barriers that keep people aligned with social characterizations.

5.2 Interactional Effects in Intergroup Conflict

When people accept social categories, they are likely to interact with other groups on the basis of the characteristics and expectations linked to the categories (Orbe, Everett, and →Putnam 2013). This sets up a self-reinforcing communication cycle that preserves notions about other social groups. For example, if people in group A, which generally does not care about politics, believe that people in group B are politically conservative, group A members may never raise the subject of politics in interactions with members of group B. By so doing, they never give the people in group B a chance to show their actual political beliefs. In turn, people in group B, who might be somewhat centrist in their political beliefs, might infer that the people in group A agree with them regarding their political agenda. Group A members who never talk about politics might confirm that the two groups do not need to discuss politics. Thomas →Scheff (1967) called this phenomenon *pluralistic ignorance* since each side is mistaken about the other, but neither is aware of the mistake. So, both sides act on their "true" beliefs and invite interaction cycles that confirm their views.

Intergroup conflict stems from *group differentiation*, which refers to the attendant stereotyping of and polarization with other groups. In group differentiation, members attribute responsibility for their problems to other groups and unite against them. This *we-they polarization* stems from several communication dynamics. When groups are in competition, they call for their members to increase loyalty and commitment to the group. In-group messages also demean the claims and validity of the other group while they favor

their own group. The tendency to favor in-group messages often blocks reflection on the merits of the other group's claims. Thus, internal communication processes move the in-group toward an oversimplified view of the out-group, often based on stereotypes or highly simplified beliefs about the other group. Individuals use stereotyping to interpret out-group members' behaviors that they treat as threatening or undesirable.

Suppression of disagreements among in-group members also heightens polarization (→Abrams et al. 2005). In-group messages present a shared stance and minimize disagreements within their own membership. Individuals who posit that the other group has some valid claims or a legitimate position may be charged with disloyalty (→Janis 1972). This stance preserves stereotypes and prevents members of the in-group from exploring common ground with other groups.

In-group messages also embrace intergroup ideologies that justify a group's positions. *Intergroup ideologies* are organized belief systems that depict differences between the groups in terms of the in-group's favorable light. For example, in the ongoing Israeli-Palestinian conflict, each side developed elaborate explanations as to why it had *the* legitimate claims and had been wronged by the other side. These explanations provide each side with a stock of justifications for aggression toward the other and an unwillingness to concede.

5.3 Reducing Intergroup Conflict

The most common approach to reducing intergroup conflict is to bring members of different groups in *contact* with each other (→Brewer and Gaertner 2003). The belief is that sharing in-depth experiences with members of other groups shows people that their stereotypes are unrealistic. Bringing environmentalists and business leaders together, for instance,

may enable members of each group to see the other as individuals or as human beings like themselves. In this way, contact between groups aims to undermine ingrained attitudes and stereotypes.

In the second approach, *recategorization*, parties emphasize common goals and interests, and thus create a new "category" around those interests. A third approach, *mutual differentiation*, recognizes the differences but appreciates and aims to capitalize on the strengths of diverse groups (→Distefano and Maznevski 2000). *Bridging*, a fourth approach, entails communicating effectively across differences to bring people and ideas together. This process involves building motivation to overcome problems and fostering confidence to bridge differences. A final aspect of bridging is to establish common ground among the parties and develop new ways of interacting. *Integrating* requires all parties to participate on an equal basis and work together toward a mutually acceptable outcome.

5.4 New Directions in Intergroup Conflict

The rise of the global workplace pushes intergroup conflict in new directions. Namely, the growth of transnational teams and global commerce calls for different ways that social identity, stereotyping, and in-group biases function, whether teams are co-located, distributed, or virtual (→Gibson and McDaniel 2010). Awareness and sensitivity to national differences becomes more pronounced as micro- and macro-level boundaries dissolve, linguistic and interpretive diversity increases, and cultural/professional norms diverge (→Stohl, McCann, and Bakar 2013). Even forming a salient team identity is challenging when group members are multicultural, distributed, and virtual.

Developing constructive approaches to intergroup conflicts in this context calls on team members to learn "what

differences make a difference between and among cultures and nation-states" (→Stohl, McCann, and Bakar 2013: 725) as well as how similar ideas are often expressed differently. Strategies for managing transnational intergroup conflicts include adaptation, structural interventions, and third-party managerial oversight. Adaptation or adjusting to accommodate differences are preferred strategies for conflicts that arise from communication differences and time orientations. Developing a global mindset to transcend intergroup differences is another form of adaptation that aids in managing disputes. In cases of negative stereotypes between groups, structural interventions that alter the shape and boundaries of teams often removes sources of conflict (→Brett, Behfar, and Kern 2006). Managerial interventions are often needed to address norm violations and high levels of negative emotions in intergroup conflicts. Thus, a new direction for studying intergroup conflict focuses on transnational and global teams as group differences rooted in multilayered social conflicts.

As this discussion suggests, intergroup conflict is not based on natural characteristics or inevitable differences among individuals. Rather it develops from group differences grounded in social identities and processes of categorization. Its communicative roots in this way are structurally based on the language patterns that develop and sustain categories. Expectations of self, others, and categories, however, set up interaction effects between groups, often as self-reinforcing cycles that foster stereotyping and polarization between groups. As a new direction, the global workplace sets the stage for transnational intergroup conflicts spurred by linguistic and interpretive differences, blurring of team boundaries, and diverse cultural norms. Organizations can manage intergroup conflicts through increasing contact, recategorization, mutual differentiation, bridging, and integration. At the transnational level, developing a global

mindset resembles recategorization and aids in managing intergroup conflict in addition to interventions that alter the shape and boundaries of teams and help to nullify negative emotions and norm violations.

6 Conclusion and Discussion

As an area of organizational communication research, conflict and negotiation in the workplace is pivotal to interpersonal relationships, reaching agreements on polices and practices, and moving forward in the midst of intergroup tensions and disputes. Crossing these three areas, interpersonal, workplace negotiations, and intergroup conflict, suggests that communication plays a pivotal role in selecting strategies and tactics, shaping the underlying meanings of situations, managing emotional expressions, enacting turning points, and reaching mutually beneficial agreements. In overall scholarship, researchers have moved away from treating communication as a structural variable (e.g., choice of style, frequency of tactics, formation of social identity) and moved toward interactional and process explanations for conflict phenomena (e.g., sequential patterns, negotiation dance, turning points, linguistic style mapping, self-reinforcing cycles of stereotyping).

In addition, scholarship on communication and conflict has become increasingly interpretive in its focus on symbols, meanings, discourse, and contradictions. In this work, communication and conflict co-constitute each other through studying how parties navigate opposites (e.g., cooperation-competition, relational paradoxes, in-group-out-group reactions and expectations) reframe, transcend, and develop common ground that bridges differences. Researchers are also exploring new terrains, such as emotional expressions, apology and forgiveness, and pluralistic ignorance – ones that cut-across the three areas of work. New frontiers are

emerging, such as machine learning, natural language processing, and AI technology – that hold considerable promise to examine verbal and nonverbal communication, emotional expression, and conversational flow as well as linguistic and message patterns. Importantly, communication is not just a building block of organizational conflict, it is the very process in which it is enacted and managed.

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Chapter 10 Diffusion

Kerk F. Kee

James W. Dearing

Abstract

Diffusion is the communicative process through which a new technology, behavior, practice, idea, business model, policy, etc. spreads and changes through certain channels and media across and within organizations. In this chapter, we provide a broad overview of diffusion of innovations theory as it relates to organizational communication, offer theoretical and methodological critiques, and propose opportunities for future research. We begin by offering an overview of diffusion as a research area, its historical development, and the two selected theoretical concepts of opinion leaders and diffusion networks not fully discussed in prior handbooks. Second, we discuss organizations and organizational members as different units of adoption, and then further distinguish between adoption as the individual phenomenon that leads to diffusion at the organizational or systemic level, and the relationships between the two levels. Third, we offer critiques of diffusion research from theoretical and methodological perspectives, including how qualitative and/or critical cultural scholars can contribute to diffusion research. Finally, we discuss areas where diffusion research can make the greatest contributions to understanding organizational communication, including drawing from big data/data analytics and psycho-physiological methods.

Keywords: diffusion of innovations, technology adoption, opinion leaders, diffusion networks, biases (pro-innovation bias, individual blame bias, knowledge-gap bias), reinvention,

adaptation, Everett Rogers, qualitative research, organizational change, implementation, Georg Simmel, Gabriel Tarde,

1 Introduction

One thing is certain about today's organizations – they are bombarded by innovations! Not only do organizations get exposed and introduced to innovations on a frequent basis, those organizations face pressure to consider, try, adopt, adapt, and then implement them. Then over time, those same organizations face the same pressure but in reverse: to de-implement, not renew or relicense, and consider again the negative aspects of that now-old thing as they simultaneously reenact the innovation-decision process regarding something newer. Some organizations adopt quickly, others adopt only when an innovation becomes an economic (or public relations) necessity. This difference in tendency to adopt between the first and last organizations within a social system also manifests at the individual level of organizational members, creating a complex web of pushes and pulls to investigate, adopt or reject, and later discontinue using what had earlier been adopted. The garbage can model of organizational choice (→Cohen, March, and Olsen 1972) comes to mind as a pretty apt perspective of the multifaceted nature of diffusion across and within organizations and, to us, a rather good rationale for why qualitative and critical perspectives can be smart approaches for studying diffusion.

When organizational members with decision-making authority are all or mostly in favor of or opposed to an innovation, there is little to no struggle with the decision to adopt. However, in most organizations in real life, our behavior at this point in time can appear bizarre to the outsider. Much of the time we rely on others – other organizations of the same type, others within our organization

– as a heuristic cue as to how we too should respond to an innovation. Imitation is a pretty safe route through the innovation-decision process that demands little cognitive load and less time. Yet imitation also confers little competitive advantage, so decision makers are always on the lookout for what's new.

Then there is the further confounding activity within organizations once they have adopted an innovation, for as we implement we change innovations just as their presence changes organizational context (→Czarniawska and Sevón 2005). Whereas adoption is a time of exploration outside the organization to learn about an innovation and its potential fit with an organization, later implementation is a time of exploitation so that as much value as possible can be drawn from use of the innovation. The predictable dilemmas that arise post-adoption present a rationale for organizational communication researchers to study *diffusion* as translation – the communicative process through which a new technology, behavior, practice, idea, business model, policy, etc. spreads and changes through certain channels and media across and within organizations.

Diffusion processes are often replete with stops and starts, and often for good reason – many innovations are ill-suited to any given organization. And it is precisely the stops and starts that make diffusion so much fun to study and learn from, as Peter →van der Merwe (1989) did with his meticulous tracing of the antecedents of 20th-century popular music. Indeed, it is the translational aspects of innovations as they spread that partly accounts for the popularity of what researchers in healthcare and public health refer to as dissemination and implementation science (→Dearing 2021; →Dearing, Kee, and Peng 2023).

Researchers trace diffusion through social systems, whether across work teams, within a department or a startup company or a nonprofit organization or a public agency, and

on larger scales within global conglomerates or across entire industries, cultural communities, a geographical state, government, or country. Regardless of social system, it is communication within or among organizations that makes diffusion take-off. This is true for Korean pop culture (→Kim 2021), educational technologies (→Looi and Teh 2015), scaling up of health services (→Simmons, Fajans, and Ghiron 2007), as well as military weapons (→Goldman and Eliason 2003).

Diffusion was not a full chapter in prior handbooks of organizational communication (i.e., →Jablin and Putnam 2001; →Jablin et al. 1987; →Putnam and Mumby 2013). However, diffusion was very much in the background, as prominent diffusion scholars (e.g., Ron Rice) contributed to the handbooks. Furthermore, a scan of the subject indices shows that 'technology adoption', a proxy of diffusion of innovations, was included in the 2001 handbook to cover concepts such as critical mass, cultural and structural influences, gender, and collective action. Diffusion of information in organizations was briefly discussed in the 1987 handbook. Given the integral role of technologies and innovations in today's organizations (e.g., ChatGPT), and the need for organizations to constantly explore, adopt, discontinue, and adopt something new as described earlier, we believe there is much to gain from a full chapter on the diffusion of innovations for organizational communication going forward.

In this handbook chapter, our goal is to provide a broad overview of diffusion of innovations theory as it relates to organizational communication, offer theoretical and methodological critiques, and propose opportunities for future research. To accomplish this goal, we first offer an overview of diffusion as a research area, its historical development, and two selected theoretical concepts not fully discussed in prior handbooks. Second, we discuss organizations and organizational members as different units of adoption, and then further distinguish between adoption as

the individual phenomenon that leads to diffusion at the organizational or systemic level, and the relationships between the two levels. Third, we offer critiques of diffusion research from theoretical and methodological perspectives. Finally, we discuss areas where diffusion research can make the greatest contributions to understanding organizational communication.

2 Overview of the Diffusion of Innovations

2.1 Diffusion as a Communication Theory

Diffusion theory is commonly known by its key concepts, such as innovativeness, the innovation-decision process, innovation attributes, adopter categories, opinion leadership, and diffusion networks. These concepts emerged out of a rich history of multidisciplinary research traditions. These classic concepts have been written about by many diffusion scholars in book-length manuscripts (e.g., →Rogers 2003; →Singhal and Dearing 2006), articles (→Beausoleil 2018; →Hameed, Counsell, and Swift 2012; →Kapoor, Konstan, and Terveen 2005; →Vagnani, Gatti, and Proietti 2019), and summary chapters (e.g., →Dearing 2008; →Dearing and Meyer 2006; →Kee 2017; →Rice 2009).

Diffusion operates via communicative behavior and always revolves around newness and responses to it. As Miller and Poole argued in the introduction of this handbook, major changes in technology are reshaping how we interact in and across organizations. Think about it: as recently as 2019, Zoom was new to most people! In 2022, it was an innovation no longer because it was quickly and widely adopted as a response to the stay-at-home orders during the pandemic. And while COVID-19 precipitated major changes in the organization of work, the diffusion of innovations is a constant in organizational life. The resulting normalization of virtual

meetings is reshaping organizational expectations and daily practices.

Just as organizational communication is an interdisciplinary field at the intersection of communication, management, industrial psychology, organizational sociology, etc., diffusion has proven to be an interdisciplinary topic. Organizational communication researchers can draw from diffusion's interdisciplinary and multidisciplinary nature, while still working on an authentic communication theory. Despite being regarded as a communication theory by →Rogers (2003), this paradigm emerged out of historical work in political philosophy, anthropology, sociology, education, and psychology, and continues to be studied by scholars of public health, management, economics, political science, and health services research.

2.2 Some Historical Developments

Two of the very first scholars to study diffusion were Gabriel Tarde and Georg Simmel. The French judge cum sociologist Gabriel Tarde explained diffusion as a societal-level phenomenon of social change in his 1902 book, *The Laws of Imitation*, including the identification of an S-shaped curve in cumulative adoptions over time and the importance of opinion leadership in promulgating that distribution. As a judge, Tarde had taken note of the way people coming before the bench used new slang and wore new clothing fashions as if on cue.

In Germany at the same time, Georg Simmel, a political philosopher, was writing about how individual thought and action was structured by the set of interpersonal relations to which a person was subject. Tarde's perspective was the forerunner for the macro, social system perspective on diffusion as the means by which cultures and societies changed and progressed, much of those changes occurring through inter-organizational communication. Simmel's

contribution, explicated in his book, *Conflict: The Web of Group Affiliations*, was the forerunner for understanding how social network position affects what individuals do in reaction to innovations, and when. Simmel's insights have been borne out in studies of reference groups, social pressure to conform, and how individuals vary in their thresholds to adopt innovations.

Together, these perspectives provided the micro-macro explanation for much about diffusion processes: how system-level effects pressured the individual to adopt new things; and how individuals, linked in social networks, contributed to (and mostly resisted) system change. The interplay of these ideas and their popularity over the years among scholars in different fields has been shown in a co-citation analysis in the social sciences from 1945 to 2004 (→Estabrooks et al. 2008). Both Tarde's and Simmel's ideas about diffusion remain foci for contemporary organizational communication scholars who study change processes. We will further elaborate on the micro-macro relationship later in this chapter as we discuss *adoption vs. diffusion*.

2.3 Selected Concepts of Diffusion Theory

Diffusion theory has a complex framework involving different key concepts. For example, two of the commonly known concepts that are psycho-social and sociological in nature are *innovation attributes* (e.g., relative advantage, compatibility) and *adopter categories* (e.g., early adopters, laggards). In this chapter, we focus on discussing *opinion leaders* and *diffusion networks*, two concepts that have received much research attention in communication.

Opinion Leaders. Opinion leaders are an important group of organizational members who play a critical role in promoting (or stalling) the diffusion of an innovation through interpersonal conversations with their coworkers. Opinion

leaders make up about 5% to 8% of an organization, often found among the group of early adopters (→Dearing, Kee, and Peng 2023). They informally influence their coworkers about an innovation through interpersonal conversations, because they represent the organizational norms and they are respected by and well-connected with the people they work with (→Kee et al. 2016). Organizational communication researchers interested in upward influence could study how opinion leaders without formal management titles successfully champion or resist an innovation (e.g., Zoom) at work.

→Boster and colleagues (2011) developed a self-assessment opinion leadership scale that included three constructs – connectivity, persuasiveness, and mavenness – that together comprise a measure of whether an individual functions as highly influential (what they labeled a superdiffuser) in a particular topical domain. Subsequent work demonstrated high construct validity for political and health topics (→Boster, Carpenter, and Kotowksi 2015) and strong test-retest reliability (→Boster 2012). Individuals scoring as political mavens were more politically active and more knowledgeable about politics. Health mavens reported being sought out by others, and that others report that they are good sources of health advice. Organizational communication researchers interested in remote work arrangements can use Boster's scale to study if and how organizational members scoring as technology mavens may be more effective in helping coworkers adopt a new technology, such as Microsoft Teams for virtual meetings.

Besides superdiffusers, opinion leaders are also known as influencers. In studying medical workplace intervention from Latin America, →Althabe and colleagues (2008) identified and then intervened with opinion leading birth attendants as influencers in hospitals to decrease the use of episotomy and increase the use of oxytocin during the third stage of labor.

They randomly assigned 19 hospitals in Argentina and Uruguay to receive a multifaceted behavioral intervention. Desirable practices increased and undesirable practices decreased at the intervention hospitals as compared with control hospitals. At intervention hospitals where opinion leading birth attendants had been sociometrically identified by questionnaire and then contacted and recruited to help talk with their work colleagues in positive terms about evidence-based birthing practices, the rate of use of prophylactic oxytocin during the third stage of labor increased from 2.1% to 83.6% and sustained for at least 12 months after the end of the study. Organizational communication researchers interested in social change could study how influencers can be identified to help champion a new practice, such as diversity and equity in hiring and/or promotion decisions in organizations.

→Valente and Pumpuang (2007) suggest ten different ways to identify opinion leaders who can help promote social change in a social system. The methods range from self-selection (i.e., volunteers who respond to recruitment efforts) to the position approach (i.e., an individual who occupies a leadership role) to the sociometric method (i.e., based on nomination frequency of all organizational members). While the sociometric method is sophisticated and robust,
→Banerjee and colleagues (2019) suggested the shortcut of simply asking people to name ‘gossip seeds’ in the social system, members who are most helpful for spreading gossips and rumors. They empirically demonstrated that this much simpler approach in fact yielded very good results of identifying opinion leaders at a low cost. Organizational communication researchers interested in socialization could study how members nominated as gossip seeds could help spread important company updates, especially to virtual workers not onsite.

Diffusion Networks. The sociometric method and the method of identifying ‘gossip seeds’ suggests the concept of *diffusion network* – the social network and communication connections in place in every organization through which an innovation spreads. Two network characteristics are important to consider here – strength and presence. →Granovetter’s (1973) weak ties hypothesis suggests that tie strength matters and that new information often spreads through weak ties (i.e., acquaintances), because strong ties (i.e., close coworkers) often already share the same information sources. Therefore, one is less likely to learn about something new from a strong tie. Furthermore, →Burt (1992) also adds that the absence of ties reveals ‘holes’ in social structure that prevent the flow of new information or information about an innovation.

A recent application of how these characteristics of diffusion networks operate to communicate evidence-based practices across organizations is Project ECHO (→Arora et al. 2007). Project ECHO (Extension for Community Healthcare Outcomes) is a telementoring system in which specialist providers mentor primary care providers to deliver specialty care, thus reducing the shortage of medical specialists in poor rural and urban communities while improving access to care for community members. Typically, ECHO uses a ‘hub and spoke’ model of virtual meetings that create weak ties among providers to spread medical innovations and information to improve the health care of patients. Launched at one site in 2003, as of December 26, 2020, the ECHO Model had spread to 252 sites operating 621 distinct multi-session programs in 48 states in the US. Worldwide, ECHO had diffused to 423 sites representing 920 programs addressing one or more of 73 health conditions in 44 countries. Three years later by November 13, 2023, the data in the US show 2,120,657 total session attendees, 422 ECHO hubs, and 3,329 ECHO programs. In the world, there were 5,207,210 total session attendees, 1,150 ECHO hubs, and 6,880 ECHO programs (→ECHO, n.d.).

This approach to telementoring has been shown to increase patient access to specialty care, reduce travel costs and the time to receive care, increase provider knowledge and satisfaction, and improve patient outcomes (→Sayre et al. 2017). Organizational communication researchers interested in social enterprise can study how entrepreneurs in big cities employ a similar model to train new entrepreneurs in small towns and developing countries to launch ventures to transform their local communities.

3 Adoption vs. Diffusion

Much of our discussion up to this point focuses on individual-level adoption and diffusion. However, organizational communication researchers are also interested in organizational level adoption because of contingent adoption decisions (→Rice 2009). The concept of contingent adoption decisions refers to the situation where individual organizational members often adopt an innovation only after management has formally adopted it. In such a case, members may adopt by choice or by requirement due to a commitment from management. Also, organizational members often cannot fully implement an innovation for work (or even obtain access to the innovation) without the formal adoption by management. Differences in degrees of commitment to an innovation are common in such situations since the decision makers who adopt are often not the implementers and users of the innovation. Organizational communication researchers interested in paradoxes and dialectics could study how contingent adoption creates tensions in organizational members' pursuit of creativity and innovation.

When talking about diffusion, there is often a deterministic assumption that the innovation's adoption by decision makers and diffusion within an organization or across a system is

inevitable, especially in a top-down case. This is partly due to the assumption that many of the innovations (e.g., new technology such as Amazon Web Services, a new organizational change such as a merger) introduced into an organization are filtered down from management, and organizational members are expected to simply follow management's decision. Moreover, this assumption is also often portrayed by the cumulative S-curve in that more and more organizational members will get onboard with the innovation over time. However, reactance among organizational members in response to authority decisions is common. Diffusion can be impeded (or completely stalled) by organizational members in an active or passive aggressive fashion (remember those opinion leaders? They are influential both for *and against* adoption), perhaps because the innovation can be perceived as irrelevant to one's job, too difficult to learn, not as good as the current way of doing things, a threat to one's job security, etc. Organizational communication researchers interested in human-machine interactions could examine how workers respond to the increasing adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) chatbots in industries such as banking, retail, potentially replacing some human employees.

3.1 Top-Down and Bottom-Up Diffusion

Diffusion can be a bottom-up spreading process, in that an innovation gets adopted by individual members through interpersonal conversations among them. Diffusion can also be a top-down spreading process, in that an innovation is introduced by management via mass messaging, and members are required to use it organization-wide. However, in most cases, diffusion – when it occurs – is a mix of bottom-up and top-down processes, as feedback contributes to the further development, trials and errors lead to learning how to

best implement, and local interpretations and individual resistance result in creative adaptations of the innovation.

Given the above, we treat diffusion as the systemic spread of an innovation within an organization or among organizations based on individual adoption as a point in time when the decision to accept or reject an innovation takes place. Subsequent to adoption, implementation and/or discontinuation can follow. Therefore, it is important for management to also track discontinuation and/or problematic implementation, because otherwise, the cumulative S-curve only shows the initial organization-wide adoption, which does not paint the complete picture of current implementation and future use towards sustainable productive goals. Organizational communication researchers interested in ethics could study how an HR department adopts an AI resume screening platform, but struggle with actual implementation given the complexity of hiring decisions and ethical concerns.

3.2 The Micro and the Macro Processes

In general, diffusion is a complex process because it is intertwined with the development, reinvention of an innovation by its developers, and then implementation and/or (dis)continuation of the innovation after adoption within organizations. In short, there's a lot more going on than just adoption! Diffusion theory is one of very few social science theories that link the macro diffusion processes of organizational change to micro adoption behaviors of organizational members (→Dearing, Kee, and Peng 2023).

By micro, we refer to individual-level activities, such as the act of adoption, the interpersonal conversations surrounding adoption, and subsequent activities to implement the innovation for individual and collaborative use at work. By macro, we refer to the observation of the systemic spread/ing

of an innovation within an organization (such as demonstrated in the cumulative S-curve), and external industry pressures. It is easier to treat these separately in research, but in order to have a holistic understanding of diffusion in organizations, it is important to merge the two. For example, the adoption by early adopters may be triggered more by interpersonal conversations with opinion leaders, but as the S-curve moves to late majority, adoption may be more stimulated by peer pressure. Looking simply at the micro phenomenon may lead researchers to overlook the function of time and stages, what grounded theory (→Glaser and Strauss 1967) terms the 'conditional matrix' that governs observable behaviors. In other words, organizational members often act in response to the evolving condition and dynamic context of their situations. Therefore, it is important to integrate the micro and the macro in organizational communication research. For example, researchers interested in robots could study the adoption of collaborative robots in two different manufacturing plants, and identify the macro conditions unique to each to explain two different diffusion patterns.

3.3 Organizational Concepts Related to Diffusion

Given that organizations are often the unit of adoption, this section summarizes several organizational concepts related to diffusion, in that these processes are often adopted by management in an organization. As a preview, these concepts are organizational change, industry pressures, governmental policy, technology transfer, and organizational capacity and readiness assessments.

Organizational Change. When an innovation is presented by management to an organization, change often occurs, at various levels and in varying forms. Instead of treating change as a reaction to something new, →Lewis (2019) explains that many simultaneous processes take place during

organizational change to involve internal and environmental sensemaking that mutually influence each other. She emphasizes that the change, hence the adoption and implementation of an innovation, is interrelated with the diffusion of the change in the environment external to the organization (see also Chapter 13 in this handbook). This argument suggests the complex relationship among communication, interaction, and sensemaking during implementation/use, dis/continuance, and environmental diffusion, especially during adaptation and reinvention.

Industry Pressures. In organizational communication research, adoption and diffusion can be the result of industry's pressure. →Zorn, Flanagin, and Shoham (2011) draw from institutional theory and explain that organizations often adopt an innovation in response to isomorphic pressure. Isomorphic pressure refers to an organization's perceived need to achieve and maintain legitimacy. Therefore, organizations often adopt an innovation due to three types of pressure: coercive, normative, and mimetic. *Coercive pressure* refers to the pressure from legal and regulatory requirements in the organization's industry. *Normative pressure* often stems from professional standards of a field. *Mimetic pressure* is the result of an organization's desire to imitate peer organizations. Zorn, Flanagin, Shoham found that isomorphic pressure asserts a strong influence on an organization to adopt an innovation more than other factors, such as the organization's size and budget.

Governmental Policy. Similar to organizations susceptible to industry pressure, governments are pre-disposed to observing other governments for policy adoption. Organizational communication researchers can study governments, states, and countries in diffusion research. →Graham, Shipan, and Volden (2008) explain that the diffusion of policy among and across governments is often driven by the adoption choices by other governments they observe, making diffusion an

interdependent process. Although the adoption focus may be on governments, Graham, Shipan, and Volden emphasize that the policy decisions are made by people in governments with different preferences, capabilities, and goals. Thus, they suggest diffusion researchers interested in policy adoption to focus on three sets of actors: *internal actors* (decision makers within a government), *external actors* (decision makers who adopted the policy in the diffusing governments; the source), and *go-betweens* (those who work across governmental units as intermediaries).

Technology Transfer. Technology transfer refers to the process of transferring, diffusing, and disseminating technology (and associated knowledge, skills, methods, etc.) from a source that holds the technology to a recipient. The source and recipient can be a university, a business, or even a person. It is important to note that at the core of technology transfer is knowledge utilization and translation. →Dunn, Holzener, and Zaltman (1985) argue that when the technology is new knowledge, it is often negotiated between the source and the recipient. →Estabrooks and colleagues (2006) further maintain that knowledge translation often involves exchanges, syntheses, and applications facilitated by interactions among the sources and recipients in a complex fashion. In this case, organizational communication plays a critical role in the diffusion of innovations in the case of technology transfer, where the innovation is dynamic in the diffusion process. Technology transfer can spark new startups and entrepreneurial organizations that engage in strategic efforts to promote their technology to a marketplace. Not only does technology transfer improve the capabilities of organizations, the process stimulates the economy of the society.

Organizational capacity and readiness assessments. Organizational capacity and associated readiness are critical in how an organization puts an innovation into practice. →Shumate and colleagues (2017) define capacity in the

nonprofit context as “the processes, practices, and people that the organization has at its disposal that enable it to produce, perform, or deploy resources to achieve its mission [...] an ability to accomplish organizational goals and mandates” (p. 156). The goals and mandates can include successful and meaningful implementation of an innovation. However, how can an organization’s capacity be measured? How do we know if an organization is ready for an innovation? We propose asking the following questions in assessing readiness for diffusion: “Is the innovation ready?” “Is the sponsoring change agency ready?” “Is the implementing organization ready?” and “Is the host industry or community ready?”

4 Critiques of Diffusion Research

In this section, we raise a few theoretical and methodological critiques of diffusion theory. While we present the arguments as critiques, they also represent opportunities for organizational communication. Since diffusion research has employed mostly quantitative methods (e.g., survey, field experiment, network analysis) to date, we recognize opportunities for qualitative researchers and critical cultural scholars to advance diffusion research in new ways.

4.1 Theoretical Critiques

Biases. Diffusion theory often carries with it an assumption of determinism. This can be seen in the cover of Rogers’s 4th edition of his book published in 1995 – an image of ripple effects in water. The visual metaphor suggests how a drop of water can create propagations of ripples in an outward mass communication-like fashion. Although the ripples will subside the further they travel from the starting point, the metaphor still suggests an inevitable outward propagation of an innovation. Yet this image does not suggest the key roles of

implementers and users of an innovation in terms of how they further shape and give meaning to new practices and programs and policies over time. Remember: users shape innovations just as innovations can alter organizations. Such mutual adaptation is by no means rare.

While uniformity from determinism makes organizational processes easier (although not necessarily better), there are biases associated with diffusion. First, the diffusion of an innovation can lead to both positive and negative consequences. However, organizational pressure often over-emphasizes the positives, leading to a *pro-innovation bias*. Such a bias often leads an organization to adopt an innovation wholesale by pressure, requiring organizational members to get on board. For example, one of us (Jim) joined Kaiser Permanente, a large integrated healthcare organization, as a researcher just after Kaiser had required its tens of thousands of employees to postpone all meetings and train for several days in the use of Epic, a widely used electronic medical records (EMR) system.

Second, slow adopters and non-adopters of an innovation in organizations often have good reasons not to adopt. Some of them may lack certain skills and/or resources to meaningfully adopt. However, the organizational pressure for all to adopt can paint a picture that non-adopters are deficient, incompetent, and/or negative in attitude in some ways, leading to the *individual blame bias*. In other words, instead of understanding the reasons for slow and non-adoption (e.g., poor introduction and facilitation of innovation by management), organizational members are often individually blamed for being responsible for stalling or stopping diffusion. Yet many times, resistance is well-founded. After all, who knows an organizational context better than its working members?

Third, as the cumulative S-curve expands from left to right, diffusion can create gaps in access to innovations, and

eventually gaps to knowledge that members need to perform (and/or compete to keep) their jobs. Unless the S-curve reaches 100%, which can also be argued to be oppressive, diffusion often leads to tensions of the *haves* versus the *have nots*, resulting in a *knowledge-gap bias*. For example, diffusion researchers in the 1970s and ’80s documented how Knowledge-Attitude-Practice (KAP) gaps do not just exist between the haves and have nots, but widen over time, since gains by the haves will outpace gains by the have nots. Critical cultural scholars interested in deconstructing determinism can study how the three biases reveal the symbolic power of innovations and ways to deconstruct such symbolism, contributing to productive critiques of diffusion processes – and diffusion research.

Adaptation. Perhaps one of the most interesting but under-investigated opportunities in organizational diffusion is adaptation – how members of an organization creatively improvise, customize, adapt, and/or repurpose an innovation for their own situations by maximizing the value extracted from the innovation. One of the reasons for limited adaptation research by communication scholars is the perception that adaptation represents ‘noise’ in the diffusion process. Fortunately, there are now many health services and public health researchers of organizational change who focus on adaptation processes and effects. We have found that *guided adaptation* – the communication to organizational implementers of alternative effective ways of implementing an innovation – can help implementers “do the right thing” by limiting adaptations to evidence-based practices and programs to the modifiable components of those practices and programs while leaving intact the causal components of those innovations that have been shown to produce a desirable outcome (→Larson, Dearing, and Backer 2017). Given the open-ended and creative nature of reinvention,

qualitative methods (e.g., interviewing, observations) are well suited here.

Although →DeSanctis and Poole (1994) did not use diffusion theory as a framework, they have long argued that a mix of social influences and technologies explain the observations that some work groups adapt advanced technology in creative and unexpected ways. An example of adaptation is workarounds. In a study of healthcare workers, →Barrett and Stephens (2017) investigate workers' perception of EMR systems during adoption, and they report that workers who were able to create workarounds during EMR implementation are more likely to view the innovation more favorably. The insight here is to recognize that 'one size does not fit all', and adaptations by implementers as well as reinvention by innovation developers are key to organizational members' adoption.

Another example of reinvention is adaptation, as documented in →Larson, Dearing, and Backer's (2017) study of 45 social innovations that had scaled up to varied degrees in the US. They found a nearly constant interplay among the pathways selected for diffusion and innovation fidelity as inter-organizational teams sought to scale up their health, education, and youth development innovations. Pathways were characterized either as the opening up of branch offices in new geographic locations, affiliating with others in those localities to franchise out operations, or taking a more expansive and less controlled network approach to diffusion. The study distinguished changes made to innovations as they diffused as either reinvention (changes made to an innovation by its developers or its host organization prior to spread), and adaptation (changes made by implementers in communities as they enact an innovation at their site). Reinvention and adaptation of innovations can both affect innovation fidelity, and in different ways.

Reinvention by innovation developers is a normal part of diffusion (→Rice and Rogers 1980). →Larson, Dearing, and Backer (2017) found that as they debut, test, and grow their innovations, developers reinvent, trying to find a fit between their innovation as well as their early collaborators and the staff at the few sites where the innovation was initially tried. Among the innovations in the study, most lead partners believed adaptation to be required for effective and continued implementation. Most leaders had personal experience with field conditions; they believed that even the best innovation could fail if put into place in an ill-suited incompatible environment. When adaptation was expected or encouraged, sometimes certain components of an innovation were prescribed while others were only suggested, or could be implemented in one of a number of ways. Being rigid about certain innovation components but flexible about others was a common orientation to fidelity by team leaders across the many organizations involved in the study.

Although final decisions about programmatic or scale-up changes reside with a lead organization in branching pathways, →Larson, Dearing, and Backer's (2017) results show that decisions to reinvent were influenced by funders and consultants. Regarding innovations that diffused via affiliate pathways, partners often engaged in interactive redesign with partner organizations. Lastly, several examples of reinvention exist where the organizations themselves – not just the innovations they launched – were changed as a result of working together.

4.2 Methodological Opportunities

Diffusion is a complex communication process based in newness and the uncertainty it produces, thus we encourage researchers and students of organizational communication to employ multiple methods and/or mixed methods to study

diffusion. However, researchers who employ only quantitative, qualitative, or critical methods can also study diffusion through their unique methodological lens. We elaborate on these opportunities below.

Big Data. A majority of diffusion studies to date was conducted empirically using quantitative methods based on sampling strategies. As big data become more readily available and data science techniques mature, there is an opportunity to take diffusion research to the next level by using big data, data science, and computational methods. While the idea of big data is that its dataset is 'big' in size, in organizational communication research, it can also be understood as using the population data and not relying on simply a sample. This argument was advanced by →Mayer-Schönberger and Cukier (2014) as they talk about 'N=All', another definition of how big data can be applied to the social sciences and humanities. This argument is helpful because not every company is big in size or number of organizational members.

Big data research can be applied to diffusion in organizational communication. For example, a social network analysis of email communication within an organization can reveal who are the most central members in the organization's email communication network (→Kossinets and Watts 2009). Given this insight, management and/or researchers can strategically partner with these central individuals (i.e., opinion leaders) to promote the diffusion of an innovation. Organizations have access to many other types of digital data automatically recorded on the server. The possibility of diffusion analyses and creative applications is abundant.

The opportunity for using big data for diffusion research in organizations is also made possible because management usually already owns or has the data of innovation adoption and implementation within the organization, especially for

technological innovations. However, ethical guidelines and thoughtful interpretations by management need to be enforced by those who analyze organizational members' usage data for internal insights about diffusion. →Mayer-Schönberger and Cukier (2014) emphasize that analytics and correlational insights from big data often inform us about the 'what', and not the 'why'. But the inclusion of all the data (N=All) is what allows management to track and understand the trends and patterns of innovation adoption, implementation, and adaptation towards sustainable diffusion.

Qualitative Methods. →Meyer (2004) argues for more qualitative diffusion research. As previously mentioned, quantitative analysis can generate great insights into the 'what' (especially with N=All), but in order to get to the 'why', researchers would benefit from incorporating qualitative studies, such as interviews, observations, and focus groups. Organizational members often have quite different reasons for their adoption, hesitations, adaptation, or "mashing up" of different innovation components due to personal, situational, or local constraints. Understanding the 'why' through qualitative data can help triangulate the 'why' with the 'what' from quantitative data. Indeed, many of our prior studies of diffusion have featured strong qualitative aspects to the studies we have conducted.

Qualitative diffusion research can identify and investigate 'critical events' during diffusion, what triggered them, how they developed, and with what consequences on adoption, implementation, and reinvention. Sometimes critical events are treated as socioecological or environmental factors that disrupt the assumed linear spread of an innovation. However, these 'critical events' often represent the reality in organizational life and can be insightful for understanding diffusion.

Psycho-physiological Methods. Advances in biological approaches to studying communication science, such as psycho-physiological research (→Keene et al. 2017) – where participants are wired up for measuring their heart rates, respiratory markers, body temperature, etc. – provides another new and exciting method for studying diffusion. One might ask what are the physiological responses of organizational members when they are first introduced to an innovation? Does different message framing affect their physiological responses (and subsequently psychological responses)? What about when they first encounter an innovation required for their job? What physiological states trigger sharing behaviors (online or in person) with peers, and with what sentiment (positive or negative)? Such a study would require a laboratory setting, but the experimental conditions and priming messages can be organizational in nature.

5 Conclusion

Where can diffusion research by organizational communication researchers make the greatest contributions to understanding the communication processes by which innovations shape and contribute to organizations? What explains organizational members' own rationalities in responding to new things? How much shaping of innovations – adaptations – is due to organizational context? What can organizational communication researchers gain from studying diffusion?

We believe diffusion research can contribute to important research paradigms in organizational communication such as the communicative constitution of organizations, dialectical tensions as fundamental forces in organizational communication, the narrative rationality perspective, and social change in organizations, which we will elaborate further

below. While innovations are often thought of as new technologies, we remind readers that innovative behaviors, practices, ideas, business models, and policies can be studied as innovations, too (some of our favorite diffusion investigations concern fads and fashions!). Consider the four areas below.

First, modern organizational communication is facilitated by a mix of face-to-face (FTF) and computer-mediated communication (CMC), and increasingly human-machine communication (HMC). Scholars taking the communicative constitution of organizations (CCO) approach (→Putnam and Nicotera 2009; see also Chapter 2 in this handbook) would argue that organizations are the result of FTF, CMC, and HMC. Studying the diffusion of new communication technologies and how they are adopted and implemented in organizations to facilitate FTF, CMC, and HMC and perhaps especially the consideration of what the evolving mix of those technologies means to organizational members and their work/life balance as it is being shaped right now is fascinating.

Second, diffusion is a dynamic mix of top-down and bottom-up processes. Such a situation creates tensions and 'dialectics' (→Fairhurst 2001; →Gibbs 2009), a fundamental force in organizational communication. Studying diffusion would help organizational communication researchers better understand the tensions inherent in organizational life, and how the dialectical tensions can also create binding structures that hold complex organizations together, making tensions productive forces in the process of contemporary organizing (→Kee and Browning 2010).

Third, diffusion is often not smooth, linear, and deterministic, but rather full of barriers, misperceptions, rejections, adaptations, and discontinuations. For example, →Leonardi's (2009) study documents that a group of engineers rejected a computational tool that was in fact capable of improving their work, simply due to a

misunderstanding that originated within, then spread across, the work group. →Browning (1992) argues that organizational communication is not simply about technical rationality (i.e., standards, logics, accountability, and certainty), but also narrative rationality (i.e., stories that are humorous, tragic, dramatic, and of multiple voices). To emphasize one and overlook the other makes our full understanding of organizational communication incomplete. Studying diffusion allows researchers to embrace Browning's model of organizational communication.

Fourth and finally, studying diffusion allows organizational communication researchers to identify, problematize, and deconstruct the hierarchy that leads to biases for or against adoption. It also allows organizational communication researchers to investigate how innovations challenge the power imbalances in organizations, and help members move towards understanding differences, and/or transform organizations towards social justice as an innovation (see also Chapter 3 in this handbook). As mentioned earlier in this chapter, diffusion theory is about social/organizational change, whether the level of analysis is a team, a division, an organization or industrial sector, a community or society, a state or country. Given the significance of studying diversity in organizations (→Doerfel and Gibbs 2020), diffusion research can be leveraged to advance our understanding of organizing for inclusion. We believe that diffusion theory when understood and applied in practice can help make organizations a better place to work, connect, and contribute to society and humanity.

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Chapter 11 The Role of Social Identity in Organizational Communication Over Time

Jos Bartels

Abstract

This chapter examines theories, conceptualizations, and research concerning social identity, organizational identification, and organizational communication over time. The first section focuses on the development of social identity theory, self-categorization theory, and the introduction of multiple organizational identities (the 1970s). The second section describes how organizational identification is perceived from a management and a communicative perspective (the 1980s and 1990s). These two streams developed in parallel over time and show both differences and shared elements. The role of communication in organizational identification is also extensively described in the chapter's third section, both from a management/organizational behavior perspective and a communication-centered perspective (beginning of the 21st century). The final section focuses on the role of social media in organizational identification over the past decade. It discusses identification as a result and as an antecedent of social media usage in organizations. The chapter concludes with some challenging ideas for future research. However, the question "Which came first, the chicken (organizational identification) or the egg (organizational communication)?" remains unanswered. In short, we may call this book chapter a brief history lesson on the development of social identification in organizational communication research, with an intentional open ending.

Keywords: communication and mergers, communication climate, computer-mediated communication, horizontal communication, Facebook, LinkedIn, multiple organizational identification environments (MOIE), online employee advocacy, organizational identification, organizational commitment, social identity theory, social media, Henri Tajfel, John Turner, Twitter, vertical communication,

1 History and Definition of Social Identity Theory (the 1970s)

→Hess and Goldblatt (1957) were among the first to use the term social identity to explain the status of American adolescents. However, social identity theory (SIT) truly started in the 1970s, when →Tajfel (1972) and →Turner (1975) introduced the term in the context of intergroup behavior. Social identity was defined as "the individual's knowledge that he (or she) belongs to certain groups together with some emotional and value significance to him (or her) of the group membership" (→Tajfel 1972: 31). Tajfel and his colleagues were mostly interested in why people behave in certain ways when in groups. More specifically, they started to investigate under what conditions individuals perceive themselves as group members and favor their own group over other groups. Although they conducted a series of experiments, I will briefly explain one illustrative example. Sixteen high school students had to choose between one of two painters (Paul Klee versus Wassily Kandinsky). Based on this choice, they were assigned to a group who all preferred that painter.

Students did not know each other in advance, nor did they meet each other. The only thing they had in common was that they thought they had chosen the same painting. Then, the researchers randomly assigned the 16 high school students to one of two conditions, independent of their choice of painter. The students were then allowed to assign credits to give the

largest reward to both groups (maximum joint profit), give the largest reward to the member of the in-group regardless of the reward to the student from the other group (largest possible reward to in-group), or give the largest possible difference in reward between members of the different groups (maximum difference or in-group favoritism). The researchers found some remarkable results. In all experiments, students chose to maximize the difference between the two groups. Therefore, Tajfel concluded that even under minimal conditions (where people do not know each other), provided they are "assigned to a group" compared to another group, there seems to be some kind of in-group favoritism. Accordingly, perhaps the most important outcome of peoples' knowledge of belongingness within a group is in-group favoritism. Some concrete examples of the actual behavioral outcomes of this in-group favoritism include wearing a sweatshirt of your former university to show people that you are a proud alumnus, buying a hat of your favorite football team to show which team you support; or, in an organizational context, proudly talking about your company at a birthday party. In short, the stronger the relationship between an individual and a group, the more willing individuals are to exhibit cooperative behavior toward this group (→Haslam 2012). Although there are several assumptions contained within SIT and its behavioral outcomes, I believe that the most important assumption is that self-esteem is the reason why an individual decides to identify with a group. In other words, we simply want to feel good about ourselves; therefore, we identify with a group of people who will help us acquire this feeling. Consequently, we then accept that a part of our self-identity will turn into the social identity of the group.

Some questions remain unanswered in SIT that could be answered by self-categorization theory (SCT) (→Turner et al. 1987). Although SCT has focused on a variety of topics within

social identity, I will briefly focus on the most important. The first topic concerns the multiple personal and social identities that people can have. The second topic is related to the visibility of these different identities in different situations (e.g., identity salience). The third topic concerns how one recognizes a typical member of a certain group (e.g., prototyping). To explain multiple identities, SCT is often used to further explain the so-called depersonalization processes from oneself as an individual, via the self as a team member (social) and as an organizational member (social), toward the self as a human being. For an overview, see Haslam (2012). Identity salience means that when a certain category (or identity) becomes salient, people see themselves and other members less as individuals and more as interchangeable exemplars of the group prototype (→Hornsey 2008). Prototypes are then specific people who exhibit characteristics that are prototypical for the entire group. Colloquial examples of this include, “This is typically how my students react to the announcement of an exam”, “Politicians are unreliable”, or “I truly like old people”. In all these remarks, there are certain assumptions of prototyping. Although prototyping is often defined with the negative connotation of stereotyping (e.g., accusing Dutch customs of ethnic profiling), we all need prototyping at some point. Moreover, it is hardly possible to judge every individual with whom we communicate as an individual. Furthermore, in organizational communication, researchers mainly talk about organizational stakeholders (e.g., employees) instead of individuals. In summary, in addition to all the possible risks of prejudice, prototyping makes our lives easier with regard to defining others and ourselves. For an extensive historic overview of SIT and SCT, please see →Hornsey (2008).

Since the so-called minimal group studies in the early 1970s, thousands of studies have been conducted on SIT and SCT in a wide variety of contexts. For example, several authors

have proven that SIT has great importance for the study of social relations (→Brewer and Kramer 1986), self-esteem (→Abrams and Hogg 1988), and group boundaries (→Ellemers et al. 1988). Moreover, SIT has been used to explain employee behavior (→van Knippenberg and van Schie 2000), consumer behavior (→Bhattacharya and Sen 2003), and even sports fans' behavior (→Fisher and Wakefield 1998). As this chapter is about the role of organizational communication in social identity over time, it is not my intention to be exhaustive on this matter. In the following section, I will further focus on the definition and relevance of SIT for organizations.

2 Introduction of Social Identity Theory in Organizations: Organizational Identification (the 1980s and 1990s)

Organizational identification (OID) can be defined as "the perception of oneness with or belongingness to an organization, where the individual defines him or herself in terms of the organization(s) of which he or she is a member" (→Mael and Ashforth 1992: 104). Based on SIT, research in the 1990s already indicated that employees who identify strongly with their organization demonstrate positive attitudes and behaviors toward that organization (→Ashforth and Mael 1989; →Mael and Ashforth 1992; →Dutton, Dukerich, and Harquail 1994). Extensive research has further indicated that stronger organizational identification leads to higher levels of job satisfaction, more extra-role behaviors, lower feelings of intent to leave, higher employee well-being, less employee absenteeism, and less burnout (see for example →Riketta 2005; →Riketta and van Dick 2005).

Employees can also identify with different parts of an organization. Thus, here, I briefly discuss the importance of these possible multiple identities in organizations. →Figure 1

shows a division of multiple identities in an organization (→Ashforth and Johnson 2001).

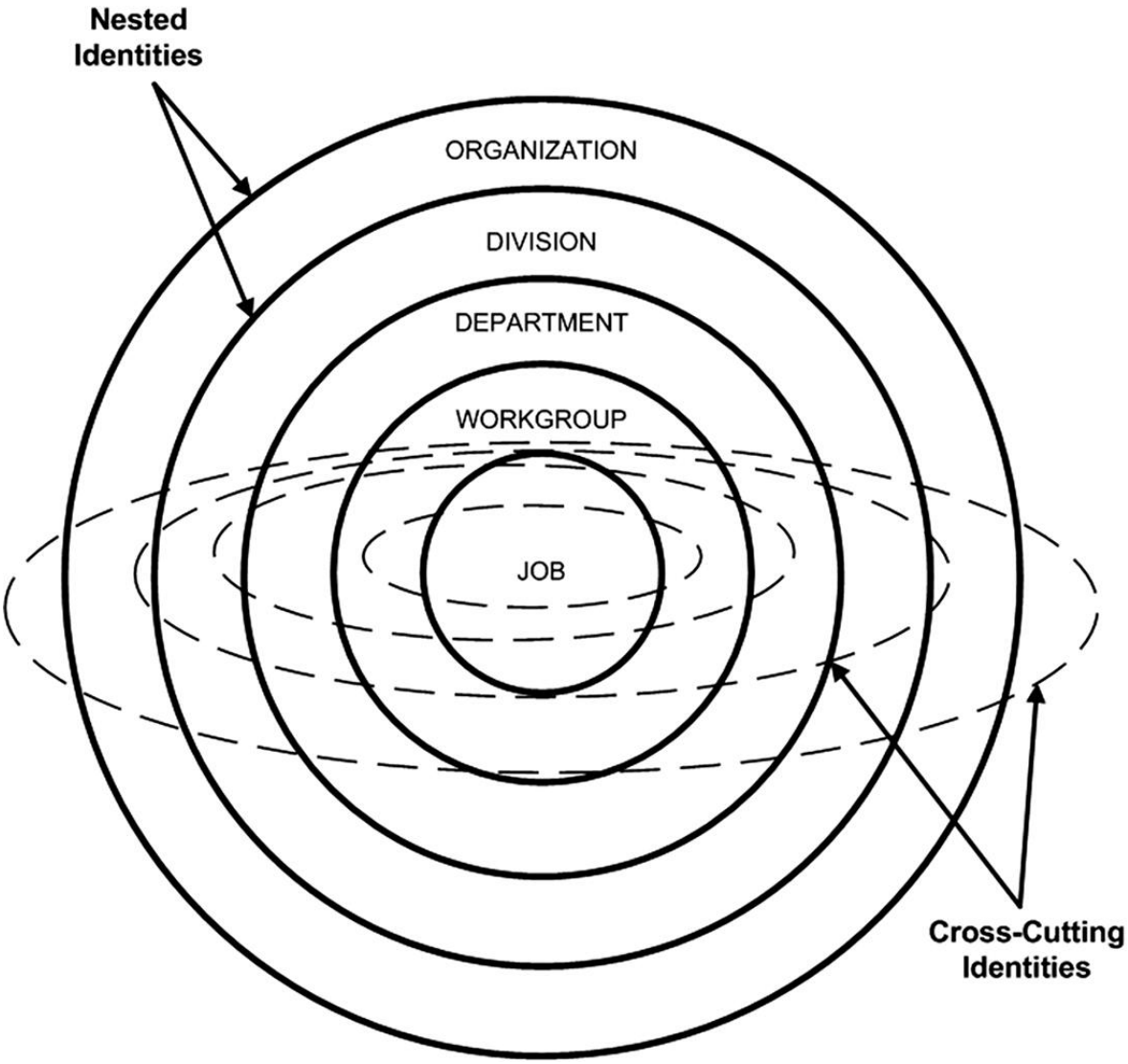


Figure 1: Nested and Cross-Cutting Identities in Organizations. Source: →Ashforth and Johnson (2001: 33).

The authors proposed a model in which identities could be cross-cutting and/or nested (embedded). Cross-cutting means that an identity cuts vertically through organizational levels. For example, although employees within marketing and human resource (HR) departments have their own identities within their department, they share an identity in regard to

the overall organization. Hence, some parts of these identities overlap or are cross-cutting (organizational characteristics), while others are distinct (departmental characteristics). Nested identities in organizations imply that one identity is part of a bigger identity. In an organizational context, all departments (e.g., marketing and HR departments) are part of a more general organization. →Ashforth and Johnson (2001) further describe closely linked identities (workgroup/department) as lower-order identities in which daily work life happens. In contrast, higher-order identities are further away from daily work life and are at a more abstract level (division/overall organization). Research has indicated that employees tend to identify more strongly with lower-order identities than with higher-order identities in organizations (→Riketta and van Dick 2005) and that employee identification with these lower-order identities (job, workgroup, or department) is mostly positively related to employee identification with higher-order identities (e.g., →van Knippenberg and van Schie 2000). Moreover, the distinction of these different identities within organizations is further relevant for organizational communication scholars, since studies have also demonstrated that identification with different levels of the organization shows different determinants and can have different consequences (e.g., →Reade 2001). Hence, different forms of organizational communication explain different forms of employee identification (→Bartels et al. 2007; →Bartels et al. 2010).

Organizational identification research can be divided into several streams; specifically, two major streams of researchers can be derived: management scholars (e.g., →Ashforth and Mael 1989; →Ashforth, Harrison, and Corley 2008; →Scott and Lane 2000), who mostly use insights from social psychology (→Ellemers, Kortekaas, and Ouwerkerk 1999), and communication scholars (e.g., →Cheney 1983; →Kuhn and Nelson 2002). While the two streams have some distinctive

backgrounds, sometimes they coincide. Moreover, although the use of organizational identification seems to be much more common for management scholars (thousands of studies in management journals) compared to communication scholars (dozens of studies in communication journals), both streams have had a significant impact on the knowledge of organizational communication regarding employee identification.

From a communication perspective, →Cheney (1983) wrote a pivotal paper on the role of organizational identification in employee decision making. Although the author describes "belonging" (p. 347) and "tightening of one's association with a group" (p. 361), he does not necessarily define the term organizational identification (based on SIT or SCT). →Cheney (1983) states the process of identification in relation to decision making as follows: "A person identifies with a unit when, in making a decision, the person in one or more of his/her organizational roles perceives that unit's interest – AS that unit's interest – to be relevant in evaluating the alternatives of choice" (p. 353). Similar to many communication studies on identification processes, the author uses both qualitative (to explain a process) and quantitative (to explain relationships) approaches. He uses the outcomes of interviews to interpret participants' scores on an organizational identification questionnaire (OIQ). This OIQ is used in many communication studies and comprises a wide variety of topics: (a) feelings of solidarity or a sense of belonging, (b) loyalty to the organization, and (c) perceived similarity in terms of shared characteristics, values, or goals (see →Miller et al. 2000: 629 for a detailed explanation). Hence, although authors of OIQ papers stem partly from different backgrounds, the characteristics they use to operationalize organizational identification appear closely related to SIT characteristics. Subsequently, →Cheney and Tompkins (1987) specified

organizational identification as a process of identification in which identity (the end-product) is shaped through the use of language (process). As →Larson and Pepper (2003) further stated, “People bond themselves with a particular value-based identity and subsequently make sense of the world through discourse” (p. 532).

Since Cheney’s early work (→1983), communication scholars have conducted organizational identification research based on theories other than SIT (e.g., →Kuhn and Nelson 2002). For example, →Scott, Corman, and Cheney (1998) used structuration theory to explain organizational identification, stating that organizational identification can be treated as a duality in which identities create and are created by identifications in social interactions with others. They further argue that different identities can be conceptualized and that these multiple identities have corresponding “targets” of attachment. Hence, →Scott, Corman, and Cheney (1998) seemed to explain organizational identification somewhat similarly to what researchers from the management stream correspondingly explained as multiple organizational identification environments (→Ashforth and Johnson 2001). Based on the assumptions of social presence theories and adaptive structuration theory, →Fonner and Roloff (2012) discuss a so-called connectivity paradox in which they try to explain the relationships between perceived social presence (positive), stressful interruptions (negative), and organizational identification. They argue that the more frequent use of communication media can lead to both advantages and disadvantages in a teleworking setting. In summary, although some studies incorporate SIT into their assumptions (e.g., →Kuhn and Nelson 2002) or explanations (e.g., →Miller et al. 2000), a variety of other theories are used by communication scholars to explain organizational identification.

→Ashforth and Mael (1989) were two of the first management scholars to use SIT to explain organizational identification. Moreover, →Dutton, Dukerich, and Harquail (1994) focused on similarities between attributes of oneself and perceived organizational identity or how employees define themselves in terms of organizational attributes. The more similar the characteristics between themselves and the organization, the greater they define the organization as a social group. Hence, there is stronger organizational identification. →Dutton, Dukerich, and Harquail (1994) indicated some overlap of the communicative conceptualizations of organizational identification in terms of shared characteristics, which are used by some communication scholars to define the concept of identification (e.g., →Cheney 1983). However, in contrast to the views of communication scholars, the view of Dutton, Dukerich, and Harquail is more rooted in SIT.

Other important conceptualizations have been proposed. Several authors argue that cognitive definitions lack some of the core elements of SIT. →Ellemers, Kortekaas, and Ouwerkerk (1999: 372) argue that organizational identification can be a cognitive, affective, and evaluative process (→Bergami and Bagozzi 2000). →Van Dick (2001) further describes various components, including affective (emotional attachment), knowledge or cognitive (awareness of being a member of a group), evaluative (pride), and behavioral (conative) components, with the latter including actual behavior. Although this final component seems to be more of an outcome of the identification process, this idea is closely related to that of →Cheney (1983), who describes organizational identification as a function of decision making. Furthermore, →Leach et al. (2008) describe identification in terms of five dimensions: solidarity (I feel a bond); satisfaction (I am glad to be part of a group); centrality (I often think about being part of a group); individual self-stereotyping (I have a

lot in common with the average in-group person); and in-group homogeneity (in-group people have a lot in common with each other). The conceptualization they use for centrality could also be perceived as the identity salience derived from SCT. Despite the strong overlap between several conceptualizations of organizational identification, some appear to be more suitable than others. Moreover, some definitions appear to encompass more than just the process of organizational identification by focusing on behavioral outcomes (e.g., see →Edwards 2005; →Ashforth, Harrison, and Corley 2008). Other conceptualizations can be too narrow, since they only describe cognitive aspects (knowing) of identification. I would argue that definitions that at least recognize a cognitive, emotional, and evaluative process align more effectively with the original concepts of SIT.

Some similarities can be distinguished within the two streams of research. Both streams emphasize organizational identification as a strong indicator for a variety of positive attitudes and behavioral outcomes. Furthermore, both communication and management scholars recognize the multidimensionality of organizational identification. Identities corresponding to different organizational levels have different strengths, antecedents, and consequences and are mostly positively related to each other. Moreover, both streams emphasize the multidimensionality of the construct of identification with regard to content, e.g., the cognitive knowledge of overlapping values between oneself and the organization and the sense of belongingness. This multidimensionality becomes confusing when actual behavior is included in the conceptualizations, since these behaviors often seem to be more of an outcome of organizational identification.

There are also some important distinctions. Management scholars seem to rely more emphatically on insights from SIT. Communication scholars often use different explanations for

these identification processes (e.g., social presence theories and structuration theory) and appear to use a more interpretative approach than management scholars (with some exceptions). Consequently, most communication research is both qualitative and quantitative, focusing more on the interactive process of identification. In comparison, management researchers tend to place greater emphasis on a more empirical, analytical view. I do not necessarily believe that this is a bad thing. Social sciences need both research streams to derive more insights regarding the process and state of organizational identification. However, slightly more overlap could sometimes prove beneficial. Although there is overlap between their conceptualizations and operationalizations and scholars from both streams sometimes refer to each other, management and communication scholars mainly seem to work apart.

3 Role of Communication in Organizational Identification (2000s Onward)

3.1 Communication Climate

In various studies, the importance of internal communication has been highlighted in terms of its relationships with organizational identification (e.g., →Atouba, Carlson, and Lammers 2019; →Scott 1997). →Kitchen and Daly (2002) argued that supportive organizational communication is crucial for the survival of an organization. One way of explaining this supportive communication is through a communication climate. →Dennis (1974: 29) defined a communication climate as “a subjective experienced quality of the internal environment of an organization: the concept embraces a general cluster of inferred predispositions, identifiable through reports of members perceptions’ of messages and message related events occurring in the

organization". Accordingly, a communication climate can be described as an employees' perceptions of the quality of communication within an organization. Readers are directed to →Goldhaber (1993) for an extensive description.

The impact of a communication climate was initially studied in research on organizational commitment. Although I realize that organizational identification and commitment are distinct, they are strongly related constructs, as explained in detail by →Edwards (2005). In a meta-analysis, →Riketta (2005) found a strong overlap between affective commitment and organizational identification. Other communication studies have also used these constructs in an intertwined manner (e.g., →Fay and Kline 2012; →Reed, Goolsby, and Johnston 2016). Without ignoring differences, I will rely on the literature pertaining to the relationship between communication and commitment to explain my arguments. Researchers have already found a positive relationship between dimensions of communication climate and employee commitment (→Allen 1992; →Guzley 1992; →Trombetta and Rogers 1988) when →Smidts, Pruyn, and van Riel (2001) introduced the term into organizational identification research. Since their seminal paper, studies have elaborated on the relationship between a communication climate and employee identification, for example, at different levels of an organization (e.g., →Bartels et al. 2007). In line with →Ashforth and Johnson's (2001) multiple identities in organizations, →Bartels et al. (2007) found that communication climate at a specific level in an organization was strongly positively related to identification at the same organizational level.

In summary, a vast number of studies on the role of internal communication in employee identification or commitment have focused on employee perceptions of communication. Although authors have formulated distinct terms for these perceptions, communication climate could be used as an overall concept to define internal communication.

3.2 Horizontal and Vertical Communication

3.2.1 *Vertical Communication and Organizational Identification*

In addition to communication (climate) at different levels of an organization, a distinction can be made in horizontal and vertical communication. →Postmes, Tanis, and De Wit (2001) found that vertical communication was positively related to organizational commitment. Moreover, →Bartels et al. (2010) investigated the roles of horizontal and vertical communication in professional and organizational identification. The results of their study indicated that vertical communication (both upward and downward) was more strongly related to organizational identification than horizontal communication.

Some specific forms of vertical communication have further received extensive attention in organizational identification research: interactions between supervisors and subordinates, leader-membership exchange (LMX) (→Loi, Chan, and Lam 2014; →Walumbwa et al. 2011; →Zhao et al. 2019), and more recently, ethical leadership (→Qian and Jian 2020). →Van Vuuren, de Jong, and Seydel (2007) revealed that feedback from (and the listening skills of) managers played the most important role in employees' commitment to an organization. In accordance with these results, →Scott and Stephens (2009) demonstrated that supervisor communication competence (e.g., being a good listener and providing appropriate feedback) was positively related to organizational identification. Most recently, several studies in different contexts have found that communication from leaders (more specifically, motivating language) has both direct (→Mayfield, Mayfield, and Walker 2021; →Men, Chen, and Ji 2021) and indirect effects (→Yue, Men, and Ferguson 2021) on employees' identification with an organization. In short, vertical communication, specifically upward and

downward communication with one's supervisor/manager, seems to play an important role in employee identification with the organization.

3.2.2 Horizontal Communication and Employee Identification

In addition to vertical communication, horizontal communication focuses on employees who are on an "equal footing" in the hierarchy (→Postmes 2003). Previous research has shown that communicating with colleagues within a group can lead to more cohesion (→Levine and Moreland 1990). →Wallace (1995) also demonstrated that the support of colleagues is important for employees' professional commitment. Similarly, →Bartels et al. (2010) concluded that horizontal communication (openness and the level of contact with colleagues) was more important for professional identification than for organizational identification. Team-member exchange (TMX) has often been used to describe the quality of relationships between team members (e.g., →Seers 1989). Moreover, TMX is directly and positively related to commitment (→Liden, Wayne, and Sparrowe 2000) and team identification (→Apker, Propp, and Zabava Ford 2009). More recently, →Boyraz (2019) further found a strong and positive relationship between a psychologically safe communication climate and team identification. These studies demonstrate that vertical communication seems to be more linked to overall identification with the organization (higher-order identities), while horizontal communication is more related to workgroup or team identification (lower-order identities).

3.3 Communication during Mergers and Organizational Change

To be comprehensive, special attention should be paid to the role of communication in organizational identification during

mergers and organizational change. →Chreim (2002) argued that the language and communication strategies of managers should focus on reducing members' identification with their previous organization while simultaneously enforcing their identification with the new organization. →Schweiger and DeNisi (1991) found that the quality and quantity of communication shared about a merger was positively related to organizational commitment. Moreover, →van Dick, Ullrich, and Tissington (2006) demonstrated that positive evaluations of management communication resulted in stronger employee postmerger identification. →Bartels et al. (2006) also found a positive relationship between employees' perceptions of communication (communication climate) about the merger process and their expected organizational identification with the new organization. →Bartels, Pruyn, and de Jong (2009) further found that a communication climate was more important for employees' identification with their division than for their identification with the overall organization. More recently, →Neill, Men, and Yue (2020) concluded that communication climate (e.g., open and participatory) had a positive impact on organizational identification, resulting in positive responses to organizational change. These studies emphasized the role of communication during merger processes and organizational change. More specifically, in addition to general perceptions of openness and honesty about the process, the language that managers use in their communication and the meanings they give to new organizational identities seem to play crucial roles in positive organizational identification processes during mergers and organizational change.

3.4 Computer-Mediated Communication and Organizational Identification

Before the current prevalence of social media, studies emphasized the role of computer-mediated communication (CMC) in social identity (e.g., →Postmes, Spears, and Lea 1998). →Larson and Pepper (2011) argued that identification can influence technology and that technology can influence employee identification. This is because identification can shape the symbolic meanings we have of technology, while these technologies may also shape and reinforce these meanings. →Huff, Sproull, and Kiesler (1989) were some of the first to investigate the relationship between the mode (and frequency) of communication and organizational identification. They revealed that computer mail was somewhat positively related to organizational commitment. Although →Wiesenfeld, Raghuram, and Garud (1999) found no direct effect of the frequency of electronic communication, this form of communication was important for employees with high virtual statuses to their identification with the organization. In the context of knowledge sharing, studies have confirmed that CMC use (the use of email or the intranet) positively influences affective commitment (e.g., →van den Hooff and Ridder 2004). Moreover, in multiple identity contexts, →Millward, Haslam, and Postmes (2007) investigated communication via CMC and employees' working conditions. They found that positive perceptions of electronic communication mediated the relationship between desk assignment and organizational identification. Although studies have mainly revealed the positive role of CMC in organizational identification and commitment, some have reported negative results. →Fonner and Roloff (2012) concluded that connectivity can increase stress from interruptions, causing an indirect negative effect on teleworkers' identification with an organization. Moreover, →Stich et al. (2019) found that a higher email load was

associated with lower organizational commitment. In the next section, I will describe the possible positive and/or negative effects of social media on employee identification in more detail.

3.5 Role of Social Media in Organizational Identification (2010–2020)

Studies on the relationship between social media and employee identification have only more recently evolved. Some studies on social media use SIT to explain this relationship (e.g., →Madsen 2016; →Bartels, van Vuuren, and Ouwerkerk 2019; →Men, O'Neil, Ewing 2020). To provide a broader overview of the topic and to be consistent, I will use insights from both organizational and affective commitment and organizational identification research. Moreover, I will also elaborate on studies that do not necessarily use SIT. When they do, I will highlight how these studies use SIT.

3.5.1 Organizational and Affective Commitment

The first employee studies on social media that included organizational/affective commitment focused on the possible negative consequences of social media usage. →Barber and Santuzzi (2015) developed a scale for measuring what they referred to as telepressure, meaning stress from social media usage at work. The authors did not focus specifically on employees' affective commitment as an antecedent or outcome variable. Rather, they revealed mixed results in the relationship between social media usage and commitment. For example, ICT availability was positively related to commitment, whereas a lack of control over ICT was negatively related. Moreover, ICT workload was not related to commitment. →Jena (2015) focused on "technostress" in ICT-enabled collaborative learning, where the results were more

delineated. Here, technostress creators (e.g., personal lives being invaded by ICT) were negatively related to organizational commitment. Conversely, technostress inhibitors (e.g., the organization provides rewards the use of new technologies) were positively related to commitment. In addition to “technostress”, some commitment studies have focused on the privacy concerns of employees. →Chory, Vela, and Avtgis (2016) found that the more employees were concerned about organizational infringement (e.g., employee concerns about the organization intruding into their perceived ability to control access), the lower their organizational commitment was. However, the perceived ability to control access (e.g., employee perceptions of their own ability to control access) was not related to organizational commitment. In other words, if the organization is able to control employee CMC usage, privacy concerns regarding this control lead to lower employee commitment to the organization. →Cistulli and Snyder (2023) further found a clear negative relationship between employee social media privacy concerns and organizational commitment. →Snyder and Cistulli (2020) demonstrated that social media privacy was indirectly positively related to organizational commitment through supervisor trust.

Some studies have also described the role of social media in the relationship between leadership (e.g., LMX) and employee commitment. →Hill, Kang, and Seo (2014) revealed that the role of LMX in organizational commitment is more important when the work environment is more insecure due to online communication. More recently, →Khan et al. (2019) concluded that transformational leadership has direct positive relationships with task performance and affective commitment and an indirect positive relationship through social media on task performance. However, they did not find the same effect of social media on commitment.

→Luo et al. (2018) focused on positive outcomes of employees' social media usage. The authors suggested that nonwork-related bloggers voluntarily disclose themselves to other members of the organization, which can enhance the feeling of a close circle of employees, making these employees feel more at home in the organization (sense of belongingness). Moreover, sharing private content with colleagues could also lead to shared meaning, strengthening emotional attachment. Although the authors did not use SIT to explain their results, they seem to use a similar argument of feelings of belongingness. Several other commitment studies have focused on the positive effects of social media usage (e.g., →Kock and Moqbel 2021). For example, →Olfat et al. (2019) demonstrated that the use of public social networks (SNs) to communicate with colleagues was positively related to affective commitment, while the use of enterprise social networks (ESNs) was not related. The authors explained these results for public SNs in terms of strengthening social relations among employees and enhancing a sense of belonging to each other and the organization. →Zhang et al. (2019) found that both work- and nonwork-related social media usage had a positive effect on organizational commitment through organizational engagement. In contrast to previous →studies, Olfat et al. (2020a, →2020b) used organizational commitment as an antecedent of employees' work-related use of online social networks rather than as a consequence. Their results indicated that organizational commitment is directly and indirectly related to employees' work-related use of online SNs.

Finally, two recent related studies focused on the anonymous use of social media in organizations (→Kim and Scott 2019; →Kim and Leach 2020). →Kim and Scott (2019) found positive relationships between the perceived qualities of changes in communication, freedom of speech, and affective commitment. Furthermore, they revealed a negative

correlation between anonymous online support seeking and expressing ideas (e.g., expressing concerns and offering input) and affective commitment. This negative relationship seemed to have disappeared when other variables were concluded in the analyses. →Kim and Leach (2020) also found a positive relationship between freedom of speech and commitment. However, they revealed a positive relationship between the anonymous expression of ideas and commitment. In other words, studies have indicated that positive perceptions of communication have a positive effect on commitment, while the effect of anonymous online behavior is less clear.

In conclusion, recent studies have tried to link the social media usage of employees to organizational commitment, with only a few using SIT to explain this relationship. Some studies have used commitment as an antecedent, while others have perceived it as a consequence. Overall, these studies on organizational commitment exhibit mixed results, with positive, zero, and/or negative relationships. In summary, the relationship between commitment and social media in work contexts seems somewhat inconclusive. Accordingly, in the next paragraph, I will attempt to illuminate the role of social media in organizational identification specifically.

3.5.2 *Organizational Identification*

Studies on organizational identification and social media have focused more on SIT and do not generally seem to be closely connected to previous studies on organizational and affective commitment. Perhaps one of the first studies on organizational identification was an interesting conference paper by →Larosiliere and Leidner (2012). They investigated the relationships between the use of Facebook (FB) to communicate with the organization, the use of a group FB page of the organization to communicate with colleagues,

vertical and horizontal communication climate, and organizational identification. Based on the assumptions of SIT and channel expansion theory, the authors found that social network usage (both individual and group FB use) was directly related to both vertical and horizontal communication climate, resulting in stronger employee identification. Moreover, →Sias (2017) found a positive relationship between the frequency of company FB use (visiting, posting comments, and liking items) and organizational identification. Based on social capital theory, she argued that being more active on the company's FB pages will lead to more links with weak ties, enhancing feelings of being part of a broader group.

Several studies have focused on the overlap between online private and social identities and on work-private life boundaries. Readers are directed to →Ollier-Malattere, Rothbard, and Berg (2013) for an extensive review of online boundaries. →Fieseler, Meckel, and Ranzini (2015) revealed that the more professional social media users identified with their organization, the greater they perceived some overlap between their private and professional social media profiles and contacts. More recently, →Piercy and Carr (2023) investigated the opposite (the effect of personal overlap on organizational identification) and found that a stronger overlap between online private and social networks results in stronger organizational identification. →Bartels, van Vuuren, and Ouwerkerk (2019) focused on employee perceptions of having colleagues on FB to explain employees' identification with the organization. Based on SIT, they argued that work-related friends on FB may affect employee identification with different levels of the organization. The authors found that having colleagues on FB whom employees perceived as friends was more related to departmental identification, while having "powerful" colleagues as friends on FB resulted in stronger organizational identification. →Van Zoonen, Sivunen, and Rice (2020) investigated professional smartphone use

(messages, mail, and conversations) outside working hours, revealing that this usage was positively related to organizational identification. These studies imply that positive perceptions of an online overlap between private and work life can positively affect employees' identification with the organization.

Most work appears to have been conducted on the effect of internal social media on organizational identification. In her qualitative study, →Madsen (2016) investigated how employees' internal social media usage contributed to the construction of organizational identity. She concluded that online conversations could become organizational stories and narratives. These narratives can help employees make sense of the organization, helping to shape organizational identity. Furthermore, several recent studies have found positive effects of employees' internal (or organizational) social media use on organizational identification (→Men, O'Neil, Ewing 2020; Oksa et al. 2021; →Sias and Duncan 2020).

Some studies have used organizational identification as an antecedent to explain employees' online advocacy behavior (e.g., →Piercy and Carr 2023). →Van Zoonen et al. (2018) indicated that stronger organizational identification resulted in stronger online word-of-mouth on FB but not on LinkedIn. The authors explained that this difference was caused by the different affordances both social networks can have. Strong identification seems to be a prerequisite for positive behavior on social media that are not necessarily work-related (such as FB), while identification is less important for being positive on more professional social media (such as LinkedIn). Additionally, →van Zoonen and Treem (2019) found that stronger identification resulted in more information sharing about organizational issues on Twitter. I believe that these findings further explain the different roles organizational identification can play in social media that have different affordances.

Compared to studies on the relationships between social media and affective and organizational commitment, studies on organizational identification elicit somewhat more consistent results. The former exhibited mixed results, while the latter mostly proved the positive role of social media in employee identification with the organization. This positive role seems to be apparent in situations where organizational identification is treated as an antecedent and when identification is treated as a consequence of social media perceptions and usage. Therefore, I believe that the usage of the characteristics of SIT is crucial to further explain these relationships.

Based on the previous discussions, I would like to conclude this chapter with some food for thought. Without going into much detail, we can draw some conclusions from this chapter. First and most importantly, social identity theory (SIT) has easily stood the test of time. Since the early 1970s, research on SIT has been influential in the literature of both management and communication. Although communication scholars seem to prefer a somewhat more interpretative approach than management scholars, there are many similarities in how both research streams define organizational identification (as a specific process or a state of SIT). However, more emphasis on integrative thinking about the role of communication in organizational identification could be beneficial for everyone. Understanding organizational identification as multidimensional – in terms of both content (cognitive, affective, and evaluative) and context (with a team, department, or overall organization) – seems to further lead to more cumulative knowledge on the determinants and consequences of employee identification.

More work is needed in regard to today's prevalence of social media. While current (social media use) studies on employee commitment and identification seem to still focus strongly on the "frequency" of communication, research on

the quality or perceptions of communication via social media requires more attention. At least from the perspective of communication climate research, we can conclude that employees' perceptions of organizational communication are more important than the quantity of communication (via social media). It is then perhaps less relevant how we define these perceptions (e.g., communication climate; communication satisfaction) as long as they are addressed.

Recent work also indicates that organizational identification can be both a consequence of communication (via social media) and a determinant of concrete online (advocacy) behavioral intentions. Although I have not discussed whether organizational identification is a determinant or consequence of employee social media use, this topic may merit further elaboration.

Future research could focus on the universal role of social media in organizations. Although several literature reviews and meta-analyses on social media use by employees have recently emerged, research on organizational identification in cross-cultural contexts remains scarce. Moreover, research on centralization, freedom of speech, and employee voice (open and anonymous, and positive and negative) in these different cultural contexts could enhance our knowledge of SIT in organizations. Further insights from the affordances of different social media could be used to investigate the different contexts in which different forms of social media use (public, ESM, passive, or active) influence employee identification or vice versa.

Finally, we live in a world where a pandemic has made the role of social media in organizations more prominent than ever before. Therefore, the possible consequences of new ways of communication in organizations for different forms of (salience in) employee identification will need attention from both communication and management scholars in the years to come.

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Chapter 12 Coordination

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Abstract

Coordination is at the center of organizational process and accomplishment. This chapter reviews literature on coordination in organizational contexts at the dyadic/group/organizational and also at interorganizational levels. At the dyadic/group/organizational levels, similarity of experience and commitment among members can result in communities of practice and/or shared mental models that facilitate coordination, while structural issues such as boundary permeability of membership can foster or erode trust and group decision-making speed and effectiveness. Research also demonstrates that coordination is influenced by relationships and resources at the organizational level which can result in norms for mutual respect, shared knowledge, and common goals, but also conflict and power struggles between members. At the interorganizational level, coordination can be a driving force, but is complicated by differing organizational missions, and power imbalances between organizations and interpersonal relationships. These issues can facilitate or erode trust and organizations' desire to cooperate. We review traditional models with particular attention on current issues related to *diversity*, *globalization*, and the use of *technology* given the changing environment in which teams and organizations operate.

Keywords: coordination, collaboration, cooperation, interdependence, power in coordination, collective mind, transactive memory systems, shared mental models,

structural relationships in coordination, relational coordination theory, swift trust, workgroup diversity, interorganizational collaboration (IOC), global coordination, technology in coordination,

Most organizational accomplishments rely on individuals pooling their knowledge, skills, and labor to accomplish tasks, develop ideas, or achieve a goal, in cooperation, collaboration, and/or coordination – terms often used interchangeably. In this chapter, our focus is on coordination, but we also draw on research that includes collaboration and cooperation in organizations. We discuss coordination at the dyadic/group/organizational and interorganizational levels reviewing traditional models and focusing attention on current issues related to *diversity*, *globalization*, and the use of *technology* given the changing environment in which organizations operate. These issues shape relationships and the complexity of coordination to magnify tensions and opportunities that frequently arise in workgroup, organizational, and interorganizational coordination (→Woo 2019). Our discussion begins with an overview of some foundational issues.

First, although they are often used interchangeably, the terms cooperation, collaboration, and coordination are different. *Cooperation*, the more general, is an agreement by two or more parties to do something (→Castañer and Oliveria 2020). In *collaboration*, parties engage in a negotiated process to combine resources to accomplish a task (→Hardy, Phillips, and Lawrence 2003; →Lewis 2006). *Coordination* is in the middle and involves an effort to work together that draws upon structures to control and define the process and the desired outcome (→Alter and Hage 1993; →Zackrison, Seibold, and Rice 2015). Coordination has been and remains a major focus for organizational research because it is at the heart of nearly every major task in organizations affected by many factors including participants' professional commitment

(→Mitchell, Boyle, and Von Stieglitz 2019), motivation of parties to complete the task, resources available, and a shared understanding of each other's abilities (→Heath and Isbell 2017). For these reasons, individuals who share certain commonalities – whether that be in shared identities, experiences, or knowledge – often find coordination easier (→Hollingshead 1998; →Iverson and McPhee 2002; →Lave and Wenger 1991).

Second, coordination is primarily focused on information exchange and action (→Castañer and Oliveria 2020). Based on these ideas, →Thompson (1967) described three types of interdependence that affect the process and outcomes of working together. In *pooled interdependence*, individuals do not entirely depend on one another, but individuals count on each other to do their part to attain a shared goal. *Sequential interdependence* exists when individuals must depend on one person to complete their tasks before the next individual can begin theirs. When each does their respective part, they can achieve their shared goal. The third type – *reciprocal interdependence* – describes situations in which one person's work becomes the input for the next individual's work and their outputs are linked or looped to the previous person's work.

Third, underlying coordination of any type is power. "Power is the basic energy needed to initiate and sustain action or, to put it another way, the capacity to translate intention into reality and sustain it" (→Bennis and Nanus 1985: 6). Thus, power is the driving force bringing collaborative efforts to fruition. Power has been vilified and publicly shunned because many associate power with the abuse of power in which individuals elevate themselves and their causes at the expense of others. However, as →Gardner (1990) argued, "power is simply the capacity to bring about certain intended consequences in the behavior of others" (p. 56). It can exist because of formal structure (e.g., being in a

powerful organizational role), or because of informal or relational dynamics (e.g., being interpersonally persuasive or having a close personal relationship). While power can be abused, it also can be used for prosocial causes with positive effects such as the power to champion a team to win a sports event, to lead development of a new life-saving vaccination, or to pass a law providing greater voting access to citizens. Power is present whenever one or both parties have dependencies on, or with the other. Therefore, in any coordination when parties have interdependencies, they share power and rely on each other to attain a goal. When there is a power imbalance, the party with power over the other – whether that be resource control or social capital – defines the goals and can make demands about the other's contributions. Though power imbalances may be exploitative, they may also be the result of benign situations such as a trainee learning from a veteran employee or a mentee cultivating skills under the supervision of a mentor.

Desire for power can also create conflict within teams. For example, some individuals seek power in groups, while others are less concerned over such control of their team mates. Recent research by →Alipour, Mohammed, and Raghuram (2018) investigated power values diversity – "differences in the desire to attain social status and prestige, as well as social influence or control over others" (p. 231) – and its relationship on conflict in the workgroup. They found that when team members value power differently, friction was likely. However, conflicts among team members related to power concerns were less frequent if individuals felt safe or non-threatened participating in the work environment, setting the scene for effective coordination. Basic interdependencies and power issues are at the core of coordination. Next, we review the most researched level dyadic- and group-level coordination that occurs in organizations and contexts that shape those interactions.

1 Dyadic/Group/Organizational Coordination

When most people think about coordination, they first envision coordination in dyads or groups. On any given day across the globe, members of workgroups coordinate their efforts to assemble products, teammates coordinate to write sections of a report, cross-functional medical teams meet to create treatment plans for patients, and members of executive groups develop plans to expand their businesses. A central premise is that individuals who think similarly or have shared understandings have an easier time coordinating. Shared or group-level knowledge and experience make communication easier and usually more precise because individuals can draw on common terminology, communication processes, and connections developed from their mutual past to improve efficiency and performance (→Nonaka and van Krogh 2009; →Uitdewilligen, Waller, and Zijlstra 2010). A powerful example is →Weick and Roberts's (1993) study on the collective interrelating between members in a high reliability organization. They demonstrated the heedful interrelating of crews on an aircraft carrier where individuals developed cognitive interdependence and predictable patterns of action as a result of training and experience together which they call *collective mind*. Through collective mind, members are better able to anticipate others' actions, reducing the need for verbal communication in the moment, and with fewer errors as they coordinate.

A similar type of collective cognition has been investigated as *transactive memory systems*, described as group-level cognitions that can be used to coordinate and accomplish goals (→Hollingshead 1998), or *shared mental models*, defined as "a cognitive architecture that enables effective coordination and collaboration in work teams" (→Gross and Kluge 2012: 403). These terms specify that knowledge can be held within a group and communicatively shared (→Kuhn 2014). Transactive

memory and shared mental models are developed when group members share their knowledge within the group so that members are aware of each other's knowledge. Then, members develop a means to communicate verbally and non-verbally to enact knowledge when needed (→Hollingshead 1998). This metastructure provides a shared system of cognitive labor to learn, distribute, and store knowledge (→Hollingshead 1998). →Gross and Kluge (2012) proposed *four types of mental models* commonly held in teams: (1) task mental models specify how tasks should be accomplished; (2) equipment mental models provide guidance about the function of and procedures for using equipment; (3) interaction mental models specify roles and responsibilities of team members including patterns of interaction and information sources; and (4) team mental models provide information about the collective team's attributes, skills, and knowledge including who knows what and about resources available. Because experiences influence the development and sustainability of these common understandings, workgroups and teams that are stable in their membership and continuously work together are most likely to have developed and benefit from transactive memory or shared mental models.

Unfortunately, even groups that have developed transactive memory, shared mental models, or collective mind through training and a history of working together may experience errors that can reduce their effectiveness such as: (1) *accuracy errors* – inaccurate perceptions of others' levels of expertise or skills (→Brandon and Hollingshead 2004); (2) *omission errors* – inaccurately assuming someone else is handling a task; (3) *shared errors* – when members disagree or are unclear about who is supposed to perform a task; (4) *urgency errors* – when a member perceives an urgency to a situation and they take on a task that may not match their level of expertise; (5) *redundancy errors* – when tasks are

unnecessarily repeated by others; and (6) *validation errors* – when individuals fail to participate and take responsibility for the group's actions (→Hollingshead et al. 2011). Any of these types of errors can derail the workgroup's ability to coordinate effectively – with minor and major consequences.

1.1 Structural Relationships and Resources

Structural relationships create a system of skills and knowledge held within the group enabling the flow of communication between coordinating parties (→Brandon and Hollingshead 2004). Workgroups with stable membership and whose tasks are more or less routine generally find it easier to coordinate their efforts and make fewer mistakes because they know who knows what within their group, the roles of their peers, and they can more easily predict their peers' behaviors (→Vashdi, Bamberger, and Erez 2013). Workgroups that are housed in organizations or contexts that are in flux are more likely to make mistakes and be less efficient because structures of knowledge, skills, and roles are less stable (→Grabher 2011). Recent studies have questioned an assumption of transactive memory systems that knowledge is more or less uniformly distributed among members. Instead, knowledge can be centralized in one member which can be an effective system for information exchange and its integration (→Mell, van Knippenberg, and van Ginkel 2014). Alternatively, some members can actively or passively hide or fail to share knowledge from other members (→Anand, Centobelli, and Cerchione 2020). A lack of trust and feelings of interpersonal injustice have been attributed to knowledge hiding within groups (→Su 2021). Knowledge hiding can influence coordination when only some members have information that can facilitate the group's decision-making and activities. On this basis, group leaders are wise to encourage task

interdependence and promote work-related communication and knowledge sharing within the group.

The type of knowledge or expertise held by individual members of a workgroup is also consequential. →Barley, Treem, and Leonardi (2020) argued that three types of expertise are required for effective coordination. These include *domain expertise*, or knowledge of important topic areas; *interactional expertise*, or the ability to translate knowledge across domains; and *process expertise*, or the "skills and abilities to access, orient to or manipulate information in a manner that aids others and, therefore, involves communicative practices beyond the mastery of language" (→Barley, Treem, and Leonardi 2020: 64). Of course, expertise alone is not enough. The success of coordination efforts is contingent on members' ability to envision desired outcomes, which facilitates development of identification and commitment to the effort (→Koschmann 2013). See Chapter 17 of this volume for a discussion of team processes using the flows model of communicative constitution.

Organization-level factors also affect and shape knowledge sharing. Individuals' information sharing and consequent development of mental models are impacted by the quantity and quality of team communication, members' perceived appraisal (whether an individual believes the information they share has value), organizational communication norms (whether sharing among members is encouraged by the organization), organizational support (whether information is easily attained), and social ties (interpersonal interactions among members) (→Gross and Kluge 2012). Many of these factors are affected by leaders who can encourage communication, facilitating diversity of knowledge and its utilization. For example, →Liu, Zhang, and Zhang (2021) investigated teams with knowledge diversity which is known to enhance creativity teams. However, knowledge diversity, like many other types of diversity, can

contribute to in-group and out-relationships leading to friction between members (→Zheng and Wei 2018). They found that when team leaders used cognitive reappraisals to positively reframe diverse perspectives, their more positive appraisals affected the entire team's acceptance of diverse knowledge. This openness stimulated team creativity and the team's ability to coordinate their work.

Network structure also has a noteworthy impact on effective coordination. In particular, *structural holes* can present a barrier to effective communication between members. Structural holes are gaps between actors, or locations in networks where actors are not connected (→Burt 1992). While structural holes can create network environments ripe for innovation, they can create barriers to transmitting ideas and coordinating activities (→Zhao and Anand 2013). Another type of structural barrier to effective coordination are knowledge silos – clusters or actors who are connected to one another, but disconnected from the organization as a whole – because they hoard information that could facilitate interaction between individuals and groups in the organization (→Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt 2010). Solutions to these communication disconnects often involve *bridges*, *boundary spanners*, or *brokers* – individuals who can connect more than one social group, move between social groups or translate between social groups (→Granovetter 1973). These individuals provide the communicative link of knowledge or skills between individuals or groups who are otherwise not connected (→Long, Cunningham, and Braithwaite 2013).

1.2 Relationships and Coordination

Another lens to probe dyadic/workgroup/organizational coordination is a *relational view* which affirms the importance of relationships between individuals. As Sias and colleagues (→Sias 2008; →Sias and Shin 2019) affirm, interpersonal

relationships are interwoven into organizational processes. Many aspects of coordination are affected by relationships such as the relationships between peers, relationships between members of a cross-functional group, and members of leadership teams. Often, members may have little say about who they must work with in a team, but they may have at least some agency in choosing coordination partners (→Emirbayer and Mische 1998). They may opt to coordinate only with those with whom they have a positive relationship (→Cross and Cummings 2004), but they may choose to work with those with differing views and with whom they have a somewhat negative relationship believing they will derive more problem-solving benefits (→Brennecke 2020). Regardless of their degree of agency in choosing their team members, negotiation of relationships impacts the outcome of the coordination.

Relational coordination theory proposes that mutual respect, shared knowledge, and common goals enhance timely problem-solving to result in effective group functioning and coordination (→Bolton, Logan, and Gittell 2021; →Gittell 2006). Given the necessary interdependencies of members, trust developed through interpersonal relationships is foundational in their functioning and success (→Fairholm 1994; →Zolin et al. 2004). But, trust is especially difficult to develop when tasks are dangerous and when members have little shared history (→Myers and McPhee 2006) or professional experience as is often the case in cross-functional teams (→Bishop 1999). Usually, group members need time and opportunities to develop trust, but *swift trust* can be developed by sharing credentials, providing accounts of past work experience, and through other interpersonal exchanges (→Woo and Leonardi 2018; →Woo, Miller, and Lamsen 2020). Unfortunately, although workgroups can devote considerable time toward developing trusting relationships that generate positive outcomes, when one individual leaves the group, so

does the strength of their coordinating relationships (→Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt 2010).

Conflict and power struggles often affect relationships and members' ability to work together, but nuances of the relationship affect outcomes. For example, when conflicts occur between members who are friends, team performance suffers. Members may refuse to share the same space, communicate, or adjust their behavior to accomplish tasks with the other. However, when conflict occurs between members who are not friends, it can have a positive impact on the team's performance (→Hood, Cruz, and Bachrach 2017; →O'Neill and Mclarnon 2018) by causing them to compete with one another, either individually or with allies. Also, when members experience relational conflict, transactive memory systems within the group can be eroded, but when conflict is related to tasks, transactive memory can be enhanced (→Todorova 2021). Individuals also have an ability to upset coordination when a members' behavior is judged unacceptable to others. In leaderless teams, members often exert concertive control to exert pressure to perform. *Concertive control* is described as pressure from peers to compel a member to conform to the group's normative standards (→Barker 1993). Concertive control can be effective to achieve goals in the short-term, but over time it can erode peer relationships causing members to resist cooperation and to become ambivalent (→Larson and Tompkins 2005).

Open workspaces – offices mostly without interior walls and doors – have been adopted by many organizations to promote relational development by encouraging more spontaneous communication (→Pentland 2012), increasing innovation (→Congdon, Flynn, and Redman 2014), improving group cohesiveness (→Stryker and Santoro 2012), and achieving greater collaboration (→Fayard and Weeks 2007). Most investigations on open workspaces have examined the implications of closer proximity, but →Sivunen and Myers

(2022) argued that open workspaces can have a negative effect due to increased visibility. Their study in a company that recently moved from traditional office space to open workspaces revealed that many workers felt negatively exposed in open spaces. In some instances, it caused workers to *reduce* their spontaneous communication with others with negative implications for relationships and their ability to coordinate with coworkers.

Overall, structures of the workgroup and organization, and relationships within the collective affect coordination in various ways including by shaping knowledge sharing, expertise distribution, group cohesiveness, leadership, and member-to-member control. Several topics in dyadic/group/organizational-level research are significant for coordination now, but promise to become more significant in the future, they include increased diversity, globalization, and technology.

1.3 Diversity

With increased diversity in the workplace and minoritized members' quest for inclusion, workgroups promise to reflect increasing demographic, experiential, and knowledge diversity. Diversity enhances group performance due to increased sources and variety of information, but many groups struggle to benefit from increased information and member knowledge because diversity can also bring social categorization that reduces cohesion and performance (→Zheng and Wei 2018). Member cohesiveness tends to be lower and turnover higher in groups with more diversity (→van Knippenberg and Schippers 2007). Further, in groups with diversity of members, coordination and completion of tasks take more time (→Lau and Murnighan 1998), and members are less likely to share their knowledge within the group (→Iverson 2011).

Despite these challenges, workgroups reflecting diversity in their membership can operate more effectively, under the right conditions. Cultural diversity among team members can promote individual member and team-level creativity through information sharing and elaboration, especially when the team operates in a climate that promotes inclusion (→Li et al. 2017). Even though they may require a more significant commitment of time, diverse groups can develop higher-quality ideas in comparison to more homogenous groups (→Van Knippenberg and Schippers 2007). Importantly, with greater stakeholder diversity – including with customers and communities that many organizations serve – diversity of perspective can offer better solutions to serve an increasingly complex society.

Nevertheless, power struggles among group members continue to be a reality (→Alipour, Mohammed, and Raghuram 2018). Organizational and team leaders should lead by example offering individuals from minoritized groups opportunities to share perspectives and ideas. Leaders also are key in how they communicate informational diversity so that it is valued and utilized by members within the group including those from more dominant groups (→Liu, Zhang, and Zhang 2021). See Chapter 16 in this volume for more information on supervisor-employee communication.

1.4 Globalization

The effects of diversity are amplified when individuals and groups coordinate globally, with the added pressures of time, distance, and other factors challenging their ability to work together. Communication technologies including hardware and software, as well as access to physical facilities may not be not equally distributed globally. Equipment and facilities that some members take for granted are less reliable or come at a steep cost in other parts of the planet. Language and time

differences also can exacerbate communication barriers. Frequently, members from more powerful locations – especially in Western society – dictate locations and timing of meetings and the communication technologies used. English is the predominant language used in groups that span national boundaries (→Hinds, Neeley, and Cramton 2014), but the lack of English proficiency can affect individuals' ability to understand and participate in interactions (→Eisenberg, Glikson, and Lisak 2021). Finally, cultural norms and perspectives can affect understandings of an issue, who has the power to make decisions, and how coordination occurs. →Leonardi (2011) reported on cross-global teams in the automobile industry. Teams in India and Mexico perceived their reporting relationships and decision-making capacities differently, causing a breakdown in knowledge sharing, creating worker frustration and persistent engineering problems throughout the system.

1.5 Technology

Technology plays a central role in how people accomplish and coordinate their work with others; technology enables people to share and store information and knowledge, schedule meetings and working sessions, and most certainly communicate (→Walther 1996). Some of this research is not entirely new. For example, studies in the 1980s and 1990s discussed uses of *group decision support systems* (GDSS). New at the time, GDSS are technology systems that enable groups, rather than individuals within groups, to make decisions, which typically translates to a higher-quality outcome due to a better balance of power and diversity of perspective (→Liu et al. 2017; →Poole and DeSanctis 1992; →Watson, DeSanctis, and Poole 1988).

Currently, technology also provides workgroups and organizations with a means to collect, store, and retrieve

information to facilitate coordination. For example, *enterprise social media* work much like social media, but are used within an organization for posting information or posing questions to other members (→Leonardi 2013). Unlike directing questions to particular individuals, members of the organization can pose questions to others without knowing who knows the answer. Later, members can search the database for previously posted information. During the COVID-19 pandemic, individuals who worked remotely were unable to ask questions from colleagues who normally would be collocated. Instead, many relied on enterprise social media and other databases as information sources when it was impossible to ask a coworker at a neighboring desk (→Woo, Endacott, and Myers 2023).

Technology also enabled socialization and coordination of new organizational members during the pandemic when many worked from home and were unable to personally interact with coworkers. Human resource leaders overcame some of the barriers of remote socialization by organizing virtual trainings, producing training videos that could be viewed online, and hosting virtual social events to acquaint newcomers with tasks and coworkers (→Woo, Endacott, and Myers 2023). While newcomers developed task proficiency through these coordinated training efforts, their ability to get to know others and the culture of the organization was limited. This confirms research by →Claggett and Karahanna (2018) who argued that coordination that had traditionally relied on high-quality relationships is now changing as a result of interactions migrating to online platforms. See Chapter 24 of this volume for more on the history of the shift toward distributed collaboration, especially following the COVID-19 pandemic.

Technology also affects the coordination of collocated groups. Even before the COVID-19 pandemic, workgroups and teams that could meet face-to-face utilized technology to

communicate and coordinate their efforts because of the convenience it provided (→Straube et al. 2018). However, using mediated communication can affect performance based on communication intensity and the richness of the media. These effects are magnified by demographic *faultlines*, described as “hypothetical dividing lines that may split a group into subgroups based on one or more attributes” (→Lau and Murnighan 1998: 328). When faultlines are weak, members can compensate for lean communication channels by increasing intensity and vice versa. When faultlines are major, teams have difficulty making adjustments (→Straube et al. 2018).

Artificial intelligence offers opportunities for coordination because it can help solve problems, make decisions on behalf of individuals, and even “learn” over time to perform on behalf of humans (→Faraj, Pachidi, and Sayegh 2018). One increasingly popular AI tool is scheduling technology which reaches out to potential meeting partners to schedule a time to meet, thereby facilitating coordination. When AI schedulers work well, they alleviate the need for individuals to communicate back and forth to find a meeting time and place. AI technologies such as schedulers have important implications for how AI users are viewed by their communication partners. →Endacott (2021) found that use of AI can project an image as progressive and efficient; conversely, if the tool makes errors, it may project negative images of the user. Furthermore, some communication partners can feel under-valued when an AI scheduler is delegated the task of scheduling their meeting.

2 Interorganizational Coordination

Organizations often coordinate with other organizations to pool resources – including human resources, money, or material goods. Communication is most crucial among

members who represent diverse organizations when knowledge and expertise must be shared (→Barley, Treem, and Leonardi 2020). Large-scale problem-solving related to disasters, pandemics, economic disparities, and civil society development necessarily require coordination among multiple organizations. Such coordination often facilitates short- and long-term interorganizational collaborations (IOC) enabling organizations to tackle problems together in potentially cost-efficient, comprehensive ways (→Takahashi and Smutny 2002). Challenging these efforts are the meanings and values embedded in knowledge and practice, which make coordination between organizations in different sectors (different communities of practice) more complex. Merely sharing information does not necessarily lead to successful IOCs (→Woo, Miller, and Lamsen 2020). When a partnering organization's expertise is under-appreciated, coordination efforts are hindered or even collapse (→Woo and Paskewitz 2021).

As in most interactions, coordination at the interorganizational level is influenced by a variety of power and relational issues. Organizations with more social capital (member rated trust, mutual understanding, community warm circle, common values, mutual help, and "we feeling") are more adept at coordination among members (→Ansmann et al. 2020). Much like coordination efforts within organizations, social ties in IOCs influence members' intent to share information about task, equipment, interaction, and team processes (→Gross and Kluge 2012). Establishing authority is typically a first step in IOCs. →Koschmann and colleagues (2017) argue that authority is established not only through control and power, but is an emergent communicative and relational process. In humanitarian relief IOCs, smaller and newly established organizations have a harder time exerting authority (→Koschmann et al. 2017). Personal relationships are important for establishing

organizational authority, which means authority rankings may break down when one individual leaves (→Koschmann et al. 2017). Beyond authority, members of an IOC may perceive resources as scarce, resulting in self-interested, rather than community-interested behavior (→Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt 2010). This tension between cooperation and protection of resources is just one tension that IOCs must manage.

Interorganizational awareness, trust, and personal relationships significantly shape IOC in several ways. First, the ability for organizations to initiate coordination with others necessitates that the organizations are aware of one another (→Farley 2007). Second, effective coordination requires trust among partner organizations. For example, →Kapucu (2005) found that post-disaster response and recovery operations required trust between responding government agencies, public, and nonprofit sectors. Trust is increased by ongoing collaboration (→Kapucu 2005). Personal relationships born of trust further enable effective collaboration as these long-term relationships between members of different organizations allow communication to flow smoothly. However, the importance of personal relationships also means that when one member who served as a key point-person in collaboration leaves their organization, relations between organizations may break down (→Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt 2010). Such breakdowns make it difficult for organizations to reach beyond the limits of their close interorganizational network, impacting interorganizational awareness. Thus, interorganizational awareness, trust, and personal relationships are not only related to the efficacy of coordination efforts, but also to each other.

The ways members manage tensions can significantly impact the effectiveness of an interorganizational relationship. →Lewis, Isbell, and Koschmann (2010) identified two types of tensions in IOC: relationship tensions, which are the push-pull forces between internal and external concerns (including the

need to balance communal interests with organizational self-interest); and structural tensions, which concern the process of collaboration (including the need both to have rules and to avoid over-structuring the process, which can hinder participation). In response to tensions, participants may avoid, or simply stop participating in a collaboration. They may accept tensions as a necessary part of collaboration, or they may vacillate between the extreme poles of the tension (→Lewis, Isbell, and Koschmann 2010). →Woo's (2019) study reveals the value of tension management rather than avoidance of structural tensions. When organizations attempt to rigidly standardize processes to avoid tensions (and avoid conflict), they might be faster at making decisions and getting a job done, but the results are typically not as good. Woo uses a tensile metaphor to demonstrate their reliance (interdependence) on each other which strengthens them as a group. When conveners promote flexible structures to address tensions, they are more likely to capitalize on emerging opportunities. This promotes a "both-and" or "more than" solution (→Putnam, Fairhurst, and Banghart 2016).

2.1 Diversity

Organizations must also deal with whether and how diverse perspectives are included in decision-making. Coordination can involve organizations or members with dramatically different world views, priorities, procedures, and legal obligations – for example, a nonprofit agency and a law enforcement agency both working on human trafficking issues (→Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt 2010). Diversity in IOCs can be challenging as the quality of the IOC depends on members' willingness to work together and share resources (→Koschmann 2013). Yet diverse perspectives can enrich a collaborative's capacity to identify solutions and create change, and many IOCs seek to facilitate participatory

engagement. In community-based organizational collaboration, democratic participation is prioritized. Nevertheless, many organizations actively proclaim to foster participation, but communication often merely enables individuals to express their views rather than facilitate true integration of ideas and negotiation to include a variety of views in decision-making (→Deetz 2008).

To foster democratic participation in diverse organizations, →Milan and Heath (2014) found three requirements: first, time must be spent deliberating and contesting ideas; second, decision-making processes must be visible to all; and third, diverse ideas must truly be considered in the process, not merely heard and passed over. These processes may be aided by the emergence of a new collective identity within an IOC, which can help facilitate collaboration among a diverse group of otherwise self-interested members (→Koschmann 2013). One means of bringing together representatives of multiple organizations is through appreciative inquiry which promotes communication among members toward recognizing organizational strengths. However, as →Woo and Paskewitz (2021) found, when organizations have not previously developed a relationship of working together, individual members' communication needs must be satisfied. Representatives must be given time to share information and develop enthusiasm for working together.

2.2 Globalization

An area for continued and increased research is on interorganizational coordination during national and international tragedies. In a globalized world – and one facing increasingly frequent natural disasters as a result of the climate crisis – the exigencies demanding interorganizational coordination have increased, and so too have the challenges. "Wicked problems" (→Rittel and Webber 1973) such as climate

change, pandemics, diminishing democracy, and global pandemic require coordination to achieve solutions. While organizational collaborations bring considerable resources and the attention of many to an issue, their challenges are also magnified. For example, often organizations view the issue, problem, or opportunity in slightly different ways and have differing views about strategies to reach objectives (→Woo 2019). Given their cultural differences and that they typically work in different environments and with different assumptions, the process IOC members use for approaching and addressing the issue vary (→Milam and Heath 2014). Of course, the various organizational leaders may disagree about who is to lead the interorganizational effort. Organizations and their various stakeholders must not only develop trust, but do so within cultural paradoxes and differences (→Levitt 2019).

Globalization has also given rise to international organizations such as the United Nations that aim to address complex, interdependent social problems. Such problems cannot be addressed by a single entity alone, but efforts to increase coordination at one level often conflict with coordination across levels, resulting in trade-offs between inter-agency and intra-agency coordination (→Egeberg and Trondal 2016). →Mele and Cappellaro (2018) suggest that this incompatibility can be resolved through the coordination practices of “systemic thinking” and “jointly mobilizing resources and consensus”. These practices, they found, gave rise to new information flows, areas of competence, and development of mutual knowledge that enabled both inter- and intra-agency coordination. In large, multinational collaborations, language use must be negotiated with an awareness and appreciation for cultural differences (→Nielsen 2020).

2.3 Technology

Increased technology has created myriad opportunities for interorganizational coordination on pressing issues. For example, new technologies enable increased coordination among IOCs working on human trafficking prevention. Such IOCs take advantage of technologies including personalized databases, online search tools, and specialty software systems (→Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt 2010). However, technology does not solve all problems. Organizations working on human trafficking issues reported that available technology was insufficient to meet the needs of increasingly complex coordination (→Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt 2010). Furthermore, as is the case with members working within globalized firms, organizations may have asymmetrical access to technology; this is especially true for nonprofits working with high-risk vulnerable populations like human trafficking victims and for IOCs involving partners in less developed regions. Members must be aware not only of whom they must contact, but also the best way to reach that person (for example, using social media rather than email). Technology can be an important element of IOCs when resource disparity does not enable organizational members to fully participate. Organizations without resources to acquire and use advanced communication technology have less ability to participate in IOCs.

Technological asymmetries are compounded by power asymmetries that often lead to resource control. →Stoll, Edwards, and Mynatt (2010) found that some nonprofit organizations were unwilling to devote resources to technological infrastructure that would support coordination because such resources were perceived as “strategic” rather than geared toward directly meeting the needs of clients. Such perceptions and practices further hobble organizations and their ability to partner in IOCs.

3 Conclusion and Future Directions

Coordination (cooperation and collaboration) within and among organizations endures as a significant area of research for organizational communication. In an increasingly complex society and as organizations continue to increase in power and size, their ability to operate across cultures and national boundaries through the use of technology appears limitless, but it may be bounded by human ability and motivations to coordinate.

Changes in context and technology introduce new issues that require future investigation. First, physical proximity is known to encourage more spontaneous coworker communication (→Pentland 2012), but as the world emerges from the COVID-19 pandemic, what are the implications for coordination when some members have returned to the office and others work remotely all or a portion of the time? Second, a challenge that continues to stymie group coordination is the increasing number of communication channels that members utilize to communicate for different purposes. With the availability of many communication channels, members often lack clarity about which channels to use and monitor. For example, many workgroups use instant messaging such as Google Chat, others prefer applications such as Slack, but some members and workgroups continue to rely on email or even the telephone. Finally, even when workgroups generally agree on the communication channels, individuals' differing usage, monitoring habits, and response times can hinder smooth coordination. These differences can be related to industry norms, generational differences such as younger generations' dislike for email and telephone (→Schwantes 2021) or individual work habits such as the reliance on personal devices or email checking frequency. When membership is often unstable (and increasingly so in recent

years), can best practices be identified and implemented that minimize these growing coordination issues?

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Chapter 13 Stakeholders and Organizational Change

Laurie Lewis

Surabhi Sahay

Abstract

Change inevitably alters the relationships among an organization's stakeholders and the stakes they hold. During a period of organizational change, stakeholders often reappraise their own stakes and assess the degree to which those stakes are at risk. There is both a possibility of stakes being diminished and opportunities for new stakes to be claimed. There are a variety of roles that stakeholders may play during a change process. Communication research can help to identify the processes by which stakeholders of various types are identified and the various communication tactics they employ in order to facilitate, shape, and/or derail change. This chapter provides a review of the major areas of stakeholder change scholarship and develops a critique and directions for future research.

Keywords: frames, information sharing, models (of change), motors (of change), participation, resistance, roles (in change), soliciting input, stakes (in change), stakeholders, uncertainty,

Organizational change is described as a disruptive period or an altered state which paves the way for new practices, objects, or ways of doing things (→Lewis 2019). Change inevitably alters the relationships among the organization's stakeholders and the stakes they hold. As →Lewis (2021a: 250) suggests:

> Whenever organizations move through change processes, individuals and groups may perceive threats and opportunities related to their stakes. A stake in an organization may take any number of forms, including finances, information access, goods/services, reputation, relationships, environmental conditions, and other resources [...] When an organization changes in some significant way, stakes are invoked and often are cast into uncertainty. Organizational change can also result in the creation of new stakes, new stakeholders, alteration of stakeholder relationships, and shifting importance of stakes.

Although stakeholders may hold negative, ambivalent, or positive views of any particular change, those in favor of change as well as proponents of change often present it as a way for organizations to stay current, gain competitive advantage, and adapt to the demands of the environment. As we wrote in 2019:

> Change is necessary to advance innovation, address injustices, remedy failing or poor practices, revitalize the energy of participants, maintain competitiveness, create variety, experiment, and adapt to environments. Without change, organizations would eventually fail to adapt to their changing environments, stakeholders, and participants and would at some point become so mismatched with the demands made on them that they would likely become obsolete. (→Lewis and Sahay 2018: 127)

Scholars broadly categorize change as either planned versus unplanned or as episodic versus continuous. They also attribute the initiation of change to a number of internal and external causes (→Poole and Van de Ven 2021). Internal causes may include strategic or structural changes in the organization, such as reorganization or downsizing, whereas external causes may be introduced due to competition and a changing industry, among other factors. Change is prompted by a wide variety of factors, with communication triggers sometimes playing a major role. Social pressures may mount on organizations and their leaders when organizational players tend to identify and realize the need for change by assessing their environment. →Zorn, Christensen, and Cheney

(1999) discuss that many organizations adopt a change simply because they feel pressure into doing so, often overlooking the fit between the organization and the planned change effort. Unplanned change caused by environmental factors such as natural disasters (e.g., hurricanes), pandemics (e.g., COVID-19), or mandatory policy changes (e.g., electronic health record systems) can also pressure the organization to adopt specific policies, often in a limited amount of time. For instance, →Sahay and Dwyer (2021) found that COVID-19 forced frontline nurses to improvise due to dearth of resources, mounting death toll, and uncertainty around the disease. Over time, some of these practices were retained and institutionalized by the organization in a planned fashion.

1 Change Models

Change scholars focus on both the content of the change and how change is implemented in organizations (see →Table 1). The mapping of organizational change processes dates back at least to the 1940s, which marked one of the earliest attempts to describe different change implementation styles. In 1948, Kurt Lewin proposed a three-phase model of change (unfreezing, changing, refreezing). John →Kotter's (1996) prescriptive model included an eight-step model specifying steps to create urgency; form guiding coalition; establish vision; communicate; develop change plans; create short-term wins; consolidate; and institutionalize change.

Table 1: Models of Change Management on How Change Process Is Conducted and Studied.

Model	Description	Role of communication
Three phasal model of change (→Lewin 1948)	Linear model of unfreezing (i.e., identifying and preparing organization to change), changing (i.e., implementing the change), and refreezing (i.e., stabilizing the organization when involved parties have embraced the change).	Communication is used to prepare the organization for change, convince the employees of the benefit of change, provide clear instructions and details, and manage the change through rewards and control.
Eight-step model (→Kotter 1996)	Discusses organizational challenges and suggests eight steps for successful change management: create sense of urgency, create a guiding coalition, develop a vision and strategies, communicate the vision, remove barriers to actions, accomplish wins, build on the change, and institute the change.	Communication is an essential part of each step, from conveying urgency to articulating the newly adopted behaviors.
Adaptive versus programmed approach (→Roberts-Gray and Gray 1983)	Adaptive approach sought to modify the change to easily assimilate into everyday practices, whereas, the programmed approach focuses on changing the users to make them capable of using the innovation.	Adaptive approach calls for active participation from involved parties to modify the change-related strategies or adapt the change, whereas, programmed approach uses communication to make the impact of the change more tolerable/acceptable, without modifying the change.
Diffusion of innovation (→Rogers 1995)	Initiating stage (i.e., agenda setting and matching) and implementation stage (i.e., reinvention, clarification, and routinization).	Both the stages focus on the importance of framing, persuasion, and selecting the appropriate communication channels.
Change motors for	Life cycle (i.e., depicts change processes as	Each motor has a distinct way of looking at

Model	Description	Role of communication
understanding and studying change (→Van de Ven and Poole 1995, →2021)	progressing through necessary phases dictated by institutional, natural, or logical causes), teleological (i.e., intentional goal formation, implementation, and modification of behaviors, which is closest to how planned change initiatives are currently studied), dialectical (i.e., accounts for conflicts and opposing forces through which change emerges), and evolutionary motors (i.e., repetitive sequences of variation, selection, and retention, describing how change is driven by competition for scarce resources).	communication and organizing: Life cycle: communication ideals here are embedded in institutional logic. Teleological: communication is based on achieving change goals and creating consensus. Dialectical: communication and organizations are rift with power struggles and opposing forces, mostly geared toward maintaining status quo and also challenging the dominant perspectives. Evolutionary: communication is a key part of variation, selection, and retention, where ideas emerge by chance, which are then selected through competition, and the right fit for the environment is adopted. These choices may be further retained by the organization through inertia and persistence. Furthermore, communication may also be altered in this process.
Stakeholder model of change communication (→Lewis 2011)	Unpacks the complex and dynamic context of change and aids in uncovering the multiple layers of stakeholder claims and how they are negotiated as the stakes change.	This model is centered on communication and communicative choices made by implementers and other stakeholders during the process of change implementation, thus perceiving implementation

Model	Description	Role of communication
		as inherently communicative in nature.

Since then there have been myriad efforts to theorize and describe processes of organizational change. For instance, →Roberts-Gray and Gray (1983) discussed the difference between the adaptive and the programmed approaches to change, where the adaptive approach sought to modify the change or the innovation so that it could be easily assimilated into everyday practices of the stakeholders. On the other hand, the programmed approach focused on changing the users to make them capable of using the innovation and committing to it. Essentially, these users were then accommodating the change at hand. Over time, other prominent scholars started to refine these ideas as they paid closer attention to the different phases of the change process. For instance, →Rogers (1995) viewed the change management process in two distinct phases consisting of the initiating stage, which included agenda setting and matching, and the implementation stage that involved reinvention, clarification, and routinization.

As the scholarship about organizational change processes has evolved over time, theoretical explanations have become more prolific, varied, and sophisticated. →Van de Ven and Poole (1995, →2021) describe change through four change motors that shed light on the different approaches to the change process, namely, life cycle, teleological, dialectical, and evolutionary motors. These models differ in terms of the unit of change (i.e., actions of a single entity or multiple entities) and whether the sequence of events is prescribed, a priori, or emerges as the change process unfolds (→Van de Ven and Poole 2021). The life cycle motor closely depicts change processes as progressing through necessary phases dictated by institutional, natural, or logical causes. The teleological

model pays close attention to intentional goal formation, implementation, and modification of behaviors, which is closest to how planned change initiatives are currently studied. The dialectical motor, as the name suggests, accounts for conflicts and opposing forces through which change emerges. And lastly, the evolutionary model consists of repetitive sequences of variation, selection, and retention, describing how change is driven by competition for scarce resources.

→Lewis (2011, →2019, →2021a) developed the stakeholder model of change communication, which helped unpack the complex and dynamic context of change and aided in uncovering the multiple layers of stakeholder claims and how they are negotiated as the stakes change. She embraced the dynamic nature of stakeholder relationships by employing stakeholder theory. The concept of stakeholders was first explored by →Freeman (1984), who saw stakeholders as important constituents of the organization without whose support the organization would perish. The initial applications of the stakeholder perspective suffered from static categorization of stakeholder groups that relied heavily on the standpoint of the focal organization.

Lewis' work (→2011, →2019) highlighted the relationship between the focal organization and its stakeholders, and shed light not only on the formal communication that occurred between stakeholders and their organizations, but importantly, the communication and negotiations (both formal and informal) that occurred among stakeholder groups. Her initial argument suggested that stakeholders were active agents in changing the environment and played multiple roles and assumed different identities within each context, making communication and relationships quite complex.

Sometimes, organizations may even involve non-managerial employees to drive their change efforts, which is

often targeted at developing corporate entrepreneurship and citizenry (→Chebbi et al. 2020). While these efforts are conducted to foster employee engagement and innovation, they can change the relational dynamics within an organization. Management has to proactively communicate through briefings and meetings to successfully manage these initiatives.

2 Stakeholders

We can think of stakes and stakeholders as individuals/groups/organizations. This is a very typical way that stakeholders have been portrayed in the change literature over time. However, more scholars are examining stakes and claiming the negotiations of stakes to be a fluid and multi-directional process (→Lewis 2021a). Understanding how stakeholders influence each other and form coalitions and rivalries is a necessary component of full exploration of any particular stakeholder network. →Mitchell, Agle, and Wood (1997) have noted that stakeholders who form alliances may increase the chances of the focal organization's compliance. For example, unions often seek community support or the endorsement by powerful political office-holders in order to put pressure on organizations during contract negotiations. Some scholars have started to explore the ways in which stakeholders not only recognize one another, but also assess the degree to which their stakes are competitive or complementary (→Hendry 2005; →Lewis 2019, →2021a; →Post, Preston, and Sachs 2002). And, of course, this can become even more complex as we consider how changes in the organizations involved can alter the maps of stakes and stakeholders. This is an important direction for future communication scholarship. Research that explores the ways in which stakeholders discover and assess each other's stakes, negotiate their relationships related to a particular change

effort, and perhaps coordinate their responses and actions taken will move our theorizing forward.

There are a variety of roles that stakeholders may play during a change process. Four potentially important roles critical to the change process include: opinion leaders, connectors, counselors, and journalists (→Lewis 2011, →2019). Opinion leaders, as the name suggests, are stakeholders who can influence others. The role of opinion leadership is studied widely by management scholars who tend to characterize these leaders as change champions (→Stouten, Rousseau, and De Cremer 2018). As suggested by →Warrick (2009), organizations should develop and train change champions at all levels of the organization and not only those in the management for successful implementation of an organizational change. Change champions can help develop a change-related mindset and facilitate activities to support the change process. Even psychology researchers have hypothesized and found opinion leaders to promote more positive attitudes toward new initiatives. However, cultivating change champions is an activity that takes time and resources and recent literature also suggests that opinion leaders may end up curbing stakeholder voices due to their commitment toward the change, thus creating a closed organizational climate (→Sahay 2017). Communication research can help to identify the processes by which change champions are created, encouraged, and/or identified and the various communication tactics they employ in order to facilitate change. Further, investigation of how change champions confront resistance efforts and interact with those whose goals are to undermine change efforts will add to our explanations of change failures.

Connectors help bridge the gap between different stakeholder groups. Connectors tend to play a key role in networks, and research around use of connectors spans different types of planned change initiatives from health

interventions (→Wallace et al. 2021) to creation of counter-terrorism activities (→Spalek 2014). →Meyer (2006) has argued that middle managers are often derided as “foot-draggers” during change. However, her empirical work has illustrated how middle management can play both destructive and constructive roles in change depending how the interests of middle manager sub-groups are aligned. Similarly, →Thomas, Sargent, and Hardy (2011) discuss how senior management creates discursive templates to frame change initiatives, which are often resisted by middle managers or connectors who are charged with conveying, interpreting, and implementing the change on the ground level.

Journalists gather and share information and offer their own interpretations of events. These individuals play a major role in framing what the change is and how it works. Scholars have documented the dramatic effects that social sensemaking may have on how a change is understood (→Bird 2007; →Leonardi 2009). Our current scholarship has paid more attention to those on the receiving end of “news” about a change and the resultant impact on their uncertainty and concerns. We have a good deal of opportunity to discover how “news” is spread and agendas are set for conversations about change efforts. Communication scholars ought to investigate the intentions, tactics, and motivations of those who take on this journalistic role. Change scholarship has long noted the deleterious impacts of rumors and gossip during change, but has rarely examined this type of communication as strategic effort to undermine change, alter the course of a particular change, or lead decision-makers or other stakeholders to specific conclusions about a change.

And lastly, counselors provide social and material support to others. For instance, there is wide literature around toxin handlers – individuals who invest time in listening to their coworkers and other employees to help resolve their problems. Individuals who play this role in organizations are

known to reduce organizational pain and toxicity through empathetic listening, suggesting solutions to current or lingering problems, developing a trusting relationship with those who confide in them, helping employees participate in sensemaking, and reframing complicated and difficult messages (→Frost 2004). In the context of organizational change, socially supportive actions and messages can ease the difficulty of a change process, help individuals to bond around mutual concerns and stressors, and facilitate instrumental and informational support (→Ashford 1988; →Lewis 2019). However, some evidence has found that socially supportive communication may at times impede adjustment to change and cause individuals to feel less competent (→Barrett and Stephens 2017). Moreover, expectation of social support may cause undue stress to those who are expected to provide support, thus hurting their mental wellbeing. There is an abundance of opportunity for communication scholars to shed light on the role of emotion and emotional labor during organizational change. Major organizational change (or even modest change that brings significant implications for some individuals) may increase worry, self-doubt, insecurity, hidden concerns, as well as the need to portray oneself as fully on board with a change that is disliked. These burdens and the ways in which they are communicatively managed is an area in need of elaboration.

3 Uncertainty and Participation

Scholars have continually noted that uncertainty runs high for most stakeholders during change. Stakeholders who have not been involved in problem analysis nor solution evaluation rarely have a very complete understanding of how a change process came about, nor what impacts it is supposed to have. Uncertainties about the organization’s future, its strategic directions, and the impacts of changes to individuals’ statuses

in the organization are among those that create negative impacts. During a period of organizational change, stakeholders often reappraise their own stakes and assess the degree to which those stakes are at risk (→Lewis 2021a).

There is both a possibility of stakes being diminished and opportunities for new stakes to be claimed. These individual consequences and personal impact are always accompanied with uncertainty (→Schulz-Knappe, Koch, and Beckert 2019). For, instance →Wainwright et al. (2019) found that there was a high degree of uncertainty among both management and employees regarding the feasibility of increasing working life age limit and how this new extension would be managed. Thus, uncertainty about the direction, purpose, and focus of a change is quite concerning.

A typical remedy proposed in scholarly and practitioner literature alike is for implementers to provide information and seek participation in decision-making from their stakeholders to reduce uncertainty (→Bordia et al. 2004). For instance, →Schulz-Knappe, Koch, and Beckert (2019) found that transparent communication and employee involvement were essential for developing a more positive attitude toward the change. Although research around uncertainty typically states that it occurs due to inadequate information or conflicting interpretations, other researchers have pointed out that information sharing is not always the ideal way to reduce uncertainty (→Kramer, Dougherty, and Pierce 2004). →Kramer, Dougherty, and Pierce (2004) provide an example of the complexity of information dissemination during change in their study of an airline acquisition. Their study illustrates that for many stakeholders during change, increased appropriation of information can add to, rather than reduce, uncertainty. These authors found that the pilots' value of official sources of information increased over time, while their value of information from union officials and media outlets decreased over time. They also found that the ways in which

stakeholders relied upon each other for information, peer support, and uncertainty reduction varied considerably. For example, these authors found that high information seekers (71% of respondents) actively sought more information in an attempt to manage their uncertainty. However, low information seekers (29% of respondents) tended to use internal techniques (passively allowing information to come to them; dismissing value of/reliability of any existing information) to manage uncertainty instead of seeking new information. In fact, sometimes social interaction and sharing information around uncertainty collectively can transfer the worries from one person to another. →Sahay and Dwyer (2022) in their research in a community that was undergoing change found that as individuals shared more information about the change, they felt more uncertain and anxious, which incentivized them to form a stronger movement against the change. Therefore, uncertainty can also yield positive unintended consequences.

Managers and implementers develop and provide frames to stakeholders which helps with interpretation of the change and the change process. As →Fairhurst (1993) suggests, framing helps highlight certain aspects of the change and also helps de-emphasize other information. It is a critical process that helps management become more effective and successful. This literature has since discussed the importance of more holistic interactional frames, where managers are not the only ones framing change-related information (→Dewulf et al. 2009). Other stakeholders too collectively come together and use interactional frames for sensemaking and sensegiving during change (→Dewulf et al. 2009; →Sahay and Dwyer 2021). For instance, Sahay and Dwyer in their research with nurses caring for COVID-19 patients found that as nurses interacted with the new protocols and expectations imposed by the pandemic, they collectively participated in sensemaking that helped improvise both the type of communication they

were having with others as well as the task, relational and cognitive modifications necessary to meet the demands of the everchanging situation.

Implementers also sometimes solicit input from stakeholders during the change process. Soliciting input is a general strategy often employed to increase involvement and understanding, and garner approval for change. The traditional perspective around change management participation suggests that it helps reduce resistance and uncertainty and enhances commitment toward the change (→Bordia et al. 2004; →Ford and Ford 1995). →Lewis (2019) argues that participation itself may be of varied types, including direct or indirect/representative, voluntary or involuntary, and formal or informal. Specific design issues for gathering input include timing, setting, anonymous access, choice of facilitator, and previous attempts at solicitation, to name a few.

→Sahay's (2017) study of a change process in a metropolitan hospital found that the specific design of input solicitation is highly consequential. Sahay found that nurses often felt left out and skeptical about how individuals were selected to provide input. Nurses were also reluctant to provide input after zealous announcements that celebrated the change initiative. Invitations to provide input in the context of a rally-like gathering about the change presents perceived risks, including stepping on the message and enthusiasm of implementers, opinion leaders, and organizational leaders. In another study, →Sahay (2021) found that the perspectives around listening through input solicitation differed for senior level executives as compared to non-managerial employees. The study found that stakeholders are aware of input solicitation initiatives that are authentic versus inauthentic. Inauthentic listening may occur due to change-related restrictions, confined process of solicitation, and sparse analysis and presentation of input. In

summary, inauthentic listening actually has negative consequences for the organizations and those providing input in the organization. Therefore, participation must be well planned and structured for the stakeholders to trust it. Communication research can help us to understand better how various stakeholders perceive the context for providing input and the degree to which it is understood to be benevolent or risky. Further, there is much opportunity for researchers to explore what triggers stakeholders to be motivated to provide their input (especially when that input may be perceived as critical of management).

Barge and colleagues (2008) collected data on a multistakeholder initiative and called attention to the conflict faced by implementers when including different stakeholders in different phases of the change because who got invited to the table and at which phase was critical for the organization. Later work (→Lewis 2019; →Lewis and Russ 2012) detailed the ways in which input solicitation can be more or less sincere (e.g., use of a resource or symbolic approach) and how that may influence the degree and nature of stakeholders' participation. Through the lens of a stakeholder perspective, we can view these design issues as predictors of stakeholders' willingness to name, claim, and assert stakes. Where stakes are highly relevant, but the circumstances of input solicitation are perceived as risky or insincere, stakeholders may be tentative about asserting their stakes. On the other hand, in contexts where many stakeholders are raising and asserting stakes, and there is an absence of negative repercussions, that may promote additional stakeholders to participate and assertively claim stakes. As suggested by →Fairhurst, Cooren, and Cahill (2002), contradictions are a key part of organizational change initiatives, where individuals and groups negotiate and navigate their ideals about participation. However, these actions and interactions can have unintended consequences for those involved and the

organization (→Fairhurst, Cooren, and Cahill 2002; →Jian 2007).

4 Resistance to Change

Implemented change impacts stakeholders' attitudes, as stakeholders actively interact with the process (→Lewis 2021a; →Sahay 2017). When discussing employee reactions to change, management literature focuses on two broad aspects of stakeholder perspectives, including commitment or resistance to change (→Visagie and Steyn 2011). In general, resistance to change is perceived with a negative valence, with resistors often viewed as being irrational, skeptical, problematic, or individuals who are simply unable to adapt. "Much of the research on organizational change over the years has largely adopted and reproduced an ideology of change as an unquestioned good" (→Zorn and Scott 2021: 766) and resistance as a natural anxiety-based response to it. Too often, change scholarship has asked the question, how should we stop or limit resistance to change while ignoring the alternative question, how can bad change be effectively quashed? Further, our scholarship on resistance too often comingles resistance to changes, change processes, and change outcomes (→Zorn and Scott 2021).

Communication literature on resistance also suggests that resistance is in fact a taken-for-granted consequence of the power dynamics that exist in any organization or within different types of organizing (Mumby et al. 2017). However, these theorists caution us against over-simplifying resistance (→Deetz 2008). Usually, resistance is analyzed from a victim (non-decision-maker stakeholder) versus perpetrator (e.g., management) perspective. During change events, stakeholders react to change processes and may actively negotiate these power dynamics. →Lewis (2019) presents a continuum on which different forms of change-related

resistance may be situated from more subtle forms of resistance to more forceful forms. For instance, subtle forms may include merely asking questions, while more forceful forms include boycotts and protests. An interesting area for future scholarship will be to identify the decision-making of change resistors as they consider how to object to change. Some will stop with simple complaints to peers and family/friends, others will take their concerns to supervisors or general management, still others progress to more forceful forms of protest or sabotage. We know very little about what drives some to take more forceful action while others remain nearly silent.

The implementer role is often constructed as concerned with quelling resistance to the change effort. Their efforts are focused on compelling cooperation, convincing reluctant stakeholders to go along with change, discrediting attacks on the change, and/or coercing objectors into silence or acceptable levels of cooperativeness (→Sahay 2017). →Armenakis, Harris, and Mossholder (1993) examined the importance of convincing the stakeholders about the necessity of the change in order to gain commitment toward it. According to these authors, in order to prepare an organization for the impending change, an organization must convince the stakeholders that (a) the change is necessary for the organization, (b) this change appropriately fills the gap, (c) the organization has the capability of implementing the specific change, (d) that leaders champion the change, and (e) that the change will positively impact stakeholders. While these strategies are geared at controlling resistance, the very same strategies can be applied to planning resistance movements. For example, resistors may work to establish the need for resistance, justify the appropriateness of the resistance approach, discuss employees' capability of implementing these efforts, find support in senior leadership to resist change, and develop an understanding of how these

efforts will have value to stakeholders. It is important to note that these resistance efforts can also range from being fully planned to completely spontaneous.

As scholars and practitioners alike struggle with how resistance should be recognized, its causes, and the remedy for it (if remedy is even appropriate), we have increasingly recognized that explanations of psychological flaws (e.g., irrational fear of change) in the stakeholder-resistor are likely short-sighted or completely inaccurate (→Dent and Powley 2002; →Zorn and Scott 2021). Scholarship in the field has often focused too much on the diagnosis of resistance and resistors from a lens of personality dysfunction. Mantras of 'everyone hates change' and other similar sentiments easily act to diminish reports of negative impacts of a change, change process, or multiple and layered change processes.

When managers and implementers tend to blame personality or widespread panic for resistance to change, principled perspectives of stakeholders who value their organizations are ignored. Further, stakeholders' beliefs and observations about flaws in the change can be overlooked, left unexplored, and may ultimately lead to change failure (→Lewis 2021b). As →Zorn and Scott (2021) argue, "[Stakeholders] resist change because they hold a view that something about the change itself, the means of change, or the likely outcomes are problematic" (p. 769). When major organizational change brings with it high-risk investment, senior leader expectations, and public scrutiny among other pressures, implementers and other "middle layers" of the organization may be subject to coercion to bring good news, squash any sign of resistance (no matter its source or cause) and this can result in self-censorship and upward distortion that leaves the organization vulnerable to serious failures (→Lewis 2021b). Said differently, listening to resistance/resistors may be a failsafe that will draw "attention to aspects of change that may be inappropriate, not well

thought through, or perhaps plain wrong" (→Waddell and Sohal 1998: 545). Communication scholars are well positioned to unpack the organizational characteristics that make it more or less likely for honest, open, communication about a struggling or ill-designed change to surface to the top.

5 Critique of Current Approaches to Organizational Change

Although organizational change has been examined from a variety of perspectives and has certainly become quite rich and insightful over time, there are still weaknesses and biases that need to be addressed. "One striking observation is how much the change scholarship tends to be defined by management-centric models. Approaches [...] are nearly always grounded in a perspective of managers and owners of organizations and the ways in which *success* is defined for them" (→Lewis 2014: 517). While the stakes of managers/owners/senior leadership are typically the baseline for judging outcomes of change processes, the risks to stakes of other stakeholders are often ignored or treated as potential obstacles.

Management-oriented treatment of organizational change processes, and search for causes and prevention of reluctance to accept change often portrays a false dichotomy between commitment and resistance. Scholars have at times sought only to define success in terms of full or near full compliance with original plans of senior leaders and implementers eschewing nuanced consideration of varied use, novel use, improvements on original ideas. Further, consideration of how and when a successful resistance to flawed change might be a beneficial outcome is extremely rare in the change literature.

Another vulnerability in change scholarship relates to the lack of attention to the fundamental nature of the activity. It is ironic that change experts (scholars and practitioners alike)

often fail to treat change processes as a fluid and dynamic undertaking. Although there is frequently an application of language implying dynamic process, the ways in which we examine change and sometimes the ways we theorize about it take on a static cast. We overly focus on change as discrete events and under-explore ongoing change and the cumulative effects of multiple changes that intersect in different ways at various points along a continuum. Since the early 2000s scholars in management and communication fields have further studied the perspectives of change stakeholders about their experiences and the ways in which they create accounts of change processes. Much of this scholarship tends to be accomplished through interviews with employees about stories and sensemaking about change in a moment in time. Although there have been calls for the study of communication as it unfolds in real time and in natural interaction, this shift has not yet been fully realized in published research. Although collecting real-time interaction data raises some serious methodological challenges, the only way that researchers can discover and describe how interaction works in these processes is to capture communication data in the moment.

Given in part due to the case-study methodology or large organization focus of our change scholarship, too much of our research has ignored detailed description and exploration of individuals as they are actors in change. We have spent considerably less energy explaining the ways in which individuals understand, interact with/about change, and how change/changes impact their organizational lives than we have spent trying to explain the success/failure of whole organizations during change. Underdeveloped topics include change narratives, story-telling, sense-making/giving as well as the lived experience of individual stakeholders whose stakes are under significant, ongoing negotiation as the organizations around them. We have especially neglected

experiences of stakeholders who are neither managers nor employees of organizations undergoing change. Perspectives of clients, customers, partners, suppliers, or of other organizations whose business or operations are implicated by neighboring organizations' changes are rarely examined in detail. Further, when we do explore the vantage point of such stakeholders, we typically view them as recipients of a change process brought about by others. We have largely ignored how these types of stakeholders spur change; advocate for their own stakes to prompt alteration of organizational practices; or innovate in their own relationships with organizations to ensure that their stakes are advanced.

6 Future Directions

The landscape of scholarship about organizational change and the roles communication plays in prompting, moving forward, altering, and rejecting it is quite robust. As even this brief overview of this field of literature has illustrated, there are many directions research and theory building on change may take. Communication scholars have much to add to the understanding of how, in what ways, and with what consequences organizations change or resist changing. There are some distinct opportunities for scholars in the communication discipline which are briefly outlined here.

It is perhaps an old refrain in the organizational field that we need to expand the types of contexts in which we do our work. Too often our work has restricted focus to large for-profit businesses and failed to look to a wider range of size, industry, and sector as we seek empirical evidence related to our topic of focus. The organizational change research base has by-and-large been overly produced in for-profit business settings. Although one can find research exemplars in schools and universities, and some nonprofits and governmental settings, these contexts do not get the attention needed to

build a robust understanding of the social dynamics surrounding change and change implementation. To fully understand how stakeholders engage through a change process, a diverse set of stakeholders should be considered. Nonprofits and governments have extensive sets of diverse stakeholders who often claim stakes in ways that are less common in for-profit businesses. They may also be much more likely to affiliate, negotiate, and form alliances and/or rivalries throughout a change process in an organization in which they are stakeholders. This may make them ideal contexts to study change questions related to complex messaging, and the claiming of stakes during change.

Further, small businesses of less than 500 employees may seem an odd choice to study the complexity of change. However, there are far more small and medium enterprises (SMEs) and nonprofits than large ones (both in the United States and globally) and it seems odd that we know so little about how these organizations change (→National Action Plans on Business and Human Rights n.d.). Small businesses make up 99% of US businesses and employ a large segment of US employees (Semrush.com). That said, small businesses have a high failure rate and often struggle to make the necessary adaptations to survive in changing environments.

Opportunities to expand what we know about organizational change processes in the SME context is vast. Small businesses and nonprofits cannot rely on the same sorts of internal structures, specialist experts, and capital that larger organizations do, so how do they decide how to change under those circumstances? Are they more participatory in decision-making? Are they closer to their stakeholder groups and more inclusive in gathering and using input? Do the millions of women-owned SMEs take different approaches to organizational change than those run by men or larger organizations that tend to have male-dominated leadership? Do family-owned SME manage change and change

communication in unique ways? Much can be learned from examining changes related to leadership succession, strategic planning, culture shifts, updating of techniques/products/services, and adjustment to regulatory encroachment on traditions among many others. Also, we can ask if many of the traditional problems facing SMEs – lack of financing, difficulties in exploiting technology, constrained managerial capabilities, low productivity, regulatory burdens – spur innovation and change or do they drive SMEs to be more conservative in their approach to change?

In another area of this sub-field we can certainly gain from deepening our understanding of effective means to defeat/redirect/derail change. Our focus on resistance thus far is dominated by efforts to reduce it. That effort, biased by our managerial orientation to change, has greatly limited our attention to the tools, methods, processes used to actively oppose organizational change. While there are certainly relevant pockets of literature on dissent communication (cf. →Garner and Wargo 2009; →Graham 1986) in the context of change, these are distinct from examination of organic or strategic organized efforts to thwart a change process or redirect it to some alternative path/goal. Even when change management scholars focus on resistance, there is an assumption that it is a reactive and disorganized response to change (→Lewis and Sahay 2018) and is typically attributed to anxiety or emotional reactionary responses to upcoming change.

Our opportunity here is to focus on efforts to counter or redirect a rumored change, or to garner support of powerful allies to completely derail a change that is expected by some to produce negative outcomes for at least some stakeholders. Our scholarship might explore the ways in which these counter campaigns are started, waged, and won (or lost). Findings of this work might find a very practical audience of employee unions, neighborhood associations, advocacy

groups, among others. Also, we tend to focus on these overt examples of resistance, but we should also focus on the micro-conflicts and more shrouded forms of disagreements, which might not be resistance; rather, they may be seen as legitimate concerns for the change. However, we tend to focus on the big cases of resistance, which almost dictates our understandings of all types of resistance.

Our new directions for research should also include adapting more of an interest in explaining individuals' desires to participate in guiding change, and the evolution of their views about specific changes in their organizations. "It is ironic that most organizational change scholarship lacks a focus on stakeholders' evolving perspectives, attitudes, and behaviors through a process of change. Inherent in many of the single-point-in-time data collection strategies is an assumption that stakes and stakeholders are fixed, and that the continuous flow of interaction and influence among stakeholders is irrelevant to outcomes" (→Lewis 2021a: 268). Our scholarship ought to investigate early indicators that groups of stakeholders are forming antagonistic stances towards one another or when stakes in relation to the change are becoming staunchly oppositional. Also, sometimes organizational changes are results of the powerplay/negotiation that happens among stakeholders, which also influences how change is implemented. Change goals evolve over time and are measured based on the saliency of the stakeholder group the organization is trying to satisfy. We might also examine turning points in the evolution of key stakeholder groups' networks, transformation of groups' rhetoric from collaborative stances to contentious stances, and increases in oppositional language, which would provide insight into how groups of stakeholders move "sides" throughout a change. Once we understand how coalitions form and dissolve and how that maps onto efforts to promote,

resist, or accept change, we will be better positioned to explain how shifting loyalties forecast the path of a change.

Further, in addition to tracing the conversations and shifting views of individuals during a change, we could learn a good deal from investigation of the impact of multiple changes on a given individual over a lengthier period of time. Whether data is collected in real time (certainly more methodologically challenging) or in a retrospective manner, it could teach us about the cumulative effects of changes on a given individual to learn about the 'change biography' of individuals and how that might relate to their general attitudes when confronted with change or perhaps how various biographical patterns correlate with career choices and tolerances for ambiguity, frequent change, and other outcomes.

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Chapter 14 Communication, Power, and Organizational Politics

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Abstract

This chapter describes recent trends in the study of organizational power and politics from a communication perspective. The chapter begins by tracing developments in conceptualizing power, control, hegemony, and resistance and then discusses methodological issues. We then elucidate recent insights in key research domains including communicating identity, the political workplace, as well as organizing for advocacy and democratic social change. The chapter ends with commentary on some key debates in the field. In each area, we address opportunities for further research.

Keywords: power (definitions), control, resistance, dissent, coercion, colonialism (and decolonization), intersectionality, heteronormativity, precarity, organizational policy, social change/social justice, constitutive model, sociomaterialism, capitalist reproduction,

Organizational communication research addressing power situates organizing as a communicative struggle among competing interests. This chapter reviews conceptual developments, methodological issues, and major research trends related to communication, power, and politics, followed by a discussion of key debates.

1 Trends in Conceptualizing Communication and Power

Foundational organizational communication researchers drew from critical and social constructionist epistemologies to illustrate how struggles over meaning are constitutive of organizational life (→Allen 1995; →Clair 1993; →Conrad 1983). Theorists linked relations of power and hegemony with the communicative naturalization and reification of sectional interests (→Deetz 1992; →Hardy and Phillips 2004; →Parker 2003) and colonization of subjectivities (→Holmer Nadesan 1996; →Mumby and Clair 1997). Researchers increasingly connect organizational power with broader sociocultural discourses, such as queer theorizing of heteronormativity (→McDonald, Harris, and Ramirez 2020) and decolonial theories excavating Western epistemological erasures (→Cruz 2017; →Pal et al. 2022). Researchers have also connected organizational power to embodiment via theories such as Foucauldian biopower, "aimed at controlling life itself" (→Dempsey and Gibson 2017: 255) By contrast, →Mease (2021) drew from the communicative constitution of organizations (CCO) tradition to define power as "the capacity to set forces into particular relations" (p. 25), and force as "the capacity to affect and be affected" (p. 25). This conception de-emphasizes human agency as it treats the material and social as mutually constitutive.

Recent research has also expanded communicative conceptions of control. For example, investigation of unobtrusive and concertive control (→Barker 1993; →Larson and Tompkins 2005) led to theorizing concertive resistance and collective advocacy (→Wieland 2011; →Zanin and Bisel 2020; →Zoller, Strochlic, and Getz 2020). Research also illustrates how the comprehensiveness, interactivity, instantaneity, and opacity of digital algorithms extend rational and bureaucratic control (→Elmholdt, Elmholdt, and Haahr

2021; →Kellogg, Valentine, and Christin 2020) and forge new forms of panoptic control including peer coveillance and counterveillance (→Berkelaar and Buzzanell 2014; →Ganesh 2016).

Linked with control, foundational research conceptualizing hegemony as a dialectical negotiation among dominant and marginalized groups (→Gramsci 1971; →Mumby 1997; →Parker 2003) drew attention to ways that managerial/leader imperatives are recursively accepted, rejected, and/or undermined by subordinates over time (→Gálvez, Tirado, and Alcaraz 2021; →James and Zoller 2017). The focus on covert and individualized resistance (→Gagnon and Collinson 2017; →Ybema and Horvers 2017) has shifted with increasing attention to overt and collective forms (→Ganesh and Stohl 2013; →Pal 2016; →Rosile et al. 2021; →Zanin and Bisel 2020) including transformational organizing (→Cruz 2015; →Dempsey, Parker, and Krone 2011; →Ganesh 2018; →Ganesh, Zoller, and Cheney 2005; →Jensen 2021).

Researchers depict differing relationships between resistance and dissent. For example, →Garner (2016) contrasted resistance as covert expression with dissent as overt expressions of concern about workplace policies, whereas →Kassing (2007) theorized dissent as a form of resistance. This latter viewpoint broadens dissent to include everyday forms of disagreement and self-advantage along with principled expression (e.g., whistle-blowing). However, researchers largely situate dissent episodically within Weberian, hierarchical relations of authority (e.g., upward and lateral dissent, circumvention) (→Kassing, Fanelli, and Chakravarthy 2018), which may limit attention to shifting, fluid, and invisible organizing structures as well as systemic forms of inequality (→Cruz 2017).

Moving forward, we need more conceptual development of resistance becoming domination, including investigating the organizing of →Gramsci's (1971) subaltern

counterhegemony (see for example →Burawoy 2012) and →Freire's (1993) *conscientização* processes designed to prevent the oppressed becoming oppressors. In addition to theorizing consent, more work can examine the communicative negotiation of *coercive* power (→Ali 2015; →Burawoy 2012; →Jacobson 2017; →Moore 2014; →Penny 2017), such as →Harris's (2019) analysis of how university Title IX policies participate in violence. Coercion involves organizing and legitimizing state/civil violence, including intersecting discourses of colonialism, permanent states of war, and necrocapitalism that render certain bodies vulnerable, and indeed, killable (→Banerjee 2008; →de Souza 2023; →Ganesh 2018; →Mbembe 2003).

2 Methodological and Metatheoretical Approaches

These evolving conceptions of communication, power, and organizing are linked to methodological issues. As researchers from Marxist, feminist, postmodern, and decolonial/postcolonial perspectives contested positivist and realist metatheoretical positions that failed to account for the politics of data gathering and analysis (→Allen 1996; →Broadfoot and Munshi 2007; →Buzzanell 1994; →Deetz 1996), many adopted qualitative methods to understand contextualized experiences of political organizing. We briefly highlight some methodological developments linked to this "interpretive turn" in organizational communication.

First, ethnographic, bottom-up methods often highlighted employee perspectives (→O'Connor et al. 2016) as well as non-dominant groups such as working-class families and unemployed people (→Dougherty et al. 2018; →Gist-Mackey and Guy 2019; →Lucas 2011), sex workers (e.g., →Blithe, Wiederhold Wolfe, and Mohr 2019), and low-income farmers (→Carter and Alexander 2020; →Pal 2016). Recent scholarship has begun to address the relative lack of access to everyday

experiences of powerful decision-makers, such as male managers' use of sexist discourses (→Tracy and Rivera 2010). For example, →Carrillo Arciniega (2021) framed their study of diversity trainers' appeals to white men as "studying up" to connect the decision-making of powerful groups to structural inequality.

Second, more critical scholars are expanding qualitative methods to enact commitments to emancipatory social change via participatory action and advocacy research (→Dutta and Thaker 2019; →Linabary et al. 2021; →Pal 2014; →Parker 2020; →Quinlan et al. 2020). This engagement may necessitate changing publication practices (see →Parker, Oceguera, and Sanchez 2011) and more translational writing for practitioner audiences (e.g., →Lutgen-Sandvik and Tracy 2012; →Pauly and Buzzanell 2016).

Third, more work can be done to integrate quantitative methods in studying communication and power. Metatheoretical critiques of post/positivist theorizing should not lead to binary and oppositional treatment of methodologies. Quantitative research sheds light on the influence of authority on perceptions of deception (→Dunleavy, Chory, and Goodboy 2010) and expressions of dissent (e.g., decisional control, supervisor relationships, and managerial rationalities) (→Garner 2016; →Kassing, Fanelli, and Chakravarthy 2018; →Thompson, McDonald, and O'Connor 2020). Engaging multiple methods to study power requires scholars across research traditions to enact greater reflexivity regarding their orientation to dominant rationalities (→Ellingson 2008; →Field-Springer 2020; →Pal 2014). For example, quantitative researchers may adopt a consensus viewpoint that reinforces the status quo and overlook hidden conflict (i.e., by positioning dissent as managerial feedback that benefits the entire organization or as a form of misbehavior). By contrast, critical scholars have begun to engage quantitative methodologies with explicit commitments

to advance social justice goals (→Garcia, López, Vélez 2018; →Scharrer and Ramasubramanian 2021).

3 Developments in the Study of Communication, Power, and Politics

Next, we describe theoretical developments in major research domains including communicating identity, the political workplace, and nonwork organizing. We also discuss organizing in the context of policy and social change.

3.1 Communicating Identity

Research into the role of differences including gender, race, nationality, sexuality, and ability status in organizing power relationships (→Biwa 2021; →Cruz 2017; →Fleming 2007; →Gill 2014; →Pauly and Buzzanell 2016) increasingly adopts intersectional lenses that highlight overlapping forms of inequality (→Crenshaw 1989; →Harris 2017; →Parker, Oceguera, and Sanchez 2011). For example, research interrogates how dominance is reinforced though constructions of whiteness, masculinity, and heteronormativity (→de Souza 2019; →McDonald 2015; →Parker and Mease 2009). Much of this scholarship reveals the interplay of marginalized and dominant rationalities marking the organizing process (→Carrillo Arciniega 2021; →Pal 2016), and connects with material outcomes such as closeting, harassment, and violence (→D'Enbeau and Kunkel 2013; →Dougherty and Goldstein Hode 2016; →McDonald, Harris, and Ramirez 2020).

Decolonial/postcolonial research examines power and identity in terms of centering and erasing voices, highlighting tensions related to vulnerability and advocacy, and visibility and invisibility (→Cruz 2017; →Ganesh 2018; →Irigaray et al. 2021; →Kang and Krone 2022; →Yousfi 2021). →Pal (2016)

investigated how farmers in Singur, India re-asserted subaltern cultural values largely erased from mainstream knowledge in organizing against land acquisition. Reflecting more inclusive "ecologies of knowledge" (→Santos 2015), researchers are rethinking disciplinary concepts through paradigms rooted in the Global South (→Biwa 2021; →Broadfoot and Munshi 2015). For example, →Spiller et al. (2020) reconceptualized leadership from indigenous Māori practices of *wānanga*, →Cruz and Sodeke (2021) reconfigured conceptions of liquidity based on Nigerian and Liberian market women and street hawkers' experiences, and →Kang and Krone (2022) re-theorized technology, "organized dissonance" (→Ashcraft 2006) and the four flows (→McPhee and Zaug 2008) from the nonduality practiced by the Tibetan grassroots collective *niamle*. These insights challenge taken-for-granted assumptions in Western theories of power and politics.

3.2 Theorizing the Political Workplace

The workplace has been a central concern for identity research in organizational communication. Early critical research interrogated the politics of identity in work socialization processes, marking class, racial, and gendered assumptions in defining what constitutes a "real job", an "entrepreneur", a "professional", and a legitimate college major (→Cheney and Ashcraft 2007; →Cheney et al. 2009; →Clair 1996; →Gill and Ganesh 2007; →Lair and Wieland 2012). Recent scholarship situates these processes within the increasing precarity of work. Research illuminates growing expectations for the entrepreneurial subject to continually adapt to meet neoliberal economic demands (→Bryson and Dempsey 2017; →Mumby 2019), including racialized systems for managing unemployment and job seeking (→Gist-Mackey 2018).

Building on critical theories of organizational culture as a site of power/resistance dynamics (→Mumby 1987), recent research highlights how workplace health promotion discourses reinforce neoliberal values (→Dailey, Burke, and Carberry 2018; →Ford and Scheinfeld 2016), depicting the ideal employee as a self-regulated, self-motivated corporate athlete, maximizing productivity and minimizing costs (→Dale and Burrell 2014; →James and Gill 2018). →James and Zoller (2017) and →James and Gill (2018) observed the growth of cult-like workplace fitness programs, including CrossFit, that incorporate evangelical leadership, peer surveillance, and pressure for conformity in ways that may legitimize abusive managerial practices (see also →Sørensen and Villadsen 2018; →Tourish and Vatcha 2005). Promoting digital health self-tracking technologies ("the quantified self") also enables new forms of corporate paternalism through self and organizational surveillance over things like exercise and sleep (→Elmholdt, Elmholdt, and Haahr 2021).

More broadly, rapidly developing algorithmic technology affords nearly instantaneous managerial tracking linked to rewards and punishments, such as automated performance management systems for app-based delivery workers (→Kellogg, Valentine, and Christin 2020; →Veen, Barratt, and Goods 2020). Employees nonetheless resist incursions into privacy and freedom of expression, context collapse, and social media strictures (→Thompson, McDonald, and O'Connor 2020). For example, although platform capitalism's "gig economy" creates vulnerabilities among contracted, home-based, part-time, and outsourced labor (→Bryson and Dempsey 2017; →Chattopadhyay and Pandit 2021; →Gálvez, Tirado, and Alcaraz 2021), it has fomented collective organizing in response (→Dutta and Kaur-Gill 2018; →Gálvez, Tirado, and Alcaraz 2021; →Rizzo and Atzeni 2020).

3.3 Expanding Beyond Work

Research has expanded our understanding of political organizing beyond the workplace, including volunteer work-life boundary management and professionalization dynamics (→Cruz and Meisenbach 2018; →Ganesh and McAllum 2012). Collectives organized around particular faiths, politics, or ideological principles often encounter political struggles around interpretations of principles, missions, and priorities (→Ban 2017; →D'Enbeau and Kunkel 2013; →Jensen and Meisenbach 2015). Research also illustrates how non-profit and activist organizations (e.g., social service organizations, food pantries) working with marginalized groups struggle with inclusion and client voice, and contest/reinforce the structural bases of inequalities (→de Souza 2019; →Ivancic 2017, →2021; →Jensen 2021; →Olufowote 2017).

Organizational communication scholars address the resistive potential of subaltern collectives and grassroots solidarity networks as spaces to articulate alternative imaginaries and promote social change (→Dempsey 2011; →Dutta and Thaker 2019; →Kang and Krone 2022; →Pal 2016; →Zoller 2021). Although organizing protest movements remains undertheorized, more work attends to the communicative dynamics of mobilizing, connecting, and strategizing (→Ganesh and Stohl 2013; →Heath, Fletcher, and Munoz 2013; →Pinazo Calatayud and Nos Aldas 2016; →Zoller and Casteel 2022).

3.4 Organizing, Power, and Policy

Scholars increasingly investigate ways that dominance and resistance become embedded in organizational-level policy discourses, including workplace sexual identity (→Compton 2016), Title IX (→Harris 2019), and sexual harassment (→Dougherty and Goldstein Hode 2016). A significant body of food security research links organizational policy with

governmental and cultural politics (→Dempsey and Gibson 2017; →Ivancic 2021; →LeGreco 2011; →Okamoto 2017). For example, →de Souza (2019) connected US food pantry aid with food industry political influence and presidential racializing of welfare programs, and →Dutta and Thaker (2019) situated dalit women farmers' cooperatives with a larger movement to transform Indian agricultural policy.

Critical public relations and rhetorical organizational communication investigate industry influence over policy debates such as genetic modification (→Henderson, Cheney, and Weaver 2015), challenging depictions of equitable dialogue in public relations research (→Boyd and Waymer 2011). Additionally, →Conrad's (2011) rhetorical punctuated equilibrium model explicated how corporate issues advocates maintain policy dominance, and dialectically, how non-elites collectively organize to open policy windows. →Zoller and Casteel (2022) applied this model to #MarchforourLives activists' attributions of gun violence to weapons manufacturers.

Researchers have demonstrated how corporate social responsibility (CSR) discourses privatize policy debates (e.g., labor conditions and sustainability) while boosting organizational image and competitive advantage (→O'Connor and Gronewold 2013; →Pal and Jenkins 2014), including the garment industry's promotion of labor rights (→Ban 2020), and the fast food industry's depiction of consumer responsibility for health (→Ban 2016). More research can address roles for governments, NGOs, and trade unions in corporate accountability and multistakeholder certification (→Mitra and Warshay 2016; →Rosile et al. 2021; →Zoller, Strochlic, and Getz 2020).

Finally, communication scholars have begun to critically examine power and inequality in our disciplinary policies (→Ahn et al. 2021; →Cruz et al. 2020; →Dar et al. 2021; →Mukherjee 2020). The #Communicationsowhite forum called

“into focus the complicity of the academy in perpetuating existing racial and intersecting hierarchies” (→Ng, White, and Saha 2020: 143) and promoted collective action redressing systemic inequalities in citation practices, editorial decisions, mentorship, and promotion. Ballard (→Ballard et al. 2020) called for organizational communication scholars to promote anti-racism in *practice*. In that forum, Allen and Ashcraft (→Ballard et al. 2020) noted the need for university leaders to name anti-Black violence in unwavering terms and learn how to address it, and Ganesh and Zoller (→Ballard et al. 2020) called for all scholars, not just critical scholars, to challenge whiteness and Western worldviews in academic publishing and forge inclusive policies in our academic units.

3.5 Emerging Debates

We now turn to some key theoretical debates in the field. These debates center questions of agency and materiality, order, and approaches to social change.

3.5.1 The Constitutive Model

We see growing questions about the constitutive model’s influence on the study of organizational power and politics. First, scholars have argued that social constructionist theories led scholars to privilege dynamics of order over disorder (→Bisel 2009). We caution against the claim that social constructionism necessarily privileges order. Critical-interpretive traditions (e.g., feminist, Frankfurt school, poststructural, and dialogic) have long excavated hidden conflict from discursive closure (→Clair 2000; →Deetz 1992; →Thackaberry 2004), addressed change/stability dialectics (→Ashcraft 2006; →D’Enbeau and Buzzanell 2011; →Dempsey, Parker, and Krone 2011; →Kang and Krone 2022), and investigated how paradox management reinforces or

transforms status quo structures (see →Putnam, Fairhurst, and Banghart 2016) via discursive opening and closure (→Mease 2021; →Vásquez, Schoeneborn, and Sergi 2016). Nonetheless, the amplification of flux and tension as a routine feature of organizational politics is important (→Knox et al. 2015; →Meisenbach 2008; →Mitra and Buzzanell 2017; →Sheep, Fairhurst, and Khazanchi 2016), particularly as a corrective to viewpoints equating overt power struggles with disorder. We should continue to grapple with the implications of framing social arrangements such as neoliberal precarity as disorder (→Mumby 2019) versus a hegemonic form of order, or both.

A second debate about the constitutive model emanates from sociomaterial perspectives. For example, →Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren (2019) called for a decisive break from constitutive theories, drawing from feminist new materialism and Actor Network Theory. They charged the interpretive turn with erasing materiality by focusing on "what people and only people do" (→Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren 2019: 104). We encourage greater attention to issues of power in this proposed "turn". First, we caution against reinforcing modernist and post-positivist straw arguments that overlooked material theorizing in early social constructionism such as "accidentally" spilled coffee as embodied resistance (→Hochschild 1983), the hierarchical organizing of work spaces (→Bell and Forbes 1994), worker injury reporting (→Zoller 2003), and protest signs (→Ganesh and Stohl 2013). As →Harris (2019) observed, feminist new materialism should *not* be interpreted as a break with longstanding feminist theorizing of materiality. However, we value increasing attention to material-symbolic relationships in organizing inequality (→Harris 2019) such as →Gist-Mackey and Guy's (2019) investigation of social support and financial precarity, and →Dougherty et al.'s (2018) use of photovoice to offset symbolic privileging in interview methods.

Third, we question new materialist epistemological politics in claiming a ground that is "neither social constructionist nor realist" (→Harris 2019: 26). On what (and crucially *whose*) grounds do we talk about what is "real" or true, and how is that implicated in power/knowledge relationships (→Foucault 1980; →Rorty 1979)? We also question the implications of theorizing responsibility if we view texts/objects as *independent* actors (see also →Meisenbach 2018). →Harris (2019) used feminist new materialism to theorize organizational responsibility for violence, yet viewing texts such as policy documents as objects with *independent* influence (→Mease 2021) may ultimately disconnect those texts from their human creators and the political contexts in which they are interpreted, enacted, and/or resisted by particular organizational members over time within multiple hierarchies. We further question the implications for marginalized humans of promoting material agency while depicting humans largely as effects of discourses.

Moving forward, we need more dialogue centering social justice and voices of marginalized groups in rendering theories of agency and the material (→Broadfoot and Munshi 2015). Zakiyyah Iman Jackson (in →Muñoz et al. 2015) centered Black experiences in asking "What and crucially whose conception of humanity are we moving beyond?" (p. 215). Jackson (→Muñoz et al. 2015) suggested that part of the appeal in "moving beyond the human" may be to reinscribe Eurocentric values and racial logics. Haritaworn (→Muñoz et al. 2015) asked, "If we are interested in recovering things and beings that are continually rendered disposable as a result of colonial capitalism and cis-heteropatriarchy, why not start with anti-colonial accounts of the world that have a long history of resisting both human and nonhuman erasure?" (p. 213). These materiality debates are linked to conflicts regarding organizing and social change.

3.5.2 Role of the Researcher in Social Change

Critical traditions generally share a commitment to praxis, or theoretically informed emancipatory social change. However, "positive" organizational communication researchers have charged critical theorists with focusing on *problems* and failing to promote organizational flourishing such as wellness (→Bisel, Kavya, and Tracy 2020).

We encourage greater attention to the role of power and difference in defining what counts as resistive, "positive", and "critical" and for whom. Positive psychology, for example, has militaristic roots and an individualist focus (→Ehrenreich 2010; →Ganesh and Zoller 2014). Taking a more dialectical approach, critical participatory action research with low-income and marginalized people promotes flourishing by fomenting agency in addressing social problems, but also recognizes and contests structural limits marked by power disparities (→Dutta and Kaur-Gill 2018; →Parker, Oceguera, and Sanchez 2011).

At the same time, researchers engaging embodied social change efforts face questions about their critical commitments. For example, researchers investigate the role of "alternative organizing" such as fair trade, cooperatives, and community sustainability in re-imagining and transforming late capitalism (→Chertkovskaya and Paulsson 2021; →Peredo and McLean 2020; →Webb and Cheney 2014; →Zoller 2021), yet many critics dismiss these efforts as inconsequential to or co-opted by capitalist relations. Similarly, some organizational studies scholars express fear that engaging management in social change projects via "critical performativity" (→Esper et al. 2017; →Huault et al. 2017) will blunt radical critique (→Cabantous et al. 2016; →Gond and Nyberg 2017). It is important to interrogate hegemonic reproduction within transformative movements (→Hanchey 2018). However, treating capitalism as all-encompassing inhibits organizing for

change (→Gibson-Graham 2006). Privileging radical critique over managerial and other forms of engagement reflects elitism when it undercuts (even imperfect) material action addressing the needs of marginalized groups. We encourage recognition of actually existing alternatives to capitalist relations and contextualized assessments of their resistant potential (see →Bryson and Dempsey 2017).

4 Conclusion

We believe that this review has pointed to multiple directions for future studies of organizational power and politics. The study of the communicative dynamics of dominance and resistance in the organizing process is central to major political challenges of our time, including growing inequality, political instability and violence, climate change, and the connected rise of pandemics. There is significant opportunity for engaged and intersectional organizational communication research to develop solutions to these challenges as they build insights into the political organization of society.

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Chapter 15 Piecing Together Inclusion: A Critical Overview of Organizational Inclusion Research and Praxis

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Abstract

This chapter addresses the fragmented, complicated, and multilayered nature of inclusion in organizations and organizing. Specifically, we trace the historical origins of inquiry about inclusion and related concepts such as diversity and equity in the organizational communication field and other relevant disciplines. We then situate the ideological nexus that has characterized inclusion theorizing and practices. We describe the micro-, meso-, and macro-level explorations of organizational inclusion in communication inquiry and acknowledge the limitations that hegemonic neoliberal discourses impose upon inclusion praxis. We discuss how tensions, contradictions, and limitations are constitutive of inclusion scholarship and extend an invitation to lean into these complexities as entry points to advancing inclusion theory and praxis within the field of organizational communication.

Keywords: inclusion, diversity, equity, difference, intersectionality, business case, diversity management, materiality, relationality, functionalist tradition, critical tradition, institutionalization,

1 Introduction: Constituting Inclusion

Theoretical and practical examinations of organizational inclusion are valuable, yet they have been frustratingly rare within the field of organizational communication. Inclusion can be defined as "people's belief that they can be safe, heard, engaged, fully present, authentic, valued, and respected, both as individuals and as members of multiple identity groups" (→Ferdman 2017: 239). Often discussed in tandem with 'diversity' and 'equity', inclusion inquiry and praxis occupy a complicated space where calls for social transformation and tendencies toward institutionalization practices are in constant tension. For example, organizational practitioners tasked to develop strategies and programs to activate or increase institutional inclusion bump against the sedimented and de-radicalized record of institutional practices (→Mease 2012). Indeed, due to the fragmented nature of its origins and applications, ideological underpinnings of inclusion remain in flux, and theorizing of the concept poses challenges that invite further exploration.

Accordingly, we outline three main goals of this chapter. First, we trace the study of inclusion in organizational communication with attention to the ideological frameworks that have informed its development. In doing this, we acknowledge the fragmented composition of the term and the fluidity with which inclusion has been used both to account for institutional bureaucracies and to strive for social transformation. This exploration suggests the need for a reconstitution of inclusion that acknowledges the tensions and motivations of its research and practice. Second, we unpack different levels in which inclusion research and praxis have unfolded within the field of organizational communication. Furthermore, we situate the study of inclusion in the complicated context of growing neoliberal politics that attach humanity to profit, productivity, and

efficiency. As such, developing practices and further theorizing about inclusion is often limited to finding and highlighting the neoliberal values of inclusive practices. As a response, scholars and practitioners have argued for creative ways to approach discourses of inclusion to disrupt neoliberal discourses. Third, we address the contradictions, tensions, and limitations of inclusion theory and praxis and embrace the messiness as constitutive of inclusion work within the field of organizational communication. As such, we propose multiple entry points to navigate, study, and practice inclusion amidst limiting structures.

2 Tracing Fragmented Origins of Inclusion Scholarship

In discussing and thus producing knowledge around inclusion scholarship, it is necessary to provide a historical and contextual tracing of its emergence out of and alongside "diversity" within our field. We specifically address earlier research on social justice and diversity management for three reasons. First, while conceptualizations of and research on inclusion have grown exponentially in recent years, this research is still relatively new. Second, the term 'inclusion' is fundamentally entangled with constructs such as diversity, difference, social justice, and equity. At times, the terms have been used interchangeably, or alongside each other as descriptors of organizational practices. Third, to address the fragmentation of inclusion scholarship, we attempt to create connections among the various bodies of literature surrounding diversity and inclusion. However, we recognize that this tracing is only one of many ways to perceive and make these connections.

2.1 From Social Justice to Diversity in Management and

Organization Studies

Current inclusion scholarship in the United States can be traced back meaningfully to discourses in the 1960s and 1970s that constituted a social justice approach. This approach suggests that systemic equality, fairness, and antidiscrimination are necessary for addressing historical injustices (→Ahonen et al. 2014). These social justice discourses (e.g., antidiscrimination) were rooted in the idea that workplace exclusion stemmed from legal and institutional discrimination based on race and gender differences. To remedy such discriminatory workplace policies, Congress passed the Civil Rights Act of 1964. Two elements of this Act are particularly powerful outcomes of this social justice approach. First, Title VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 prohibited employment discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex, or national origin. Second, to enforce these provisions and address noncompliance, the same Act created the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC) (→Prasad 2001). In the years that followed, the Nixon Administration instituted affirmative action (AA) policies, specifically for women and racial minorities, with respect to federal contracts and broader hiring practices (→Graham 1996).

However, by the mid-1980s, under the Reagan Administration, many EEO/AA initiatives and their subsequent enforcement by federal agencies had declined dramatically. This decline coincided with the *Workforce 2000* (→Johnston and Packer 1987) report, published by the Hudson Institute, a conservative American think tank. The report forecasted that the US workforce would experience an influx of women and racial and ethnic minorities by the year 2000 (→Nkomo et al. 2019). In addition, the report argued that managers needed to be prepared for this massive shift in workplace demographics or risk losing the United States' global standing as an economic power. While these predictions are now understood

as largely spurious (see →Riccucci 2021), the impact on practitioners and management scholars of the time was far-reaching (→Oswick and Noon 2014). In particular, →Kelly and Dobbin (1998) point to a dramatic increase in research articles on diversity management because of the *Workforce 2000* report. At the same time, EEO/AA specialists and human resource managers struggled to maintain a social justice approach and related discourses within a political environment that privileged government deregulation, individuality, and market logic.

Thus, practitioners and managers shifted from social justice to diversity management approaches to difference. Here, managers intentionally stressed the economic benefits of 'properly' managing a diverse workforce and argued it helped organizations maintain a competitive advantage in the global marketplace. In their foundational article, →Cox and Blake (1991) provide an empirical link between managing diversity and competitive advantage based on six arguments: (a) cost, (b) resource acquisition, (c) marketing, (d) creativity, (e) problem-solving, and (f) system flexibility. This logic became known as the business case for diversity (→Prasad 2001). Moreover, organizations and practitioners adopted the business case to sustain and continue their equal opportunity efforts.

Although EEO policies remained largely unchanged during this time, pro-affirmative action interventions were abandoned (→Oswick and Noon 2014). In fact, terms such as social justice, discrimination, and equality were positioned as negative, archaic, and ineffective; diversity management, on the other hand, was perceived as positive, economically valuable, and forward-thinking. As a result of this shift from social justice to diversity management, practitioners argued that meaningful differences encompassed more than gender, race, age, ethnicity, ability, religion, and sexual orientation. Instead, diversity came to mean a range of enactments of any

individual-level characteristic including personality traits, attitudes, values, and cognitive function. In broadening the meaning of diversity to differences beyond those focused on the social justice approach's interest in equity, organizations could explicitly promote valuing commitments to diversity, while rarely being held accountable for substantive changes in their policies and membership (→Holck, Muhr, and Villesèche 2016).

2.2 Diverging Approaches to Diversity and Diversity Management: Functionalist and Critical Traditions

Alongside the move among organizations and consultants to focus on this broad definition of diversity, two approaches to studying this conceptualization (functionalist and critical) emerged among researchers. →Nkomo et al. (2019) argue that the binary between visible/surface and invisible/deep categories of difference determined the trajectory of diversity research in the field. As such, many management and organizational scholars began to study diversity via identifiable, "surface level" demographic traits or as a broad set of "deep level" attributes and values (→Harrison, Price, and Bell 1998; →Kelly and Dobbin 1998; →Prasad 2001). When scholars focused on surface-level differences, categories such as race and gender were assumed as essentialized and fixed (→Zanoni et al. 2010). One implication of this framing is that white, heterosexual men, especially those in managerial positions, were frequently positioned as the default perspective. Over time, examining diversity as a measurable construct emerged as the dominant practice in management and organization studies. To further understand the tracing of inclusion scholarship, we briefly explore how debates over this conceptualization established two diverging systems of knowledge: one that embraced and advocated the value of the

diversity as measurable (a functional approach) and one that challenged this stance (a critical approach).

Under the functionalist, post-positivist paradigm, diversity research draws heavily from social psychological theories such as similarity-attraction theory, social categorization theory, and social identity theory (SIT) to understand the effects of surface and deep level diversity on organizational processes (→Harrison, Price, and Bell 1998; →Roberson, Ryan, and Ragins 2017; →Roberson 2019). See also Chapter 11 in this Handbook, on social identity in organizational communication. Scholarship within this tradition addresses four categories: (a) diversity as a construct, (b) diversity/differences within intergroup relations, (c) diversity climates, and (d) diversity as value-based. First, research on diversity as a construct analyzes the meaning of differences within and across work groups. →Harrison and Klein (2007) established a typology of how differences influence work units through separation, variety, or disparity. Second, scholarship in this dimension also centers intergroup relations and interpersonal cognitive processes and the relationship with demographic differences. Utilizing identity-based theories, this line of research examines how individuals understand themselves in relation to their environment and intergroup memberships (e.g., →Holck, Muhr, and Villesèche 2016). Here, research is concerned with how diversity is suffused within teams or groups. Third, diversity climate research examines members perceptions about organizational diversity values and policies. Much of the climate research is measured at the individual level or collective level to determine its impact on organizational performance. Moreover, diversity climate studies at the individual level analyze employee perceptions and their relationship with organizational-level effects compared to collective-level climate studies that focus on between-group agreement and their perceptions of policies and programs (→Holmes et al. 2020). For example, →Reinwald,

Huettermann, and Bruch (2018) demonstrated that a strong diversity climate can promote positive collective emotions and therefore increase organizational performance. Finally, the value-in-diversity approach (→Cox and Blake 1991) suggests that differences within teams and groups support novel perspectives, greater variance to informational resources, and innovation. This research addressed how diversity is manageable and enhances organizational performance and innovation. For example, →Smulowitz, Becerra, and Mayo (2019) found that racial diversity in law firms can be leveraged as a strategic resource to increase financial performance. In sum, functionalist diversity research has focused on observation and effective management of diversity to increase organizational performance and maintain a competitive advantage. This functionalist research assumes that top management priorities and results-driven outcomes should come before workers' interests.

In contrast, critical organizational and management diversity scholars emerged in response to the business case and what they viewed as a problematic exploration of human difference in functionalist research (→Prasad, Prasad, and Mir 2011). There are five common assumptions underlying this critical diversity scholarship. First, critical scholars assert that functional diversity management approaches neglect the political and contested nature of diversity and difference. Second, these scholars believe that diversity management reinforces inequality by accepting existing conditions and ignoring the presence of power, inequity, and privilege. Next, critical diversity scholars assume that over-reliance on "the business case" for diversity backgrounds social justice and foregrounds market logic and the managing of identities for a productive order. Fourth, critical scholars challenge that functional approaches either reduce diversity into single, fixed categories, or broaden diversity to the point that it becomes

an empty signifier. Fifth, these scholars assume diversity is socially constructed and difficult to measure.

Based on the aforementioned assumptions, discourse is viewed as central to critical approaches to diversity (→Zanoni et al. 2010). Discourse approaches are keenly focused on how language (re)produces meaning and social reality, viewing the linguistic features of diversity as a constellation of enduring systems of thought or everyday talk and interaction (→Tatli 2011). For example, →Fernando (2021) details how a Sri Lankan subsidiary challenged a Western multi-national corporation's (MNC) implementation of diversity management. In this case, workers resisted diversity discourses of essentialism by leveraging occupational discourses that were context specific. Other scholarship centers on dismantling the persistence of seemingly stabilized identity categories. For example, in viewing identity as a dialectic between agency and structure, critical scholars reposition difference as fluid and contested (→Ashcraft et al. 2012; →Villesèche, Muhr, and Holck 2018). This line of research is mostly concerned with how identity categories are enacted and reproduced in organizational contexts. Relatedly, →Jammaers and Zanoni (2020) revealed how three service organizations reinforced the regulation of disabled bodies and identities by attempting to fit "disabled" bodies into organizational idealized notions of work.

Finally, critical scholars hold the position that diversity and its management is constituted in practices and processes that are temporally and spatially embedded in organizational and societal structures. More specifically, diversity is understood as an interwoven structure of rules and resources. Theoretically, these scholars center on the production and reproduction of inequality in everyday interactions. →Acker (2006) problematized how power, understood via rules, resources, and decision making, instantiates organizational structures in the form of inequality regimes. Identifying and

analyzing inequality regimes makes present the tensions that undergird formal structures (diversity programs) and everyday informal "tacit substructures of inequality" (→Holck 2018: 245). For instance, →Romani, Holck, and Risberg (2019) found that human resource professionals framed their diversity initiatives as benevolent practices of accommodation despite how they could also be analyzed as reinforcing and perpetuating structural discrimination.

2.3 From Diversity Management to Inclusion Scholarship: Differences and Assumptions

Following these functional and critical stances toward diversity management, many management and organization scholars have shifted their focus to center on the role of inclusion as a next step. Recent practitioner literature implies that inclusion is a "superior" organizational practice that creates fairness, equality, and belonging (→Oswick and Noon 2014: 26). However, as →Nkomo (2014) posits, inclusion may simply be "old wine in new bottles" (p. 580). Before exploring the study of inclusion in communication scholarship, we briefly touch on other disciplinary organizational scholars' approaches to inclusion.

Definitions and consideration of inclusion relate to, yet differ from, the diversity concept and research (→Wilhoit Larson, Linabary, and Long 2022). It has been conceptualized as a need for belonging (→Mor Barak 2014) by some and by others as "a process through which [diversity as a 'desired state of heterogeneity'] can be achieved, managed and maintained" (→Brewis 2019: 94). →Roberson (2006, →2019) examined diversity and inclusion as separate terms that are reliant on each other. In this view, diversity represents varied demographic makeups of organizations while inclusion "is focused on integrating diverse employees and integrating diversity into organizational practices" (p. 228). Inclusion-as-

process scholars often argue that organizational inclusion requires a multifaceted approach. For example, →Shore et al. (2011) developed a model of organizational inclusion along six dimensions: (a) feeling safe, (b) being involved in work groups, (c) feeling respected and valued, (d) influencing decision making, (e) valuing authenticity and sharing of values and identities, and (f) espousing recognition of diversity. As a caveat, however, several scholars argue that inclusion's focus on valuing all organizational members supports an identity-blind approach rather than an identity-conscious approach that attends to historically marginalized groups (→Holmes et al. 2020; →Roberson 2006, →2019).

Critical scholars offer two primary concerns about inclusion: (a) inclusion, like diversity, is subject to cooptation and institutionalization, and (b) inclusion processes may rely on individualism while obscuring opportunities and the need for organizational change. For example, →Burchiellaro (2021) found that inclusion in LGBTQ friendly organizations was contingent on normative performances of queerness. Performances that aligned with "pride" and positivity were organizationally valuable, whereas queer performances that failed to meet these normative expectations experienced disciplining. Similarly, →Dobusch (2017) found that for dis/abled employees, inclusion relied on the degree to which one's body impacted organizational productivity.

Second, critical scholars assert that inclusion work, much like diversity management, centers almost exclusively on the individual. For instance, →Brewis (2019) observed how diversity trainings constructed an infallible "inclusive subject" for whom inclusion emerged as a professional skill that accommodated difference only through governing of the self. →Petrucci (2020) qualitatively examined how gender-inclusive meetups, rooted in postfeminist perspectives, provided inclusive spaces for women, transwomen, and non-binary tech workers, but rarely addressed how gender discrimination and

transphobia were structurally constituted. Ultimately, critical scholars have sought to call attention to (a) how difference is formulated to fit and comply with the organizational standard rather than disrupt organizational practices, and (b) how inclusion is easily coopted by dominant discourses and becomes about individual actions instead of reconstituting organizational practices.

3 Organizational Communication Explorations of Inclusion

Communication scholars have begun efforts to study and enact inclusive organizational practices at the micro, meso, and macro levels of organizing. At the micro level, organizational and intergroup communication inquiry has explored how individuals manage and interrupt communication processes that lead to exclusion and discrimination (e.g., →Meisenbach's [2010] stigma management strategies, and →Lutgen-Sandvik's [2008] intensive remedial identity work for those who have experienced workplace bullying). →Warner and Villamil (2017) tested imagined intergroup contact as a promising mechanism to reduce intergroup bias. Their study suggested that imagining interactions could potentially reduce negative bias towards outgroup members, even in cases when the imagined interaction was negative.

Scholars focused on difference via the lens of inclusion typically view identity as socially constructed, power-laden, contested, and intersectional. They study inclusion and identity via demographic groups such as race (→Allen 1995), gender (→Jones 2020), nationality (→Shenoy-Packer 2015), and sexuality (→Compton and Dougherty 2017) that are constructed as different in work and organizing. As →Just and Christensen (2012) note, individuals are noted for their difference in organizations as a means of "othering" or to

demonstrate a commitment to diversity. Less common in this research is a focus on the impact that interlocking systems of oppression have on organizational members and their intersecting identities. As an exception, →Forbes (2009) found that intersections among race, gender, and sexuality in the workplace resulted in what she defined as a simultaneous commodification and co-modification of Black women. Specifically, Black women were othered (commodified) in a way that made them both visible and invisible.

Inclusion efforts at the meso level have evolved out of organizational discourses and practices around diversity, difference, and equity. These discourses and practices initially involved compliance-driven and mandatory 'diversity trainings' (→Thibeaux et al. 2006) and evolved into more proactive, encompassing, and educational interventions. For example, →Goldstein-Hode, Behm-Morawitz, and Hays (2018) tested the effectiveness of a university-wide diversity curriculum that aimed to proactively educate faculty and staff about both interpersonal and systemic diversity processes (see also, →Behm-Morawitz and Villamil 2019). Additionally, →Ramasubramanian, Sousa, and Gonlin (2017) addressed meso-level communication when they argued for the incorporation of communication elements such as small groups settings, community norms, case studies, and perspective-taking exercises to hold productive difficult dialogues and generate goal-based solutions against racism in organizations.

Other inclusion scholarship in organizational communication has critiqued the 'bottom-line' approach to inclusion driving inclusion work. For example, →Mease (2012) reflected on the complicated roles of diversity consultants who experience a push-and-pull between advancing organizational inclusion and encountering resistance from organizational members. Mease concluded that inclusion workers must navigate 'discursive mergers' in which they combine business

case messages with other dominant or resisting discourses as an access strategy or to push discursive boundaries around inclusion. Similarly, →Ahmed (2012) critiqued organizational inclusion processes from the perspective of what these processes concurrently reveal (i.e., economic benefits, hierarchies, etc.) and conceal (i.e., intersectional oppressions, neoliberal dynamics). More recently, →Gist-Mackey (2018) analyzed how organization-based job trainings reified workforce inequality by privileging upper middle-class communication as a normative practice. Ultimately, notions of class and race were mapped onto workers to suggest that blue collar workers must negotiate their discourse and bodies to fit a normative standard of employment.

Other inclusion research has highlighted macro-level societal discourses. Scholars argue that diversity practices and discussions are often more about image or surface-level action than deep and meaningful structural change (e.g., →Ahmed 2012; →Ballard et al. 2020). Neoliberal assumptions, that issues of inclusion and diversity can be addressed through diversity trainings for individual organizational members and through some organizational-level slogans, overlook the deep and societal-level macro discourses that undermine and coopt inclusion efforts. The power of a capitalist and neoliberal discourse in US society for example, easily renders organizational efforts to be inclusive as subservient to goals of business effectiveness and efficiency. Indeed, organizations across any continuum, especially in Western cultures, are subject to the neoliberal economic, political, and social landscape of free market, individualist micro-economies, and profit-based outcomes (→Branton and Compton 2021). In contrast, →Cruz (2017) shared an example from Liberia of resistance to neoliberal cooptation in alternative organizing, where members managed visibility and invisibility through temporal, relational, and structural dimensions.

Similarly, unquestioned discourses of professionalism as a (problematically assumed to be) neutral standard of appropriate talk and decisions can lead to the key concerns raised by communication scholars in a series of recent discipline-focused articles, essays, and forums. For example, the #commsowhite movement seeks to disrupt the neutral assumptions of professional academic publishing by showing the disproportionate number of articles by white scholars published and cited in communication journals (→Chakravartty et al. 2018). Organizational communication's own #ToneupOrgComm Collective (→Collective 2020) is specifically calling attention to how a respondent's call for an NCA organizational communication division paper presented by Kate Lockwood Harris to "tone down its fiery wording" demonstrated Harris's very argument about the problematic power of white professionalism as a discourse that throttles diversity and inclusion in organizational communication research. Thus, organizational communication scholars are aware of, yet struggle to engage with, neoliberal and other dominant discourses and structures that hinder practices and even the study of inclusion (see also Chapter 3 in this Handbook).

4 Reconstituting Inclusion

We arrive at this section acknowledging the multi-disciplinary, ontological, axiological, epistemological, and pragmatical fragments that inform and limit the study of organizational inclusion. In the remainder of this chapter, we offer next steps to engage in meaningful and inclusive research and praxis about inclusion. Perhaps these steps pose more questions than answers for organizational communication scholars and practitioners, but they hold space for complexities, tensions, and contradictions, all constitutive features of inclusion inquiry. In doing so, we invite all scholars and practitioners

(including post-positivists, interpretivists, critical scholars, and others) to resist pressures to follow rigid heuristics when approaching organizational inclusion and instead expand the entry points of inquiry to incorporate the strengths these fragments add to the study and practice of inclusion. Ultimately, we argue that we can utilize the fragmented nature of inclusion to advance arguments and establish uncommon coalitions. As such, we purposefully stray from proposing a single framework for inclusion scholars and practitioners. Instead, we delineate the following important potential entry points for future scholarship and praxis around inclusion:

4.1 Entry Point 1: Acknowledge Space and Materiality as Constitutive of Inclusion

Inclusion scholars and practitioners must consider the organization of space and its intrinsic connection to human relations (→Skoglund and Holt 2021). In their typological analysis about space, →Stephenson et al. (2020) write about space as a 'becoming' organizational process where space is understood as "material features and ongoing everyday practices" (p. 808). This interplay of physical terrain and social interactions can function as an opportunity to challenge or interrupt oppressive organizational practices. Organizational communication scholars have argued for the centrality of space in organizing and its ability to communicate and act as an agentic force (i.e., →Vásquez 2016; →Wilhoit 2018; →Wilhoit Larson 2020).

As an example of how a focus on space can generate inclusive practice and research, →Skoglund and Holt (2021) share how they disrupted binary thinking around bathrooms and gender at a university by transforming a single occupancy unisex bathroom into a space with utility and toiletry artifacts that would invite users to reflect on their personal ideas of

gender construction and break through gender binaries. The spatial transformation also included a replacement of the original binary man/woman sign placed outside the bathroom with a commissioned ‘hir-toilet’ art sign. While the university’s inclusion and affirming policies were not seen as inadequate, this spatial intervention elucidated deeply embedded binaries that circulate and define relations at work. Future scholarship on organizational inclusion should examine and push for similar disruptions to gender and other binaries.

Similarly, →Tyler and Cohen (2010) and →Wasserman and Frenkel (2015) write about the spatial nature of gender performativity and how gender norms are exposed and reinforced using material and spatial elements like placement of family photographs or decorative choices. As such, these scholars argue that organizational members do not simply occupy a space in a vacuum, but they become themselves through it. In addition, other scholars have investigated space as racialized. For example, →Connellan (2013) argues that the color white in stylistic and architectural design choices becomes a powerful force enacting ideological whiteness through space and its aesthetics. Likewise, →Walters (2018) exposes the weaponizing of space against Black women workers in clothing retail stores who find themselves exoticized or excluded.

To challenge still and inert ideas about space in organizations, →Beyes and Steyaert (2012) argue that spacing should be reimagined as a performance “attuned to the material, embodied, affective, and multiple sides and sites of organizing” (p. 53). Organizational communication scholars and practitioners should attend to this ‘spatial turn’ in inclusion inquiry and expand research that conjugates the material and spatial landscape with the affective and discursive realms of any macro, meso, or micro inclusion planning. Ignoring the crucial role of the spacing will likely derail inclusion efforts or render them incomplete. To prevent

this derailment, scholars should attend to theorizing about physical and digital accessibility in organizational spaces, question artifacts, names of buildings, seating charts, office arrangements, third spaces to account for existing relational and group dynamics, and caring for the rhythms, affects, and sensations that a space produces that determine how organizational agents interact with the organization and its members (→Stephenson et al. 2020).

4.2 Entry Point 2: Center Relational Coalitions

We also propose that inclusion inquiry should attend to the intercorporeal and relational nature of difference (→Tylor 2019), that is, it should emphasize the intertwined humanity of organizational members, recognizing this interrelatedness as essential to organizing. →Janssens and Steyaert (2020) criticize and warn against assuming an individualist ontology for studying or implementing inclusion as it prioritizes rationality and cognition over emotional realms, separates members from their positionalities and contexts, and tends to generate superficial inclusion work that is not only insufficient but also often reproduces the very exclusionary elements it seeks to eradicate. In contrast, we propose a constant, careful, ongoing, and intentional examination of relational ordinary practices that prioritize standpoints (→Allen 1996), voice (→Buzzanell 1994), and the communicative agency (→Ganesh 2015) of organizational members who experience oppression. →Ballard et al. (2020) refer to these practices as “not sexy or provocative” (p. 605) but necessarily frequent if they are meant to permeate the fabric of organizational culture in meaningful ways.

Feminist communication scholars argue that a relational turn is key to bringing much-needed destabilization to the contemporary rigidity of institutionalized inclusion efforts. For example, →Rowe (2008) uses the term ‘coalitional subjectivity’

to describe the process of deep engagement by which experiences of privilege and oppression are connected. From this stance, inclusion can emerge from coalescing across power lines and prioritizing people and their experiences over institutional bureaucracies. To this point, →Janssens and Steyaert (2020) argue that inclusion must be examined through a theory of practice that emphasizes embodiment as a dynamic motion to co-create inclusion. →Cunliffe and Coupland (2012) define embodiment as the "emotional, personal, felt and sensed bodily experience embedded in words, gestures, facial expressions, 'body language'" (p. 69). Thus, a relational turn in inclusion work calls practitioners and scholars to investigate corporeal (in)actions as an important variable in understanding organizational inclusion. However, →Dobusch (2021) warns that these relational processes are often attached to neurotypical ideas of social interaction that can inadvertently exclude non-neurotypical persons. Therefore, organizational scholars should explore how relationality is co-constructed in non-neurotypical groups and how institutions can develop structures to support multiple ways to build relationships.

Via a relational approach, →Dutta's (2018) Culture Centered Approach (CCA) provides a useful framework to examine organizational inclusion. At its core, CCA is an invitation to listen to, engage with, and follow the lead of voices from the margins before generating any kind of inclusion development plan. One of CCA's main tenets is to generate institutional knowledge from the individuals in organizations who often experience the most isolation because of oppressive structural barriers. As such, a CCA interpretation of inclusion would start with the lived experiences of organizational members as the experts and main agents to formulate plans of inclusive action. A departure from the top-down planning around inclusion can open spaces of participation, problem-solving, empathy,

solidarity, reflexivity, and resistance. For example, incorporating dialogue-based programs (→Gayles et al. 2015; →Ramasubramanian, Sousa, and Gonlin 2017; →Villamil et al. 2023) like 'town halls', 'listening sessions', or 'caucusing opportunities' to reveal individual, institutional, and structural oppressions can be useful modalities to disrupt power imbalances and co-create participatory and cathartic spaces. However, because these efforts tend to be coopted, dominated by advantaged organizational members (e.g., →Droogendyk et al. 2016), or not structurally supported with sustainable follow through, organizational members can end up with more work to do and another failed attempt to destabilize the institutional bureaucracies that halt any structural change.

Because institutionalizing inclusion efforts often come with a loss in radicalizing power, generating social change might be a challenge. However, while the institutional context might be limiting, it can also generate subversive spaces for relational coalitions to build inclusion. For example, →Jones and Calafell (2012) suggest intersectional reflexivity and critical consciousness narrative building to resist individualist-driven ontological stances around organizational inclusion. To wit, →Jones (2010) calls these efforts a "rhizomatic underground railroad" (p. 124) where inclusion scholars and practitioners carry social transformation efforts with and for the communities they serve. Doing so can offer a path to partially circumvent or at least consciously navigate neoliberal bureaucracies and push forward people-centered and agentic goals as a cornerstone and binding force of organizational inclusion.

Ultimately, inclusion inquiry and praxis are better understood as the convergence of spatial, material, ethical, embodied, and political organizing practices. We draw from →Tyler's (2019) concept of 'embodied ethics' and join her invitation to conceptualize inclusion as a corporeal and

interconnected vulnerability where embodied ethics are not a moral obligation but an “ontological compulsion” (p. 51).

4.3 Entry Point 3: Engage with (Do Not Appropriate) Emancipatory Analytic Frameworks

A third entry point invites inclusion scholars and practitioners to engage liberatory theory and praxis frameworks (see also Chapter 3 in this Handbook on doing justice through organizational communication). →Cruz et al. (2020) manifested the urgent need to tone up and make time for intersectionality in organizational communication inquiry; we join their call and invite inclusion researchers and practitioners to consider the systemic disadvantages of having several oppressed identities (→Crenshaw 1991). To wit, organizational communication scholars should also make time for transnationality, disability studies, environmental justice, indigenous epistemologies, decoloniality, queer theory, and critical race theory (CRT), among other analytics, to account for traveling and interlocking systems of oppression that affect organizational members (see also →Linabary et al. 2021).

Once again, we warn about the cooptation of these frameworks, a concern that some transnational feminist and intersectional scholars have already articulated (e.g., →Falcón and Nash 2015; →Grzanka et al. 2017), but ignoring these important analytics will only continue the cycles of oppression that permeate organizations and affect organizational members’ experiences of inclusion. Thus, while inclusion scholars and practitioners should account for these frameworks in their inquiry and praxis, they should abstain from bureaucratizing these analytics and taking away their emancipatory motives.

Following this call, some organizational communication scholars have expanded their inquiry to center

intersectionality. For example, →Baker and Brewis (2020) interrogated how neoliberal discourses of individualization and self-responsibility perpetuate feelings of self-blame and impostor syndrome. As such, they proposed disrupting the 'ideal worker' discourse that affects all workers, but disproportionately affects marginalized others. Accounting for this disruption in inclusion theorizing and praxis can destabilize neoliberal discourses of perfectionism and generate an intersectional conscience about the dangers of the 'perfect worker' and its relation to systems of ableism, heteronormativity, and whiteness. Relatedly, →Ferguson and Dougherty (2022) called for contesting discourses of professionalism that often function as a veneer for normalizing whiteness. In addition, these discourses negate the historical positionalities of Black professionals who have navigated interlocking systems of oppression and surveillance. →Long and Buzzanell (2022) explored the impactful ways in which intersectional resistance is an avenue to advocate for change. →McDonald (2015) proposed a 'theory of closeting' to contest organizational disclosure and expose overlooked power dynamics. →Lockyer (2022) exposed the exploitative organizing practices in anti-trafficking organizations that in addition to being steeped in saviorism have retraumatized survivors and neglected their needs. All this work shows the heuristic and human value of engaging emancipatory frameworks for the study and praxis of inclusion.

5 Conclusion

In this chapter, we gathered numerous fragments across disciplines, scopes, and contexts about inclusion scholarship and praxis. Taken together, these fragments provided a complex view of the institutional space inclusion occupies and acknowledged both restrictions and possibilities for future

inquiry and practice. In closing, we argue that institutionalized inclusion efforts are crucial in organizational life just as are finance, accounting, and other organizational practices. These efforts will not yield a radical uprising against exclusionary practices, but they can offer institutionalized accountability and avenues to push through and transform bureaucratic barriers. If approached as another institutional urgency, inclusion inquiry and praxis can be a powerful form of knowing the organization, its boundaries and its permeabilities, such that we are "encountering resistance and countering that resistance" (→Ahmed 2012: 175).

Furthermore, while potentially restricting, institutionalized inclusion efforts can also enable workers to embody a 'trojan horse' praxeology to mobilize inclusion agendas and innovations within the institution. In doing so, scholars and practitioners must follow →Parker and McDonald's (2019) advice to engage in deep and constant reflexivity to gauge competing commitments, political implications, and adequate beneficiaries of organizational inclusion.

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Section III: Contexts

Chapter 16 Supervisor-Employee Communication

Guowei Jian

Abstract

Supervisor-employee relationships (S-Es) present an influential context for organizational communication. This chapter offers a survey of contemporary S-E research previously strewn across diverse disciplines and research fields. Foregrounding communication, the chapter introduces a nomological framework that integrates four research areas across a wide range of topics: supervisory communication (supervisory mentoring, managerial coaching, feedback and performance appraisal, abusive supervision, and other supervisory communicative practices), employee upward communication (upward influence tactics, voice, dissent, and silence), S-E relational development (leader-member exchange, trust, and congruence), and context (culture, peers and work groups, and technology). By zooming in and contrasting these various research areas, the chapter sheds light on the gaps and limitations that could spawn exciting opportunities for the field's future growth.

Keywords: supervisory communication, mentoring, managerial coaching, feedback, performance appraisal, abusive supervision, listening, leader-member exchange, trust, congruence, upward influence, employee voice, employee dissent, employee silence, social exchange theory,

Supervisor-employee relationships (S-Es) present an influential context for organizational communication. Since →Jablin's (1979) state-of-the-art review over four decades ago, research on this topic has accelerated in recent years. However, the growth of this scholarship has been fragmented across various disciplines and related topics, such as leadership (→Fairhurst and Connaughton 2014) and organizational socialization (→Jablin 2001; →Kramer and Miller 2014). The state of the field is in need of integration and reflection that would undoubtedly benefit its future growth. Thus, the purpose of this chapter is to offer an integrative survey, critique, and directions for S-E communication research.

First, S-E refers to a dyadic relationship between members of a work organization in which one party is granted with formal and direct

authority over the other (→Jablin 1979; →Sias 2014). The supervisor has higher status and the right to exercise organizational control over his/her direct report. Thus, the formal power asymmetry is a defining characteristic of the relationship. In the past, scholars have contributed to the subject from diverse disciplines, such as communication, psychology, and management. Given the disciplinary focus of this handbook, the chapter foregrounds communication and highlights theories and empirical studies that help advance organizational communication scholarship on the topic. To balance the limited publishing space allocated here with the accelerating output of scholarship in recent years, the chapter will emphasize research published since the year 2000.

In the following, the chapter first describes the field's historical development and theoretical landscape and introduces a nomological framework to integrate the S-E scholarship. Second, the review delves into specific S-E domains that have garnered significant empirical work in the last two decades. The chapter will end with a critique of existing research and offers directions for future development.

1 Historical Background and Theoretical Overview

The theoretical development in S-E research can be traced to the consideration of organizations as systems of roles (→Katz and Kahn 1978). It was based on the role theory that Dansereau and colleagues (→Dansereau, Graen, and Haga 1975) developed a vertical dyad linkage (VDL) framework that conceptualizes how S-Es differentiate into unique vertical dyads, with each dyad reflecting a different set of role behaviors and role development processes to which both the supervisor and employee contribute through interaction and negotiation. The VDL approach was later renamed and developed into a theory known as leader-member exchange (LMX) (see also Chapter 7 on leadership communication). Despite the term "leader" in its name, the theory has been largely operationalized and tested within the S-E context and serves as the most dominant framework for understanding S-E relational development. LMX theory posits that both of the roles of supervisor and employee are ambiguous and go through a testing and negotiation process, which results in varied levels of relational quality (→Graen and Uhl-Bien 1995) marked by distinct patterns of communication (see Chapter 7 for contributions by organizational communication scholars to LMX research).

In addition to LMX theory, social exchange theory (SET; →Cropanzano and Mitchell 2005) is often employed to frame the underpinning transactional mechanisms of S-Es. SET focuses on the rules (e.g.,

reciprocity and negotiated rules), resources (e.g., information and status), and the obligations that exchange generates in facilitating and constraining relational development (→Cropanzano and Mitchell 2005). →Nienaber et al.'s (2015) review found that over 60% of research on S-E trust employed the SET lens. Research on employee voice also draws heavily on SET to explain voice as a signal of employee commitment in exchange for manager recognition and reward (→Bashshur and Oc 2015).

Despite the popularity of LMX and SET, S-E scholarship is diverse and fragmented and has expanded significantly beyond these frameworks through independent or siloed growth of research domains in diverse disciplines. The present review identified 13 S-E research domains, which, for the sake of parsimony and integration, are organized into four areas (supervisory communication, employee upward communication, relational development, and context) through a nomological framework of Supervisor-Employee Communication and Relational Development (SECRD; see →Figure 1).

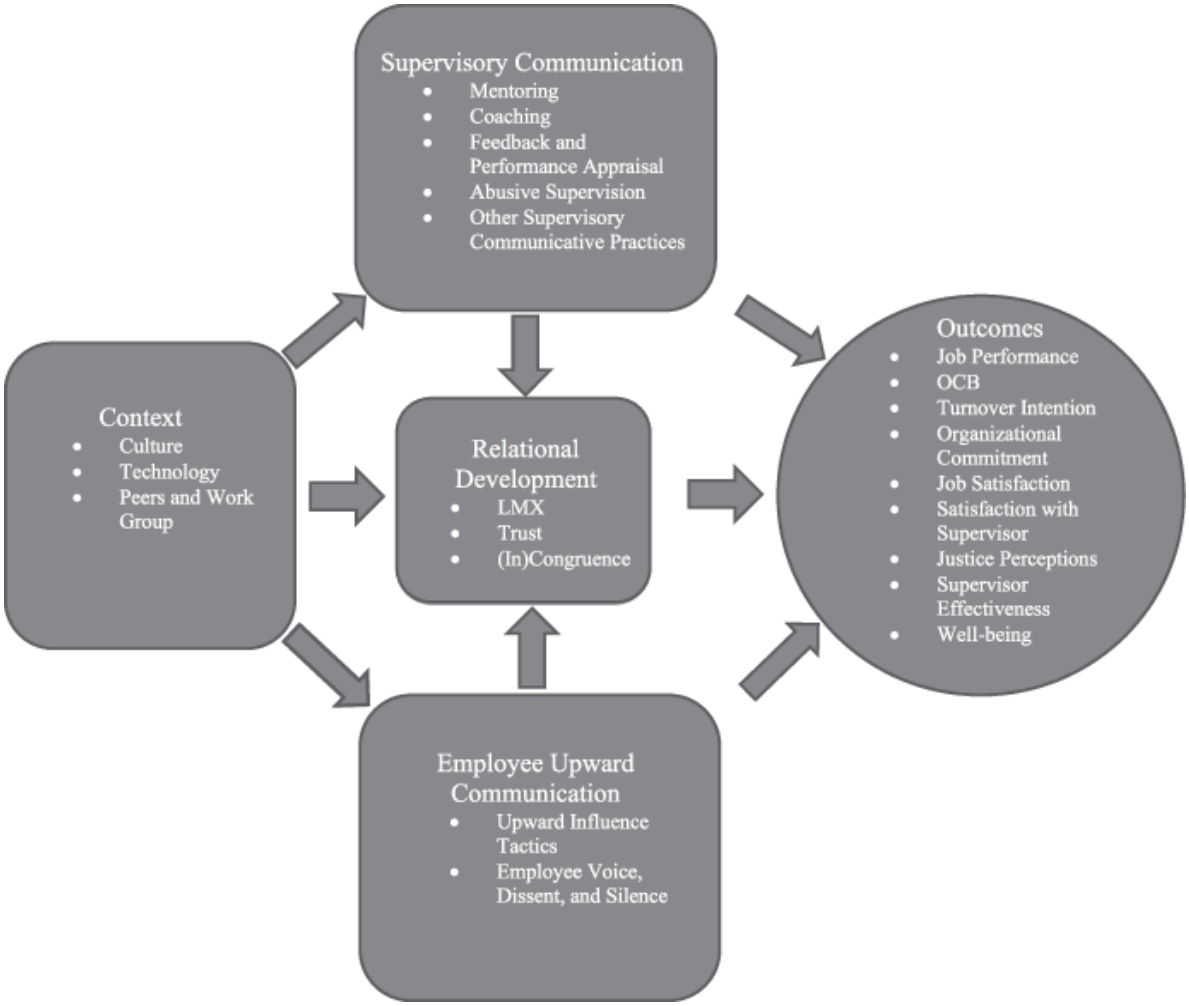


Figure 1: The Nomological Framework of Supervisor-Employee Communication and Relational Development.

In SECRD, each square represents an area of S-E research with several key domains. It should be noted that SECRD is not a result of deductive theoretical explication but an inductive nomological representation based on a survey of the empirical literature scattered across many research fields and disciplines. The categories are not intended to exhaust all existent research domains but reflect key areas that have accumulated significant insights through empirical investigations toward understanding S-Es in recent decades. These domains are not mutually exclusive, either, but overlapping categories, which often emerged independently from cognate disciplines without much dialogue. To gain a comprehensive understanding of this rapidly growing S-E scholarship, it is now necessary for us to zoom into each of these domains.

2 Supervisory Communication

Supervisory communication refers to the communicative behaviors by a supervisor directed toward his/her direct reports that serve task and relational goals. Supervisory communication is central to three adjacent functional domains, including supervisory mentoring, managerial coaching, and feedback and performance appraisal. Also included in this section are studies that focus on specific supervisory communication practices (e.g., listening) irrespective of particular functional contexts. This section ends with a review of abusive supervision, in contrast to the positive and supportive supervisory behaviors.

2.1 Supervisory Mentoring

Mentoring is a developmental relationship between a more experienced adult and a lesser experienced one in which the former provides support to the latter (→Kram 1985). In the workplace, supervisory mentoring is common when supervisors take on the mentorship with their direct subordinates. Supervisory mentorship is significantly associated with provision and receipt of career mentoring (→Ghosh 2014) and with various employee job outcomes, for example, job satisfaction (+) and turnover intentions (-) (e.g., →Lapointe and Vandenberghe 2017). Recent research on supervisory mentoring focuses on identifying the boundary conditions of mentoring effects. For example, provision of challenging jobs and career opportunities was found to moderate the negative association between supervisory mentoring and turnover intentions (→Lapointe and Vandenberghe 2017).

Although research on mentoring shows strong evidence for its benefits, negative experience and outcomes of supervisory mentoring have also come to light. For example, negative mentoring experience was found to be a stronger predictor of protégé's well-being than positive experience (→Eby et al. 2010). Focusing on communication, →Madlock and Kennedy-Lightsey (2010) revealed that supervisor's verbal aggressiveness may negate the positive effect of supervisor mentoring, and thus concluded, "the mere act of mentoring is not as vital as is the way supervisors communicatively enact mentoring" (p. 56).

Overall, research is abundant in linking supervisory mentoring with its outcomes. However, few directly investigated the communicative process or variables in supervisory mentoring, although studies often acknowledge the role of communication when making sense of particular findings. Additionally, much of the literature on the negative mentoring

experience did not separate supervisory versus non-supervisory mentoring, which future studies could further address.

2.1.1 Managerial Coaching

Although sharing much family resemblance with supervisory mentoring, managerial coaching has shown a stronger concern with performance improvement and more intense focus on communicative coaching behaviors than does the mentoring literature. The term *managerial coaching* is commonly used to refer to a coaching relationship between a supervisor and her/his direct reports. While numerous definitions of managerial coaching exist, they tend to coalesce around supervisor/manager's communicative actions to facilitate employee learning with the purpose of enhancing their competence and performance (→Beattie et al. 2014; →Hagen 2012; →Lawrence 2017). Meta-analytic reviews (→Hagen 2012; →Lawrence 2017) suggest a common set of communication behaviors, including, although not limited to, open communication, informing, offering and asking for feedback, and establishing clear goals, although the lists of behaviors generated from various studies often lack theoretical coherence or conceptual clarity.

Most studies employed quantitative cross-sectional surveys with findings supporting a positive association of managerial coaching with job performance, organizational commitment, job satisfaction, in-role competence, and customer satisfaction, although very few studies used objective performance measures (→Lawrence 2017). By contrast, qualitative studies, though very limited in number, paint a more complex picture of managerial coaching, highlighting its relational process and questioning the very definition of managerial coaching and the prevalence of its actual practice among managers. For example, a case study (→Hannah 2004) found that employees reported having far more assessment sessions than coaching sessions with their supervisors, suggesting that managerial coaching may have taken place much less frequently in practice or that employees see coaching in a different light. This latter possibility finds support in another qualitative study (→Dixey and Hill 2015), which concluded that employees often saw managerial coaching not as a formalized interactional event or activity but conversations taking place in "a relaxed and safe environment" (p. 84). Echoing the spirit of this finding, →Grant (2017) argued that workplace coaching should be viewed as "quality conversation not a goal-focused manipulation" (p. 43).

2.2 Supervisor Feedback and Performance Appraisal

Although mentoring and coaching could be deemed as discretionary supervisory behaviors or functions, supervisor feedback and performance appraisal are often written into a supervisor's job description. The feedback-performance link, in particular, has been a persistent scholarly concern for decades. Although earlier research showed that feedback improved performance on average, feedback intervention theory (FIT; →Kluger and DeNisi 1996) posits that feedback intervention cues that direct attention to task learning and task motivation are more likely to enhance performance than do those that direct attention to self-concept.

Recent feedback research in the work context offers strong evidence that supervisors are an effective source of performance feedback; performance feedback explains large effect sizes of performance change; and higher feedback frequency is more effective than lower frequency (→Sleiman et al. 2020). Research has also shown that performance feedback not only impacts contractual efforts of employees but also discretionary behaviors (→Tagliabue, Sigurjonsdottir, and Sandaker 2020).

Regarding specific feedback properties, perceived immediacy and frequency of performance feedback moderate the positive effect of perceived constructiveness of supervisor feedback on work performance (→Kuvaas, Buch, and Dysvik 2017). Supervisor negative feedback, although being positively related to employees' feeling of emotional exhaustion, is associated with improvement in both in-role and extra-role performance (→Xing, Sun, and Jepsen 2021). Moreover, experimental research (→Young et al. 2017) demonstrated that, following negative feedback, supervisors' display of empathic concern helped decrease employees' negative affect while increasing their positive affect.

As a formal type of feedback, performance appraisal is often considered one of the most challenging supervisory tasks, central to which is performance appraisal interview (→Clifton 2012; →Gordon and Miller 2014). Supervisors report that relational concerns and fear of resistance and retaliatory action are among the issues that make the conversation especially difficult (→Bradley and Campbell 2016). The importance of relational concerns echoes the meta-analytical results from earlier quantitative research showing that S-E relational quality strongly predicts appraisal reaction (→Pichler 2012). Through a combination of fine-grained qualitative and quantitative analyses, →Meinecke, Lehmann-Willenbrock, and Kauffeld (2017) identified a reciprocal sequence between supervisor relation-oriented communication and active employee involvement and that the presence of such sequences is correlated with both parties' perception of appraisal interview success. To mitigate

relational concerns, supervisors' use of empathic communication (e.g., verbal mimicry) during appraisal interview can lead to greater employee intention to change and to higher perceived supervisor likability (→Meinecke and Kauffeld. 2019). The most systematic treatment of the performance appraisal interview from a communication lens can be found in →Gordon and Miller (2012) who framed performance appraisal as a conversation that not only attends to the appraisal message content but also the interaction management, context, and follow-up actions.

In addition to supervisory feedback giving, from the subordinate's perspective, employee feedback-seeking behavior has also been the focus of scholarly attention. Some significant antecedents of employee feedback-seeking behavior include performance goals (+), the amount of feedback received (+) (→Anseel et al. 2015), autonomy support by supervisor (+) (→Beenen, Pichler, and Levy 2017), supervisor arrogance (-) (→Borden, Levy, and Silverman 2018), listening (+) (→Qian et al. 2019), and leader humor (+) (→Karakowski, Podolsky, and Elangovan 2020). Although employee feedback seeking is found to be positively related to job satisfaction, socialization, and relationship-building behaviors, contrary to common expectation, meta-analysis does not show a significant positive association between employee feedback seeking and performance (→Anseel et al. 2015).

2.3 Other Supervisory Communication Practices

Additional to the more functional domains of supervisory communication reviewed above, scholars have examined specific communication practices that do not fit neatly into the functional categories. These practices include supervisor's use of motivating language, listening, and embodied practices.

First, motivating language theory argues that direction-giving language, empathetic language, and meaning-making language are essential discursive tools for motivating employees (→Sullivan 1988). Applied to supervisor language use, motivating language was shown to be associated with positive employee outcomes, for example, work attendance (e.g., →Mayfield and Mayfield 2009). Among telecommuters, according to →Madlock (2013), direction-giving language by supervisors has stronger predictive value than empathic language and meaning-making language on employee outcomes (e.g., job satisfaction).

Although much of S-E research on supervisory communication prioritizes speaking, →Van Quaquebeke and Felps (2018) proposed a construct *respectful inquiry* to theorize the role of supervisor attentive listening combined with asking open questions in motivating positive

employee behaviors. Empirically, employee perceptions of supervisor listening were found to be significantly associated with employee organizational citizenship behavior (OCB), emotional exhaustion, and turnover intentions (→Lloyd et al. 2015).

Finally, few studies examine embodied practices that constitute S-E interaction. A notable exception is →Argaman's (2009) conversation analysis, which demonstrated how a supervisor enacted and maintained authority and control through gaze and use of objects together with argumentative verbal expressions. →Jia, Cheng, and Hale's (2017) work investigated supervisor nonverbal immediacy, which was found to significantly predict subordinates' perceived emotional support and level of engagement in emotional work.

2.4 Abusive Supervision

In contrast to the positive and supportive side of supervisory communication above, scholarly interest in abusive supervision has grown considerably since 2000 (→Mackey et al. 2021). →Tepper (2000) defined abusive supervision as "subordinates' perceptions of the extent to which supervisors engage in the sustained display of hostile verbal and nonverbal behaviors, excluding physical contact" (p. 178). Researchers have gathered strong evidence that links abusive supervision to a series of negative individual outcomes, ranging from subordinates' depression and emotional exhaustion to decreased in-role and extra-role performance (→Mackey et al. 2017). A large array of supervisor and employee attributes are associated with abusive supervision, for example, supervisor's Machiavellianism and subordinate political skills (→Mackey et al. 2017; →Zhang and Bednall 2016). However, cross-sectional survey designs in most of these studies do not permit any conclusion regarding causal effect.

Although communication behaviors largely define the perception of abusive supervision, only a few studies directly focus on communication that constitutes the phenomenon. For example, through both experiment and survey-based field studies, →Chen et al. (2021) showed that abusive supervision talk can elevate hostility toward the abused subordinate, which, in turn, increases supervisor's subsequent abusive behavior. While a supervisor's anger expression can have both negative and positive effects on employees, abusive supervision exacerbates the negative effects of anger expression and weakens its potential positive effects (→Wang et al. 2018). Moreover, subordinates who confront abusive supervisors with direct maintenance tactics reported less psychological distress than those who employed avoidance ones (→Tepper et al. 2007).

Finally, according to →Mackey, Huang, and He (2020), abusive supervision is positively associated with a subordinate's destructive voice directed to the supervisor with the association conditioned by the level of LMX differentiation across work teams. Collectively, these studies suggest that abusive supervision is much more interactive than previously conceived and has to be understood in the broader peer/team relational context of the S-E dyad.

3 Employee Upward Communication

Employee upward communication can be directed to multiple targets, although the review below focuses on supervisor-targeted communication, including upward influence tactics, employee voice, dissent, and silence. Due to the considerable conceptual overlap among voice, dissent, and silence, they are grouped under one research domain.

3.1 Upward Influence Tactics

Upward influence tactics refer to behaviors by a person in a lower hierarchical position to achieve a desired goal from those in higher positions in an organization (→Kipnis, Schmidt, and Wilkinson 1980; →Waldron 1999). Earlier research in the 1980s and 1990s identified a range of influence tactics, for example, assertiveness, ingratiation, rationality, coalition, and sanctions (e.g., →Kipnis, Schmidt, and Wilkinson 1980; →Schriesheim and Hinkin 1990). Recent research has advanced this body of literature on several fronts. First, more nuanced understanding has emerged about the effects and conditions for using some of these tactics. For example, →Olufowote, Miller, and Wilson (2005) demonstrated that factors, such as employee role change goal and change magnitude, interacted to predict employee's use of rationality and coalition. Delving into the often-overlooked affect dimension, →Deng, Walter, and Guan (2020) found that supervisor-directed emotional labor functioned as upward influence with deep acting producing beneficial outcomes and surface acting with detrimental implications.

Second, research has broadened the types of outcomes from using upward influence tactics and their underlying mechanisms. For instance, according to →Kim, LePine, and Chun (2018), ingratiation functions as "a double-edged sword" (p. 501), which positively influences the relational quality between the focal actor and his/her boss but negatively impacts his/her own subordinates' job performance and the relational quality with them. Moreover, message content and delivery style by subordinates in

upward influence situations have differential impact on supervisor's evaluation of the subordinates (→Foste and Botero 2012).

Finally, in contrast to the variable-analytic approach to upward influence, which is anchored in the object-like taxonomies of tactics, qualitative work that examined the actual communication process of influence unveiled unique insights. For example, →Clifton's (2009) conversation analysis showed how influence was achieved *in situ* through identity work and the maneuver of discourse resources. From a dialectical approach, →Erhardt and Gibbs (2014) demonstrated that impression management was better understood not as an employee's self-interested upward influence act but interactional moves of tactic and countertactic between supervisors and subordinates in managing relational tensions. Overall, the qualitative studies highlight a much more interactive and fluid process of S-E influence than that previously shown from the conventional taxonomic approach.

3.2 Employee Voice, Dissent, and Silence

Employee voice refers to a specific form of employee OCB through expressing proactive and constructive suggestions for change (→Botero and Van Dyne 2009; →Hirschman 1970). Employee silence, by contrast, refers to the withholding of expression that could affect positive change. Scholars differ in theorizing the relationship between voice and silence. Some argue that voice and silence are the opposite sides of the same coin (→Ashford, Sutcliffe, and Christianson 2009) or two poles of one single continuum, while others contend that they qualify as separate multidimensional constructs (→Van Dyne, Ang, and Botero 2003).

Past research suggests that employee voice has a positive relationship with the voicer's subjective self-rated and other-rated performance ratings modified by such factors as voicer's trustworthiness, the timing of voice, organizational norm for speaking up, and the nature of the message (e.g., solution oriented) (→Bashshur and Oc 2015). However, when employee voice is problem-focused without constructive proposal for solutions, the voicer's performance rating can be negatively affected (→Bashshur and Oc 2015). Recent studies have given more in-depth look into the potential contributors to employee voice. For example, a multiphase study by →Kumar and Mishra (2017) showed that organizational situational variables, such as supervisor's use of power and organizational politics, are much stronger predictors of employee voice than employees' trait of willingness to communicate.

One specific form of voice, employee upward dissent, has received significant attention from organizational communication scholars.

Employee upward dissent refers to the expression of objection and disagreement to managers or supervisors (→Kassing 2000). Employees' likelihood to dissent is conditioned by their relationship with supervisors, their sense of control and influence, and their comfortability with engaging in arguments (→Kassing 2011). When considering dissent strategies, dissenters view solution presentation, circumvention, and repetition as effective strategies (→Garner 2012). However, supervisors interpret dissent messages differently from dissenters and value dissent messages that are aligned with organizational goals and contain solutions and rational analysis (→Garner 2016).

In comparison to the literature on voice and dissent, research on employee silence has been scant and is largely centered on why employees choose to remain silent. According to →Klaas, Olson-Buchanan, and Ward (2012), interpersonal risks figure prominently in employee decisions to speak up or remain silent. In particular, a supervisor's interactional unfairness, employee strained relationship with supervisor, and dissatisfaction with supervisor are all significant contributors to employee silence (→Ng and Feldman 2012).

Qualitative work offers additional insights into employee silence. According to →Milliken, Morrison, and Hewlin (2003), the top issue employees feel uncomfortable to bring up is about the competence or performance of a colleague or supervisor and that the top reason for silence is due to fear of being viewed or labeled negatively as a "troublemaker", "complainer", or "tattletale" (p. 1462). →Bisel and Arterburn (2012) further elicited various reasons why employees refrain from bringing up supervisor-targeted negative feedback, for example, employees predicting more harm to themselves than benefits.

Several theories have emerged to account for employee silence and voice. First, Bisel and colleagues (→Bisel, Messersmith, and Kelley 2012; →Bisel 2018) extended the mum effect theory (→Rosen and Tesser 1972) by coining the term "hierarchical mum effect" to refer to subordinates' propensity to remain silent especially in situations with ethical concerns. →Hussain et al.'s (2019) theory of "bystander effect" posits that employees are more likely to remain silent on a work-related issue with their managers when they perceive information redundancy among peers. Drawing on social learning theory, →Ng et al. (2021) argued that witnessing a coworker's voice as a form of social learning helps create the dynamic of "voice contagion" (p. 1571).

In summary, the theoretical development in employee voice, dissent, and silence in the S-E context is still in a formative stage. Two areas deserve particular attention. First, empirical research thus far strongly supports the argument that employee voice and silence are

multidimensional constructs (→Van Dyne, Ang, and Botero 2003; →Morrison 2011). Each dimension may emerge from unique relational dynamic and bear different individual, dyadic, and group relational consequences and, thus, could benefit from nuanced theorizing and empirical investigation. Second, it is imperative to theorize the interactive process of voice/silence, which involves not only tactics, strategies, and affects but also the way in which their effects unfold over time in interaction with supervisor responses (→Bashshur and Oc 2015).

4 Supervisor-Employee Relational Development

Earlier, this chapter surveyed research on LMX as a major theory as well as construct that informs our understanding about S-E relational development. This section covers two other bodies of literature, i.e., trust and (in)congruence, which can shed further light on the S-E relational dynamic.

4.1 Trust

According to →Mayer, Davis, and Schoorman (1995), trust is "the willingness of a party to be vulnerable to the actions of another party based on the expectation that the other will perform a particular action important to the trustor, irrespective of the ability to monitor or control that other party" (p. 712). The definition suggests that trust as a psychological state requires trustworthiness on the part of trustee and risk-taking behavior by the trustor. Social exchange theory and social information processing theory are commonly used to explain trust development in S-Es. Supervisors high in perceived competence, integrity, and benevolence are more likely to gain employee trust (→Colquitt, Scott, and LePine 2007; →Fulmer and Gelfand 2012; →Nienaber et al. 2015). In particular, supervisor competence is found indispensable in trust development for both nascent and established S-Es (→Frazier, Tupper, and Fainshmidt 2016). Employees also report higher levels of trust in supervisors who demonstrate higher degrees of procedural and interactional justice (→Colquitt and Rodell 2011; →Dirks and Ferrin 2002).

Employee trust in supervisor has positive predictive effects on a wide range of employee outcomes, including satisfaction with supervisor, job satisfaction, job performance, job satisfaction, OCB, and decision commitment (→Colquitt, Scott, and LePine 2007; →Dirks and Ferrin 2002; →Fulmer and Gelfand 2012; →Nienaber et al. 2015). Moreover, trust is also a significant mediator in the association between constructive

feedback and perceived fairness of performance appraisal (→Ryu and Hong 2020).

In the organizational communication field, trust is often conceptualized as an outcome of communication behaviors. For example, a supervisory communication style that is less domineering and controlling and more supportive and empathetic predicts higher levels of trust in supervisors; communicative practices, such as active listening, open communication, small talk, and self-disclosure, are conducive for supervisors to gain trust (e.g., →Ellis and Shockley-Zalabak 2001; →Fulmer and Gelfand 2012; →Willemyns, Gallois, and Callan 2003). Overall, research on trust in S-Es has focused more on identifying factors that influence trust in supervisor than supervisor's trust in employees. One notable exception is a study by →Kelley and Bisel (2014), which examined the narrative logic by leaders in supervising roles to make sense of whether and when to trust and doubt their subordinates.

Although the positive predictive effect of trust has been supported with overwhelming evidence, →Skinner, Dietz, and Weibel (2014) challenged us to consider the potential dark side of trust, such as situations where trust becomes unwelcome obligations, or when one party decides to withdraw trust. Also, trust and distrust may not be two opposite poles of a continuum but two distinct constructs, which could be present simultaneously in a relationship (→Kelley and Bisel 2014; →Keyton and Smith 2009). To follow up on these interesting leads, research may benefit from conceptualizing S-E trust, not just as a psychological state, but as a mutually constructed process that is dialectical and dialogic.

4.2 (In)Congruence

Another expanding literature on S-E relational development centers on the effects of S-E (in)congruence. Drawing on similarity attraction theory (→Byrne 1971), earlier research examined the effects of demographic (dis)similarity, known as relational demography (→Tsui and Gutek 1999). To explain findings unaccounted for by the similarity attraction paradigm, later inquiries expanded their theoretical lens by incorporating the logic of cultural and relational norms (e.g., →Bakar, Jian, and Fairhurst 2014; →Tsui, Porter, and Egan 2002) and role congruity theory (→Eagly and Karau 2002), which argue that the effect of (dis)similarity has to be understood in conjunction with its congruence with relational and cultural norms and stereotypes. For example, gender stereotypes help explain why gender dissimilarity poses greater relational challenges for female supervisors with male employees than for male supervisors with female employees (→van Gils et al. 2018).

Despite these interesting findings, →Kacmar et al. (2008) offered evidence that deep-level perceived similarity (e.g., values, attitudes, goals, and perspectives, etc.) has stronger effect than does relational demography in predicting S-E agreement on relational quality. The interest in surface-level (dis)similarity, thus, gradually evolved into inquiries about deep-level compatibility or congruence (→Kristof-Brown, Zimmerman, and Johnson 2005). For example, according to →Li and Tangirala (2021), S-E congruence in proactive personality impacts the trajectory of employee voice over time.

In summary, with a few exceptions (e.g., →Kelley and Bisel 2014), the theoretical lens taken in the literature of S-E trust and (in)congruence has been largely social psychological. Future research can foreground communication in several ways, for example, by examining message characteristics or discursive patterns in constructing (dis)trust, identifying and contrasting patterns of interaction over time among dyads who are (in)congruent along various dimensions, or formulating and testing communicative strategies in overcoming challenges commonly associated with conflict-prone incongruent structures (e.g., younger supervisor-older employee dyads).

5 Contexts

Scholars have long recognized the importance of contexts in conditioning S-E relationships (→Jablin 1979). Although systemic theorizing about context is still lacking, empirical research in three areas, including culture, communication technology, and peer and group communication, deserves particular attention.

5.1 Culture

Despite the dominance of the US work context in S-E research, a growing number of studies have relied on samples from non-US workplaces and incorporated cultures in model building. One stream of research focuses on the moderating role of certain cultural dimensions (e.g., individualism/collectivism and masculinity/femininity) (→Hofstede 2001) on S-E development. The meta-analytic review by →Rockstuhl et al. (2012) showed that, in more egalitarian, individualistic cultures, the association of LMX with OCB, justice perceptions, job satisfaction, turnover intentions, and trust in leader is stronger than in hierarchical, collectivistic cultures. Another meta-analytic study (→Zhang et al. 2019) found the effect of abusive supervision on counterproductive work behavior more pronounced in masculine cultures than in feminine ones.

Another stream of research explores specific local cultural constructs, norms, and historical contexts that may impact S-E relational development and outcomes. For example, according to →Bakar, Jian, and Fairhurst (2014), the historical context of ethnic relations in Malaysia helped explain why ethnic similarity moderated the effects of LMX agreement on both in-role and extra-role performance of Malaysian employees. Based on the Chinese relational concept *guanxi*, →Davison, Van Dyne, and Lin (2017) found that depending on employee perception of job control, supervisor-subordinate *guanxi* could either hinder or help employee voice.

5.2 Communication Technology

Studies that investigate the use of communication technologies in S-Es are very scarce and mostly focused on email communication. For instance, employees in low LMXs reported their preference for email as a medium to express dissent, whereas those in high LMXs preferred an in-person approach (→Turnage and Goodboy 2016). In the Malaysian work context, supervisors reported their email use as an "equalizing medium" to lessen face threat and perception of imposition when communicating requests to subordinates (→Paramasivam and Subramaniam 2018). Through a series of studies, →Haesevoets et al. (2021) found that the practice of including supervisors in an email carbon copy enhanced perception of transparency but negatively impacted felt trust among coworkers and contributed to the construction of a culture of fear in organizations. Clearly, future research needs to explore how S-Es operate in the growing multi-media environment that challenges traditional boundaries and norms regarding work/life balance and privacy (see Chapter 24 on distributed collaboration).

5.3 Peers and Work Group

In the matrix of workplace relationships, S-Es are intertwined with coworker and team relationships (→Omilion-Hodges, Ptacek, and Zerilli 2016; see Chapter 17 on team process). Despite the positive individual-level outcomes of high-quality S-Es (→Dulebohn et al. 2012), multilevel research has demonstrated complex effects of LMX differentiation among S-Es on peer relationships and team performance. →Yu, Matta, and Cornfield's (2018) meta-analytic review of 4,114 workgroups showed that LMX differentiation had a direct negative association with group unity and solidarity. Such results are not surprising given the findings from previous research that have shown intricate associations between S-E relationships with peer communication (e.g., →Omilion-Hodges and Baker 2013) and

team communication (e.g., Bakar and Omilion-Hodges 2018). For example, according to →Omilion-Hodges and Baker (2013), the fairness perceptions employees derived from evaluations of their own LMX vis-à-vis coworkers' LMXs influence how employees share resources among themselves. Thus, group dynamic is interlocked with S-E relational dynamic.

In summary, the context that shapes S-Es is multilevel and multidimensional and is constantly shifting. Existing research in this regard has merely scratched the surface. To address the contextual complexity would require both theoretical and methodological innovations that can break boundaries of previously siloed growth in cognate domains. This leads to a broader critique of the S-E scholarship to which the chapter turns next.

6 Critique and Directions for Future Research

Despite the great strides S-E research has made, the review above exposed several major issues and barriers that scholars have to address in order to sustain its continued growth. First of all, fragmentation appears to be a major impediment to the progress of the S-E scholarship. This is in part a result of the historical development and greater specialization in its individual topical domains, many of which did not start from a specific interest in the S-E relational context or theory but as offshoots from other broader academic or practice fields (e.g., coaching). As a result, interdomain dialogue has been uncommon yet much needed for cross-pollination and integration to achieve greater insights. By exposing this fragmented state in this review, the SECRD framework could function as a heuristic to spur future theoretical integration.

Second, the development of a communication lens in these various domains has been uneven. Organizational communication scholars have made sustained contributions to such areas as employee voice and dissent, upward influence tactics, performance appraisal, and a communicative understanding of LMX. However, the areas of mentoring, coaching, (in)congruence, and context (e.g., culture) could benefit from a much stronger communication perspective. Communication theories also have the potential to be the integrator of or bridge across previously disparate domains, for example, by linking managerial coaching with employee voice.

Third, although LMX theory has long served as a conceptual framework to account for S-E relational development, the penetrating critique by →Gottfredson, Wright, and Heaphy (2020) and others over the years (e.g., →Sheer 2015) challenges us to step up to a higher level of conceptual and methodological complexity and rigor when

conceptualizing constructs, like LMX, trust, and their association in the S-E context. One way to help realize this change is to diversify our research discourse from the dominant post-positivist paradigm and to embrace social constructive and critical paradigms (→Sias 2014). For example, S-E scholars can borrow and build on social constructionist leadership theories grounded within a strong communication foundation (e.g., →Jian 2019, →2022; see also Chapter 7 on leadership communication) to address the inherent limitations in the post-positivist theorizing (→Sias 2014).

Fourth, methodologically, S-E research has made some significant advancements in research design (e.g., →Chen et al. 2021), statistical modeling techniques (e.g., →Wong. 2019), and measurement instruments (e.g., →Jian, Shi, and Dalisay 2014). Despite these methodological gains, studies that take a truly dyadic perspective methodologically are still in the minority (→Kim et al. 2020), even though a dyadic approach is crucial when researchers lay their theoretical claims on the interactional process (→Kim et al. 2020). Also, in correspondence to the call for paradigmatic shift mentioned above, S-E research will benefit immensely from more qualitative studies or mixed method designs to capture relational interplay, change, and adaptation over time.

Finally, transformative societal events, new information technologies, and emerging organizational forms foreground dimensions of S-E relationship which research used to gloss over or consider as contextual factors to be controlled for statistically. The COVID-19 pandemic, for example, has thrown into sharp relief the connection of the S-E relational dynamic with such issues as work/life balance, use of communication technology, and health disparity in the 21st-century workplace, which undoubtedly deserve greater scholarly attention in the future.

In conclusion, this chapter has offered a broad survey of contemporary research on S-E relationship in the workplace that has previously been strewn across diverse disciplines and research fields. Foregrounding communication, the chapter introduces the SECRD nomological framework to integrate the fragmented S-E research domains with the hope to spur future interdisciplinary dialogue and cross-pollination. By zooming in and contrasting these various research areas, the chapter sheds light on the gaps and limitations that could spawn exciting opportunities for the future growth of S-E communication research.

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Chapter 17 Team Process

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Abstract

This chapter synthesizes and frames team process literature according to a constitutive four-flows model of organizational communication (→McPhee and Zaug 2009), an extension of structuration theory. A four-flows lens on team process shifts researchers' attention away from input, process, and output variables (common in the prevailing systems theory view of teams), in favor of asking how team communication processes and practices unfold and to what effects. The flows refer to broad types of communication that enact organizational experiences, including communication by which members: (1) act out aspects of their organizational role (referred to as membership negotiation), (2) work together to accomplish tasks (activity coordination), (3) structure and regulate their interactions and the scope of their work (reflexive self-structuring), and (4) align with or depart from practices of neighboring organizations in a broader social and institutional context (institutional positioning). This chapter also considers a fifth flow, syncretic superstructure (→Lutgen-Sandvik and McDermott 2008) which speaks to ways that broader societal factors influence team organizing processes. Considering team processes through a four-flows lens shifts our focus from asking how inputs and processes (or throughputs) lead to outputs, to asking how patterns of communication constitute, or build, organizational experiences and realities.

Keywords: communication constitutes organization (CCO), communicative flows, input-process-output (IPO), four flows, structuration theory, systems theory, team, team process, teamwork, throughput,

For the past several decades, team research has benefited from using systems theory to inform theorizing and inquiry. However, researchers are increasingly asking questions, proposing hypotheses, and conducting research that stretches beyond the scope of a systems theory explanation. In this chapter, we make a bold claim: that research on teams has outgrown systems theory, and that it needs a new framing theory to address limitations and advance the domain. Toward that end, we propose that a communication as constitutive of organization (CCO)

explanation for team process, grounded in structurational 'four flows' theorizing (hereafter referred to as 'flows', →McPhee and Zaug 2009), provides a way forward for thinking about the generative mechanisms of teams – namely, their communication patterns and practices – that shape their work together.

There is a vast body of research on teams and teamwork, and numerous valuable comprehensive reviews of the field (among others, see →Kozlowski and Chao 2018; →Marlow et al. 2018; →Mathieu et al. 2017; →Nielsen, Hrivnak, and Shaw 2009; →Rousseau, Aubé, and Savoie 2006; →Salas, Reyes, and McDaniel 2018). The goal of this chapter is not to reproduce these reviews. Instead, this chapter highlights notions of team 'process' common in that work, and situates them in relation to understandings about process grounded in the organizational communication subfield. This approach highlights lingering questions and possible research directions about team process for researchers and practitioners across disciplines.

There are several reasons why it is a good time to revisit the idea of team process. First, the team research arena (management, psychology, social psychology) has become laden with lists of variables corresponding with inputs, processes/throughputs, and outputs (IPO) in linear models. These linear models reflect prevailing systems theory explanations of team process. Second, in recent decades, researchers have begun embracing cyclical models, a preference that throws into question where team processes begin and end, and which variables count as independent and dependent variables. Third, recent research has struggled to identify the role of 'emergent states' in teams, particularly how they come about and what effects they impose on teams. Importantly, each of these developments in team research poses important questions about how team 'processes' unfold and to what effects.

This chapter provides an alternative way to frame and synthesize the team literature by grounding it in a constitutive view of communication, specifically, the 'four flows' model of organizational communication (→McPhee and Zaug 2009), an extension of structuration theory. Generally, the value of applying a constitutive *flows* lens to understanding team process is that it shifts researcher's attention away from input, throughput, and output variables, and instead is open to asking how team communication processes and practices unfold and to what effects. Specifically, the *flows* refer to broad types of communication that enact organizational experiences, including communication by which members: (1) act out aspects of their organizational role (referred to as membership negotiation), (2) work together to accomplish tasks (activity coordination), (3) structure and regulate their interactions and the scope of their work

(reflexive self-structuring), and (4) align with or depart from practices of neighboring organizations in a broader social and institutional context (institutional positioning). This chapter also considers a fifth flow, syncretic superstructure (→Lutgen-Sandvik and McDermott 2008), which speaks to ways that broader societal factors influence team organizing processes. Examining team processes through a constitutive flows lens shifts our focus from asking how inputs and processes (or throughputs) lead to outputs, to asking how patterns of communication constitute, or build, team members' experiences.

This chapter proceeds as follows: first, we provide a basic overview about how teams and teamwork are conceptualized from a systems theory perspective, focusing on the input-process-output, or IPO, model. Second, the chapter walks through main points about team process literature, highlighting both limitations of the work and areas ready for future development, namely, team process, emergent states, and multilevel influences on teamwork. We then propose an alternative framing theory for understanding team process: the flows model (→McPhee and Zaug 2009) of constitutive communication, which is an extension of structuration theory (→Giddens 1984). The rest of the chapter conceptualizes team process from a flows lens, highlighting new possibilities for research on, and intervention into, team processes.

1 Foundations for Discussion

1.1 What Is a 'Team'?

Teams can be defined as entities with two or more people who are interdependent with one another to achieve common goals while being embedded in organizations. Teams display some unique characteristics: (a) members interact in dynamic ways as the team adapts to fluctuating demands; (b) there is a division of labor such that different members are responsible for different tasks; (c) members coordinate their efforts to accomplish a shared goal, and their collective performance depends on team cohesion and interpersonal trust (→Salas et al. 1992; →Mach, Dolan, and Tzafrir 2010).

Teams (and workgroups) fall under the umbrella of a 'group'. Broadly, a group is defined as a collection of people who are mutually aware of their membership in the collective and who interact to fulfill a commonly held goal (→Langfred 1998). Many scholars have used the terms 'team' and 'workgroup' synonymously (see →Kozlowski and Ilgen 2006; →Kozlowski and Bell 2013; →Breuer, Hüffmeier, Hertel 2016; →Dietz et al. 2017; →Razinskas and Hoegl 2020), while others have distinguished

between them (see →Katzenbach and Smith 1993). The term ‘team’ tends to be more popular in management studies, while the term ‘workgroup’ appears more often in non-management disciplines (→Cohen and Bailey 1997).

When scholars have made a distinction between teams and workgroups, they have differentiated these concepts based on three common criteria. First, teams tend to exhibit a greater degree of interdependence than groups. Interdependence in teams goes beyond members’ reliance on each other for expertise at the individual level; a mix of dependencies on skill sets distinguishes teams from groups. In closely interdependent teams, that includes mutual participation in members’ social spheres; such intimacy provides team members opportunities to support, interpret, and challenge each other to develop a deeper appreciation of the overall strengths and weaknesses that exist in the team (→Katzenbach and Smith 1993).

Second, team members tend to exhibit a higher level of commitment to their collective goals than do workgroup members (→Katzenbach and Smith 1993). Team members expect each other to be strong performers and hold each other accountable to achieve organizational and personal growth goals (→Katzenbach and Smith 1993), although factors such as psychological closeness and length of the group’s duration also matter (→Cleveland et al. 2011). Authors tend to idealize teams by suggesting how organizations might transform their workgroups into teams (→Blumberg et al. 2012).

Third, teams tend to be better than groups at fostering ‘synergy’, meaning that members prioritize team successes that lie both beyond their individual achievement, and that affect them at a visceral level (→Katzenbach and Smith 1993). “Unlike working groups, whose performance depends solely on optimizing individual contributions, real team performance requires impact beyond the sum of the individual parts” (→Katzenbach and Smith 1993: 132). Synergy becomes possible through members’ tightly coupled interdependencies that help them develop deep understanding of each other’s competencies and weaknesses. The next section problematizes team process according to the input-process-output (IPO) model from systems theory.

1.2 Explaining Team Process Using Systems Theory

Much of the team literature is grounded in systems theory, which posits that a team, when conceptualized as a system, is “a set of interdependent components that form an internally organized whole that operates as one in relation to its environment and to other systems” (→Poole 2013: 50). A

main premise of systems theory is that the whole of any system is greater than the sum of its parts. In other words, the product a team of people builds together will be more complex and encompassing than anything an individual member could produce independently (→Marks, Mathieu, and Zaccaro 2001). Team members' actions are interdependent, meaning they rely on each other to do their part toward a common goal. Members work interdependently to accomplish taskwork and collective goals by converting inputs to outputs using various cognitive, verbal, and behavioral processes (→Mathieu et al. 2017).

Teams are viewed as dynamic, complex, adaptive, and open systems that are affected by and in turn affect, their environment. Central to the systems theory conceptualization of teams is the input/process/output (IPO) model describing team function (→Kozlowski and Ilgen 2006; →Salas, Reyes, and McDaniel 2018). *Inputs* can be divided into three categories: individual-, team-, and environment-level inputs (→Mohammed and McKay 2017). Individual-level inputs represent the characteristics of team members (e.g., knowledge, personal background). Team-level inputs are team-level factors that can affect group processes (e.g., norms, team culture, team size). Finally, environmental inputs comprise characteristics of the environment where the team is embedded.

Processes, also referred to as throughputs (→Katz and Kahn 1966; →Henman 2003), can be defined as the activity that team members participate in to convert inputs into outputs. Thus, members may use their knowledge (input) to convert raw data (process) into tangible outputs in the form of charts and graphs to explain an organization's fiscal performance (output). Such processes leading to an outcome can include communication patterns, cognitive activities, and decision-making practices to name a few. Inputs drive these processes, which behave like interconnected series of developments that reveal themselves gradually (→Poole 2013).

An *output* is the consequence of processed team inputs. Outputs are either concrete and tangible, or abstract and subtle. For example, a concrete output might include the development and implementation of strategies to train incoming employees, along with the assessment of those strategies and their implementation. Subtle outputs can include psychological changes such as members' attitudes, or their approach to decision-making. Teams are held accountable for their outputs in a few ways: people external to the team judge the value of a team's outputs; internally, team members assess the extent an output meets their collective standards and, if needed, make changes to inputs and processes (→Hackman 1987; →Kozlowski and Ilgen 2006). Producing concrete outputs (e.g., achieving a team goal) is desirable; however, the longevity

of the team usually depends on rather intangible outputs (e.g., team (dis)satisfaction or (dis)harmony). Extant literature leans towards the exploration of more concrete team outputs, perhaps because they can be more easily measured (→Mohammed and McKay 2017).

The IPO model follows a causal logic explaining that the structure of any system (e.g., a team) and its individual components are accountable for the functioning of the whole team (→Frey 2004; →Mohammed and McKay 2017). The interdependent actions that bring about a holistic output include ongoing, collective activities like taskwork (the to-do list) and teamwork (the interpersonal processes by which members coordinate and cooperate with each other) (→Mathieu and Rapp 2009). Examples of teamwork processes include mission analysis, goal specification, formulating strategies, monitoring progress, coordinating with team members, conflict management, and so on (→Marlow et al. 2018). Further, systems theory assumes that teams are multilevel phenomena. They exist within organizational boundaries, and organizations exist within societal boundaries (→Kozlowski and Chao 2018). Each level of the system can provide additional inputs that ultimately inform the team's processes and outputs.

Systems theory, particularly the IPO model, is a mainstay of post-positivist research on teams in communication and other disciplines (management, social psychology). However, because the communication discipline is relatively pluralistic in its use of theoretical perspectives, communication research has explained team-based communication phenomena using various perspectives and methodologies, such as structuration theory (→DeSanctis and Poole 1994; →Poole, Seibold, and McPhee 1985, →1996; →Seibold and Meyers 2007), socialization (→Myers and McPhee 2006), a constitutive lens (→Jahn 2016), coordination (see Chapter 12 in this volume on coordination), collaboration (see Chapter 24 in this volume on distributed collaboration), and symbolic interactionism (→Frey 2004). A later section will differentiate how some researchers in the communication discipline define communication as an ongoing, constitutive process, compared to other fields' definitions of it as a single event or discretionary decision, or their focus on communication amount or type (see →Marlow et al. 2018).

In sum, this section has briefly summarized the IPO model and its uses. The next section points to three conceptual areas – process, emergent states, and multilevel influences on teams – where IPO-based research on teams is challenging systems theory's explanatory power.

1.3 Limitations of a Systems-Based Model for Team Process

This section synthesizes reasons IPO-based team researchers critique the ability of the IPO model to explain process, emergent states, and multilevel influences on teams. The IPO model is an enduring heuristic for group and team research and theorizing (→Salas, Reyes, and McDaniel 2018; →Rousseau, Aubé, and Savoie 2006). However, in recent years, scholars have voiced concern that the linearity of the IPO model is unrealistic, noting that the straightforward relationships depicted between inputs, processes, and outputs rarely unfold so simplistically in real team settings (→Salas, Reyes, and McDaniel 2018). As a result, scholars have expanded the IPO model, creating more complex variations of the original – adding on numerous contextual variables, mediators, and triggers, to more closely mirror real-life group scenarios (e.g., →Ilgen et al. 2005). Adaptations to the IPO model have enabled scholars to present a more complicated and realistic view of team and workgroup interactions. Unfortunately, using these adapted IPO models gives scholars the nearly impossible task of predicting outcomes by quantitatively recognizing every mediator, trigger, and feedback loop imaginable. A related limitation is the inability for IPO models to account for a given variable's behavior once feedback loops are introduced (→Mathieu et al. 2008). That is, factors initially recognized as outputs can cycle back into the system as inputs to catalyze the existing team environment.

A second limitation of IPO-informed team research is that scholars have struggled to identify the role of 'emergent states' in teams, particularly how they come about and what effects they impose on teams. Generally, *emergence* is a systems theory principle that helps explain how interactions between system components create the system itself (→Poole 2013). Specifically, an *emergent state* refers to the affective and/or cognitive state of a team, and typically is defined as a dynamic property of a team that varies based on context, as well as inputs, processes, and outputs (→Mathieu et al. 2017). Examples of emergent states include motivation, shared mental models, psychological safety, cohesiveness, and procedural justice climate. Formulaic methods such as IPO models that try to understand and predict synergistic outcomes by using vast lists of variables may not work effectively because team synergy can lead to unexpected outcomes that surpass the components and imagination of the team.

A third limitation of IPO-informed team research is that it treats multilevel influences on teams primarily as inputs (→Mohammed and McKay 2017), which limits scholars' ability to explain how earlier patterns of behavior serve as precedents for later patterns, or how team processes

might have reciprocal effects on a broader organization. IPO scholars accept the assumption that individuals are embedded in teams, teams are embedded in organizations, and organizations are embedded within an environment (and so on) (→Guzzo and Dickson 1996). Yet, even though systems theory provides a multilevel explanation for phenomena, the IPO model limits scholars' ability to theorize how team processes are entrenched in organizational, occupational, regional, national, and other kinds of cultures, identities, and ideologies.

The next section heeds calls from team scholars to explore qualitative and longitudinal work on teams (→Canary 2018; →Mohammed and McKay 2017), and add precision to our understanding of team process (→Marks, Mathieu, and Zaccaro 2001), emergent states (→De Dreu and Weingart 2003), and multilevel influences on teams (→Kozlowski and Chao 2018). Toward that end, the section discusses how organizational communication scholars have used a constitutive metamodel to understand how communication, in effect, builds team members' social realities and their collective trajectories of action. Of particular interest is scholars' use of structurational flows theorizing to conceptualize and study team communication processes.

2 Structurational Flows Theorizing: An Alternative Framing Theory for Team Process Research

In contrast to the main premise of systems theory, which is that the whole of a system is greater than the sum of its parts, the main premise of structuration theory is that any group, broadly speaking (e.g., society, organization, team, family), is defined by the patterns of behavior in which they engage (→Giddens 1984). Structuration theory has been used as a social theory to explicate the structure (rules and norms) and interaction patterns of teams (→Poole, Seibold, and McPhee 1996; →Seibold and Meyers 2007). Authored by sociologist Anthony Giddens, structuration is a metatheory explaining how everyday interactions use rules and resources in a system in specific ways to create and recreate the system (→Canary 2018; →Schoeneborn et al. 2014). Structuration helps researchers investigate how unique organizational systems are constituted through people's everyday communicative, relational, and behavioral patterns, or in other words, *regularities* in actions and interactions that create structures (→Poole 2013).

2.1 Conceptualizing Teams According to Flows Theorizing

In adopting a constitutive communication-based framing theory for team research it is important to differentiate conceptualizations of communication from one another. Outside of the communication field, communication is often seen as a *transmission* of information from one person's mind to that of another – the 'transmission model' (→Putnam and Boys 2006). Further, in quantitative studies on teamwork, communication, when conceptualized as a variable (e.g., as amount or type of communication), becomes stripped of its potential to explain how team processes unfold. →Marlow and colleagues' (2018) meta-review of communication in team processes exemplifies how the transmission model permeates team research outside of the communication field. They define communication as: "an exchange of information, occurring through both verbal and nonverbal (e.g., email) channels, between two or more team members" (→Marlow et al. 2018: 146). In particular, Marlow and colleagues reviewed communication-oriented quantitative studies noting how independent variables – such as the clarity of messages, frequency of member interaction, and the extent of knowledge sharing – contributed to team performance (a dependent variable). →Marlow et al. (2018) emphasize the centrality and importance of communication for teamwork, noting that "team communication is conceptualized as integral to a majority of team processes or interdependent team behaviors that lead to outcomes such as performance" (p. 146). Importantly, communication generally enhances team performance by facilitating crucial team processes, enabling emergent states to develop (e.g., team cognition), and distributing task information.

Structuration theory brought the emphasis from a variable-led approach to teams back to processes, placing emphasis on mundane communicative interactions between members. It has spawned the development of communication-centric theories that emphasize the importance of communicative processes in the creation of organizations. One such approach, flows theorizing, asserts that organizations are constituted through the interaction of types of communicative or interaction processes, referred to as 'flows' (→McPhee and Zaug 2009). The flows are briefly defined here and expanded upon in a later section; they include: (1) membership negotiation, (2) activity coordination, (3) reflexive self-structuring, (4) institutional positioning, and we add, (5) syncretic superstructure.

Membership negotiation pertains to members' connections with their organizational role – its scope, and how it compares with other roles. Membership negotiation becomes important during team processes

because it impacts whether, and the extent to which, members can participate in (and impact) team processes.

Activity coordination refers to members' connections with each other through patterns of unfolding action that accomplish a team's tasks or goals. Activity coordination explains team processes by which people come together to accomplish collective goals.

Reflexive self-structuring pertains to the team's connection to formal organizational procedures, policies, rules, and hierarchy. These elements of an organization's governance structure connect disparate organizational roles and purposes toward a cohesive whole pursing a unified vision (→McPhee and Zaug 2009).

Institutional positioning refers to ways a particular organization positions itself in relation to other similar organizations in an industry or sector (→McPhee and Zaug 2009). We might expect to see institutional positioning impacting team processes when norms from a profession or industry filter into a team and make a difference in how members accomplish work.

A fifth flow, proposed by →Lutgen-Sandvik and McDermott (2008) is *syncretic superstructure*, which refers to broader societal discourses and influences, or a "shifting macrosystem of meaning schemas from which organizations emerge and in which they are suspended" (p. 310). The descriptor, syncretic, refers to the idea that societal discourses and meanings are readily available to draw from, but they remain only partly integrated and are always unfinished (→Lutgen-Sandvik and McDermott 2008). Further, the syncretic superstructure *flow* is not so much a message type (like the other flows), but rather is a broader meaning schema that lends cultural and historical context to explain how the other flows operate in a given communication episode or pattern.

2.2 Communicative Constitution of Team Process

A key assumption of flows theorizing is that moments of communicative constitution unfold when two or more flows intersect with one another (→McPhee and Zaug 2009). That is, intersecting flows are constitutive moments in which members instantiate, maintain, change, or ignore some aspect of organizational structure (→McPhee and Zaug 2009). *Membership negotiation* intersects with other flows to enable and constrain the scope, enactment, and impact of a particular role, and vice versa. *Activity coordination* intersects with other flows, highlighting the socialization, norms, pressures, and incentives that animate how a team gets things done. *Reflexive self-structuring* intersects with other flows to provide a sense of structure or sequence to accomplishing work.

Institutional positioning intersects with other flows to introduce influences to team interactions that are broader or further removed from the team- or organizational-levels of analysis – for instance from across an industry, sector, or type of institution (e.g., educational, governmental, religious). Finally, *syncretic superstructure* intersects with other flows, introducing broad cultural norms, influences, and discourses that influence team goals, values, and processes.

3 Shifting Focus on Team Process Using a Flows Framing Theory

Applying communicative flows theorizing as an alternative framing theory for team research requires researchers to shift analytical focus in important ways: first, we recommend researchers assume that team interaction processes are cyclical such that previous action patterns can influence later action in ways that reproduce, omit, change, or begin new patterns. Second, we recommend researchers attend to communicative interactions in which interdependence between or among members becomes salient – moments of interdependence likely will point to intersecting flows. Third, we recommend researchers consider more complex operational definitions for communication. That is, instead of focusing on communication amount, quality, or type, we suggest considering entire interaction episodes and communication practices as units of analysis (e.g., single meetings, communication practices and norms during meetings, sequences of meetings across a project's timeline). Analyzing these communication patterns and practices longitudinally, the researcher can explain how beneficial and dysfunctional practices became entrenched and to what effects.

3.1 Intersecting Flows and Their Effects on Team Processes

A constitutive lens looking for intersecting flows within team processes must consider that any flow could make a difference to team process at any time, and that a flow might bring influences into team processes that are relatively far removed from the action of teamwork (e.g., institutional positioning, syncretic superstructure). This section explains what occurs, and what types of phenomena become salient where flows cross, starting with proposing how flows intersect with membership negotiation, activity coordination, reflexive self-structuring, institutional positioning, and syncretic superstructure (→Table 1).

Table 1: How Flows Intersect and to What Effects.

Flow	Intersecting flow	Description of intersecting flows	Example concept(s)
Membership Negotiation	Syncretic Superstructure	The ways and extent to which societal norms value roles, functions, professions; norms for including roles in teamwork and decisions	Participation and impact in knowledge construction (→Hansen and Canary 2015)
	Institutional Positioning	How the norms from an industry impact the function, valuing of a role on a team	Status ordering based on professional prestige (→Poole 2003)
	Reflexive Self-Structuring	How the role is enabled, empowered, or constrained to draw from, leverage, or be subject to policies, procedures, rules, resources	Collaborative/teamwork climate (→Hansen and Canary 2015) Role shaping from previous org. experiences (→Endacott and Myers 2019) Assimilation into a role in relation to other roles on the team (→Scott and Myers 2010)
	Activity Coordination	How the scope and purpose of a role is utilized and included in ongoing activity	Knowledge coordination (→Hansen and Canary 2015) Assimilation into contributing to a team (→Endacott and Myers 2019)
Activity Coordination	Syncretic Superstructure	How societal norms, values, cultural differences come to bear on ongoing activity	Cross-cultural teamwork, collaboration
	Institutional Positioning	How an institution's or industry's standards get adopted/translated in ongoing activity	Multi-organizational collaboration Responsive affiliations (ad hoc teams; →Jahn and Johansson 2018)
	Reflexive Self-Structuring	How policies, hierarchies, rules, resources get invoked in, inform, get reproduced or altered in ongoing activities	Adaptive structuring practices (→Jahn and Johansson 2018) Knowledge construction (e.g., scientific method, research process, decision-making procedures)
Reflexive Self-Structuring	Syncretic Superstructure	How societal norms get translated into 'best' practices or aspirational policies and practices	Diversity, equity, inclusion (→Mease 2016)
	Institutional Positioning	How an institution's or industry's 'standards' get	Sector-related stabilizing structuring practices (→Jahn

Flow	Intersecting flow	Description of intersecting flows	Example concept(s)
		translated and reproduced in organizational policies and practices	and Johansson 2018)
Institutional Positioning	Syncretic Superstructure	How societal values and discourses get incorporated and isomorph across a society's institutions	Democratic/egalitarian values Hierarchy Diversity, equity, inclusion (→Mease 2016)

3.1.1 Membership Negotiation's Intersection with Other Flows

Membership negotiation refers to how organization members learn and navigate the expectations of their occupation and role, and how they see themselves and others relative to other's roles (→McPhee and Zaug 2009). Membership negotiation can be operationalized as references to priorities or expectations associated with a role, rank, position description, or scope of one's control or responsibility, or references to acting out values or norms of a broader profession. IPO-based team researchers evoke the membership negotiation flow when they examine variables related to composition-of-members-based demographic categories, identities (e.g., role, occupational, organizational, national), role expectations, and supervisor/subordinate or leader/follower relationships (see also Chapter 6 in this volume on supervisor-employee communication). Further, the other flows intersect with this one, helping to explain how and why membership negotiation is enabled and constrained.

First, we might consider how membership negotiation intersects with syncretic superstructure to explain why one's participation in, and impact on, knowledge construction processes reflect societal norms related to how roles, professions (and so forth) are valued in decision-making processes. For example, →Hansen and Canary (2015) examined a university campus taskforce aiming to solve facilities-related problems; it consisted of administrator managers and facilities management workers. Even though the facilities managers were the most knowledgeable about facilities-related problems, managers communicated a dismissive attitude toward those recommendations by acting on broader cultural discourses around which some professions have higher status than others (i.e., manager vs. worker). The impact of syncretic superstructure intersecting with membership negotiation was that broader cultural discourses that marginalized facilities managers impacted their membership negotiation resulting in their voices making less of a difference in shaping taskforce decisions.

Second, we might look where membership negotiation intersects with institutional positioning to impact how the norms from an industry impact the function and valuing of a role on a team. For example, →Poole (2003) described a medical team that set up a pattern of interaction that was meant to encourage diverse opinions and give members an equal say (membership negotiation), but in the end everyone ended up deferring to the doctors/MDs, mirroring the deference they showed in other contexts that imposed the rigid hierarchical order common across medical contexts (institutional positioning). This helps explain why well-intentioned invitations to contribute to a team might not result in everyone participating.

Third, membership negotiation intersects with reflexive self-structuring to shape how a role is enabled, empowered, or constrained to draw from, leverage, or be subject to policies, procedures, rules, and resources. One way these flows might intersect is in shaping a team's collaborative climate. →Hansen and Canary (2015) found that the collaborative climate on the university facilities task force became dysfunctional because those with the most expertise about policies, rules, and resources about facilities were routinely undermined by manager's actions. That is, managers tended to dictate jobs, procedures, and tasks while dismissing the value of engaging facilities management workers in participatory decision-making. The result of these actions was that facilities workers experienced less agency in the conduct of their roles.

Another example of membership negotiation and reflexive self-structuring intersecting is when members new to an organization shape their role based on the rules, procedures, and resources they used in their previous experiences in other organizations. →Endacott and Myers, (2019) found that knowledge about the formal elements of a role derived from experience in a different organization was particularly empowering for members when their current organization valued it; when the current organization did not value such knowledge, members felt especially disconnected from their team.

Fourth, where membership negotiation and activity coordination intersect, we expect to see how the scope and purpose of a role is utilized and included in ongoing activity. For instance, →Hansen and Canary (2015) demonstrated how knowledge coordination was hindered by exclusionary boundaries that managers raised between themselves and facilities workers. Managers belittled those who were not in management, showed apathy toward others, avoided building relationships between managers and facilities workers, concealed important information, and failed to share accountability for collective outcomes. All these actions perpetuated inefficiencies and a dysfunctional working culture in which

workers were reluctant to trust managers. This lack of trust both isolated and marginalized facilities workers, while hindering the campus's broader change initiative for all units to be more 'entrepreneurial'.

3.1.2 *Activity Coordination's Intersection with Other Flows*

Activity coordination refers to how organization members cooperate with one another to accomplish goal-directed activities requiring interdependent contributions (→McPhee and Zaug 2009). Activity coordination can be operationally defined as references to previous communicative interactions; discussing unfolding circumstances, options, plans, and desired outcomes, and references to actions that unfolded over time. IPO-based team researchers evoke activity coordination when they research variables related to emerging processes leading toward various outcomes (e.g., taskwork). The specific patterns of action and interaction by which teams accomplish activity coordination can be further explained by ways flows intersect with activity coordination – each flow bringing a different set of expectations for how the team process should unfold, why, and to what effects.

First, where activity coordination intersects with syncretic superstructure, we can explain how societal norms, values, and cultural differences matter in ongoing activity. For example, the team process dynamics on a cross-cultural team could be explained at this intersection of flows because it draws attention to ways that broad cultural discourses might clash in a cross-cultural team's efforts to work together. Another example is 'diversity work', which is an extension from broader social justice discourses. →Mease (2016) concluded that doing diversity work involves translating social justice discourse (syncretic superstructure) into trajectories of action within an organizational context. She found that diversity consultants tend to draw on different definitions of 'diversity' to serve various ends – a broad definition of diversity encourages all members to raise their ideas and to participate, while a narrow definition of diversity specifically acknowledges legacies of marginalization based on race, gender, and other differences. Mease found that the broad definition was helpful to support an organization's legitimacy relative to similar organizations regarding the sector's efforts at diversity work (institutional positioning), while the narrow definition informed how consultants tailored diversity programs and conversations (activity coordination) based on the organization's culture and training needs.

Second, activity coordination and institutional positioning intersect to impact how an institution's or industry's standards get adopted in

ongoing activity among multi-organizational collaborations, or multi-organizational ad hoc teams. For example, →Jahn and Johansson (2018) examined a series of conference calls in which representatives from a range of Swedish municipalities, agencies, and services (e.g., insurance) coordinated to provide public information about a large wildfire encroaching on communities. Here institutional positioning and activity coordination intersected to create a 'responsive affiliation' of representatives from various governmental institutions to coordinate public information together. The inter-agency collaborators brought institutional norms and expectations into the team's work that were generally shared across their agencies; these shared sector-wide norms enabled the group to collaborate efficiently because its members already had a recognizable template for organizing themselves.

Third, activity coordination and reflexive self-structuring intersect to shape how policies, hierarchies, rules, and resources get invoked, inform, reproduce, or change in ongoing activities. For example, →Jahn and Johansson (2018) showed how multiple government agencies worked together to develop 'adaptive structuring practices' as they adapted their collective priorities and procedures for working together as needs evolved as the wildfire event unfolded.

3.1.3 *Reflexive Self-Structuring's Intersection with Other Flows*

Reflexive self-structuring refers to the governance structure that holds the organization together as a differentiated, yet purposeful whole (→McPhee and Zaug 2009). Examples of such governing structures include formal/documented rules, procedures and chain of command (or hierarchy) specific to the team, organization, or profession. Reflexive self-structuring can be operationally defined as references to formal authority tied to hierarchy, rules, procedures, policies, or past precedents for action. IPO-based team researchers refer to reflexive self-structuring when they examine variables related to processes, such as how genres of action lead toward certain outcomes, and factors that contribute to members taking processes (or structures) seriously. Reflexive self-structuring will intersect with other flows in ways that impact the formal processes, policies, and chains of command that organize a team's ongoing activities.

First, when reflexive self-structuring intersects with syncretic superstructure, we might expect to focus on how societal norms get translated into 'best' practices or aspirational policies and practices. Examples include translating social justice discourse into practices for diversity work, adapting environmentalism discourses into sustainability

procedures and practices, and adopting public health campaigns into organizational wellness programs – all of which can possibly impact team processes depending on the extent to which members, teams, and organizations prioritize such initiatives (→Mease 2016).

Second, the intersection of reflexive self-structuring and institutional positioning focuses attention on how an institution's or industry's 'standards' get translated and reproduced in organizational policies and practices. For instance, →Jahn and Johansson (2018) examined how representatives from an array of governmental organizations coordinated in an ad hoc manner to provide public information about a wildfire. Their efficiency in organizing themselves was partly attributable to their use of a standard meeting process, familiar across all representatives' agencies, which lent order and predictability to the meetings and allowed all members to know when in the meeting to share what types of information. This 'stabilizing structuring practice' began with roll call, reporting of public information needs, and current public communication activities representatives were currently conducting (→Jahn and Johansson 2018).

3.1.4 *Institutional Positioning's Intersection with Syncretic Superstructure*

Institutional positioning refers to communication and coordination with, and influences from, outside organizations within the larger social system (e.g., of a profession). Institutional positioning can be operationalized as references to ways other organizations are shaping work in this organization, and competition between or among organizations. IPO-based team researchers engage with institutional positioning when they examine how norms for teamwork are isomorphic across organizations, professions, or national cultures.

The intersection of institutional positioning with syncretic superstructure directs attention to ways an institution's or industry's 'standards' get translated and reproduced in organizational policies and practices. This intersection of flows brings attention to societal priorities that get adopted within sectors in ways that lend credibility to an organization that participates in it. One example is *kaizen*, a Japanese ethos for quality management that involves all employees making gradual efforts to improve productivity and overall efficiency. A *kaizen* approach has been adopted across sectors that engage in manufacturing (automobile industry, factory food production, aerospace manufacturing), and that seek to minimize error (e.g., medical facilities). Also, corporate social responsibility initiatives might engage social justice causes,

environmental sustainability, or health and wellness for employees. Another example would be organizational structures normative to a given institution or sector – military and paramilitary organizations might demonstrate their legitimacy among similar organizations by emphasizing their deference to hierarchy, while start-up companies might emphasize democratic or egalitarian values. In each of these cases, we expect that cultural discourses and practices that a sector values would permeate into organizations to impact their team's priorities and how they work together (see also Chapter 24 in this volume on stakeholders and organizational change).

4 Conclusion

This chapter has argued that research on teams has outgrown systems theory, and that teams scholarship needs a new framing theory to address limitations and advance the domain. Toward that end, we propose that a communication as constitutive of organization (CCO) explanation for team process, grounded in structurational 'flows' theorizing, provides a way forward for thinking about the generative mechanisms of teams – namely, their communication patterns and practices – that produce trajectories of action. In particular, we note three limitations of systems-based theorizing about teams (i.e., process, emergent states, and multilevel influences on teams) that can be addressed and extended when applying a flows model of CCO as a framing theory for team research.

Our proposal that team research should shift from a systems-based framing theory to a structurational flows framing theory requires an analytical shift away from deductive uses of the IPO model, and toward abductive engagement with ongoing team processes that evince previous 'structures'. A structuration perspective on teams focuses on how team members *structure the processes* that move them toward accomplishing collective goals, such as argumentation (→Seibold and Meyers 2007) and decision-making (→Poole, Seibold, and McPhee 1996). That is, structuring alludes to arranging or designing interaction patterns.

Similar to a systems view, a flows lens on team process zooms in on sites where interdependent action is salient (e.g., task accomplishment). However, a key difference between the two perspectives is that IPO models tend to be linear, while structuration-based models are cyclical and process-oriented. In particular, a systems-based analysis examines the collection of relevant variables at play in collective team action (e.g., team composition, emergent states) that contribute to dependent outcomes. Importantly, IPO models terminate at a linear outcome. In

comparison, a structuration-based view of teams focuses specifically on *patterns of interaction* – particularly how past patterns of action act as a precedent to structure current action, and how mundane communicative moves do or do not make a difference to structure (or restructure) interaction patterns in ways that might inform future action in new ways.

We propose that communicative flows theorizing can be useful for understanding team process because it acts as a diagnostic tool that can help IPO researchers identify and prioritize which variables are most salient in team processes. Instead of asking what processes and outcomes emerge, and answering the question by pointing to specific inputs, a flows view of team process asks: what patterns of interaction emerged? How do those patterns evince ways that various flows intersected, or became interdependent with each other, over the course of a team's work together? The value of this alternative approach is that it allows for a more parsimonious understanding of process that avoids creating lists of input and outcome variables, and instead, gives researchers a more flexible and simplified framework for naming and tracking how various flows are shaping ongoing team processes and toward what effects.

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Chapter 18 Networks

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Abstract

This chapter explores how researchers have examined organizational communication through the lens of social networks. It begins by introducing the concept of network thinking, which emphasizes how networks can be understood both as a structure and as an organizing logic. The chapter then delves into an informal systematic review, summarizing and critiquing the existing literature on social networks and organizational communication. This includes networks as an explanation (i.e., a predictor variable), networks as an outcome (i.e., a dependent variable), and networks as the focus of novel theory construction. Drawing from various empirical studies, the chapter then explores how social network analysis has been used in an organizational communication context. It discusses the most common and uncommon network measures and models. All in all, the chapter concludes with theoretical and empirical gaps based on the review, including (1) expanding upon outcomes predicted by social networks, (2) more consideration of environmental and macro factors in network theorizing, (3) more progress towards novel organizational communication network theories, and (4) continuing to pursue longitudinal designs.

Keywords: brokerage, capitalization theories, centrality, contagion theories, homophily, intraorganizational network, interorganizational networks, egocentric networks, explanans, explanandum, multiplexity, network, network strength, network theory, network thinking, popularity, reciprocity, relational states, relational events, representational networks, structure, theories of networks, tie range, transitivity, weak ties,

A network is simply a “set of *entities* connected by one or more *relations*” (→Contractor and Forbush 2017: 1, emphasis added). Not surprisingly, in organizational communication, the ‘relation’ often represents some sort of communicative behavior, whether it be a transmission of information, a co-construction of reality, a public affiliation, or a shared interpretation. Likewise, the word ‘entities’ largely defines the context because those nodes often represent something ‘organizational’. For instance, we might look at employees inside an organization, organizations connected to

other organizations, or various organizational texts (e.g., mission statements, reports).

Organizational communication scholars have been studying networks for a long time. If you were going to look for a first major treatise on the topic, →Farace, Monge, and Russell's (1977) book *Communicating and Organizing* would probably be a good place to start. Their ideas began to unpeel the organizational onion, demonstrating the shrouded ways in which organizing was accomplished beyond the traditional workflow chart. Since then, studies of networks in organizational communication contexts have escalated and show no signs of slowing down (→Contractor and Forbush 2017). The purpose of this chapter is to review some of the more recent research on this topic and provide recommendations to further propel its growth. However, before such a review can surface, it is important to situate the reader into why organizational communication scholars might be interested in networks in the first place.

1 What Is Network Thinking?

Organizational communication researchers do not conduct network research because they enjoy looking at matrices all day. Instead, there is a guiding spirit motivating the study of networks. We can roughly call this *network thinking*. Rather than an explicit theory with clear propositions, network thinking is more about an orientation towards viewing social phenomena, especially within and between organizations (see →Table 1). As such, what constitutes this orientation? What did it evolve from?

Table 1: Network thinking.

Principle	Basic idea	Contrasted with	Example
Networks are a structure.	Many outcomes can be explained by *network relationships*.	Individual attribute, aggregative, atomistic explanations.	The cause of employee burnout may be a result of their central location in a work network, rather than of some individual-level deficiency (e.g., they lack resilience).
Networks are an organizing logic.	Organizing can be accomplished through *self-organizing network interactions*.	Hierarchical and market organizing structures.	Decision mechanisms on a new work technology may be the result of attitudes spreading through an informal network of chatter, rather than flowing down from a chain of command.

Like many perspectives growing out of the mid-20th century (e.g., postmodernism), network thinking grew out of a dissatisfaction with approaches that can be characterized as atomistic, methodologically individualistic, aggregative, etc. For instance, →Borgatti and colleagues (2009) link network thinking to Jacob Moreno's sociograms to explain why so many students were running away from the Hudson School for Girls in New York in the 1920s. →Wellman (1988) traces explicit network theorizing to British anthropologists in the 1950s as a way of extending and diving deeper into cultural systems of norms. Not much later, American sociologists, unconvinced by dominant psychological explanations for collective phenomena (e.g., strain and breakdown theories), came to draw on Georg Simmel's work on interpersonal triads (→Simmel 1908).

Although there have been many debates regarding social network thinking's relationship with existing philosophies of social science (e.g., →Haines 1988), we can sketch out networks through two guiding principles that most network theorists might have little disagreement with as a simple introduction:

1. Networks are a structure.
2. Networks are an organizing logic.

You can think of this as a sort of network orientation in thinking about social phenomena. The first principle, that *networks are a structure*, is largely about using networks to understand why things happen to people and organizations the way they do. By structure, we can view networks akin to how →Giddens (1984) thought about structure, as the rules and resources that enable and constrain attitudes and behavior. For Moreno, girls were not running away from school because of some individual-level deficiency, but because their network position in the school had enabled them to do so (i.e., a social influence argument). The second principle, *networks are an organizing logic*, is more about understanding complex coordination efforts, incentives, and mechanisms within and between organizations (→Powell 1990). For the mid-20th-century British anthropologists, cultural systems were not diffused through top-down mandates (e.g., hierarchical logic) or through some economic exchange (e.g., market logic), but through reciprocal network interactions "linking social system members across social categories and bounded groups" (→Wellman 1988: 158).

Let's use another more modern example. Consider that you want to understand how misinformation about COVID-19 ran rampant in 2020. The examples are numerous, ranging from Bill Gates installing microchips

in vaccines to drinking bleach to cure COVID-19. A social psychologist might examine several predispositions related to somebody's increasing likelihood to adopt conspiracy theories (e.g., general paranoia, distrust, etc.). On the other hand, a network theorist might look at how individuals are *embedded* in communities of like-minded thinking (network structure explanation). After all, we might be more likely to believe our friends rather than experts. Similarly, public relation theorists might look into failed public messaging from governments to understand top-down coordination and organizing efforts. On the other hand, a network theorist might look into broad network ecosystems involving systems of interactions between politics, science, law, religion, and the media (e.g., →Luhmann 1995) to explain how the phenomenon of misinformation was *self-organized* in the first place (network organizing logic).

These two principles are meant to introduce the spirit of network thinking. However, the devil is in the details. The next section sketches out exactly how researchers have explicated different strands of network theory, especially with respect to organizational communication.

2 An Informal Systematic Review

To sketch the trajectory of network studies in organizational communication, we conducted a rather informal systematic review. For this, the Communication and Mass Media Complete (CMMC) database was searched for about the last 20 years (2000–2021). We decided for the last 20 years to get a sense of where network scholarship is at the moment. Moreover, reviews already exist that have reviewed networks in organizational communication from previous periods, so we did not want to reinvent the wheel.

Basic search terms were entered like "network analysis", "social networks", "organizational communication", etc. All in all, we included 104 journal articles[1] into a spreadsheet and placed them into categories including (1) networks and theory, (2) network structure, (3) network function, (4) network strength, and (5) network models. Each will be explained further below, along with summaries and critiques for future research.

3 Networks and Theory

Sometimes it gets confusing when somebody says "Drawing from network theory, I hypothesize [insert hypothesis]" because there really is no grand network theory per se. Moreover, sometimes the network is the *explanans* (i.e., independent variable, the cause) and sometimes it is the

explanandum (i.e., dependent variable, the effect). This can be pretty confusing. To make sense of this, we can follow and adapt →Borgatti and Halgin's (2011) organizing typology and apply it to organizational communication networks in →Table 2.

Table 2: Theoretical Framework for Networks.

The antecedent, cause, or independent variable	**The outcome, effect, or dependent variable**	
	Non-network variable	**Network variable**
Non-network variable	*Non-network theory*	*Theory of networks:* Theories of convergence (e.g., homophily,) and cooperation (e.g., collective action)
Network variable	*Network theory:* Theories of contagion (e.g., social influence) and capitalization (e.g., social capital)	*Network theory of networks:* Theories of endogeneity (e.g., balance theory, preferential attachment)

We could view *network theories* as being more motivated by the first principle of viewing networks as structures that enable and constrain behavior and attitudes. In this sense, network theories seek to explain why individual networks within organization or organizational networks between other organizations influence non-network phenomena. For example, do high-performing employees have lots of network ties (capitalization theories) or does being embedded in cliques result in similar attitudes about the CEO (social influence theories)? All in all, 29 studies (28.43%) were explicitly interested in seeking a network explanation for a non-network phenomenon. To make sense of these studies, it might be easier to analyze them in the context of networks (1) within an organization and (2) between organizations.

3.1 A Summary and Critique of Network Theory within Organizations

We have included 20 (19.23%) studies in organizational communication that have dealt with the analyzing network explanation for various organizational outcomes. These outcomes include:

- Career aspirations (e.g., →Aley and Levine 2020)
- Sales output (e.g., →Bolander et al. 2015)
- Organizational identification (e.g., →Broch et al. 2018)
- Cyberbullying behavior (e.g., →Festl and Quandt 2013)

- Negative gossip (e.g., →Grosser, Lopez-Kidwell, and Labianca 2010)
- Leadership (e.g., →Huffaker 2010)
- Expertise awareness/exchange (e.g., →Kim 2018)
- Enterprise social media use (e.g., →Kim and Pilny 2019)
- Team-member performance (e.g., →Xia, Yuan, and Gay 2009; →Manata 2019)
- Team-level performance (e.g., →Pilny et al. 2020; →Sauer and Kauffeld 2013)
- Negative adoption attitudes (e.g., →Fu, Shumate, and Contractor 2020)
- Satisfaction (e.g., →Pollock, Whitbred, and Contractor 2000)
- Information adequacy (e.g., →Susskind 2007)
- Media choices (e.g., →Chang and Johnson 2001)
- Turnover (e.g., →Feeley, Hwang, and Barnett 2008)

Of these 20 studies, it seems to be clear that most organizational communication scholars are more interested in theories of capitalization (85%), that is, how individuals can benefit themselves and their organization/work team by leveraging communication networks. Only four studies (20%) really came from a contagion perspective, looking at negative gossip, cyberbullying behavior, media choices, and negative adoption attitudes.

If you consider the nature of the outcomes, a pattern regarding valence begins to emerge. That is, positive outcomes seemed to be associated with capitalization perspectives while negative outcomes seemed to be associated with contagion perspectives. Intuitively, this makes sense as social capital theory, as a capitalization perspective (e.g., →Burt 1992), inherently borrows from a *capital* metaphor: the more capital, the more opportunities and beneficial outcomes will lie at your disposal. On the other hand, contagion perspectives often reflect less desired outcomes. Again, this is not surprising. Think of colloquial concepts related to contagion like echo chambers, groupthink, and deadly virus outbreaks.

However, this does not necessarily need to be the case. For instance, can accumulating *too* many network ties be associated with negative outcomes? Here, communication networks could be directly associated with aspects like workplace burnout, information overload, or even conflicts of interest. Likewise, can contagion theories be used to explain more positive outcomes? For instance, →Chang and Johnson (2001) found that structural equivalence was related to common media choices, a relatively neutral outcome. Nevertheless, concepts like sense of belonging and solidarity linked to contagion perspectives have longed been

associated with positions in networks (e.g., →Coleman 1990). However, there seems to be a lack of studies in organizational communication in this regard. As such, we recommend that researchers take a more 'double-edged sword' approach, investigating how different network positions might have both positive and negative outcomes. But, how does this apply to research regarding *inter*-organizational communication networks?

3.2 A Review and Critique of Network Theory between Organizations

Here, we have included 14 (13.46%) articles answering questions how positions in organizational communication networks are related to non-network outcomes. These include outcomes like:

- Referrals (e.g., →Cooper and Shumate 2012; →Koschmann and Wanberg 2016)
- Trust and communicative effectiveness (e.g., →Atouba 2019)
- Organizational capacity (e.g., →Cooper and Shumate 2012)
- Expressive and instrumental support (e.g., →Doerfel, Lai, and Chewing 2010)
- Reputation/importance/influence (e.g., →Doerfel and Taylor 2017; →Pilny, Atouba, and Riles 2014)
- Resilience/stability (e.g., →Doerfel, Chewing, and Lai 2013)
- Board of director's leadership (negative) (e.g., →Fu and Shumate 2017)
- Terrorist activity (e.g., →Pilny and Proulx 2018)
- Quality public relationships (e.g., →Sommerfeldt and Kent 2015)
- Common funders (e.g., →Fu and Cooper 2022)

Unlike intraorganizational network research, nearly all of the studies seemed to look at positive outcomes from a capitalization perspective, looking at how positions in interorganizational networks are related to positives external (e.g., reputation) and internal (e.g., capacity). It seems to be clear that external perceptions resulting from network centrality (i.e., garnering a large amount of ties) matters. After all, when we think about outcomes related to interorganizational networks, it makes sense that researchers would be interested in outcomes beyond an individual organization. Nonetheless, the results are still mixed regarding great effectiveness of *internal* operations. For instance, →Fu and Shumate (2017) unexpectedly found a negative relationship with the amount of network ties and internal board leadership. On the other hand, →Pilny and Proulx (2018) found that network centrality matters with respect to

terrorist activities as an internal operation (attacks and lethality). We suggest that this needs to be teased out more. That is, under what conditions might central network position matter with respect to bolstering internal capacity?

Likewise, contagion perspectives are seldom to be found, with the exception of →Fu and Cooper (2022). How interorganizational networks matter to such diffusion processes needs to be researched further. For instance, institutional theory might suggest that interorganizational networks might increase various isomorphic processes (→Fu and Cooper 2022) resulting in organizations looking more similar (see →Lammers and Barbour 2006). Likewise, other social influence theories, like diffusion of innovations (→Rogers and Kincaid 1981) or social identity (→Tajfel 1979), might also be used to explain how embeddedness in communication networks can result in some sort of social homogeneity.

3.3 A Review and Critique of Theories of Networks within Organizations

Theories of networks largely explain why individuals in an organization create ties with one another. Twenty (19.23%) articles were identified as dealing primarily with answering this question. The factors used to explain the emergence of communication networks within different organizations include:

- Endogenous explanations like reciprocity, closure, popularity, etc. (e.g., →Contractor et al. 2012; →Riles, Pilny, and Tewksbury 2018)
- Multiplexity (e.g., →Foucault Welles et al. 2014; →Lee and Lee 2015)
- Proximity (e.g., →Contractor, Monge, and Leonardi 2011; →Kim 2018)
- Homophily (e.g., →Lee, Kim, and Piercy 2019; →Pilny et al. 2017)
- Power relations/roles (e.g., →Stephens, Chen, and Butler 2016; →Whitbred et al. 2011)
- Work environment factors (e.g., →Su 2021; →Weber and Kim 2015)
- Common meanings in semantic networks (e.g., →Fitzgerald and Doerfel 2001)
- Identity explanations (e.g., →Eddington 2020; →Pilny et al. 2017)
- Collective action incentives/motivations (e.g., →Yuan et al. 2005)

The vast majority of studies tend to control for various factors and theories that can be used to explain the emergence of communication networks in organizations. The most obvious is the presence of other network ties, when network theories of networks like reciprocity, closure, and popularity are often used. Other common factors include multiplex

explanations. For instance, friendship ties tend to be associated with communicative interaction ties in the workplace. Homophily is also significant across several studies. Here, attributes like common ranks, work units, interests, etc. contributed to workers establishing various types of communication networks.

However, many of these common explanations (endogeneity, multiplexity, homophily, proximity) are quite general in theories of communication networks and could apply to lots of different contexts beyond organizations. But what is it about life inside an organization that influences connections that is unique for organizational studies itself? Here is where we can see fresh perspectives developed, especially from an organizational communication perspective. For instance, a few studies looked at how various forms of interdependence might influence ties like sharing common tasks (→Su 2021), experiencing dynamic external structures (→Weber and Kim 2015), and how sharing similar activity foci (→Contractor et al. 2012; →Whitbred et al. 2011) might influence network ties. We would thus encourage organizational communication scholars to continue to explore more contextual explanations about organizational life. Although the replicated factors should also be controlled for, more factors related to organizational life can push organizational communication scholars to make novel contributions to theories of networks inside organizations.

3.4 A Review and Critique of Theories of Networks between Organizations

Explaining why interorganizational networks emerge seems to be a bit more popular than studies of intraorganizational networks. Here, we included 33 (31.73%) studies that were primarily focused on this task. The factors used to explain the emergence of communication networks between different organizations include:

- Endogenous explanations like reciprocity, closure, preferential attachment, etc. (e.g., →Atouba and Shumate 2010; →Fu 2019)
- Homophily (e.g., →Saffer 2016; →Wang, Bar, and Hong 2020)
- Multiplexity (e.g., →Lai and Fu 2021; →Pilny and Shumate 2012)
- Organizational/stakeholder type (e.g., →Barbour et al. 2020; →Evans 2015)
- Geography/proximity (e.g., →Liu and Shin 2019; →Lee and Monge 2011)
- Power attributes like hierarchy/size/age (e.g., →Saffer, Pilny, and Sommerfeldt 2021; →Shumate and Palazzolo 2010)

- Organizational type (e.g., →Liu and Shin 2019; →Xu 2021)
- External time phase (→Bryant and Monge 2008; →Doerfel and Haseki 2013)
- Normative standards/legitimacy (e.g., →Shumate and O'Connor 2010a; →Zhou 2021)
- Narrative/discourse environment (e.g., →Bennett, Foot, and Xenos 2011; →Jackson and Foucault Welles 2015)
- Political opportunity structure (e.g., →Caiani and Wagemann 2009; →Wang and Guan 2020)

Interestingly, it appears that the choice of method seems to heavily influence what factors get examined (more on methods in the next section). For instance, if the measure can take place at the node or tie level, various forms of linear inferential models or network inferential models are typically used. On the other hand, if the factor is more at the macro level (e.g., political opportunity structure, discourse environment), comparative methods are often used because such factors are hard to isolate for specific organizations (e.g., →Caiani and Wagemann 2009).

To us, this presents an interesting opportunity to simultaneously analyze tie-based, attribute-based, and external environmental factors through multiple samples of interorganizational networks. Because interorganizational networks are inherently at a more grandiose level of analysis than intraorganizational networks, perhaps it is time to more seriously analyze how micro/meso factors contribute to the emergence of specific interorganizational systems, while at the same time, comparing multiple samples of networks together to see how larger macro factors might be also playing a role. For instance, →Monge, Heiss, and Margolin (2008) theorize that 'external factors' will always have some influence on how organizations connect with one another, but there has been little follow up on sorting out what these macro influences are and under what contexts they might be influential. Here, organizational communication scholars might have to take a broader look at macro-level factors like institutions, culture, political opportunities, economies, etc. in order to flesh out different types of external factors as well as the common endogenous (e.g., reciprocity, popularity) and exogenous explanations (e.g., multiplexity, homophily).

3.5 Networks and Theory Construction

It is worth noting that communication networks have played significant roles in papers that were purely dedicated to theory construction, with either no or limited use of empirical data. Included were 12 (11.53%)

papers that used networks in various ways to construct novel communication theories and frameworks. These include:

- Community network evolution (→Monge, Heiss, and Margolin 2008)
- Multidimensional network approaches (→O'Connor and Shumate 2018)
- Terrorist network organizing (→Stohl and Stohl 2007)
- Organizational change management (→Eisenberg, Johnson, and Pieterson 2015)
- Social eavesdropping (→Bighash et al. 2020)
- Public information goods (→Bighash et al. 2018)
- Emergency management (→Ford et al. 2016)
- Issue niches (→Yang 2020)
- Organizational network ecologies (→Yang and Taylor 2015)
- Inter-group network typology (→Hejnova 2010)
- Communication network typology (→Shumate et al. 2013)
- Symbiotic sustainability (→Shumate and O'Connor 2010b)

Networks play different roles in the various theoretical propositions of these papers. Sometimes, networks are simply used in the formation of typologies, whether they be of different network relationships (→Shumate et al. 2013) or organizational forms (→Hejnova 2010). Sometimes, they are the explanation for the development of some sort of phenomenon. These include communication networks as at least partly responsible for the development of resources like public goods, effective emergency management, issue niches, and social capital.

Less often, however, are theories constructed for explaining why some networks get created in the first place. Perhaps the reason for this stems from the publication of →Monge and Contractor's (2003) multi-theoretical multi-level (MTML), which synthesized a vast amount of theories into different theoretical families and levels to explain various network relationships. Although →Yang and Taylor (2015) theorize about how organizational size and institutional transitions might influence different patterns of network tie creation and →Shumate and O'Connor (2010a) theorize on the specifics of NGO and corporate ties, there has been little to further our understanding on theories of networks.

Here, organizational communication researchers have a novel opportunity to expand upon existing network theories of networks. Common theories like (1) reciprocity (i.e., you scratch my back, I'll scratch yours), (2) closure (i.e., the friend of my friend will be my friend), (3) brokerage (i.e., don't be stupid, be like cupid), and (4) popularity (i.e., the rich get richer) have been well-documented over the years (for a review,

see →Stadfeld and Amati 2021). Advancing our knowledge on how some tie structures lead to the creation of other tie structures could put organizational communication scholars in positions to be theoretical leaders in general network theorizing. However, this is easier said than done because there are only so many meaningful network configurations one can think of. Nevertheless, creativity in thinking about network arrangements could be useful to spur theory construction. For instance, →Lyu et al. (2022) recently explicated *tie range*, the length of the second shortest path between two already connected nodes (i.e., two friends who do not have any other mutual friends) as an important bridging mechanism for the diffusion of attitudes and beliefs.

How organizational communication scholars have used social network analysis might be useful here. That is, by expanding our views of network data and metrics, we may be able to develop more novel network theories of networks. But first, how do we generally use such type of analysis?

4 How Social Network Analysis Is Used

Understanding how communication networks form and perform more often than not takes advantage of the use of social network analysis (SNA). Indeed, 92 (90.19%) articles in the review made explicit use of SNA. However, how exactly SNA was used is up to the hypotheses and research questions being proposed: there is no standard template. Here, we will attempt to break down how SNA is used and not used.

4.1 Network Structure

SNA is primarily interested in understanding the structure of network relationships. At the most basic level, we can ask whether or not the focus was on egocentric or whole networks. Egocentric networks are interested in a node's individual network connections. One advantage here is sampling; traditional random sampling could be used. Whole networks are analyzed when an a priori or snowball technique is used to draw boundaries and then ideally, every node's connections are mapped. One advantage here is whole network analysis places a vast amount of metrics and tools at the researcher's disposal to understand such a structure.

Overall, the vast majority of empirical studies tend to focus on whole networks. We identified 83 (90.27%) of the empirical articles to explicitly focus on constructing whole level networks. Of these, 44 (53.01%) were of interorganizational networks and 39 (46.99%) were at the intraorganizational level, representing a relatively even split. Again, focusing on whole networks gives researchers the advantage of using

networks metrics not possible in egocentric studies like multiple forms of centrality (e.g., →Bennett, Foot, and Xenos 2011; →Doerful and Taylor 2017), network densities (→Evans 2015), and clustering techniques (e.g., →Caiani and Wagemann 2009: →Eddington 2020).

However, the drawback here is generalizability. Because egocentric studies can be randomly sampled, the findings from these studies may (arguably) be more applicable to organizations in varying contexts, even though that may not be the point. Given that only nine studies (9.78%) primarily used egocentric designs (e.g., →Barbour et al. 2020; →Fang et al. 2016), we would suggest that organizational communication scholars not give up on egocentric networks even though they are limited with what types of network metrics can be extrapolated. For instance, →Lai and Fu (2021) use an egocentric design to extrapolate measures of multiplexity, specifically composing unique measures of *network diversity*. Indeed, such designs can offer researchers a number of creative outlets to extrapolate various structures and types of ties.

4.2 Network Function of Relational States

Network function focuses less on the structure of the network and more on the nature of the relationships. Here, we are referring to relational states, typically defined as "continuously persistent relationships between nodes" (→Borgatti, Everett, and Johnson 2013: 3). For instance, →Shumate and Contractor (2013) theorized about four different types of relational states related to communication: (1) flow ties (e.g., information transmission like emails), (2) affinity ties (e.g., social construction like friendship), (3) representational ties (e.g., public affiliations like re-tweets or Facebook 'likes'), and (4) semantic ties (e.g., shared common interpretations like similar mission statements).

Overall, the 92 empirical studies contained a variety of these communication networks, with 23 (25%) studying at least more than one network. Of these, 46 (50%) studies contained a flow network, 52 (56.52%) contained an affinity network, 14 (15.20%) contained a representational network, and 9 (9.78%) contained a semantic network. This distribution is not entirely surprising given various traditions in communication theory emphasis in information flow (e.g., information theory, cybernetics) and co-construction (see →Shumate et al. 2013).

On the rise, however, is the study of representational networks, defined as "affiliation related messages among actors that are communicated to a third party or to a public" (→Shumate et al. 2017: 11). Earlier studies tended to focus on hyperlinks (e.g., →Biddix and Park 2008; →Kim 2012), while more recent work focuses on Twitter networks like

‘mentions’ (→Lai and Fu 2021) or follower-followee relationships (→Fu 2019). Work on semantic networks seems to be sporadic, with earlier studies focused on discursive content like consumer complaints (→Fitzgerald and Doerfel 2001) and more recent work on social media content (→Xu 2020) and corporate social responsibility reports (→Zhou 2021).

Moreover, 23 studies (25%) explicitly report data on multiplex networks, that is, more than one network. This is promising as it is time for network theories and theories of networks to specifically reference different network functions. In other words, not all communication networks are the same. For example, it would be misleading to assume that flow (e.g., email) and representational (e.g., Twitter re-tweets) networks are created for the same reasons (e.g., the latter is more about a mass audience) or lead to the same outcome (e.g., the former is much more prone to information overload) (→Saffer, Pilny, and Somerfeldt 2021). We would encourage network researchers to adopt an inherently ‘multiplex’ orientation to tease out these differences.

4.3 Network Function of Relational Events

Relational events can be defined as a “discrete event generated by a social actor and directed toward one or more targets” (→Butts 2008: 159). In other words, relational events are episodic interactions between nodes. Only four (4.34%) articles explicitly dealt with relational events (→Liang 2014; →Foucault Welles et al. 2014; →Pilny et al. 2017; →Pilny et al. 2020). This is not surprising as formal models to model relational events are relatively new and the data needed for relational events (i.e., a sender, a receiver, a timestamp) may be more difficult to gather.

Nevertheless, the study of relational events within and between organizations remains a fruitful area of inquiry as they represent a more sequential and processual view of communication dynamics (→Schecter et al. 2018). Like relational states, a typology distinguishing different types of relational events is sorely needed into order to understand the different types of relational interactions and how they are related to the formation and dissolution of relational states. Moreover, there is little research documenting outcomes stemming from certain patterns of relational events (→Leenders, Contractor, and DeChurch 2016). Here, organizational communication scholars have a rich opportunity to contribute to this growing inquiry.

4.4 Network Strength

Networks are often constructed in matrices with ones and zeros or in other words, a binary form. With data formatted this way, insights from graph theory are often used to construct complex network metrics at the individual and whole level. Many of these metrics become complicated when ties actually represent network strength, also known as valued networks. Many times, however, it makes sense to include network strength. For instance, network strength was paramount to →Granovetter's (1973) thesis on the strength of weak ties. You can think of a weak tie as somebody who would help you move a couch and a strong tie as somebody who would help you move a body.

Overall, only eight studies (8.69%) explicitly measured and used network strength in their analysis. Of course, not every study necessarily needs to include tie strength. However, we would suggest that tie strength be the 'default' approach for a couple of reasons. First, if network ties are measured on such a scale, but the analysis requires binary matrices, they can be dichotomized into such a form anyway. Indeed, there are best practices on how to do such network dichotomization (→Borgatti and Quintane 2018). Second, network methodologists are developing metrics and models to account for tie strength more and more by the day. This is important because the conclusions reached from comparing dichotomized binary versus original valued networks can sometimes be different (→Pilny and Atouba 2018). Because communication is rarely measured in a binary form anyway, the push for more studies using tie strength could be a useful strategy for advancing communication network theory.

4.5 Network Models

When an empirical study creates a social network, there are a host of analytical strategies a researcher can deploy. We have categorized this into four areas: (1) linear models, (2) descriptive network analysis, (3) inferential network analysis, and (4) qualitative network analysis. Overall, there were 39 (42.39%) studies primarily using linear models, 35 (38.04%) using inferential network models, 15 (16.30%) using purely descriptive network analysis, two (2.17%) using qualitative techniques (e.g., →Garner 2006; →Woo 2019), and one using a novel hypergraph approach (→Lungeanu et al. 2018).

It is tempting to use various linear models for network metrics because they are often very good predictors of various outcomes. However, there are questions of whether or not such types of analysis

violate the spirit of network thinking in the first place. For instance, in many cases, linear models assume independence of observations, which is of course the opposite of network thinking. Nevertheless, sometimes there is just no other good way to get around this issue. As such, we would recommend that authors pay special attention to whether or not the particular linear model of interest contradicts assumptions about interdependence and influence cases might have on one another. Researchers should at least explore whether or not various network inferential models might be capable of testing the proposed hypotheses or research questions. If so, they should adopt those network models as a priority.

Of the 35 inferential network models, 18 (51.42%) studies used exponential random graph models (ERGM), six (17.14%) used stochastic actor-oriented models (SIENA), four (11.42%) used relational event models (REM), three (8.57%) used valued exponential random graph models (VERGM), and four (11.42%) used quadratic assignment procedure (QAP). ERGMs are useful at predicting what exogenous and endogenous parameters predict network tie formation. However, after examining them, we noted that they are often underspecified (i.e., include a limited set of effects). For instance, sometimes researchers are selective regarding which parameters, especially endogenous ones, are used. We would suggest that researchers at the very least control for four common tendencies relevant to network theories of networks because (a) they have been shown to influence various types of networks in the past and (b) they can be useful alternative explanations to rule out (e.g., →Siciliano, Wang, and Medina 2021):

1. Reciprocity (i.e., you scratch my back; I'll scratch yours)
2. Closure mechanisms (i.e., the friend of my friend will be my friend)
3. Structural holes (i.e., don't be stupid, be like cupid)
4. Popularity mechanisms (i.e., the rich get richer).

Finally, it worth noting that only 16 (17.39%) empirical studies were inherently longitudinal in design, even if they did not use a specific longitudinal model like SIENA or REM. We would encourage more studies to adopt a longitudinal frame for a couple of reasons. First, depending on the time frame of data collection, there could be different generative mechanisms at work (e.g., →O'Brien et al. 2019). As noted earlier, this could be a unique avenue for fresh theorizing. For instance, →Doerfel and Taylor (2004) demonstrate just how significantly network structures of civil society and media organizations can change in a span of just two years,

relating such findings to resource dependence and cooperation-competition theories.

5 Summary and Conclusion

Overall, the study of networks in organizational communication remains robust. If you aggregate the trend since 2000, an exponential trend equation slightly outperforms a linear trend (R^2 = 0.62 vs. R^2 = 0.60). Any way you slice it, both suggest that there is little slowing down in terms of network research in organizational communication. This review was meant to introduce network thinking and map/critique the terrain of network research in organizational communication. Our suggestions can be summarized as follows:

1. Expand upon the outcomes theorized from capitalization and contagion perspectives to take a 'double-edge sword' approach on negative (e.g., burnout) and positive (e.g., belonging) outcomes.
2. Consider more environmental and macro influences for cooperation and convergence perspectives that explain interorganizational networks.
3. Contribute towards novel forms of network theories of networks. Introducing relational metrics like multiplex networks, valued networks, and relational events could spur thinking in this regard.
4. Continue to pursue more longitudinal network research designs.

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Chapter 19 Organizational Structure

Matthew Koschmann

Abstract

This chapter explores the concept of organizational structure and assesses its place in organizational communication scholarship. Despite its ubiquity, structure has become one of the most contested and complicated terms in all of organizational studies. Structure continues to be used uncritically throughout many areas of organizational communication, while also challenged and rejected in other areas. Thus, now is a good time to bring all this to the forefront and clarify exactly what is at stake. Accordingly, this chapter proceeds in four sections. First, I begin with a shorter section on basic definitions and a brief intellectual history of organizational structure to establish the context for the remainder of the chapter. Next, I review how the concept of structure has been taken up in the field of organizational communication, focusing on key moments and shifts that shape the trajectory for current and future scholarship. Then I explore the key ontological issues that underwrite the debates and departures for different approaches to structure in the field of organizational communication. This appears to be some of the most exciting and promising theoretical work in the field currently, and likely will shape the future of communication theory and its place within organizational studies for many years to come. Finally, I conclude with some comments and speculations about future directions.

Keywords: actor-network theory, Margaret Archer, Roy Bhaskar, Francois Cooren, critical realism, duality of structure, emergence/emergent, Anthony Giddens, Bruno Latour, Robert McPhee, ontology (depth/stratified), ontology (flat). M. Scott Poole, structuration, structure,

1 Introduction

Organizational structure refers to the shape or form of an organization and emphasizes the configuration of organizational members, divisions of labor, flows of information, and locus of authority. Basically, the practical existence of an organization on paper and in its day-to-day operations (structure as noun), like whether an organization is hierarchical, decentralized, networked, matrixed, etc. Structure also entails an action connotation (structure as verb), referring to the ways in which the “thing”

or the “what” of an organization comes into being and maintains its presence. That is, the various practices and processes that structure an organization into a particular shape or form. But as we will see, this conventional approach to organizational structure gets very complicated very quickly, with various subfields of management and organizational studies defined and differentiated by the ways in which structure is conceptualized. This variation is certainly the case for the subfield of organizational communication, where contemporary scholarship and the trajectory of future research are shaped significantly by contrasting approaches to structure, either directly or indirectly. Thus, the main goal of this chapter is to take stock of the concept of structure and its implications for organizational communication scholarship.

Structure is a defining aspect in the genesis and development of organizational studies as a field, especially because of its sociological roots (see →Meyer and Rowan 1977; →Scott 1987), much of which is premised on the use of social structures to understand and explain collective behavior. In fact, the apparent structured-ness of modern, bureaucratic organizations is what made sociological analysis so attractive. As organizations emerged as a distinct sphere of sociological investigation throughout the 1940s, the field of organizational studies basically imported traditional sociological concepts for the new context of modern organizations, and structure was at the top of the list.

Despite its ubiquity, structure has also become one of the most contested and complicated terms in all of organizational studies. For some scholars, structure is one of the most obvious, most central, most significant anchor points to ground nearly all organizational analysis and inquiry. After all, structure is what makes organizations *organizations*, distinct from other collectives and social phenomena. Structure is *the thing* that makes organizational studies relevant and meaningful. If we aren’t studying structure or incorporating the concept into our organizational analysis, then what are we doing? However, for other scholars, structure is a defining problematic for modern organizational studies. Structure is the concept we have most misunderstood and misapplied. It is *the thing* we need to rethink, question, and perhaps even move beyond if organizational studies is to remain relevant and meaningful in our modern era – relinquishing the idea that there is some sort of stratified social realm “outside” of human interaction and discourse. As such, the concept of structure is generally treated in three different ways across the broad landscape of organizational studies: one, structure as a fairly stable construct that can be assumed and uncritically accepted so we can get on with other work; two, structure as a dynamic and complex concept that should be continually interrogated but nonetheless accepted as real and

beneficial; or three, structure as a concept that is a useful fiction at best and a distraction or deception at worst, something we need to let go of and move past if we are to make progress in organizational scholarship.

This threefold distinction is basically the case as well for the subfield of organizational communication, which traditionally has followed the lead of sociology and social theory more broadly. As the field emerged as a formal academic discipline in the 1960s the notion of structure was generally accepted as given and defined by the prevailing sociology, management, industrial, and administrative literatures of the day. In the ensuing decades, organizational communication scholars became more conversant with broader intellectual trends influencing the social sciences and humanities, especially ongoing debates about structure, action, and agency, as well as various "turns" towards linguistics, hermeneutics, and postmodernism. This led to a reconsideration of many key concepts and constructs that were grounded in a conventional and uncritical understanding of structure, as well as new insights about the relationships between communicating and organizing. More recently, these developments have led many leading organizational communication scholars to question the very notion of structure in the first place as they develop the full implications of a robust communicative approach to organizations and organizing. Consequently, the place of structure in organizational communication remains an open question and an important area of inquiry.

Which brings us back to the purpose of this chapter. My goal is to help make sense of the concept of organizational structure and its place in organizational communication scholarship. It will become clear that the key differences in the various approaches to structure are (currently) irreconcilable, given that they are defined mainly in opposition to each other. Thus, no grand synthesis will be attempted here. However, there are points of convergence, and the broad territory of organizational communication scholarship should be able to accommodate multiple perspectives, so it is useful to be aware of other approaches in order to explore fruitful engagement and avoid unnecessary conflict. Plus, many organizational communication scholars and projects cross disciplinary boundaries (sociology, psychology, management, public administration, etc.), so it is important to understand what intellectual resources are available to ensure the paradigmatic consistencies usually required for successful interdisciplinary work.

2 Organizational Structure: Basic Definitions and Brief

Intellectual History

Given the prominence of structure as a key concept in organizational studies and communication scholarship, there is a wealth of previous research on the subject and several notable reviews of this literature (e.g., →Ahmady, Mehrpour, and Nikooravesh 2016; →D'Urso et al. 2015; →James and Jones 1976). Summarizing this vast body of work is beyond my purposes in this chapter, but I will note some key themes that contextualize organizational communication's evolving relationship with structure and set the stage for current and future scholarly pursuits, fully recognizing that each paragraph in this section could easily be its own chapter or even handbook. My goal here is to provide just enough background and context to set the stage for current developments, getting a decent sense of where we've been and where we are so we can understand where we seem to be going.

Throughout much of the 20th century, large bureaucratic organizations were the main focus of organizational, management, and administrative scholarship. Structure was seen as a general way of understanding the configuration of people, policies, and procedures that made up the social shape of organizations, like the arrangement of material elements that shaped the physical structures of organizations that housed their operations. After all, many organizations seemed so orderly, defined, and permanent, so why not understand their social and material aspects in similar (i.e., structural) ways. Plus, the notion of social structure was a well-established sociological concept that seemed to explain how social forces enabled and constrained human behavior, especially within the "iron cage" of modern bureaucratic organizations (see →DiMaggio and Powell 1983).

Accordingly, initial research focused on naming and classifying the various forms organizations could take (like the M-form, franchising, or matrices), investigating the effects of these forms on organizational outcomes (like productivity, efficiency, compliance), and identifying the practices needed to sustain or change these forms (like management styles, information sharing procedures, human resource policies). A key driver of this work was contingency theory, the idea that organizations need the right form or structure to "fit" well in their environments and survive (see →Donaldson 1987, →2001). In this regard, structure was treated as both an independent and dependent variable, exploring the effects of various structures on key organizational results, or the various factors that affected organizational structure, all with the aim of enhancing "landscape fitness" to ensure continued operation and success. We also see an emphasis on structural "features" throughout

much of this work, like whether organizational forms are more or less hierarchical or flat, formal or informal, centralized or decentralized, vertical or horizontal, etc.[1] Plus, these structural features were often contrasted with notions of *process* – the "what" of organizations distinguished from the "how". All of this makes up the conventional wisdom about organizational structure that became so established in organizational studies that scholarship on any number of other topics could simply refer to "structure" as a background assumption that generally was unquestioned and presumed to be common knowledge – structure was just the term used for organizational shape, form, or configuration.

However, two important developments throughout the later 20th century began to complicate this conventional wisdom. First, the so-called agency-structure debate in sociology began to bubble over into organizational studies, to the point where this dualism became a defining aspect of the field. Sociologists had long explored how the social structures that arise from human activity simultaneously constrain our actions, that the houses we build are now the houses we must live in. Yet as sociology had increasing impact on management and organizational studies, this challenged the uncritical acceptance of structure as a basic "feature" of organizations and instead made it more of a "problematic" that needed to be investigated. Ideas such as neo-institutionalism (→Meyer 1977), structuration (→Giddens 1984), and enactment (→Weick 1979) became increasingly influential throughout all aspects of organizational scholarship, essentially becoming their own schools of thought in relation to economic and administrative literatures that previously defined the field. Despite general agreement that structure referred to organizational shape or form, new questions arose about what, exactly, this meant (e.g., How do structures come into existence? How do they influence human behavior? How are they altered or sustained? Where do structures reside? Are they fundamentally psychological, sociological, discursive, or something else?).

Second, the rise of digital technologies, the Internet, and a globalized economy at the turn of the century exposed the perceived stability and permanence of organizations and their structures, revealing just how temporary, fluid, and malleable organizational configurations actually are and could be. Thus, one of the most popular topics of organizational research and inquiry throughout the early 2000s was "new" or "alternative" organizational forms and structures. Advances in communication technologies enabled companies to organize and share information in new ways, leading them to experiment with novel arrangements and forcing organizational scholars to confront many

taken-for-granted assumptions about structure. The rise of start-up companies, novel inter-organizational relationships, outsourcing of various business functions, cross-sector partnerships, mergers and acquisitions, ambiguous holding companies, and even 'virtual' organizations raised important questions about what organizations actually are and what was meant by their structure. Given the fluidity, flexibility, and hybridity of so much modern organizing, the notion of structure (implying stability, permanence, and recognizable forms) seemed questionable or even irrelevant. There was growing recognition that "new" or "alternative" organizational forms were now quite common and normal. For many organizational scholars, all of this led to a renewed emphasis on debates about structure and agency and the relationships between micro- and macro-level phenomena, seeking to bolster our understanding of organizational structure in light of modern organizational advancements and developments. Yet for others involved in more theoretical work, these changes led to a fundamental rethinking of core concepts that had defined the field for decades, and even sacred cows like organizational structure were up for grabs. New insights from diverse areas such as postmodernism, quantum physics, linguistics, new materialism, posthumanism, and of course, poststructuralism raised deeper ontological and epistemological questions about the nature of organizations and what we think we know about them. From these perspectives the notion of structure became increasingly problematic, an assumption that does not seem valid considering what we are learning about modern organizing and human behavior.

A key point of contention is the notion of a "stratified ontology" that is assumed in most work on organizational structure and organizational studies more broadly, which is the ontological position that social phenomena are composed of multiple levels or layers of social stratification (i.e., micro, meso, and macro), with "deeper" levels providing the generative mechanisms that shape behaviors at the "surface" levels, and higher-order phenomena emerging form smaller-scale interactions. The key point is that higher or deeper levels of abstraction are "real" and consequential even though they exist independent of (though related to) observable behavior. Organizational structures are an exemplar of this approach – social abstractions that presumably explain various organizational behaviors and cannot be reduced to individual interactions. In contrast, critics question the empirical validity and theoretical utility of social stratification, instead advocating a "flat" ontology where all social phenomena are observed and understood at the horizon of observable behavior and interaction. From this perspective the notion of structure becomes suspect, like the ether of 19th-century physics, a theoretical

substance that was presumed to be necessary for the transmission of electromagnetic waves but turned out to be nonexistent. More on these ontological issues later in the chapter.

For now, the key takeaway from this brief intellectual history is that the field of organizational studies generally takes three approaches towards the concept of organizational structure: (1) uncritical use of some generic notion of organizational shape, form, or configuration that is largely agnostic about ontological implications; (2) serious attempts to rethink the idea of structure and shore up its ontological underpinnings (especially in relation to agency and action); and (3) efforts to move beyond the structure concept itself in favor of more linguistic and discursive approaches to organizational phenomena. This sets the stage for exploring the place of structure within the field of organizational communication, which generally follows the trends of organizational studies and social theory more broadly.

3 Structure in Organizational Communication Scholarship: The State of the Art

Organizational communication has had an evolving (or devolving?) relationship with the concept of structure since its inception as an academic field in the 1960s. Initially the field accepted structure as given, a key construct that defined organizations and shaped communication patterns; nowadays structure is more often seen as suspect, a concept whose use may indicate that one does not fully understand or appreciate the implications of a distinctly communicative approach to organizations and organizing. In this regard, structure has become somewhat of a "vestigial appendage" in the field of organizational communication, something that may have had utility at an earlier stage of development but now appears to serve no substantive purpose and should be disregarded or even removed. In fact, when corresponding with one prominent organizational communication scholar about this chapter (also an author in this handbook) she remarked, "Ah, structure … what is that anymore ?!?!"

To understand how we got to this point it is helpful to survey the handbooks, encyclopedias, and edited volumes that have defined the field for nearly 40 years and trace the progression of structure in the various chapters and sections of these key texts. Although not a comprehensive literature review, this will enable us to capture the state of the art and clarify the direction we seem to be heading. →Putnam and Pacanowsky's (1983) edited volume on the *interpretive approach* was the crucial text to initiate the new field of organizational communication and signal its

official break with the functionalism of conventional management and administrative sciences. Within this book Poole and McPhee's chapter articulating a structurational analysis of organizational climate is the most pertinent to the topic of structure. They begin by explaining the "undeniable paradox" shaping organizational studies: that even though people create and maintain organizations, they develop a life of their own and subsequently constrain and control the very people who made them. Organizational communication would thus be defined by how it tries to explain this dynamic. In their attempt to provide such an explanation, Poole and McPhee invoke structuration theory to uncover the "deep structure" of organizational climate because of structuration's focus on "the way structures are produced and reproduced through interactions" (→1983: 195). The key contribution here is to articulate an understanding of structure as *intersubjective*, meaning that structure only exists in interaction. Structure (i.e., rules and resources) cannot be reduced to individual cognitions and it does not exist independent of communication – structure is both medium and outcome of interaction and thus the property of social practices (→Poole and McPhee 1983).

McPhee continued this line of work in a chapter on "formal structure" in the 1985 edited volume *Organizational Communication: Traditional Themes and New Directions*, which sought to refine the "emerging field" of organizational communication as it "stumbl[ed] toward identity" (→Redding 1985: 15). McPhee claimed that structure is the "defining characteristic" of organizations: "*it* is what brings about or makes possible" all the things that distinguish organizations from other social collectives (→1985: 150, emphasis in the original). Furthermore, he argues that structure is a "defining condition" of organizational communication, which he characterizes as communication that is "shaped by, and shapes, task processes and formal structure in the organization" (p. 150). An important takeaway here is that the field of organizational communication is beginning to define itself though its explanation of the "weaving dance" of the structure-communication relationship through space and time (→McPhee 1985: 169).

Next came the first *Handbook of Organizational Communication* (→Jablin et al. 1987), which has a section titled "Structure: Patterns of Organizational Relationships" that begins with the acknowledgment that "the notion of structure is probably one of the oldest concepts in organization theory" (p. 297). Subsequent chapters in this handbook section focus on emergent communication networks, superior-subordinate communication, multiple levels of analysis, formal organizational structure, and information technologies. The chapter on formal organizational structure provides the most direct treatment of the

subject. It considers structure as a "meta-communicative object" and explores how the formal features of organizations (i.e., configuration, complexity, formalization, and centralization) affect communication. The emphasis here is on the structure-communication relationship, which is generally accepted as given and suggests (at least) an analytical distinction between structure and communication. Yet the final sentence of the chapter does acknowledge that "the specific manner in which emergent network structure and formal organization structure are interrelated and, in turn, shape and are shaped by communication processes presents an exciting though formidable area of research" (→Jablin et al. 1987: 413).

Fast forward to 2001 and the "New" *Handbook of Organizational Communication* (→Jablin and Putnam 2001), which also has a dedicated multi-chapter section called "Structure: Patterns of Organizational Interdependence". These chapters cover dualisms in leadership research, emerging communication networks, organizational structures and configurations, and new media and organizational structuring. The chapter on organizational structures and configurations engages with structure as a concept most directly, beginning with "traditional dimensions of structure" and concluding with a number of "new" approaches that complicate the structure-communication relationship – especially McPhee's work on structuration (1985) and Taylor's work on text-conversation dialectics (1993) – and thus foreshadowing the rise of CCO scholarship (communicative constitution of organizations) that would further complicate the place of structure in organizational communication (see below). But for now, the emphasis in this handbook is still on the structure-communication relationship. Though acknowledging this relationship is much more complicated than we initially thought, the focus is still on figuring out or redefining this relationship rather than questioning it altogether.

Prior to this section on structure, an opening chapter in the 2001 *Handbook* on the "Development of Key Constructs" lists the action-structure dialectic as "the central tension in organizational communication research and theory" (→Jablin and Putnam 2001: 49), and the key constructs discussed in this chapter are all different approaches to this action-structure dialectic. This chapter does end with a brief section on "postmodernist challenges" that "reject the action-structure dualism itself". Yet little is offered in the way of specific examples, and the section concludes by noting that "Of course, postmodern assumptions have been widely criticized" (→Jablin and Putnam 2001: 66) – and are criticized here for defining structure out of existence (i.e., collapsing structure into language/practices) and supposedly lacking a conception of agency. But

as we will see shortly, many contemporary organizational communication scholars actually welcome these critiques because that is exactly what they are trying to do – eliminate the notion of structure and profoundly change our understanding of agency.

Then we have a chapter on "organizational structure" in the *International Encyclopedia of Communication* (2008), a multi-volume project published by the International Communication Association. In this chapter McPhee and Canary define structure as "the set of formally stipulated rules and regulations that regulate and legitimate the organization's work processes, communication, and other activities" (2008: 3471) and further explain structure as a "managerial tool" that establishes authority relations, information flows, and work allocations and grouping arrangements for employees. Yet they also acknowledge that more recently, "scholars have conceptualized an organization's structure as itself created and conveyed in a communication process that reflects cultural norms and the organization's environment and history" (p. 3471). Thus, this chapter reinforces the general consensus at the time that organizational structure is a foundational concept that is important for understanding various organizational phenomena, while also further complicating the structure-communication relationship and suggesting the need to reconsider our understanding of organizational structure from a communication perspective.

Next, the third and most recent *Handbook of Organizational Communication* (→Putnam and Mumby 2014) represents a key shift in the field's approach towards structure; not so much for what it says, but rather what it omits. Gone is any formal section or chapter on organizational structure, and the term "structure" as a distinct concept is not even listed in the subject index. To be sure, there are numerous related terms in the index, mostly associated with "structuration theory" and a variety of "structural approaches". Yet the message is clear: structure is no longer seen as a stand-alone construct that defines the field of organizational communication, but rather more of a problem to be investigated and perhaps even a concept whose utility had passed. The section that previous handbooks devoted to structure is now titled "Communication and Post-Bureaucratic Organizing", and none of the six chapters in this section say anything directly about structure (the closest is a chapter on emergent social networks). And the preface that introduces this section is unambiguous about these shifts, stating "This section brings into sharp relief the movement and maturation of organizational communication research and conceptualizing since publication of the previous two editions of the present Handbook". It also notes that "organizational communication scholarship has moved on from the

framing of the past" and that organizational communication scholars are now "less burdened by sociological and psychological traditions" and released from the "tight strictures of having to engage the organization firstly as a function of its hierarchy and rules" (→Barker 2014: 321–322). Surely, these statements should be read with the notion of organizational structure in mind, given that structure was the main theme of these sections of chapters in the previous handbooks. The implication here is that organizational communication, as a field, no longer feels obligated to treat structure as a foundational construct from which to begin analysis and inquiry. Structure would continue to be used as a generic term to describe organizational shapes and forms. But as a scholarly concept structure would now be something that is questioned, interrogated, or simply left behind as we developed more communicative approaches to understand and explain the order of organizations.

Finally, the most recent treatment of structure in the handbook/edited volume/encyclopedia literature for the field of organizational communication comes from a chapter by Simpson and Holdsworth in the multi-volume *International Encyclopedia of Organizational Communication* (2017). This chapter provides an extensive outline of the various ways in which organizational structure is treated by organization communication scholars using three contextual frames of modernity, postmodernity, and liquid modernity. The authors' review of modernist and postmodernist approaches mirrors many of the developments I have described thus far, albeit with more exemplars from the literature to demonstrate these perspectives. The key advancement here is the notion of *liquid modernity*, which the authors explain as directing attention to the increased pace of change for both organizations and organizing, plus the "melting" of supposedly "solid" organizational structures. Thus, research in this vein focuses on the pieces of fragmented organizations plus the growing fluidity of modern organizing, with the overall goal of providing a conceptual framework for understanding the notion of structure in light of current developments in communication and organizational theory. Additionally, the notion of liquidity provides a frame for a number of non-Western approaches to structure and organizational communication that privilege order, substance, rationality, and objectivity (e.g., →Cruz and Sodeke 2021; →Kang and Krone 2022).

All of this points to a growing tension over the concept of structure and its place in the field of organizational communication. As scholarship moves more in the direction of post- and liquid modernity the idea of structure becomes increasingly suspect or irrelevant. Yet because of the history of organizational communication scholarship there is a reluctance to abandon what has been a key construct for such a long time. Thus,

there is simultaneously a need to start with structure while also moving away from it, to invoke the very thing that may be the problem. That is the tension. But even more so, the full implications of communication scholarship rooted in post- or liquid modernity suggest a move beyond just alternative approaches to the same concept (like the proverbial blind men touching parts of the elephant), but rather a bolder claim that perhaps there is no *there* there in the first place. And that seems to be the direction of contemporary organizational communication scholarship on the subject of structure. Yet any time conventions are challenged, we also see a renewed defense of those conventions from folks who realize they can no longer take them for granted. That too is the case with structure, where there are recent attempts in the broader organizational studies literature to bolster our understanding of structure and its ontological legitimacy (e.g., →Fairclough 2005; →Fleetwood 2005; →Reed 2005). Instead of the ether of 19th-century physics that was never there, structure is more like the dark matter of modern physics that we have yet to fully figure out but *has* to be there to make everything else work. That brings us to the main issue that drives debates about structure and its place in the field of organizational communication.

4 The Crux of the *Matter*: Ontology

Every dispute about organizational structure inevitably comes down to the issue of ontology – what exactly *is* structure, what is its mode of being? Anything we claim or investigate regarding structure's influence on organizational phenomena (and vice versa) entails something about the existence – or not – of structure and its capacity to influence and be influenced by human behavior. Now, many organizational communication scholars are not interested in these sorts of philosophical issues, at least not most of the time – they've made their ontological commitments in line with their theoretical orientations and would rather get on with other work. But this is important because these days many leading organizational communication scholars are making very deliberate theoretical moves that implicate the notion of structure and have significant consequences for the "other work" we're all busy doing. Thus, we are moving towards somewhat of a reckoning on what structure should and will mean for the field of organizational communication.

There is still general agreement in organizational communication that structure (noun) has something to do with the shape or configuration of organizations, that structure (verb) is also the process by which these shapes are formed, and that whatever structure is, it is constituted communicatively. But that still leaves important questions about what is

actually constituted and the ontological status of whatever results from this constitution process. Obviously, the subject of ontology is vast and could fill a whole handbook, let alone its own chapter. But that should not prevent us from at least sketching out the various ontological positions that shape our understanding of structure and its place in the field of organizational communication. Accordingly, the debate in our field is shaped by three general positions, summarized in →Table 1.

Table 1: Ontological Positions and Conceptions of Structure.

Theoretical position	Ontology	Conception of structure
Critical realism	Stratified/depth	Emergent, socially constructed entity reified through social processes that precede and condition human action
Actor-network	Flat	Nonexistent, instead focus on configurations of agency
Structuration	Duality	A set of rules and resources that constitutes the virtual order of social systems, a time-space presence instantiated in practices and memory traces

First, a *critical realist* (CR) position, characterized by a *stratified* or *depth* social ontology that distinguishes between different domains of reality that are related but independent. Critical realism is based largely on the philosophy of →Bhaskar (1978) and →Archer (1995) and applied in organizational studies by folks like →Fairclough (2005), →Fleetwood (2014), →Reed (2003), and →Modell (2020). For critical realists, structures are socially constructed entities that have been reified through various social processes and therefore precede and condition human action (→Modell 2020). Although there are not necessarily explicit advocates of this position in the field of organizational communication, it seems to be the stance of those who have a more taken-for-granted approach to structure, that some sort of depth ontology is being assumed in the work of those who discuss organizational levels, micro-macro distinctions, and/or notions of deep structure without further qualification or critical examination. Surely this is the case for many critical scholars working from more of a materialist position (e.g., →Cloud 2005; →Dutta and Zapata 2019).[2] Critical realism is also mentioned as a valid "alternative" perspective when organizational communication scholars survey the various paradigms that are available to inform investigations of various topics (e.g., →Kuhn 2014; →Leonardi 2013; →McPhee, Poole, and Iverson 2014).

Second, the position of *actor-network theory* (ANT), characterized by a *flat* ontology where all social phenomena exist on a single plane of reality, and based on the work of →Callon (1999), →Latour (2005), and →Law (1992). Notable advocates in organizational communication include →Cooren (2012) and the work of the Montréal School more broadly. Scholars working in this area are not merely trying to come up with a better conception of structure; instead, they are trying to dismantle the very notion of structure in the first place, concerned with the larger ontological implications of ascribing meaning and causation to social structures and other forms of reality beyond the flat horizon of interaction and practice – which is where the action is at in current organizational communication scholarship. That is, most of the recent theoretical work in our field argues that a distinctly communicative approach to organizations and organizing *requires* a flat ontology, *never* leaving the domain of interaction. As →Cooren et al. (2011) argue, "Being serious about the communicative constitution of organization indeed means that we cannot leave the realm of communicational events without the risk of betraying the 'design specifications' of our own agenda" (p. 1153). Basically, scholars who advocate this position have thrown down the gauntlet for the rest of the field: it is time to break from the traditional sociological commitments of organizational studies and their notion of social structures to forge our own path based on ontological positions that truly foreground the constitutive power of communication.

And third, the position of *structuration theory* (ST), which is based on the work of Anthony →Giddens (1984) and characterized by an ontology of *duality* where structure and action/agency are mutually constitutive and ontologically interdependent. In organizational communication this position is exemplified in the work of scholars such as →McPhee (2004), →Poole (2013), and →Riley (1983). This was the dominant position for much of organizational communication from the 1980s through the early 2000s, providing a more sophisticated understanding of the relationship between agency and structure that elevated the role of communication and gave us a strong theoretical foundation to justify our development as a distinct subfield of organizational studies. Yet structuration theory and its duality/dialectic ontology has fallen out of favor lately in organizational communication. Not necessarily because of any particular shortcoming, but rather because structuration is not generating much new organizational communication research these days – either direct theoretical development or utility as a theoretical foundation for other work. This decline is a bit unexpected, especially since the Four Flows Model (rooted in structuration theory) arose as one of the three schools of CCO thinking and seemed poised to be a foundational aspect of

organizational communication scholarship for many years to come (especially after the publication of →Putnam and Nicotera's 2009 text). But the main advocates of this position have either retired or moved on to other projects, and few younger scholars have taken up the mantel of structuration theory in their work.

These three positions (CR, ANT, ST) and their corresponding depth, flat, and duality ontologies have been in conversation with each other for decades and are often defined in relation to each other, so I will continue that practice to explain them further here. Some notion of a stratified or depth ontology is the majority position for much of organizational studies and the sociology that informs it, plus the related fields of organization science, management, and administration. Yet critical realism has experienced a resurgence of late in organizational studies (see →Fairclough 2005; →Fleetwood 2005; →Reed 2005), especially in response to the rise of postmodern and discursive perspectives that posit a flat ontology and challenge the notion of social structures with causal powers that exist independently from human interaction. Those who advocate a flat ontology seek a departure from traditional dualisms of micro/macro, agency/structure, or subjective/objective as ontologically meaningful categories. Instead, they reject attempts to identify and privilege any *a priori* social entities that have the capacity to stratify our relationships and structure the possibilities of agency. For them, the notion of structure is "illusory" (→Westwood and Lindstead 2001) and all phenomena we consider *social* exist on a single level of reality (or, indeed, no level at all). Rather than making attributions to some sort of structural influences or generative mechanisms, we should only trace the connections between individual actors (human or otherwise) and identify the networks of agency to explain what makes a difference in a particular situation.

In contrast, critical realists argue that organizations, structures, and other social realities cannot result from only local constructions because this process necessarily depends on *non*-local relationships, resources, and practices that make local constructions possible in the first place (→Reed 2010). Additionally, critical realists claim that important social realities like structure are *emergent*, higher-order entities that cannot be reduced to the actions of their constituent parts, something that advocates of a flat ontology deny. As →Elder-Vass (2008) explains:

> Reality is stratified into an ontological hierarchy of entities, in which higher-level entities have emergent properties [...] Each emergent property of an entity is the result of a mechanism that is characterized by the existence of a particular type of relations between particular types of parts – which we may call the *structure* of the entity. (→Elder-Vass 2008: 462, emphasis added)

This logic of emergence is crucial for critical realists and their notion of a depth or stratified ontology because it is the emergent properties of higher-order social structures – not specific practices or local interactions themselves – that infuse the world with enduring and pervasive conditions of stability (→Modell 2020). And it is this stability, this stubborn persistence of institutions, this tendency for social structures to bear down upon their creators that enables us to understand and explain social/organizational phenomena. To the extent that we trace local interactions (*à la* actor-network theory), the goal should be to uncover and explain social structures, not explain them away (→Elder-Vass 2008). Thus, critical realists argue that the flat ontology of actor-network theory is unnecessarily reductionist and overly empiricist, focusing too narrowly on observable behavior to the neglect of structural (i.e., emergent) properties and causal mechanisms.

In response, proponents of a flat social ontology argue that the notion of structure is at best a distraction but more likely a deception, for it relies on an ideological commitment to an antiquated social ontology that pretends to account for a variety of invisible forces that are really nothing more than local interactions and situated practices that have no external existence beyond their enactment (→Ashcraft 2021; →Westwood and Lindstead 2001). From a more practical standpoint, structure simply is not a very good way of explaining social phenomena anymore (if it ever was), especially given the fluidity and dynamism of modern organizations. Rather, it is better to focus on agency – human and nonhuman – on a single plane or realm of reality. As →Cooren (2004) explains:

> The problem with the term 'structure' [...] is that it functions as a hodge-podge concept, in which scholars include an array of factors [...] Instead of using the term 'structure' to explain these effects, let us start from agency – in all its forms. (→Cooren 2004: 385, 387, 389)

The goal here is to stay focused on local interactions, practices, and whatever appears to make a difference in each situation – to keep the social *flat*, as →Latour (2005) advocates. By tracing these associations, we can identify networks of influence that describe organizational phenomena, but without leaving the *terra firma* of interaction (see →Cooren et al. 2011). These actor-networks may give the appearance of structure but should not be attributed to any underlying (or overarching) force that is external to the interaction simply because there is nothing else there. Contra critical realism, structure here is the thing that needs to be explained (the explanandum), not the thing doing the explaining (the explanans); structure is an eventual effect rather than a causal

mechanism, the *consequence* of associations and not the *cause* (→Ashcraft 2021).

For flat ontologists in the tradition of actor-network theory, the main critique of critical realism and its depth ontology is that it forces us to depart the realm of immediate, observable human interaction and journey to an invisible, intransitive domain of reality (→Baxter and Chua 2020), positing unseen structures to explain organizational behavior when all we really need is right here in the situated practices – if only we have the patience and perception to look carefully, what Latour calls "*slow*ciology". Conversely, depth ontologists in the tradition of critical realism argue that we will never adequately understand and explain organizational behavior if we only look at local interactions – no matter how slowly and carefully – because those interactions are always enabled and constrained by forces that are outside of and irreducible to the actions of individual actors, forces (like structure) that are *real* and consequential and necessarily precede action. Thus, we appear to be at a standoff: a supposed epistemic fallacy, where statements of being are reduced to statements of knowledge (CR's critique of ANT) versus a supposed ontic fallacy, where statements about what we claim to know about reality are confused with reality itself (ANT's critique of CR).

Meanwhile, structuration theory maintains somewhat of a middle position, trying to thread the needle between the strong structural accounts of critical realism with its depth ontology and the strong agency accounts of actor-network theory with its flat ontology, seeking to maintain an analytic distinction between structure and agency but without affording independent ontological status to social structures. In structuration theory, structure exists as a time-space presence that is instantiated in practices and memory traces, a set of "rules and resources" that constitutes the "virtual order" of social systems (→Giddens 1984: 17). This position is a bit trickier to pin down because it advocates more of a dialectic between competing alternatives (rejecting dualisms for duality) rather than a distinct ontology per se. But it is the most sophisticated social theory that attempts to retain a balance between structure and agency without privileging one over the other.

Yet like all bridges, structuration gets walked on from both sides. Critics from each direction accuse structuration of trying to have its cake and eat it too, positing an abstract "duality" instead of committing to either a robust notion of structure or abandoning it altogether, somehow preserving the idea of structure but also without affording it distinct ontological status. Depth ontologists claim that structuration theory is merely "conflationism" where structure is collapsed into agency and

results in a flattened ontology. The problem, as →Reed (2010) explains, is that this leads to:

> a form of social theorizing and analysis that is unable to account for dynamic social emergence and change because it cannot begin to recognize the crucial ontological and analytical differences between structure, agency, and the complex interplay between them over time and space within a stratified social reality. (→Reed 2010: 153)

Conversely, flat ontologists criticize structuration theory for not following through on the implications of its "flatland" (→Taylor and Van Every 2000) approach and not relinquishing the notion of structure, but instead seeking a compromise between two nonexistent positions. →Latour (2005) argues:

> As long as we try to use either local interaction or structure, or some compromise between the two, there is no chance to trace social connections – and the cleverer the compromise, the worse it would be, since we would simply extend the lease of two non-existing sites. (→Latour 2005: 204)

Thus, structuration theory currently suffers the fate of many "compromised" positions: criticized for exemplifying the worst of each side versus trying to preserve the best, seen more as a betrayal rather than an innovative path forward. Yet it remains the best attempt to maintain a relationship between agency and structure without succumbing to ontological dualism, and thus continues to be a foundational idea for the field of organizational communication.

Across all three of these positions there is agreement that organizational communication practices are shaped by influences that seem to transcend local interactions and thus call for an explanation, yet they differ greatly on where they go for this explanation. Critical realism turns to social structures that are ontologically distinct with emergent properties that cannot be reduced to individual actions; actor-network theory turns away from any notion of structure altogether and instead towards nonhuman actants and configurations of agency; and structuration theory tries to avoid turning too far in either direction, maintaining a duality between structure and agency and navigating the Scylla and Charybdis of social theory that defines organizational studies.

5 Conclusion: What Are We Talking About When We (Don't) Talk About Structure?

As new ideas are developed and refined there is some latitude for conceptual slippage and imprecision as the details are worked out. But

eventually we get to a point where that fuzziness and vagueness is less tolerable and defensible, that enough scholarship has been done to show that various camps are relatively incompatible, and it is time to make tough decisions about where to reside and work. I believe this is where we are at in organizational communication with regard to the concept of structure – if not as an overall field, at least in terms of individual projects and lines of research. Decades ago, organizational communication began by accepting the concept of structure as given and focused on how communication variables affected structure, and vice versa. As our field developed, there was a growing recognition that communication didn't just represent or enable structure, but somehow *made* it instead, that structure itself was communicative. Theories of enactment and social construction fueled this insight, and the notion of structuration gave communication a prominent position and a more sophisticated understanding of the structure-agency relationship. Interest shifted away from structure per se (noun) to structuring as a process (verb), less emphasis on *the* structure and more on *how* things were structured. Although this is where many organizational communication scholars remain today, for others this pursuit has led to further questioning of the structure concept altogether – maybe there's no *there* there at all, that it can all be explained through communication practices without invoking structure, and now we have the intellectual resources to demonstrate this. And so the question going forward is how best to proceed: to cede the structure issue to other fields and just consent to the conventional wisdom of the day while we get on with other work; to accept the structure-agency dilemma as given and try to develop the best communicative response, or to forge ahead and continue progress towards a distinct "communication perspective" that foregrounds local interactions and foregoes any loyalties to established sociological concepts like structure.

If we are serious about developing a distinct communication perspective on organizations and organizing, then we need to follow through on the implications of this approach, even when it puts us at odds with the conventional wisdom of organizational studies and its sociological roots. This means no more talk about levels, micro/macro distinctions, and underlying/overarching causes (at least in the traditional sense); if we really think these concepts are problematic then we cannot stay tethered to them just to appear credible when we're really talking about something else. When we omit the concept of structure from our scholarship it should be because we really don't believe there is such a thing or that it has any usefulness. In for a penny, in for a pound.

Conversely, if we are not ready to commit to the consequences of such a robust communication perspective then we shouldn't trade on the entrepreneurism of our colleagues to seem fashionable and relevant in our field while quietly depending on the safety of established concepts so we can still appear as respectable organizational scholars to outsiders. That is, we shouldn't depend on other scholars to do the heavy lifting of elevating organizational communication among the disciplines if we're not willing to identify with the implications of their work. Or if we really do mean depth, stratification and distinct ontological status of structure in our analysis then we should be honest about this and clear that we are not aligned with much of the current scholarship in organizational communication. And if we really do think the agency-structure dilemma is valid and the best resolution is through a mutually constitutive duality, then we should recommit to structuration theory, even if it has fallen out of fashion of late and has critics on both sides.

However, as it stands, we do not have this level of conviction and clarity throughout the field of organizational communication. When people do mention structure without explanation it is unclear what is implied – perhaps the flat ontological position that is gaining momentum in current organizational communication scholarship, maybe the duality of agency and structure that was more widespread in previous scholarship, or possibly the depth ontology that is commonplace in organizational studies more broadly. And when structure is not discussed we do not know if this is because scholarship is moving on from the notion of structure, or because it is so established and accepted that it is not worth mentioning. What is clear is that when it comes to structure, we're not all talking about the same thing – but it is unclear whether we know this.

I hope I have demonstrated throughout this chapter that there are several reasonable and valid approaches to structure to inform organizational communication scholarship. Yet what is increasingly unacceptable is trying to dabble in each without a substantive commitment, as if there is a kind of alchemy at work that can somehow combine the best of each position while glossing over the inconsistencies without requiring a full account – that we can claim to foreground communication but still invoke unseen structural forces or ambiguous dualities when we get stuck and not have to pay a conceptual price. For the field of organizational communication this basically comes down to whether we think it's prudent and timely to make a clean break from traditional sociological roots and continue developing a distinct "communication perspective" that is based on a flattened ontology and hybrid/nonhuman agency, or if we need to stay tethered to established

concepts to maintain respectability as a legitimate field of organizational inquiry. Can we sustain our own independent endeavor, or will it eventually lead us to a cul-de-sac of obscurity, only able to have friendly conversations with our neighbors but limited impact on the broader community? Can we make legitimate communicative contributions to organizational studies in ways that are consistent with established notions of structure and agency, or will that cement our status as a perpetual younger sibling, part of the family but always getting the hand-me-downs, allowed to "complicate" some of the concepts but never question their validity? Or might we avoid tough (and perhaps unnecessary) choices, focusing our attention on the structuring capacity of communication while remaining agnostic or ecumenical about the ontological implications of that process? Whatever the case, the topic of structure is sure to maintain a prominent place in the field of organizational communication for the foreseeable future, either as a concept we continually refine or as a point of departure that defines our subsequent development as a field.

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Notes

1 See chapter 21 in this volume on *organizational types* for more on this subject.

2 And if it's *not* the case, then this is exactly the sort of conceptual confusion I'm talking about – using the language of critical realism and its depth ontology while meaning or intending something else.

Chapter 20 Generational Shifts: The Emergence of Visibility in Globalization Research

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Abstract

The frustration, sense of helplessness, and alienation we experience – what →Durkheim (1933) calls anomie – as global problems become ever more visible, make our incapacities to address these global problems through collective action starkly apparent. This paper explores the ways in which increased visibility has become a key aspect of global dynamics and a fundamental force in a new generation of work in global organizational communication. It builds on →Stohl and Ganesh's (2014) review of the first three generations of research on globalization and organizational communication to call for a new generation, the *Generation of Visibility*. First, we describe how the ascendance of visibility has reshaped globalization, paying attention to four processes of increased global crisis: magnification, monitorization, distortion, and refraction. We next review a corpus of pieces published since the turn of the millennium to explore how visibility has been worked into major organizational and communicative attributes of globalization research, as well as to describe how elements of a fourth generation have begun to surface as scholarship emphasizes visibility more and more as a communicative force within globalization. Finally, we call on future scholarship in organizational communication to attend to the emerging contours of visibility in research on globalization.

Keywords: anomie, crisis, dérèglement, distortion, generations of globalization, globalization, magnification, monitorization, refraction, visibility,

Not until the millennium did a handbook of organizational communication research include a chapter on globalization. The chapter, appearing in *The New Handbook of Organizational Communication* begins with quotations from corporate executives and an academic, all referring to a "new" global order (→Stohl 2001). Yet, globalization dynamics have been part of the organizational landscape for more than 400 years. The very first

multinational corporations, such as the East India Company, were established to support colonial expeditions funded by European powers; the industrial revolution enabled organizations to extend their influence across borders; two world wars brought together new forms of institutional building and global trade; and technological advancements in transportation and communication increased transnational employment. Yet little work in organizational communication explicitly addressed the theoretical and pragmatic implications of this history until the 1990s.

Since this belated start, the study of globalization by organizational communication scholars has burgeoned. Early research explored the uncertainties of globalization and communicating in a multicultural environment, then moved to examining issues of increased connectivity, studying networks and new forms of partnerships, and soon after, a new generation emerged in which globalization was seen as ubiquitous and global dynamics were no longer seen as just a special case of organizing (→Stohl and Ganesh 2014).

But in the last ten years major events have forced us to once again confront and question globalization, accentuating the wicked problems we encounter in our relentlessly interconnected world. The frustration, sense of helplessness, and alienation individuals and communities experience – what →Durkheim (1933) calls anomie – as global problems such as the COVID-19 pandemic, climate change, the refugee crisis, populism, disinformation, and intolerance become ever more visible, means that the incapacities of individuals, groups, organizations, civil society, and nation states to address these global problems through collective action has become starkly apparent.

Despite these troubling times, this chapter is not grounded in what many pundits and academics see as the collapse of globalization and global organizations. See, for example, *Foreign Policy*'s "Globalization Is Headed to the ICU" (→Walt 2020) and *The Economist*'s May 14, 2020, issue asking whether COVID-19 had killed globalization. Rather, it affirms the ascendance of visibility as a major force in assembling, sustaining, and transforming global organizing, even as such organizing is increasingly around global crises. Extending the work of →Leonardi and Treem (2020), for us, increased visibility refers to the reconfiguration of sociomaterial practices of organizing "in a format that can be observed by third parties through minimal effort such that patterns, causes, or motives can be inferred" (p. 1605). In this chapter we explore the ways in which increased visibility has become a key aspect of global dynamics and a fundamental force in a new generation of work in global organizational communication.

To get at this objective, we first review how the ascendance of visibility has reshaped globalization, paying attention to four processes that accentuate global crises: magnification, monitorization, distortion, and refraction. In the second part, we review how visibility is being worked into major organizational and communicative attributes of globalization research. As we do this, we describe how organizational communication scholarship continues to grapple with ongoing global problematics that surfaced in earlier generations of globalization research.

1 The Impact of Increased Visibility on Globalization Dynamics

Visibility has been identified as a major contemporary analytical category, not only for studies of globalization but for the social sciences at large (→Brighenti 2007). Digital transformation has enabled interactions with individuals, groups, organizations, and objects to create trails of data that can be compiled, evaluated, and reused, as well as made available to both vested audiences and non-vested third parties through multiple channels, locations, and time periods (→Leonardi and Treem 2020). →Flyverbom and Garsten (2021) identify how a mix of sources including narratives, numbers and digital traces contribute to an organization's ability to, "attempt to see, know and govern future affairs" (p. 19), and demonstrate the ways in which increased visibility has far reaching consequences for established assumptions about the nature and dynamics of communication. We argue that visibility reshapes globalization through the interdependent processes of *magnification*, *monitorization*, *distortion*, and *refraction* where issues in global organizing and communication quickly become unrelenting, dissociatingly malignant, and calamitous. In an age of visibility, an emerging research focus in studies of globalization is on the ways in which information is weaponized, communication is inauthentic, meanings are incompatible, and communities are fractionated. Optimal organizing solutions are no longer possible and satisficing invariably requires some sort of visibility management.

1.1 Magnification

While increasing visibility has been a part of the modern world since the Enlightenment, its acceleration and intensification in the new millennium have resulted in attenuating a fundamental dynamic of globalization even further: the compression of time and space. Increased availability and accessibility of all types and forms of messages and events regardless of

when or where they are happening have resulted in a kind of hyper-compression and intensification on a scale that the world has never seen.

Such intensity is well captured by the term *magnification* which signals the amplification of global phenomena, from pandemics to climate catastrophes, from humanitarian crises to disinformation, from corporate corruption to discriminatory practices. Magnification is a cross product of increased levels of visibility derived from an emerging computational infrastructure and algorithmic rendering of social activity multiplied by the hyperconnectivity of social life. We begin to see phenomena like global warming or economic disparity as what →Morton (2013) describes as "hyperobjects", entities of such vast temporal and spatial dimensions that they defeat traditional ideas about what a *thing* is or how it should be approached in the first place.

1.2 Monitorization

Monitorization describes a process whereby organizing and communicating are extracted into formats that make them amenable to observation, scrutiny, extraction, and manipulation. Recall →Andrejavic's (2007) now prescient observation that the digital enclosure characterizes an environment where every act of communication generates data about itself. Increased visibility and the subsequent monitorization of communication are a direct result of digitalization and the development of automated systems, social media platforms, smart devices, interconnected financial and production systems, and new and hybrid forms of organizing and socializing. The data monopolies produced and owned by Big Tech companies exert new forms of control in the global system. Power is increasingly derived from the ability to see and trace what people and systems do, what →Zuboff (2019) describes as "instrumentarian power" (p. 8). Although instrumentarian power is enabled by the Internet and smart devices, it is a primarily human global capitalist economic system that benefits those with the ability to access and utilize that which has been rendered visible.

1.3 Distortion

Ironically, in times of distrust and suspicion, increasing pressures for organizational transparency and accountability have often resulted in new ways to produce opacity and misleading information, be it camouflage, information overload, or other mechanisms of secrecy and misalignment. The complex and permanent *distortions* in the communication environment often stem from monitorization in the "act of digital

dispossession", which →Zuboff (2019) operationalizes as the "*rendition* of human experience as behavioral data" (p. 233). Under these conditions, secrecy-by-design and heightened surveillance and sousveillance (→Mann, Nolan, and Wellman 2003), become fundamental features of organizing. Zuboff, in a 2020 *New York Times* editorial, wrote while talking about social media platforms that, "Only repeated crises have taught us that these platforms are not bulletin boards but hyper-velocity global bloodstreams into which anyone may introduce a dangerous virus without a vaccine" (→Zuboff 2020). Distortion is thus now in the DNA of global organizing. The twin axes of misinformation and disinformation are not externalities in this system; they are intrinsic features of a world driven by visibility. When distortion becomes the *sine qua non* of organizing, we lose trust in organizations and institutions and authority becomes ever more suspect as simultaneously new and insidious forms of non-institutional voice are buttressed.

1.4 Refraction

Traditionally, globalization involves increasing global consciousness through self-reflexivity, i.e., a process of self-understanding, self-positioning, and repositioning, based on the increasing awareness of different cultural norms. But the condition of heightened visibility increasingly *refracts* that consciousness. Visibilities of both global convergence and divergence means that there is no longer a single point of reconciliation with a global world; rather it is with the refraction that results from not only our own overlapping identities (e.g., sexual orientation, gender identities, ethnicity, religious identity, age), but the overlapping identities of all those individuals and groups around us. Compared to the "looking glass self" of the past (→Cooley 1902), contemporary identities are reflected in a fractured mirror; global consciousness is contested at local, regional, and global levels, and no longer can we easily expect it to engender cosmopolitanism, but rather the sense of fractionated and fragmented identities corrodes, complicates, and disorganizes global dynamics, contributing to contemporary anomie.

2 Visibility as a Fourth Generation of Organizational Communication Research on Globalization

In previous work, →Stohl and Ganesh (2014) described the first three generations of research on globalization in terms of two distinct sets of attributes related to the ontological and communicative aspects of global organizing, evident in the organizational communication literature.

Communication is, of course, an inextricable part of the ontology of globalization – and vice versa – yet, as →Stohl and Ganesh (2014) established, scholars ask distinct and different questions and concerns when they zoom in on one or the other set of attributes. The first set becomes salient when one asks the question "what is globalization?" Each generation of research carries a distinct set of beliefs and assumptions about what 'counts' as globalization and its main research problematics; where globalization is located, who its agents are, and what kind of organizational phenomena are under investigation.

A second set of attributes are thrown into relief when one asks, more specifically, "what is communication?" Here, →Stohl and Ganesh (2014) showed how each generation of organizational communication research focuses upon different kinds of communication logics, constructs communication problems in distinct ways, consequently, formulating communication competencies differently; and conceives of ethical dilemmas related to communication in different ways. Detailed discussions of each attribute can be found in →Stohl and Ganesh (2014), and a summary of all attributes can be found in →Table 1.

Table 1: Four Generations of Globalization Research.

	The generation of uncertainty	**The generation of connectivity**	**The generation of ubiquity**	**The generation of visibility**
Ontological attributes of globalization				
Problematic of globalization	Is globalization a distinct and unique phenomenon of the time?	Globalization exists and is at the foreground of study. How do organizations respond to globalization dynamics?	Globalization exists in the background. What is the relationship between individual efficacy and organizational action?	Globalization embodies systemic distortions. How do we act collectively to address structural crises?
Locus of globalization	Formal organizations	Interorganizational linkages	Liminal or transnational public sphere	Flows – economic, cultural, ecological physical, ideological
Agents of globalization	Formal members of organizations	Interorganizational actors, boundary spanners	Entrepreneurial actors, community stakeholders	Aggregators – entities that collect, curate, separate, sort, declassify, and destroy data
Foundational debate: organizational form	Are there distinct organizational forms that can be called global?	What are relationships among organizations in the global system?	Are formal organizations still relevant?	Are organizational forms distinct?
Communicative attributes of globalization				
Communication logic	Intergroup logic	Networking logic	Deinstitutionalized logic	Anomic logic
Communication problem	Engaging intercultural differences	Creating new forms of partnerships	Collective action	Optical illusion
Communication skill: global communicative competence	Cultural awareness and accommodation	Building extensive and effective relations	Coherency management	Satisficing

	The generation of uncertainty	The generation of connectivity	The generation of ubiquity	The generation of visibility
Foundational debate: communication ethics	Cultural relativity vs. universalism, each as evidence of a form of cultural imperialism	Communitarianism vs. cosmopolitanism	Individual efficacy vs. expanded corporate interest	Transparency vs. surveillance

The 2014 review of these ontological and communicative attributes, grounded in research on globalization in organizational communication studies published both in the 20th century as well as the 21st century, established that all three generations of research on globalization were alive, intermingling, and flourishing in the field. In this project, *we began by focusing upon research on globalization published since the turn of the millennium* to better enable us to examine what may have changed and what may have stayed the same about such research. We identified a robust body of work published in organizational communication studies between the years 2000 and 2021 – at least 113 articles and books. As we parsed through this body of work, we realized that not only were all three generations of work continuing to have an impact on how scholars formulated organization, communication, and globalization, but there were elements of what appeared to be a fourth generation of work on globalization, both as research on the subject began to emphasize visibility more and more as a communicative force. Additionally, we observed a shift in tone in research across all generations of research: instead of treating globalization as an emerging or inexorable force, scholarship began, more and more, to treat globalization in terms of crisis.

In what follows, we review how visibility is being worked into organizational communication scholarship by taking up the ontological and communicative attributes of this research, along the lines of →Stohl and Ganesh's (2014) schema. Thus, we compare fundamental ontological and communicative attributes of the contemporary generation with those that preceded it, using illustrative examples from organizational communication research. These examples draw from research produced since the publication of →Stohl and Ganesh's (2014) review of the first three generations of research on globalization and organizational communication. →Table 1 extends that work, summarizing the communicative and ontological attributes of all four generations of

organizational communication research on globalization. We discuss them in detail below.

3 Ontological Attributes of Contemporary Globalization Research

Four attributes have historically come into focus when one asks how different generations of research understand what counts as globalization. The first of these relate to the central problematic of globalization. The first generation, true to its name “Uncertainty”, asked, as a central question, what globalization was, and whether and how it was having a unique impact on communication and organizing. We observe that while debates about the newness, scale, intensity, and extensity of globalization were put to rest in the 1990s, scholars continue to work with the building blocks of this question: the compression of time and space, disembeddedness of events, and reflexivity (→Monge 1998). A recent scholarly forum on the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic – itself a global phenomenon – asked how the pandemic would impact globalization, wondering: “how is our global organizational society and discourse influenced by and influencing adaptations to pandemic-related uncertainty?” (→Stephens et al. 2020: 443).

Work influenced by the second generation of research, “Connectivity”, continues to think through its central problematic: organizing problems related to the interconnectedness produced by globalization. →Büchler, ter Hoeven and van Zoonen (2020), for instance, examined the impact of constant connectivity upon employee wellbeing in a large global corporation, finding that it reduced wellbeing by disabling their ability to psychologically detach from work. Scholarship also continues to work with the problematic raised by a third generation of scholarship on ubiquity: how does organizing itself occur when formal organizational structures appear obsolete and individual agency appears supreme? A case in point is →Mazmanian’s (2019) commentary on worker/smartphone hybrids, which speculates provocatively on how this particular form of agency is put together in the service of late capitalism.

The central problematic of the emerging generation of visibility, systemic distortions, emerges from and cuts across the problematics posed by earlier generations. Here, globalization is understood as ubiquitously behind and built into the crises that we face collectively. These crises are far reaching in their consequence because of collective interconnectedness, and uncertain in their consequences and eventual impact. The focus is therefore how increased visibility accentuates crises through magnification, monitorization, distortion, and refraction, and the

central question that such research asks can be couched as: How do/can we act collectively to address structural and global crises that engage issues such as human rights and social justice, inequality, corruption, pandemics, global trade, climate change, environmental degradation, and populism? A good example of such research is →Etter and Albu's (2021) study of two activist organizations in Tunisia that work on issues such as corruption, and the public right to information. Through participating in protests and scraping data, they outline how "*algorithmic distortion* (through information overload, creation of opacity, and disinformation) [...] constrains the actualization of collective affordances" (p. 75).

Two other core attributes relating to the ontology of globalization have to do with the locus of globalization, and the agents of globalization. Historically, the three established generations of globalization research have treated these in distinct terms. For research on "Uncertainty", the locus of globalization are formal organizations, and the members of those organizations. For research on "Connectivity", the locus of globalization are networks, and the agents are interorganizational actors and boundary spanners. And for research grounded in "Ubiquity", the locus of globalization is the liminal or transnational public sphere, and key agents are entrepreneurial actors.

We find that elements of all three generations are present in contemporary organizational communication research that implicates a locus for and agents of globalization. For instance, →Kim's (2018) study of a large global organization established how internal social media use and internal hierarchy insidiously reinforced each other, buttressing the power of high-status employees. A good example of second-generation research on the subject is →Bean and Buikema's (2015) work on Al-Qaeda which showed how key nodes lost control of this secretive and relatively hidden global terrorist network. →Dawson and Brunner's (2020) study of corporate social responsibility coined the term 'wild social network' to describe how Patagonia, ostensibly a large global organization, acted like an entrepreneurial political activist, launching an inflammatory political campaign titled "The President Stole Your Land", thereby harnessing "politically energized discourses, and fragmented conversations that travel wildly across platforms to raise awareness" (p. 60). →Saffer, Pilny, and Sommerfeldt (2022) demonstrates that in a network of global civil society organizational, preferential treatment might lead to homophily of leadership based on preferential treatment and multidimensional relationships

In globalization research that centers visibility, the focus is no longer on places per se, or on networks or nodes, but on increasingly visible *movement*. The locus of globalization is, therefore, a global flow

(→Appadurai 1996) which may encompass multiple domains or scapes: economic, cultural, linguistic, ecological, or ideological. In fact, increasing visibility, inevitably digital in nature, enables us to track constant fast-paced movement, dynamism, and deepening intensification. Organizational communication work on fluidity and liquidity exemplifies such focus. →Dobusch and Schoeneborn (2015) for instance, understand fluidity as a property of all contemporary social collectives, and use this frame to analyze how Anonymous, the iconic dispersed and hidden hacker collective, achieved organizationality, i.e., identity and actorhood. Another good example of such work is →Cruz and Sodeke's (2021) work on postcolonial liquidity and organizing that identifies three qualities of such liquidity – motion, solvency, and permeability – arguing that necrocapital logics fuel such liquidity, even as marginalized actors seek it out as a space in which to thrive.

Likewise, research on visibility and globalization positions its agents as nodes that maneuver through global flows. We tentatively refer to these nodes as aggregators: entities that are engaged in collecting, curating, separating, sorting, declassifying, and destroying data, and then putting that in place, regardless of whether that place is hidden or open. Perhaps the simplest example of such aggregation is an algorithm (e.g., →Leonardi and Treem 2020), but such agents include key players in surveillance capitalism, including Big Tech, and also smaller entrepreneurial companies, such as Pegasus. →Etter and Albu's (2021) study, which we have already mentioned, positions algorithms as agents of distortion and control. →Alkhatib, Bernstein, and Levi's (2017) article on gig work, a form of on-demand labor popularized by growing Internet access, analyzes the influence that decentralizing labor through online platforms has on the agency of workers through the historical lens of piecework.

A final salient attribute when thinking through the ontology of globalization has to do with the question of organizational form – what →Stohl and Ganesh (2014) referred to as a "foundational debate". For the first generation of research, concerned with uncertainty, the question was whether there were distinctive forms of organization that could be called global. A second generation took this question as addressed, and instead addressed the nature of relationships among organizations in the global order. The third generation, where globalization was taken as ubiquitous, asked whether organizations themselves were still relevant, and if so, how.

As is the case with the other attributes, generational legacy still makes its presence felt in organizational communication research. However, the legacy of second-generation and third-generation concerns about

organizational form appear to be much more salient in contemporary research, and with good reason. The debate about whether there were distinct forms of organization that could be called global receded in the wake of the slew of research in the 1990s on network forms of organizing, as well as the more recent acceptance that globalization was also part of the fabric of everyday organizing practice. Consequently, there is still considerable concern with the nature and shape of global networks. →Atouba and Shumate (2010) for example, examined the role of homophily in creating international nonprofit networks, an archetypally second-generation concern. →Stephens's (2019) research on emergent forms of organizing during disaster events finds that informal, ad hoc, and short-lived forms of organizing have unexpected efficacy, thereby displaying a third-generation concern with whether or how formal organizations are still a necessary part of the organizing landscape.

The emerging emphasis on visibility in organizational communication research on globalization asks a related question about organizational form: are they still distinct? Increasing visibility suggests that organizational forms collide with greater frequency. As →Ganesh and Stohl (2020) argue: "Heightened visibility makes it impossible for different organizing forms to not 'see' each other in the organizing environment; consequently, the velocity and scale of organizational mimesis is likely to increase, resulting in increasingly hybrid organizing forms across sectors". →Ganesh, Stohl, and Kim's (2022) research on organizing archetypes in the digital landscape, which examines the place of organizationally driven versus organizationally embryonic archetypes in contemporary activist organizing, observed that entrepreneurial forms of digital engagement, usually associated with organizationally embryonic archetypes, appeared to be spreading in organizationally driven archetypes for collective action. Indeed, this mimics the same trend observed by →Dawson and Brunner's (2020) study of Patagonia, which documented how this iconic large organization began to act like digital activists.

4 Communicative Attributes of Contemporary Organizational Communication Research on Globalization

When scholars of organizational communication and globalization have turned their attention to communication as the object of inquiry, as distinct from global organizational arrangements in general, four attributes have been salient. The first of these pertains to communication logics, defined by →Stohl and Ganesh (2014) as "fundamental principles that guide interaction" (p. 720). First-generation communication logics have emphasized intergroup dynamics, not surprising as much early work

on globalization in organizational communication studies came from the study of intercultural differences at work. We note, for instance, that Triandis and Albert's foundational chapter in the 1987 *Handbook of Organizational Communication* reviewed how communication patterns differed by country and the impact of those differences on organizational activities. This emphasis continues in organizational communication research today. →Elers, Dutta, and Elers's (2021) deft analysis of contemporary hypervigilant othering of Pasifika and Māori cultures by dominant Pākehā cultures that shape charitable and community services in Aotearoa New Zealand is a case in point.

Networking logics, which emerged from second-generation scholarship, continue to shape how organizational communication scholars view globalization. For instance, →Fu's (2019) study of a network of 184 environmental organizations across the world found that while organizations sought out connections with groups that were the most digitally active, they maintained connections over time with groups that were geographically more proximate to them. Third-generation scholarship on deinstitutionalized logics of communication that destabilize formal organizations continue to be seen in scholarship. For instance, →Mitra's (2018) study of natural resource management dynamics in the Arctic demonstrated how groups developed flexible organizing logics that did not center organizations.

Studies that focus on visibility and globalization tend to emphasize what we call an anomic logic. Grounded in →Durkheim's (1933) conception of anomie, it encompasses not only feelings of alienation, estrangement, and despair, but also implicates social structure itself, summarized by the notion of *dérèglement* – "a rule that is a lack of rule". That is, there are no grounds, procedures, or rules upon which to act. This logic is evident to some degree in the notion of VUCA – volatility, uncertainty, complexity, and ambiguity – produced as a result of a systemic shock that appears in some organizational communication scholarship. For example, →Ganesh and Stohl (2020) draw on VUCA to describe the intemperate quality of contemporary digital environments. →Schwartzman (2020), drawing on Klein, also outlines how large systemic crises create a sense of shock, upheaval, and ultimately, docility. As Jensen, Rolison, and Barbour 2022 say: "constant interaction, digital interruptions, and shrinking time to think and act characterize much of present-day communication" (p. 1).

Each generation of globalization research also conceives of communication problems and related competencies in different ways, and the legacy of those formulations is very clear in contemporary scholarship. For instance, first-generation scholarship understands the main

communication problem related to globalization as the need to engage intercultural differences; relatedly, the communication competence such scholarship focuses upon tends to be cultural awareness, accommodation, and explanation. Current studies of issue management and message design continue this legacy. →Barbour, Doshi, and Hernández's (2016) study of global health messages, for example, argued that narrative approaches that center cultural logics are particularly important in global public health because of the "reach, importance and scientific complexity" of such issues (p. 811).

Second-generation scholarship on globalization understands key communication problems to be those related to creating new forms of partnerships, and the related communication competence as building "extensive and effective stakeholder relations" (→Stohl and Ganesh 2014: 720). →Foot, Sworn, and Alejano-Steele's (2021) study of counter-trafficking coalitions in the Global South is an excellent example of such work. The study identifies the complex challenges for coalition-building in the Global South, given the fragile nature of much non-governmental organizational (NGO) work and dramatically changing forms of political control and legal frameworks, arguing that positive partnership outcomes were largely a product of leadership practices that fostered, "equity, constructive decision-making, goal-oriented activity, positive influence of the coalition on member organizations, positive relational environment, and inclusivity of diverse member organizations" (p. 438). →Banghart, Etter, and Stohl (2018) also explored this problem in their work on organizational boundary regulation via policies on social media, investigating the line between personal, professional, and public communication when building relations between stakeholders. The authors argued that recognizing these boundaries lead to recognition of expanded corporate control in a more digitized and globalized society.

Third-generation scholarship centers communication problems that relate to difficulties in accomplishing any kind of collective action in the face of digital cultivation of individual efficacy, the mushrooming of ad hoc and improvisational organizing practices, and the multisectional nature of social problems themselves. Consequently, the principal competency is coherence management that helps actors navigate through multiple discourses, diffuse environments, and information overload. Such work continues to flourish. For instance, →Huang and Zhang's (2019) study of employee WeChat use for work found that it created deep paradoxes of engagement, formality, and visibility that then hampered collective engagement, and which they then negotiated by either making up new rules, trying to control such chaotic communicative encounters, or withdrawing from them altogether. Similarly, →Alkhatib, Bernstein, and

Levi (2017) found that gig workers engage in a complex ecosystem of dichotomies between limits and opportunity as tasks become smaller and further decentralized.

Emerging scholarship on visibility certainly addresses problems and competencies highlighted in previous generations of globalization research. However, it reframes communication problems in terms of what one might call optical illusions. The term 'illusion' does not just indicate that what we see is not actually present; rather, more broadly, it implies that with increased visibility, we can see multiple 'illusions' in particular sets of aggregated data. Work on hidden organization exemplifies the concern with optical illusions as a communication problem, highlighting that hiddenness in the contemporary era requires considerable communicative labor (→Scott 2015). The manner in which organizations digitally curate their identities and presence and co-author them with audiences is another example of how illusion has become a central communication problem (e.g., →Dawson 2018). In their piece on global virtual teams, →Gibbs et al. (2021) describe the construction of subgroups as part of the dynamic process of global teamwork, challenging the illusion that subgroups are instead representative of collective faultlines.

The communication competence that appears to be emerging in scholarship on visibility and globalization is best described using Simon's groundbreaking heuristic, satisficing: a communicative skill that aims for a satisfactory or adequate result, rather than an optimal solution (→Simon 1987). When visibility is dominant, and communicative activity is evident for all to see, yet shared meanings cannot be assumed – and in many cases do not exist – optimal communication solutions become impossible, and the focus becomes much more on making do or coping. The considerable interest in work on resilience in organizational communication studies, in our view, is an index of this tilt (e.g., →Buzzanell 2018, →2021). Schwartzman's recent "Performing Pandemic Pedagogy" (→2020) also illustrates how the global pandemic has resulted in radical forms of improvisations to keep basic tasks of teaching and learning afloat.

The fourth communicative attribute emphasized across various generations of research on globalization has to do with communication ethics. Each generation has featured an archetypal ethical debate. For first-generation researchers, that debate often took the form of cultural relativity versus universalism. We observe that this historic debate has, if anything, accentuated in the last ten years and is especially evident in postcolonial approaches to organizational communication. Cruz's articulation of African feminism and its emphasis upon holism, collectivity, and situationality (→Cruz 2017) and her exposition of the Eurocentric

biases of organizational communication theory alongside Sodeke (→Cruz and Sodeke 2021) are an important case in point. →Dutta and Thaker (2019) also demonstrate this debate in their look into resistance strategies of women farmers in India, strategies that involved culturally centered collaboration against corporate global agriculture movements.

Second-generation debates about communication ethics often center communitarianism on one hand and cosmopolitanism on the other, and ask whether and how morality, responsibility, and accountability ought to be positioned, either as common social goods or as properties of communities. This debate is also ongoing in the field, and perhaps most alive in current work on global corporate social responsibility (CSR) and the continued questioning of whether and how CSR messages matter and to whom (→Maktoufi, O'Connor, and Shumate 2020). Third-generation scholarship on communication ethics centers the paradoxical relationship between expansive forms of corporate control on one hand, and individual efficacy and empowerment on the other. →Mazmanian's (2019) discussion of worker/smartphone agency, for instance, talks about its fundamental duality: on the one hand it represents a considerably powerful (albeit specific) form of individual efficacy; on the other, that very efficacy is the product of a broader actor-network and set of relations (→Kuhn, Ashcraft, and Cooren 2017).

How does emerging scholarship on visibility and globalization frame and treat communication ethics? The fundamental debate evident in organizational communication studies appears to be the tension between transparency on one hand and surveillance on the other. This body of work considerably complicates how we understand both phenomena. →Flyverbom, Christensen, and Hansen's (2015) work on transparency and global governance, for instance, questions its easy assertion as a practice of empowerment, and positions it as fundamentally intertwined with power, a kind of control in its own right. Conversely, →Südkamp and Dempsey's (2021) work on transparency discusses how it emerged as a resistant practice in nonprofit and NGO contexts that mitigates against the increasingly precarious conditions of employment by using it as leverage to make visible data about wages and work. →Mease (2021) uses →Albu's (2019) analysis of a Tunisian civil society organization working on human rights to argue that state-sponsored surveillance practices reveal how increased visibility is not just a signal of social order, they indicate, in equal measure, disorder and chaos. We expect such research to continue to sort through the variegated contours of debates about both transparency as well as surveillance, where ironies continue to proliferate. For instance, some scholars in fields such as information systems, have begun to discuss South Korea's 'virtuous surveillance', a system that used

phone location data, public CCTV systems, facial recognition software, and even credit card data to track individual whereabouts, as a complicated and problematic post-COVID ethic (→Riemer et al. 2020). The implications for organizational communication studies of such issues is immense.

5 Directions for Further Research

Taking the ontological and communicative attributes of a generation of visibility into account, we call upon current and future scholarship to engage with the visible as a foundation, rather than simply a facet, of communicative inquiry. To do so, we predict that further investigations will and should continue to engage with research sites using a multifaceted approach to overlapping generational attributes, a nuanced understanding of technological affordances and constraints, and an updated inquisitive sensibility to research mindsets and approaches.

Primarily, we recognize that studies of visibility are often technologically grounded and draw attention to digital media, data, affordances, technical surveillance, algorithms, and so forth. We believe it is important for scholarship to examine visibility in ways that center broader communication contexts, ethics, and issues. For instance, what would a fourth-generation study of CSR look like? We believe that instead of focusing primarily on technology itself, post-pandemic CSR initiatives themselves will intervene more vigorously in contemporary social and environmental controversies and challenges, centering the ethics and social impact of global circular economy initiatives, and attending to the increasing post-pandemic sustainability crises of global supply chains.

Next, we believe future research on globalization by organizational communication scholars should begin inquiry with an updated research sensibility. Visibility, when taken as a centralizing force for analyzing and understanding communication phenomena, calls for varied epistemological and methodological approaches to global organizational communication scholarship. Further scholarship should challenge the assumed best practices for qualitative and quantitative inquiry, continuously questioning the historical delineation between the two, and instead further investigate the best mode of examination in response to contemporary global crises and issues of visibility.

Finally, while the corpus upon which we have based our conclusions covered the period from 2001 to 2021, we note that 2022 and 2023 have seen an upsurge in the publication of organizational communication research on globalization. By our count, at least 30 pieces have been published on the subject by scholars who describe themselves as organizational communication researchers. We find that these pieces, as

we suggested three years ago, tend towards hybridity, drawing from multiple generations of research (e.g., →Navick and Gibbs 2023). We also find an increasing attention to visibility (e.g., →Harness, Ganesh, and Stohl 2022), and crucially, the place of crisis is more central to organizational communication research on globalization, whether such research foregrounds issues of communication visibility or not (e.g., →Albu, 2023). The latter is probably not surprising given that the global COVID pandemic and its aftermath attracted a considerable amount of attention from researchers in the US and beyond (e.g., →Browning, Sørnes, and Svenkerud 2022). It seems reasonable to surmise that these trends will stay in place for a while.

6 Conclusion

In this chapter, we explored the ways increased visibility has become a key aspect of global dynamics and a fundamental force in a new generation of work in global organizational communication. We demonstrated how the four processes of magnification, monitorization, distortion, and refraction have reshaped global flows and identified the ontological and communicative attributes of an emerging generation of scholarship on visibility. At the same time, we showed how previous generations of research on globalization continue to flourish in organizational communication studies. This is hardly surprising. The specific ontological and communicative attributes of each generation stem from questions researchers continue to ask about broad organizational communication phenomena and constructs, such as: How do organizations work as cultures? How do networks form and dissolve? What is the impact of digital technology? These questions and more drive our continuously changing program of research as a field of inquiry and we should continue to question our methods, standpoints, and understandings of the field as a whole.

The contemporary era asks us to take more seriously and fundamentally the idea of global anomie and its broad communicative significance. Global crises on everything from social justice, global health, populism, and climate catastrophes will continue to exacerbate both subjective (individual) and objective (structural) realms of *dérèglement*. Asking what sorts of challenges these crises pose, attempting to learn what impact they are having on our collective psyches, relationships, and connections to each other and the world itself, and even attempting to predict further dystopic impacts, are among the most important tasks facing our field today. It is critical that we find appropriate vocabularies

and methods to discuss, come to terms with, and act upon these issues. We hope this essay is one step in that direction.

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Chapter 21 Types of Organizations

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Abstract

This chapter examines various “types of organizations” (and subtypes within each) as an important issue for scholars because of the evolving and expanding nature of organizational types. It begins with a review of major existing types of organizations – including for-profits, nonprofits, benefit corporations, government/public, etc. Two other broad approaches to understanding types of organizations are then presented. First, hidden/clandestine organizations represent a less visible type of collective found in various parts of society that may differ in key ways from more visible forms. Second, a range of other alternative organizational types that depart in significant ways from traditional forms are discussed (e.g., cooperatives, decentralized autonomous organizations, temporary organizations, etc.). The chapter concludes with a brief discussion about future work in our field around the topic of organizational types.

Keywords: alternative organizations, benefit corporations, clandestine organizations, cooperatives, decentralized autonomous organizations, for-profits, gig economy (see sharing economy), hidden organizations, network organizing, nonprofits, public/government organizations, sharing economy, temporary organizing,

The desire to classify organizations into various types is nothing new. Most people already recognize some of the most basic types, several of which are defined by their opposites: for-profit and nonprofit, governmental and nongovernmental, public and private, startup and well-established, virtual and brick-and-mortar, etc. Although these familiar labels may describe many of the types that have been most widely studied, these account for only some of the many organizations found in our world today. Increased attention to issues surrounding transparency and visibility management, new technologies, and more democratic/non-hierarchical ideals have also contributed to an expanding array of organizational types. These emerging types are also relevant to the study

of organizational communication in part because they are based on different assumptions about communication and may influence communicative processes and outcomes in unexpected ways.

Despite the existence of several traditional and emerging types, a fair amount of scholarship glosses over organizational type by gathering data from members across multiple organizations – with type then reduced to a descriptive element of the sample at best. Other research demonstrates an implicit awareness of the importance of organizational type by examining only one organization or one type – but too often this research then ignores organizational type as an important construct itself. Some organizational communication scholarship makes comparisons between two or more types to highlight similarities/differences between them; however, this work is relatively uncommon and rarely digs into organizational type as an explanation for key findings. Furthermore, such comparisons almost never involve any of the emerging types examined in this chapter. We believe that a consideration of organizational type and the ways in which such types influence communication is vital. We see value in making distinctions between different types of organizations because the world is filled with a wide variety of collectives. Classifying them into types that we can then analyze helps to highlight similarities and difference within and across them – variations that may grow amid forces related to globalization, hyper-capitalism, transparency, and technology. It is not enough to simply theorize about such type-based differences; we need to see that reflected in our research as well.

The goal of the chapter is to examine "types of organizations" (and subtypes within each) as an important issue for communication scholars – partly because it is also evolving and expanding. We begin with a review of major existing types of organizations. Two other broad approaches to understanding types of organizations are then presented. First, hidden/clandestine organizations represent a less visible type of collective found in various parts of society that may differ in key ways from more visible types. Second, a range of other "alternative" organizational types that depart in significant ways from traditional forms are discussed (e.g., cooperatives, decentralized autonomous organizations, temporary organizations, etc.). The chapter concludes with a brief discussion about future work in our field around the topic of organizational types.

1 Traditional Types of Organizations

In general, types should be understood as largely separate from organizational structure, form, or design. Of course, some types may be associated with certain structures/forms and sometimes types are defined

at least in part by the structure: bureaucratic/hierarchical, network, etc. As we see it, “type” refers to a high-level categorization or classification that helps to group organizations with common characteristics. Within those types is the possibility of various subtypes as well. Even with a focus on organizational types specifically, a wide range of labels can be found in textbooks and the research literature. Much of that work comes from Western capitalistic theorizing about organizing; thus, issues surrounding ownership and profit orientation have been heavily emphasized. However, other traditional bases for classifying organizations can also be identified.

1.1 For-Profit vs. Nonprofit

Two of the broadest types of organizations are for-profit and nonprofit. →Zhu, Wang, and Bart (2016) suggest key differences between the two based on revenue source and organizational mission. For-profit organizations generate revenues on the products or services supplied whereas nonprofit organizations rely mainly on donations from private contributions, public support, or private sector payments. These authors argue that for-profits have historically been focused on shareholder or owner interests (i.e., profits), whereas nonprofit organizations are responsive to a wider range of stakeholders.

1.1.1 For-Profits

What first comes to mind when we talk about organizations in many societies are a range of for-profit entities. They typically represent the largest employers and the most visible collectives, especially in more developed countries. An examination of the research literature in organizational communication reveals a strong focus on for-profits.

One way to further classify these types of organizations is based on various sectors and industries. For example, the North American Industry Classification System (formerly the Standard Industry Codes) lists 20 sectors (e.g., educational services, manufacturing, retail trade, information, etc.). The product-service and publicly held/privately held (including family-owned) distinctions may also be useful subtypes describing for-profits.

Another way to classify for-profits is based on the tax status of such entities. For example, the US Internal Revenue Service (n.d.) has these classifications: sole proprietorships are unincorporated entities owned by a single person; partnerships are relationships between two or more people who share in profits/losses; C corporations legally separate

owners' or shareholders' assets and income from that of the corporation; S corporations are a special type that have the benefits of a corporation and the tax-exempt privileges of a partnership; limited liability companies are allowed by state statutes and combine characteristics of corporations with those of partnerships or sole proprietorships to protect owners from personal responsibility for debts/liabilities. These tax-based types can be found in non-Western cultures as well. In Japan (→Oda 2009), the basic types are limited liability partnerships (*yūgen sekinin jigyō kumiai*); *Kabushiki kaisha* (like a corporation); *Gōdō kaisha* (similar to a limited liability company); *Gōmei kaisha* (general partnership); and *Gōshi kaisha* (a limited partnership). Legal entities in Ghana (GLEIF, n.d.) take one of these official forms: sole proprietorship, private limited by share, private unlimited by share, private limited by guarantee, public unlimited company, external company, public limited company, public limited by guarantee, partnership, and subsidiary business name. Communication research examining these various types across countries on issues like stakeholders, risk, and social responsibility could be especially informative.

There are several other typologies/taxonomies found in the organizational studies literature that primarily describe for-profits. These include →Woodward's (1958) typology based on production technology (small batch, large batch, and continuous process); →Parsons's (1956) functional types (economic, political, integrative, and pattern maintenance); →Thompson's (1967) examination of differences in core technology (long-linked, mediating, or intensive); →Miles and Snow's (1978) typology of organizational configurations (prospector, analyzer, defender, and reactor); →Mintzberg's (1979) variations that include simple structure, machine bureaucracy, professional bureaucracy, divisionalized form, and adhocracy; and →Meyer's (1977) typology of insular, oligopolistic, competitive, administrative, and composite organizations.

1.1.2 *Nonprofits*

→Lewis (2005) describes the enormous size of the nonprofit (or civil society) sector in the US and other parts of the world (where nongovernmental, or NGO, is often the term used). →Keatinge (2009) describes three common types of nonprofits: charities or public benefit organizations (usually 501c3s in the tax code), mutual benefit organizations (e.g., business leagues or homeowners associations), and religious organizations. In some cases, that second group is separately

called not-for-profit because it is run by unpaid volunteers and does not have a profit goal.

→Salamon and Anheier (1992) provide an extensive list of existing classifications for nonprofit organizations at the time, including the UN International Standard Industrial Classification (ISIC) of all economic activities, the National Taxonomy of Exempt Entities (NTEE) developed by the National Council of Charitable Statistics in the United States, and the General Industrial Classification of Economic Activities (NACE) developed by the European Statistical Office. Based on limitations of existing schemes those authors offer a new International Classification of Nonprofit Organizations composed of 12 activity groups: culture and recreation, education and research, health, social services, environment, development and housing, law/advocacy/politics, philanthropic intermediaries and voluntarism promotion, international activities, religion, business/professional associations and unions, and other.

→Lewis (2005) notes that even though substantial work has been done on nonprofit organizations (NPOs), less often have we focused on the characteristics of nonprofits directly. She argues "it is important to recognize the great range in types of NPOs" (p. 244), which may vary based on hard (size, budget, infrastructure) and more intangible (mission, commitment of volunteers, diversity of membership) criteria. Based on that, Lewis argues there may be sizable differences between nonprofit hospitals, churches, grassroots advocacy organizations, and membership clubs. Each of these might be considered a subtype of nonprofit organization. →Koschmann, Isbell, and Sanders (2015) have also provided a useful review of communication research in the nonprofit literature – some of which is also suggestive of future research comparing nonprofits to other types.

1.1.3 *Blurring For-Profit and Nonprofit: Benefit Corporations*

Scholars have noted that it is not uncommon for some nonprofits to act like for-profit businesses at times. One prime example of this is benefit corporations (BCs), which are an emerging hybrid type of organization. Although they are considered for-profit corporations, BCs are obligated to provide a general public benefit (→Hiller 2013) with a primary focus on maximizing contributions to the common good rather than focusing only on shareholders. The Model Benefit Corporation Legislation (MBCL) outlines the requirements for BCs and what constitutes a public benefit (→Robson 2016). One of those requirements is using a third-party reporting agency to evaluate their performance. Robson argues this

allows for a flexible and adaptive structure to accommodate various value-driven entities.

→Kopaneva and Cheney (2019: 506) contend "the significance of BCs goes beyond the matter of socially conscious individuals starting mission-driven organization." Communication scholars are well positioned to better understand BCs' identity formation as they bring a stronger social responsibility orientation to the business sector. Other scholars such as →Hiller (2013) relate BCs to theories of corporate social responsibility (CSR). Future research should examine if BCs as a hybrid type can effectively promote corporate responsibility.

1.2 Other Traditional Types

Several other traditional types are either distinct from for-profits and nonprofits or are based on entirely different sets of issues. The most prominent of these is government or public (not to be confused with publicly traded organizations in the private sector). Public organizations are owned and operated by the government (→Antonsen and Jørgensen 1997) and are usually funded through taxes. These include a wide range of agencies, ministries, departments, bureaus, schools, courts, and policing/military units that exist on multiple levels. So, in addition to local public schools and police departments as well as state/federal courts and agencies, we can also have intergovernmental organizations – which involve multiple nations working together on issues of common interest (e.g., United Nations, African Development Bank).

Public/government organizations may also vary from one another. →Antonsen and Jørgensen (1997) argue that Danish public organizations vary on their degree of publicness, which they define as attachment to public sector values (e.g., due process, welfare provision). Part of that variation is due to blurring with other types. Government/public organizations can mix with for-profits and nonprofits to create public-private or public-nonprofit partnerships or quasi-governmental organizations (e.g., Amtrak, Smithsonian Institution). Government-sponsored enterprises that operate like private organizations (e.g., Fannie Mae, Freddie Mac) but are created and financially backed by the government provide another example of this.

Other traditional types are based on life cycle (e.g., startup organizations, established legacy organizations), number of employees or other measures of size (e.g., small-to-medium enterprises, mega-churches), or distinctions based on information and communication technologies (e.g., virtual vs. brick-and-mortar). Typologies that cut across for-profit, nonprofit, government/public, and beyond include →Burns and

Stalker's (1961) distinction between mechanistic and organic organizations; →Etzioni's (1961) coercive, utilitarian, and normative compliance relationships; and →Emery and Trist's (1965) classification of organizational environments (placid random, placid clustered, disturbed reactive, and turbulent fields) and the organizations in those environments.

Linking this to communication, nearly any communication process could be (and regularly has been) examined within each of these traditional types. It is less common to find work in organizational communication that makes explicit comparisons between types and theorizes type as an explanation for such differences. Multi-site case studies that examine communicative processes in a for-profit, nonprofit, and government organization could be quite informative. Interview and questionnaire studies could also target different organizational types as a way to create more nuanced understanding of various communication processes and outcomes.

Although these could be useful changes, a focus only on these traditional types of organizations creates potential blind spots. Even →Spangler et al.'s (2014) recent efforts to take classic organization types and transform them into contemporary ones (new bureaucracy, new entrepreneurial firm, new voluntary organization, and new service organizations) still focuses on very traditional categories. As →Scott (2013) argues, a focus on these traditional types is incomplete if we wish to better understand the full range of organizations found in the 21st century. Thus, we suggest two broad additional categories of organizations deserving greater attention from organizational communication scholars: hidden/clandestine and alternative types.

2 Hidden/Clandestine Types

Most traditional types of organizations are characterized by their visibility or desire to be visible to various audiences. However, conversations about the limitations of transparency suggest full visibility and complete disclosure are not always desirable (see →Christensen and Cheney 2015; →Flyverbom et al. 2016). More specifically, recent work on clandestine organizations (see →Stohl and Stohl 2007, →2011) and hidden organizations (→Scott 2013, →2015) has drawn attention to a different type of organization. These hidden and clandestine organizations might include the following: secret societies, anonymous support programs, hate groups, terrorist cells, covert military units, organized crime, parts of the informal economy, front organizations, shelters for the abused, organizations characterized by dirty work, stigmatized businesses, etc. All

of these, to some degree, communicatively conceal core aspects of themselves from various audiences.

2.1 Transparent, Shaded, Shadowed, and Dark Organizations

→Scott (2013) created a typology of organizations to better incorporate these more hidden types based on three key dimensions. *Organizational visibility* concerns how identifiable an organization's identity is (ranging from highly recognizable to highly anonymous). This dimension is the most important for hiding an organization. *Member identification* usually refers to a feeling of belonging with one's organization (→Mael and Ashforth 1992) – but the key in Scott's typology is how much that gets expressed by organizational members (ranging from completely silent to actively expressed). It is second in importance in creating types of hidden organizations. Finally, *relevant audience* concerns the other stakeholders to whom we attempt to be recognizable or anonymous and to whom we actively express or remain silent about our affiliations. Scott conceptualizes these audiences as more limited/local or more mass/public in nature and views this dimension as the least crucial (though still important) for organizational hiding.

Combining those three continua into a multidimensional space and looking toward the ends of each dimension creates what Scott describes as eight organizational regions. He calls these regions rather than types to suggest a more fluid space where we might find similar organizations. These regions vary from how transparent or dark they are, with different types of shaded and shadowed organizations in between.

Transparent suggests a type of collective where the identity of organizations and members are known substantially and communicated widely. This region would describe many of the organizations defined by traditional classifications. *Dark*, at the other extreme, describes a region where the identity of organizations and their members is substantially (though perhaps not completely) hidden from all. In →Scott's (2013) framework, the dark type of organization is not about organizations whose existence is unknown despite their efforts to be visible, or those collectives that are products of conspiracy theories. Instead, this might include highly covert military or intelligence organizations operating in a limited scope, select secret societies and hate groups where the organization and its members remain hidden from the local/limited communities in which they operate, potentially some hacker/hacktivist organizations with a limited agenda, localized criminal organizations and gangs where members and the organization remain hidden, or even some highly stigmatized organizations where members and organizations hide

in their local communities. Considering how consequential some of these organizations are, understanding how these types of organizations communicate and still maintain their hiddenness seems especially important.

Shaded describes a category of regions illuminated by enough light to help make the organization and/or its members visible, but with some identity elements remaining shielded (→Scott 2013). Not to be confused with shady operations, shaded regions are only concealed on one of the three dimensions described in Scott's model. *Mildly shaded* organizations are likely smaller corporations and businesses that lack a global or even national focus, local nonprofits, and government units not visible beyond their localities. This subtype is likely large and shares much in common with transparent organizations given the only concealment is being focused on a more local/limited audience. In *moderately shaded* organizations, members are more likely to conceal their affiliation than to express it even though the organization itself may be visible on a large stage. Organizations in this region could be large businesses, nonprofits, or government agencies that have poor reputations – leading members to avoid association with such groups (e.g., US Internal Revenue Service). This might also describe instances where members are concealing engagement in "dirty work", which is linked to activities having some sort of moral, social, or physical taint (→Ashforth and Kreiner 1999); visible national/international intelligence agencies using clandestine or undercover members (e.g., Israel's Mossad); or even certain global criminal networks where members protect the organization and themselves through silence. Finally, *mostly shaded* organizations have the collective itself hidden even while other elements are more visible. This could include international secret societies where the organization is secret but membership is open, various firms that operate on a large scale but still keep a low profile to avoid unwanted attention, large-scale religious cults where the organization's true identity remains hidden even as members are sometimes quite visible (e.g., Scientology), and even larger organizations that hide their identity behind the use of front organizations. Indeed, we know very little about fronts, shell companies, and astroturfing movements that effectively hide the organizations behind them.

Shadowed regions are characterized by much less visibility and are similar to dark organizations on two of the three dimensions in →Scott's (2013) model. The *mildly shadowed* region has a visible organization, but its members are hidden and it operates on a more limited/local stage. Organizations here might include locally operated offline support groups whose members conceal their identity (e.g., Alcoholics Anonymous) as

well as various hate groups (e.g., Ku Klux Klan), a city street gang whose members remain hidden even as the organization is more open, certain visible fraternal orders or secret societies that operate locally and whose members are concealed, or even some forms of dirty work where members conceal their affiliation (e.g., a local garbage company, independent adult video store). Conversely, the *moderately shadowed* region in this model has relatively anonymous organizations with a local/limited audience but with members who are still generally expressive about membership. Among the limited examples in this region are locally based fraternal orders or secret societies where the organization has secrets but membership is open (e.g., Skull and Bones) and local businesses and clubs that do not need to promote their visibility (already have members and/or markets for products). Finally, those in the *mostly shadowed* region would include terrorist and counterterrorist groups on a national or global stage, major organized crime groups, and anonymous activist groups with a more public agenda (e.g., Anonymous). We need research to better understand how these shadowed organizations use a variety of communication-based concealment strategies to remain hidden from some while still visible to certain others.

2.2 (In)Appropriately Hidden Organizations

Some hidden organizations seem to have good reasons for being hidden whereas the hiding of others is quite problematic. The regions identified by →Scott (2013) can actually contain both appropriately and inappropriately hidden organizations in the same space. Thus, →Scott and Kang (2017) offer a different typology of hidden organizations more focused on normative judgments about the acceptability of that hiding (while also noting such judgments are not universal). This is an area where future research about the ethics surrounding organizational anonymity, hiding, and secrecy could be especially insightful.

Inappropriately hidden organizations typically conceal identity to avoid accountability for illegal, immoral, or otherwise problematic behaviors (→Scott and Kang 2017). Because many of these represent a substantial threat to society, it is necessary to study these inappropriately hidden organizations and their communication strategies in order to better hold them accountable for their behaviors. These authors offer three primary examples of inappropriately hidden organizations: organized crime, terrorist organizations, and hate groups.

Conversely, other hidden organizations are generally seen as *appropriately hidden*. These primarily conceal their identity to protect the organization, its employees, and its clients from others who might seek to

harm or restrict them unjustly. →Scott and Kang (2017) argue we need to study these organizations to better recognize the communication strategies they utilize for concealment and to support the important role they play through their hidden nature. Key examples of this subtype include shelters/services for the victimized, crime fighting and counterterrorist units, and 12-step and other support groups.

→Scott and Kang's (2017) final subtype of hidden organizations is more difficult to describe in terms of appropriateness because these may be acceptably hidden sometimes but not others, because some aspects of the organization may be more appropriately hidden than others, and/or because there is less agreement about the motivations underlying their concealment. These *ambiguously hidden* organizations require attention because their concealment choices are not well understood, because they have some elements that are appropriately hidden and others that are not, and because they may even have multiple identities to manage (some that are more concealed than others). Key examples of ambiguously hidden organizations include core-stigmatized organizations (e.g., several in the sex industry), activist organizations (e.g., Anonymous), and aspects of the informal economy. The informal economy, especially in the Global South (see →Cruz and Sodeke 2020), potentially contains many ambiguously hidden organizations in need of more research.

One of the limitations with all these types of organizations is the lack of empirical studies on them, especially those emphasizing communication. Although scholarship does exist (e.g., →Conquergood 1994; →Witmer 1997), it is limited and rarely focused on the "type" of organization in particular. The problem is magnified when working with hidden/clandestine organizations because many of these can be dangerous and difficult to access for researchers. Research is also constrained because much of our existing theory is based on traditional types of organizations – making it unclear if those understandings apply to these more hidden types. It is possible that emerging work in the field around issues of (in)visibility management (see →Flyverbom et al. 2016) may help stimulate research on these types of organizations.

3 Alternative Organizations

In response to globalizing capitalism as well as promoting means to reinvigorate democracy and transform traditional organizing practices, a series of novel organizational types have emerged as alternatives to traditional organizations. These *alternative organizations* serve to redistribute power to workers and are commonly understood in opposition to familiar, traditional, mainstream, predominant, and

hierarchical institutional arrangements; thus, they are associated with individual autonomy, equality/equity, participation and democracy, solidarity, and commitment to the community (→Cheney and Munshi 2017).

3.1 Cooperative Organizations

Cooperatives as a type of organization emerged through a series of entrepreneurial experiments in North America and Europe during the first half of the nineteenth century (→Nelson et al. 2016). Cooperatives and other social and solidarity economy enterprises have appeared as alternative ways of both conducting business and organizing workers in many sectors as a resistance to the threat of colonization and neo-capitalism (→Dufays et al. 2020; →Esim and Katajamaki 2017). Cooperatives are defined as "autonomous associations of persons united voluntarily to meet their common economic, social, and cultural needs and aspirations through a jointly-owned and democratically-controlled enterprise" (→International Cooperative Alliance, n.d., para. 4). In contrast to the wealth-centered investor-owned model, the cooperative model is employee-centered (owned and controlled by the members). In addition, cooperatives are distinguished from traditional types because of their focus on democracy, solidarity, equality, member engagement and participation, and social and economic sustainability; however, boundaries can be blurry when compared to highly democratic organizations that parallel cooperatives' decision-making structure or businesses that implement employee stock ownership plans (ESOP) (→Esim and Katajamaki 2017; →Webb and Cheney 2014).

Cooperative enterprises may be found in different sectors of commerce. Among various types of cooperative organizations, worker cooperatives are perhaps the best known and most highly regarded. Worker cooperatives are "enterprises run and managed by and for the workers who own the capital, vote as equal members on matters related to running the business and have the right to stand in for elections of the board of directors" (→Esim and Katajamaki 2017: 3).

The Mondragon Cooperative Corporation, based in Spain's Basque region, is considered one of the most significant worker-owned and -controlled cooperatives. The Mondragon system includes multiple areas, such as the retail chain Eroski, industrial components, a cooperative bank, and Mondragon University that trains workers in business skills as well as cooperative principles and values (→Heras-Saizarbitoria 2014). John Lewis Partnership (JLP), a UK retailer, is another example of an employee-owned cooperative. However, partners (permanent employees) do not own JLP or

have ultimate control over the firm. Instead, partners can benefit from dividends and they are obliged to control managerial decision-making through JLP's governance structure (→Paranque and Willmott 2014). As another example, Co-op Cincy offers a model for building and expanding power among marginalized groups and communities (→Zoller 2021). Cooperative workers are affiliated with local unions and the union movement provides support for the cooperative network. Through this, the union helps prevent problems by adding another layer of worker protection if management conflicts with cooperative principles.

Regardless of the commercial success cooperatives have accomplished, the concept of cooperatives has received critical backlash. One of those concerns is the "degeneration thesis", which argues cooperatives are bound to fail or to degenerate into capitalist forms of business (→Basterretxea, Heras-Saizarbitoria, and Lertxundi 2019). Other tensions and paradoxes also arise within cooperatives. For instance, the necessity to perform on the market may jeopardize cooperatives' democratic practices in favor of control and monitoring functions to ensure organizational efficiency (→Varman and Chakrabarti 2004). Researchers have also examined tensions between solidarity and independence, equality and equity, efficiency and participation, and the need for hierarchical control and democratic practices (→Dufays et al. 2020; →Harter 2004).

However, there are clearly benefits to this type of organization. →Storey, Basterretxea, and Salaman (2014) showed that cooperative degeneration can be reversed via good management that prioritizes democratic elements, and democracy may be enacted and organizational tensions managed through members' discourse about tensions (→Harter 2004). Other research has also demonstrated the viability of employee ownership, its contributions to employees' job satisfaction and retention, as well as the positive effects on the local economy, public finances, and health (→Pérotin 2013; →Webb and Cheney 2014). Furthermore, cooperative businesses have shown their stability in terms of low rates of worker layoffs despite rising unemployment around them (→Webb and Cheney 2014). Through redefining members' roles as both employees and owners of the enterprise, cooperative organizational practices may provide more power to workers (→Dufays et al. 2020). Furthermore, researchers could also examine workers' perceptions about cooperative values and practices, which may reveal key communication processes and implications related to cooperatives.

3.2 Decentralized Autonomous Organizations (DAOs)

With the advancement of information and communication technologies (ICTs), organizations have become more open and decentralized. The concept of decentralization serves as a response to resist censorship and surveillance imposed by centralized management, as well as a way to improve efficiency and facilitate collaboration (→Dwivedi et al. 2021; →Skarzauskiene, Maciuliene, and Bar 2020). Contrary to the hierarchical structures of traditional organizations, decentralization is an alternative way of running businesses in which decision-making power is transferred from a single authority to operational units at multiple levels (→Catalini and Gans 2020; →Dwivedi et al. 2021). What makes this an alternative type of organization is that the implementation of decentralized decision-making at the organizational level starts with blockchain technologies.

A blockchain is a peer-to-peer digital distributed ledger where records of business operations are distributed to every participant's ledger (→Catalini and Gans 2020). Blockchains can control the execution of interorganizational processes via smart contracts that specify a series of rules that govern participation, such as participants' rights and obligations. Since smart contracts are code programmed into the blockchain, the execution happens automatically in a discrete manner without human interaction and the need for intermediaries to verify transactions (→Dwivedi et al. 2021).

By providing an autonomous, open, and programmable accounting system, blockchain technologies facilitate DAOs (→Skarzauskiene, Maciuliene, and Bar 2020). DAOs are organizations where the interaction of participants (humans or machines) is mediated by a blockchain technology, which stores the DAOs' regulations and transactions and is controlled by smart contracts that comprise a set of rules embedded in the blockchain's source code (→Dwivedi et al. 2021; →El Faqir, Arroyo, and Hassan 2020). DAOs operate in virtual spaces where participants collaborate with one another and constitute the bigger network governed by smart contracts that limit the behavior of participants (→Dwivedi et al. 2021). →Sims (2019) argues that blockchains are transformational through DAOs because blockchains essentially eliminate participants' misbehavior and ensure transparency of organizational processes.

Bitcoin is often considered a type of DAO that effectively "runs a payment system" that "employs subcontractors who are miners" to validate transactions and they are paid with bitcoins that can be considered as shares (→Vigna and Casey 2015: 229). As another example, the decentralized web (DWeb) is a novel idea based on "communication without the need for centralized operators" (→Skarzauskiene, Maciuliene,

and Bar 2020: 1019); furthermore, DWeb provides affordances for users to co-create knowledge in a self-governed network. Other examples include OpenBazaar (a decentralized marketplace), Graphite Docs (a Google documents alternative), and Dash, which has just one type of token that performs a number of different functions (→Sims 2019).

DAOs are subject to several critiques. For example, managing and promoting the development of a decentralized community without sacrificing decentralization creates paradoxical challenges (→El Faqir, Arroyo, and Hassan 2020). As another concern, criminals who rely on DAOs and the anonymity of blockchain technology create challenges for law enforcement trying to identify them (→Krishnan 2020). DAOs also raise power issues – where internal stakeholders possess power over the organization, including developers (who write the code embedded in blockchains) and miners (who are incentivized to compete on writing the history and validating transactions). However, DAOs open doors for collaboration to members with different backgrounds, which promotes a continual influx of new ideas and knowledge. DAOs are self-organizing and employ collective decision-making, thus helping to facilitate productive forms of collaboration and collective intelligence (→Skarzauskiene, Maciuliene, and Bar 2020). More recently, there is growing work on governing DAOs by providing empirical insights or creating governance frameworks, aiming to aid in integrating leadership and decision making into the technical systems and improve DAOs' long-term viability (→van Vulpen, Siu, and Jansen 2023). For example, a recent study shows that DAOs without weighted decision-making and incentive structures tend to be more viable (→Rikken, Janssen, and Kwee 2023). Overall, blockchain-enabled DAOs are at their early stage of development and further investigation from a communication perspective is warranted. Future research directions may include examining the process of decision-making of DAOs, DAOs' power structures, DAOs' task coordination and information flow via ICTs, as well as how DAO-associated discourse (i.e., transparency, decentralization) plays out in stakeholders' involvement in DAOs.

3.3 Network and Temporary Organizing

Attempts at defining and understanding the potential of network organizing originated in the 1980s and 1990s as a response to turbulent and globalizing markets of the late 20th century (→Borgatti and Foster 2003). Researchers noticed how vertical hierarchies, primarily in the United States, were inefficient in responding to ever-changing and globalizing economies. Network, or horizontal, organizing based on non-

hierarchical relationships was seen as a way for organizations to be highly adaptable to market changes.

Early definitions of network organizing include "any collection of actors (N≥2) that pursue repeated, enduring exchange of relations with one another and, at the same time, lack a legitimate organizational authority to arbitrate and resolve disputes that may arise during the exchange" (→Podolny and Page 1998: 59). Network organizing can be understood as an informal social system that allows members to socially commit to the organization's goals versus being bound to bureaucratic structures and legally binding contracts (→Jones, Hesterly, and Borgatti 1997) These views suggest a common focus on repetitive exchanges that rely on trust and social relationships.

An example of network organizing can be seen in temporary organizations (TOs), which are themselves a type of organization. TOs favor network structures as they need to quickly form a group with effective coordination in order to innovate, share expertise, and accomplish set tasks. One definition of TOs views them as a consciously organized collective aimed at evoking non-routine processes with a predetermined termination point (→Packendorff 1995). →Burke and Morley (2016) have defined them as a temporally bounded group of interdependent organizational actors who come together to complete a task – and categorize TOs into four configuration forms: intra-organizational, interorganizational, project-based organizations (PBOs), and project-based enterprises/firms (PBFs). Examples include research and development projects, theater productions, construction projects, and emergency response teams.

Because TOs bring together individuals with different task-relevant knowledge, coordination can become a challenge in this organizational type. →Meyerson, Weick, and Kramer (1996) discussed overcoming this issue through the mechanism of "swift trust," which is defined as individuals acting as if trust is already present even if there is not a developed history between people. One understudied example includes collective action and social movements where individuals organize under a certain purpose and maintain communication. An example of this community-oriented organizing can be seen in →Estes's (2019) *Our History Is the Future*. Another area of interest is developing better understandings of how temporary organizing and permanent structures interact with one another. →Sydow and Windeler (2020), for example, call for further research on the influence of digital technologies and platforms on the design and dissemination of both TOs and permanent structures. They suggest "temporary organizing contributes essentially to the survival of

more permanent social systems like organizations and inter-organizational networks" (p. 493).

3.4 Sharing Economy

Although the sharing economy is not a type of organization per se, it is characterized by a different type of organization that has disrupted traditional marketplaces where goods, services, skills, and spaces are shared, exchanged, rented, or leased (→Mont et al. 2020). It distinguishes itself from the traditional economy by prioritizing the sharing of resources rather than producing new ones (→Mair and Reischauer 2017). Likewise, the sharing economy's use of digital platforms bypasses traditional models of relationships between suppliers, producers, and customers.

As an umbrella concept, the sharing economy is also known by several pseudonyms: gig economy, on-demand economy, do-it-yourself (DIY) economy, or the platform economy. It can be seen as a model for co-access and co-ownership of resources, goods, and services for joint production and/or consumption among multiple actors, involving a reduction of individual ownership (→Belk 2014). →Schor (2016) conceptualizes the sharing economy by parsing it into categories such as the recirculation of goods, the increased utilization of durance assets, the exchange of services, and the sharing of productive assets.

→Acquier, Daudigeos, and Pinkse (2017) go further and offer three foundational cores to the sharing economy: access, platform, and community-based economies. The access economy is defined as the sharing of underutilized assets to optimize their use. This type of sharing has long existed within for-profits (e.g., rental/leasing) and nonprofits (e.g., libraries). However, recently the access economy has taken the form of companies offering services rather than products with no specific governance type such as Zipcar's car-pooling system. The platform economy is defined as "intermediate decentralized exchanges among peers through digital platforms" and promotes post-bureaucratic structures in order to offer broader exchange systems and individual economic opportunities (→Acquier, Daudigeos, and Pinkse 2017: 4). Examples include Uber or Lyft. The community-based economy is based on non-contractual, non-hierarchical, or non-monetized forms of interaction, and it attempts to promote a post-market society by rejecting formal market coordination. One example is seen through Wikipedia as it promotes free access and peer production meant to connect community members.

There are several opportunities and challenges for the sharing economy. Some scholars believe these models can support a more

efficient use of natural resources, build social relationships between peers, and enable more people to participate in and profit from economic activities (→Miralles, Dentoni, and Pascucci 2017). Others find the sharing economy to be a threat towards professionalism, public safety, privacy, health, and labor rights (→Vith et al. 2019). →Mair and Reischauer (2017) argue that businesses within the sharing economy differ depending if they are for-profit or nonprofit and what the cultural contexts are surrounding the businesses; but in other countries, such as Germany, businesses under the sharing economy are more alternative and structured similarly to cooperatives.

One problem of unregulated practices in these types of organizations is the tension of employer-employee vs. employer-contractor relationships. Gig workers concurrently employed by multiple platforms (called "multi-apping") complicates which employer holds responsibility – disrupting the traditional application of employment regulation (→Kaine and Josserand 2019). Likewise with the introduction of venture capitalists and their promotion of rapid company expansions, there is increased pressure to generate profits (→Belk 2014). To lower costs, workers are labeled as independent contractors allowing companies to avoid labor law requirements (→Schor 2016). The sharing economy also changes the nature of the organization-employee relationship. The sharing economy has morphed into a large sector that organizational communication scholars have only just begun to fully examine.

4 Conclusion

Considering traditional and emerging organizational types is important for better understanding organizational communication. It also positions us well for thinking about how these could evolve and what future types might look like. We already see blurring across some types and overlaps between them – which creates numerous opportunities and challenges for considering organizational type in our research. We also recognize the types examined here are not exhaustive and may still reflect an overly Eurocentric focus despite efforts to incorporate a more global view; but hopefully this is a useful starting point for describing organizations and for thinking about research on organizational types.

One of the most important issues from a communication perspective concerns the role of ICTs as they relate to organizational types. We already see this influence with aspects of DAOs and parts of the shared economy, but we also suspect ICTs may challenge existing types and blur them even more. As the influence of ICTs grows, they may even become some of the basis for organizational types (e.g., digital organizations, hacker

collectives). Relatedly, different organizational types may also be characterized by different ICT usage and development patterns.

Future work from a communication perspective is needed to examine organizational types – especially the more invisible and other alternative types. Developing methods to better access hidden types and to more effectively analyze alternative organizations will also be necessary. These types highlight differences in relevant stakeholders, concerns for ethics, strategies for communication and a host of other communication processes. It is our hope that our efforts here will help to stimulate greater scholarship in this area.

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Section IV: Technology

Chapter 22 Artificial Intelligence and Organizational Communication

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Abstract

This chapter explores the intersection of artificial intelligence (AI) and organizational communication. It distinguishes AI from traditional tools by highlighting its ability to learn from data patterns rather than relying on explicit programming. Such a workplace is viewed as a sociomaterial network comprising humans, processors, data, and algorithms. Within this framework, the chapter examines how AI disrupts three communicative processes traditionally performed by humans: (1) communication displacement (i.e., decision-making), (2) communication augmentation (i.e., pattern identification), and (3) communication representation (i.e., speaking on the behalf of). Drawing on recent research examples, the chapter prompts a reconsideration of several core concepts in organizational communication, such as agency, trust, power/bias, and visibility. Overall, the chapter provides a framework for scholars to investigate how the design, use, and consequences of AI can alter or reinforce communicative processes. Considering that communication is fundamental to the organizing process, it is crucial for organizational scholars to understand how AI shapes and expands our understanding of communication in the era of intelligent technologies.

Keywords: agency, algorithm(s), communication augmentation, communication displacement, communication representation, human-agent teaming, learning, reinforcement, learning, supervised, learning, unsupervised, Los Angeles Strategic Extraction and Restoration (LASER), PredPol, power, selection bias, strong AI, trust, visibility, weak AI,

Machine learning algorithms perform an ever-increasing number of activities within organizations. For example, they have fundamentally shifted the nature of Wall Street trading activity (→Beunza 2019), they determine credit scores for existing and potential customers (→O'Neill 2016), and they are used to screen applicants and assist in hiring decisions (→van den Broek, Sergeeva, and Huysman 2021). They also enable chatbots to respond in real time to customer support queries (→Davenport 2018), assist those looking for new loans (→Hassani 2021), and help workers seeking new information in their jobs (→Chamoso, González-Briones, and García-Peñalvo 2021).

With such quick advances in computational power, digital technologies have migrated from tools that people use to platforms upon which they interact, and with advancements in artificial intelligence (AI) they are beginning to move into the role of agents with which people actively collaborate. Think of the chatbot you interact with when you want to open a new bank account, the physical robots (controlled by digital automation tools) that operate on high-tech product assembly lines, and digital personal assistants like Siri, Alexa, and Google Assistant. Each of these digitally controlled bots uses AI and machine learning techniques to evaluate data inputs, makes suggestions for behaviors and actions, and learns from your responses to improve performance in future interactions.

Although AI has been in development since the late 1950s (→McCarthy et al. 1955), it was not until the turn of the millennium that the proliferation of data and computer

processing power made it feasible for computer programmers to create and implement algorithms that could work at the speed and scope necessary to make real-time recommendations at an industrial scale (→Russell and Norvig 2002). And it has only been in recent years that advances in personal computing and cloud-based infrastructures have made it feasible to use AI in the workplace and for other user-end applications. For these reasons, communication researchers, specifically, and social scientists, more generally, have only just begun to focus their attention on AI. Yet despite the growing interest in this topic, there is scant empirical research that describes specific AI development and implementation efforts. Most communication and social scientific writings on the subject tend to make pronouncements about the likely ways that AI will change behavior within and across organizations and offer advice for how to study such changes.

Given the dearth of prior research on AI in organizational communication, our aim in this chapter is to provide a grounded understand of what AI is (and is not) and to situate the potential opportunities and problems that AI portends for communication in the context of theorizing about organizational communication. We begin by providing a plain-spoken description of the technological innovations behind AI that will be useful for communication scholars to not only understand how the sociomaterial networks of complex technologies work, but also to implicitly highlight the many communicative processes through which AI technologies are configured and used. We then highlight three different ways that AI-based technologies can be configured within communicative practice. Finally, we explore four key theoretical constructs – agency, trust, power/bias, and visibility – that are profoundly implicated in and by the development and use of AI in organizational communication.

1 What Is Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Like many concepts in communication and social theory in general, AI is difficult to define. There have been many attempts to posit definitions (for a review, see →Monett, Lewis, and Thórisson 2020), but this can be quite a dizzying process. Most discussions seem to include the idea that AI leverages computers and data to mimic the problem-solving and decision-making capabilities of the human mind. Given the ambiguity about the term, what is perhaps more useful than trying to nail down a specific definition is to provide a framework for identifying AI "in the wild".

Pursuant to this mission, we can identify AI if it satisfies at least two conditions.[1] The first simply revolves around the idea that AI must follow a process of making sense of input data to make decisions:

1. Any AI must go through the process of turning inputs (e.g., data) into outcomes (e.g., decisions).

This first condition is quite standard and is meant to make the point that AI systems perform a set of computations similar to what humans would characterize as a sensemaking process – they take diverse forms of data and interpret such data points in ways that arrive at a certain outcome. For example, every purchase you make on your credit card (i.e., input) might be converted into a "likelihood of fraud score" (i.e., outcome). If that score is high enough, you might receive a text message or phone call asking if you really made such a purchase.

However, the first condition, although *necessary*, is not on its own *sufficient* to constitute AI. For instance, many technologies, if not most, follow this basic process. For example, a calculator takes in inputs (e.g., an algebraic formula like 2 + 2) and converts it into an outcome (e.g., 2 + 2 = 4, not 5). The second condition is perhaps the heart of any AI

system, reflecting the fact that AI follows a cybernetic-like training-based flow.

2. Any AI must be continuously trained, not explicitly programmed.

What do we mean by being “trained”? It might be easier to start with the opposite of training: explicit programming. Explicit programs are ‘rule-based’ systems that tell programs what to do. They often use lots of “if” and “then” statements. For instance, *if* I type “shutdown /i” in a Windows command prompt, *then* it will shut down my computer. This function was explicitly programmed by a smart human being.

AI systems do not really work this way. Instead, they are trained by different types of learning algorithms to find patterns in the input data that are used to make decisions. In *supervised* learning, humans create labels on the key outcome of interest. For instance, imagine you have a set of 1,000 news articles. Half of these articles were determined to contain *misinformation* and the other half did not. A learning algorithm would use the text as input data and then create various inferences to predict which ones contained misinformation and which did not (i.e., a training dataset). Afterwards, if reliable and valid enough, a program could be created using the algorithm to classify new articles (i.e., a test dataset). Ideally, the algorithm could be continuously refined, reflecting an ongoing cybernetic process of updating. Common supervised algorithms include neural networks, regressions, decision trees, and Bayesian networks. The point here is that these algorithms are not explicitly programmed by a human, but are instead a product of learning and training that allows the algorithms to inferentially find patterns in the data to maximize predictive accuracy.

Reinforcement learning works similarly, but instead of predicting an outcome, algorithms trained in this method are penalized for making wrong decisions (e.g., getting your Queen caught in a chess match) and rewarded for making

right decisions (e.g., capturing an opponent's Queen in a chess match). It is classical psychological behaviorism (i.e., carrot or stick approach) applied to an algorithm.

Unsupervised learning is a practice that trains algorithms using what are essentially clustering or dimension reduction techniques like exploratory factor analysis. Using this approach, algorithms tend to get rewarded based on how much separation they get from identified clusters. Unsupervised learning is often used for (somewhat controversial) recommendation systems. For instance, if YouTube users find that people who watch cat videos also tend to watch videos on loneliness, YouTube might send these clusters of people similar recommendations, which also might mean they can sell ads easier to these people for targeted advertising (e.g., anti-depressant ads to those who watch lots of cat videos).

All these examples represent what is commonly referred to as *weak* AI (or, more formally, "artificial narrow intelligence"). Weak AI are essentially systems designed to complete specific tasks like detecting objects in images, predicting the best websites for search results, completing what text might come next in a sentence, detecting fraud, etc. *Strong* AI (otherwise known as "artificial general intelligence") represents systems that develop information processing capabilities akin to humans, self-awareness, and the ability to adapt on the fly. It is important to note that strong AI is still (at the moment) the stuff of fantasy, represented in movies like *The Matrix* (1999) and *Her* (2013).

It is important not to treat AI in a vacuum, isolated from other important components essential to its application. Instead, AI might be better conceived in communicative terms as existing in what can be called a sociomaterial network (→Contractor, Monge, and Leonardi 2011). Sociomaterial networks consist of interconnected relations where the nodes represent both (1) human and (2) nonhuman elements. When

viewed as a sociomaterial network, AI cannot be reduced to a single technology, but instead represents multiple (and multiplex) interdependent connections among humans and technological objects in which nodes enable and constrain each other in complex ways. This is important because the creation of AI requires all these nodes operating together. Although there may be many types of important nodes, we describe four of that may be the most fundamental (see →Figure 1):

1. **Humans**: Human agents including programmers and behavior being analyzed.
2. **Processors**: Hardware that follows instructions of a program. These include computer processors, graphic processing units, sensors, etc.
3. **Data**: Processed data as inputs and outcomes of predictive models. These include traditional tabular data, network data, image data, and textual data.
4. **Algorithms**: Inferential rules used to construct predictive models. These include traditional algorithms like regressions and more complex ones like deep learning models.

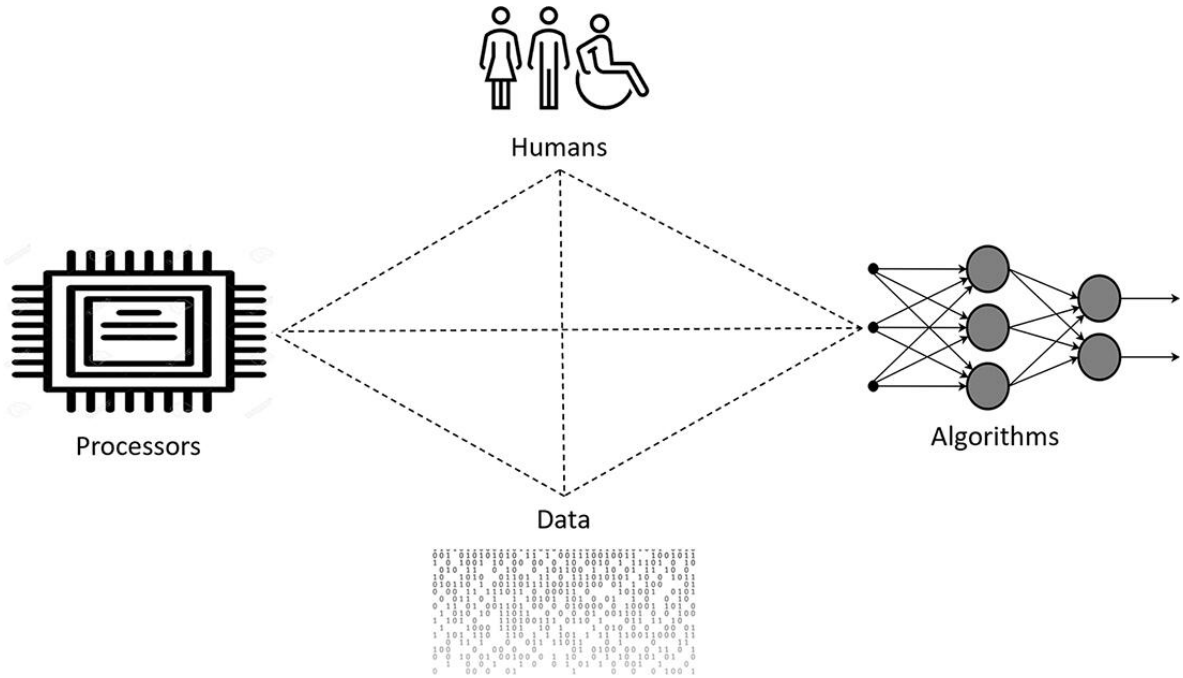


Figure 1: AI as a Sociomaterial Network.

Any perspective or study on AI will likely have to account for such complex interdependencies, otherwise important communicative activity will be easily missed. Consider an example to illustrate our point about why thinking about AI as a sociomaterial network is important for organizational communication scholarship.

Have you ever wondered why we cannot seem to be able to predict elections very well anymore? Despite increases in computing power, the development of advanced algorithms, and access to new sources of immense data representing individuals and behaviors, the accuracy of political forecasting has not kept pace with associated technological progress. The answer may lie with human-data relationships in the AI network. Exactly *how* we extract data from humans has changed. For example, predictive models seem to have trouble both gauging public opinion and understanding candidate preferences as exemplified by the 2016 and 2020 US national elections. The shift from randomized landline calls from voter registration data to quick and cheap online surveys

has introduced an important *selection bias*. Selection bias is simply the phenomenon that emerges when the sample extracted for data systematically differs from the true population, which is especially evident in online surveys (→Bethlehem 2010). When that data is processed into tabular data for an algorithm to analyze, the results will simply reflect such bias in the sample. In other words, algorithms are not magical crystal balls. If you feed them garbage data, they will return garbage results. What this insight suggests for communication researchers is that AI are neither neutral nor inevitable. They represent the constant negotiation of actors in a sociomaterial network. The communication practices and behaviors used by those actors in performing their roles and interacting with each other are socially constructed. To understand how AI works and what it does is to recognize that communication pervades every aspect of it.

2 How Does AI Become Entwined with Communication Practices?

We can discern at least three ways in which AI is currently configured to enter into communication processes.

2.1 Communication Displacement

Communication displacement refers to situations in which AI displaces communicators to make decisions and recommendations without direct input or consultation from humans. One example of such communication displacement occurs in the arena of algorithmic management, where AI-based algorithms make decisions about staffing, resource allocation, and evaluation – all practices that were historically the responsibilities of human managers. Today, algorithmic management has made the most inroads in the on-demand economy (→Kellogg, Valentine, and Christin 2020).

→Cameron's (2022) study of workers in the largest sector in the on-demand economy, ridehailing, suggests that when on-demand drivers are evaluated and assigned jobs by an AI tool, individuals transform tasks into games in which they can assert more agency in determining the outcome. Workers adopted various relational practices (e.g., providing water or phone chargers during rides) aimed at increasing the ratings customers would provide in the app. Individuals also adopted practices that gamified the efficiency of their work, positioning themselves in high-traffic areas and declining rides that would take them too far away. In both cases workers explicitly and directly shifted behaviors and interactions based on communication they received from the app or communication they perceived as being supplied to the app. The findings highlight not only what one would expect given Marxist studies of alienation – that traditional managers who were displaced by the AI became disenfranchised – but also that major downstream effects of such displaced communication occurred, changing the way that workers created meaning and responded to their new assignments.

2.2 Communication Augmentation

Communication augmentation refers to situations in which AI is able to identify patterns and provide data that changes the kind of knowledge and information communicators have. An example of communication augmentation can be seen in a study by →Lebowitz, Lifshitz-Assaf, and Levina (2022) examining the use of AI technologies by radiologists to make diagnostic decisions. The results provided by the AI often conflicted with the assessments made by the human radiologists, but the reasoning for the AI's results was unclear because the mechanisms driving the algorithm used were unknown. This created uncertainty among the radiologists about the accuracy and usefulness of the AI, and as a result

some departments chose not to use AI inputs in their diagnostic decisions. In one department, radiologists adopted the practice of using divergent assessments between the AI and humans as a trigger to further interrogate the source of the inconsistencies. This approach led radiologists to question their own assumptions and knowledge and seek to understand how the AI arrived at its results. After questioning the AI and integrating the results into decision making the radiologists expressed increased certainty and confidence in diagnoses. Yet these professionals also recognized the increased time and labor necessary to effectively integrate the communication from the AI with human judgments. This study shows that augmentation required the development of a set of skills to make sense out of the opaque recommendations given by the AI.

2.3 Communication Representation

Communication representation refers to situations in which an AI communicates on behalf of an individual, making decisions that reflect and represent the intentions of the person to others. An example of communication representation can be found in →Endacott and Leonardi's (2022) comparative field study of users of two AI scheduling technologies. They investigated how the processes of impression management and impression formation unfolded as users deployed AI-based bots to engage in the communicative work to schedule meetings on their behalf. Users of the AI hoped that communication by the bots on their behalf would bolster the impression they were sophisticated technology users, or signal that they could skillfully manage schedules. However, over time, as the AI tool made scheduling decisions autonomously, and communicated on the behalf of humans in a conversational manner, human users felt less control over how they were being perceived by others. Consequently, some

users found themselves apologizing for the AI's communication, or explaining to others that they had been interacting with a bot. Users understood that when the AI communicated in a way that was deemed as rude or incompetent, those impressions could be transferred into evaluations of the human users.

The differing definitions, conceptualizations, and configurations of AI are not merely ontological issues for scholars to debate, but also the basis for ongoing research into the ways in which different groups shape how AI is viewed in society. The meaning of any technology is the product of a communicative negotiation among actors who have different goals, resources, and positionality that contribute to how technological change is understood (→Bijker, Hughes, and Pinch 1989). Organizational communication scholars are well positioned to move past views of AI that adopt deterministic stances that treat AI as inevitable, and examine how different groups, organizations, and institutions influence acceptance, resistance, and development of AI as a technological space.

3 Communication Concepts in Transition

The various ways that AI presents to re-configure communication practices challenges us, as a field, to rethink many of our core concepts. In this section, we suggest that our conceptualizations of (1) agency, (2) trust, (3) power and bias, and (4) visibility may need to be re-thought in light of the ways AI-based predictions are evolving.

3.1 Agency

Discussions of agency have long been core to the field (→Riley 1983; →Poole, Seibold, and McPhee 1985). With their potential for autonomous decision-making, AI may challenge our

current understanding of who has the ability to act and what it means for non-humans to act. How scholars approach agency in exploring questions related to AI will differ based on the ontological assumptions they adopt (→Brummans 2017). Specifically, investigations primarily vary in whether they take a structurational ontology that centers the agency of humans relative to social structures, or a relational ontology that focuses on what makes a difference in networks of human and nonhuman actants (→Piercy, Bisel, and Treem 2022).

In a structurational approach to action (→Banks and Riley 1993; →McPhee, Poole, and Iverson 2014), the focus is on the ways in which actors enact the world around them and carries with it the assumption that actions are coupled with aspects of knowledgeability and reflexivity. As a result, within a structurational view the existence and locus of AI is a consequence of actions by individuals and organizations that are operating in a social world governed by rules and diffused with resources. Alternatively, a relational ontology (→Cooren 2018) sees communicative action as fundamentally constitutive of organizing and organizations. Within this perspective AI (and the technologies that deploy them) has agency in the sense that it makes a difference and other actants take action in relation to AI. Within this view humans and non-humans are both capable of acting and analytical attention is paid to the emergent web of relations that is constituted through the exercise of different agencies. These differing ontological stances are highlighted not to advocate one over the other in the study of AI, but to note that empirical studies adopting a structurational perspective operate with assumptions that make it difficult for direct comparisons to those operating from a relational ontology.

Other scholars argue that the emergence of AI and associated automated activity requires a reconceptualization of agency altogether. →Neff and Nagy (2016) characterize the imbrication of human and technical agency present in the

activity of AI as a *symbiotic agency* perspective that reflects the presence of human agency in the creation of AI and the ways in which those encountering AI may ascribe agency to technologies. They describe the case of a Microsoft-developed chat bot named Tay, which was designed to learn from and adapt to the language of a young American adult communicating on Twitter, and within a day began tweeting expletive-laden, racist, insulting messages. This incident raised questions as to who bore responsibility for a chat bot's behavior, and how the actions of the bot were being perceived and attributed by those interacting with the AI. Researchers seeking to describe the processes by which AI can take actions absent the direct or ongoing intervention of humans have also characterized this dynamic as the enactment of synthetic agency (→Legaspi, He, and Toyoizumi 2019), computational agency (→Tufekci 2015), or algorithmic agency (→Andersen et al. 2016). Each of these perspectives seeks to address how the presence and use of AI both results from, but also operates independently of, direct human action. Below we describe how scholars might study AI by addressing various approaches to agency that have dominated thinking in organizational communication (→Putnam 2015).

Questions of agency associated with AI are also closely tied to how much *autonomy* is granted to AI, or the frequency and significance of actions that the AI can take without the ongoing intervention or direction of humans (→Hancock, Namaan, and Levy 2020). A distinguishing aspect of AI is its ability to carry out some actions absent the input of human activity; however, the extent to which that may result in data or decision-making can vary widely (i.e., does the medical AI system give information to aid a diagnosis, or actually determine subsequent care). Moreover, studies of individuals interacting with AI through chat, or experiencing the consequences of AI on social media, demonstrate that individuals hold a variety of different views of when, and how,

they are interacting with AI (e.g. →Siles et al. 2020). Therefore, questions about who is acting are not straightforward, and may become murkier as AI become more developed, and actions more removed from the direct influence of the original design.

It is increasingly difficult to argue that AI, and the artifacts that deploy it, are incapable of taking action: Alexa and Siri respond to questions, robotic vacuums roam the floors of homes, software suggests words and phrases that might be useful in email. Yet it is also understood that somewhere along the road of developing any AI humans inherently play a role in obtaining the resources, setting the conditions, and facilitating implementations that allow AI to operate. As a result, examinations of agency in AI are inherently incomplete, partial, and often opaque. Because organizational communication scholars have historically studied the design, implementation, and consequences of technology use in diverse contexts, they are well equipped to examine these questions from multiple dimensions. Organizational researchers have employed concepts such as ventriloquism (→Cooren 2012), conjoined agency (→Murray, Rhymer, and Sirmon 2021), hybrid agency (→Schultze et al. 2018), and imbricated agency (→Leonardi 2011) to explore the various ways that technologies are folded into organizational practice. But with the increasingly agentic characteristics of AI, organizational communication scholars will likely need new conceptualizations of the way agency materializes in the organizing process. As we will see in the following treatments of trust, power and bias, and visibility, developing robust conceptualizations of the ways in which agency is enacted will be important for organizational communication scholars to be able to speak to pressing social issues in the age of AI.

3.2 Trust

Because many AI applications are being used today to augment human decision-making (→Raisch and Krakowski 2021) and many more that are under development are being configured to operate as an agentic team member, the issue of how individuals come to trust the recommendations or decisions made by an AI agent are of increasing importance. Human-agent teaming is beginning to appear in an increasing number of situations (→Larson and DeChurch 2020). The US Army is deploying AI to assist in battlefield action decisions, Google is beginning to incorporate smart digital technologies into executive decision-making teams, Foxconn is using smart digital tools on shop-floor manufacturing teams, and banks are using smart digital technologies on underwriting teams. In a series of experiments led by →Logg, Minson, and Moore (2019) subjects were told they were being given advice by either an AI algorithm or a person about how to tackle a series of estimation tasks – predicting the success of business events, the popularity of songs, or romantic attraction. Their findings showed, overwhelmingly, that participants relied more on identical advice when they thought it came from an algorithm than from other people. Participants even showed a willingness to choose algorithmic advice over their own judgment. But this willingness to defer to AI in decision-making tasks was lower among experts or other individuals who were simply less open to taking any advice. The accuracy of their judgments suffered as a result. What this study and others like it show is that when a task is fairly straightforward and numeric (based on accurate counting), people appear to have very little problem trusting the results of AI – and it seems that doing so typically results in better outcomes.

But the situation becomes considerably more complicated when the tasks themselves are not so straightforward and are less numerically oriented. →Newman, Fast, and Harmon (2020) conducted a different series of experiments in which

students and organizational employees were told that they were receiving feedback on their performance from either a manager or an AI tool. The results showed that when people were being evaluated on what they perceived as “objective” criteria, like how many sales calls they closed in a certain amount of time, the AI did a better job at recognizing their performance than human managers. But when they were being evaluated on what they perceived as “subjective” criteria, like how hard they worked to close the deal or whether or not they built a relationship with the potential customer, they felt that human managers were more accurate than the AI. Clearly, our trust in the accuracy of AI depends a great deal on the kinds of tasks the technology performs.

The use of unknown sophisticated technology, such as AI, suggests a need for and trust in processes that cannot be directly observed or cognitively understood. →Glikson and Woolley (2020) argue that learning to trust AI requires that a number of conditions are met. First, AI must be transparent. This means that people have to be able to understand how a set of algorithms work, or at least recognize the assumptions through which the algorithms are operating. Second, AI has to be reliable. Low reliability significantly decreases trust and restoring trust is difficult and takes time. They also argue that although anthropomorphizing AI can increase trust to a point by making people liken the technology to a human counterpart, it also creates high expectations that can be violated when the AI does not perform as anticipated.

Trust lies at the core of many communication processes in organizations. As we have discussed, understanding whether or how we can trust in AI-based machines in situations of ambiguity or high-reliability contexts will grow in importance as more of these technologies begin to take on roles on teams and in other decision-making contexts that were previously only the province of humans. Organizational communication scholars must begin to understand how and under what

conditions people make purposeful or blind decisions to trust AI. Also, because many of the algorithmic processes governing the decision rules implemented by AI are opaque (→Burrell 2016), questions of how organizational members do or do not build trust in situations where they cannot fully understand the basis, data, or parameters related to the decision will be of great consequence. Communication scholars have built theory around how people do this with information (→Metzger, Flanagin, and Medders 2010), but we know very little about how they might do so effectively with AI.

3.3 Power and Bias

Pattern recognition and predictive capabilities provided by AI tools have the potential to change who makes decisions and who has responsibility for the outcomes of those decisions. Discursive theories of power that treat actors as strategic in crafting hegemonic narratives (→Mumby 2001), sociological theories of power that look to dependence (→Cook and Yamagishi 1992), or psychological theories of power that identify attributes of certain actors (→Raven 1992) do not account well for the ways that power is constituted in systems involving AI. Importantly, those with power to shape the data on which algorithms are trained, those who build the logic into the algorithms, and those who do the training are able to embed their constructions of the world into an AI's decision-making process. Of course, organizational communication scholars have long understood that systems are biased in favor of those with the resources and standing to discursively construct reality (→Deetz 1992). But as critical theorists have shown, the ability to make a subjective reality appear objective and obdurate is quite precarious. Researchers examining contexts such as search engine results (→Noble 2018) and facial recognition software (→Raji et al. 2020) have documented how outcomes suggested or recommendations

made by AI are more easily taken for granted as ground truth in many more situations than discursive constructions produced by humans. Consequently, understanding how power and bias shape AI predictions should be of central concern for organizational communication scholars.

In perhaps the most detailed analysis of power and bias in AI to →date, Brayne (2017, →2018, →2020) spent nearly a decade observing and interviewing members of the Los Angeles Police Department (LAPD) to understand how they used advanced data analytics techniques to predict where crime might occur. As Brayne discussed, the LAPD used advanced data algorithms and AI to identify "hot spot" locations where crime typically occurred or was likely to occur and classify "chronic offenders" – both these places and people were then subject to increased surveillance and monitoring. In making these determinations, the AI used a variety of data sources including criminal affiliations, location-based license plate readers, and social media networks. As Brayne observed, when the data analytics algorithm directed officers to specific areas like a low-income neighborhood where crime was predicted to be higher, they collected more data points than they did in more affluent areas, thus creating a vicious cycle: increased police presence in these areas then puts officers in contact with more low-income individuals, which creates more police records, which then have a higher likelihood of accumulating into the chronic offender score. This problem was exacerbated by differential resources among precincts. The most affluent areas of LA, which had the lowest crime, faced less pressure to use the AI technologies in order to save money. This meant that residents in those neighborhoods were less likely to have interactions with police, less likely to show up on the LAPD's watchlists, and less likely to have a chronic offender classification than people living in low-income neighborhoods. Similarly, research by →Lum and Isaac (2016) on the use of an AI technology, called

PredPol, showed that efforts to predict the location of drug crimes in the Oakland region disproportionally focused police resources on predominately Black neighborhoods. Increases in police actions (i.e., arrests and surveillance) resulted in these areas despite Census and survey data indicating illegal drug use occurred at higher rates in more affluent, heavily white neighborhoods.

These extended examples of machine learning algorithms, data, and AI in policing demonstrate how power and bias can work, under the umbrella of "technological neutrality", to disenfranchise marginalized communities and reinforce a dominant power structure. Understanding how power and bias are implicated in the development and implementation of AI-based tools should be a central concern for organizational communication scholars. Current theories about how discursive practices and materiality can reinforce or alter power (e.g. →Harris 2016; →Putnam 2015) and reproduce bias need to be augmented with an understanding of the way that AI-based predictions create asymmetries in the communicative production of reality.

3.4 Visibility

A fundamental goal of communication is to make one's own behaviors visible to someone else. In technical terms, that someone else is a target audience. When people conduct their behaviors in the presence of a target audience, they typically style them in such a way to communicate a certain message to that target. Knowing information about the target is essential for crafting that message because if one knows how a target is likely to interpret a behavior or string of behaviors, they can design those behaviors (or their communication) to fit the target's interpretive style (→Aakhus 2007). Of course, the same holds true when a person communicates about their behavior to the target. But when a person's behavior becomes

visible to third parties – people who were not in the target audience – the actor loses some ability to design the message in a way that will resonate. That third party is an empirical audience, an audience that can observe a behavior intended for a specific target.

In this era of digital connectivity, actors are constantly connected to third parties who experience behaviors that were made visible for specific targets (→van Dijck 2013). Studies of social media use show that even when actors do not have a specific (single) target in mind, they often craft messages of their behavior (or messages that are behaviors) to unknown actors (→Litt 2012). But even these actors represent an imagined audience that is a specific target (→Marwick and Boyd 2011). Third parties typically lack the inferential bases for decoding communicative acts of behavior indented for specific targets.

A defining characteristic of AI is its ability to make the invisible visible through pattern identification, synthesis, and promotion (→Leonardi and Treem 2020). This is a qualitatively different process of visibility production from the strategic impression management behaviors often studied by organizational communication and computer-mediated communication researchers (→Ellison, Heino, and Gibbs 2006; →Walther 2007). Though a plethora of data and information is always available and accessible to actors to wade through individually if they have the will and time to do so, machine learning algorithms make that content functionally visible in much more economical ways by sorting, ranking, recommending, and categorizing information so that it is presumably more easily understood and useful (→Gillespie 2014). Typically, traces of communication strewn across digital platforms are so small, diffuse, and separated by long periods of time that people trying to sort through them have difficulty aggregating them (→Leonardi 2018). In these instances, larger strategies of quantitative aggregation are needed. The

rise of AI and the corresponding role of data scientists within organizations provide new mechanisms for making behavior visible through machine learning techniques (→Günther et al. 2017). For example, large consumer-facing technology companies such as Google, Facebook, and Amazon have pioneered data analytic techniques that allow people's patterns of consumption to be rendered visible (→Zuboff 2019).

Consequently, algorithms perform a disciplining function by directing our limited attention and potentially suppressing other social activity. The classifications and rankings produced by AI can create a false sense of rationality and certainty, obscuring the underlying content and possibly discouraging further scrutiny (→Hansen 2015). Furthermore, because these algorithms are often created by organizations or institutions, actors may not be aware of the ways their visibility is being manipulated (→Kennedy and Moss 2015). Others may actively make behaviors and activities purposely more or less visible in an effort to manipulate machine learning algorithms in desired ways (→DeVito, Birnholtz, and Gergle 2017). Although digital connectivity creates the potential of seeing or being seen, we must rely on tools of representation to make behaviors visible (→Alaimo and Kallinikos 2022). That process of representation is increasingly facilitated through AI that automates the selection of what is made more or less visible.

Organizational communication scholars will recognize that visibilities are also produced by algorithms rather than simply shown by them. How such visibilities are produced algorithmically is an important area of study. For example, →Gillespie (2014) argues that algorithms do not make all behavior visible, nor do they make different kinds of behavior visible in the same way. Only data that are available through digitally connected infrastructure are ready to be inputs to algorithmic processing. Further, programmers of algorithms decide what of this available data will make it into the

indexical features of the algorithm. Programmers of algorithms attempt to know and predict their users and thus build in selection and salience heuristics that correspond with the kinds of behaviors they believe users will want to be visible to them. Google's page-rank algorithm does this implicitly, but so too does Facebook's edge-rank algorithm that decides whose behaviors users would like to see. The same process operates with proprietary AI systems that select from the available behaviors to suggest to organizational hiring managers who they might like to interview (→Chander 2016). A result of the deployment of dynamic AI tools by organizations is that behaviors made visible through algorithmic ordering are not uniform for all viewers making it difficult for users to build a common base of knowledge or shared cognition (→Metiu and Rothbard 2013). In centering the visibility of some information and concurrently obscuring other information, algorithms position some behaviors as institutionally legitimate and worthy of our consideration and others as not (→Ananny and Crawford 2018). Organizational communication researchers are well positioned to understand what kinds of impacts such diffused attention might have on coordinated action.

4 Conclusion

As with most new technologies, the rhetoric accompanying AI prophecies a future in which communication occurring within and constitutive of organizations will look dramatically different than it does today. Although, as the past has shown us, such prognostications are sure to be overblown, the increasing prevalence of AI-enabled technologies does provide organizations with new capabilities and complications. The four key organizational communication concepts reviewed in this chapter offer a framework for scholars to interrogate the ways the design, use, and consequences of AI may alter or

reinforce communicative processes. If communication is indeed the key engine of the organizing process, organizational scholars will need to attend to the ways that AI is shaping and stretching what we conceive to be communication in this new era of intelligent technologies.

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Notes

1 To conceive of a framework on identifying AI, we reviewed a variety of academic and non-academic publications. In our view, the clearest conceptualizations tend to come from the people that actually build AI applications. Who would have thought, right? For this framework, we borrow from Oleksandr Konduforov, a data scientist at AltexSoft.

Chapter 23 Social Media, Organizations, and Organizing

Keri K. Stephens

Brett W. Robertson

Abstract

Research on social media use in and around organizations and organizing practices has expanded rapidly. These information and communication technologies make communication visible beyond an interpersonal context. Unlike mass media's ability to primarily communicate in a one-person-to-many-people form, social media allow both one-to-many and peer-to-peer communication. This chapter provides clarifying definitions and situates social media within an organizational communication context. It describes how enterprise social media (ESM) can be viewed through affordance-based frameworks, why people use social media in and around their organizations, and the outcomes associated with using ESM. We also discuss the growing research on people using their personal social media accounts for work use. The chapter discusses concerns like privacy that affect people in their organizational and personal lives. Finally, we explore examples of organizing processes through social media use and suggest this area is ripe for organizational communication research. As social media evolve and organizations continue expanding their reliance on technologies that use and handle big data, understanding social media is of growing importance. Readers will walk away better understanding the literature on organizational and organizing use of social media and have clear ideas for research opportunities.

Keywords: affordance, collective action, cyberloaf, digital platform, disaster, enterprise social media (ESM), enterprise social network site (ESNS), Facebook, information and communication technology (ICT), organizing, social media, social network site (SNS), Twitter (or X), visibility,

1 Social Media, Organizations, and Organizing

Research on social media use in and around organizations and organizing practices has expanded rapidly. Much like many other information and communication technologies (ICTs) used in organizations, scholars have explored their affordances (→Leonardi 2013; →Majchrzak et al. 2013; →Treem and Leonardi 2013), how they enhance organizations (→Oksa et al. 2021; →Robertson and Kee 2017), and the challenges presented by using these ICTs (→Di Tommaso et al. 2020; →Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg 2013). One major difference between social media and many other ICTs is that people used these ICTs for personal use first, and then organizational use; a practice much different from tools like email and mobile phones (→Stephens 2018). Furthermore, social media are often used for organizing outside of formal organizations, and these practices can be emergent, ad hoc, and bring people together who could not organize any other way than online (→Ganesh, Stohl, and Kim 2022; →Smith et al. 2021; →Stephens, Robertson, and Murthy 2020).

This chapter discusses two forms of social media use relevant for organizations: general social media use and enterprise social media (ESM) use – a type of use that often occurs inside specific organizations. It also builds on the affordances of social media literature to examine how some of those same affordances, especially visibility, serve key roles in online organizing. To begin, let us examine some trends in public and organizational social media use.

Recent estimates from the Pew →Research Center (2021) describe that roughly seven-in-ten Americans say they use some type of social media platform, a number that has remained relatively stable over the past five years. Usage gaps between younger and older Americans vary across platforms, with Instagram, Snapchat, and TikTok being especially common among adults under 30. At the same time, Facebook is the most common platform used among adults aged 65 and older. The trend of social media being used in and around organizations and organizing practices is becoming ubiquitous, especially with growing numbers of younger workers who grew up as digital natives (→Men, O'Neil, and Ewing 2020). According to →Bizzi (2018) in a report for the *Harvard Business Review*, 82% of employees think social media can improve their workplace relationships, and 60% believe social media support decision-making processes within their organization. These findings complement recent scholarly literature reporting that employees often use their personal social media at work, even during working hours (→Robertson and Kee 2017; →van Zoonen and Treem 2019).

While we use this chapter to highlight how social media affordances function, this brief essay is not a comprehensive review of the social media literature. Instead, our chapter illustrates how affordances, specifically visibility, impact several facets of organizational life. Thus, it compiles the literature on organizational and organizing use of social media specifically to help scholars identify research opportunities especially as social media continues evolving. The chapter begins by clarifying definitions and situating social media within an organizational communication context. We then describe how ESM use can be viewed through affordance-based frameworks, and why people use social media in and around their organizations. Finally, we explore organizing processes that take place through social media use and offer future directions for study.

2 Conceptualizing Social Media as Platforms for Communication

When considering the relationship between social media, organizations, and organizing, it is helpful to review how social media differ from other types of ICTs, as well as understand how social media use relates to organizations and organizing. By tracing these historical roots, we can elaborate on fundamental topics within the literature, and better understand the evolution of social media use in organizations.

Social network sites (SNS) are communication platforms where participants have a unique profile, their connections to others are visible, and they can "consume, produce, and/or interact with streams of user-generated content provided by their connections on the site" (→Ellison and boyd 2013: 158). When people use the more colloquial term "social media", this is typically understood to be broader than just SNS; it encompasses many peer-to-peer platforms, including discussion forums and peer-production communities (→Ellison and Vitak 2015). →Carr and Hayes (2015) critique broad definitions and encourage scholars to focus on (1) what makes social media a distinct subset of ICTs, (2) how people interact with social media, and (3) how these interactions will innately change the tools themselves.

One of the biggest challenges in studying SNS and social media, as well as ICTs in general, is that platforms are constantly changing and adding more capabilities. Therefore, strict definitions and attempts to differentiate between specific platforms can quickly become meaningless (→Stephens 2018). Yet there are important reasons to study social media, especially in an organizational context. These ICTs allow communication and information to be visible beyond an interpersonal context, and unlike mass media's ability to primarily communicate in a one-person-to-many-

people form, social media allow both one-to-many, and peer-to-peer communication (→O'Sullivan and Carr 2017).

3 Social Media Use in an Organizational Work Context

3.1 Using Social Media with External Stakeholders

Organizations use social media both as a means to communicate with external stakeholders and to facilitate communication and information sharing between their organizational members. Communicating externally is most often the focus of organizational units such as sales, marketing, and public relations (→Heath 2020). Over the past decade, the systematic use of organizational social media has exploded, resulting in hiring specialists who focus on these public-facing messages.

3.1.1 Cybervetting

Organizations capitalize on the fact that so many people post information on social media platforms, that when they are ready to hire employees, they search through that professional and personal information. This practice, called cybervertting (→Berkelaar 2014), occurs when employers 'vet' job candidate's social media presence (or lack thereof), and make judgments based on 'red flags' to determine organizational fit. →Berkelaar (2014) observes that the normalization of this practice represents a new or extended "digital social contract" (p. 502), which has raised important ethical questions about employee availability, transparency, and visibility. Organizations can use social media to encourage desirable behaviors in their employees. For example, research suggests that when organizations are sharing health information with their employees, as long as those employees

feel identified with the organization, social media may be an acceptable ICT for sharing that health information (→Stephens, Goins, and Dailey 2014).

3.1.2 *Employee Use of Social Media*

Along with specialists whose jobs are to use social media to directly benefit the organization, quite often individual organizational members use their social media accounts to share not only personal information, but also information related to their organizational affiliation. In their study examining employees' willingness to share their organizational affiliation on social media, →Piercy and Carr (2023) found three significant predictors. They found that including an organizational affiliation and the degree someone is identified with the organization are both predicted by social media use, degree of overlap between personal and professional lives, and organizational prestige. The strongest predictor was organizational prestige, or whether people think highly of the organization where they are affiliated. This suggests that people may be trying to boost their prestige or image by including their organizational affiliation on social media.

Some organizations hire companies or purchase software services, called employee advocacy platforms, to help or encourage employees to post meaningful information on social media (→Thelen and Men 2023). These are relatively new tools, but in their study of how organizations encouraged what they called organizational citizenship behaviors of sharing positive content through social media, →Walden and Kingsley Westerman (2018) found that positive organizational commitment was key when employees chose to share good information about their employer. Beyond the relationship with the organization, scholars in public relations fields have found that leader-member relationships, company culture,

and how employees are socialized into the organizations impact their willingness to be an employee advocate (→Thelen and Men 2023). With so many people using social media for both personal and work reasons, understanding the impact that organizational members' use of social media has on their employing organizations and on external stakeholders is ripe for additional study.

3.2 Using Social Media and Social Network Sites in the Enterprise

In addition to the outward-facing use of social media, many organizations have web-based platforms that are restricted for interaction and communication that happens within the organization – often called enterprise social media (ESM) use or enterprise social networking sites (ESNS). →Leonardi, Huysman, and Steinfield (2013) defined ESM as

> Web-based platforms that allow workers to (1) communicate messages with specific coworkers or broadcast messages to everyone in the organization; (2) explicitly indicate or implicitly reveal particular coworkers as communication partners; (3) post, edit, and sort text and files linked to themselves or others; and (4) view the messages, connections, text, and files communicated, posted, edited and sorted by anyone else in the organization at any time of their choosing.
>
> (p. 2)

3.2.1 Understanding Enterprise Social Media Use through Affordances

Instead of emphasizing specific social media platforms in research, most scholars agree that focusing on theoretical perspectives relating to social media allows for the study of interactions and organizing processes that will persist as platforms change. One perspective helpful for understanding the role of communication in using social media is through

studying their affordances. →Gibson (1986) defined affordances as the perception of the usefulness of an object that is derivative of one's environment. He conceptualized an affordance as relational, triggered by "the particular ways in which an actor, or set of actors, perceives and uses [an] object" (p. 145). While this definition is not necessarily about technology or social media, many communication scholars believe that affordances have the potential to shape how we view and study technology.

Affordances provide a framework to understand relationships while preserving relational ontology – even when the contexts of technology use are dynamic, the attributes and abilities of users are diverse, and the materiality of technologies varies. Social network sites (boyd 2010), social media (→Treem and Leonardi 2013), and mobile devices (→Stephens 2018) have all been examined through an affordance-based framework. →boyd (2010) describes a set of affordances used in social media broadly, including persistence, replicability, scalability, and searchability.

Focusing specifically on ESM, Treem and →Leonardi's (2013) work identified four affordances often associated with organizational social media use: visibility and association of content and people, as well as the persistence and editability of content. They argue that although ICTs used at work, such as email and teleconferencing, may score high on one or two of the affordances they identify, overall, these other technologies provide limited visibility and association, and inconsistent persistence and editability. In contrast, social media provides high degrees of each of the four affordances. Because ESMs afford visibility and the content can persist over time, they can expose people to new ideas and networks, and thus they can contribute to social learning processes in organizations (→Leonardi, Huysman, and Steinfield 2013).

→Leonardi (2013) did considerable additional work theorizing the role of visibility as an affordance of social

media. More recently, he has expanded beyond just social media to argue that social and ICT infrastructures allow for behaviors (of individuals, groups, technologies, and even nature) “to see and been seen” (→Leonardi and Treem 2020: 1601). →Treem and colleagues (2015) now argue that visibility can be considered the root affordance because not only is it fundamental to the nature of visibility, the other affordances build on and depend on visibility.

Scholars have also focused more specifically on key actions that occur in organizations, and how social media affordances influence activities like knowledge sharing. In one of the first attempts to present social media affordances in a less pro-technology and more balanced manner, →Majchrzak and colleagues (2013) proposed four affordances of social media designed to shift conversations from the more individual perspective of knowledge sharing to communal knowledge conversations. They claim that new forms of knowledge can develop when conversations become visible, and they articulate the specific affordances that address not only the positive, but also more contradictory uses of social media (→Majchrzak et al. 2013).

To further advance an understanding of ESM, and compare affordances between a host of ICTs, →Rice and colleagues (2017) present the concept, organizational media affordances, that aggregates agents’ needs and uses across different ICTs in organizational contexts. Their conceptualization acknowledges the relationships between ICTs and affordances occur on at least three levels relevant to organizations: interpersonal, group, and organizational. Their quantitative approach revealed several significant affordances that significantly correlate with external social media use, including visibility, self-presentation, awareness, pervasiveness, and searchability.

Over the past decade, scholars have examined affordances of social media from many different angles, and

what counts as an affordance of social media has been more refined; therefore, early scholarship theorizing social media may differ from more recent understandings. In a productive attempt to more carefully focus scholars' attention on affordances, →Evans et al. (2017) developed three criteria to determine whether a particular technological usage meets the minimum threshold criteria to qualify as an affordance. They claim that what is called an affordance cannot be a feature of the technology, an outcome of its use, and it must have variability in how it is used. While these criteria are helpful, there is still some variation in how scholars may interpret and define an affordance.

3.3 Why People Use Social Media in and around Organizations

Before we explore the reasons – many theory-driven – that people use social media in organizations, it is important to remember that public social media can be considered a hybrid space because both professional and personal information are shared on these platforms (→van Zoonen and Treem 2019). Therefore, it makes sense that some of the same actions organizational members have engaged in the past with other ICTs, will also be present through social media. The literature on ESM often considers impression management, social capital, and knowledge sharing as three of the most common reasons people use social media in and around organizations.

3.3.1 *Impression Management*

Impression management focuses on goal-directed behaviors to control or manipulate the attributions and impressions that others form and is a primary human motive that pervades every aspect of life (→Goffman 1959; →Leary 1996). Individuals often use social media strategically, and when

crafting their content, they have imagined audiences in mind (→Marwick and boyd 2011). For example, when some people post a comment either on an ESM platform or through public social media platforms, they may believe their managers will see that comment, and thus, they consider them their specific audience when crafting their content. Research suggests that these behaviors can be linked to having a desire to succeed, something common in organizational contexts (→van Zoonen and Treem 2019).

However, on public social media platforms, it is challenging for people to both manage their impressions and establish collective boundaries around what they consider private information (→Choi and Bazarova 2015). In their study examining Azerbaijanis' self-presentation strategies, →Pearce and Vitak (2016) reveal how social structures and cultural behavioral codes can influence how people use social media. Thus social media affordances can conflict or not be accessible to members wanting to adhere to cultural norms. While they did not study an organizational context, their work reveals gender differences in how people use social media, as well as how knowing they are surveilled has a direct influence on their behavior.

3.3.2 *Social Capital*

Social capital refers to the resources that derive from the relationships among people in varying social contexts (→Steinfield et al. 2009). Specifically, the concept of social capital describes the benefits individuals derive from their social relationships and interactions. This can include resources, like emotional support, exposure to diverse ideas, and access to non-redundant information. Social capital is embedded in the structure of social networks and the location of individuals within these structures (→Burt 2005). Historically, scholars have focused on two main types of social

capital: bridging and bonding. Bridging social capital refers to the benefits received from establishing connections to others outside one's primary networks. Bonding social capital includes the benefits received from connections to those within one's primary network (such as family and friends). Bridging social capital is commonly understood through access to new information, compared to bonding social capital, which is more likely to include benefits like emotional support. Specific communication practices on social media (e.g., Facebook; →Sias and Duncan 2020) have been empirically linked to users' social capital.

Several studies have examined social capital and the use of social media in organizational contexts. →Sias and Duncan (2020) conducted a cross-organizational survey and explored both bridging social capital outcomes and the bridging structure when employees interact with their organization's Facebook page. Their findings suggest that these types of interactions benefit employees not by forming traditional weak tie interpersonal relationships, but instead by helping employees have a broader form of connection and increased outward-looking perspective. In their empirical work on how people use ESNSs, →Cummings and Dennis (2018) studied the impact of coworker perceptions when people use these systems before formally meeting one another. They found that many forms of social and structural capital can develop before meeting peers. While their findings are nuanced, they reveal the importance of including details in an ESNS profile, especially when working in a team environment; people who see this content will likely form an initial impression that can shape the subsequent working relationship.

While prior research has shown that impression management through ESNSs is important for virtual teams (→Cummings and Dennis 2018), the trends toward allowing a significant portion of the workforce to work from home will present additional priorities for research. Prior to the COVID-

19 pandemic, most of the research on what has been called telework, virtual work, and work from home centered on knowledge workers and a more limited number of people who chose these alternative work arrangements. Now it appears that entire organizations will allow their employees to work from home, including job roles like administrative staff, who were not always offered those options in the past. Exploring how people in different job roles tap into the affordances of social media to make themselves appear more present in a more virtual organization can offer promising insight into our understanding of affordances and theories that will guide future research in this area.

3.3.3 Knowledge Sharing

Sharing information and knowledge is a foundational part of organizations, and it is also a commonly examined reason and outcome of using social media in and around organizations. Some of the reasons ESM platforms were introduced in organizations were to make knowledge sharing easier (→Leonardi, Huysman, and Steinfield 2013), however, using social media to share knowledge or have knowledge conversations (→Majchrzak et al. 2013), can both facilitate and restrict what is actually shared in organizations (→Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg 2013; →Majchrzak et al. 2013).

In their theoretical work about knowledge sharing and social media use, →Ellison, Gibbs, and Weber (2015) illustrate how ESNSs can be used to enable, constrain, and reshape knowledge sharing, especially in large organizations that have networked organizational structures. Scholars also explain that knowledge sharing does not occur independently from the development of social relationships, social capital building, power structures, and self-presentation (→Ellison, Gibbs, and Weber 2015; →Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg 2013; →Treem and Leonardi 2013).

3.3.4 Privacy

Privacy is a consideration that can impact how individuals choose to use social media. As →Trepte and Reinecke (2011) describe, “Our fundamental need for privacy is contrasted by a powerful mechanism of social interaction: self-disclosure to others is similarly important for social functioning and psychological well-being” (p. 5). Because people digitally record and archive their performance and enactment of self on social media, individuals often make critical decisions about what content to share and how to share it – especially on social media based on environments that thrive on users’ shared content. In certain contexts, sharing and protecting private information are important goals for people. For example, some employees may choose to utilize social media to be connected to coworkers, whereas others may limit social media coworker connections with a preference for engaging in face-to-face interaction with colleagues at work (→Frampton and Child 2013).

Research suggests there is a privacy paradox, meaning there is a gap between what people report as their individual privacy attitudes and their actual behaviors on social media (→Choi and Bazarova 2015). Furthermore, in their study of more public forms of social media, →Choi and Bazarova (2015) found differences between different social media platforms (e.g., Facebook and Twitter (or X)). They used the Communication Privacy Management theory and the concept of boundary turbulence – the difficulty of managing privacy boundaries due to misalignments in boundary permeability, linkages, and ownership (→Petronio 2002) – to bring light to the tensions people feel when others want them to be open, yet they want to be able to manage their boundaries. This finding is similar to the tension that →Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg (2013) found when organizational members struggled with being open or more closed with their online

communication. Future research on knowledge sharing and privacy will benefit by building on existing research on the affordances of social media, specifically how people invoke the affordance of visibility (e.g., →Leonardi and Treem 2020).

3.4 Outcomes of Organizational Social Media Use

Much of the early research on organizational social media use focused on defining and developing frameworks around understanding this form of ICT use (e.g., →Leonardi, Huysman, and Steinfield 2013; →Majchrzak et al. 2013; →Treem and Leonardi 2013). More recently, scholars have contributed empirical findings to this literature, and the organizational outcomes of these studies can be categorized into knowledge and information sharing and work engagement.

3.5 Knowledge and Information Sharing

While knowledge and information sharing are key reasons people use ESMs, they are also key outcomes complicated because of the affordances of social media. Some empirical studies have found that using social media to share knowledge increases job satisfaction (→Robertson and Kee 2017) and fosters social capital (→Leonardi and Meyer 2015). However, some people are also skeptical about using social media for work purposes (→Treem et al. 2015). In their empirical work studying a high-tech startup, →Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg (2013) found these systems can increase open communication, but they also create dialectical tensions that workers often covertly manage. Specifically, they identified three tensions: visibility-invisibility, engagement-disengagement, and sharing-control. The visibility-invisibility tension explores how social media affordances enable remote coworkers to be more visible, but also to lurk/remain invisible

to others in the information stream. Engagement-disengagement refers to how affordances can promote quick interactions and frequent updates, but also can be distracting to others. Sharing-control represents how social media affordances allow for ease of knowledge sharing, but with concerns present about confidentiality and job security.

3.6 Work Engagement and Using Personal Social Media for Work Use

A body of empirical research on social media use in organizations has uncovered some meaningful mechanisms to understand work engagement. Prior research has found that work-related social media use can increase feelings of being identified with an organization (→van Zoonen and Treem 2019), having colleagues as Facebook friends can increase identification (→Bartels, van Vuuren, and Ouwerkerk 2019). When employees interact with their organization's Facebook page, they also report higher levels of identification (→Sias and Duncan 2020).

While many employees use social media for work-related information sharing, they also use social media for nonwork-related purposes (→Oksa et al. 2021; →van Zoonen and Banghart 2018; →van Zoonen and Treem 2019). People who engage in these different types of uses often experience context collapse, meaning their various audiences become obscured (→Vitak 2012), and scholars studying this phenomenon have identified ways people manage these difficult situations. For example, sometimes SNS users create separate accounts for work and personal life, and other times they deliberately keep professional contacts out of social media platforms they use for their personal life; thus, they create boundaries (→van Zoonen and Banghart 2018), and engage in forms of self-presentation (→Vitak 2012).

Recently, research has examined whether people are engaged in using social media for work-related, or non-work-related communication when communicating with work colleagues. In their study of five Finnish professional organizations and a sample of the population, →Oksa and colleagues (2021) found that work-related social media use with work colleagues led to higher work engagement. However, they also found that both work- and nonwork-related social media lead to work engagement indirectly through social support and organizational identification. Both forms of social media communication with colleagues led to higher feelings of identification with their organization and led them to feel more support, which in turn increased their work engagement. Their findings suggest that using social media at work, even when it is not on task, could play an important social role that ultimately increases their engagement with work. Future research should explore this further especially given the changing organizational environment as more people work from home.

3.7 Organizational Social Media Use and Negative Outcomes

Thus far this chapter has provided several examples of situations where using ESM or public social media creates tensions for employees. It is noteworthy to remember that social media is one of the few ICTs (in contrast to email or mobile phones) where people used these platforms first in their personal lives, and now it is also used in their organizational life. (→Stephens 2018). Therefore, people may have developed personal usage patterns that could conflict with how social media are used in organizations. In their interview study of workers before and after implementing an ESM system, →Treem and colleagues (2015) found that employees had different opinions concerning the usefulness

of ESM, and their initial views served to anchor them in how they used the ESM. Specifically, they found that before implementation, younger employees (defined as people under 24), and heavy social media users were more skeptical of ESM. In contrast, while older workers and light social media users were more optimistic. These opinions shaped how they engaged with the platform, and those less optimistic engaged with it less.

There is also some evidence that many of the same dominant power structures observed with in-person, and online platforms also exist with online social media use. Using a big data set consisting of server-side data across organizations, →Di Tommaso and colleagues (2020) found that high-ranked employees tend to connect with colleagues of a similar rank, and those in higher ranks are more central in their organizational networks.

Another challenge is that some people will likely view any social media use at work as cyberloafing (an unproductive use of online media), especially when it is for personal reasons. In their study, →Andreassen, Torsheim, and Pallesen (2014) found that older employees, and female employees viewed using social media for personal reasons during work more negatively. They also found that top-level managers used social media for personal reasons during work hours more than members of other groups, and that people who reported having challenging work, and those with high work demands tended to cyberloaf less.

3.8 Research Priorities around Organizational Social Media Use

Cultural and demographic differences are only occasionally examined in the organizational social media literature (e.g., →Di Tommaso et al. 2020), and few scholars (e.g., →Etter and Albu 2021) are using critical theories to better explain the

power dynamics around these practices. For example, people who have limited access to the internet are not able to access social media, and that is often overlooked in our studies. Even people employed by organizations do not have equal access to the internet or technology tools, and some are banned from using these platforms based on their job roles (→Stephens and Ford 2016). Our field could benefit from understanding how unequal access to social media may actually marginalize certain populations, and using the recommendations from →Pearce and Vitak (2016), we should further explore how cultural norms prevent groups of people from leveraging social media in beneficial ways.

4 Social Media and Organizing

Beyond the use of social media in and around work organizations, is the notion that social media can be used to facilitate organizing outside a work context, and outside a formal organizational structure. A considerable body of research on collective action, and digital technologies have enabled new organizational forms to emerge (→Bimber, Flanagin, and Stohl 2012; →Theocharis, Vitoratou, and Sajuria 2017), and new forms of participation (→Ganesh, Stohl, and Kim 2022). While a full review of the role of social media in collective action is beyond the scope of this chapter, it is helpful to see how the affordances discussed earlier in this chapter also operate in online organizing contexts.

A common thread in much of the work on organizing and social media is that it happens in response to some form of shared need or crisis: political, economic, or disaster response. Furthermore, recent work arguing that visibility is an affordance of social media that is foundational, meaning other affordances rely on or build on it (→Treem, Leonardi, and van den Hooff 2020), can be used to explain the prolific growth in online collective action: people can see organizing happening

through conversations on public forms of social media, and it can even transition to offline actions. For example, in their study of an online tutoring system in Greece that emerged for economic reasons, →Theocharis, Vitoratou, and Sajuria (2017) found that platforms like Twitter (or X) can bring strangers together and build network ties that allow for sustained organization of voluntary actions. In their case, not only did new organizational structures form out of the use of social media, but they transferred their efforts to an offline environment as well.

The social media affordance of visibility is key in prompting spontaneous organizing behaviors amidst an uncertain environment. While this context may be different from how employees communicate at work, collective actions offer organizational scholars new ways to view social media as a tool for online organizing, and thus provides ample opportunities for research. Social media have increased the speed, scale, and visibility of communication behaviors (→Stephens, Robertson, and Murthy 2020; →Treem, Leonardi, and van den Hooff 2020). Their utility has also expanded into high-stakes organizing like for disasters. →Houston's (2019) functional framework for strategic social media use in disaster resilience showcases how social media enables users to organize around disaster preparedness and response. Following a tornado hazard, →Spialek, Czlapinski, and Houston (2016) found that social media behavior (specifically knowledge sharing) was associated with community resilience perceptions: participants using social media were more likely to find their community as connected and caring, as well as having more transformative potential.

Drawing on the affordance of visibility also opens opportunities for studying how participation happens and how groups self-organize, often in an ad hoc manner. The use of social media during disasters offers a clear example of how people organize and contribute their individual expertise to a

cause. Furthermore, they can also compensate for a lack of official organizational responses. →Smith and colleagues (2021) studied the organizing behaviors of volunteers who used social media to work behind the scenes and coordinate response and recovery efforts during Hurricane Harvey. These ad hoc groups emerged because they saw social media posts of desperate individuals whom official response organizations were not quickly rescuing. Smith and colleagues call these volunteers disaster knowledge workers because they brought their professional expertise into the volunteer task, and they used technology extensively to work behind the scenes. Their efforts performing coordinating and communicative functions using online public and semi-public social media tools resulted in people being rescued.

When groups collectively access and use social media as their primary organizing platform, they tend to develop what →Leonardi (2013) calls collective or shared affordances. This means they can draw upon and use social media in similar ways. A considerable amount of the existing work on organizing and social media use describes what happens when people organize online around disasters (→Hughes 2019; →Smith et al. 2021; →Starbird and Palen 2011), and while that is a valuable part of this body of research, there are additional research opportunities for scholars in our field to study *how* groups self-organize online, and *how* they rely on affordances of social media to make decisions to get involved, leave, and grow their organizations.

One study offers some promise in understanding this more nuanced relationship. →Ganesh, Stohl, and Kim (2022) studied an online collective action platform and found that the ubiquity of digital platforms (in this case, their platform could be considered a form of social media) provided opportunities for new forms of organizing and participation. At the heart of their findings is how each of the four archetypes they develop in the study relied on different digital affordances, and the

shared affordances in each archetype related to their participatory styles. Their research provides a theoretical mechanism to describe some of the patterns of participation seen in contexts such as disaster organizing. For example, →Hughes (2019) explains that much of the disaster social media research relies on a convergence framework describing people's actions after they see calls for help on social media. There is an opportunity for organizational communication scholars to move the online disaster organizing literature forward by better understanding *how* people draw upon affordances of social media to help them self-select into their organizing roles.

There are also nuanced ways that people draw upon the visibility affordances of social media to capture attention. For example, →Stephens, Robertson, and Murthy (2020) examined how individuals in need of rescue used social media not only to make their calls for help visible, but how they drew upon affordances of social media to amplify their calls for help (→Stephens, Robertson, and Murthy 2020). Specifically, they found that battery life was a material limitation of the mobile phones people used to access social media, so when they could no longer post messages, they used other individuals as proxies to make their urgent situation visible. They also amplified their rescue messages by including images, a more evocative way to draw upon the affordance of visibility. When people not in danger saw terrifying images, it motivated them to take action, or to share those images, thus further amplifying and increasing the visibility of the original calls for help.

Just because the visibility affordance of social media makes conversations and community action more visible, it does not always mean that what is being seen was generated by a human, or by an algorithm with neutral intentions. Many people are unaware that algorithms constantly operate behind the scenes of social media platforms, and something

as simple as calculating the use of a hashtag and having content appear in a feed are all part of the algorithmic world of social media. In a multi-method study of Tunisian social media-based activist organizations, →Etter and Albu (2021) reveal that algorithms can be designed to act like humans, can deliberately distort messages, can propagate capitalist agendas, and humans are often unaware this is happening. Their study that both interviewed activists and scraped data from social media feeds finds that "hidden algorithms introduce constraints on collective action by operating in other ways to those anticipated by actors" (→Etter and Albu 2021: 84). They identify three forms of algorithmic distortion that can constrain organizing processes: information overload, opacity, and disinformation. They caution people trying to interpret activism realities because the content being circulated that forms the foundation of online collective action often includes hidden algorithms with algorithmic distortion.

5 Directions for Future Research

Organizational communication scholars have many opportunities to contribute to the growing body of research on social media use in and around organizations as well as in online organizing. Many prior studies have started to build strong connections to meaningful organizational constructs like identification, knowledge sharing, privacy, and impression management, and that should be continued. The theoretical work on affordances of social media has progressed to meaningful levels, and our next step is to explore how they function across contexts. Learning about how online organizing happens could also help organizations and their members better use ESMs to facilitate more informal organizational collaboration.

While still very new, scholars might examine the growing prevalence of employee advocacy systems and explore how

they enable and constrain employees' social media use. For example, Hootsuite Amplify and other programs claim to help employees share organizationally approved content, and some of the systems will feed pre-approved content to employees so they can build their own credibility as they use social selling strategies (→Best Employee Advocacy Software 2021). Scholars can study how employees use this curated content including how this relates to core organizational constructs like identification and knowledge sharing. It is also important to study employees who choose not to use these systems and those who avoid displaying their organizational affiliations on social media; this will provide a balanced approach that will likely further enhance understandings of organizational relationships and social media.

While discussions around artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning are not new to organizations, access to big data, including social media data, along with advancements in computing have made them increasingly studied in and around organizations and organizing practices. →Matei and Kee (2019) describe the role of AI and machine learning as important to the field of organizational communication because organizations often make key decisions based on large amounts of data, including social media data. As we continue studying the relationships between social media data and constructs important for our field, it is important to acknowledge and examine how these technologies enable, constrain, and assist organizational members. There are rich opportunities to focus on ethics and privacy in the use of this data because, as →Etter and Albu (2021) showed in their analysis of social media platforms and activism, there is a lack of transparency in the algorithms used.

6 Conclusion

Organizational communication scholars have actively engaged in studying the relationships between people and social media on the theoretical, empirical, and practical levels. We have amassed a solid body of work focused on ESM and ESNS, developed understandings of their affordances, and examined antecedents and outcomes of their use. Our scholarship has built on understandings of personal social media use and compared that to uses more tightly coupled with organizational goals. Additionally, we have used our knowledge of organizing, membership, and participation to uncover relationships between social media use and new organizational forms. The future is bright for our work to continue advancing even as social media platforms morph into new communication tools for us to use.

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Chapter 24 Distributed Collaboration

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Abstract

Scholars from a variety of disciplines have been studying distributed collaboration – defined here as work-based interactions that are enacted across geographical, temporal, cultural, and organizational boundaries – for over two decades. Although distributed collaboration is clearly not a new phenomenon, the current moment in which we are living – defined by the COVID-19 pandemic as well as a renewed focus on racial and social justice – has both raised the visibility of distributed organizing and transformed our understanding of it, as distributed or remote work has become the new normal. This chapter traces the historical trajectory of research on distributed collaboration, reviews the literature across various levels of analysis and meta-theoretical traditions, and outlines future research directions and opportunities for critically examining the state of knowledge in this area and moving it forward to better address our contemporary circumstances. While this topic is of interdisciplinary interest and relevance, we argue that scholars of organizational communication are uniquely poised to theorize and empirically study collaboration in distributed contexts of organizing, and we invite them to help extend the conversation.

Keywords: boundary management, collaboration, computer-mediated communication (CMC), constant connectivity, constitutive view (CCO), critical approach, discontinuities, enterprise social media (ESM), global teams, inter-

organizational collaboration, interpretive approach, Media Richness Theory, multinational teams, networks, proximity, post-positivist approach, Purdue Peace Project (PPP), remote work, Social Presence Theory, sociomateriality, telework, virtuality, visibility, zoom,

The proliferation of communication technologies in the workplace has facilitated new forms of distributed collaboration. While early views of organizations regarded them as bounded in time and space, with work taking place in co-located, physical buildings through face-to-face interactions, this is no longer the case, or even the norm. Scholars from a variety of disciplines have been studying distributed collaboration – defined here as work-based interactions that are enacted across geographical, temporal, cultural, and organizational boundaries – for over two decades (→ter Hoeven and Gibbs 2019). Scholars have studied this topic under the guise of several distinct but overlapping terms: distributed work (e.g., →Hinds and Kiesler 2002), virtual work (e.g., →Raghuram et al. 2019), telework (e.g., →Bailey and Kurland 2002), and remote work (e.g., →Veinott et al. 1999). Although distributed collaboration has been taking place for decades, the current moment in which we are living – defined by the COVID-19 pandemic – has both raised the visibility of distributed organizing and transformed our understanding of it, as distributed or remote work has become the new normal.

Distributed collaboration is a phenomenon that spans levels of analysis, as well as disciplinary and meta-theoretical traditions. At the individual level, it has been studied primarily in terms of telework and remote work (e.g., →Fonner and Roloff 2010; →van Zoonen, Sivunen, and Rice 2020). A large body of research has studied collaboration in global virtual teams (e.g., →Connaughton and Shuffler 2007; →Gibson and Gibbs 2006; →Gilson et al. 2015; →Martins, Gilson, and Maynard 2004). Distributed collaboration in organizations has

also been studied (→Fulk and Yuan 2013; →Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg 2013), as well as in inter-organizational alliances and network organizations (e.g., →Cooper and Shumate 2012; →Connaughton and Ptacek 2020; →Connaughton et al. 2017). A review of communication and distributed work (→ter Hoeven and Gibbs 2019) divided the literature into the following categories: proximity and distance, telework, virtuality and virtual teams, mobile work, organizational social media use, work-nonwork boundaries, and stress and overload.

Different technologies have also been studied, ranging from early studies of email and computer conferencing to more recent workplace technologies including instant messaging, knowledge management and collaborative technologies, enterprise social media, mobile devices, and algorithmic systems. Distributed collaboration is an interdisciplinary topic that is prevalent in the fields of management, information systems, computer science, and communication. This has resulted in scholarship taking a range of disciplinary and meta-theoretical perspectives. For instance, the management literature on virtual teams is heavily dominated by the functionalist inputs-processes-outputs model (e.g., →Martins, Gilson, and Maynard 2004). The virtual teams research has been characterized by study of a variety of team types and designs, which have led to divergent findings in some cases (→Gibbs, Sivunen, and Boyraz 2017). Organizational and inter-organizational level studies are more likely to take a constitutive perspective that regards organizations as communicatively constructed (e.g., →Barbour et al. 2020; →Treem and Leonardi 2013) or a network approach (e.g., →Cooper and Shumate 2012; →Doerfel 2016).

While this topic is of interdisciplinary interest and relevance, scholars of organizational communication are uniquely poised to theorize and empirically study

collaboration in distributed contexts of organizing. In particular, the current historical moment – characterized by remote work due to the COVID-19 pandemic and a renewed focus on racial and social justice – is opportune for encouraging us to critically examine the state of knowledge in this area and what we have yet to discover. Thus, this chapter will review the literature on distributed collaboration and revisit it with an eye to the future.

1 Historical Context

Distributed collaboration has been studied since the 1970s, since advances in computerized technology allowed for work to be conducted across geographical locations. Early research (→Hiltz, Johnson, and Turoff 1986; →Olson and Olson 2000; →Rice and Love 1987) was characterized primarily by lab-based studies that examined the differences between face-to-face and computer-mediated communication (CMC), with attention to the extent to which socioemotional cues and interpersonal relationships could be conveyed through CMC, and whether distributed groups and teams could perform as effectively as traditional, co-located teams.

Perhaps due to the short-term, zero-history nature of the CMC teams used in early research (→Gibbs, Sivunen, and Boyraz 2017), early theorizing was characterized by the cues-filtered-out (CFO) approach (→Walther and Parks 2002). This approach – reflected in theories such as Social Presence Theory (→Short, Williams, and Christie 1976) and Media Richness Theory (→Daft and Lengel 1986) – assumed that the reduced socioemotional and context cues available in CMC would impair the development of interpersonal relationships and impede the effectiveness of distributed teams. Later CMC theorizing gave way to theories such as Social Information Processing (SIP) (→Walther 1992) and the hyperpersonal perspective (→Walther 1996) that recognized that CMC users

were still motivated to form impressions and relationships, even in reduced-cue environments, and that reduced cues may even lead to greater intimacy. More recent theorizing draws on an affordances perspective (→Gibbs and Navick 2023; →Gibson 1979; →Treem and Leonardi 2013) to explain the ways in which digital technologies afford new action possibilities, shifting our thinking even further away from a deficit or deficiency model (→Gibbs et al. 2008). While communication scholars have moved from a deficit to an affordance view of CMC, the interdisciplinary literature on distributed and virtual work has not fully incorporated this view. The research has, however, moved out of the lab to include field studies of in situ teams and organizations.

Around the turn of the 21st century, the terms "virtuality" and "virtual" became adopted in order to go beyond the single dimension of "distance" or "distribution" and incorporate other aspects of technologically enabled teams and organizations. While these terms have been contested and applied differently in the literature, with various typologies being proposed (e.g., →Chudoba et al. 2005; →Gibson and Gibbs 2006; →Kirkman and Mathieu 2005), there is general consensus that virtuality is a multidimensional construct. A recent co-citation analysis of the research on virtual work conceptualizes virtuality in terms of two predominant dimensions in the literature: dispersion and technology dependence, which refer to the locational and technological contexts in which virtual work occurs (→Raghuram et al. 2019). →Gibson and Gibbs (2006) defined virtuality more broadly in terms of four features: geographical dispersion, electronic dependence, national diversity, and dynamic structure. They also recognize that virtuality is a continuum, such that teams range from low to high on each characteristic (rather than being simply virtual or non-virtual). Given the ubiquity of technology use in contemporary

organizations, it can be argued that all teams are now virtual, albeit to varying extents.

Scholars often define virtuality in terms of boundaries and discontinuities. →Watson-Manheim, Chudoba, and Crowston (2002) define virtuality in terms of discontinuities (e.g., gaps or differences) that arise due to working across the boundaries of time, space, organization, and culture. Discontinuities are regarded as inherently communicative, as they write: "a discontinuity is created at a boundary when an individual perceives a change in information and communication flows that requires conscious effort and attention to handle" (→Watson-Manheim, Chudoba, and Crowston 2012: 36). Distance and culture have been identified as two key boundaries that are crossed by multinational, multicultural teams (→Connaughton and Shuffler 2007). Scholars have used several terms to describe the cultural aspects of virtual/distributed organizing. These include: transnational, multicultural, multinational, global, intercultural, and international. Similarly, researchers have employed three terms to allude to the distributed nature of these organizing forms: virtual, dispersed, and distributed (→Connaughton and Shuffler 2007). In their conceptual piece, →Connaughton and Shuffler (2007) acknowledge that researchers have combined these terms in various ways and have produced 14 different terms (i.e., cross-cultural virtual teams, computer-mediated distributed teams, global teams; for a complete list, see p. 390).

A general shift in the virtual work literature can be seen from viewing virtual workers as disconnected to overly connected (→Gibbs and Navick 2023). Older literature tended to regard them as isolated and separated by computer screens and distance, and placed emphasis on attempts to connect them through either more interactive technologies such as social media (→Ellison, Gibbs, and Weber 2015) or through interpersonal processes such as building trust,

perceived proximity (→Wilson et al. 2008), or psychologically safe communication climates (→Gibson and Gibbs 2006). The explosion of mobile and digital devices such as smartphones, laptops, and tablets has shifted the discourse away from concerns about lack of connection to concerns about excessive connection due to the constant connectivity enabled by these ubiquitous forms of technology (e.g., →Büchler, ter Hoeven, and van Zoonen 2020; →Mazmanian, Orlikowski, and Yates 2013; →Nurmi and Hinds 2020; →van Zoonen, Sivunen, and Rice 2020). This has given rise to research documenting the communication strategies used by distributed workers to strategically increase, rather than decrease, distance from their colleagues (→Leonardi, Treem, and Jackson 2010) and to limit their engagement and availability to others (→Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg 2013) in order to protect their time and attention in an attempt to manage tensions between autonomy and connection.

2 Levels of Analysis

As mentioned above, distributed collaboration is a phenomenon that spans contexts and levels of analysis. It is evident at the individual level through telework and remote work (e.g., →Fonner and Roloff 2010; →Kossek 2016), and at the team level through the research on collaboration in global and virtual teams (e.g., →Connaughton and Shuffler 2007; →Gibson and Gibbs 2006). At the organizational and inter-organizational levels, collaboration has been studied across distributed organizations (e.g., →Fulk and Yuan 2013; →Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg 2013) as well as in inter-organizational alliances and network organizations (e.g., →Cooper and Shumate 2012; →Connaughton et al. 2017; →Connaughton, Kuang, and Yakova 2017). In the following sections, we review key research findings at each level of analysis, and conclude with suggested questions for future research to explore.

2.1 Individual Level

A first level of analysis is the individual level. Scholars have been studying telework, remote work, and virtual work with a focus at both the individual (e.g., teleworkers) and the team (e.g., virtual teams) level. At the individual level, the telecommuting (or telework) literature focuses on the characteristics and outcomes of individual teleworkers including motivation, satisfaction, performance, and well-being (→Fonner and Roloff 2010; →Golden, Veiga, and Dino 2008; →ter Hoeven and van Zoonen 2015). The literature portrays telework as fraught with paradox, as its surrounding discourse emphasizes it as liberating and empowering for employees by giving them greater autonomy and flexibility, yet teleworkers often experience greater job stress and work-life conflict due to greater interruptions from the conflation of their work and home domains (→Kossek, Lautsch, and Eaton 2006), as well as professional isolation (→Golden, Veiga, and Dino 2008), reduced status and legitimacy (→Hylmö 2006), and lower organizational identification (→Fonner and Roloff 2012; →Wiesenfeld, Raghuram, and Garud 2001). More recent research examines boundary management tactics for managing work-life conflict (→Kossek 2016; →Kreiner, Hollensbe, and Sheep 2009), including the role of boundary communication, which involves communicating about cross-boundary demands (→van Zoonen, Sivunen, and Rice 2020), as well as impacts of constant connectivity on employee well-being (→ter Hoeven, van Zoonen, and Fonner 2016). While much of the popular discourse around remote work treats it as a new phenomenon necessitated by the COVID-19 pandemic, work-from-home arrangements have been common for decades and the telework literature provides a useful base to build on in understanding what is the same or different about the current “forced remote work” arrangements (e.g., →Nordbäck et al. 2021).

Future research on distributed collaboration at the individual level should consider the following research questions:

- How does distributed collaboration constrain or enable remote workers' motivation? Participation? Feelings of inclusion or exclusion?
- How do remote workers experience identity, particularly its intersectional nature, amidst distributed collaborations? How do interactions and other forms of communication constitute identity? What are the consequences of such constructions?
- How do remote workers navigate the tension between greater autonomy and greater isolation in distributed work settings? How is autonomy discursively constructed and manifested in distributed collaborations? How is isolation and disconnectedness discursively constructed and manifested in distributed collaborations?
- What are the implications of constant connectivity for remote workers? Specifically, for their personal health and well-being? For their ability to collaborate effectively?

2.2 Team Level

A second level of analysis is at the group or team level. Early research on distributed, computer-mediated, or virtual teams tended to compare 100% face-to-face and 100% computer-mediated groups in laboratory settings, often finding that co-located or in-person teams outperformed virtual teams (→Hollingshead and McGrath 1995). This research often relied on cues-filtered-out perspectives such as Media Richness Theory (→Daft and Lengel 1986) and Social Presence Theory (→Short, Williams, and Christie 1976), which argue that electronic media are leaner in information richness and convey less social presence, to forward the commonly accepted view that interpersonal dynamics are hampered in

virtual teams due to reduced social and nonverbal cues. This can be seen in empirical studies finding that virtual teams struggle to build trust (→Jarvenpaa and Leidner 1999), experience greater conflict (→Hinds and Mortensen 2005), and have difficulties sharing knowledge (→Cramton, Orvis, and Wilson 2007; →Sole and Edmondson 2002). This research also began to focus on communicative mechanisms that could overcome the deficiencies of virtuality and help build relational closeness, such as perceived proximity (→Wilson et al. 2008), a psychologically safe communication climate (→Gibson and Gibbs 2006), distanced leadership (→Connaughton and Daly 2004, →2005), and homophily in social networks (→Yuan and Gay 2006).

Other research has challenged the deficiency model of virtuality (→Gibbs et al. 2008) and argued that early findings may be explained by the study design, in that experimental groups were often short-term, zero-history, performing an artificial task and learning to use a new technology (→Gibbs, Sivunen, and Weber 2017). Longitudinal and field studies have produced more positive and nuanced findings regarding the ways in which communication technologies are intertwined with team and organizational processes (→Erhardt et al. 2016; →Majchrzak et al. 2000). They have also adopted constitutive and discursive perspectives to examine how team processes such as subgroups and status differences are discursively constructed through language and team interaction (→Gibbs 2009; →Gibbs et al. 2021a, →2021b; →Hinds, Neeley, and Cramton 2014).

Future research on distributed collaboration at the team level should consider the following research questions:

- How does distributed collaboration contribute to inequities among team members?
- How can communication patterns in distributed collaborations contribute to psychologically unsafe communication climates?

- What communicative dynamics contribute to certain remote team members emerging as team leaders and not others?
- How are subgroups that are disruptive to distributed collaborations formed? How are they enabled or constrained?
- How do new communication technologies such as chat and videoconferencing platforms (e.g., Zoom, Slack, WhatsApp) contribute to status differences among team members?

2.3 Organizational Level

A third level of analysis is the organizational level. Scholars have studied collaboration in distributed organizations through two major research streams: (1) organizational social media use and (2) mobile work. The first research stream arose about a decade ago, when enterprise social media (ESM) platforms were starting to be adopted by organizations. Communication scholars, in particular, contributed to this research stream by developing the affordances perspective (→Leonardi, Huysman, and Steinfield 2013; →Treem and Leonardi 2013) to theorize and study the unique potential of ESM to transform work and organizing processes. Research emphasized the benefits of ESM for organizational knowledge sharing in terms of location of expertise, motivating participation, and developing social capital and context awareness (→Ellison, Gibbs, and Weber 2015; →Fulk and Yuan 2013). Other research found that the open architecture of social media platforms produced contradictory outcomes that motivated not just open communication and knowledge sharing but also strategic behavior to limit knowledge sharing and involvement (→Gibbs, Rozaidi, and Eisenberg 2013; →Majchrzak et al. 2013), and that the use of ESM platforms depends on the technological frames or meanings developed

around their usage (→Treem et al. 2015). This research has given way to increased focus on behavioral visibility arising from newer technologies such as algorithms through the datafication and digitization of organizations (→Leonardi and Treem 2020) as digital technologies make organizational behavior, decisions, and preferences more visible (→ter Hoeven et al. 2021).

The second major research stream focuses on the use and impacts of digital mobile devices such as personal digital assistants, tablets, and smartphones on work. The ubiquity of these devices, which can be carried with workers such that they are ever present, means that work can be conducted at any time, from any place. While this brings benefits in terms of greater responsiveness and connectivity, it also creates pressures for workers to be always on – known as constant connectivity – and normalizes workplace interruptions (→Wajcman and Rose 2011). →Mazmanian, Orlikowski, and Yates (2013) document the paradoxical effects of mobile email devices through the concept of the "autonomy paradox", finding that knowledge professionals feel that these technologies allow them greater flexibility in their work yet often do not realize how much they use them in ways that increasingly tether them to it. In another study comparing the use of mobile email devices across two departments in the same organization, →Mazmanian (2013) finds that technology adoption leads to heterogeneous practices, as one occupational group is able to circumvent the trap of constant connectivity while the other one succumbs to it, due to the different sociomaterial practices developed by each group. Whereas the virtual teams research tends to take a cues-filtered-out perspective that regards technology use as determined by a medium's inherent features, much of the research at the organizational level draws on perspectives from sociomateriality or practice theory (→Oborn, Barrett, and Orlikowski 2019; →Orlikowski 2007) that recognizes that

technology use and impacts are situated in particular social contexts and moves toward a broader theorizing of how technology contributes to organizational transformation.

Future research on distributed collaboration at the organizational level should consider the following research questions:

- What expertise and/or knowledge does ESM exclude? How can we change the technologies and/or communication processes so that they are more inclusive?
- What impacts do digital technologies which enable constant connectivity have on local cultures and ways of interacting (i.e., when remote workers are employed by multinational corporations or Western non-governmental organizations)? How do connectivity norms differ across organizations and cultures, and how does this impact global work?
- How do distributed work processes differ in alternative contexts of organizing that involve populations with less resources and status than knowledge workers in corporations (which tend to be studied most)?
- How do organizing processes of governance, control, and collaboration arise in self-organizing digital contexts such as online communities?

2.4 Inter-Organizational Level

A fourth level of analysis to which communication researchers have contributed new knowledge is inter-organizational collaboration in global network organizations, cross-sector and international alliances. While these forms of organizing often take place across distance and through computer-mediated communication, they are not always studied explicitly as virtual or distributed collaboration. For this reason, research on inter-organizational collaboration is not

generally included in reviews of virtual work or distributed work (e.g., →Raghuram et al. [2019] only identified research clusters at individual, group, and organizational levels). We include it here because we regard inter-organizational collaboration as an important research domain for organizational communication scholars that incorporates similar elements of distributed collaboration.

To be sure, collaboration in general, and especially inter-organizational collaboration, is communicatively constituted (→Barbour and James 2015; →Flanigan, Stohl, and Bimber 2006; →Lewis, Isbell, and Koschmann 2010). As →Barbour et al. (2020) write, "cross-sector, interorganizational networks are essential infrastructure for community resilience" (p. 93). They illustrate this in the context of Hazmat planning, which involves cross-sector work among public and private organizations. Here, not only are these inter-organizational networks planning, preparing, and responding to dangerous situations, they are also doing so across various geographic, cultural, and technological boundaries. Inter-organizational collaboration and community resilience have also been studied in the context of disaster preparation, response, and recovery (→Doerfel 2016; →Doerfel, Chewning, and Lai 2013). As →Doerfel (2016) states, at the heart of community resilience are "organizations communicating through networks to gain and share information and resources" (p. 367).

Distributed inter-organizational collaborations also can be seen in the work on international and intercultural alliances. One example of an initiative grounded in distributed inter-organizational collaboration is the Purdue Peace Project (→Connaughton et al. 2017; →Connaughton, Kuang, and Yakova 2017). The Purdue Peace Project (PPP) is located at Purdue University in the United States as well as areas in Africa where its local collaborators reside. From its inception, the initiative was intercultural, international, and distributed,

relying often on communication technologies (i.e., Skype, WhatsApp) to organize. The distributed nature of PPP's work is seen in its team organizing as well as its programming (→Connaughton et al. 2017; →Connaughton, Kuang, and Yakova 2017). PPP not only did its work virtually due to employment commitments of all team members (tied to their geographic location – i.e., at Purdue, in Liberia), but also due to circumstances on the ground. For instance, when a public health crisis (Ebola) hit one of the nations in which PPP was doing collaborative projects, the collaboration needed to be done virtually per travel limitations.

Future research on distributed collaboration at the inter-organizational level should consider the following research questions:

- Where is power and influence located? How does it influence the ways in which distributed collaboration is done at the inter-organizational level? How does it influence who participates in distributed collaboration? What does distributed participation in these contexts look like?
- Can we imagine a democratic inter-organizational distributed collaboration? How can we bring it to fruition? How do varying and multiple regional, national, organizational and occupational cultures influence the processes and outcomes of inter-organizational distributed collaborations?
- How does technology enable and constrain inter-organizational distributed collaborations, especially when considering differences in time, geography, and culture?

3 Disciplinary and Meta-theoretical Traditions

A variety of meta-theoretical stances inform the study of distributed collaboration. One of those meta-theoretical stances is post-positivism. With the goal of predicting,

explaining, and controlling, post-positivist work on distributed collaboration can be seen in inputs-processes-outputs models or similar approaches to examining distributed collaboration, which is particularly prevalent in the virtual teams literature (e.g., →Martins, Gilson, and Maynard 2004).

This work often views communication along the lines of the transmission model. As such, researchers who adopt a post-positivist perspective consider the frequency with which communication takes place among team members (→Hinds and Mortensen 2005; →Jarvenpaa et al. 1998; →Maznevski and Chudoba 2000), the extent to which there is face-to-face communication among team members (→Mortensen and Hinds 2001; →Oertig and Buegri 2006), and other variables. In addition, researchers who emanate from a post-positivist perspective are interested in what makes distributed collaborations effective in terms of performance (i.e., →Chudoba et al. 2005), job satisfaction (→Fay and Kline 2011; →Fonner and Roloff 2010), and well-being (→ter Hoeven and van Zoonen 2015; →ter Hoeven, van Zoonen, and Fonner 2016). Others are interested in relationships among culture and other team variables such as trust (i.e., →Cogburn and Levinson 2003) and team effectiveness (→Jarvenpaa et al. 1998).

Post-positivist research presents mixed findings on the role of geographic distance on the effectiveness of distributed collaboration. On one hand, some researchers frame distance as a challenge. As →Connaughton and Shuffler (2007: 399) write:

> [D]istance is often framed initially as a constraint, a factor that must be overcome. In particular [...] constraining to relationship formation (→Jarvenpaa et al. 1998), team leadership (→Kayworth and Leidner 2001–2002), conflict management (→Maruping and Agarwal 2004), isolation (→Maruping and Agarwal 2004), social identity (→Maruping and Agarwal, 2004), socialization processes (see →Mortensen and Hinds 2001), communication (see →Cogburn and Levinson 2003), trust

(→Jarvenpaa and Leidner 1999), and knowledge sharing (→Cramton 2001).

Yet, other research has found that distance does not have an adverse effect on virtual collaboration. For example, →Chudoba and colleagues (2005) did not find a relationship between a team's geographic distribution and the team's performance (i.e., trust, communication effectiveness, commitment, and quality of outputs). →Hinds and Mortensen (2005), in a study that compared co-located and distributed team processes, found that shared identity and context as well as what they term spontaneous communication moderate distribution's relationship on task and affective conflict. Further, →Wilson et al. (2008) found that psychological closeness, or perceived proximity, matters more than physical proximity or distance.

Post-positivist researchers have found relationships among leadership, communication, and geographic distribution of teams. For instance, according to →Zaccaro, Ardison, and Orvis (2004), a critical aspect of effective leadership in distributed teams is engaging in intensive and supportive interaction with distributed team members as well as engaging in effective and efficient communication. →Wiesenfeld, Raghuram, and Garud (1999) uncovered a positive relationship between managers' and employees' frequency of communication with each other and those employees' organizational identification when working virtually.

Organizational communication scholars are well positioned to examine distributed collaboration, which in the absence of physical structures takes place and is instantiated through communicative interactions. The interpretive/critical turn in the 1980s shifted our thinking away from conceptualizations of organizations as "containers" in which communication takes place to embrace more complex, communication-centered views of organizing processes that

regard them as *constituted* by communication (→Putnam 1983; →Taylor et al. 2001). This shift was precipitated by Weick's theorizing of organizing as a process of communicating or conversing, in which organizational members actively create and make sense of their environments through processes of enactment, selection, and retention (→Weick 1979). It was then formalized through the 1981 conference in Alta, Utah, which resulted in an edited volume by →Putnam and Pacanowsky (1983) outlining the interpretive and critical perspectives. Since then, this constitutive view has become institutionalized into the field through the communicative constitution of organizations (CCO) perspective (→Boivin, Brummans, and Barker 2017). →Gibbs et al. (2008) developed a theoretical framework to reconceptualize virtual teaming from a constitutive perspective as it occurs through communicative processes of leadership, identification, knowledge sharing, conflict management, and trust. As mentioned above, much of the research on distributed collaboration at organizational and inter-organizational levels takes a constitutive approach (e.g., →Barbour et al. 2020; →Mazmanian, Orlikowski, and Yates 2013; →Treem et al. 2015). Communication scholars are well positioned to extend research on distributed collaboration at all levels of analysis through taking a variety of epistemological perspectives.

4 Future Directions

Despite the considerable work that has been done on distributed collaboration from post-positivist and constitutive (including both interpretive and sociomaterial) orientations, researchers still have much to unpack and interrogate about this kind of collaboration. In this section, we offer two general areas for future research.

COVID-19 prompted many individuals to (re)consider their relationships to work and their organizations. Since COVID began and policies and restrictions were put in place, individuals found themselves in situations where they had to quickly adopt remote work and thus, distributed collaboration, as the new normal. To be sure, some embraced this movement toward remote work, teaming, and collaboration. While not new for many sectors, distributed collaboration was a new organizing form for many others (i.e., many in higher education). Some universities in the United States, for example, have continued to allow staff (i.e., Human Resources, Business Office, Sponsored Programs) to work remotely despite university policies for faculty and students to return to campus for classes. Many needed to quickly learn new ways of doing collaborative work, “Zooming” and “(Microsoft) Teaming” with others to accomplish tasks. Many organizations have discovered that jobs that were once thought to only be possible to perform in person (such as teaching) are possible in geographically dispersed, technologically mediated forums.

For some, this was a welcome change. For others, this was not a choice nor was it welcomed. Future research needs to further examine the implications for remote and hybrid work of factors such as organizational and team identification; the relationship between work and life; the coping strategies used by members to deal with the various stressors they face; the overwhelming burden on women as they navigate family care and professional lives and attempt to have some semblance of self-care – which for many has meant dropping out of the workforce in what has been termed “the Great Resignation” (→Marks 2022); inequities related to technology, and new phenomena such as “Zoom fatigue” that take a toll on personal well-being.

A second domain for future work relates to the meta-theoretical stance that researchers adopt. As we have noted in this chapter, prior researchers have tended to adopt post-

positivist or constitutive (interpretivist, sociomaterial) meta-theoretical stances when studying distributed collaborations. To be sure, these bodies of research have contributed empirical knowledge that has built theory and contributed to practice. However, now perhaps more than ever, future research must embrace an array of critical perspectives to examine distributed collaborations, which have been underrepresented in this research domain.

Critical meta-theoretical perspectives (e.g., →Buzzanell 2010; →Cruz 2018; →Deetz 2006; →Dutta 2012; →Ganesh and Zoller 2012; →Mumby 2005) are themselves varied. These stances may include feminist perspectives, post-colonial and subaltern approaches, and others. Each of these approaches attend to various issues in their pursuit of emancipation and change from dominant or emergent ways of being and doing, issues such as power, participation, ideology, inclusion/exclusion, intersectionalities, erasures, and justice. Such approaches center issues of diversity, equity, inclusion, and justice (DEIJ).

Researchers embracing critical perspectives ask questions of social and organizing phenomena that must be asked and asked now. As distributed collaboration and remote work have become the new normal, we have a responsibility to pose questions emanating from critical meta-theoretical perspectives. These questions include: Whose voices dominate decision making when organizing and collaborative work becomes distributed? Which team members benefit from distributed collaborations and which ones do not, and in what ways? How do distribution and technologies affect participation and inclusion in collaborative processes? Are some voices silenced, and if so, how? How can we make distributed collaborations genuinely inclusive? How can we embrace tension and navigate conflict in ways that enable diverse perspectives to be heard? How can we do so in such a way that also motivates innovative processes and outcomes?

How does distributed collaboration contribute to (un)healthy organizing?

5 Conclusion

This chapter has reviewed the interdisciplinary literature on distributed collaboration by situating it in a historical context and tracking intellectual shifts over time, reviewing empirical research at individual, team, organizational, and inter-organizational levels of analysis, reviewing various epistemological perspectives, and highlighting the unique contributions of organizational communication scholarship. We concluded by outlining a future research agenda to stimulate further research in this area that incorporates two features of our current moment: a focus on remote work due to the Covid-19 pandemic, and a renewed focus on social justice that can be captured through embracing critical perspectives. We encourage organizational communication scholars to consider the research questions raised here and add new ones, as distributed collaboration will only become more prevalent in the future.

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Section V: Emerging Areas

Chapter 25 Wellness in the Workplace

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Abstract

This chapter focuses on communication about wellness in non-health-related organizations distinct from national or societal wellness campaigns. We review the history of wellness programs, and explore the communication literature on workplace wellness, which is informed by literature within and beyond the communication discipline. Wellness programs are increasingly popular, especially among larger employers. However, due to the variety of wellness programs, employee participation, and organizational settings, the effectiveness of wellness programs is difficult to study. Moreover, researchers have yet to document a return on investment or to show that wellness programs are effective in terms of biometric indicators. We argue that wellness in the workplace is not only a function of formal wellness programs but is also expressed in indirect wellness-related practices, like vacation policies, family leave, and concerns about work-life balance and self-care. We note the critical tension in wellness programs, which is expressed in the limits of employers' efforts, the limited extent of voluntary participation, and the rhetoric around wellness in the workplace.

Keywords: wellness, Healthy People 2030, health, workplace wellness programs, Family and Medical Leave Act, whole-person approach, work/life balance, self-care, culture of wellness, rhetoric of wellness, Talcott Parsons,

Americans spend approximately 42 years as active members of the workforce (→Ghilarducci 2021). The average life expectancy of a US citizen is 78.5 years, which suggests that more than half of every American's life will be spent at work (→CDC 2020). Although life expectancies differ given one's socioeconomic status, race, and occupation, the workplace is an important place to examine health, wellness, and the role of health communication. *Healthy People 2030*, a program of the US Department of Health and Human Services that sets national health goals and objectives, has set a goal to increase the proportion of worksites that offer employees physical activity, nutrition, and health promotion programs, by 2030 (→Office of Disease Prevention and Health Promotion, n.d.). Indeed, workplace health promotion, like employee assistance programs, is increasingly viewed as part of corporate social responsibility (→May 2016). Given the national concern for wellness in the workplace, in this chapter we (a) define the concept of wellness as it relates to the workplace, (b) discuss the role of formal wellness programs and informal wellness practices, and (c) provide recommendations for organizational communication scholars concerned about studying workplace wellness.

Most studies of health in the workplace concern non-communicable diseases (→Cahalin et al. 2015). These diseases, like diabetes, cancer, and heart disease, trace their immediate causes to personal behaviors such as diet or exercise. In the last four years, a communicable disease, COVID-19, has had the most salient effect on workplaces. Therefore, while we review workplace wellness initiatives as traditionally understood, concerning non-communicable diseases, we note the tension between individual health and workplace health, and in our conclusion return to the implications of COVID-19 on workplace health and workplace health initiatives.

This chapter focuses on wellness in non-health related organizations and distinct from national or societal wellness campaigns. Our concern is with wellness in workplaces or at worksites that do not otherwise have the benefit of medical or health expertise, like hospitals or clinics. We explore the communication literature on workplace wellness and include literature from beyond the discipline. We note that much of the literature in communication and beyond tends to be exhortatory. Additionally, many disciplines (e.g., public health, occupational safety, communication, psychology, economics, and sociology) publish about wellness in the workplace. For those reasons, the body of literature on the topic is vast. Therefore, we have been interdisciplinary in our choices but also selective in what we report in this chapter. Finally, as we will see, a critical tension in wellness programs exists between the arrangements developed by employers and individual workers' actual participation. This tension is expressed in the limits of employers' efforts, the extent of voluntary participation, the rhetoric around wellness in the workplace, and finally the role of communication in the workplace about wellness in general and formal wellness programs. To lay the groundwork for our examination of wellness, we first turn to definitions of wellness.

1 Defining Workplace Wellness

Scholars and reformers have studied the health and safety of workers since the dawn of the industrial revolution (→Gainer 2008). While *health* is sometimes understood as the absence of disease, *wellness* suggests the fulfillment of human potential: "An integrated method of functioning which is oriented toward maximizing the potential of which the individual is capable, within the environment in which [they] are functioning" (→Dunn 1959: 447). This definition implies that there is no optimal level of wellness or set standard for what a

well-person looks like. The definition encompasses a wide variety of workplace environments and employees' needs. Another frequently cited definition of wellness is "an active process through which people become aware of and make choices toward a more successful existence" (→Hettler 1984, as cited in →Oliver, Baldwin, and Datta 2018: 41). This definition suggests that wellness is a process in which *individuals* must first identify the areas of their life that are not ideal, and then work on improving those areas. →Harrison and Stephens (2019) also recognized the importance of the personal reality, experiences of work, and perceptions of wellness in the workplace. →Geist-Martin, Horsley, and Farrell (2003) advocated for a whole-person approach to wellness, which includes emotional, physical, and spiritual aspects of an individual. Thus, the wellness literature points toward a comprehensive vision of environmentally situated, multifaceted human potential, emphasizing the individual in the context of a workplace.

These definitions and approaches underscore important features of our understanding of wellness. The first is that wellness is a process with no endpoint, an ongoing evolution of an individual. Second, wellness involves personal choices, however, those choices are confounded by the systems and environments in which individuals live and work. This second feature of wellness points towards the idea that wellness is simultaneously understood as an individual problem and as an organizational responsibility to provide the necessary resources and policies that enable people to be well. Third, wellness is about self-realization and individual perception of what being well means and how it is achieved. Finally, wellness is more than just physical, but also involves an individual's sense of mental and spiritual health. These elements of wellness point towards a more subjective understanding, as "being well" can take on many forms. However, there are also more objective ways in which wellness is measured, for

example through Body Mass Index and blood pressure testing. Given both the subjective and objective ways in which wellness can manifest, and individual preferences in a social context, communication plays a crucial role in how wellness is enacted and understood. Through communication, formal wellness programs, to which we now turn, are launched and carried out in workplaces.

2 Formal Workplace Wellness Programs

Workplace wellness programs are "coordinated and comprehensive set[s] of health promotion and protection strategies implemented at the worksite that includes programs, policies, benefits, environmental supports, and links to the surrounding community designed to encourage the health and safety of all employees" (→CDC 2016: n.p.). National policies promote wellness generally, but workplaces are the sites where wellness activities are put into action through explicit and implicit communication.

Formal employee wellness programs are common in the United States, especially among large employers. →Mattke et al. (2015) estimated that about four fifths of all US employers with more than 1,000 employees offer wellness programs. Moreover, the number of workplaces offering wellness programs appears to be growing. →Linnan et al. (2019) reported that the percentage of employers with comprehensive programs responding to their survey rose from 6.9% in 2004 to 17.1% in 2017. Comprehensive workplace wellness programs included those that incorporated (1) health education, (2) a supportive social and physical work environment, (3) integration of the program into the organization's structure, (4) links to related programs such as employee assistance programs (EAPs), and (5) health screening with appropriate follow-ups and education (→Linnan et al. 2019). While these elements might be

regarded as a gold standard of formal workplace wellness programs, there is great variety in types of wellness programs in US workplaces.

Specific components of wellness programs correspond to individuals' health risks and may include nutrition and weight management, physical activity, diabetes (high blood glucose) management, tobacco cessation, stress management, clinical preventive screenings and biometric assessments, sleep hygiene, social connectedness, and alcohol management (Johns →Hopkins 2015). The success of these programs depends both on employees' willingness to participate, an individual-level variable, as well as organizational factors, including creating a culture of health, intertwining individual-level health promotion efforts with the overall company goals and objectives, and ensuring that both leadership and the workplace environment provide support for healthy choices (Johns →Hopkins 2015). Considering the legal requirements for voluntary and fair participation, which prohibits complete employer control over participation, it is apparent that well-developed and effective wellness programs require substantial resources and leadership commitment in addition to employees' willingness to participate.

While larger organizations possess the resources for well-developed programs, →Banks, Winslow, and Thibau (2018) found small and medium-sized organizations exhibited a range of programs that fell on a continuum of management investment from none to substantial commitment of resources and even the employment of health professionals. Their typology included eight types (external education programs, employee-driven community-building programs, organization-managed community building, preventative care involving an insurance vendor, healthy habit development using employer resources, healthy habit development using employer facilities, prevention programs, and specific disease management programs). The first two types, external

education and employee-driven community programs, do not include organizational leadership involvement other than making resources known (→Banks, Winslow, and Thibau 2018). The subsequent six types involve increasing management involvement and commitment of resources, from assigning an employee to coordinate resources, up through active engagement of leadership, efforts to build health promotion into the organizational culture, and direct disease management, including in-house medical clinics (→Banks, Winslow, and Thibau 2018).

→Banks, Winslow, and Thibau (2018) also identified facilitators and barriers to program success. Barriers mirrored facilitators, including leaving time for employees to participate, lack of knowledge dissemination, cost concerns, lack of dedicated leadership for a wellness program, and management distrust of workers motivations. Their review, particularly with respect to awareness, leadership, and trust, suggests that the success of wellness programs, even by some objective standards, is far from straightforward, and involves multiple lines and types of communication between management and employees. With more developed wellness programs, communication about their features and interaction around the topics of health also increases. This leads us to the question of the effectiveness of formal programs.

2.1 Impact of Formal Workplace Programs

Unfortunately, workplace wellness programs are not always effective. For example, in a multi-year randomized controlled clinical trial of over 4,000 employees at a large university, →Reif et al. (2020) found that employees invited to join a wellness program showed “no significant differences in biometrics, medical diagnoses, or medical use relative to the control group” (p. 960). Similarly, →Song and Baicker (2019),

in a study of 160 worksites and over 30,000 employees, reported an increase in individuals' self-reports of exercise and weight-managing efforts, but no differences between the treatment and control groups in either biometric outcomes or medical care consumption. →McHugh and Suggs (2012) found that an online weight management program had significant effects but in clinically undesirable directions. Thus, the presence of wellness programs is no guarantee of an increase in individuals' wellness.

Moreover, despite convincing evidence in support of the health benefits of prevention activities, generally worksite wellness programs do not deliver positive returns on investment within the first few years of initiation (→Baid, Hayles, and Finkelstein 2021). One problem in measuring effectiveness is the wide variety of programs, worksites, and durations measured in studies, making summary statements or aggregations difficult. In a meta-analysis of 48 US studies of worksite programs that focused on diet and adiposity (i.e., severe or morbid obesity), →Penalvo et al. (2017) found modest changes in fruit consumption, body mass, and waist circumference reduction, but these effects varied by the duration of the studies and design biases. Similarly, →Murphy et al. (2022) found mixed results in a meta-analysis of randomized controlled trials of workplace weight loss programs aimed at reducing stress-induced overeating. Their study is instructive with respect to the complexity of sorting individual and workplace effects. They reported finding no observable association between psychological stress reduction and food choice or weight management, although mid-length interventions (six-to-nine months, as opposed to shorter or longer periods) were associated with weight and stress reduction. Once again, the distinction between employers' investments in programs and individuals' participation makes analysis and predictions of effectiveness very difficult.

Indeed, employee participation in programs varies widely. A review of multiple studies in the Netherlands showed participation ranged from 33% to 64% (→Robroek et al. 2009). →Stephens and Harrison (2017) suggested that in addition to the wide variety of program objectives and methods, and the need to tailor messages to diverse populations, employees may fear that participation in programs or sharing health information may overtly or covertly threaten their employment status. However, workplace wellness programs are also the formal manifestation of elements of an organization's culture, which includes informal, unwritten practices, or practices not directly related to formal wellness activities.

3 Indirect Wellness Practices

In many organizations, management and supervisors are the boots on the ground who work closely with the largest number of employees. How these individuals choose to lead not only affects business outcomes but also largely contributes to the culture of wellness in the workplace (→Aldana et al. 2012; →Kaspin, Gorman, and Miller 2013). From a traditional top-down approach, management is responsible for conveying and promoting certain attitudes and behaviors including those related to health and wellness among their workforces. These attitudes are often cultivated by individuals who work above management, making investment and policy decisions, so it generates a "trickle down" type approach to business operations. So, if a company promotes wellness as important to its workforce, the employees could be inclined to engage in wellness-oriented behaviors, for example, taking personal days for preventative care appointments or taking maternity and paternity leave. Thus, communication and the rhetoric in an organization contribute to the success of what we refer to as *indirect*

wellness practices in the workplace. These include other formal polices related to wellness as well as unspoken rules about wellness.

3.1 Formal Policies with Unspoken Rules

Generally, upper management is responsible for the investment decisions that may contribute to wellness, like the formal wellness programs discussed above, but also vacation time, sick days, employee assistance programs, and child and family leave policies. However, as we have seen with respect to formal wellness programs, just because a policy exists does not mean that the employees will use it. Many employees recognize that there are unspoken rules surrounding these kinds of policies and that there is company etiquette when it comes to the use of such benefits. In the following sections, we review unspoken phenomena surrounding vacation time, sick time, and child and family leave policies.

3.1.1 Vacation Policy

Vacation is thought by many to be a time to relax, unwind, and de-stress from the everyday rush of employment. However, more than half of Americans do not use all their available vacation time (→Fottrell 2017). Research suggests that company culture and informal practices (i.e., not formal policies) are one of the main reasons that people do not take all their time off. Further, employees tend to take vacation days in short periods instead of all at once, using vacation time to run errands or take long weekends (→Torres, Yost, and Ronzoni 2021). Employees report a fear of being replaced or feeling guilty for being gone for long periods of time. Employees often perceive their use of vacation time as a violation of company norms (→Tan and Li 2021). Another reason employees avoid taking vacation time is because of the

excess work that they must return to when their vacation is over. Employees who were given resources (i.e., someone to take over their responsibilities while away) did not experience this increased workload upon return and the effects of their vacation lasted a longer period of time (→Fritz and Sonnentag 2006). Overall, this suggests that regardless of formal policy, company culture is what dictates use of vacation time.

3.1.2 *Sick Leave*

In the US, paid sick time is not governed by federal law. It is up to state, local, and company discretion or union agreements whether to supply paid sick time to individuals (→Susser and Ziebarth 2016). Some have argued that the lack of paid sick time in the US is an issue of economics, public health, and equity (→Hanson, Kemp, and Leggett 2021). Research shows that employees who do not have paid sick time fear the economic losses of taking a day off and will come to work even when they are ill (→DeRigne et al. 2019). These actions increase the spread of seasonal influenza and other communicable diseases in workplaces, which raises questions of equity. Blue-collar jobs or jobs that pay around the minimum wage are more likely to not have paid sick leave (→DeRigne et al. 2019). Workers without paid sick time are less likely to receive preventative medicine than those with paid sick leave, which increases health disparities (→DeRigne et al. 2017). This contributes to health and wellness in the workplace and beyond. In 2020, during the COVID-19 pandemic, a temporary national paid sick leave policy was enacted to reduce the transmission of COVID-19, but there were loopholes in the policy. Olive Garden, a national restaurant chain, implemented its own paid sick leave, and it showed a significant decrease in COVID-19 cases and also increased employee wellbeing (→Schneider, Harknett, and Vivas-Portillo 2021). See below for a more developed

discussion of the effects of the pandemic on wellness in the workplace.

3.1.3 *Family Leave*

The Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA) of 1993 established that employers meeting certain criteria must offer 12 weeks of unpaid leave with job security to employees who have recently had a child, adopted a child, are fostering a child, are facing serious medical problems, or need to care for a family member (e.g., aging parents; →Donovan 2019; →Mayer 2013). However, a reported 40% of the US workforce does not meet the requirements for FMLA and thus the law fails to provide them job security in times of family-related illnesses (→Montez, Thomson, and Shabo 2020). Further, many individuals cannot afford to take unpaid leave for 12 weeks. This particularly affects those who are independent contractors, new employees, or those employed at small businesses (i.e., under 50 employees). Thus, the wellness that might come with this benefit is unavailable to a large segment of the workforce.

Most other developed countries offer *paid* family leave policies that allow employees to balance family activities with their jobs (→Rossin-Slater 2017). Paid family leave policies result in more positive health outcomes for both parents and their children (→Bullinger 2019; →Chung et al. 2007; →Hamad, Modrek, and White 2019; →Khan 2020). Additionally, paid family leave policies are beneficial to company wellbeing and ultimately, economic prosperity and growth (→Rowe-Finkbeiner et al. 2016). For example, women who are offered job security through government and company leave policies are more likely to return to the workforce after their leave is over than those who are not offered such leave (→Schott 2012). This ostensibly saves organizations the recruitment and startup costs associated with new hires.

Beyond government and corporate formal policies, there remain unspoken rules or problems with paid family leave. Men who take family leave are stigmatized and face pressures to return to work sooner than what may be beneficial for their families (→Prohaska and Zipp 2011; →Rudman and Mescher 2013). →Wayne and Cordeiro (2003) found that men who took leave to care for an elderly family member or a new child were viewed as caring less about their jobs than their female counterparts, and other men rated these men particularly harshly. Communication scholarship has also demonstrated that family leave constitutes gendered conflict interaction for female workers and their bosses (→Buzzanell and Liu 2007) and can be problematic for women workers (→Lucas and Buzzanell 2006; →Meisenbach et al. 2008). In addition to the unspoken or informal rules surrounding time off and family leave, there is also the day-to-day promotion of work/life balance and self-care, which represent an additional indirect wellness practice.

3.2 Work/Life Balance and Self-Care

Communication research on work/life balance suggests that the main beneficiaries of individuals living a “balanced” life are their families (→Golden, Kirby, and Jorgenson 2006; →Kirby et al. 2003). Balance refers to an equilibrium, however, what constitutes equilibrium is highly dependent on the individual and their attitudes and perceptions towards their work (e.g., job satisfaction, job identification; →Botero 2013). Once again, we notice the role of the individual in their own wellness. However, employers also have a role to play in the work/life balance of individuals. →Hoffman and Cowan (2008) conducted a rhetorical analysis of the 2004 list of “Fortune’s 100 best companies to work for” websites to determine what corporations are promoting as their idea of work/life balance. They discovered that the corporate ideology of work/life

balance is made up of four components: “1. Work is the most important element of life; 2. life means family; 3. individuals are responsible for managing the relationship between paid work and the rest of life; and 4. organizations control work/life programs” (→Hoffman and Cowan 2008: 233–234). These findings point toward the idea that employers control the ability of employees to achieve work/life balance and that they, the employers, get to decide what work/life balance looks like. Research has demonstrated that it would behoove employers to communicate with their employees regarding work/life balance needs as it increases satisfaction and in turn, reduces turnover in the organization (→Abdien 2019). So, in this regard, the individual responsibility in wellness is not as salient when it comes to achieving a work/life balance given the control the employer has.

There is, nonetheless, a growing notion that individuals should engage in the practice of self-care to combat the stressors of everyday work and life. Self-care can include a wide range of activities, with the goal being to improve one’s own wellbeing (→Barnett and Cooper 2009). →Barnett, Johnston, and Hillard (2006) say “self-care is not an indulgence. It is an essential component of prevention of distress, burnout, and impairment. It should not be considered as something ‘extra’ or ‘nice to do if you have the time’” (p. 263). Mindfulness is one type of self-care and has been demonstrated to significantly decrease worker stress following an 8-week intervention that taught employees how to engage in mindfulness as a self-care practice (→McGarrigle and Walsh 2011). However, what constitutes self-care is based on the preferences of the individual. For example, a study conducted with Finnish men found that self-care could include rest, exercise, or engaging in hobbies (→Hyvönen 2020). Further, the men reported that self-care is something that they do for their own benefit and not for the benefit of their employer, which reflects a shift towards the importance of

self-care. The wider cultural movement toward self-care, like the movement toward wellness, is endorsed by wellness advocates who argue that the success of wellness programs depends on creating a culture of wellness, to which we now turn.

4 Creating a Culture of Wellness

A *culture of wellness* (→Reed 1981) is created through both formal (i.e., wellness programs) and informal (i.e., policies with unspoken rules and self-care) communication, and ultimately is dependent upon the communication or rhetoric within the workplace. Because rhetoric in the workplace exists alongside activities in the workplace, we describe below both the normative meaning of a culture of wellness developed by advocates of wellness in the workplace, as well as rhetorical criticism of the culture of wellness.

4.1 Advocacy for a Culture of Wellness

The contemporary focus on a culture of wellness in workplaces might be traced to the so-called fitness craze of the 1970s and early 1980s (→Reed 1981). →Stein (1982) pointed out the tension between individuals' desire for health and the spreading of cultural values that promoted new standards of health and fitness. In one of the first uses of *culture* related to workplace wellness programs, →Stange et al. (1991) pondered whether racial differences in participation in a workplace wellness program might be overcome by creating a "culture of wellness" (p. 477). As narratives around wellness took on a more salient role in the wider society, and as management scholars observed the importance of organizational culture, the culture of wellness entered the lexicon of those who promoted wellness in the workplace (→Allen and Allen 1986). By the early 2000s researchers

expressed confidence that the “implementation of comprehensive health protection and promotion activities can lead to a culture of health in the workplace” (→Hymel et al. 2011: 699). Today, the culture of wellness as a key to the success of wellness programs is well established in the workplace health promotion literature (→Dailey, Burke, and Carberry 2018). However, the rhetoric around wellness programs is not without its detractors.

4.2 Rhetorical Criticism of the Culture of Wellness

The rhetoric of wellness recognizes that particularly in organized settings wellness may be promoted for symbolic as well as substantive purposes. Critical and rhetorical studies point to contradictions and problematics in the wellness movement. To promote wellness is to signal to current and prospective employees that an organization has adopted policies that give it legitimacy. →Dale and Burrell (2014) pointed out that a key aspect of the wellness social movement is its foci on organized (as distinct from individual or governmental) behavior. They highlighted the tensions between the wellness movement’s goal of a healthy worker and unhealthy job requirements that led to overwork, injury, accidents, disability, or addiction. Indeed, they argued that wellness ironically depends on the persistence of unwellness in work. The forms of unwellness that critics point out include the embodied nature of work, the emotional cost of work, and an emphasis on wellness as an individual’s responsibility toward an organization. Focusing on the tension between an organization’s needs and individual wellness, →Moore (2021) reported on the use of technology (Fitbits and self-report logs) by management to quantitatively monitor workers’ wellbeing, productivity, and affect. She connected this practice to the development of the “quantified self, a self that would otherwise not be knowable except with the help of new

technologies that aid in biometric and physiological analysis" (p. 228). Her study found that in the interest of a more agile, measurable workplace, management tracked stress, subjective productivity, wellbeing, physical movement, heart rate, and sleep. Such practices may constitute the leading edge of the comprehensive incorporation and quantification of wellbeing as well as "'wellbilling' (the amount of revenue an employee generates for the company)" (→Moore 2021: 238–239).

→McGillivray (2005) studied the discourses of organizational wellness as "the language and practices which institutionalized workplace health promotion programs and organizational settings" (p. 126). Following Foucault, McGillivray suggested that workplace wellness programs are about the appropriation of workers' bodies using quasi-medical logic to construct healthy workplaces. His work echoes →Trethewey's (1999) observation that "the professional body is also a body of an individual who is self-motivated, responsible, willing and able to work" (p. 423). Therefore, wellness advocates stress the importance of integrating wellness into organizations' cultures, while critics point out that the culture of wellness may be a symbolic ploy simply to advance management interests. We would point out that given the modest success of wellness programs in measurably promoting health or demonstrating returns on investments, the symbolic role of wellness in the workplace is a communicative phenomenon worthy of further investigation. This brings us to a brief review of the content of communication research concerning workplace wellness.

5 Taking Stock: Communication Research and Wellness Programs

The forgoing discussion demonstrates that organizational communication plays a multifaceted role in workplace

wellness and formal wellness programs and campaigns. →Harrison and Williams (2015) demonstrated the many ways beyond structured wellness programs that health and organizational communication intersect. The presence or absence of communication about wellness, even in informal terms, can undermine or promote workplace health. As →Farrell and Geist-Martin (2005) pointed out, work-related conditions and stress contribute to a lack of wellness or what they called “not working well” (p. 545). As we have seen, communication also plays a role in formal worksite health promotion efforts. Studies of wellness in the workplace are familiar to communication scholars, from the point of view of both advocacy (→James and Zoller 2018; →Martin 2021) and analysis (→Geist-Martin and Scarduzio 2011; →Wilhoit 2016). For example, →Scarduzio and Geist-Martin (2016) developed a whole-person approach to the idea of wellness in organizations. →Stephens et al. (2015) researched organizational identification and information sharing to promote the dissemination of heart-healthy efforts. →Clubbs, Gray, and Madlock (2021) applied the theory of planned behavior to analyze and support employees’ use of fitness trackers. Communication scholarship has also focused on workplace behaviors that contribute to wellness, such as bullying (→Tracy, Lutgen-Sandvik, and Alberts 2006) and burnout (→Tracy 2009).

In addition, communication scholars have also recognized the tension between what is healthy for individuals and what is healthy for organizations. This issue strikes at the core of what we mean by the organization – a social form that has an existence independent of the individuals who compose it. →Geist-Martin, Horsley, and Farrell (2003) reviewed individual versus collective wellness initiatives. →Ford and Scheinfeld (2016) identified cultural, privacy, confidentiality, and ethical boundary violations in workplace health promotions. Similarly, →Zoller (2003) documented employees’ concerns about

workplace health promotion. Her work showed that workplace health promotion initiatives not only differ greatly across employers but are also viewed differently within the workplace by individual workers. However, communication research on workplace wellness, like a lot of scholarship, was disrupted by the advent of the world-wide COVID-19 pandemic. We now turn to wellness in this new context.

6 Wellness in the New Context: COVID-19 and Working from Home

As of the winter of 2022, the global COVID-19 pandemic has interrupted virtually every organization's formal and informal activities. This chapter would be remiss if we did not discuss the effects of COVID-19 on the workplace and the role that working from home plays on wellness. Workplace wellness programs tend to focus on non-communicable diseases, which account for the greatest amount of death and disease around the world (→World Health Organization 2013). The pandemic has highlighted the contrast between individuals' autonomy and their interests, and the collective interests or at least private collective interests of organizations. Because the pandemic has touched every aspect of work, communication scholars have their hands full. While remote work is not exactly new, the pandemic has forced people to work from home (→McGloin et al. 2022). Under this pressure, workers have experienced threats to their psychological safety and organizations have faced challenges in their support of workers (→Lee 2021). Not only have workplace wellness programs been disrupted, but the pandemic has also created new sources of stress for workers (→Fu et al. 2021). In addition, this disruption has raised questions about ethics (→Neill and Bowen 2021) and justice (→Thornton-Lugo and Rupp 2021) in management and work. Under these circumstances, workers have fallen back on their own

resources to manage their wellness: “I’ve been remaking sense out of my work time […] finding a healthy personal wellness routine is also important” (→Stephens et al. 2020: 436). Thus, the very nature of the workplace itself is in flux, and the sites of wellness and wellness activities are also changing.

Under these circumstances, workplace wellness definitions must be adapted to the multi-location, electronically mediated, and virtual workplace (→Anderson et al. 2022). Wellness – that is, an individual’s physical, emotional, and psychological wellbeing – and its tangential constructs, such as ethics, justice, bullying, or stress, need to be reconceptualized. This also means that other activities and policies we have discussed, such as sick and family leave or vacation policies, will also be reassessed.

7 The Future of Organizational Communication and Wellness Programs

This review has shown that although workplace wellness programs are widespread, especially among larger employers, their clinical and cost effectiveness are questionable. Moreover, the lack of national standards makes comparison across programs difficult. One could argue that while wellness programs are widespread, they are nonetheless weakly institutionalized (→Lammers 2011). While there is no doubt that well-managed campaigns require close attention to communication channels and employee input, many of the claims about wellness programs’ success remain unsubstantiated. This leaves room for the rhetorical criticism that the claims of employers are aimed at convincing publics of their legitimacy rather than accurately portraying outcomes. Finally, throughout the history of formal wellness programs, the nagging question of worker participation remains. This issue is even more important now that the very

definition of the workplace has been called into question with the advent of COVID-19.

We have seen that wellness in the workplace is part of a broader cultural trend toward concerns with fitness and health. Ironically this contrasts with an epidemic of obesity that currently blankets the US (→Kwak, McMillan, and McDonald 2021). So, while many people worry about fitness and wellness, and companies and organizations attempt to respond to workers' concerns about wellness, there are countervailing pressures toward higher levels of obesity-borne diseases. Communication scholarship under these circumstances needs to include not only the messages and channels associated with the promotion of wellness campaigns, but perhaps the more subtle messages and channels associated with poor health. Seventy years ago, →Parsons (1951) delineated the *sick role* as part of a functional analysis of organizations and society. We might well study instead the *well role* to understand both what individuals want for their lives and what organizations need to be effective. Communication scholars should pay more attention to the evolving nature of wellness given the change in what many "workplaces" look like. More research is needed on how specifically these cultures of wellness are created. What are people saying and doing that is really creating or not creating cultures of wellness or sickness? Communication scholarship can also tease apart the role of the *well individual* versus the role of the *well organization*. It is probably naive to think that they are coterminous. This is even more important in the age of the viral pandemic where the line between work and life is blurred or even erased.

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Chapter 26 Organizing Social Change

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Abstract

Organizational communication scholars have developed explanations and insights into the role of communication in accomplishing a variety of purposes. Our chapter is designed to sketch the contours of organizational communication when it is taken up specifically for the purpose of social change. Social change requires the ability to disrupt “settled” ways of thinking and talking to create new understandings and ways of working for systemic change. Since social change organizing seeks to challenge the status quo and existing power relations that routinely favor certain groups over others, it almost always meets with passive, active, and/or hidden forms of resistance. We reconceptualize repeated conflicts between dominant and marginalized groups as a process of struggle and organizing social change as a way to equalize the dynamics of power and resistance between groups. Although many organizational communicative practices contribute to organizing the struggle for social change, we highlight, in particular, the importance of (re)framing realities, mobilizing membership, developing relationships, and telling stories. We conclude with a case to exemplify the contending use of these practices in the struggle for social change around race, equity, and inclusion in education.

Keywords: agonistics, counterframing, counternarratives, counterorganizing, destructive struggle, (re)framing, loving struggle, mobilizing, organizational forms, organizing social

change, relational development, resentful struggle, storytelling, struggle,

1 Organizing Social Change

Whether seeking economic, social, or environmental justice, social change requires the ability to disrupt “settled” ways of thinking and talking to create new understandings and ways of working for systemic change. While courageous individuals are often first to point out injustices and the need for change, working toward (and managing resistance to) social change also entails inspiring others to join them and coordinating their collective efforts over time. We examine how individuals organize for social change, not only in terms of organizational forms but centering on how social change is predicated on struggle, and highlighting *the communicative work* of organizing social change. We close with a case to exemplify the struggle of social change.

2 Organizing Social Change: Definitions and Organizational Forms

Multiple descriptions of “organizing social change” exist. In their foundational set of studies, →Papa, Singhal, and Papa (2006) explain it as “a process through which a group of individuals orchestrate their skills, resources and human potential to gain control of their future” (p. 31); one that produces four central tensions: (a) control|emancipation, (b) oppression|empowerment, (c) dissemination|dialogue, and (d) fragmentation|unity. →Dutta (2011) discusses the role of organizations in his cultural approach to social change by emphasizing “the communicative processes involved in the formation of the collective, the crafting of a collective identity, and the development of infrastructures, capacities, and resources to meet the needs of the collective” (p. 223).

Sociologist →Lofland (2017) explicitly theorizes organizations as expressions of social movements or:

> [A]ssociations of persons making idealistic and moralistic claims about how human personal or group life ought to be organized that, at the time of their claims-making, are marginal to or excluded from mainstream society – the then dominant constructions of what is real, realistic, and moral. (pp. 2–3)

Taken together, these definitions highlight the importance of social change organizing as a way to amplify citizens voices to strengthen communities (Ledwith and →Springett 2010) and provide pathways for civic activism to help actualize the ideals of democratic societies (→Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018).

Furthermore, social change organizing needs to be distinguished from organizing to provide social services. Just because an organization is "serving" vulnerable community members does not mean it is organizing for social change – indeed, some social service organizations actually preserve the status quo by operating in ways that sustain a demand/need for their services. This means separating *social justice efforts* to remove root causes of inequity and improving structures, from *services/charitable works* that aid individuals by meeting basic needs. Maintaining a distinction between the two is important because it draws attention to how social change organizing produces and engages conflict with powerful entities seeking to maintain the status quo. The work of social change organizations, then, aligns with an agonistic view of politics (→Mouffe 2013) and an agonistic approach to dialogue – both of which foreground conflict as integral to social change (→Ganesh and Zoller 2012).

2.1 Organizational Forms and Social Change

Experienced organizers argue there needs to be a model guiding social change organizing: "There is always a model. If

you don’t create it, it evolves on its own, often influenced by funding” (→Bobo, Kendall, and Max 2010: 68). Committing to a model/form that best aligns with the organization’s purpose helps manage “mission drift” and can strengthen an organization to withstand attempts by opposing groups to undermine and weaken their existence (e.g., →Bean and Buikema 2015). Such decisions should be based on the range of options currently available, recognizing that potential members have many alternatives for participating in collective action without formal organizational membership (→Bimber, Flanagin, and Stohl 2012; →Wilhoit and Kisselburgh 2015). Because social change organizing seeks to develop and amplify citizen voices, the organizational design should facilitate communication and the development of relationships and leaders.

The design of an organization can range from formal to informal, and may combine elements of both. For example, (formally) maintaining status as a 501(3)c (nonprofit) requires creating bylaws regarding rules, procedures for governing meetings, and selecting board members. Nonprofits commit to following specific state and federal (Internal Revenue Service) laws and requirements to maintain tax-exempt status. The specification of status differences between officers and members and the restriction of activities can create barriers to relational and leadership development. In addition, the dependence on external fund-raising creates tensions of accountability that can contribute to mission drift.

Informal, self-funded models offer an alternative and freedom from many of these restrictions. In his study of Assisi House, an anarchist-run homeless shelter, →Jensen (2017) illustrates how a “personalist” model guides decisions rather than a more bureaucratic rule-based model. As another example, the Infoshop model of organizing involves creating an alternative, radical space to explore current realities and the need for change (→Atton 1999). These organizations

purposefully self-fund, make resources available (e.g., library, copier/printer, supplies), and create an environment of learning and camaraderie. In Lincoln, Nebraska, Black Cat House relies on activities such as yard sales to self-fund. They are headquartered in an actual house that serves as an informal food bank, lending library, and place to view/discuss films in order to develop shared understandings of current events. Black Cat House resources then provide opportunities for members to educate themselves and the broader community about oppressive power structures (→Adams 2020). Aligned with anarchist principles, the Infoshop model offers the promise of a hierarchy-free organizational space (→Atton 1999).

Organizational communication scholars have also drawn attention to hybrid models of organizing that manage to create space for meaningful participation and the development of relationships and voice within more formal, bureaucratic structures (e.g., →Harter et al. 2008). →Ozkula (2021) illustrates how forms may need to adapt over time; she ethnographically describes how Amnesty International internally (re)organized based on external pressures to move toward "a flexible, decentralized, and hierarchically flatter social media activism culture" (p. 1984). And →Mitra and Fyke (2017) detail the actions of "purpose-driven", for-profit consultancy firms mobilized by their clients (i.e. corporations, nonprofits, and government agencies) to implement social change programs.

Thus, while there is no ideal organizational form for social change, intentionality should be used in choosing from the wide variety of possibilities. In addition to considering organizational forms, we must also articulate organizing for social change as an activity. →De Bakker, den Hond, and Laamanen (2017) illustrate how organizing includes the process-oriented, time-varying nature of member behaviors, emphasizing how *organizing behaviors* may come before

organization, and that indeed a formal "organization" may never emerge (e.g., Occupy Wall Street, the Kony movement). Whatever form it takes, social change organizing emerges as a struggle for voice and participation by (or on behalf of) members of oppressed groups.

3 Organizing Social Change: Power, Resistance, and Struggle

Because organizing social change challenges the status quo and structural "isms", it cannot be seen outside of power relations and discourses of resistance that transgress, subvert, and/or rebel against dominant realities (→Ott 2011). Ways of resisting and organizing social change have morphed and shifted in the 21st century. Dramatic stories have been written about viral engagements such as the occupation of Tahrir Square in Egypt, Black Lives Matter, #MeToo, and the Susan G. Komen Foundation's decision to stop funding Planned Parenthood. Furthermore, recent forms of protest have emerged that conventional organizational frameworks fail to fully address, such as protests around World Trade Organization meetings and the mobilizations inspired by Occupy, which are "more generalized expressions of dissatisfaction with the prevailing (neo-liberal) economic order and attempts at showing that alternatives are possible" (→de Bakker, den Hond, and Laamanen 2017: 208).

Processes of questioning power relationships lead to a greater critical awareness of the root sources of social issues: What is happening here? Why is it happening? In whose interests? (Ledwith and →Springett 2010). In communication studies, →Deetz's (1992) work on who gets authentic voice, and who can genuinely participate is instructive, as marginalization is a function of not being able to participate. This does not mean that people from dominant groups cannot organize for social change alongside people from oppressed

groups, but it does mean they need to consider the impacts of their own identity and its power dimensions (Ledwith and →Springett 2010).

Since social change implies a struggle between marginalized and dominant groups – and between what is and what could be – there will likely be a response from those who resist change. In the words of Frederick →Douglass ([1857] 1985), "If there is no struggle there is no progress [...] Power concedes nothing without a demand. It never did and it never will" (p. 204). Organizing social change almost always meets with passive, active, and/or hidden forms of resistance. Passive resistance is loosely organized around shared and unexamined assumptions about how life should be (e.g., the wealthy deserve better access to health care, education, and housing; generalized feelings of White fragility) and ignorance of, tolerance for – or indifference to – the suffering of others. Active resistance is highly organized and often involves direct conflict with social change organizations (e.g., National Rifle Association vs. March for Our Lives). And some forms of resistance are more "hidden" as the groups do not want people to know they are organizing resistance. Whether handling direct conflict, or attempting to disrupt passive or hidden resistance, social change organizing requires the ability to create and work well with enduring conflicts.

Struggle is a way to reframe repeated conflicts over issues that are rarely easily resolved or settled once and for all. Even when a community handles a particular conflict well at a single point in time, the same conflict can arise later. Consequently, seeking social justice involves struggle/organizing struggle. Struggle involves the capacity for opposing groups to exercise both power and resistance where the use of power by one group provokes resistance on the part of an opposing group which itself is an expression of power. →Fleming and Spicer (2007) offer the concept of struggle as a way to acknowledge the relationship between power and resistance that lies at the

heart of all political change. Importantly, struggle is more than a destructive process. They note Simmel's emphasis on how struggle gives actors a sense of agency, strengthening the belief that they can make a difference. Struggle also is inherently social as members of opposing groups unite among themselves to fight and even engage each other in social interaction. Struggle shapes not just how actors come to understand themselves and each other, but also may deepen social relations between actors, even with those they may be struggling with. The creative potential of struggle is realized with the creation of new identities, new ways of life, and even new institutions (e.g., trade unions, political parties, movements). Importantly, "At the heart of the creative dynamics of struggle is communication" (→Fleming and Spicer 2007: 55).

This acknowledgment of communication begets a discursive perspective: a struggle between discourses that compete to define aspects of the social world, often seeking to legitimize one perspective, action, or discourse – and simultaneously delegitimize another (e.g., →Jørgensen and Phillips 2002). Some communicative practices involved in discursive struggle are recognizing and engaging competing frames (see (re)framing realities). Indeed, those who resist social change often deploy the language of democracy to undermine democracy and its promise of social equality. Communication skills are required to recognize and confront discursive closure, as well to create discursive openings (→Deetz 1992). The organization No Left Turn in Education (NLTE) exemplifies discursive struggle. They hope to have a chapter in every state to "restor[e] parental function in public education and elevate the family as a core teaching unit of society" (n.d.). NLTE deploys slogans like "Education NØT Indoctrination" and "MLK not BLM", and even has a list of Critical Race Theory (CRT) Code Words to prepare people to protest at local school board meetings:

- Equitable: “a euphemism for the Marxist goal of equality of outcome”
- Representation and Inclusion: “silenc[ing] ‘white’ or ‘white adjacent’ voices and utilizing quotas to meet goals instead of merit”
- Systemic Racism: “the existence of discrimination by design in every area of life”
- White Privilege: “labels all whites as privileged despite life circumstances that show otherwise”

In this struggle, there are clear differences in how opposing sides define terms like inclusion; NLTE is “correcting” what these terms mean and suggesting those who believe tenets of anti-racism do not know what they are talking about. They are “qualifying” members to feel powerful enough to speak with expertise on these subjects when confronting school authorities. Using these (reframed) definitions at a school board meeting could definitely create discursive closure through disqualifying other definitions.

Struggle is “an ongoing, live, tense and overwhelmingly social process” (→Fleming and Spicer 2007: 61). Because it involves back and forth patterns of interaction between groups, it is important to attend to cycles of interaction that arise over time. Struggles between opposing groups can become destructive, resentful, or loving, but only loving struggle produces meaningful change (→Jaspers [1932] 1970). With destructive struggle, opposing actors seek to destroy each other and make the other side give up, which reinforces pre-existing power inequalities and can make the sides even more resistant to change. Differences between contending parties intensify, nothing new is learned, and how the parties understand each other remains the same. Destructive struggle draws attention to an issue, but rarely creates meaningful change by itself. With resentful struggle, less powerful actors display their unhappiness at being dominated. They may quietly express dissatisfaction or resist

the current power relationship by dragging their feet or appearing to play along, while the opposing side plays along by making small concessions without addressing the root causes of a problem.

In contrast, loving struggle affirms each other's right to exist while also calling each other into question: struggling *with* someone rather than against them. This requires a willingness among opposing sides to communicate in ways that recognize differences in life experiences and how power relations have shaped these (→Ganesh and Zoller 2012). Engaging loving struggle, then, has the potential to create new understandings of ourselves, each other, and of concerns larger than ourselves. For example, following sustained protests over the murder of George Floyd, the Clyde Malone Community Center hosted meetings between leaders from local civil rights groups and the Lincoln Police Department to address questions of police brutality. The police department committed to revising their policy on the use of force in making arrests. While these encounters can be highly emotional, over time loving struggle eventually frees participants from the emotions of resentment and hatred, and creates fresh ways to conceptualize and approach systemic social change. Organizations can fulfill their social change purposes by disrupting destructive and resentful struggle and creating conditions where loving struggle becomes possible. This includes preparing members for the kinds of communication needed to initiate and sustain conflict between opposing groups.

4 Organizing Social Change: Communicative Practices

Numerous communicative practices contribute to organizing for social change. In this review, we expand on (a) (re)framing realities, (b) mobilizing membership, (c) developing

relationships, and (d) telling stories. Certainly, this separation is for illustrative purposes and additional processes are at work: →Servaes (2016) reviews multiple communication strategies for development and social change, noting that while communication strategies and tips can be offered, social change can only be achieved:

> in combination with and incorporating aspects of the wider environment [...] includ[ing]: structural and conjunctural factors (e.g., history, migration, conflicts), policy and legislation, service provision, education systems, institutional and organizational factors (e.g., bureaucracy, corruption), cultural factors (e.g., religion, norms, and values), sociodemographic factors (e.g., ethnicity, class), sociopolitical factors, socioeconomic factors, and the physical environment. (p. 704)

4.1 (Re)Framing Realities

(Re)framing realities is central to organizing social change. Social change organizations provide leadership for reframing a marginal or excluded ("out") reality to a dominant ("in") reality. For example, "past in|present out" realties include racism and ableism, and "past out|present in" realities include LGBTQ+ acceptance and gender equality (see →Lofland 2017). Yet activists "are not able to construct and impose on their intended targets any version of reality they would like" (→Benford and Snow 2000: 625). Instead, they must work to reframe realities in ways that illustrate the partiality of dominant frames and make social change seem possible. The importance of (re)framing to social change has been addressed by sociologists and communication/rhetorical scholars.

Benford and Snow's foundational work on *framing theory* illustrated how collective action frames can "mobilize potential adherents and constituents, garner bystander support, and demobilize antagonists" (→Snow and Benford 1988: 198). There are three core tasks of framing (see review in →Benford and Snow 2000). *Diagnostic framing* involves negotiating a

shared understanding of some problematic condition/situation that is defined as in need of change (often using “injustice” frames) alongside making attributions regarding who or what is to blame. *Prognostic framing* involves the articulation of a proposed solution to the problem, or at least a plan of attack, and the strategies for carrying out the plan while taking into account oppositional framing activity. *Motivational framing* urges others to join the effort to effect change and engage in collective action.

The discursive processes of frame articulation and frame amplification|punctuation are (explicitly) communicative. Frame articulation “involves the connection and alignment of events and experiences [...] the manner in which they are spliced together and articulated, [is] such that a new angle of vision, vantage point, and/or interpretation is provided” (→Benford and Snow 2000: 623). The frame amplification process involves the idealization, embellishment, clarification, or invigoration of existing values or beliefs; some issues are accepted more than others to provide a “conceptual handle” for bringing things together via movement slogans such as *Homeless, Not Helpless*. Other communicative strategies to achieve social change are (a) bridging frames to link two more ideologically congruent but structurally unconnected frames, (b) extending frames beyond primary interests to include issues presumed to be of importance to potential adherents, and (c) transforming frames to change old understandings and meanings and/or generating new ones (→Benford and Snow 2000).

Importantly, →Brummans et al. (2008) argue that these sociological views imply that language represents cognitive frames rather than recognizing that framing is “part and parcel of ongoing mundane interactions” (p. 27) and advocate looking at everyday practices. In rhetorical social movement studies, →Peeples (2011) described how articulation “creates the parameters and identity of the group by establishing who

it is and who it isn't, what it believes and what it eschews" (p. 251), and notes that once successful, the articulation begins to be *appropriated* in rhetoric of other like-minded or oppositional groups.

Studies that illustrate the importance of (re)framing realities (or counterframing) include →Harter et al.'s (2008) illustration of how Passion Works "questions taken-for-granted scripts by [re]position[ing] disability as a source of lived difference to be acknowledged and affirmed – not sequestered or managed" (p. 441). In their study of intractable multi-party conflicts surrounding environmental disputes, →Brummans et al. (2008) found four different framing repertoires that disputants drew upon that people utilized to characterize their conflict(s), which they labeled "stories of" (a) victimhood, (b) dispassion, (c) optimism and hope, and (d) power and powerlessness. →Xiong, Cho, and Boatwright (2019) identified emergent frames associated with hashtags used concurrently during the first two months of the #MeToo movement to illustrate how social movement organizations and publics *co-create* words, meaning, and hashtag frames to achieve their shared goals. →Peeples (2011) explores how the frame "downwinders" expanded from its initial association with nuclear contamination (who was downwind from the site) to utilization in other environmental/toxin controversies and how these appropriations used it to create meaning for the three elements of toxin controversies: location, victims, and contaminants.

Framing and counterframing are central to organizing social change. Some questions raised by this review and related studies include: How can organizations provide leadership for framing/counterframing as loving struggle – where both sides learn more about themselves and each other? What would it look and sound like to co-construct loving struggle around differences in framing? What is the role of (re)framing in transforming destructive and/or

resentful struggle into loving struggle? What are the communicative processes by which opposing groups co-create changes in frames over time? How can organizations surface and actively engage conflict between opposing frames: how the sides position themselves, the opposing groups, and their perspectives on a problem? How can organizations surface and actively engage conflict when frames are appropriated in ways that resist social change (e.g., Black Lives Matter, Blue Lives Matter, All Lives Matter)? What is the role of (re)framing in the communicative constitution of a social change organization?

4.2 Mobilizing Membership

In an in-depth study how different social change organizations transform their members' motivations and capacities for involvement, →Han (2014) suggests that while people often confuse mobilizing with organizing, they are different sets of behaviors and different ways to build power. Mobilizing is considered *transactional* as it frames the relationship between the activist and the organization or movement as an exchange relationship. Here, opportunities to participate are designed to be as "costless" as possible. For example, with moveon.org, people can take action simply by clicking on a petition, which stands in contrast to other forms of engagement (and has indeed been labeled "clicktivism" and "slacktivism" by skeptics – see →Gladwell 2010). This illustrates how mobilizing *can* be done in ways to (de)emphasize interpersonal connections between people even though emphasizing relational connections (see relationship building) increases the probability of action because it builds on solidarity motivations.

One form of mobilization is *maximization*, where a focus is placed on *maximizing numbers* by "activating people who already have some latent interest [...] Some people may act

only once and some may become involved over the long term" (→Han 2014: 152). Here, having a large list of members leads to a higher probability that more people can be activated to participate for any given action. *Consensus* mobilization relates to separating those who express a willingness to affiliate with the association from those who do not. *Action* mobilization is about differentiating those who want to take further action with the association from those who do not, figuring out how much action those people want to take (→Han 2014). In all forms, a useful strategy is reinforcing people's *identities as activists*, since individuals will go to great lengths to act consistently with the identities they have established.

To achieve mobilization, →Han (2014) articulates three levels of "list building" and offers some best practices (see p. 159). In this schema, the higher the level, the more the "downstream effects" in terms of successful mobilizing; for example, level two has downstream effects because of volunteers working together and building relationships. To begin, there should be a leader responsible for recruitment and member mobilization. Organizers must be proactive about driving people to (level one) *marketing sites*, using the website, Facebook, Twitter, tabling, newsletters, mailings, visibility, buying lists, and membership drives. *Individual outreach* (level two) strategies should be utilized to "reach out" through specific activities designed for list building, such as phone banks, door-to-door canvassing, and friend to friend outreach. *Functional outreach* efforts include policy education via multiple channels, online action alerts such as petitions, online social expressions such as sharing stories with surveys and donation requests, house meetings, recreational activities, and townhall meetings.

Studies about mobilizing behaviors include →Yin's (2018) examination of mobilizing (and empowering) migrant workers in China to participate in alternative and collective media production for social inclusion and equality by writing short

articles for an NGO newsletter. Hashtags can also be leveraged to mobilize: the #CripTheVote campaign promoted direct contact among individuals with disabilities about voting accessibility at polling places in the United States and assisted in helping disabled people know which locations they would be able to vote at (→Mann 2018; also see #MeToo in →Xiong, Cho, and Boatwright 2019). →Pal and Dutta (2012) document how the US-based International Campaign for Justice in Bhopal (ICJB) utilizes its website to complement its offline activism and "expand its reach beyond its local and national boundaries through the Internet, thus mobilizing support for the campaign from diverse nonlocal terrains" (p. 231).

Mobilizing large numbers of people is one way organizations build and display their power. Mobilizing makes visible the widespread desire for change and can influence the other side's willingness to directly engage important differences. Under what conditions can mobilizing give opponents reasons to shift from resentful and/or destructive struggle toward more loving forms of struggle? How can organizations mobilize people to better prepare them for the distinctions between destructive, resentful, and loving struggle? Finally, given the importance of mobilizing to increasing commitment among participants, what are the relational processes by which maximization, consensus, and action mobilizing are accomplished and shift over time?

4.3 Developing Relationships

Whether interacting with members, volunteers, donors, allies, or even opponents, organizing social change is highly relational. Interpersonal interactions with like-minded others can develop collective identities in "fighting for a cause" and generate activist commitment. An implicit theory exists that new relationships can generate new commitments to organizing for social change, as people's motivation for action

and potential for learning become centered in their relationships (→Han 2014). Emphasizing social connections personalizes outreach, making it more likely that people get involved and "activated". Relationship building may be furthered by organizing social and political gatherings, as well as lobbying activities and celebratory events (→Han 2014).

Leaders in social change efforts must manage significant interpersonal tension since they are pushing people to do things they might not do otherwise (and ideally towards higher levels of activism – see →Han 2014). In asking others to commit to activism, leaders face the possibility of rejection. Indeed, some social change organizations (e.g., People for the Environment) utilize the *activism ladder* to refer to four levels of "asks" of activism, where level 1 is easiest and will have more people saying yes (see →Han 2014: 34).

> Level 4: Commit to leadership development (leader)
> Level 3: Commit to outcomes (leader)
> Level 2: Commit discrete amounts of time
> Level 1: Affiliate with organization (paying dues, donations, etc.)

Relationship building is important for leaders to know how to meaningfully motivate those they work with.

Relationship building also happens in partnerships organizing for social change. In her work founding the Ella Baker Women's Center, →Parker (2020) highlights the kinds of relational practices needed when organizational members develop partnerships with members of vulnerable communities. Practices such as "radical listening" allow community members to define their own problems, co-construct interventions, and grow into community leaders themselves. "Radical listening" involves listening for context, silences, and multiple perspectives in order to reduce hierarchical differences that privilege elite voices. Advocates for participatory practice argue such dialogue is necessary to

address the community's most pressing needs (Ledwith and →Springett 2010). Radical listening aligns with a dialogic approach to decision making that recognizes different forms of expertise and nourishes the leadership potential among members.

Another facet of relational development in organizing social change is building coalitions and alliances across differences. For →Levitsky and Ziblatt (2018), building coalitions among adversaries while working within existing institutions (versus dismantling them) strengthens democracy. Building coalitions among adversaries creates challenges and raises interesting questions about communication. In her ethnographic work with residents of Lake Charles, Louisiana, →Hochschild (2016) details her process of bridging "empathy walls", defined as "obstacles to deep understanding of another person, one that can make us feel indifferent or even hostile to those who hold different beliefs" (p. 5). Perhaps exemplifying loving struggle, respectful relationships were maintained even as residents routinely questioned her identity as a progressive from Berkeley, and she routinely posed questions asking residents to reflect on contradictions between their conservative political beliefs, economic realities, and public support for corporations responsible for repeatedly degrading the local environment and quality of life.

→Norander and Galanes (2014) illustrate how community groups in a primarily White city "bridged a gap" in relationships to mobilize resources to create a more inclusive community. →Chávez's (2011) longitudinal study examined relationship building between organizations where a migrants rights organization and an LBGTQ+ organization joined in coalition to confront the ways they are similarly demonized and scapegoated in purportedly "objective" public rhetoric. →Cooper (2021) expands on the "grasstops-grassroots" tension that emerged in collaborations between change

organizations and the public. Both organizational leaders (grasstops) and the public (grassroots) are needed to impact change, but there were arguments “over who should have more influence in the collaboration” – the organization or the community (p. 404). →Meyer (2004) alludes to the ladder of activism via a “commitment|apathy” tension that emerges when people are perceived as apathetic for participating without taking on higher levels of leadership.

Relational development is central to organizing social change. Organizers must manage relational tensions with and among activists, with members of vulnerable communities, and when developing alliances across differences. Perhaps most challenging are the extreme tensions organizers must manage from engaging with “the opposition”. In addition to building upon research on cooperative relational development across differences, scholars might explore questions related to the role of communication in sharpening differences and forming relationships with opposing groups/organizations. What are the relational and communicative processes by which contending frames transform into shared new ones? What communication practices bridge “empathy walls” in building relationships with members of extremely different groups/organizations? Under what conditions do they help transform the relationships produced by destructive or resentful relational struggles into those able to withstand and grow from the agonistic tensions of loving struggle? How do these figure into organizing, resisting, and re-organizing social change? What does leadership look and sound like for the relational processes of destructive, resentful, and loving struggle?

4.4 Telling Stories

Storytelling is another central communicative process in organizing for social change. “Narratives of liberation are

always tied to people's stories" (→Freire and Macedo 1993: xii), and "transformative process begins in the stories people tell about their lives" (Ledwith and →Springett 2010: 103). Storytelling serves multiple purposes, including to make us active agents in our own lives and to develop a collective organizational identity, since organizations can also tell stories about themselves (see →Feldner and Fyke 2016). Numerous training materials teach activists to engage through stories. For example, the progressive New Organizing Institute training encourages a three-tiered story of "self, us, and now" that is about oneself, their community/group, and the urgent need for action. Conservative activists in the American Majority Teachers do the same through "me, together, do" where activists tell stories about themselves, about who they are when they work with others, and what they need people to do (→Han 2014: 163).

Stories can reproduce power and embed myths into society, but they can also lead to questioning power as personal stories narrate the ways our lives have been socially situated by power structures. Stories can capture life experiences to help us understand our own perspectives and the perspectives of diverse others. Stories can be transgressional when used to "question why things are as they are, we transgress the false consciousness that the world is a fixed experience, that it cannot be changed. Story then becomes part of the toolkit of transformative practice" (Ledwith and →Springett 2010: 104).

Grounded in the understanding that personal stories are never final (→Frank 2010), →Bell (2020) offers a typology to guide storytelling for the explicit purpose of social change and the transformation of race relations. Social change begins by identifying *stock stories* – a set of familiar, widely held stories that explain racial dynamics in ways that support the status quo. They perpetuate stereotypes and explain away challenges to their authority, however, they can be

destabilized through the use of concealed, resistance, and emerging/transforming stories. *Concealed stories* reveal what stock stories hide about race relations and in doing so, disrupt the status quo by foregrounding the ways race shapes life experiences and opportunities. *Resistance stories* highlight examples of individual and collective action taken to challenge racism and can inspire others to act. *Emerging/transforming* stories are those that have yet to be created. They convey the experiences of people who are currently living their lives in ways that reimagine social categories and relationships. Bell's typology highlights the importance of artistic expression to imagine and act "otherwise". This approach influenced how Parker organized the work of the Ella Baker Women's Center for Leadership and Community Activism (2020).

Studies that illustrate the potential impact of storytelling for social change include →Harter et al.'s (2004) chronicle of how StreetWise (as a newspaper of counterdiscourse and as a movement) organizes for social change through offering alternative ways of thinking about the issues of homelessness and poverty by (a) prioritizing people and issues on the margin, (b) privileging personal experiences, and (c) positioning the readership as a diverse and participatory public. →Pal and Dutta (2012) illustrate how activists in the US-based International Campaign for Justice in Bhopal (ICJB) utilize "the story of Bhopal" to generate awareness and support for regulations. Assisi House used social media as "opportunities to tell individual stories and reflect on the social conditions that created poverty" (→Jensen 2017: 384). →Feldner and Fyke (2016) illustrate how the Skoll foundation, whose vision is a sustainable world of peace and prosperity, "believe[s] in the power of storytelling" as a platform "to make vivid the world's most pressing problems and to articulate specific solutions with potential for large-scale impact" and consequently create films and documentaries (p. 24).

Knowing the importance of personal, collective, and public storytelling, future research might explore how organizations deploy multiple levels of storytelling in the struggle to create or resist social change. How might storytelling empower and prepare opposing groups to engage in loving struggle? Researchers can identify specific communicative processes by which it becomes possible to re-story a life and the role of the organization in creating these conditions. How can organizations provide leadership for surfacing and critiquing stock stories, sharing and validating concealed and resistance stories, and co-creating emerging stories of transformation? What are the specific *communication processes* by which organizations become meaningful sites for the co-creation of emerging/transforming stories? Scholar/activists might also explore how this storytelling trajectory could be deployed in activism around environmental and economic justice.

Finally, although we separated our discussion of these four communication processes for illustrative purposes, they are often mutually reinforcing. For example, →Han's (2014) research on organizational factors that increase the likelihood that people will take action illustrates how combining *transformation organizing* (developing the capacities of people to engage, develop relationships, and become leaders) with *transactional mobilizing* (maximizing numbers without developing people's capacity for civic action) can be even more effective in achieving higher levels of activism over time.

5 The Struggle for Organizing Social Change Exemplified: Race, Equity, and Education

A struggle ensues when those who oppose the changes advocated by a movement publicly challenge its diagnostic and prognostic framings (→Benford and Snow 2000). Nebraska is one of multiple states experiencing visible (and destructive) "struggles" related to progressive social change

in education, and leading the resistance was Republican Governor Pete Ricketts. When the Nebraska State Board of Education proposed health education standards that included grade-school students learning about gender identity, gender expression, sexual orientation, and gender stereotypes, he started an "opposition tour" and called to scrap them completely (→Summers 2021). Such an uproar ensued (including death threats to board members) that the standards were redone – and then voting was postponed "indefinitely" (→Dejka 2021). Ricketts warned how the "State Board of Education could bring these controversial standards back at any time [so] we must remain vigilant" (→Dejka 2021).

And the need to prevent teaching Critical Race Theory (CRT) also emerged as an imminent threat as Ricketts encouraged Nebraskans "to support efforts to ban teaching this theory to young kids in our schools" (→Gentzler 2021). Nebraska's revisionist catchall of CRT includes not only teaching students about systemic racism or White privilege, but has broadened to basically anything related to equity, diversity, and inclusion in an exemplification of *frame bridging* (see →Gross and Kingkade 2021). One University of Nebraska regent lamented how his "9-year-old grandson go[es] to school and [is] told he has to apologize for being White" (→Essex 2021) and created a proposal to the Board of Regents to oppose CRT in the university curriculum. When this did not pass, Ricketts "committed to continuing the fight" (→Nebraska Office of the Governor 2021a).

Within this political climate, the University of Nebraska-Lincoln (a primarily White institution), under the leadership of Chancellor Ronnie Green (a White man), put forward its progressive social change commitments *Journey for Anti-Racism and Racial Equity* in November 2021. The plan was based on 18 months of discussions and recommendations provided by multiple units across the university to "address this deeply enduring challenge of anti-racism and racial

equity” (→University of Nebraska Office of the Chancellor 2021). Almost immediately, an “escalating, mostly one-sided, war of words” began against Chancellor Green (→Omaha World Herald Editorial Staff 2021a). Ricketts condemned the plan as “anti-American”, “Marxist”, “communist” (→Omaha World Herald Editorial Staff 2021b) and “the product of ideologues” (→Dunker 2021). He asserted it “pit[s] people against each other” (→Omaha World Herald Editorial Staff 2021a) and is “legally questionable, intellectually flawed and politically charged” (→Dunker 2021). He called upon “Nebraskans to let the University know that they reject their plan to apply CRT on campus” and gave instructions for how people could (should) attend the next meeting of the Board of Regents (→Nebraska Office of the Governor 2021b).

Chancellor Green was targeted specifically: Ricketts publicly stated he had “lost all faith” in him (→Kipper 2021), prompting Green to defend himself and the plan as “the work of the UNL community” and to note CRT is not even mentioned (→Ward 2021). Simultaneous to these attacks, there have also been vocal defenders of UNL’s racial equity plan. The editorial staff of the *Omaha World Herald* (2021a, 2021b) advocated for the plan, argued diversity plans are not “anti-American”, and noted that Ricketts’s backlash “tells the rest of America and its workers that Nebraska is unwelcoming to people of color”. The Omaha and Lincoln chapters of the NAACP publicly supported the plan and pledged to work with the university (Crisler 2021).

We introduce these examples because this pushback is not unique. Those who organize for social change need to be prepared for those who wish to combat it, maintain the status quo, or go a different direction (to “take back our country”, “make America great again”, etc.). In this case, some of the backlash is rooted in White fragility and White supremacy, and those groups are counterorganizing and counterframing. In June 2021, at least 165 local and national groups tried to

disrupt or block lessons on race in schools (→Gross and Kingkade 2021). These groups are reinforced by media outlets like *Fox News*, who talked about CRT 1,300 times across three months. The conservative think tanks The Heritage Foundation and ALEC have hosted calls and webinars between activists and on-the-ground parent groups who teach parents activism using activities such as filing records requests to inundate schools. When the founder of No Left Turn in Education appeared on Tucker Carlson, Facebook followers increased from 200 to 30,000 within a day (→Gross and Kingkade 2021).

The tactics most frequently utilized when *organizing to combat social change* surround school boards, and include disrupting board meetings, ousting liberal board members, and harassing parents who advocate equity issues. Parents and protestors show up to school board meetings with chants to ban CRT before meetings even start; one meeting in Virginia had 263 people signed up to speak (→Gross and Kingkade 2021). In some areas, violence has been threatened to the point that meetings have gone back to virtual because of security concerns. Think tanks also brief conservative lawmakers on proposed legislation (e.g., banning CRT); several states have already passed some version of banning CRT or the teaching of "divisive concepts" in schools (→Gross and Kingkade 2021).

The resistance in counterframing illustrates how oppositional groups respond when campus leaders "unequivocally admit organizational injustice and inequity [...] and work to unsettle, challenge, and educate those who benefit" (Ashcraft and Allen in →Ballard et al. 2020: 600). Consequently, when organizing for social change, there *will* be opposition – so attention should be given to knowing who may be counterorganizing. In this case of social change in education, what are lessons that could be learned to have made this a more loving struggle?

First and foremost, both sides would need to be acting in good faith and not just doing performative work for their constituent base. Second, the importance of relationship building cannot be overstated: several regents wished they had known more about the UNL plan before it was published, and this relational work could have garnered more support in advance. Third, if the plan had been introduced with stories/narratives of how students, staff, and faculty at UNL have been treated in ways that necessitated the plan, it would have been impactful. Fourth, while it seems strange to defend a plan against something it is not (and does not contain), perhaps a reference to CRT's absence in the plan may have been helpful. Finally, while it is unclear whether stories about institutional discrimination at UNL would be persuasive to conservative audiences, they would allow for introducing counternarratives.

Organizing social change involves a series of interrelated communicative practices that are utilized not only to further the cause, but also to address the counterframing, mobilizing, relationship building, and storytelling that will emerge throughout discursive struggle. Organizational communication scholars have a role to play in articulating the role of communication in perpetuating destructive and resentful cycles of interaction, and in illuminating how those cycles can be transformed. There are "many different ways of making sense of the world, and many different experiences of life in the world, [so] practices [...] predicated on equality and social justice must heed these diverse ways of knowing and being in the world" (Ledwith and →Springett 2010: 109). Organizational communication scholars have a role to play in articulating how communication perpetuates destructive and resentful cycles of interaction and in illuminating how those cycles can be transformed to loving.

6 Conclusion

Social change organizations contribute to the vitality of democratic societies by empowering less powerful groups to challenge – and even transform – systemic inequalities. To do so they need to build the capacity to engage dominant groups in repeated conflicts, a struggle that can become destructive for all sides. Although destructive struggle can draw attention to the anger and pain produced by living a marginalized reality, we have argued that differences between contending realities will best be engaged through a more cooperative process of *loving struggle*. Social change organizations can prepare members for the kinds of communication needed to initiate and sustain conflict between opposing groups (i.e., re/framing, mobilizing, relationship-building, and storytelling), and ideally choosing loving struggle over destruction and/or resentment. We acknowledge the aspirational nature of loving struggle and the challenges involved in co-creating it. We also believe, however, that taking the idea seriously can help leaders and members at least *imagine* the kinds of communication capable of disrupting destructive and resentful struggle, and creating conditions where loving struggle and meaningful social change become possible. After all, at the heart of struggle is communication.

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Chapter 27 Work and Life Communication

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Caryn E. Medved

Abstract

This chapter provides a review and critique of work-life communication research as organized around two interrelated inflection points: structures of work and related worker experiences in relation to family and personal lives. We argue that work-family communication, practices, and structures intersect in complex ways and are inherently paradoxical. In closing, three cross-cutting paradoxes are detailed: flexibility, difference, and policy along with related directions for future research.

Keywords: precarity, work-life conflict, careers, DEI, gig economy, informal economy, stress, burnout, policy, resilience,

1 Work and Life Issues

The pace of significant social change in the organization of work and family lives often is gradual and visible only over successive generations. Yet when the COVID-19 pandemic hit in early 2020, the intersections between earning a living and caring for others rapidly and strikingly shifted in different ways for workers across the globe. These changes were accompanied by increasing recognition of economic, health, and racial disparities, marked by global protests against systemic racism. The global long-term nature and

consequences of these events on families, organizations, and economies are yet undetermined; short-term, however, researchers see significant shifts in global labor markets and work processes and preferences (→Beauregard et al. 2020; →Kossek and Lee 2020). This chapter enters into this messy, divisive, and promising context to review and critique recent work-life communication scholarship as well as offer an agenda to push forward this essential research (for additional reviews, see →Berkelaar and Tronstad 2017; →Buzzanell 2021). Specifically, this chapter discusses the discourse and practices through which work and life interpenetrate for both positive and negative outcomes and with considerations of macro-meso-micro interconnections. It is organized around two, interrelated inflection points: (a) structures of *work* and related (b) *worker* experiences in relation to family and personal lives. In closing, we posit that work-family communication, practices, and structures intersect in complex and inherently paradoxical ways. We detail three cross-cutting paradoxes: flexibility, difference, and policy with directions for future research.

1.1 Evolving Discourses and Practices of *Work* and Family

First, regarding the evolving discourses and practices of *work*, we review research on macro shifts in the structures and nature of work and their relations to family such as increased precarity and contingency of labor and rising remote, digitally enabled freelance, and 'gig' labor, while noting that space precludes discussions of other shifts (e.g., work automation) (→Kalleberg 2016; →Rosenblat 2018). We explore research on meso-level issues such as connections to workplace diversity and inclusion initiatives, work-life policy enactment, and shifting career conceptualizations.

The ever-changing nature of work invokes a succession of discursive and material realities. The US saw changes from

colonial slave labor to family farms, Model T assembly lines and the 1950s ‘corporate man’ moving into the 1990s Silicon Valley. Today’s imagery of Mark Zuckerberg, celebrity social media influencers, Uber drivers, and Instacart or Alibaba shoppers are global. Transformations in work structures always have affected and were affected by daily family-personal life experiences.

While access to stable, long-term employment with benefits characterizes only a short moment in labor history and experiences of mostly non-minoritized workers (→Hyman 2018), recent decades have seen rising worker precarity and “bad jobs” with effects on work-life conflict (→Fan, Lam, and Moen 2019). Even workers in supposedly “good” jobs where tenure previously meant security, now feel vulnerable, leaving workers’ families in economic jeopardy. Further, workers are increasingly in nonstandard, irregular, or contingent forms of employment (→Arnold and Bongiovi 2012; →Kalleberg 2016). The percentage of workers engaged in alternative arrangements such as temporary help agency, on-call, contract, and independent contractor or freelance workers, rose from 10.7% in 2005 to 15.8% in 2015 (→Katz and Krueger 2019).

Precarity has risen due to many factors. These include the elimination of particular kinds of work due to automation, AI, and robots as well as related increases in digital labor platforms for organizing gig or freelance work (→West 2018). Following the Great Recession, companies such as Uber strategically entered large metropolitan markets with abundant labor forces to connect users to service providers (→Srnicek 2017). While supplying earnings options to low-income marginalized workers, these companies also thwart economic stabilities and employment and housing regulations across the globe (→Rosenblat 2018). While employees report varied experiences by income dependence and pay level, companies that classify low-income workers as ‘independent

contractors' versus 'employees' have increased worker precarity by not providing health and accident insurance, legal recourse in employment disputes, and collective bargain abilities (→Vallas and Schor 2020). Precarity of work, particularly for low-income women, is associated with work-to-family conflict (→Fan, Lam, and Moen 2019). While communication, particularly media studies, scholars (→Chen 2018) have explored issues of digital labor, scant research looks at the discourses and practices of work-life management in platform workers' lives.

Digital platforms have disrupted industries and shifted employment relationships, but corporate use of alternative work arrangements, including remote work, was on the rise prior to the pandemic. The extent of its global adoption in 2020 was unprecedented (→Dey et al. 2020); simultaneously, sectors such as health care and service, particularly related to low-wage workers, were differently affected given needs for in-person, at times hazardous forms of labor (→Parker, Horowitz, and Minkin 2020). Studies of working from home (WFH) during the pandemic have linked reduced social isolation with not only communication opportunities through the use of lean channels, such as e-mail, but also needs to foster social exchange (→Galanti et al. 2021) and trust in remote management (→Parker, Knight, and Keller 2020).

1.1.1 Meso-level Considerations

Besides larger scale shifts in the nature of work, key meso-organizational level considerations related to work-family intersections have emerged including: strategic initiatives around issues of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI); work-life policy enactment and flexibility; and reconfiguring of careers, including design, agility, and sustainability.

Societal debates have renewed the urgency for workplace DEI initiatives, particularly in the US. These wide-ranging

programs mirror calls for increased attention to DEI in work-life research (→Beauregard at al. 2020). Taking an intersectionalities approach focusing on politics and identities organized around gender, race/ethnicity, nationality, citizenship, age, and so on (→Crenshaw 1989), →Ammons et al. (2017) find that levels of work-to-family and family-to-work conflicts vary by gender, race/ethnicity, and their intersections. For work-to-family conflict, race/ethnicity may matter more than gender. Early in work-family communication studies, →Medved and Kirby (2005) explored critical intersections between gender and race in corporate mothering discourses, but scant communication research has continued to investigate diverse work-life discourses and practices. →Dixon and Dougherty's (2014) study of LGBTQ (lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer) and single employees found that compulsory traditional family discourses in the workplace "othered" people from alternative families. As a result of this othering, LGBTQ, single, and childfree workers experienced simultaneous and paradoxical invisibility and hypervisibility and caused participants with alternative families to work around traditional family assumptions in their everyday interactions at work. Additionally, →Bishop and Medved (2020) explored how mixed status immigrant families communicatively navigate their uncertain life terrain through conversation about immigration status, conflicting career dreams, and hybrid cultural values. While this study highlights family interactions, additional research needs to unpack the work-family intersections, particularly of the 'dreamer' generation that has entered the workplace while constantly on uncertain political ground. With calls for increased attention to communication issues in Black families (→Hutchins and Nelson 2021), much work remains in investigating diverse and intersectional work-family communication, including that in the Global South.

Recent studies have explored everyday communicative enactments of work-life policies in relation to national, organizational, and relational levels of analysis. While European-style national work-life regulations are often touted by US scholars as praiseworthy and progressive in contrast to market-based, employer-focused work-life policy, resistance was found by Dutch employees to work-life policies and their differential enactment (ter Hoeven et al. 2017). Differences were found between rules and resources enacted in Dutch workplace interactions with supervisors and colleagues; national regulations were followed more closely and were less questioned by employees of the Dutch public organization than the private corporate culture.

Furthermore, co-worker memorable messages about work-family tensions in the US context were constructed in relation to two dimensions: perceived efficacy-inefficacy and individual-shared context (→Yoshimura and Heisterkamp 2019). These dimensions illuminate workers' sense of ability to help co-workers' work-family tensions (e.g., by perspective taking) and to frame tensions around individual-collective strategies for management (e.g., managing personal frustrations, fatigue, unfair treatment).

Finally, careers shifted from organizational advancement models to accommodate and shape individuals' goal-directed activity regardless of the form of paid work (e.g., employment, entrepreneurship, informal, and gig labor). Given neoliberalism's promotion of hypercompetitive individualistic career activity, individuals and companies attempt to display shifting and visible competencies in face-to-face and/or virtual platforms that can be plugged into multiple labor contexts. These drives toward sustainable and agile careers mean that individuals, vis-à-vis others, construct careers differently across lifespans and with attention to institutional and social structures. Career at micro-levels, then, are themes that underlie paid and unpaid activity, whereas career at broader

levels are the institutional, social, economic, and global forces enabling and constraining work-life fulfillment. Career scholarship challenges traditional approaches to individual agency by linking lives and structures to better meet work-family needs in particular circumstances (Tomlinson et al. 2018), but still has not pushed against omnipresent neoliberal values of meritocracy, efficiency, and market prioritization (→Amis, Mair, and Munir 2020).

1.2 Evolving Discourses and Practices of *Workers*

Second, we analyze studies of *worker* experiences in managing both paid employment and caregiving responsibilities in general and then workers typically not found in organizational and work-family communication scholarship.

Contemporary academic and popular works center on control of work, family, and other personal considerations to forestall precarity and risk and on individuals' and organizations' struggles to distinguish themselves via branding and advantageous market management. These discussions hinge on governmentality, the form of power that operates according to logics of differentiation by which people seek to position themselves as valuable, find fulfillment in work itself, and live with precarity as the new normal (→Mumby and Plotnikof 2019). For example, those who wish to control their creative and artistic talents may embrace precarious conditions and forego work-family balance in efforts to show commitment to their work and callings (→Adler 2021). Everyday talk and cultural understandings (d/Discourses) perceive following one's passion as the most desirable career form and the only type of career worth pursuing (→Berkelaar and Buzzanell 2015).

Work-family research delves into the multiple tensions with which families and organizations contend. These tensions emerge in both materialities and d/Discourses of intense paid

labor, intense mothering, at-home fathering, and conflicts with childcare and elder responsibilities (→Chatot and Medved 2016; →Medved 2016). With the exceptions of sensemaking about "dirty" or stigmatized work (i.e., work is physically, socially, and morally tainted; →Ashforth and Kreiner 1999) and under-resourced, particularly artistic and not-for-profit, work aligned with callings, most attention has been paid to professionals and managers as well as successful entrepreneurs. Of interest is how contradictory discursive and material patterns reproduce structures that simultaneously privilege and marginalize (e.g., →Lucas 2011). Ironically, those who face the greatest economic, temporal, and relational precarities are those least able to develop or retain viable and fulfilling conditions for themselves and their families. Nonstandard work hours and days relate to work-family conflict in 32 European countries but the association strength varies based mostly on whether workers have unions in their countries (→Taiji and Mills 2020). Additionally, those who do not work in managerial and professional occupations and/or are located in the Global South are neglected in communication scholarship as a whole (→Dutta and Pal 2020) and particularly in work-family contexts.

Since many workers do not fit mainstream categories, we discuss workers typically not found in organizational and work-family communication scholarship: informal sector, transnational, essential, and gig workers. We then describe workers' material-discursive precarities and felt meaninglessness. First, →Villanueva and Lin (2020) estimate that half of the labor force in Latin America works in the informal economy, an unregulated sector without legally recognized contracts or benefits, and with lower wages and easy entry. In this region, these mostly unskilled laborers work in the service (restaurant, hotel, retail) or construction industries. Women are more likely to work in the informal sector and less likely to move into formal sectors. Analyzing

household survey data from Argentina, Brazil, Chile, Mexico, and Peru, findings indicate that mothers, in contrast to childless women, typically work in the informal sector with additional penalties for ethnic, racial, and national minorities and lower educational levels. Mothers bear the brunt of short-term income and long-term lack of retirement and poverty, with instabilities likely shaping and being shaped by efforts to control work-family imbalances. In informal work studies, reporting of broad sociological, economic, and labor force patterns means that little is gleaned about the d/Discourses producing and mitigating work-family conflicts and associated processes in boundary, role, temporal, and spatial/place management.

Second, workers at the fringe of work-family discussions, like nannies and household workers such as gardeners in the Global South, engage in labor designed to assist families, but rarely are part of work-family research. Exceptions are when discussions examine resources upon which affluent families depend to enable their paid labor. Nannies and other household workers help families navigate schedules but also perform "commodified intimacy, or the intersections of money and intimacy in everyday life, [...] shaped by, even as it shapes, relations of race, class and gender" (→Kim 2017: 201). Drawing from ethnographic interviews and observations with 140 Filipina, Indonesian, and Sri Lankan nannies in Paris, →Kim (2017) found that migrant mothers struggle with tensions including intimacy through technology, moral 'good' mother uncertainties, and distal care for and technologically mediated contact with their own children and proximal caregiving for others' children. Yet such discussions often do not enter work-family communication despite likely insights into boundary permeability and the costs of commodified intimacy driven by financial precarities. Their good mothering is unlike the d/Discourses of privileged 'good' working mothers whose goodness is not dependent upon direct care

but upon locating and negotiating quality secondary care (→Buzzanell et al. 2005). Similarly, →Dubrofsky and Magnet (2015) describe how surveillance and inequity co-exist, questioning how people do certain things, for whose benefit, in reproductive technologies and Indian surrogates.

Third, essential workers form another group whose work is generally under-resourced and undervalued, but deemed valuable and necessary. These workers were compelled to engage in paid labor during the COVID-19 pandemic without protective equipment and despite protest (→Hintz, Betts, and Buzzanell 2023). With regard to essential migrant domestic workers, →Pandey, Parreñas, and Sabio (2021) note that the valuation of essential work is contradictory insofar as people are "treated as indispensable and undervalued": "high risk of unemployment, demand for overtime work, unremunerated labor, unsafe workplaces, and minimal access to state benefits extended to other essential workers" (p. 1288), particularly if undocumented. These conditions enable control and dampen resistance.

Fourth, gig workers are contingent laborers who often depend upon technologies and have the potential for upward mobility depending on location and industry. Gig workers range from lower skilled-task-based through creative industry workers but all are challenged with organizational, identity, relational, emotional, and career-path uncertainties (→Caza et al. 2022). Although Fayard (2021) describes political and social implications, no mention of work-family considerations are mentioned. Given the great variation in gig work, Caza et al. hope that researchers can better understand gig workers' stressors that can inform public policy and practice. As a case in point, →Anwar and Graham (2020) conducted a four-year study on gig work with 65 workers in South Africa, Kenya, Nigeria, Ghana, and Uganda. Their work yielded four dimensions – freedom, flexibility, precarity, and vulnerability – not unlike Caza et al.'s challenges – but noting benefits given

the lack of employment opportunities for particular groups in these locations. Like other gig studies mentioned here, work-family d/Discourses, conflict, and/or "balance" were not considered. Finally, these four worker groupings have different d/Discursive and material resources with which they handle tensions centering on precarities and meaninglessness. Precarity in general and the more positively oriented "flexibility" can affect workers to greater and lesser degrees. Effects depend on context, industry, intersectionalities, and lifespan phases (e.g., →Murgia and Poggio 2019).

Furthermore, workers experiencing perceived loss of economic status or class privilege and pressures to maintain or surpass generational class status can affect and be affected by family communication (e.g., →Berger and Engzell 2020). Latinx immigrants and their next generations exhibit family communication pressures for children to fulfill immigrants' dreams of better lives (→Sánchez Sánchez 2019). Likewise, Chinese Post80s members express concerns that they might not be able to live up to generational resource investment and filial piety obligations (→Long, Buzzanell, and Kuang 2021). →O'Connor and Raile (2015) found that US millennials' discourse expressed discouragement that the kind of job to which they aspired was even possible in today's world. In these cases, broad employment patterns and shifts have been coupled with interview data analyzed typically through discourse, critical discourse, and/or constant comparative analysis.

It is worth noting that precarities are often treated as states, rather than active agents with variability in workers' world making. Workers experience precarities related to work itself and 'bad' job qualities, gendered labor, and temporalities (→Buzzanell 2021; →Gist-Mackey and Guy 2019; →Kalleberg 2016). We add lack of safety – physical harm, sexual assault, emotional and gendered harassment –

associated with isolated conditions (→McDermott, Gee, and May, forthcoming). In some cases, workers may be uneducated or untrained in other kinds of work, geographically limited, encumbered by felony records, and/or constrained by classed, gendered, nationality, and raced job searches (→Cruz et al. 2020; →Gist-Mackey 2018; →Pager and Pedulla 2015). In other cases, people desire flexibilities afforded by low-commitment jobs with limited hours for caregiving – not envisioning the trap that might exclude them from better future work (→Hašková and Dudová 2017).

Last, workers' meaningful work is associated with positive well-being, whereas 'bullshit' (BS) jobs are perceived useless work associated with poor well-being (→Soffia, Wood, and Burchell 2022). Using →Graeber's (2018b) definition of bullshit jobs as employment "so completely pointless, unnecessary, so pernicious that [...] the employee feels obligated to pretend that this is not the case" (p. 28), →Sampatasatien and Beckstein (2021) provide examples of designers who do commercial work that conflicts with their values and deviates from societal contributions. They advise designers to empower themselves, but do not offer structural remedies. Using academe as an example based on "galloping bureaucratization" and useless meetings, →Graeber (2018a) recommends "de-bullshitize[ing by] do[ing] something about the current precarity of intellectual life" (p. 12). Soffia, Wood, and Burchell suggest transforming poor management and toxic workplace environments. Work-family studies have not yet focused on the BS in workers' job communication.

1.3 Individual Experiences of Stress and Burnout

For decades work-family studies have explored the connections between work-life conflict and workers' stress or burnout (e.g., →Gisler et al. 2018; →Kossek and Lee 2017; →Ray and Miller 1991; →Powers and Myers 2020). Recently,

→Riforgiate, Howes, and Simmons (2022) found that workers' daily emotional labor in the form of surface acting negatively related to their psychological well-being, physical health, and burnout in a small website development company. →Dailey, Burke, and Carberry (2018) explored employee narratives surrounding workplace wellness programs (WWP) offered during work hours. While employees expressed positive WWP involvement, their narratives also revealed struggles between employee agency and competing discourses of managerialism and control. Supervisors and colleagues questioned WWP use during work hours and inflexible productivity expectations. A workplace wellness program in a pediatric residency program inadvertently served to reproduce institutional norms and workers' stress levels (→Harrison and Stephens 2019). Communication and wellness professionals should connect daily experiences with d/Discourses of wellness to study and practice more meaningful whole-person approaches. These approaches include workers' mental health (i.e., anxiety, depression, ADHD) as elements of the 'whole worker', desired by millennials and mentally healthy workplace cultures. Progress in wellness requires disclosing mental health issues or illness in workplaces that can improve relationships, authenticity, and work environment support but also reproduce discrimination and stigma (→Brouwers et al. 2020). Workplace disclosures are complex. Disclosure processes attend to timing, recipients, preparation, message content, and communication style as well as workplace, financial, and employee factors.

Finally, whereas the role of communication technologies across work-family boundaries and telecommuting arrangements is not a new topic for communication research (e.g., Golden and Elia 2017; →Fonner and Roloff 2012), recent research indicates that smartphone use for after-hours work, paradoxically, was *not* associated with work-life conflict in a study of a large Scandinavian telecommunications company's

employees but was positively associated with organizational identification (→van Zoonen, Sivunen, and Rice 2020). Supervisor communication about family demands mediated the relationship between smartphone use and work-life conflict, while communication about work demands did not. A similar paradoxical finding was reported by ter Hoeven and colleagues (2017) who demonstrate the communication technology use increases well-being through positive pathways (accessibility and efficiency) and decreases well-being through negative pathways (interruptions and unpredictability). They recommend studies on technology as both resources and demands in relationship to employee well-being (for a critique of well-being discourse; see →Ganesh and McAllum 2010) and in flexible work and technology use implementation. Still others suggest attention to communication flows of membership negotiation and activity coordination (e.g., Finnish organizations; →Nordbäck, Myers, and McPhee 2017). Boundary management, however, also has been argued to be, itself, an interpersonal competency. On platforms such as Facebook, people connect with professional and personal contacts as well as share work and non-work information. →Ollier-Malaterre's (2018) research offers four boundary management strategies (audience, content, tailored, and open) to manage this collision acknowledging both positive and detrimental consequences to interpersonal relationships and professional reputations.

2 Emerging Research Areas and Practical Implications

Work-family communication, practices, and structures intersect in complex ways and, we argue, are inherently paradoxical. These paradoxes are made even more complex as our post-pandemic personal and work lives continue to take form even as we write this chapter. It is in these

complexities that a revised research agenda for work-life communication scholarship emerges.

2.1 Intersecting and Paradoxical Nature of Work-Family Processes

First, what makes sense in one political economic system may have ironic consequences and be non-transferrable. For instance, Nordic social welfare affordances for greater work and personal life balance, such as longer paid parental leave and state-provided childcare, may come hand-in-hand with gender inequities. Finish mothers experience contradictions between ideal workers and mothers such that they enact "bounded individualism" that "obscures persistent organisational and societal inequalities in and around production and reproduction" (→Niemistö et al. 2021). The "Finnish dream", an unattainable egalitarian work-family ideal, produces personal dissatisfactions in women with career and family aspirations.

Second, processes and non-human agents interact to produce policies whose practices and outcomes defy their aims. For instance, family leave policies and supervisors send mixed messages, with workers admitting that they cannot use policies without repercussions (→Kirby and Krone 2002). As a result, work-family policies remain unused to the extent that one would want (→Long, Selzer King, and Buzzanell 2018; →Williams, Blair-Loy, and Berdahl 2013). Still, what kinds of mixed messages will arise in the context of hybrid work? And, will co-workers (who may no longer be geographically co-present) exert the same influence on their colleagues' policy use as found in past research (→Kirby and Krone 2002)? Will virtual teams negotiate tasks and responsibilities in ways that allow (or not) for personal and work conflict management (→Nordbäck et al. 2021).

Third, in the neoliberal economy, self-care and leisure activities are viewed as means of increasing individual productivity and worth (human capital) in the competitive marketplace with the feminist subject taking full responsibility for her own self-care but not for others' well-being (→Banet-Weiser, Gill, and Rottenberg 2020). For work-life, balance is the illusive feminist ideal. However, given the increased awareness of the mental health challenges in the face of the COVID-19 pandemic, communication scholars can explore discourses, practices, and material consequences of mentally healthy workplace cultures, including hybrid workplace cultures. What new or 'hybrid' discourses of mental health, flexibility, and work will emerge in the coming years?

Finally, claims to value diversity, champion #BlackLivesMatter, redress inequities, and incorporate critical approaches to family (and interpersonal) communication scholarship proliferate, but are rarely implemented in family communication studies (→Hutchins and Nelson 2021), not fully represented in organizational communication research and pedagogy (→Walker and Muñoz Rojas 2021), and still warrant further consideration from intersectional perspectives and non-Western perspectives (e.g., Chinese and Afrocentric approaches; see →Long, Buzzanell, and Kuang 2021; →Williams 2022). Future research, for example, needs to explore how intersectionality shapes worker narratives about flexibility, work-life conflict and 'return to work' experiences.

Given what people proport to value and design in policy versus what people actually do and say, paradox seems the optimal lens for work-family communication. Paradox is tensional – generative and conflictual – with incompatibilities such as identities, positions, emotions, boundaries, and policies happening simultaneously and requiring work at multiple levels (→Putnam, Fairhurst, and Banghart 2016; →Smith and Lewis 2011). The contradictions, ironies, and dilemmas that ensue can make some feel uncomfortable and

disempowered (→Berti and Simpson 2021) whereas others feel exhilarated and creative. Bednarek and Lê (in →Pradies et al. 2021) discuss work-family conflicts from a paradox approach during the COVID-19 pandemic. They described how the pandemic disrupted work-family management such that balance was unachievable in some circumstances, reconstructed in others, varied through oscillation or interweaving of work and family, and knotted with multiple tensions. They conclude that a paradox mindset through which people proactively confront tensions and seek both/and alternatives can assist workers and organizations (→Miron-Spektor et al. 2018).

2.2 Paradoxes of Flexibility, Difference, and Policy

Taking the paradox mindset into consideration, paradoxes that operate in work-family communication are not mutually exclusive categories. They overlap and draw force from integration with other paradoxical discussions in work-family communication. Each presumes seemingly incompatible relationships between sustainable work and family qualities and organizing processes, practices, and structures. Each holds the promise for creative solutions. Toward this end, we extend our earlier discussions about flexibility, difference, and policy.

First, there is great variation in what ***flexibility*** means in organization and organizational communication studies. The ramifications for work-family communication and conflict are long-term and dependent upon the nature of occupations and quality of jobs. For work-family investigations, Goldin (2014) collapsed flexibility of time and place into the multidimensional construct of “temporal flexibility” through which people gain control over work. In a multimethod study examining archival, survey, and experimental data, →Bear (2021) found that when positions did not have temporal

flexibility, women anticipated work-family conflict and dampened their promotion aspirations. In asking the question of work-life flexibility for whom, Kossek, Perrigino, and Rock (2021) found that workers with less job quality could benefit from scheduling flexibility yet were unlikely to utilize flextime. Leave can benefit mid- to upper-level employees if these employees can separate from work itself. Cutting through the many differences in flexibility as a work-family intervention, flexibility seems better posed from a paradoxical mindset where employees, as well as entrepreneurs and gig workers, could sustain an openness to the advantages and constraints afforded by different options and consequences.

Flexibility's overarching autonomy-control paradox is grounded in occupational and job types by →Kossek and Lautsch (2018) but →Putnam, Myers, and Gailliard (2014) elevate flexibility to a human right. To derive how to communicate this right through a paradoxical mindset, focus groups could enable employees to discuss how they struggle with common experiences and design change initiatives (→Gist-Mackey and Guy 2019). Furthermore, →Delanoeije, Verbruggen, and Germeys (2019) point out that "no research on the relationship between telework and work-home conflict to date had used a daily approach [but they] clarify how telework affects employees' daily work home experiences and [...] impact[s] of telework" (p. 1862). →Medved (2004) provides examples of what micro-practices of navigating work-life on a daily basis look like from a communication perspective. →Medved's (2004) strategy of examining practical action clusters has yet to be replicated or expanded in work-family communication studies. Future communication research can pose questions such as: how pandemic work-life experiences shifted (or not) discourses and practices of flexibility? Or how have workplace negotiations about supposed 'alternative work arrangements' changed post-pandemic and with employee resistance to the traditional 9-to-5 workplace? Or,

finally, for gig employees how is flexibility communicatively constructed in the face of technological/algorithmic control?

Second, ***difference*** functions as a catch-all term for the need for *intersectional* examinations of work-family communication and of sites where *equalities and inequalities* are visible. Difference presumes that neoliberal intents to maintain hypercompetitive systems to benefit organizations can be positioned advantageously against actions geared toward common good and elevation of family over paid labor. Inherent contradictions between neoliberalism and the common good demand creative workarounds and a paradoxical mindset for change.

→Hutchins and Nelson (2021) call for essays grounded in critical race theory, intersectionalities, narrative, and cultural-linguistic-normative communication, to focus on Black families: if "#BlackLivesMatter, shouldn't we consider that Black families matter too?" Whereas they situate their call within US-centric considerations, →Williams (2022) takes an Afrocentric lens – particularly the therapeutic approach of NTU that uses mindfulness and holistic spiritual-health/well-being values – as guidance rather than prescriptive strategies. Black women's roles, burdens, and feelings of entrapment in maintaining and serving as family support systems are inherently paradoxical. Williams recommends harmony that affirms all family members and can become underlying dynamics for work-family communication.

In addition to the marginalization of peoples of color and the Global South in work-family communication, another area of difference that has been gaining traction is LBGTQ+ concerns. →Hastings, Minei, and Warren (2021) indicate how co-workers' direct messages and underlying Discourses or social norms encourage closeting. Hastings, Minei, and Warren provide practical implications for creating workplaces where people can live their whole selves and depend on allies for support. Toward that end, incorporation of difference,

intersectional and culture-centered scholarship, and equity require accountability. Regarding accountability, Long (in →Linabary et al. 2021) constantly questions herself about what she is missing or how she might be perpetuating colonial structures by relying on or starting from Western theories and methodologies. In her own struggles, she challenges organizational communication and, by extension, work-family communication scholars to ground studies in situated approaches, to enrich intersectionalities beyond the race-class-gender mainstay, and to delve deeply into difference. In raising these accountability issues, Long and collaborators provide insight into the possibilities for radically transforming academe and in vital areas such as work-family communication.

To broaden research, →Traylor et al. (2020) advocate critical global research and methodologies that attend to unaddressed issues in work-life interfaces, working parenthood, and legal protections for working women using diverse and mixed methodologies. These methods, particularly with a communication focus, can delve into the findings of →Allen et al.'s (2020) first cross-sectional meta-analysis on work-family conflict in over 30 years of studying this phenomenon. Communication scholars should explore Allen et al.'s finding that "work-family conflict relationships differ in strength as a function of regional clusters" (2000: 539). For Allen et al., such findings can assist organizations in managing work-family conflict; for communication scholars, such contrastive studies also assist in sensemaking about the different ways people engage in productive-unproductive, satisfying-unsatisfying work-family processes from global and intersectional perspectives (e.g., →Cao and Zhang 2022; →Long, Selzer King, and Buzzanell 2018).

Third, ***policy*** communication offers opportunities to engage with policy as a constitutive knowledge construction process with multilevel foci. →Canary et al. (2018) found that

policy communication and outcomes are dependent on the organizational culture in which such policies are situated (e.g., cultures of compliance or innovation) and how policies were perceived (e.g., as barrier-resource, automated-personalized, punishment-protection) meaning that standardized training sessions on policies are not useful as tensions in activity systems as a whole and the different elements, such as division of labor, may offset those of others. Future research can investigate how work-life policies are constituted in hybrid organizations? What is the role of internal communication professionals in shaping and sharing these policies as well as providing opportunities for employee voice throughout policy development processes?

Bridging micro-macro contradictions by focusing on one level but attending to other levels provides insight into why and how policy designed to bring relief to work-family conflicts often fails to meet needs of particular groups. One-size-fits-all policy applications serve those already advantaged by current systems. →Schieman et al. (2021) found that average levels of work-life conflict decreased during the early pandemic months, but that households with children younger than 13 years did not experience this benefit on average. →Padavic, Ely, and Reid (2020) attack the question about how and why policies meant to promote women's advancement to highest levels have harmed these goals. They contend that two unchallenged Discourses – need for long hours and acceptance of women's stalled advancement – render policies ineffective. →Kossek and Lee (2020) seized the pandemic moment to contrast US work-family policy against those of other industrialized countries. They advocate for three evidence-based changes: national paid sick and family leave, emergency back-up staffing, and legal rights to request flexible reasonable work schedules in mutually beneficial employer-employee decision making.

3 Conclusion

In their 50-year review of work-family scholarship, →Kossek et al, (2021) noted that most work-family research focuses on women's careers and takes trade-off approaches that assume family-career incompatibilities. They recommend that researchers pursue integrative lenses that examine different lifespan and career processes situated in whole lives, diversity, and changing contexts. Our review and suggestions for future research and practice are compatible with and extend Kossek, Perrigino, and Rock's view by recommending that communication be the primary process whereby researchers and practitioners can understand how individuals through organizations and societies constitute and structure their worlds to create healthier and more sustainable work-family processes and outcomes by utilizing paradoxical mindsets and attendant action.

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Chapter 28 Military Exit and Reentry to Family, Society, and Work

William T. Howe

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Abstract

This chapter reviews recent literature on exiting the military and reentering civilian life from a communication standpoint. Many military veterans experience at least short-term challenges regarding finding civilian employment/housing, sustaining relationships with family/friends/coworkers, maintaining physical/psychological health, and finding a sense of purpose. The chapter begins by forwarding assumptions about the reintegration process and reviews existing interdisciplinary frameworks for studying this phenomenon. Following this, three communication theories are used to organize extant research and sketch future directions for exploring military-to-civilian transitions. First, the effects of the military, as a totalistic organization, on the lives of service members is discussed with an emphasis on the socialization processes which the military deploys to shape service members. Second, the communication theory of identity is presented to reveal the importance of military communication in the identity formation process. Third, the communication theory of resilience is reviewed, including how it offers a lens for evaluating attempts to build service members' resilience both during their time in service and after they have exited the military. The authors conclude by offering several lines for future research that could prove fruitful for organizational communication scholars who are looking to add their expertise to the issue of military veteran reintegration.

Keywords: reintegration, military-to-civilian transition, military veterans, military culture, totalistic organizations, high reliability organizations, organizational values, organizational socialization, organizational exit, communication theory of identity, communication theory of resilience, psychological resilience,

1 Military Exit and Reentry to Family, Society, and Work

Nearly 2.5 million Americans have served in the US military since the beginning of the post-9/11 conflicts and then exited back to civilian life (→Statistica 2021). Indeed, between 200,000 and 250,000 service members separate from the US military annually, which means that roughly 1,300 new veterans and their families return to civilian life each day (→Zogas 2017). Beyond the US, veterans regularly transition out of the military in many other societies as well.[1]

This chapter reviews organizational communication perspectives on military service member and veteran reintegration, defined as "both a process and outcome of resuming roles in family, community, and workplace which may be influenced at different levels of an ecological system" (Elnitsky, Fisher, and Blevins 2017a: 2). Although the study of reintegration is not new (e.g., →Waller 1944), research has exploded in the past decade (for reviews, see →Castro and Dursun 2019; Elnitsky, Fisher, and Blevins 2017a; Elnitsky et al. 2017b). More research to date has focused on active duty and/or National Guard/Reserve service members returning to their families and communities following wartime deployment than on veterans and their families separating from the military (→Hunniecutt 2020, →2022; →Mobbs and Bonanno 2018). Given the large numbers of service members who separate from the US military annually, we focus primarily on

veterans exiting the military while also including research on return from wartime deployment where relevant.

The reintegration literature is interdisciplinary, with relevant work from psychology, medicine/nursing, sociology/social work, education, and family studies. Organizational communication, with its rich streams of scholarship on socialization, identity, culture, and change, is well positioned to offer complementary insights about military exit and reentry to family, society, and work life. After reviewing existing reintegration models, we discuss how organizational as well as family and intercultural communication frameworks focused on socialization and totalistic organizations, identity layers and gaps, and transitions and resilience can contribute to this vital area. Given that military service members and veterans in the US are increasingly diverse in terms of gender, sexual orientation, and race/ethnicity (→Hunniecutt 2020, →2022; →Wilson et al. 2021a), we call for greater focus on the common and unique reentry experiences of diverse veterans throughout the chapter.

2 Military Service Member and Veteran Reintegration: An Overview

2.1 Assumptions about Reintegration

To clarify the concept of military and veteran reintegration, we highlight six assumptions that run through most work (e.g., Elnitsky, Fisher, and Blevins 2017a; →Pedlar, Thompson, and Castro 2019). First, reintegration involves adjustment and wellbeing across multiple domains. As Elnitsky, Fisher, and Blevins (2017a) explain, “reintegration refers to co-occurring psychological, social, health-related, and community-related functioning with one’s immediate veteran friends, family, and larger social groups” (p. 5). As an outcome, reintegration has

been assessed in terms of successful functioning in: behavioral and physical health; relationships with family/friends/coworkers; employment, housing, and finances; civic participation; and spirituality/sense of purpose (e.g., →Sayer et al. 2011).

Second, reintegration is characterized by challenges and opportunities. Exiting the military, "like all major life transitions, commonly is associated with identity disruption requiring psychological adaptation to an unfamiliar culture" (→Pedlar, Thompson, and Castro 2019: 54). Other common reintegration challenges pertain to health (e.g., substance abuse), interpersonal (e.g., maintaining relationships), community (e.g., belongingness at work/school/home), and societal (e.g., unlawful behavior) issues (→Ahern et al. 2015). Although reintegration challenges are magnified by behavioral health issues like post-traumatic stress (PTS),[2] many veterans experience challenges regardless of their mental health status (→Mobbs and Bonanno 2018; →Smith and True 2014). Reintegration also creates opportunities, such as when veterans call on a military "get it done" attitude while seeking civilian employment (→Cooper et al. 2018) or the value of "selfless service" as a motivation for community engagement (→Angel et al. 2018).

Third, reintegration occurs over time (→Pedlar, Thompson, and Castro 2019). Like many life transitions, the time frame for reintegration varies, and the process must be understood in light of prior transitions (e.g., moving from being a "civilian" to a "service member" after joining the military). A turning point analysis with military spouses whose service member recently returned from deployment showed that no single trajectory characterized participants' experiences, but many spouses experienced "ups and downs" over time (→Sahlstein Parcell and Maguire 2014). The same is likely true when exiting the military.

Fourth, reintegration should be understood within the context of specific conflicts. The wars in Afghanistan and Iraq represent the first time the US fought a two-front conflict with an all-volunteer force. Many service members deployed multiple times, and Guard/Reserve units played an unprecedented role leading to unique challenges upon return (→Ahern et al. 2015; →Orazem et al. 2017). Unlike during Vietnam, post-9/11 service members often remained with the same unit over time, which likely increased unit bonding but also feelings of disconnection after leaving the military (→Mobbs and Bonanno 2018). Due to advances in healthcare, troops were more likely to survive serious physical injuries than in previous conflicts, resulting in families of wounded warriors being thrust into caregiving roles (→Ramchand et al. 2014). Finally, many veterans express concern about a growing US military-civilian divide (Pew →Research Center 2011). Although US public support for military veterans runs high, many Americans say that the Afghanistan and Iraq conflicts had little impact on their own lives and many veterans feel misunderstood, stereotyped, and disconnected from civilians (→Wilson and Chernichky 2016).

Fifth, reintegration is a heterogenous experience. Life course perspectives stress that vulnerability to reintegration challenges is shaped by life before military service (e.g., adverse childhood experiences), during service (e.g., combat, military sexual trauma), during transition (e.g., medical retirement), and after service (e.g., exiting during a recession), as well as personal characteristics (e.g., negative coping strategies; →Duel et al. 2019). For →example, Hunniecutt (2020, →2022), who served in the Virginia National Guard but did not deploy abroad, questioned whether reintegration challenges she experienced were connected to military service given that she was not a prototypical veteran (i.e., a male with combat experience). Her story reinforces calls to move from focusing only on combat exposure and PTS to exploring a

range of transitions stressors that create reintegration vulnerability (→Mobbs and Bonanno 2018; →Smith and True 2014).

Finally, reintegration impacts not only veterans but their families (→Knobloch, Knobloch-Fedders, and Yorgason 2019; →Wilson et al. 2011). Many military spouses and children, just like service members, define their social identities and positively distinguish themselves from "civilians" based on military culture (→Wilson and Chernichky 2016), and may experience identity disruption when exiting the military. Leaving the military also has tangible implications (e.g., changes in employment, healthcare, housing, and/or schooling) for family members.

2.2 Existing Theories and Frameworks

Several frameworks have been proposed to explain veteran reintegration processes/outcomes (see →Pedlar, Thompson, and Castro 2019). In addition to the aforementioned life course perspective (e.g., →Duel et al. 2019), Elnitsky et al. (2017b) present a social-ecological model that views veterans "as interacting in and with their environment and posits that an individual is impacted by four levels of influence (i.e., individual, interpersonal, community, and societal); the factors at these levels may act directly or synergistically with one another" (p. 115). During reintegration, individual-level risk and protective factors include physical/psychological health and military identity. Veteran friendships and marital (dis)satisfaction illustrate interpersonal factors. Community-level factors include healthcare systems and job training programs, whereas DOD policies and public attitudes illustrate societal-level factors.

→Cooper et al. (2018) present a military-to-civilian transition model based on Bourdieu's concepts of habitus, fields, and capital. Habitus "refers to a system of unconscious

dispositions formed through regular social encounters and experiences which generates perceptions and actions within cultural settings" (→Cooper et al. 2018: 161), and thus tends to endure over time while also being shaped by ongoing experiences. Habitus is developed within fields, or "the social spaces that people inhabit [...] a field is a distinct social microcosm, underpinned by its own set of rules, regularities, and structures of authority" (p. 161). The authors conceptualize the military as a field and the civilian world as a collection of alternative fields, most of which have different rules and logics. Becoming a competent actor in a field "allows one to accrue capital, which is understood as resources at stake in that field" (p. 162). Capital may be cultural (e.g., skills), economic (e.g., wealth), and social (e.g., connections formed through membership in a social group). Leaving the military, or moving between fields, is shaped by habitus and whether cultural capital developed in the military can be transformed to civilian life.

Existing theories have strengths and limitations. Moving beyond the individual level, Elnitsky et al.'s (2017b) ecological model "acknowledges that reintegration depends on the functioning of the larger system" (p. 116). →Cooper et al.'s (2018) "Bourdieusian" model highlights the roles that culture, identity, and capital play during the transition from military to civilian life. Yet neither model foregrounds communication. Elnitsky and colleagues mention communication only when discussing how cell phones and social media have changed opportunities for communication during military deployment. Cooper et al.'s only reference occurs when they note that "military and civilian fields require different sets of cultural competencies [...] and are characterized by different ways of communicating and relating to others" (p. 163). To complement existing theories, we discuss insights gained by conceptualizing veteran reintegration using communication frameworks focused on: (a) socialization and totalistic

organizations (→Hinderaker 2015; →Jablin 2001), (b) the communication theory of identity (Hecht 2015), and (c) theories of resilience during transitions (→Buzzanell 2019).

3 Totalistic Organizations, Socialization, and the United States Military

The United States Military (USM) has been identified by organizational communication researchers as a totalistic organization (→Howe and Hinderaker 2018). The intense socialization process of the USM creates a deeply identified membership who must abide by the strict rules and resources (→Knight 1990; →Shpeer and Howe 2020). Taken together, totalistic organization and socialization scholarship help explain how and why former military members often have difficulty reintegrating to civilian life (→Howe and Shpeer 2019).

3.1 Totalistic Organizations

Totalistic organizations differ from traditional organizations in that they "often require complete member loyalty, often publically [sic] declared upon induction into the organization" (→Hinderaker 2015: 93), such as military oaths taken prior to joining the USM. Organizations which meet these qualifications have been studied for years; however, →Hinderaker (2015) was the first to codify the term totalistic in relation to organizational communication. Since this initial conception, a variety of totalistic organizations have been studied including the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints (→Hinderaker 2015) and the Independent Fundamental Baptist Church (→Howe and Hinderaker 2018). Although many studies are focused on religious organizations, →Hinderaker (2015) theorized many members of high reliability organizations (HROs, or organizations that operate in perilous

environments but have few catastrophic incidents) “like faith community members, carry the values, beliefs, and identity assumed in the organization into their daily lives” (p. 95), although some HROs may not require such a deep commitment such as medical professionals or airline pilots. Hinderaker found the exit process of two HROs, police and firefighters, was similar to that of the Mormon church.

The USM is also an HRO. In fact, →Weick and Sutcliffe (2015) credit studies on the flight decks of aircraft carriers with the foundational insights into HRO theorizing (see also →Scott, Howe, and Bisel 2022). →Weick and Sutcliffe (2015) sought to distill their rich findings into a “workable set of principles” (p. 2). They write: “One pattern that seemed to recur was a sustained focus on small failures, less abstract specifics, ongoing operations, alternative pathways to keep going, and the mobilization of expertise” (p. 2). →Hinderaker (2015) provides evidence as to how these principles are communicatively inculcated into the thought processes of HRO members. Similarly, →Howe and Hinderaker (2018) compared the USM with the ultraconservative Independent Fundamental Baptist Church and found several similarities in how these two organizations onboarded new recruits or converts to the organization. One of the ways churches foster belief in sacred texts is through the memorization of scripture. The USM also has new members memorize written materials such as military values, the oath of enlistment, general orders, and cadence calls.

Cadence calls, also known as Jody calls, are ways to keep time and step when marching or running. Such calls socialize service members for their purpose in the USM. →Knight (1990) states: “Certainly the form of the jodies, wherein one person calls out a line and the platoon or company repeats it, resonates with the military principles of instant obedience and suppression of individuality” (p. 163). Knight’s observations align with →Hinderaker’s (2015) reasoning of totalistic

organizations requiring complete member loyalty. In sum, the entry and exit socialization processes of the USM are similar to those in other totalistic organizations.

3.2 Socialization

Many studies of military communication, from an organizational perspective, focus on organizational socialization. For example, →Shpeer and Howe (2020) use the theoretical model of socialization and concepts of facework and identity to examine how communication strategies military members learn during basic training may prove problematic during reintegration. Such an approach appears justified as separating from the military is a form of organizational exit.

→Jablin (2001) outlined how individuals seek, join, assimilate, and leave organizations. Researchers have examined, either explicitly or implicitly, all four phases in the context of the USM. Work on anticipatory socialization tends to revolve around why individuals choose to enter the military (e.g., →Howe and Bisel 2020) and the encounter phase is frequently studied by examining basic training experiences (e.g., →Knight 1990). Metamorphosis or role negotiation is perhaps the most understudied socialization stage from an organizational perspective as access can prove difficult. Family communication scholars have researched this stage by examining how families renegotiate roles and relationships after service members return home from war (e.g., →Knobloch, Knobloch-Fedders, and Yorgason 2019; →Wilson et al. 2011), as well as how service members and families manage stigma, privacy, and dilemmas in talking about mental health (e.g., →Wilson et al. 2015, →2021a). Having said this, socialization research on communication *at* work, as opposed to *about* work, is lacking. The findings of many military scholars examining anticipatory socialization,

encounter, and entry align with research on totalistic organizations, but the exit process may be where research on totalistic organizations aligns best.

Exit stands in stark contrast to the other three socialization stages, as it is perhaps the most frequently studied phase in research on totalistic organizations. Unlike traditional organizations, totalistic organizations have a long and protracted exit process. →Kramer (2010) noted that scholars tend to pair organizational socialization research with other theoretical underpinnings, such as social identity theory or uncertainty management theory. →Howe and Bisel (2020) followed this method in examining stories that individuals, who claimed veteran status, posted online about the USM. In their first study the researchers found whether a story that portrayed the military favorably was the strongest predictor of how readers numerically rated the story. A second study found numerical ratings of anonymous reviews posted to job search site indeed.com about the US Air Force, Army, and Navy were significantly and positively associated with the frequency other users found this information useful. When the authors performed the same analysis with Apple, Bank of America, and Michelin, they found Bank of America and Michelin had a significant and negative relationship, whereas Apple had a non-significant relationship. The authors theorize: “membership in the U.S. Military is somewhat unique in that professional identification and organizational identification align strongly because a soldier or sailor cannot perform that identity and salient group membership in other organizations (within the U.S.)” (p. 7). For example, employees who leave a traditional organization for a competitor might experience dissonance when reading a positive review of their original organization, but members of totalistic organizations such as the military tend to carry the values and norms even after exiting, leaving them more likely to appreciate positive reviews. The idea that military members have unique identity

needs is not new, although application of this idea to review ratings in online spaces likely is new.

One specific identity need may be the necessity of reconciling the war or deployed identity with the professional identity upon returning home. Totalistic organizational theorists have written pieces which, if applied to this military setting, could help military communication theorists better understand this phenomenon. →McNamee and Gould (2019) explored the challenges totalistic members face when leaving specific roles within the organization. Their study investigated missionaries who had been abroad and were returning to their home country. Such a role exit clearly aligns with what service members face when returning home after deployment. For example, a combat medic can operate on fellow service members, civilians, and the enemy while deployed in country, but upon returning stateside medics cannot provide medical aid beyond CPR, as their civilian license is a basic EMT. Additionally, while deployed to a combat zone nearly all service members are required to carry a weapon, but when returning to the US only military police are allowed to carry weapons on base. Thus, →McNamee and Gould's (2019) findings on role exit may be transferrable to military communication research.

→Cramer, Tenzek, and Allen (2015) provide insights about the relationship between successfully exiting the USM and religion that also could spur future research. These scholars summarize a 2011 Pew Research Center finding "[r]eligious beliefs, measured by frequent attendance at religious services, proved to be the foremost factor leading to easier reentry for post-9/11 veterans" (p. 82). Combining this idea with →Hinderaker's (2015) conceptualization of totalistic organizations provides interesting suggestions as to how veterans may experience successful reintegration. →Cramer, Tenzek, and Allen (2015) focus on the role chaplains play in successful reintegration. However, there may be other factors

that help explain how religious attendance assists with veteran reintegration beyond spiritual needs alone. Perhaps veterans who attend religious services are reducing loneliness and rebuilding social support, factors associated with resilience (→Wilson et al. 2021b). Another explanation might be the strict and totalistic structure of many religious organizations could replace the strict structure of the military in the veteran's life (→Howe and Hinderaker 2018). Most religious organizations have a sacred text, similar to the Uniform Code of Military Justice (UCMJ), a hierarchal command structure, similar to the USM, and a reliance on direct and absolute communication, often found in military settings. Perhaps adhering to clearly defined doctrine reduces uncertainty for military veterans upon reentry to society and civilian workplaces. Such theorization is speculative but may provide new ideas of how organizational scholars can approach the study of this transitional period. Researchers could consider recruiting recently separated service members and having them journal their experiences reentering society over time. Such a study could clarify whether and how religious participation, as well as other forms of social activity, play a role in the reintegration process.

4 Communication Theory of Identity and the United States Military

The USM is grounded in a unique cultural identity stemming from values and norms instilled during basic training (→Mobbs and Bonanno 2018; →Shpeer and Howe 2020). Dating back to its creation as a professional fighting force during the Revolutionary War, the USM has focused on order and discipline as fundamental building blocks for a successful military force (→Shay 2009). Such a strict entry process creates new norms, values, and habits for service members which in turn create new ways to communicate, think, and act (→Howe

and Hinderaker 2018; →Shpeer and Howe 2020; →Hunniecutt 2022). The new identity that begins to form does not completely supplant the personal identity which existed before but creates a new group identity which can act with or against other identity needs. The communication theory of identity (CTI) offers a useful way to understand military identity, as CTI proposes four interrelated identity frames.

Hecht (2015) proposed CTI as an alternative way of thinking about identity. Traditional theories of identity (e.g., social identity theory) focus on ingroup and outgroup members but Hecht theorized that group memberships are only part of an individual's identity. Hecht supplied four identity frames – personal, relational, communal, and enacted – which influence how individuals communicate their identity to others and theorized that these frames are interrelated, interpenetrated, and often in tension. The personal frame "denotes how an individual defines him- or her-self" (Hecht 2015: 178), including unique experiences or attributes that distinguish the individual from others as well as group-based identities (e.g., race/ethnicity, gender) that may be a salient part of the individual's self-concept in particular contexts. The relational frame refers to how identities are influenced by the presence of other individuals (i.e., how others see us) and how identities emerge and are developed within relationships. The communal frame focuses on "how society defines identity and identities" (p. 179) through media representations, education, and organizational socialization. Finally, the enacted frame highlights a dramaturgical perspective on how people perform identities as well as constraints on identity performance. Military membership may influence multiple identity frames simultaneously. For example, a service member may personally identify as conservative, liberal, or somewhere in between, but military oaths and articles of the Uniform Code of Military Justice influence how military members can express those political beliefs. Here we can see

the personal (i.e., political beliefs), communal (i.e., military membership), and enactment (i.e., structural constraints) influencing how service members portray their identity. In sum, military identity does not have a unique relationship with any singular identity frame but can influence different frames based on the context of interaction. If these identity frames align the member can communicate in ways true to their identity, but if frames do not align the member may experience tensions in how various identity frames interpenetrate.

→Jung and Hecht (2004) conceptualize such identity frame misalignments as “identity gaps”. For example, veterans may experience conflicts between how they see themselves (personal level) and how close others see them (relational level), or between how they perform the veteran role (enacted level) and who society expects to be a veteran (communal level). Jung and Hecht found that as identity gaps (i.e., the difference between two or more frames) increased ratings of communication satisfaction, feeling understood, and communication competence decreased. The authors concluded “identity gaps may also have potential associations with psychological issues such as depression and behavioral issues such as drug use and violent behavior” (p. 280). CTI’s ability to explain these outcomes is important because the reintegration literature focuses on such outcomes when assessing veteran wellbeing (Elnitsky, Fisher, and Blevins 2017a).

Literature already links reintegration difficulties with challenges in identity adjustment after military exit (→Hunniecutt 2022; →Meca et al. 2021; →Orazem et al. 2017; →Smith and True 2014). →Orazem and colleagues (2017) recruited a diverse, national sample of 100 USM veterans who self-reported some level of reintegration difficulty. These veterans were instructed to write about “your deepest thoughts and feelings about your transition to civilian life,

including the challenges you are currently facing and the reasons for these challenges" (p. 6). Five themes emerged: (a) feeling like you do not belong, (b) missing the military, (c) negative views of civilians, (d) feeling left behind, and (e) difficulty finding meaning. Gender differences did not emerge, but veterans who had served on active duty versus National Guard/Reserves differed in the nature of some themes (e.g., for the latter group, "feeling left behind" meant that civilian coworkers had progressed while guard members were gone; for the former group, it meant adjusting to an adult civilian world they had never known given they joined the military in their teens or early 20s).

Building on other work on identity adjustment, several recent articles provide initial empirical evidence of CTI's ability to explain military service member and veteran reintegration. →LeBlanc and Olson (2015) found military veterans, who had deployed, experienced difficulties communicating with their children due to stranger anxiety, and also engaged in topic avoidance with family after deployment. The authors argue that military members often have to significantly change their communication style with family, as opposed to how they communicated in military settings, creating a gap between personal and relational frames.

Grounded in CTI theorizing, →Howe (2020) developed a "veteran contempt for civilian communication" (VCCC) scale. Contempt is a moral emotion defined as "a strong aversion similar to disgust, cool disregard, or amused dismissiveness" (→Bell 2013: 27). Howe argues that an aversion to communicating with civilians represents a communal-personal identity gap, in that veterans feel tension between how they personally feel people should communicate and perceived civilian communication norms. Based on a review of qualitative research and pilot data, scale items assess veteran perceptions that civilians "beat around the bush when they talk", and "get their feelings hurt too easily when arguing", as

well as that communicating with civilians “is a waste of time” (→Howe and Bisel 2023: 12–13). →Howe (2020) found these items factored into two related but distinct subdimensions termed “formative” (i.e., an implicit or developing negative evaluation of civilian communication norms) and “summative” (i.e., an explicit, global negative evaluation of civilian norms). Veterans who scored higher on the VCCC reported greater reintegration difficulties and loneliness as well as stronger identification with a “military” rather than “civilian” identity.

Finally, →Howe and Hartsough (2021) explored three identity gaps military members and veterans reported experiencing with their romantic partners: (a) personal-communal (operationalized with an adapted version of the VCCC), (b) personal-relational (e.g., “I am different from the way my partner sees me”), and (c) personal-enacted (e.g., “I do not reveal important aspects of myself in my communication with my partner”). Results revealed that, controlling for sociodemographic factors, the VCCC summative subscale as well as personal-relational and personal-enacted gaps all were significantly and negatively associated with romantic relationship closeness and satisfaction.

The aforementioned studies do not stand alone but echo findings from other CTI work. For example, →Hecht and Faulkner (2000) found Jewish Americans are often faced with decisions about whether to reveal their Jewish identity due to perceived risk of negative stereotyping, thereby creating a gap between personal and enactment frames. →Phillips et al. (2018) found family members who felt they could not be true to their personal identity, because of the sway of enactment and relational frames, were less likely to be committed to the family.

In sum, CTI studies highlight the importance of studying how military identity, identity gaps, and communication outcomes are related, as such an understanding could help offer insights about veteran health and wellbeing. For

example, →Meca et al. (2021) recently found military veterans who reported higher commitment to their personal identity (i.e., felt comfortable with their goals and plans) as well as national identity (i.e., knew what being an “American” meant to them and were proud of that) were significantly less likely to have PTS symptoms, depression, anxiety, substance abuse, and suicidal ideation. However, veterans who reported a strong military identity (i.e., being a veteran was an important part of their self-image) reported more PTS symptoms. Caution is warranted given the cross-sectional data, and a strong military identity in some cases may play a protective role when life disruptions occur (see the next section on resilience). However, if veterans with a strong military identity tend to experience more identity gaps after exiting the military, then CTI should continue to offer a useful framework for analyzing potential reintegration challenges. Future studies of the military could investigate the constitutive nature of communication in widening and narrowing identity gaps at varying socialization stages and within various relationships (e.g., coworkers, family). Researchers could investigate these gaps by observing how veterans and civilians interact in family, community, and/or workplace contexts including how civilian communication may inhibit or empower military identity performance and how this relates to conflict or comfort.

5 Transitions, Resilience, and the United States Military

5.1 Transitions and Transition Assistance Programs

As documented throughout this chapter, exiting the military and reintegrating to civilian life involves a series of transitions. Transitions are nothing new for service members and their families; indeed, military life is characterized by frequent

transitions such as when service members deploy and then must reintegrate after returning home or receive new duty assignments that require their entire family to relocate. Despite this, the military-to-civilian transition can be stressful (→Mobbs and Bonanno 2018). Most service members exiting the USM are enlisted personnel, who tend to be younger and have less formal education than officers (→Zogas 2017). Compared to the elaborated entry process, formal preparation for exit is brief. Under the transition assistance program (TAP), service members receive four hours of pre-separation counseling and five days of classroom education about topics such as enrolling for healthcare with the Department of Veteran's Affairs (VA) and educational benefits, job placement counseling, and effects of career changes on families (→Congressional Research Service 2017). Despite the expansion of TAP in recent years, "the program's effectiveness is limited by its brevity, and by the fact that veterans complete the program weeks before they are released from their military contracts" (→Zogas 2017: 5).

Following separation, a variety of federal agencies (e.g., Department of Veterans Affairs, Small Business Administration) along with nonprofits (e.g., Student Veterans of America) offer education and employment assistance, physical and behavioral healthcare, and caregiving support to veterans and their families (Fossey et al. 2019). Although stressful, most veterans successfully navigate the military-to-civilian transition over time. However, veterans who (a) experienced adverse childhood events before joining, (b) experienced physical injury, trauma, or discrimination during their service, (c) discharged unpredictably (e.g., due to medical complications or misconduct), (d) have a military occupational specialty less transferable to civilian contexts, or (e) exit during a recession are vulnerable to reintegration challenges (→Duel et al. 2019; Elnitsky et al. 2017b). Given its process and multilevel focus, the communication theory of

resilience (CTR; →Buzzanell 2019) has the potential to offer important insights about both reintegration challenges and successes.

5.2 Communication Theory of Resilience (CTR)

Within military contexts, resilience has been conceptualized as (a) a *trait* (e.g., hardiness) that protects service members or veterans who have been exposed to adversity, (b) a *skill* that can be learned to help prepare service members and veterans for future adversity, and (c) a *psychological process* that enables service members and veterans to adapt and sustain wellbeing in the face of adversity (→Britt, Sinclair, and McFadden 2013). The focus on "psychological resilience" in the military literature (→McGarry, Walklate, Mythem 2015) creates space for complimentary perspectives such as CTR that conceptualize resilience as an interrelated communicative process.

CTR defines resilience as "a constitutive process through which people reintegrate and actively create a new normal though language, interaction, networks, and attention to identities and identification, within their material environments and societal discourses" (→Buzzanell 2019: 68). According to CTR, resilience is activated when trigger events disrupt people's lives, creating a sense of loss accompanied by negative emotions. Regarding reentry to civilian life, triggers could include difficulty finding a job or navigating school, conflict with family/friends, physical/behavioral health issues, and insensitive questions from civilians (e.g., Elnitsky et al. 2017b; →Wilson and Chernichky 2016).

CTR proposes people enact resilience via five processes. *Crafting normalcy* involves interacting in ways that create a sense things are (getting back to) "normal", such as by enacting rituals and creating new routines. When service members deployed abroad, military spouses crafted normalcy

by maintaining couple/family routines (e.g., watching and talking about their loved ones favorite TV shows) as well as creating new rituals (e.g., marking a calendar for each day that passed; →Villagran, Canzona, and Ledford 2013). *Affirming identity anchors* involves performing identities (e.g., military spouse, career professional) that may be challenged yet offer meaning and guidance during disruption. *Maintaining and using communication networks* involves reaching out to strong and weak network ties for support. Reframing the meaning of a situation and using humor to lighten the mood illustrate *constructing alternative logics*. Military spouses "discussed how living in new cities all the time, away from family, required them to embrace the craziness of their life as an adventure" (→Villagran, Canzona, and Ledford 2013: 784), thus reframing disruptions as something they could celebrate. Finally, *foregrounding productive action* involves legitimizing negative feelings associated with disruption, while still choosing to focus on steps that will help accomplish important future goals. Spouses described a variety of tactics for foregrounding productive action (e.g., staying busy) but felt less able to validate negative feelings given a perceived norm that military spouses should "do our time with a smile" (→Villagran, Canzona, and Ledford 2013: 785).

Two other CTR elements merit brief mention. Although it does not conceptualize resilience as a trait, CTR recognizes that people learn lessons from navigating previous disruptions that they carry forward (i.e., anticipatory resilience). When individuals recall memorable messages about how they or loved ones got through past disruptions, they are more likely to report enacting resilience processes during future disruptions (→Kuang et al. 2023). Finally, CTR recognizes that resilience is created in the context of material conditions (e.g., physical disabilities; →Ramchand et al. 2014) and societal discourses (e.g., stereotypes such as "All veterans have PTSD") that shape and constrain how processes unfold.

To date, CTR has not been applied to military-to-civilian transitions, but studies with civilian samples show the extent to which people engage in CTR processes in response to a variety of disruptions is associated with individual and relational wellbeing (→Kuang et al. 2023; →Wilson et al. 2021b).

CTR offers a lens for evaluating attempts to build service members' resilience before, as well as after, military exit. Taking a skill-building approach, the US Army's Comprehensive Soldier Fitness (CSF) program aims to develop "cognitive resources and communication and reasoning skills in order to help soldiers thrive in the face of challenges inherent in Army life" (→Lester, McBride, and Cornum 2013: 194). CSF has four components: (a) a Global Assessment Tool (GAT), where soldiers periodically receive feedback on strengths and opportunities for growth in social-cognitive skills, emotion regulation, social and family networks, and ability to find meaning in work/life, (b) a menu of online training modules targeting these skills, (c) training sessions hosted by their military unit, led by "Master Resilience Trainers" (MRTs, i.e., non-commissioned officers who learn to lead sessions via a "train the trainer" model), and (d) institutionalized training, where psychological resilience is discussed during every professional development course offered to leaders. By 2013, the GAT had been administered more than 2 million times, thousands of MRTs had been trained, and 160,000 soldiers had completed at least one online module (→Lester, McBride, and Cornum 2013). In 2012, the program was rebranded "Comprehensive Soldier and Family Fitness" (CSF2), but uptake by military family members has been slow. →Cacioppo et al. (2015) report a randomized clinical trial showing soldiers in platoons that received a one-week CSF training session reported small but significant increases in perspective-taking and hardiness and decreased social isolation relative to those in platoons that received

unrelated education sessions. CSF represents an attempt to build anticipatory resilience soldiers can take forward when they encounter challenges after separating from the military. Research might explore whether intensity of CSF participation is associated with enactment of resilience processes during exit. Critics question whether focusing on psychological resilience downplays social factors (e.g., the USM as a totalistic organization) when preparing service members for challenges involved in reintegrating to civilian life (→McGarry, Walklate, Mythem 2015).

Many nonprofits support veterans during the military-to-civilian transition. For example, Team Red, White, and Blue (RWB) was "created to help veterans encountering reintegration challenges establish robust social connections with their local communities" (→Angel et al. 2018: 555). Founded in 2010, the organization had grown to include 210 chapters and 123,000 members by 2016. Team RWB emphasizes three core principles: (a) health (e.g., opportunities for members to connect through physical fitness activities, as well as a broad focus on transition stressors rather than only PTS to avoid stigma), (b) people (enhancing strong and weak ties, through an inclusive membership that includes diverse veterans but also their families and nonveteran community members), and (c) purpose (both individually in the form of goal-directed behavior and collectively as group cohesion and belonging). According to →Angel et al. (2018), initial evaluation results are promising and more rigorous evaluations are underway. Multiple CTR processes (e.g., performing identity anchors, maintaining/using communication networks, foregrounding productive action) are evident in Team RWB's core principles and activities; the program also places a high priority on bridging military-civilian divides. Research could explore if CTR processes mediate associations between RWB participation and reintegration outcomes, and whether participation leads

veterans to be less likely to voice discourses (e.g., communicating with civilians is a waste of time) that impede reintegration.

6 Conclusion and Future Directions

Almost 80 years ago →Waller (1944) wrote: “A [person] who has once been a soldier can never quite be a civilian again. A military experience, especially in time of war, leaves a mark upon a [person]. If we are to understand the veteran, we must learn what [they] experience as a soldier” (p. 18). In 2021 we have more information about the experiences of service members, yet we still see veterans struggle with reintegration. Organizational communication scholars studying socialization, identity gaps, and resilience are uniquely positioned to contribute theoretical and applied scholarship on service member and veteran reintegration. We close by highlighting two conclusions made salient by our review.

First, organizational communication research offers an important complement to existing work on veteran reintegration. When the writings of →Jablin (2001) and →Hinderaker (2015) are considered in conjunction with the assumptions of reintegration provided by Elnitsky and colleagues (2017b), we can see how the process of reintegration often is more difficult than exit from traditional organizations. For example, veterans commonly experience identity disruptions when exiting the military (→Howe and Shpeer 2019; →Orazem et al. 2017; →Smith and True 2014). CTI research shows that when veterans experience tensions between identity layers, they are more likely to report feelings of disconnection, relationship challenges, and PTS symptoms (→Howe and Hartsough 2021; →Angel et al. 2018), whereas CTR suggests that when veterans and their families affirm identity anchors (→Buzzanell 2019) via involvement in service organizations, they create resilience in the face of such

disruptions (→Angel et al. 2018). Future research should clarify when strong identification with the military impedes versus enhances reintegration, using longitudinal and/or experimental designs where possible given that most studies to date have been cross-sectional (e.g., →Howe and Bisel 2023). Organizational scholars have the tools and knowledge to develop programs that help both former service members and civilians find areas of commonality as well as appreciate difference. Research should also explore how military identity intersects with other social identities (e.g., gender, race/ethnicity, sexual orientation) during reintegration, as veterans become increasingly diverse over time (→Hunniecutt 2020, →2022; →Wilson et al. 2021a).

Second, the military reintegration literature is interdisciplinary; hence, academic organizations such as the Veterans Studies Association play a vital role in helping pull together work by scholars from different disciplines. Organizational communication scholars could be an integral part of that conversation, but others are unlikely to find our work unless we make proactive efforts to connect. Interdisciplinary conversations hold the promise of offering new insights about organizational communication as well as about supporting military veterans.

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Notes

1 Most research on veteran reintegration to date has focused on the US, and hence our chapter primarily does so as well. For comparative analyses of military veteran reintegration, see →Castro and Dursun (2019).

2 PTS is used throughout this piece as a more inclusive term. PTSD is a clinically diagnosed mental disorder, but PTS is a natural response to trauma (see →Bender 2018 for more information).

Chapter 29 Corporate Social Responsibility Communication

W. Timothy Coombs

Sherry J. Holladay

Abstract

Corporate social responsibility (CSR) has quickly become an established element of business life and spawned the vibrant field of CSR communication. CSR emphasizes how all stakeholders, not just those with a financial stake in an organization, are important to an organization and the need for managers to be cognizant of the relationship of their organization to society. We center the chapter on locating CSR communication within a web of connections with other areas of organizational communication including reputation management, internal communication, risk communication, issues management, and crisis communication. This context is important to understanding CSR communication's role in an organization. From this context, we consider the utility of transmedia storytelling to CSR communication and identify future research directions for CSR communication. We argue the attention on future CSR communication should consider the movement away from focusing on business-related outcomes of CSR to societal and environmental outcomes. Future research should prioritize examining the social and environmental outcomes from CSR efforts and how to communicate this information to organizational stakeholders.

Keywords: corporate social responsibility, corporate social irresponsibility, engagement, stakeholders, risk, crisis communication, issues management, social issues, internal

communication, reputation, transmedia storytelling, storyworld, business case, web of relationships, organizational purpose,

Corporate social responsibility (CSR), like many academic terms, has no agreed-upon definition and is considered a contested term (→Verk, Golob, and Podnar 2021). Yet CSR has moved rapidly from a niche area in research and practice to a vibrant research area and core element of business practice (→Golob et al. 2013). Communication has emerged as a central variable in the CSR research resulting in the development of CSR communication. CSR communication is a multifaceted and multidisciplinary area of study attracting researchers from public relations, organizational communication, management, and marketing (→Verk, Golob, and Podnar 2021). The range of CSR communication research includes the utilization of social media, CSR reporting, the effects on stock valuations, employee engagement, stakeholder activism, corporate-NGO partnerships, and the effects on corporate reputation.

CSR was born from the realization that corporations have a responsibility beyond making a profit meaning a variety of stakeholders should matter to an organization (→Golob et al. 2013). For this chapter, we are treating CSR broadly, as the voluntary actions of organizations that demonstrate the ability and willingness to meet the financial, social, and environmental expectations of multiple stakeholders while fulfilling its purpose. CSR communication can be taken as the utilization of communication "between firms and their stakeholders in shaping CSR meanings, expectations and practices" (→Crane and Glozer 2016: 1224). CSR communication is essential because it is what creates CSR (→Golob et al. 2013). These definitions cast a wide net. Previous reviews have documented various streams of research with CSR communication (→Crane and Glozer 2016; →Golob et al. 2013; →Morsing 2017) and the dynamic nature

of the field (→Verk, Golob, and Podnar 2021). We build upon the previous reviews by shifting the focus to how CSR communication intersects with other elements of organizational communication. By embedding CSR communication within its relationships with other communication areas, we hope to illuminate key concerns in CSR communication and to identify fruitful lines of future research for CSR communication.

1 The Evolution from Business-centric to Society-centric CSR Research

It is important contextually to understand how views of CSR have evolved because that evolution affects CSR communication (→Verk, Golob, and Podnar 2021). The business case has been central to CSR and a source of critique (→Golob et al. 2013). The business case for engaging in CSR reflects an instrumental, managerial orientation that elevates CSR to a strategic factor in the management of organizations. The premise is that "organizations do well by doing good". The business case in large part relies on people's awareness of the organization's CSR efforts. Positive organizational outcomes from CSR include attracting investors and partners, risk management, impression management, positive stakeholder relations, and attracting and retaining talented employees, all of which are expected to contribute to financial performance. Though shareholders are important stakeholders because of their influence on organizational decision-making and financial stakes, other external and internal stakeholders such as employees, community members, consumers, suppliers, governments, civil society organizations, activist/interest groups, regulators, and media can influence an organization's success.

Though the business-centric approach focuses on how the organization prospers through its CSR, the business case

necessarily implicates the interconnectedness of the three Ps of the triple bottom line (→Elkington 1998) – profit, people, and planet. →Wickert (2021) has described CSR research as evolving from a business-centric perspective to a society-centric perspective focused on tangible social and environmental outcomes. Society-centric research draws upon systems theory to view organizations as embedded in a web of relationships influenced by institutional pressures and stakeholder expectations. An organization responds to these pressures for greater responsibility and legitimacy but recognizes these are dynamic (e.g., →Scherer and Palazzo 2011; →Scherer, Palazzo, and Seidl 2013).

2 CSR Communication Connecting with Organizational Communication

CSR communication is linked to a number of related areas within organizational communication. One way to organize and to understand CSR communication is to embed it within these ties to other areas of organizational communication. The three areas with the strongest ties are: (1) risk and crisis communication; (2) issues management; and (3) employee (internal) communication. The first two are related to external communication while the third pertains to internal communication. Though these links to other areas of organizational communication help to integrate CSR communication into the larger field, there is a risk of identity loss as well. The danger lies in considering CSR communication to be “just another variable” in a more established area of organizational communication rather than a unique type of organizational communication. A review of how CSR communication connects to the three areas of risk and crisis communication, issues management, and employee communication illustrates the advantages and disadvantages of such connections. A discussion of the relationship between

CSR and reputation is essential to appreciating how CSR links to these other areas of organizational communication.

2.1 CSR Communication and Reputation

Reputation is how the organization is perceived by stakeholders that represent collective perceptions that are socially constructed (→Pollock et al. 2019). The connection between CSR communication and reputation reflects the business case for CSR. CSR can facilitate favorable social evaluations. Reputations are intangible assets that enhance organizational performance. However, organizations only experience the benefits of CSR on reputations when stakeholders are aware of the CSR activities (→Bhattacharya, Sen, and Korschun 2011). As →Bhattacharya, Sen, and Korschun (2011) noted, CSR communication is the missing link in this dynamic. The problem is that dynamic is more complicated than a simple transmission effect – CSR communication does not equal positive outcomes (→Golob et al. 2013). Stakeholders can react differently to CSR efforts. Some stakeholders might view them positively while others see them negatively. The CSR communication may be viewed as hypocritical, causing a backlash such as charges of greenwashing. Or stakeholders may simply dislike organizations spending time and money on hyping their good works (→Coombs and Holladay 2012a).

2.2 CSR, Risk, and Crisis Communication

Risk is the potential to do harm while a *crisis* can be viewed as the realization or manifestation of a risk (→Heath and Palenchar 2009). Both risks and crises are subjective. People interpret risk rather than accept scientific quantification of risk (→Covello 1998). A *crisis* can be defined as the perceived violation of stakeholder expectations that creates negative

outcomes for stakeholders affected by the crisis and the organization in crisis. Risk and crisis communication are closely related and often occur simultaneously (→Coombs 2022).

CSR communication entered the discussion of crisis communication as an asset during a crisis. Following the logic of a favorable reputation creating a halo that protects organizations during a crisis (→Ulmer 2001), engaging in CSR communication prior to a crisis was argued to create a buffer that protected an organization's reputation during a crisis (→Kim and Yang 2009). However, the design of the research study only demonstrated a difference between engaging in or not engaging in CSR and could not specify which of the two factors drove the results. →Zhou and Ki (2018) utilized a stronger design to demonstrate that a halo effect from CSR communication is unlikely. This mirrors results of earlier crisis communication research that found it was the negative prior reputation, not the positive prior reputation, that drove perceptions of post-crisis reputations (→Coombs and Holladay 2007). Thus, prior CSR communication became just a variation of the prior reputation variable in crisis communication research.

CSR communication also has been offered as a crisis response strategy – how an organization responds to a crisis (→McDonnell and King 2013). A CSR communication strategy finds the organization responding to a crisis by discussing either past or present CSR efforts. However, using a CSR response strategy in isolation is problematic because it ignores victim concerns, a central focus of an optimal crisis response (one that maximizes benefits to victims and the organization in crisis) (→Coombs 2022). Park's research (→2017) demonstrated that the CSR response simply functions as bolstering, i.e., reminding people of past good works (→Benoit 1995). Bolstering is simply a secondary crisis response strategy that should be used only after addressing

victim concerns (→Coombs and Holladay 2002). Again, using CSR communication as a crisis response devalues CSR communication by treating it as just another variable and one that has already been studied in the extant crisis communication literature (e.g., →Benoit 1995; →Coombs and Holladay 2002).

The concept of corporate social irresponsibility (CSI) has received less attention than CSR (→Lange and Washburn 2012) but provides a bridge to work on risk, crisis, and issues management. CSI focuses on negative perceptions of an organization's "bad behavior". As with responsibility assessments of CSR, assessments of irresponsibility are subjective and grounded in normative expectations for corporate behavior. However, CSI is not simply the opposite of CSR or the absence of CSR. Rather, →Lange and Washburn (2012) identify three interrelated attributions that underlie perceptions of CSI and are affected by the individual characteristics of the observers, such as knowledge and exposure to third party frames of the event. The three attributions are effect undesirability, corporate culpability, and noncomplicity of the affected party. Effect undesirability arises from normative expectations for moral behavior and corporate outcomes and includes assessments of threats that may be posed by the negative event. Corporate culpability refers to the corporation's causal and moral responsibility for the negative event. Finally, the noncomplicity of victims refers to the ability of victims to have advanced knowledge of the potential for a negative event as well as their ability to prevent the negative outcome.

Corporate irresponsibility judgments are a risk. How will stakeholders perceive an organization when it has knowingly sold a defective product, allowed dangerous chemicals to harm a local community, or used child labor? Information about corporate irresponsibility creates negative social

evaluations and becomes a liability for an organization (→Pollock et al. 2019).

CSR has been treated as a *risk to be managed* (→Bebbington, Larrinaga-González, and Moneva-Abadía 2008). Regarding CSR as a risk is predicated upon stakeholder expectations. When managers violate stakeholder expectations for responsible behavior, such as sourcing raw material in an unsustainable way, the CSR risk can become a crisis. The CSR risk is managed by addressing potentially problematic behaviors or practices before they become a public concern or as the risk begins to emerge within the public view (→Coombs and Holladay 2012b). Stakeholder perceptions of CSR matter because CSR is a major factor in shaping organizational reputations and other social evaluations (→Lin-Hi, Rothenhöfer, and Blumberg 2019). Given that reputation is a valued organizational asset, being viewed as irresponsible presents a distinct form of threat. In fact, annual corporate risk assessments now recognize reputation as a significant risk factor (→Coombs 2022). Moreover, →Palenchar, Hocke, and Heath (2011) noted the connection between CSR and risk communication is dependent upon stakeholder expectations.

Engaging in CSR communication creates a form of risk as well. CSR communication announces an organization is committed to and values CSR. By signaling CSR is a valued part of a reputation or broader social evaluations, an organization creates a potential risk. Any actions that conflict with the stated commitment can be framed as hypocritical and are now a risk that can become manifest and damage its reputation (→Coombs and Holladay 2012b). The organization's CSR communication can be used against it to reveal hypocrisy. Accusations of greenwashing can erode stakeholder perceptions of an organization. CSR communication provides a unique angle on risk because of the insights it offers into

understanding reputational threats and stakeholder perceptions

2.3 CSR Communication and Issues Management

Originally, issues management focused on systematic attempts to shape policy decisions but has been expanded to now include social issues (→Heath 2005). Social issues are marked by having two or more sides and being polarizing. Though managers once avoided social issues because of their polarizing nature, stakeholders now expect organizations to address social issues such as marriage equality, immigration, and systemic racism (→Park 2022). *Social issues management* is one term used to refer to organizations taking a public stand on social issues (→Coombs and Holladay 2018b).

→Hydock, Paharia, and Blair (2020) and →Park (2022) have argued that taking a stance on controversial socio-political issues (what we call social issues management) is a form of CSR. →Hydock, Paharia, and Blair (2020) use the term corporate political advocacy (CPA) to describe taking a public stand on divisive socio-political issues. CPA is related to CSR because it is driven by a social obligation generated by stakeholder expectations that organizations engage these topics. CPA may attract stakeholders to an organization through ideological alignment but also repel others due to misalignment. CPA seems to create mixed effects when used as a form of CSR communication. Their data found that organizations with small market shares are the most likely to gain social approval from CPA while organizations with large market shares are most likely to generate social disapproval (→Hydock, Paharia, and Blair 2020).

→Park (2022) uses the term corporate social advocacy (CSA) to refer to organizations taking a stand on controversial socio-political issues and argues that CSA can be a new form of CSR created by stakeholder expectations for addressing

social issues. →Park (2022) argued and provided some data to support the view that CSA should reduce CSR skepticism because it signals a commitment to CSR and promotes stakeholder identification with the organization.

Overall, social issues management has arisen from stakeholder demands for organizations to address social and environmental issues. Although social issues management can attract some stakeholders (create social approval assets) by highlighting certain organizational values with which stakeholders identify, it will naturally repel other stakeholders (create social disapproval liabilities) because of its divisive nature. However, any reputation-building message always will appeal to some stakeholders while repelling others (→Zavyalova et al. 2016). The polarizing nature of social issues would seem to intensify the split in how stakeholders perceive reputation-building messages. Research examining CSR's connection to social issues management has the potential to yield new insights for CSR, social issues management, and benefits for society. Important questions to ask include the types of social issues being addressed or ignored and the nature of organizational responses to social issues. Do organizations focus on social issues that have currency (in the public discussion) or do organizations focus on industry-specific social issues? When organizations are compelled to respond, are the responses more symbolic statements or do they include substantive actions? Are there identifiable differences between those organizations that make no statement, those that make symbolic statements, and those that take substantive actions?

The discussion of issues management does reflect the political perspective of CSR to a degree. The political view of CSR considers how corporations, along with NGOs, can fill policy voids found in global governance. No longer does the world ascribe businesses to focus primarily on profits and governments to focus on the public good. Corporations now

assume responsibility for many social and political concerns (→Scherer and Palazzo 2011). An example would be corporations engaging in self-regulation because there are no international standards to govern a particular practice and CSR itself has even been defined as a form of self-regulation (→Gond, Kang, and Moon 2011). However, self-regulation can be self-serving because it can prevent government intervention and reduce operating costs and oversight.

→Dawkins (2021) is among those who argue that even a political view of CSR is too limiting because it does not account for power inequities and cooptation of stakeholders by corporate interests through engagement. Agonistic CSR claims to take that next step. Drawing from the work of →Mouffe (1999) and agonistic pluralism in politics, agonistic CSR centers on how stakeholders utilize contestation and counterveillance to compel organizations to be more socially responsible (→Dawkins 2021). Agonistic CSR posits that discourse is used to contest continually the meaning of CSR. The opposing sides disagree while recognizing the legitimacy of one another's perspectives. Though opposing sides do reach agreement, it is a conflictual consensus that is temporary. These agreements are temporary resolutions, not final outcomes (→Burchell and Cook 2013). This is consistent with how issues management holds that issues are resolved, not solved, and can re-emerge at any time (→Crable and Vibbert 1985).

2.4 CSR and Internal Communication

Internal communication is an area that concentrates on employee communication (e.g., for a review see →Men 2021). *Internal communication* can be defined as the "communication between an organization's strategic managers and its internal stakeholders, designed to promote commitment to the organization, a sense of belonging to it, awareness of its

changing environment and understanding of its evolving aims" (→Welch and Jackson 2007: 186). Internal stakeholders experience messages directed to external audiences as well as employees, a concept called auto-communication. Moreover, employees are both producers and consumers of CSR communication (→Dhanesh 2021; →Morsing 2006). CSR communication intersects with internal communication through internal CSR and employee engagement (→Dhanesh 2021).

Internal CSR focuses on topics of relevance and value to employees that create a positive physical and psychological working environment. Research has identified five areas of internal CSR: (1) a secure and stable job, (2) a healthy and safe working environment, (3) skill development such as training, (4) workforce diversity including gender equity and equality of opportunity, and (5) work-life balance that seeks to minimize conflict with leisure and family time (→Lee 2020). Internal CSR communication facilitates understanding of the organization's CSR activities and helps to increase positive perceptions of the organization's CSR efforts (→Schaefer, Terlutter, and Diehl 2020) and is linked to important organization outcomes including productivity, profitability, less employee absenteeism, and a willingness to work harder (→Ferreira and de Oliveira 2014; →Schaefer, Terlutter, and Diehl 2020). Internal CSR communication also helps to facilitate employee identification (→Wang and Pala 2021) and employee engagement (→Duthler and Dhanesh 2018).

Employee engagement is "the enduring motivational and psychological states of employees, in which they devote their hands, minds, and hearts to their work and stay cognitively, physically, emotionally and fully invested in their roles" (→Lee 2021: 4). Engaged employees are absorbed in and dedicated to their jobs. CSR programs, including communication about them, provide one mechanism of creating engagement for employees (→Al-Tit and Hunitie 2015; →Lee 2020). CSR is a

way for employees to bring a part of themselves to work. Moreover, employee engagement increases employee advocative behavior such as positive word-of-mouth about the organization and defending the organization from critics (→Lee 2020). Furthermore, internal CSR can stimulate employee positive word-of-mouth about the organization's CSR efforts (→Schaefer, Terlutter, and Diehl 2020). Internal CSR communication and engagement can create employee ambassadors for organizational CSR activities. Internal CSR communication is emerging as an important topic with internal communication (→Dhanesh 2021). Currently, CSR communication is treated as more of a variable in internal communication but has the potential to develop into a distinct focus of research.

2.5 Summary

CSR communication research has formed linkages to a variety of other organizational communication research. While the connections demonstrate the value of CSR communication, there is a risk that CSR communication may be treated as simply another variable within those areas rather than a primary focus of the research. CSR as crisis risk emphasizes how stakeholder expectations shape CSR actions and communication. CSR as issues management reflects the power of stakeholder expectations in CSR and captures the political and relational orientations to CSR along with the need for organizations to work with other political actors such as NGOs to fill the existing void within global governance. Yet the extant research largely focuses on outcomes that are more business-centric than society-centric.

3 CSR Communication and Outcomes: Who Should

Benefit?

CSR communication is strategic communication, meaning it is goal-oriented. CSR goals should represent societal as well as organizational interests. Furthermore, the relational and political views of CSR suggest the goals may be a fusion of the two as organizations engage in CSR due to pressures from stakeholders. Outcomes and outputs are important considerations in strategic communication efforts. Outcomes are what you hope to achieve while outputs are the actions taken to reach those outcomes (→Laskin 2016). →Wickert (2021) notes that CSR often confuses outputs with outcomes, actually a common problem in strategic communication research (→Laskin 2016). For instance, a CSR report is an output not an outcome. CSR is not about creating the report itself (a product) but about the effect of that report on other stakeholders. What are the effects of the CSR actions? Much of the early CSR communication research necessarily focused on outputs due to the need to understand the various tools available to managers. The problem occurs when the CSR communication research fails to appreciate the difference between outputs and outcomes by simply focusing on descriptions of the outputs.

When the CSR communication research examines outcomes, those outcomes tend to be instrumental and reflect the business case for CSR. The problem with the business-centric focus on CSR captured in the instrumental CSR communication research is that we lose sight of who should benefit from the CSR efforts. CSR is meant to bring social and environmental concerns to the forefront. Yet the outcomes found in CSR communication research typically are organizational outcomes such as financial performance, social evaluation enhancement, improved employee engagement, or the ability to manage risks. Those outcomes position the organization as the beneficiary of the CSR efforts with little

regard for society or the environment. We are left wondering what the true impacts of the CSR efforts are on society, the environment, and the stakeholders associated with these concerns. →Wickert (2021) pushes us to examine alternative beneficiaries, assess aggregate social and environmental conditions, and consider long-term and nonlinear effects when considering society-centric outcomes.

→Wickert's (2021) call to study society-oriented outcomes is not new within CSR communication. In 2012, a list of potential societal benefits was presented that can serve as society-oriented outcomes (→Coombs and Holladay 2012a). →Table 1 reports potential CSR outcomes from that list of benefits to society. The list includes various societal-level outcomes and dialogue with stakeholders as outcomes. The societal-level outcomes capture the shift in beneficiaries and aggregates included in →Wickert's (2021) call. CSR outcomes should include nonfinancial reporting (→Crawford and Williams 2011) to document specific effects on social and environmental concerns, not simply what actions were taken and how organizations benefit from the efforts. For instance, how have CSR efforts addressed poverty or improved living conditions in a particular community?

Table 1: CSR Benefits for Society.

CSR benefits for society
Corrects social and environmental problems caused by business operations
Holds corporations accountable for their actions
Encourages dialogue and partnerships among diverse stakeholders
Contributes to advancing social justice
Can supplement governmental and social welfare programs designed to improve social and environmental concerns

While we should not mistake outputs for outcomes, the dialogue itself can be both. Involving people in a dialogue can be an outcome if we treat participation itself as a valued outcome because of its potential effects on participants and CSR efforts. Dialogue as a process is not an output. But stakeholder participation in the dialogue process can be considered an outcome because it diversifies the perspectives used to develop the CSR efforts. Moreover, participation in dialogue is a manifestation of meaning co-creation (→Golob and Podnar 2011). If we are to treat CSR as communication, engagement is critical to providing views other than those of the organization creating the CSR efforts. In addition, participants can accrue benefits from their involvement in the dialogue such as learning new skills and helping behaviors or supporting positive changes in the community. Researchers should examine the engagement aspect of CSR in more depth. What are the common forms of engagement and do those vary by industry? Do organizations create engagement that extends well beyond the initial CSR effort to form lasting communities designed to support stakeholders? How common are forms of engagement that provide some form of support to stakeholders through advice and access to resources that improves people's lives?

3.1 Narratives and CSR Communication Re-considered

→Xu and Kochigina (2021) conducted an experiment to demonstrate the value of narratives in CSR communication. Their research reflected an instrumental focus because it examined how the use of narratives in CSR communication could affect CSR skepticism. The research referenced work on how CSR could use narratives as part of a transmedia storytelling approach to CSR communication. However, this transmedia storytelling *is more expansive than just the benefits of narrative in CSR communication* and provides a means to

consider other ways to evaluate CSR communication that are more society-centric (e.g., →Coombs and Holladay 2018a). Elaborating on the transmedia storytelling approach to CSR communication offers insights into how dialogue creates beneficial outcomes as well as being a form of output.

3.2 Transmedia Storytelling and CSR Communication

Transmedia storytelling was developed by Henry →Jenkins (2006) to explain changes in the entertainment industry. Transmedia storytelling involves multiple voices telling different yet related stories across a variety of media. The stories are related because they inhabit the same storyworld. The storyworld is the foundation for transmedia storytelling because it provides an overall story arc that sets the parameters for additional stories by supplying a backstory and rules for relationships between characters (→Giovagnoli 2017). →Jenkins (2006) identified seven principles for transmedia storytelling. Spreadability-drillability refers to people wanting to share the stories and wanting more information about the storyworld. Continuity-multiplicity means there is a consistent experience across stories with the same situation examined from multiple perspectives. Emersion-extraction is when people want to be a part of the storyworld and apply lessons from the stories to their own lives. Worldbuilding holds that the storyworld can encourage and manage multiple stories. Seriality is how a story unfolds in different media and in separate segments. Subjectivity is the idea that there are multiple perspectives. Performance is encouraging people to take action.

Various authors have begun to apply transmedia storytelling to strategic communication (e.g., →Bourda 2014; →Sutherland and Barker 2013). Researchers have argued transmedia storytelling is ideally suited to CSR communication (→Coombs and Holladay 2018a). In CSR communication, the

organizational goals attached to the CSR efforts can become the foundational storyworld because goals reflect the organization's values that are embedded within the organizational purpose, mission, and vision (→Coombs 2019). Purpose has a logical connection to CSR and there is an increased focus on becoming purpose-driven organizations (→Dhanesh 2020; →Dupret and Pultz 2021). The *organizational purpose* is the reason a business exists coupled with how it benefits society. Purpose reflects the interdependence of organizations and society. It acknowledges its responsibilities to society through statements about making a difference, reducing harm, or improving lives (→Hollensbe et al. 2014). Purpose is translated into action through responsible actions that address organizational goals.

The organizational CSR goals and purpose are premised on values that can set parameters for additional stories. For instance, Starbucks professes a commitment to "improving society" through its organizational discourse. Its value of improving society became the storyworld for its Upstander CSR effort. Upstander began as a series of ten videos about individuals who made positive changes in their communities. The videos were not branded and were focused on the individual making the change (→Coombs and Holladay 2018a). The CSR communication transpired across multiple media. The Upstander videos were supported with content on various social media platforms and some townhall meetings. More importantly, the stakeholders could contribute their own stories to the storyworld, meaning the organization was not the only storyteller/voice. Upstander viewers were encouraged to support positive change in their own communities by joining change efforts. People also were encouraged to submit stories of upstanders they knew and to share reactions to the various Upstander stories. A second set of 11 videos created a year later encouraged people to submit

short two-minute videos about charities they felt needed attention and support (→Starbucks 2017).

Though the organization initiates the transmedia storytelling process, how the storyworld evolves over time should be driven by the stories created by stakeholders. The organization begins the transmedia storybuilding by planting a seed with a central CSR message about a CSR effort. Starbucks began the Upstander effort with ten videos selected by the organization. Stakeholders then co-created those stories through their reactions and suggested additional stories, some of which could be used in Season 2 of Upstanders. Stakeholders shape if and how that seed grows, thereby exerting some control over the CSR effort and its meaning. It is through this sharing of stories that the meaning for the CSR efforts is created jointly between stakeholders and the organization (→Coombs and Holladay 2021). Furthermore, people's offline actions to support various charities in response to the Upstander messaging reflect individual, not corporate, actions to better society. Transmedia storytelling provides a framework to generate engagement with CSR messages and facilitates the co-creation of meaning (→Coombs and Holladay 2018a).

Three principles of transmedia storytelling are essential for moving CSR communication toward the society-centric focus: (1) spreadability-drillability, (2) immersion-extraction, and (3) performance. *Spreadability* is how the story transmits through stakeholders involved with the CSR stories. *Drillability* is the desire of stakeholders to gather additional information about the initiative. Both signal engagement with the CSR stories. People want to share the CSR stories with one another and to learn more about the stories. "Generally, transmedia storytelling helps people to engage with messages more deeply" (→Coombs 2019: 356). The CSR stories become cultural attractors, elements that draw people with similar interests together. *Immersion* is a desire to enter the

storyworld created by the CSR communication, another indicator of engagement and co-created meaning about CSR activities (→Coombs and Holladay 2018a, →2021). *Extractability* refers to the lessons learned through the CSR stories and their application in the lives of those telling the stories. Extractability is an outcome because it indicates how the CSR communication is helping individual stakeholders. "It is ideal that people learn lessons from the CSR communication and apply those lessons to their lives" (→Coombs 2019: 356). *Performance* encourages stakeholders to act. The CSR communication becomes a cultural activator, a catalyst for shared meaning and shared actions. For CSR, those actions can include specific behaviors designed to improve society, including volunteering, and represent another possible society-focused outcome for CSR communication.

The key dynamic is stakeholder engagement resulting in societal changes. We move away from the view that CSR communication creates benefits for organizations through stakeholder awareness of initiatives. Instead, CSR communication benefits society when people are engaged with the CSR messaging resulting in benefits to themselves or a willingness to take actions to help others. In this case the societal changes can be individual actions rather than an aggregate as specified by →Wickert (2021). Individuals reporting how they have personally benefited from the CSR message or people reporting the actions they took to help address a social or environmental concern provides another source of evidence for outcomes that benefit society.

Engagement is an important outcome because it allows a wider range of views to enter the conversation and to become part of the CSR effort. Stakeholders engage in transmedia storytelling by consuming the various stories but more importantly by contributing their own stories as well as reacting to the stories of others. It is by contributing to the storyworld that the stakeholders shape the CSR efforts

through their own CSR messaging. If we believe stakeholders and organizations co-create the meaning of CSR efforts through their discourse, it is critical that stakeholders have a means to share their CSR discourse. A transmedia storytelling approach to CSR communication is one mechanism for giving voice to stakeholders in the CSR conversation. Researchers should explore transmedia storytelling in CSR more fully. Are particular industries or types of CSR efforts more likely to utilize transmedia storytelling? Does transmedia storytelling CSR create more supportive networks for stakeholders than typical CSR efforts? How should we go about documenting the nature of engagement facilitated by transmedia storytelling?

4 Future Research Directions

The CSR communication literature is prolific but is less productive in providing insights beyond organization-centric applications. We offer three broad areas for future CSR communication work that can increase the range of insights by moving towards a society-centric focus: utilizing societal and environmental outcomes, understanding the connections between internal and external CSR, and exploring the effects of the web of stakeholder relationships on CSR communication.

4.1 Societal and Environmental Outcomes

Societal and environmental outcomes should be primary in CSR communication research because those outcomes are the most relevant to being responsible. The effects of CSR on organizations should be the secondary outcome. Developing society-oriented outcomes is essential to future CSR communication research and consistent with the focus on organizational purpose. Researchers must begin to unpack how CSR communication is or is not benefiting the society and

environment it is supposed to be helping. Though we cannot dispute that instrumental, business-focused research provides valuable information to managers, we believe CSR communication does not contribute to an organization's purpose until we understand its effects on society-oriented outcomes. *CSR communication should begin assessing how CSR is impacting society and the environment and how CSR communication contributes to those outcomes*. For instance, CSR reports could be examined for how they quantify the effects of CSR efforts on specific social and environmental outcomes. An example might be how communicating about a specific CSR initiative gets more people involved in that effort and increases its impact on marginalized groups within a community. CSR communication's potential to do good for society will remain untapped until research shifts to a more society-centric focus, a point made in previous reviews of CSR communication (e.g., →May 2011).

4.2 Internal and External CSR

CSR communication research reflects the distinction between internal and external CSR. Research would benefit by considering how the two work together. We see some of the benefits of thinking of both in the application of auto-communication to external CSR messaging (→Morsing 2006). Another point to consider is how internal CSR is assessed and used as part of external CSR messaging. The internal CSR communication research has concentrated on employee engagement as a benefit to organizations. Little attention is focused on the benefits of internal CSR and engagement on employee well-being. Again, CSR communication research benefits from moving the outcomes from the organization to the stakeholders who are to benefit from the CSR efforts. How do internal CSR efforts affect the psychological and physiological states of employees and how does CSR

communication contribute to those outcomes? The focus would be on well-being as the outcome and not how well-being contributes to specific organizational outcomes. Interest in internal CSR should increase with the growing emphasis on corporate human capital disclosure (HCD). HCD covers a wide range of topics related to employees such as diversity, total number of employees, job training, occupational safety, and job security (→Omens, Radeva and Vaghul 2021).

Researchers should consider how internal CSR efforts are often used as part of the external CSR communication efforts. Organizations discuss internal CSR efforts as a means of bolstering social assessments. Consumers might be more likely to support an organization when it treats its employees well. We saw this theme emerge in discussions of COVID-19 and how organizations treated their essential workers. But how can we move that fusion beyond an organization-centric focus? How does the treatment of employees relate to societal outcomes? More generally, research should explore how internal CSR efforts affect societal outcomes, such as poverty reduction or net-zero emissions, and the role communication plays in that process.

4.3 Web of Stakeholder Relationships

Research utilizing the web of relationships offers not only a more society-centric focus but a more complex view of CSR communication. Exploring how CSR acts as a crisis risk provides a means of increasing our understanding of how stakeholder expectations both shape and drive CSR. But the idea of risk is an organization-focused outcome. CSR communication becomes about the effect of stakeholder expectations on CSR as well as the effects of CSR communication on stakeholders. CSR as crisis risk has logical connections to CSR and social issues management. The need to navigate social issues is a form of risk experienced by

organizations. Exploring how the interactions between organizations and stakeholders involved in the social issues provides new avenues for CSR communication. Similarly, examining how NGOs, governments, and organizations collaborate to create polices to benefit society is an interesting route for CSR communication (→Bator and Stohl 2011). CSR communication moves beyond organizational messaging to the complex processes used to encourage organizations to engage in CSR efforts. The web of relationships also allows for the exploration of dissensual CSR. Dissensual CSR explores how the conflict between organizations, NGOs, governments, and other stakeholders shapes how CSR is defined and practiced. This includes exploring how stakeholders leverage power to force changes in CSR (→Dawkins 2021). Dissensual CSR is consistent with work in strategic communication that focuses on dissensus rather than consensus between organization and stakeholders (e.g., →Ciszek 2016).

4.4 Transmedia Storytelling

Transmedia storytelling offers a useful research tool for CSR communication. The transmedia storytelling approach to CSR communication integrates the digital interactive and emerging constitutive frames of CSR communication identified in the review by →Verk, Golob, and Podnar (2021). Transmedia storytelling seeks to engage stakeholders via social media (and other channels) as well as exploring how the meaning of CSR activities are co-created. Research could explore if transmedia storytelling provides one means for fulfilling the dialogue potential that research indicates has gone unfulfilled in CSR communication. It also provides a framework for understanding how stakeholders contribute to the social construction of CSR.

5 Conclusion

CSR communication itself is embedded with a web of relationships with other areas of organizational communication including risk and crisis communication, issues management, and internal communication. Placing CSR communication within this web of relationships presents a more complete and complex view of the topic that moves beyond the basics of an instrumental view. The instrumental view provides value but not the societal focus one would expect from CSR. Moreover, it is important to understand CSR, like other forms of strategic communication, is embedded with a web of relations including organizations and their various stakeholders. A focus on the web of relationships provides a perspective that is more society-centric than business-centric because the research appreciates the effects of various stakeholders upon the CSR process. It is only by taking this broader view that CSR communication can fulfill its true potential in terms of helping society and involving multiple stakeholders in the process.

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Chapter 30 From Crisis Response to High Resilience Organizing

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Abstract

The shifting nature of crises and their related impacts call for updated theorizing in crisis response research. This chapter updates resilience theorizing by advancing a holistic focus on resilience as a dynamic, adaptive communicative process that is constituted across levels. Resilience involves communication among individuals and connecting across organizations and systems in the context of various forms of crisis/disruption. This approach both centers communication and demands a temporal analysis that highlights the role of the compression and expansion of time related to crisis. Drawing on the adaptive organizing qualities of high reliability organizations (HROs), this chapter proposes high resilience organizing (HResO) and related high resilience organizations (HiResOs) as an area of theory building to offer a transformative way to understand organizations in the context of perpetual pivoting around disruptions. Sections are organized by levels representing aspects of interdependent organizing structures that enable and constrain communication. This chapter concludes with a call for future research to focus on the exploitative side of resilience, which may affect organizational members and their constituents before, during, and in the aftermath of crisis.

Keywords: high reliability organizations (HROs), high resilience organizing (HiResO), Karl Weick, crisis/disaster, resilience, cross-sector organizing, interorganizational communication, collective action, networks, public goods, inequity/inclusion, time/pacing, Great Resignation, COVID, hurricane recovery,

Crisis communication was born out of organizations mitigating physical damage and engaging in reputation management and repair. Yet increasingly, crises span a wide range of scenarios and encompass more than simply reputational recovery and corporate-centered concerns (→Frandsen and Johansen 2020). The concept of resilience, or "the process of reintegrating from disruptions in life" (→Richardson 2002: 309), has been adopted in crisis communication as a way to look more holistically at crisis response. Resilience in the face of a crisis is constitutive of communication and not merely information sharing/dissemination (→Jahn and Johansson 2018). Thus, resilience and crisis are two sides of the same coin (→Doerfel et al. 2020). Additionally, organizing and communicating around and through disruption involves multi-level dynamic organizing (→Doerfel 2016) that spans domains (e.g., family and work) (→Afifi et al. 2020; →Roeder, Bisel, and Morrissey 2021). As such, examining disruptions that organizations, their constituents, and their environments experience can be traced back to the mid-1900s when multidisciplinary organizational scholars began theorizing about organizational survival.

The inherently temporal nature of crisis – i.e., as an unplanned event that requires a time-sensitive response – suggests its centrality to fundamentally organizational communication processes. Crisis may be embraced as part of the organization's life cycle, rather than simply something to be managed and moved past (→Chewning, Lai, and Doerfel 2013; →Doerfel, Lai, and Chewning 2010). Crisis and resilience processes both stretch and compress time, pointing to issues

of improvisation, exploitation of workers, and inclusion-exclusion (→Ballard and Aguilar 2020). Whereas crises were formerly considered to be relatively discrete events in terms of time and impact, we have arguably entered an era that is marked by *chronic crisis*. Chronic crises may have an acute period, but don't really go away. In fact, they may perpetuate and/or exacerbate other crises. In this state of chronic crisis, more traditional crises are becoming sequential. Sequential crises leave all system levels without time to recover, with the effects from each crisis piling up on the previous crisis. This expanded focus and conceptualization of crisis has led to an emerging body of research that considers the communication and adaptive ways in which entire systems cope.

As a result, crisis communication has evolved to encompass resilience research, often de-centering any one organization. Notably, disasters associated with human impacts on the environment, are catastrophic events that impact entire communities and, most recently, pandemics like COVID-19, impact entire regions, networks of organizations, governments, and citizens. These events show that crises can and do affect all organizations, cutting across domains and levels. Organization-centric examinations consider employees, communities, industries, or organizational networks. In contrast, resilience across domains considers the ways in which professional resilience may be mutually dependent on personal resilience (→Afifi et al. 2020; →Kim et al. 2022; →Roeder, Bisel, and Morrissey 2021), reflecting another question born out of the temporal aspect of resilience – where does the resilience process begin and end?

This chapter lays the foundation for new directions in research and theorizing in several ways. We begin by advancing current theorizing that mirrors a shift from crisis response to resilience as a dynamic, adaptive communicative process in organizational communication. We show how this interplay among individuals, organizations, and systems in the

context of various forms of crisis/disruption centers communication and demands a temporal analysis. Additionally, we draw on specific types of organizations and context areas for theory building and design implementation of *high resilience organizing* (HiResO) and resultant *high resilience organizations* (HiResOs). Our proposed shift in thinking from high reliability organizations (HROs) to HiResO and subsequent HiResOs offers a transformative way to understand organizations in the context of perpetual pivoting around disruptions. Our chapter sections are organized by levels representing aspects of interdependent organizing structures that enable and constrain communication. We conclude with future research directions, challenging scholars to consider the counterpart of crisis – resilience – as having exploitative and enabling sides that organizational members may face in anticipation of, during, and in the aftermath of crisis.

1 Crisis and Resilience as Dynamic Organizational Processes

Crisis encompasses a wide variety of events that interrupt the daily operations of an organization, threatening organizational stability (→Runyan 2006; →Seeger and Ulmer 2003; →Frandsen and Johansen 2020), and shedding light on origins and adaptive capacities of social order. Underlying assumptions about crisis are grounded in the social construction of reality, such that the way stakeholders perceive the event, its causes, and its consequences leads to different organizational and stakeholder action. Crisis has traditionally been defined as a "turning point" or "aberration" marking crisis as something that is both set apart from daily operation and to be "recovered from". This view isolates crisis, ignoring the idea that organizational design processes,

practices, and interventions serve as the foundation for *how* organizations experience crisis and enact resilience.

Organizational culture, practices, and networks enable and constrain the choices, communication, and actions of organizational members as they work to make sense of changing conditions (→Harrison et al. 2017). In turn, organizational choices are inextricably bound with the environment on interorganizational, community, and national levels, depending on the scope and type of crisis. Such overlap highlights interdependency that can cascade across levels (→Doerfel et al. 2020). Communities need functioning organizations, and organizations need functioning stakeholder networks, communities, resilient leaders, and employees who can carry out the operations of the organization. The COVID-19 global pandemic illustrated interdependent and cascading impacts of disruption, such that all types of organizations quickly discovered that quarantines shocked their systems into various forms of breaking points and/or adaptation.

As organizations move through crisis, they are often forced to reconsider their core assumptions and beliefs (→Seeger and Ulmer 2003) as well as their operational strategies. Likewise, when communities and their citizens move through crisis, they are forced to consider their own well-being while simultaneously recognizing the need to help other stakeholders. To this end, resilience is constituted through formal and informal communication within and external to groups and organizations. This includes processing information that changes, is limited, or obfuscated by its volume or speed (→Bean et al. 2016; →Stephens, Barrett, and Mahometa 2013), in addition to sensemaking, adapting routines, accessing networks, and technology use – all of which support and reimagine organizational culture. How organizations work through these processes affects organizational resilience (→Ishak and Williams 2018).

Viewing crisis and resilience as part of a larger lifecycle of organizing highlights the fact that these processes are inherently bound to the concept of temporality. Resilience during crisis involves “looking behind”, “bouncing back”, “bouncing ahead”, and “remembering and forgetting” lessons from the past (→Buzzanell 2010; →Coombs 2019). Crises generate the need for immediate action and sensemaking. Pacing of communication and action is altered within a crisis environment, with communication sometimes coming so quickly that it overwhelms a system’s capacity to manage it (→Bean et al. 2016; →Stephens, Barrett, and Mahometa 2013). Efficiency is often prioritized because of the rapidly evolving circumstances that come with crisis, which threatens to set up a false dichotomy between efficiency and effectiveness. Understanding how time and crisis intersect, and who and what gets privileged as a result, is a key part of understanding crisis and resilience. We next unpack levels of resilience, their intersections, and how issues of time and communication-based resources impact crisis response.

1.1 Individual-Level Resilience

As all levels of society are rooted in the individual, individual-level resilience is reciprocally connected with organizations and entire systems. During crisis, organizational culture serves as a formal organizing process that both enables and constrains individuals in terms of action (→Harrison et al. 2017; →Ishak and Williams 2018). Expecting resilience requires dynamic and ever-adaptive organizing. However, imbuing an improvisational orientation towards resilience is at odds with the tendency for employees to perpetuate organizational inertia in that “people prefer to retain beliefs, organizational positions, structures, and practices as long as possible” (→Hutter and Kuhlicke 2013: 303). Hutter and Kuhlicke’s argument reflects the point that resilience is constituted

through everyday talk and sensemaking) and identity anchors related to one's work. Engaging in practices and talk that reinforce professional identity enables and constrains employees' ability to enact resilience for themselves and the people they serve (→Harrison et al. 2017).

In many cases, individuals instigate organizational resilience. Following Hurricane Katrina, the resilience of individual leaders shaped resilience processes on the organizational level, and the social capital and resources of those leaders assisted in organizational resilience (→Doerfel, Lai, and Chewning 2010). Of note, it is not always management that initiates the response. For example, →Roeder, Bisel, and Morrissey (2021) observed that during the 2018–19 US Government shutdown, national weather forecasters carried over their professional values of contingency planning and redundancy to their home finances through conservative financial management. This practice allowed the forecasters to be resilient in the face of not being paid. Doing so enabled them to do their jobs effectively, supporting organizational resilience. →Roeder, Bisel, and Morrissey (2021) determined that the decision was driven by the communication processes that create professional and team identifications over time, again emphasizing the importance of identity and sensemaking related to resilience.

Yet, individual action during crisis can be variable. Although exogenous factors such as identification with organizational culture, organizational constraints, and personal hardship related to the crisis can impact individual action from a structural level, endogenous factors such as personal history and values also impact how individuals interpret and react to crisis. Personal characteristics of both leaders and "rank and file" employees intersect with organizational and environmental elements to impact crisis response. Personality can also come into play. Charismatic individuals often emerge as leaders, contributing to a shared

sense of belonging and urgency that enables shared action (→Gerlach 2001) within and across organizational boundaries.

Individuals outside an organization can also contribute to organizational resilience, as social media enables the creation, sharing, and coordination of crisis information and related action (→Spence et al. 2015: 172). Stakeholders can take to social media to help coordinate relief efforts (→Lai 2017), connect affected organizations and other individuals to necessary resources (→Houston et al. 2015), crowd-source and crowd-fund (→Riccardi 2016); or on the flip side, organize virtual or in-person protests (→Chewning 2016), hijack organizational social media platforms (→Veil et al. 2015), and troll organizations via social media.

In the case of wide scale or dangerous crises such as hurricanes or wildfires, individuals with a baseline of resilience have been shown to contribute to emergent networks on the organizational and community levels and even morph into ad hoc citizen organizations (→Harris and Doerfel 2017; →Lai 2017). Research on citizen organizing examines digital technology use and spontaneous organizing by citizens intersecting with each other, institutions, and emergency response (→Li et al. 2019; →Smith et al. 2021; →Spearing, Stephens, and Faust 2021). Informal organizing processes include utilizing new disaster contacts or adapting existing technology to emergent crisis needs (→Kim et al. 2022). In manufactured crises that arise from organizational negligence, individuals with no other contact than through an organization's social media platform can coalesce into one voice supporting or protesting an organization or serve as "noise" that impacts sensemaking and decision making for organizations in crisis. Looking at how individual efforts on social media can impact resilience processes of other individuals, organizations, and communities at large again emphasizes the multi-level nature of resilience.

1.2 Group- and Team-Level Resilience

Even in settings that can be described in terms of individual actions, like taking to social media or acting during an environmental disaster, collective action is a powerful site of resilience. Many of these settings are best described in terms of emergent groups, often blurring the distinction between individual and group resilience. In other organizational settings, formal groups and teams organize and mediate resilience processes through members' collective sensemaking. Attention to a team-based process called adaptation, or adjustments to process in response to some stimuli, reflects concerns with responding to crises and practicing resilience (→Maynard, Kennedy, and Sommer 2015).

Team adaptation is bound tightly to issues of time and temporality (→Ishak and Ballard 2012) with important implications for the study of crisis and resilience. Adaptation involves pausing to "look back" and includes processes of identifying discontinuities in routines that demand teams pause or cease action. For instance, crisis communication literature typically examines how novel and unexpected events create disruption to the routine team functioning that, in turn, demands an urgent response to mitigate ongoing damage. Similarly, in the team literature, resilience has largely been measured as a time-based outcome of some disruptive event (→Coombs 2019; →Runyan 2006). Nonetheless, research in both literatures tends to be based on a truncated, time-based, study of crisis and resilience rather than a process-oriented, temporally driven, approach. As a result, temporality is largely absent in theorizing about these key organizational processes. Instead, both literatures treat time as an outcome variable, primarily considering crisis communication in reference to its speed when responding to an event and resilience as a function of how quickly things return to normal.

These existing assumptions – centered on novel and unexpected events, speed, and returning to normal – fail to

adequately reflect the full range of organizations that we study as well as the reality of organizing in the 21st century. Rather than reflecting the natural lifecycle of crisis and resilience, these theoretical assumptions are shaped by methodological and practical factors. For example, much of the adaptation literature relies upon experiments and group simulation activities because of the difficulty of gaining access to the black box of adaptation, which relies upon communication in bona fide teams within an undefined window of time. It is undefined because crises, without a beginning and end that researchers can know a priori, are difficult to study in short periods of time demanded by publication cycles.

These short-term biases shape broader conceptualizations of crisis and resilience in the literature in at least three ways that do not consider the temporal insights of emerging research on groups and teams. First, crisis communication in teams is not always in response to a discrete, exogenous event. It can also be part of an ongoing cycle of teamwork. →Ballard and colleagues (2020) describe a process of continuous adaptation that many teams regularly enact. Rather than waiting to react to a perceived threat in the environment, continuous adaptation involves proactive, ongoing adjustments to team processes based on the expectation of routine disruptions.

A related point of departure concerns the assumption of a return to normal. Recent developments in post-COVID-19 organizational environments, including the Great Resignation and cultural shifts in the conversation around remote work, suggest that a return to normal is not necessarily a sign of resilience (→Hsu 2021). →Richardson (2002) describes a process of resilient reintegration that leads to “insight or growth through disruptions” (p. 312). Thus, in viewing resilience as a process, teams and their organizations might choose to redesign communication in the aftermath of a crisis.

In particular, the collective communication design (CCD) efforts described by →Barbour, Gill, and Barge (2018) can be used to reshape and reimagine work. Yet time often gets structured by the sense of urgency generated when things go wrong. This can be seen especially in the realm of organization-level crisis that HROs aim to anticipate, control, and avoid. Thus, the need for proactive, high *resilience* organizing is crucial.

While HRO theory has been especially generative (see next section), many groups and teams operate in organizations and under operational constraints that do not comport with HRO theorizing and instead reflect high *resilience* organizations (HiResOs). The idea of controlling outcomes prominent in 20th-century Western organizational theorizing is not an aim for some teams. In many cases, a focus on how communication processes support teamwork is of primary importance. For instance, palliative care teams that support their clients' end-of-life experience have no illusion of control over time-based outcomes (→Jünger et al. 2007). →Ballard and colleagues (2020) describe the difficulty of establishing traditional outcome measures for the child abuse treatment and investigation teams they studied: success was defined as perseverance in the face of tragedies such as child death. In these settings, a short-term research bias leads to impoverished understanding. Attention to high resilience organizing as encompassing multi-level, cross-domain communication processes enriches our theoretical and empirical approaches in crisis communication. This shifts questions away from efficiency-oriented questions of returning to normalcy to examining time endogenously. How does time shape the ways in which resilience communication evolves across levels and domains?

1.3 Organizational Level

When examining crisis and resilience at an organizational level, HROs are lauded as exemplars. HROs focus primarily on safety and reliability that occur as part of natural working processes; crisis is baked into their work. These processes of responding to danger, catastrophes, and complicated work practices are different than the challenges faced by organizations who are victims of crises not of their own making. However, there are lessons related to resilience in the face of danger that can be learned from HRO processes. Indeed, this mirrors one of the key lessons that →Weick, Sutcliffe, and Obstfeld (2008) advance about learning in HROs: they learn through the exploration of meaningful analogues; learning from the failures of others helps "uncover assumptions people take for granted, trace out new implications of old assumptions, and identify latent organizational flaws" (p. 54). Drawing analogous lessons from HROs to help other organizations develop the capacity to become high resilience organizations is a key focus of this section.

There is a long history of examining safety and accidents in HROs and occupations, most prominently starting with →Perrow's (1984) normal accident theory. →Weick's (1987) shift to high reliability organizing begins to address criticisms of technological determinism and "normal accidents" (→Le Coze 2015), focusing on reliability and shifting toward culture and communication practices. →Weick and Sutcliffe (2011) established what are still widely accepted as the five hallmarks of HRO functioning, which serve as the foundation for collective mindfulness that leads to success in HROs including: preoccupation with failure; a reluctance to accept simplification; remaining sensitive to operations; maintaining a commitment to resilience; and practicing deference to expertise in decision making, regardless of hierarchy or rank.

While much HRO-focused research is on reliability and safety in high-risk contexts such as the military, fire and rescue, and nuclear safety, not all organizations are HROs. Or are they? Arguably, in the landscape of the COVID-19 pandemic, all organizations operated in potentially high-risk contexts, vulnerable to the ongoing crises of both the pandemic and other potential immediate crises (e.g., extreme weather events). Yet amidst this pandemic we have seen perhaps the biggest enactment of adaptive capacity and resilience among organizations than perhaps at any other point in the 21st century – arguably equivalent to, or perhaps surpassing the wartime mobilization during World War II. We saw remarkable innovation and adaptation across a multitude of industries related to the rapidly changing scientific information about COVID-19. Even politicians in many locales promptly adapted local regulations to allow for street closures for outdoor dining, alcohol delivery, and other (mal)adaptive responses to help organizations remain viable.

While these and other examples demonstrate the resilience of many organizations, there was tremendous pain as well, with extensive layoffs, businesses closing, families unable to feed or shelter themselves, hospitals overwhelmed with the sick and dying, and entire industries with few viable paths, leading to spikes in unemployment, reduced hours, and pay cuts, particularly among lower income adults (→Parker, Minkin, and Bennett 2020). Organizations had to address the safety of the workforce and the publics and communities they served. Organizations had to adapt to changes in work in more ways than the primary focus of reliability that HROs strive for; many organizations had to innovate, adapting new work processes that fundamentally changed the nature of work and of the organizations themselves. Organizations also became crisis communicators – persuading the public it was safe to patronize their organizations.

How then do we theorize resilience and high reliability organizing when essentially all organizations around the world face crisis and high-risk contexts? It is possible to make distinctions among various industry types that might influence the process of organizing for resilience. For example, firefighters face unique and novel crises each time they go on a call – with some being routine medical calls, while others can become very complex firefighting or rescue situations. Engaging in HRO processes to maintain safety in these complex situations requires a different level and quality of high reliability organizing than is needed for safety in restaurants, retail stores, or education during COVID-19. Making distinctions of this type is not new in the research on HROs. Indeed, many scholars have sought to expand the scope of HRO theorizing to other types of organizations, including medicine (e.g., →Weick and Sutcliffe 2011) or classifying some organizations, including NASA, as "reliability-seeking" rather than HROs.

Perhaps a more useful approach than categorizing some organizations as high reliability or reliability-seeking is to focus on the process and design of communication for high reliability organizing (→Harrison, Williams, and Reynolds 2020), especially as it relates to resilience (not just reliability). This allows for a more robust approach to theorizing and building resilience in organizations and to advancing the design of communication processes for resilience – allowing organizations to shift from a reactive response to a proactive preparedness for crisis that results in resilience. →Harrison and colleagues (2017) demonstrate this with their model of change processes for risk reduction and resilience, and move from theorizing to successful design, implementation, and evaluation of an intervention to reduce risk and increase resilience of firefighters (→Harrison et al. 2018; →Harrison, Williams, and Reynolds 2020).

So, how do we draw lessons from mindfulness and the five hallmarks of high reliability organizing to improve organizing processes for resilience in organizations that do not face high risk and catastrophe as part of normal operations? There are two important paths. First, while Weick identifies all five hallmarks as key to mindfulness for reliability, theorizing should continue to tease apart those which are most closely related to resilience in non-HROs. For example, preoccupation with failure is critical when lives are at stake, but perhaps not as relevant when making a sandwich at a restaurant (although perhaps that preoccupation with failure is what distinguishes the great sandwiches from the mediocre); a reluctance to accept simplification is critical for complex operations but may or may not be as critical for resilience for a small family business. HROs are about keeping a focus on processes or systems, but for a non-HRO the need for a more informed focus of how an organization is situated in a larger external system, or how when crises hit, new processes have more potential for failure may be vital. Maintaining a commitment to resilience seems to have obvious import regardless of type of organization, with a focus on identifying, planning for, and acting to recover after a crisis. Additionally, practicing deference to expertise in decision making, regardless of hierarchy or rank is certainly valuable for on-the-fly decisions during critical incidents, but is also potentially transferable to non-HROs in times of crisis, highlighting the importance of attending to the temporal qualities of crisis.

Second, keeping a focus on organizing processes rather than organizations allows us to broaden our scope to questions about how we organize community and society around ongoing social, political, and environmental disruptions. We can ask questions such as how we organize and engage with our most vulnerable communities in processes of resiliency planning, further reflecting on processes of designed interactions, networks, social capital,

co-production of knowledge, and cross-sector collaboration (→Harrison et al. 2022). Similarly, we can focus on self-organizing processes within communities and how they help shape resilience – such as the case with the Staten Island buyouts for managed retreat after Super Storm Sandy (→Koslov 2014; →Rush 2018) organized by homeowners who lobbied for government buyouts. We can also look at cross-sector organizing among governments, non-profits, for profits, and academe to address slow crises and resilience (e.g., Rockefeller's 100 resilient cities).

1.4 Interorganizational/Community Level

Community-level resilience is seen as a government responsibility, a role particularly pronounced when government reaction does not live up to the expectations of the citizens the government is meant to protect. Grassroots efforts emerge regardless of government efforts, so organizing resilience is both a top-down and bottom-up endeavor. Studies focus on the organizing and crisis/disaster response efforts of government workers (→Hutter and Kuhlicke 2013; →Jahn and Johansson 2018), preparedness messaging by emergency management agencies (→Bean et al. 2016), how citizens intersect with institutions to manage their personal safety and long-term recovery (→Lee et al. 2020), emergent organizing through grassroots efforts (→Stephens, Robertson, and Murthy 2020), and interorganizational coordination among institutional entities that constitute community-level networked processes (→Barbour et al. 2020; →Doerfel, Lai, and Chewning 2010; →Doerfel, Chewning, and Lai 2013). These developments have an underlying theme – cross-sector interorganizational relationships (IORs) are the backbone organizers for building community resilience. Community resilience becomes a public

good and an organizing goal that gets accomplished through collective action.

Collective action theorizing includes language like rhizome (→Castells 2013) and polycentric structures (→Gerlach 2001) reflecting findings that effective collective actions are optimal in decentralized networks where shared leadership and a generally non-bureaucratic relationship structure support change efforts. In the context of larger-scale crisis, this means government is arguably only one part of the solution and must partner with others to effectively build resilient communities.

Communicating messages among activists is necessary for coordinating efforts through networks that are often loosely structured (→Flanagin, Stohl, and Bimber 2006). →Flanagin, Stohl, and Bimber (2006) identified communication-based theoretical constructs that underlie collective action, namely, modes of engagement and interaction. *Engagement* involves individuals' or organizations' activities falling along a spectrum from high to low responsibility and ranging from low-to-high in terms of having an opportunity to have a personal impact on work. *Interaction* involves activities that support relationships (e.g., routine face-to-face interaction) where low interaction is observed when members do not know each other. While interaction is constituted through activities, engagement is constituted through inclusive, authentic, and collaborative dialogue that can occur through virtual or physical interactions (→Chewning 2018) and can be formed even in the absence of strong tie relationships (→Doerfel 2018). For communities, cross-sector engagement and interaction constitute mechanisms that have the potential to connect top-down and grassroots activities (→Harrison et al. 2022). Engaging cross-sector partnerships can foster resilient communities.

Charismatic leaders often encourage factionalism through setting an agenda but encouraging groups to shape the

agenda around their own identities while both leaders and groups use communication technologies to facilitate and coordinate joint action. What integrates these groups is what they hold in common, such as a common enemy or a shared ideology. Arguably, the obvious and shared enemy is clear when disasters threaten life – and the response to that enemy is rescue and recovery. But rescue and recovery goals evolve as the context of urgency (i.e., life threatening events) shifts to routines of recovery and then to rebuilding. Joint values and ideologies might be mechanisms that initiate interorganizational collaborative efforts through communication (→Ronfeldt and Arquilla 2001) but do these networks have time to solidify into long-term collaborations before routine returns?

Collective action theory thus suggests that the opportunity to start effective partnerships is when the goals are widely shared, like when there is a crisis that generates a problem to organize around. Planning, response, recovery, and learning are part of the stages in disaster response (→Coombs 2019), but designing and timing engaged and interactive cross-sector collaborations is a matter of perceptions of the calculated risks (→Tierney 2014). How and when potential IOR partners experience and agree about the urgency of disruption echoes resilience research that adopts a constitutive view of communication. Through constructing a shared sense of urgency, efforts effectively mobilize. →Jahn and Johannson (2018) adopted a constitutive communication framework, showing how a network swiftly emerged among various agencies. As argued above, the challenge of crisis and resilience scholars is to depart from the usual message-based time-sensitive models, and instead theorize about a constitutive and disciplined set of actions. Yet the way people manage a crisis is also a function of the information environment and the dynamic conditions that can threaten communities. Therefore, time might be better theorized by

integrating perceptions of urgency and capturing information load, clarity, ambiguity, etc. as dynamic rather than fixed elements.

People do not always trust and rely on government resources, as →Stephens, Robertson, and Murthy (2020) discovered when they found that people relied on multiple different sources of information and support as opposed to using the 9-1-1 system. Likewise, sometimes an optimized set of messages help construct the situation as dire and urgent (→Stephens, Barrett, and Mahometa 2013). Tone plus information source may matter. Social media can be a source that helps emergency managers understand where their constituents are during system-wide crisis (→Chen et al. 2020). Community response and recovery depend on interorganizational cross-sector relationships which do better when they understand the variable needs, interests, and values of the groups they serve (→Barbour et al. 2020). Under what circumstances, then, does communication shift in a crisis from information messaging to constitutive organizing? Communication design suggests that by understanding such shifts, it is possible to develop communication-based (constitutive and information transfer) interventions and implementations.

As collective action processes unfold, organizations that remain relatively central in their social networks build reputations as leaders, which then generates social pressure to live up to the role of leader (→Bennett and Segerberg 2013; →Doerfel and Taylor 2004). For example, past disasters in the US generated heightened needs for accessing resources from agencies like FEMA and the Red Cross at multiple levels (individual, organizational, interorganizational). As response leaders they failed to live up to stakeholders' expectations, resulting in a crisis of their own, viz. congressional investigations after the 2005 hurricane season and again in 2012 after Superstorm Sandy (→FEMA 2015). Such crises can

have a spillover effect such that the crisis in one organization implicates another organization reputationally or operationally when one or more organizations are highly interdependent (→Veil and Ambrose 2020; →Veil and Dillingham 2020). Research studies during those times celebrated the efficacy of emergent response and downplayed government action (→Harris and Doerfel 2017). These interorganizational networks evolve because of changing resource needs, contexts, and relational dynamics within the network (e.g., reciprocity and trust might change over time relative to FEMA and the Red Cross's evolving efficacy). Here we see communication-based mechanisms at play, especially when disaster events are more frequent for some communities than others (e.g., tornado alley). But as time expands (e.g., a few years of no severe events), a sense of urgency dissipates (→Tierney 2014).

HROs are motivated to plan for crisis because of the nature of their work. Likewise, communities that are prone to disruption are variably motivated to plan yet can become complacent. But communities themselves may also vary, where urban environments tend to be more structured and bureaucratic compared with their rural counterparts which have more casual, informal community structures (→Brown and Schafft 2019). These differences, along with how communication flows and is constituted in these different types of community structures, are phenomena organizational communication is particularly suited to examine. Crisis planning as a shared problem requires organizing efforts. Resilience-focused research suggests an important aspect of planning that is not explicitly captured in collective action theory: topic-experts.

→Barbour et al. (2020) examined Local Emergency Planning Committees (LEPCs) around chemical hazards, showing an important aspect of their work is in bridging sectors; the LEPCs needed experts specific to the community.

By thinking about resilience as a public good, the nature of the threat to resilience necessitates building up networks with experts in addition to gaining buy-in from the community. For example, →Kim et al. (2022) examined organizations that serve vulnerable populations and were embedded in decentralized networks where the organizations had variable shared leadership roles based on expertise. This enabled a response that was both efficient and effective.

Such findings complement the idea that collective action networks have shared leadership where different organizations take up different functions as leaders (→Doerfel and Taylor 2017). But Doerfel et al. (2022) also found important differences between rural and urban communities. While the urban social services organizations (SSOs) were organized through formal and networked structures with shared leadership, their rural counterparts were not. The differences in disaster response were stark. The storm lasted much longer for the rural versus urban community, even though the rains and floods had receded weeks earlier for both. What is unclear is whether these differences are a problem and for whom? Where does the fault lie? Do we blame rural areas that lack capacity or urban areas because their resilience gives policymakers an excuse to not address root problems? Are there opportunities for communication design, implementation, and intervention for particular communities?

1.5 Dark Side of Resilience

The concept of resilience and resilience-related behaviors seems optimistic but can also be problematic. Resilience as a construct is laden with power and agency issues, such that resilience presupposes the benefits of recovery without considering the root problems or the potential for exploitation and marginalization that can occur in the quest of bouncing

back (or forward) from crisis. To that end, resilience has been critiqued for ignoring and even reinforcing structural inequities that contribute to crisis (→Mahdiani and Ungar 2021) and maintaining the status quo, rather than contributing to meaningful structural change (→McDonnell 2020). The potential inequities of resilience are most evident in populations that are considered vulnerable and in need of outside assistance (→Ballard and Aguilar 2020).

Even within "advantaged" populations where individuals seemingly contribute to resilience out of self-interest and/or a desire to contribute to organizational and community resilience, elements of exploitation are present. For example, the expectation that employee-staffed crisis teams or cashiers and servers making $15 per hour should put themselves at risk or attend to organizational resilience ahead of their own is problematic. Healthcare workers and first responders often bear the brunt of such expectations, and participate in "double duty," in that they must respond to the crisis on both personal and professional levels (→Stephens 2020). Essentially, such workers are expected to "hit the pause button" to give of themselves and contribute to crisis response without attending to their own needs (→Stephens 2020: 527). High resilience organizing serves and preserves organizations and businesses. Discourses of resilience condition workers to believe their own resilience is their heroic and self-sacrificing commitment to their employers (→Aguilar and Ballard 2022).

2 Conclusion

The shifting nature of crises and their related impacts call for updated theorizing in crisis response research. *HiResO* recognizes that chronic crises create ongoing, cascading, system-wide disruptions that highlight crisis response as an ongoing, multi-level phenomenon. Issues of time, pacing, and

privilege intersect with organizational communication design and decision making in ways that impact outcomes for various populations. As we progress into a space where all levels of systems are overwhelmed by chronic crisis, future research must consider what HiResO and resulting HiResOs will look like. As entire geographical spaces become less inhabitable, bouncing back will no longer be an option, and bouncing forward will necessitate more than organizational learning. In this chapter, we argue that HiResO is baked into organizational practices, structures, and partnerships. This is accomplished, in part, through organizations supporting team norms where adaptation is not driven by particular exogenous events, but rather is folded into regular pauses (that permit proactively adjusting team processes) based on the assumption that disruptions are routine. This points to organization-level adaptive orientations where structures echo HROs in terms of employee voice and participatory cultures, supported by formal codified expectations that complement autonomy, creativity, and constructive sensemaking. While the principles of HiResO can be adopted by all organizations, strategies, goals, and outcomes are likely to differ related to a variety of factors including organizational sector and mission. Just as some research has already started to classify organizations that may not be considered HROs but still embody elements of high reliability organizing (e.g., →Weick and Sutcliffe 2011) future research should focus on teasing out the different types of HiResOs that emerge related to organizations' orientation toward crisis.

However, even within types of organizations, there are factors on the individual, team, organizational, and community levels that will impact organizations' ability to become HiResOs. What happens when an organization doesn't have an adaptive culture, when employee voice is not valued, or employees themselves don't choose to participate? Certainly, organizations can change to adopt HiResO, but

there must be a willingness on the part of leadership and employees to do so. Why are some organizations able to enact HiResO, whereas others are not? Case study research of successful and unsuccessful HiResO in the field can help answer some of these questions and identify barriers to HiResO and related solutions. But a bias toward success cases might further contribute to how resilient organizations enable policymakers to focus on supporting the aftermath and show off these successes rather than address the causes that require HiResO to begin with.

Relatedly, it is important to further interrogate processes that result in the "dark side" of resilience. HiResO, as outlined in this chapter, prioritizes employee voice, participatory cultures, and constructive sensemaking inside and among organizations and their constituents. Yet, at times when speed, efficiency, and expertise are often prioritized, participatory decision making may seem at odds with organizational goals. Deferring to those whose expertise might not be sanctioned or viewed as legitimate may seem risky despite such unsanctioned experts being on the ground and experiencing the event first-hand. How can organizations and communities build in safeguards to protect, rather than exploit, vulnerable populations? How can we change the narrative of resilience so that it is inclusive and equitable? Future research should identify barriers and solutions to bring us closer to these goals.

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designers, the ostensible goals of communication design, and the designable features of communication is available at →www.macromorphic.com.

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